



ROUTLEDGE
HANDBOOKS



Routledge Handbook of Indian Politics

Edited by Atul Kohli and Purna Singh

ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOK OF INDIAN POLITICS

India's growing economic and socio-political importance on the global stage has triggered an increased interest in the country. Now available in paperback, this Handbook is a reference guide, which surveys the current state of Indian politics and provides a basic understanding of the ways in which the world's largest democracy functions.

The Handbook is structured around four main topics: political change, political economy, the diversity of regional development, and the changing role of India in the world. Chapters examine how and why democracy in India put down firm roots, but also why the quality of governance offered by India's democracy continues to be low. The acceleration of economic growth since the mid-1980s is discussed, and the Handbook goes on to look at the political and economic changes in selected states, and how progress across Indian states continues to be uneven. It concludes by touching on the issue of India's international relations, both in South Asia and the wider world.

The Handbook offers an invigorating initiation into the seemingly daunting and complex terrain of Indian politics. It is an invaluable resource for academics, researchers, policy analysts, and graduate and undergraduate students studying Indian politics.

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1

INTRODUCTION

Politics in India—an overview

Atul Kohli and Prerna Singh

The study of Indian politics constitutes an exciting area of scholarship. This collection brings together some of the leading and emerging scholars of Indian politics to reflect on their respective areas of specialization. Each contribution is a self-sufficient essay that introduces readers—be they specialists or new to the subject—to a specific topic and provides references to facilitate further pursuit of the subject. These contributions ‘speak’ in the voice of the authors. Many of the essays here are not only distillations of prior scholarship, but also point to new directions of thinking and research. We (the editors of the volume) are responsible for inviting the contributors, but since this is a *Handbook*, we have not tried to impose any artificial unity; the contributions represent a variety of normative and theoretical standpoints. The minimal unity of the volume comes from the organization of the subject matter. In this introductory chapter we provide an overview of the subject—politics in India—and point to where and how individual essays of the collection fit within the broader scheme.

The collection is organized around four major themes: three themes in Indian politics, namely political change, political economy, and the diversity of regional developments, as well as the theme of the changing role of India in the world. We discuss each of these issues in a highly abbreviated fashion below. Among the political changes on which we focus are: how and why democracy in India put down firm roots on the one hand, but why, on the other hand, the quality of governance offered by India’s democracy continues to be low, especially below the national level. The interrelated political economy themes that we discuss concern the acceleration of economic growth since the mid-1980s, worsening inequalities, the persistence of poverty, and the growing power of business groups. A discussion of political and economic changes in select states provides an inkling of why progress across Indian states continues to be uneven. Finally, we touch on the issue of India’s international relations, both in its neighborhood and vis-à-vis global powers.

Political change

Democracy has put down firm roots in India but the quality of government that India’s democracy provides continues to be quite poor. Brief schematic comments on both these trends—democratic consolidation but poor governance—may be helpful at the outset for introducing the subject, as well as for situating specific essays in this volume within the broader study of political change in India.

First, how does one best understand consolidation of democracy in India? It is clear that India's democracy has succeeded against considerable odds: a low-income economy, widespread poverty and illiteracy, and immense ethnic diversity. How did India do it? It is our suggestion that Indian democracy is best understood by focusing not mainly on its socioeconomic determinants, but on how power distribution in that society is negotiated and renegotiated.¹ A concern with the process of power negotiation, in turn, leads one to analyze leadership strategies, the design of political institutions, and the political role of diverse social groups, or, in short, the interaction of the state and society.

More specifically, India's democratic record suggests that two related sets of political processes have guided the management of power conflicts in that society. First, a delicate balance has been struck, and struck again, between forces of centralization and decentralization. Second, the interests of the powerful in society have been served without fully excluding the weaker groups. The record on both of these fronts is far from perfect; the failures, in fact, have actually put a great strain on Indian democracy. Nevertheless, accommodation of those who mount powerful challenges by granting them greater autonomy and/or a share of resources has been central to the strengthening of democracy.

As federal democracies go, India is a relatively centralized state. While many critics have made this observation, the fact is that demands for decentralization only make sense within the context of centralized authority; authority and power, like wealth, have to exist before they can be distributed. Over the years, as democracy has spread, numerous mobilized groups in India have demanded further redistribution of power. These demands were often resisted, sometimes wisely, but at other times unwisely and at a great cost. Overall, however, enough concessions were made so that the Indian political system by now possesses significant decentralized traits. Notable features of these are to be found in the practice of federalism, the considerable and growing power of state governments, the changing character of local governments, and in the evolving constitutional design.

No electoral democracy can long survive without protecting the interests of the powerful, whether these are propertied groups, groups with high status, or groups with effective political organization. Long-term exclusion of weaker groups is also not healthy for a democracy. How has this balance been managed in India? While the rhetoric of the Indian state has often been redistributive—emphasizing socialism, abolition of traditional privileges, reform of the caste system, and populism—political practice has been considerably more conservative, eschewing any decisive redistribution. The Indian state has thus been criticized both for its excessive socialist commitments and for its failure at substantial redistribution. However, the political impact of these twin tendencies—radical in tone, conservative in practice—may well have been benign, strengthening democracy: the powerful in society feel well served by the system but weaker groups do not feel totally excluded or hopeless, at least not so far.

A brief chronological sketch of several phases of political change in India may now help further clarify how strategies of power management in India have evolved. India's transition to democracy in the 1940s is understudied. Historians have often left such issues to political scientists and the latter often do not focus on the 'past.' Based on limited study, one argument in the relevant literature suggests that India's democracy is mainly a legacy of British colonialism; the British in India did introduce elections and leave behind a well functioning civil service.² This argument immediately runs into the problem of why democracy did not fare as well as in Pakistan, which after all shared a similar inheritance. Maya Tudor in the opening essay in the volume provides one possible answer to this puzzle: social origins of regime founders in India and Pakistan were distinct, leading to variable political outcomes. The origins of Indian democracy, by this account, owe much to the urban and middle-class origins of Indian nationalists.

Political changes following Independence can be usefully conceptualized in three phases. Institutions and practices of democracy found considerable acceptance during the first phase, which was dominated by Nehru and which lasted from, say, about 1950 to the mid-to-late 1960s. Aside from Nehru's own commitment to democracy, India benefited in this phase from the presence of two very important institutions: a well-functioning civil service and a popular ruling party, the Indian National Congress (or Congress).³ The civil service constituted the heart of the state that India inherited from the colonial period, and India's 'new' civil service was essentially built on this colonial base. This civil service contributed to effective government and imparted political stability.

The Congress, by contrast, had spearheaded a successful national movement and, as a result, enjoyed considerable popularity and legitimacy. These new rulers of India, especially Nehru, utilized the inherited political capital wisely, accommodating rival elites within the larger political umbrella that was Congress. Moreover, while Nehru and others employed the rhetoric of socialism, political practice was considerably more conservative. The Congress Party, for example, built its political networks on the back of the powerful members of society—often the land-owning, upper castes—exchanging state patronage for electoral mobilization. This strategy enabled the Congress Party to succeed for a while, at least long enough for practices of democracy to take root.

Indian democracy was also helped by the fact that Indian political society in this early phase was not all that mobilized, certainly far less than in the subsequent decades. Political conflict mainly took the form of claims and counterclaims by rival elites, especially regional elites demanding a greater share of power and resources vis-à-vis the central government. These conflicts could have proven difficult but were successfully accommodated by creating a federal system that recognized linguistic communities as legitimate political components. Elite versus mass conflict in India in these decades was, however, minimal. What class conflict existed was limited to a few regions. Given India's political heterogeneity, such conflicts seldom spread from one region to another. Mobilization of lower castes was also in its infancy and limited to a few southern states. Most of India's poor were lower-caste, landless peasants. These groups were generally dependent for their livelihood on those above them, the landowning, upper-caste elites. These vertical ties of patronage and dependency, in turn, constrained the political behavior of poor, illiterate Indians.

Democracy has often had undemocratic roots. India's case has been no different, at least not on this score. An effective civil service and relatively low levels of political mobilization meant that, unlike numerous other postcolonial experiments, Indian democracy was not seriously debilitated at the outset by poor governance and multiple political conflicts. The Congress Party further provided the key governing institution that not only transformed nationalist legitimacy into a ruling force, but also incorporated rival elites into a loosely knit organization, and promised future incorporation to India's unkempt masses. While the Congress repeatedly won elections during this first phase and dominated India's political landscape, a broader political change was also underway: institutions and practices of democracy took root.

Several essays in this collection shed further light on this early phase of Indian democracy. The chapter by the two Rudolphs focuses on Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, whose contribution to India's struggle for Independence from the British is well known. Their piece, however, moves away from a conventional understanding of the Mahatma as a nationalist to instead focus on Gandhi's decisive role in the creation of an Indian identity—according to them 'his most important contribution is what he did for Indian character, capacities and political culture,' as well as Gandhi's significance as a world historical figure. Jivanta Schoettli's chapter, in turn, focuses on Jawaharlal Nehru. Schoettli analyzes Nehru's considerable achievements as

prime minister and politician in both the domestic and international realm, and discusses Nehru's legacy. The chapter by Paul Staniland opens with a brief discussion of center-state relations in India. Gurpreet Mahajan's chapter discusses the ways in which the drafters of the Indian constitution as well as subsequent leaders have sought to promote social and economic equality through reservations for previously marginalized communities. In Part II, John Harriss's chapter on 'politics and redistribution' in India focuses on the contradiction that independent India has faced from the very beginning, between socialist rhetoric and the persistence of steep and ingrained social hierarchies. In Part III, the chapters by Sudha Pai and Jeffrey Witsoe describe the pattern of Congress dominance through coalitions with powerful sections of society in the modal 'Hindi heartland' states of Uttar Pradesh (UP) and Bihar, respectively.

The second major phase during the 1970s and 1980s was dominated by Nehru's daughter, Indira Gandhi. Indian politics during this phase became considerably more turbulent, even temporarily threatening democracy. As the memory of anti-colonial nationalism declined, numerous new elites entered the political arena, challenging Congress's hold on power. A rapidly growing population also produced a new generation of potentially mobilizable citizens. The spread of commerce and democracy started undermining the vertical ties of clientelism that had constrained the political choices of the lower strata in the past. India's economic development was also relatively sluggish and elitist, leaving a majority without any significant improvement in living conditions. The political situation was by now ripe for dramatic changes.⁴

After Congress's popularity declined in the second half of the 1960s, Indira Gandhi recreated the Congress during the 1970s and the 1980s as a much more populist and personalistic organ. The old Congress Party, with its modest organizational base, was destroyed in this transformation, creating a significant institutional vacuum in the Indian polity. Indira Gandhi instead promised 'alleviation of poverty' to India's poor masses, generating considerable popular support. She used this popularity to concentrate power in her person, further undermining existing institutional constraints on the use of power. Indira Gandhi appointed loyal minions to significant political offices across the country, squeezed whosoever challenged her, and when the opposition itself became strident—as it did in the mid-1970s—imposed a 'national emergency' for two years (1975–77), limiting democratic practices and bringing India's democracy to the brink.

Indira Gandhi's personalistic and populist politics definitely weakened some of India's democratic institutions. The old Congress Party was transformed into a personal tool that went into a slow but steady decline following her death. The civil service was politicized. Centralization of power also weakened the federal system, evoking strong opposition in some regions that did not readily accept loss of autonomy. As in many other democracies, personalistic power simultaneously created a viable political center but weakened institutional politics.

The balance sheet of political developments during this phase, however, was not only towards the weakening of Indian democracy. Contrary trends also deserve to be underlined. First, elections were held regularly throughout the period, and political power remained a function of securing popular majority support. Even Indira Gandhi's personal power was a function of her widespread electoral appeal to India's poor masses. It was a need to reconfirm this legitimacy that pressured her to call elections after a brief authoritarian interlude (1975–77). The fact that she was voted out of power following the Emergency only confirmed the efficacy of Indian democracy: those who tamper with the basic system will lose popular support. Second, and related to the first point, following the Emergency a number of India's political groups—for example, some of India's communists, who had hitherto held an ambivalent attitude towards democracy—realized how much there was to lose without liberal political freedoms, and became recommitted to democracy. Finally, Indira Gandhi sharply politicized the issue of widespread poverty in India. Even while she failed to deliver on her promises to the

poor, Indira Gandhi broadened the scope of Indian democracy towards greater inclusion of the lower strata.

More about this phase of Indian politics during which Indira Gandhi dominated can be learnt from a number of contributors. The deinstitutionalization of the Congress through the personalization and centralization of power by Indira Gandhi in the states, for example, is brought out vividly in Sudha Pai's analysis of UP in Part III. In his discussion of insurgencies in India, Paul Staniland notes how the aggressive centralization policies of Indira Gandhi played a key role in creating the crisis in Punjab in the 1980s.

Indira Gandhi's assassination in the mid-1980s, and that of her son Rajiv Gandhi a few years thereafter, brought to an end the era of Congress's dominance via family rule, at least for the moment. While democracy had by now taken a firm foothold in India—notice that even the assassination of the highest leaders was 'dealt with' by yet another round of elections to select alternative leaders—the quality of government that this democracy was capable of delivering remained rather uncertain. The critical issue was the absence of cohering institutions amidst a rapidly politicizing society. The third and current phase that began around 1990 has thus been characterized by a variety of national-level political experiments to find a substitute for the old Congress Party rule.

The decline of Congress's hegemony has been met by two important political developments: the rise of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), especially in India's Hindi-speaking 'heartland' that comprises states in north-central and western India; and the growing significance of regional parties and caste-based parties. These developments are the subject of a number of essays.

Amrita Basu's chapter discusses the origins, structure and fluctuating electoral fortunes of the BJP, a right-leaning, religious-nationalist party that has successfully mobilized support at the national level by simultaneously demonizing India's religious minorities, especially Muslims, and championing causes that appeal to the majority Hindus. Over time, however, the BJP has had to moderate its strident religious nationalism, both to broaden its electoral support. Jaffrelot's chapter on 'caste politics' notes that the BJP receives a significant proportion of the backward caste vote, and Ronald Herring in his chapter on 'class politics' discusses the curious phenomenon of the party's electoral support among the most oppressed social groupings of Dalits and Adivasis—and to seek coalition allies.⁵ Ironically, the BJP's electoral losses in 2004 and 2009 have underlined some upper limit on the party's performance-based popularity.

The rise of the BJP in Indian politics was of course accompanied by a worsening of Hindu-Muslim relations in India, the most egregious instance of this being the pogrom against Muslims by the BJP government in Gujarat in 2002. Varshney and Gubler discuss this case in developing a more general theory about the role of the state and civil society in Hindu-Muslim violence in India.

A variety of political trends below the national level during this phase are also notable. Suhas Palshikar's chapter provides a comprehensive overview of regional and caste parties in India. Palshikar identifies four distinct trends as regards regional parties. In the 1960s and later in the early 1970s, with the exception of parties such as the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) (which is discussed at length in Adam Ziegfeld's chapter on Tamil Nadu in Part III), regional parties did not mobilize around regional identity but instead they spoke the language of democracy and opposition to the Congress. In the 1980s regional identity emerged as a focus of mobilization with regional parties emerging or becoming stronger in states such as Punjab, Kashmir, Andhra Pradesh and Assam. The mid-1990s witnessed a further proliferation and ascendance of state parties associated mainly with the breaking away of factions of leaders from the Congress and the 'Janata family' of parties—a development that has been described more as 'regionalization' of the parties and party system. Along with the rise of state parties, the 1990s

also witnessed the rise of caste politics, specifically the intensification of backward caste and Dalit politics, as is discussed in Christophe Jaffrelot's chapter on the 'politics of empowerment' and Hugo Gorringer's chapter on 'Dalit politics.' Palshikar's discussion of backward caste and Dalit parties is usefully read in tandem with Sudha Pai's and Jeffrey Witsoe's discussions in Part III of the rise of other backward castes (OBC)-dominated parties, such as the Samajwadi party in UP and Rashtriya Janata Dal in Bihar, and Dalit parties such as the Bahujan Samaj Party in UP. A discussion of the Dalit leader Mayawati figures prominently in Niraja Gopal Jayal's chapter on 'India's minority leaders.' Jayal highlights two routes that India's minority leaders have broadly followed: first, through nomination by majority political leadership, which results in their being criticized as being symbolic at best and legitimizing the politics of dominant groups at worst (Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, Presidents Zakir Hussain and A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, and President K.R. Narayanan from the Sikh, Muslim and Dalit communities are presented as examples of those who followed this route); and second, through political mobilization and direct appeals to the communities to which they belong and claim to represent (Mayawati is presented as an exemplar of a leader who followed this route and for whom the reinforcement of difference and repeated reminders of discrimination or disadvantage are necessary to proving their loyalty to their community constituency, but also shaping the self-definition of the community itself).

The third and most recent phase of Indian politics has thus been characterized by minority national governments and some related governmental instability. Whereas India's first eight general elections were spread out between 1950 and 1990, India held five general elections in the 1990s alone. By contrast, the most recent minority governments headed by the BJP (1999–2004) and the Congress (2004–09, and then again 2009 to present) have not only managed coalitional support well but have offered a fair amount of policy coherence and stability. How does one best understand the phenomenon of minority governments without debilitating policy instability? The main underlying political trends are in tension: the growing fragmentation of India's political society on the one hand, and a narrowing of the ruling alliance involving technocratic policymakers and big business on the other hand.

Ever since the decline of anti-colonial nationalism in the 1950s and the 1960s, growing political fragmentation has been an important, steady trend in India. First, the political elite fragmented. This led to and was accompanied by growing assertiveness of a variety of oppositional elites, including some of India's regional elite. Indira Gandhi and India's regional elite, in turn, reached deeper into the social hierarchy to build political support. As noted, this led to the emergence of parties of the backward castes, and more recently of the lowest, Dalit castes. At the same time, class politics became salient in a few regions. Ronald Herring's chapter focuses on class politics in India. A variety of single-issue social movements also occupied new spaces created by a vibrant democracy. Jennifer Bussell reviews some of these social movements in her chapter. Given problems of coordinating collective action, these mobilized interests and identities in India by now generate formidable obstacles to creating cohesive majority governments.

If political fragmentation was the only trend, Indian politics by now would be a lot more unstable than it is. A variety of political and social developments also continue to impart cohesiveness to Indian democracy. In the political sphere, for example, while the Congress Party by now is only a shadow of its former self, it nevertheless remains a powerful national party, fully capable of offering responsible government. The successful mobilization of Hindu nationalism by the BJP has probably been the most important political development in recent decades; irrespective of our judgments about the desirability of this development, the fact is that, like the Congress, the BJP as one of India's two national parties remains fully capable of forging a stable national government. Beyond the political sphere, India's civil service continues to

provide effective government, especially at the apex. A powerful armed force also remains an effective coercive tool to influence politics in the last instance; while coercion is clearly antithetical to democracy, it is also the case that many developing country democracies disintegrate as the political capacity to create order declines. Finally—and probably most importantly—the power and influence of India's indigenous business groups has grown steadily. While not quite hegemonic in the Marxist sense of that term, it is the case that Indian business groups wield political influence via powerful national organizations. These organizations not only transcend many regional and other political divisions of India but also offer clear policy preferences that narrow the policy range within which political parties operate. The results include policy stability in some key areas such as economics. From a liberal standpoint, the growing power of business in India is of course a mixed blessing: on the one hand it limits political uncertainty, a condition that is essential for a capitalist economy to flourish; on the other hand the more the Indian state works for Indian capital, the more politically marginalized become India's numerous other social groups.

The discussion so far has focused on the evolution of India's democracy. It is also important to comment briefly on the quality of government offered by India's democracy. The quality of governance in India remains mixed. Judged by the standards of developing countries, India is a moderately well-run country. It is widely perceived today as a growing democratic power in which ethnic diversity has been accommodated, the economy is growing, foreign and economic policies are sound, and where an educated middle class is growing. This image is valid but incomplete. First, this is a relatively recent image. Second, it is an image that is more likely to appeal to friends of India who do not deal with daily India, but less to a common office worker in Lucknow, or to a poor farmer in Andhra Pradesh. Many such Indian citizens by contrast experience the Indian state as relatively ineffective, corrupt, more an obstacle than a source of solutions, even venal and just as often simply absent when needed.

In order to understand the mixed quality of governance in India it helps to keep in mind that the Indian state is a lot more competent in some areas and places than in others on the one hand, and regularly prioritizes some problems to solve and not others on the other hand. It is also important to bear in mind that state authority in India runs relatively shallow; the farther down the political hierarchy one travels, the more the state lacks public purpose, serving instead personal or sectional interests. For example, India's ruling elite at the apex tends to be relatively competent. Yet this competence did not translate into effective governance during the Indira Gandhi years. The main reason was that she prioritized socialism but failed to create an institutionalized power base that incorporated the popular sectors. The mismatch between the ambitious political goals and shallow authority ensured that she—as well as her son, Rajiv Gandhi—often failed to translate their considerable electoral popularity into substantial policy achievements.

The relative competence of India's highest bureaucratic elites and the concomitant shallowness of public authority are two characteristics of the Indian state that have not altered dramatically over time. What has altered instead are the priorities of India's leaders, who are increasingly focused on economic growth and political stability. There is also an effort underway to insulate—as much as possible—decision making at the apex from popular pressures. Narrower priorities have enabled India's competent rulers to achieve some important goals, though not without cost, and only when policy accomplishment did not require downward penetration of state authority. For example, some of the most significant regional movements for greater self-determination, or even secession, have by now declined in intensity. While, as Paul Staniland's chapter on insurgencies points out, some of this was a result of accommodation and clever statecraft, a fair amount of brutal state repression was also used, incurring serious human costs. A narrow alliance

of technocratic elite with business groups has similarly succeeded in steering India onto a higher growth path, but at the expense of widening inequalities.

If policies aimed at securing political stability and promoting economic growth exhibit considerable state competence at the national level, the same does not hold for a variety of policy areas that influence distributive and welfare outcomes, as discussed by a number of essays in Part III. The commitment of the state elite to India's poor has generally been rhetorical, and state authority to accomplish such tasks has also been limited. As a result, redistributive land reforms and a variety of other efforts that may enhance the life chances of the poor have often failed in India.⁶ The failure of primary education in India is also well known.⁷ In more recent years, buoyant economic growth has filled state coffers; aimed at improving India's image as a global player, the state elite, in turn, has assigned increased resources to such areas as primary education and health. Unfortunately, the capacity of lower-level governments to translate these shifting national priorities into real gains for India's poor remains quite meager.

Most state and local governments in India do not govern effectively. While there are exceptions, even important exceptions, on the whole the generalization holds. The failures are manifest in a variety of outcomes, including the inability to collect taxes in the countryside or on services, distorted priorities for public expenditures, corruption—lots of it—politicization of the bureaucracy, and ineffective policy in such areas as public education, public health, and the provision and maintenance of infrastructure. The deeper causes include the facts that sub-national and local politics in India often lack public purpose, and that the state and local bureaucracies in India are not very professional. Rani Mullen's chapter reviews and analyzes the consequences of India's attempts at instituting local self-government through Panchayati Raj institutions. She argues that the ability of village governments to deepen democracy and impact their citizens' wellbeing depends critically on a state's history of decentralization, political competition, and social mobilization.

Political economy

The political economy themes to which a volume such as the present one can contribute include politics of economic growth and redistribution on the one hand, and the growing power of business in Indian politics on the other hand. Over recent decades the Indian state has increasingly prioritized economic growth, and the economic and political importance of indigenous business groups within India has grown. The results include acceleration of economic growth, reduction in poverty, but widening inequalities. These and related issues are discussed in some of the essays below. The comments in this section reflect mainly our views on these themes.

The neo-liberal accounts of India's economic performance blame statism of Nehru and Indira Gandhi for India's sluggish growth and attribute post-1991 growth acceleration to liberal economic policies.⁸ While these views command considerable following, they are not without problems: they fail to situate economic processes within their political and social context, and thus often lead to erroneous conclusions.⁹ Focusing instead on political determinants of economic growth, one of us has argued elsewhere that Nehru used his considerable nationalist legitimacy to prioritize growth of heavy industry and achieved some important successes; by contrast, Indira Gandhi's populism hurt both public and private investments and thus led to a decline in industrial growth.¹⁰

An alternative account of India's recent growth acceleration can also be proposed along these political economy lines. To summarize very briefly an argument developed elsewhere, following the Emergency, Indira Gandhi slowly but surely abandoned her commitment to '*garibi hatao*,' prioritized economic growth, and embraced Indian business as a ruling ally. Thus was initiated a

process of state and capital alliance for growth that has been unfolding in fits and starts ever since. Rajiv Gandhi's efforts to liberalize India's economy ran into numerous political obstacles, the most significant of which was opposition from Indian business groups, who felt threatened by any sharp opening of the economy to global forces. By contrast, when liberalization came in 1991, this was in part facilitated by an economic crisis, in part by growing confidence and assertiveness of a section of Indian business groups compared to the 1980s, and in part by a careful political calibration of the liberalization process to suit the needs of indigenous Indian capital. It can thus be argued that the acceleration of economic growth in India began, not in 1991, but around 1980, and was a product not of liberal policies adopted in 1991, but of a growing state–capital alliance for economic growth that was initiated by India Gandhi, and that has by now matured into a central feature of India's political economy.¹¹

Over the last three decades then, the Indian state has shifted from a reluctant pro–capitalist state with a socialist ideology, to an enthusiastic pro–capitalist state with a neoliberal ideology. This shift has significant implications for the evolving nature of the Indian political economy. On the one hand the state's warm embrace of capital has been accompanied by higher rates of economic growth. Some of this is bound to help India's poor. On the other hand, however, the state–capital alliance for growth is leading to widening inequalities along a variety of dimensions: urban–rural and across classes and regions. Not only does rapid economic growth then not benefit as many of the poor as it could if inequalities were stable, but the balance of class power within India is shifting decisively towards business and other property–owning classes. This creates the possibility, nay, makes it likely, that future patterns of development will be even more unequal.

It is quite ironical that the shift away from socialism was initiated by Indira Gandhi herself. Seeking higher economic growth, Indira Gandhi in the early 1980s reordered the Indian state's class underpinnings, tilting it towards capital and against labor. Both she and her son Rajiv Gandhi thus moved the Indian state away from its socialist ambitions to a growth–promoting state that worked closely with the corporate sector. The distributional impact was negative but not as negative as what was to follow in the 1990s. State elites increasingly downplayed the rhetoric of socialism. A major fatality of this ideological shift was that land redistribution and tenancy reforms lost luster as policy options. While these policies had never succeeded much in India, now even their desirability became questionable. Also, very few new efforts emerged to improve primary education and public health. Mercifully, both Indira and Rajiv Gandhi kept up public investments. As some of these public investments were channeled into the countryside and others into India's poorer states, they put a brake on growing inequalities across the rural–urban and rich–poor state divides.

The state–business alliance for growth has continued to characterize India's model of development since about 1980, with another important liberalizing shift in 1991, when integration with the global economy also picked up speed. Unlike in some other parts of the world, India's leaders did not push for mass privatization of the public sector, state shrinkage, or rapid opening to global investment. What they did instead was to slowly but surely reduce tariffs, liberalize foreign investment laws, and cut back on public investments. The more economic growth was led by private investors, the more the benefits accrued to owners of capital and to their agents. A significant urban, middle class has also been growing in the shadow of this growth upsurge. All this is not surprising.

What the Indian state has also done is to throw its weight behind the winners of the new economy without compensating those who are being left behind. It is this activist role of the state that has further contributed to growing inequalities. The Indian state has thus continued to support Indian capital in various ways so as to enable it to compete against global competition.

A variety of ‘public-private partnerships’ are also beginning to absorb public initiative and resources. By contrast, investments into agriculture have not kept pace, and the poorer states of India have been left to their own resources. Since new private capital has not rushed into these areas, inequalities in India continue to grow, and the country’s poor do not benefit as much from growth as they might under a modified policy regime.

In terms of economic development, R. Nagaraj’s chapter provides a comprehensive overview of India’s economic record, delineating four distinct phases of economic growth. Vivek Chibber and Adaner Usmani’s chapter focuses on, and argues for a revised understanding of, the relationship between Indian capitalists and the state. Emmanuel Teitelbaum’s chapter familiarizes readers with ongoing debates in the literature pertaining to the effects of labor regulation and, relatedly, the activity of trade unions on India’s economic prospects.

In addition, a number of essays in this collection focus on questions of social development, broadly defined, and shed further light on the quality of governance in India that we began to discuss in the previous section. Perna Singh’s essay focuses on the abysmal state of public goods provision and social development in India. In addition to analyzing the factors behind the dismal level of social development at the national level, she also highlights and discusses the causes for the enormous variation in the provision of social services across Indian states. John Harriss’s chapter reviews India’s again generally dismal record of redistribution. Stuart Corbridge’s chapter focuses on corruption, discussing both the political economy of corruption at a macro level as well as reviewing the growing case study literature on how corruption works in practice and is experienced on the ground. Both Corbridge and Bussell (in Part I) discuss the emergence of significant sets of people’s movements and related policy reforms in recent years directed at increasing transparency and reducing corruption in government.

Contrasting developments across Indian states put redistributive politics in India into sharper relief. Over the years the states in which poverty has come down the most include Kerala, West Bengal, Punjab, Andhra Pradesh, and Tamil Nadu. By contrast, poverty has come down the least in Assam, Jammu and Kashmir, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan.¹² While rates of economic growth are a significant predictor of these trends, as interesting is the fact that for a unit of economic growth in various Indian states poverty came down much more rapidly in some states than in others. Thus, for example, one unit of growth in Kerala or West Bengal has been four times more ‘efficient’ in reducing poverty (as indicated by what economists call the growth elasticity of poverty) than, say, in Bihar or Madhya Pradesh.¹³ More concretely, this means that it will take four times the growth rate of Kerala and West Bengal to reduce the same amount of poverty in Bihar and Madhya Pradesh. How does one best understand such different capacities across Indian states to reduce poverty?

The two states in which poverty has come down the most—Kerala and West Bengal—are states with long experience of left governments. All the southern states—Kerala, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, and Karnataka—are among the top half of the states in which poverty is least apparent. By contrast, India’s BIMARU states—Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh—are among the bottom half of the states in which poverty has come down the most. Leaving proximate determinants of such patterns aside (for example, irrigation infrastructure, growth of farm yields, access to credit), the deeper explanation of such a pattern probably lies in the nature of social and political power in these states, and related to that, different policies the results of which have accumulated over decades. Put as a hypothesis, it may be suggested that poverty has been reduced the most in states where effective governmental power rests on a broad political base; in such cases, rulers have minimized the hold of upper classes on the state, successfully organized the middle and lower strata into an effective power bloc, and then used this power to channel resources to the poor.

This simple hypothesis can be used to explain varying capacities across Indian states to reduce poverty. First, let us consider the two cases of India's left-leaning states, Kerala and West Bengal. There is more of a consensus around the case of Kerala than West Bengal. Poverty in Kerala has been reduced sharply and its human development indicators are far superior to those of rest of India.¹⁴ All this was accomplished while economic growth rates in Kerala have been close to the all-India average. Underlying these redistributive achievements are complex historical roots, including the political mobilization of lower castes and classes well before Independence.¹⁵ This broadened political base then facilitated the rise of a well-organized communist party to power. A more pro-poor regime interacted with a more efficacious citizenry, creating what Drèze and Sen have rightly called a 'virtuous' cycle. This created both a supply of and demand for a variety of successful pro-poor public policies, including land reforms, higher investments into and better implementation of education and health policies, and greater gender equality.¹⁶ The fact is that when compared to other Indian states, the cultivated land in Kerala is distributed most evenly and wages of landless laborers are the highest.

While the case of West Bengal is more mixed, the main dynamics of poverty alleviation again seem to be that a well-organized regime with a broad political base has been relatively effective at pursuing tenancy reform, helping push up minimum wages—though only somewhat—and implementing centrally sponsored anti-poverty programs more effectively than other states. Land inequality in the countryside in West Bengal is also among the lowest in India by now, though wages of agricultural laborers are only marginally above the all-India average. There is also some evidence that tenancy reforms—via enhanced security and bargaining power—have helped agricultural productivity, thus making growth in West Bengal more inclusive.

If India's 'social democratic' states have effectively leveraged superior party organization and a broad political base to pursue modest redistributive reforms, how does one interpret the fact that all of India's southern states are above average in their poverty alleviation capacities? India's southern states share two sets of distinguishing political traits, one well researched and the other much in need of investigation. The well-established fact is that narrow domination of Brahmins was more effectively challenged in all the southern states relatively early in the twentieth century.¹⁷ Since Independence, the political base of power in these states has generally been middle castes and classes, and in some instances even lower classes. This is quite distinct from the Hindi-heartland states, where Brahmanical domination was only challenged relatively recently. The other fact is that the quality of state-level bureaucracy in the south has generally been superior. While this 'fact' needs to be documented by further scholarly research, bureaucracy in southern Indian states, especially in a state like Tamil Nadu, seems to be characterized by a sharper sense of professionalism, more akin to the Indian Administrative Service (IAS) than to prevailing practices in the Hindi heartland.¹⁸

How might prolonged rule by governments with broader political base and more effective bureaucracy influence poverty alleviation? Leaving Kerala aside, land redistribution has not been very effective in the southern states. The main policy instruments of poverty alleviation have been somewhat different. Over the last several decades the southern states have invested more heavily in education and health than in the Hindi-heartland states.¹⁹ Another study notes that on the whole, southern states have benefited more from subsidized public distribution of wheat and rice;²⁰ populist leaders (discussed in Adam Ziegfeld's chapter on Tamil Nadu in Part III) and superior bureaucracy must get the credit. With a more effective bureaucracy, other poverty alleviation programs (such as a variety of employment generation programs) have also been implemented better.

The contrast with the BIMARU states of northern India is striking. Of course, these states experienced low growth rates. However, the contrasts in the social and political structures are

also notable. Well into the late twentieth century, the main mode of politics in these states was Congress Party rule that rested on a narrow political base of upper castes and classes.²¹ With patron-client ties as the key defining unit of the political society, factional bickering among the patrons was the core trait of state politics. This personalistic bickering detracted from any type of constructive use of state power, whether in promoting growth or distribution. With long traditions of *zamindari* or *talukdari* rule (forms of indirect rule), the quality of state-level bureaucracy that these regions inherited was also generally low. Virulent patronage politics politicized the bureaucracy in post-independence years, further diluting the state's developmental capacity. For some three to four decades following Independence, then, a narrow political base, personalistic factionalism, and a less-than-professional state-level bureaucracy characterized the nature of state power in this region of India.

Land reforms were very poorly implemented in the Hindi-heartland states. With upper-caste landowners wielding considerable power—both in the state and in society—and with a readily corruptible bureaucracy, this failure was not surprising. A variety of other state interventions that might have helped the poor were also ineffective.

In recent decades, the political base of state power in all of these states has broadened, though social power of upper-caste landowners remains significant. Over time this broadening of state power may lead to some greater benefits to the poor, as has recently been evident in Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh. Meanwhile, factional bickering and a politicized bureaucracy have nearly been institutionalized in the Hindi-heartland areas, leading to policy ineffectiveness. Decades of malign neglect and policy ineffectiveness have thus accumulated in creating the largest concentration of the poor within India.

Chapters by Singh and Harriss compare these regional disparities in social policy and redistribution. Singh's chapter points out that while some southern states such as Kerala and Tamil Nadu, northern states such as Himachal Pradesh, as well as states in the north-east such as Mizoram, Manipur and Nagaland, have attained education and health outcomes equivalent to those of industrialized nations, states in the Hindi heartland, such as UP, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan have, on some key social development indicators, performed worse than countries in sub-Saharan Africa. She traces these stark differences to variations in the strength of their regional identity or subnationalism. Harriss's chapter attributes disparities in poverty alleviation to differences in the political representation of different castes/classes and the nature of political competition in different states.

In addition, a number of chapters in the next section, on diversity of regional developments, focus squarely on politics and development in select states.

Diversity of regional developments

Developmental performance of Indian states continues to diverge along several dimensions, including economic growth, distribution and poverty alleviation, and quality of governance. Why this should be so remains a complex, important, and under-investigated area of research. We have already made a few comments on politics of redistribution across Indian states above. The essays in this volume do not provide anything close to a systematic answer to this critical puzzle of diverging developmental performance across Indian states. What they provide instead are insights into the political and developmental dynamics within some of India's important states—Kerala (Patrick Heller) and Tamil Nadu (Adam Ziegfeld) in the south, UP (Sudha Pai) and Bihar (Jeffrey Witsoe) in the north-central part of India, and West Bengal (Manali Desai) in the east. Patrick Heller's and Manali Desai's chapters discuss the successes as well as the limitations of the politics of redistribution in Kerala and West Bengal, respectively. Ziegfeld's

chapter discusses the role of ‘populist’ policies in improving developmental outcomes in Tamil Nadu. Pai’s and Witsoe’s chapters discuss the failures of social policy and redistribution in the Hindi-heartland states of UP and Bihar.

A central theme that we believe deserves further attention is that varying politics and authority structures across Indian states are a key determinant of regional developmental dynamics. Here we provide a simple typology of Indian states that may help organize comparative analyses of authority patterns—causes and consequences—across Indian states.

State-level governments in some parts of India simply lack public purpose. Instead of using state authority and resources to pursue the public good, ruling elites in these settings use their power for personal and sectional gains. As the chapters by Jeff Witsoe and Sudha Pai, respectively, show, Bihar (until recently) and Uttar Pradesh typify these neo-patrimonial states of India. Politics in these and a few other states of India tends to be under-institutionalized and instead characterized by some shared traits: the political area is dominated by a single leader, surrounded by loyal minions; modal political relationships are vertical, of a patron–client type; bureaucracy is politicized; symbolic appeals are used regularly to build diffuse electoral support; the zero-sum quality of politics makes those excluded from power feel totally disenfranchised; and instead of any systematic public policy, leaders channel public resources for personalistic and narrow gains.

Understanding the causes and consequences of such neo-patrimonial governments in some of India’s states is an important research problem for others to pursue. Equally important is to explore ways in which one might get out of the deleterious trap created by mutually reinforcing influences of low levels of economic development and poor governance. Indian states in which governmental authority is used more constructively can be conveniently thought of as states that are either more to the left, or more to the right. Given democracy, these ideological tendencies can and do shift. Nevertheless, it is fair to characterize some such states of India as Kerala and West Bengal in recent periods as India’s left-leaning states (or, as noted above, social-democratic states), and states like Gujarat as right-leaning, developmental states of sorts, in which government has worked closely with business groups to promote economic growth. Politics in India’s left-leaning states is typically characterized by mobilized lower classes and castes on the one hand, and by the presence of a well-organized, left-of-center political party on the other hand that systematically incorporates this mobilized support into a social-democratic power bloc. The presence of this power bloc has, in turn, added public purpose to state politics. Patrick Heller’s and Manali Desai’s chapters analyze the generally progressive politics associated with left party rule in Kerala and West Bengal, respectively. While both states have a long record of rule by the same communist party, governmental authority has been used more constructively and effectively in Kerala—poverty alleviation, for example, has been more extensive in Kerala as compared with West Bengal. Desai attributes this to differences in the relationship of the same communist party to social movements that mobilize and incorporate lower classes and castes. She argues that anti-poverty capacities are enhanced when there is a synergy between parties and social movements. Such a synergy existed in Kerala where the Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI(M)) found itself regularly disciplined by social movements organized from within and outside the party, but was less evident in Bengal. Heller’s chapter on Kerala elaborates this argument eloquently, drawing out the link between the mobilization of subordinate classes and the degree to which democracy secures the conditions for an inclusive socioeconomic order in Kerala. Heller shows how the transformative role of the CPI(M) in Kerala lies less in its governance and more in its mobilization capacity, which is linked to its emergence at the confluence of three distinct social movements—the anti-colonial struggle, a caste-reform movement, and an agrarian movement. This leads Heller to call for a viewing of Kerala as a form of social democracy, analytically similar to the trajectory of Scandinavian states, but in the periphery.

Since economic liberalization and the related shift of initiative from the center to states, a few of India's states have sought actively to promote business and industry. Narendra Modi in Gujarat and Chandrababu Naidu in Andhra Pradesh are two recent examples. Narendra Modi in Gujarat has created an efficient, pro-business government with the help of the well-established business class of Gujarat and a relatively well-organized BJP that has mobilized a pro-Hindu majority against Muslims. Unfortunately, the state also has a long tradition of fermenting deliberate violence against weaker sections of the society—Muslims most recently—so as to capture state power for narrow elites. An attempt was also made in Andhra Pradesh in recent years to institutionalize a pro-business activist state. This effort, however, was heavily dependent on the political fate of a single leader, Naidu.

India and the world

Finally, it is important to touch on the issue of India's changing global position. As a poor economy with a large population base, and a colonial and a nationalist past, India has over the decades struggled to define its international position. As is well known, India during the Cold War sought to maintain an equal distance from both the superpowers, participating actively in the nonaligned movement. This attempt to avoid close alliances with the superpowers was not always successful. For example, during and following a war with China in 1962, which India lost, India sought closer links with the USA. Following the 1971 war with Pakistan—which led to the creation of Bangladesh—the USA tilted towards Pakistan and India sought closer links with the Soviet Union. While not quite an ally of the Soviet Union, India's closer relations with the communist giant strained India's claims to be a nonaligned nation. In spite of these swings necessitated by realpolitik, it is the case that in large part due to Indian nationalism India never fully joined either the Western or the Eastern camp during the Cold War. Narang calls this the ideational notion of 'strategic independence.' He argues that India's evolving security strategy with respect to both its major immediate neighbors—Pakistan and China—as well as toward the USA is shaped by this ideational factor as well as a structural factor—the sclerotic domestic institutions and bureaucracies that have impeded the full realization of India's indigenous and military potential. Baldev Raj Nayar's essay provides a broader overview of the evolving relationship between India and the world's established powers. He argues that from a very difficult starting point, borne out of a lack of knowledge or understanding of each other, India and the dominant global powers have over the past six decades made a mutual adjustment that may not be entirely satisfactory but does represent a considerable advance for them.

Indian nationalism also influenced India's early attitude towards the global economy. India was wary of foreign investment as it might weaken the country's decision-making autonomy. India in the early, post-independence years lacked the capacity and the confidence to pursue exports aggressively. India thus designed a fairly protected national economy in which foreign investment was limited and production was aimed mainly at the domestic market, often behind high tariff walls.

Some of India's most significant international challenges have emerged from its own neighborhood. India has fought several wars with Pakistan and one with China. Sumit Ganguly provides an incisive overview of the Indo-Pakistani conflict, providing an explanation for its origins, discussing its key characteristics, examining past efforts at conflict resolution, discussing some recent crises, and suggesting possible pathways for its eventual settlement. Vipin Narang's chapter explores both the drivers and the content of India's evolving security strategy with respect to both its major immediate neighbors—Pakistan and China—and toward the USA. Narang argues that India's approach to its security strategy is shaped by two factors, one

ideational—the conception of ‘strategic independence,’ the post-Cold War incarnation of non-alignment—and the other structural—the sclerotic domestic institutions and bureaucracies that have impeded the full realization of India’s indigenous and military potential.

Over the last couple of decades, India’s global relationships have undergone some important changes. The disintegration of the Soviet Union left India without a powerful ally. During this time period India also openly announced to the world its nuclear stature. India’s nuclear strategy is the subject of Kanti Bajpai’s essay. Bajpai first delineates the factors that have over the years encouraged India to develop and discouraged it from developing nuclear weapons and, second, how since the nuclear tests of 1998 India has come to view the usefulness of nuclear weapons for its security and what is the nature of its arsenal and doctrine. As economic growth in India picked up, military prowess increasingly came to be backed by growing domestic resources and technological improvements. India and the USA have also embraced each other as warmer allies, certainly a lot warmer than during the Cold War years. These changes have led to both growing confidence within India as a global actor and a recognition elsewhere of India’s global significance. Lawrence Sáez’s chapter provides a comprehensive evaluation of the trends in India’s bilateral relations with China, Japan, South Korea, and the member states of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) and the Association of South East Asian Nations (ASEAN).

Devesh Kapur’s contribution takes a slightly different cut into the question of India’s relationship to the world, focusing on the characteristics and consequences of international migration on India. Kapur presents an analytical framework outlining the channels through which international migration affects the country of origin and then moves on to provide evidence on the magnitude and characteristics of international migration from India. He then examines the political and economic consequences of international migration from India on India, concluding with reflection on how international migration has been reshaping conceptions of Indian citizenship.

To sum up, the essays in this volume shed light on aspects of political change, political economy and state-level politics within India. India’s changing position in the world is also discussed. Given the wide range of authors and subjects discussed above, no single approach to the study of Indian politics or single argument unifies the volume. That would defeat the purpose of a Handbook. What emerges instead is a comprehensive picture of a vibrant country that is both progressing rapidly and faces numerous challenges. The volume offers contributions by leading authorities who help make sense of a giant polity struggling to come into its own. We hope that these essays will provide brief introductions to specific issues for those new to the subject, authoritative overviews for those who specialize in one theme of Indian politics or another, and open up directions for further thought, reading and research for yet others.

Notes

- 1 These issues are also discussed in the ‘Introduction’ to Atul Kohli, ed., *The Success of India’s Democracy*, New York: Cambridge University Press, 2001.
- 2 See, for example, Myron Weiner, *Indian Paradox*, New Delhi: Sage, 1989, chapters 5 and 7.
- 3 Useful scholarly works on this early phase include Bipin Chandra *et al.*, *India After Independence, 1947–2000*, New Delhi: Penguin, 1988; Francine Frankel, *India’s Political Economy, 1947–1977: The Gradual Revolution*, Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1978; Rajni Kothari, *Politics in India*, Boston: Little, Brown & Co., 1970; W.H. Morris-Jones, *The Government and Politics in India*, third edn, London: Hutchinson, 1971; David C. Potter, *India’s Political Administrators: From ICS to IAS*, New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1996; and Myron Weiner, *Party Building in a New Nation*, Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, 1976.
- 4 For detailed analyses of these developments, see Lloyd and Susanne Rudolph, *In Pursuit of Lakshmi*, Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, 1987; Paul Brass, *The Politics of India Since Independence*,

- second edn, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994; Bipin Chandra *et al.*, *India After Independence, 1947–2000*, New Delhi: Penguin, 1988; and Atul Kohli, *Democracy and Discontent*, New York: Cambridge University Press, 1991.
- 5 Useful studies of the BJP include Christophe Jaffrelot, *The Hindu Nationalist Movement and Indian Politics, 1925 to the 1990s*, New York: Columbia University Press, 1996.
 - 6 See, for example, Atul Kohli, *The State and Poverty in India: The Politics of Reform*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987.
 - 7 One good study of the subject that points to leadership priorities as the main culprit is Myron Weiner, *The Child and the State in India*, Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1991.
 - 8 See, for example, Jagdish Bhagwati and Padma Desai, *India: Planning for Industrialization*, London: Oxford University Press, 1970; Isher Judge Ahluwalia, *Industrial Growth in India: Stagnation Since the Mid-Sixties*, Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1985; T.N. Srinivasan and S. Tendulkar, *Reintegrating India with the World Economy*, Washington, DC: Institute for International Economics, 2003; and Arvind Panagariya, *India: The Emerging Giant*, New York: Oxford University Press, 2008.
 - 9 For alternate economic accounts that we found more persuasive, see Gunnar Myrdal, *Asian Drama: An Inquiry into the Poverty of Nations*, New York: Pantheon, 1968; Pranab Bardhan, *The Political Economy of Development in India*, Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1998; and Bimal Jalan, *India's Economic Crisis*, Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1991.
 - 10 See, for example, Atul Kohli, *State-Directed Development: Political Power and Industrialization in the Global Periphery*, Cambridge University Press, 2005, chapter 7.
 - 11 See Atul Kohli, *Poverty amid Plenty in the New India: Politics, Economics and Inequality*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2012, chapter 2.
 - 12 For details, see *ibid.*, chapter 3. Also see Timothy Besley, Robin Burgess and Berta Esteve-Volant, 'The Policy Origins of Poverty and Growth in India,' in Timothy Besley and Louise J. Cord, eds, *Delivering on the Promise of Pro-poor Growth: Insights and Lessons from Country Experiences*, Washington, DC: Palgrave Macmillan and the World Bank, 2007, 49–78.
 - 13 See Besley *et al.*, table 3.1.
 - 14 See, for example, Jean Dreze and Amartya Sen, *India: Development and Participation*, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002.
 - 15 See, for example, Perna Singh, 'We-ness and Welfare: A Longitudinal Analysis of Social Development in Kerala, India,' *World Development* Vol. 39, Issue 2 (2011).
 - 16 This combination of progressive social policies and a politically conscious and mobilized citizenry is at the heart of Singh's explanation for why Kerala, as well as its neighboring state of Tamil Nadu, have performed far better as regards education and health outcomes as compared to other, especially north-central Indian states.
 - 17 See, for example, Francine Frankel and M.S.A. Rao, *Dominance and State Power in India*, two vols, Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1990.
 - 18 While it does not contrast northern vs. southern states, Akshay Mangla's comparison of the adjoining states of Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand brings out the significance of 'informal norms of bureaucratic accountability' for improvements in primary education. See Akshay Mangla, doctoral dissertation in preparation, MIT.
 - 19 See Perna Singh, 'Subnationalism and Social Development: A Comparative Analysis of Social Development in India,' PhD dissertation, Princeton University, 2010, chapter 4.
 - 20 See John Harniss, 'Do Political Regimes Matter: Poverty Reduction and Regime Difference Across India,' in Peter Houtzager and Mick Moore, eds, *Changing Paths: International Development and the New Politics of Inclusion*, Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 2003, 204–31.
 - 21 The fact that the lowest castes also voted for the Congress in these states, say, up until the end of the 1960s, did not make Congress a broad-based party. Members of the lowest castes often depended on members of upper castes and were entangled in a variety of patronage relationships. In spite of an apparent broad social base, Congress's effective political base in these states was thus quite narrow.

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PART I

Political change

I.I

Historical legacy

2

THE HISTORICAL INHERITANCE OF INDIA'S DEMOCRACY

Maya Tudor

The presence of a stable, consolidated democracy in the poor and unequal country of India poses a puzzle for contemporary democratic theorists, who contend that low levels of economic development and high levels of inequality and illiteracy are inimical to democracy. For over six decades, India has regularly held competitive elections guaranteeing all adults the right to vote, protected civil liberties in the context of a vigorous, dissenting media, and witnessed the genuine defeat of dominant party incumbents at national and state levels.¹ While Indian democracy is hardly perfect, there is little doubt that it remains an enduring political phenomenon.

A scholarly consensus on how and why one of the world's most populous and diverse polities has managed to create a stable democracy and evade the autocratic and unstable regime trajectories commonly characterizing other post-colonial, developing countries has yet to emerge, however. Given the sheer size of the country, understanding the origins of India's democratic exceptionalism is a question of considerable scholarly importance.²

Democracy can be defined narrowly or expansively. Most comparative theorists of democracy tend to agree that two procedural institutions are centrally constitutive of democracy: one, regular elections of the country's chief political executive by universal adult franchise; and two, the civil liberties that make these elections meaningful.³ This essay considers these institutions constitutive of democracy and reviews competing explanations for how and why India established universal adult franchise.⁴

The central question thus posed in this essay is how and why did India first come to institutionalize these constitutive democratic institutions? The essay explores the most commonly cited explanations and concludes that the creation of Indian democracy is best explained through a combination of class interest and the political party built to pursue that interest. Specifically, it acknowledges that the Congress Party was initially created to advance upward mobility for India's urban educated middle class via access to the colonial state. In the course of a prolonged anti-colonial struggle to achieve Independence, the educated segment of the urban middle class allied with the rural middle class, thereby forging a coherent redistributive coalition that was interested in amassing power and wealth at the expense of the colonial state and its collaborators, but that was also interested in preventing downwards redistribution. Because the primary party coalition shared redistributive interests, it was able to develop into an ideationally and organizationally robust institution that possessed its own causal relevance to political decision making.

This combination—of a class interest in creating more representative political institutions and a political party that had institutionalized proto-democratic commitments—was above all responsible for the post-independence creation of India's democratic institutions.

Colonialism and its institutions

One strand of relevant literature attributes the creation of Indian democracy to the broadly pro-democratic influence of British colonialism, suggesting that colonialism's legacy of competitive elections and professional institutions of the state (e.g. a professional civil service and military) were critical influences on the post-independence adoption of executive elections based on universal adult franchise and a variety of civil liberties.⁵ According to this explanation, British colonialism or the specific colonial legacy of the state played a decisive role in the creation of India's democratic institutions.

While some research has indicated that British colonialism can be beneficial for democracy, however, the thrust of this argument quickly becomes unsatisfactory when one considers how India's regime outcome contrasts with neighboring Pakistan, a country carved out of the same colonial state at the same time with broadly similar institutional inheritances. Indeed, Coen (1971) writes that 'those familiar with the differences encountered elsewhere in the world, particularly in Africa, have been loud in their praises of the good fortune of India and Pakistan in taking over their respective shares of those [military and civil] services ...'⁶ Yet despite these similarities, Pakistan embarked upon a dramatically different regime trajectory shortly after its Independence in 1947, with bureaucratic 'coups' arresting democratic development in 1953 and 1954 and a military coup formally ending Pakistan's tentative democracy in 1958. Thus, while elements of British colonialism, such as the relatively early introduction of elections and a professionalized civil service, may have contributed towards building Indian democracy, the range of democratic outcomes in former British colonies (and one former colony that specifically shared much of India's legacy) amply attests to the fact that a British colonial legacy alone insufficiently explains India's exceptional democratic trajectory.

A more nuanced argument centralizing the institutional legacies of colonialism in explaining Indian democracy might contend that India was relatively advantaged by gaining a greater proportion of the highly professional colonial civil service or a smaller proportion of the colonial army when colonial British India was cleaved into India and Pakistan. Indeed, a few scholarly studies of the institutional differences between India's and Pakistan's civil services and militaries have suggested that Pakistan inherited relatively weaker state institutions. Potter (1986) implies that India's bureaucracy was likely more professionalized,⁷ while Jalal (1995) posits that India's relatively stronger democratic inheritance relative to Pakistan, in terms of a smaller military and more centralized institutions of state, tipped its institutional balance towards the embrace of formal democracy.⁸

The facts do reveal that India was somewhat advantaged in terms of its institutional inheritance relative to Pakistan, but the causal link between this institutional differential and the radically divergent regime trajectories of these two states remains under-specified and weak. Even if Muslim civil servants were ostensibly less meritorious than their Hindu counterparts, all civil servants and military officers serving at the time of the regime divergence in India and Pakistan (namely, the five years after Independence) were similarly trained and professionalized, with strong professional ethics inculcated during the pre-independence decades.⁹ Upon Independence in 1947, civil service officers were given the choice of which state to serve, and almost all Muslims chose to serve Pakistan, meaning that Pakistan basically inherited a population-proportionate share of the ICS. Even if it were true that those Muslim ICS officers choosing to serve in

Pakistan were less competent or professionalized, several dozen professional and highly experienced British civil servants as well as military officers stayed on and served primarily in the bureaucratic and military machinery of Pakistan (and *not* India) for several years into Independence, thereby significantly attenuating any professionalization deficit in Pakistan's civil service.¹⁰ Once this supporting role of British bureaucrats and military officers in Pakistan is considered, it appears difficult to contend that a differential in the competences of their respective civil services primarily explains divergent regime outcomes (and therefore, the creation of India's democracy).

To be sure, India inherited a much smaller proportion of the military personnel of colonial India than did Pakistan and this smaller inheritance could be argued to have promoted India's establishment of democracy. Indeed, an astonishing number of recruits into the British colonial army were drawn from a few districts in Punjab that became part of Pakistani Punjab upon Independence.¹¹ Nevertheless, it does not necessarily follow that inheriting relatively low levels of military personnel promotes democratic consolidation, as many former colonies across Africa and Asia with relatively low levels of military personnel have nonetheless turned towards authoritarianism in their post-independence decades.

Moreover, the formalization of respected rules for sharing power between elites is considered to define a democratic regime,¹² and the direct impetus behind creation of universal adult franchise in India was its dominant political party, not its colonial bureaucracy or its military. Since India's *sine qua non* democratic institutions were quickly enshrined in India's constitution upon Independence and since India's Constituent Assembly was wholly led by the Indian National Congress, there is considerable *prima facie* evidence that India's dominant political party was most directly responsible for the creation of Indian democracy.¹³ Indeed, the Congress Party had already begun work on the Indian constitution before Independence was achieved. Under nearly exclusive Congress leadership, moreover, this constitution was fully drafted within two and a half years of Independence.¹⁴

If instead of its dominant political party the quality or size of India's colonial institutions were causally responsible for the creation of India's democracy, then we would expect to see a (direct or indirect) mechanism linking the quality of bureaucracy to the creation of democratic institutions. Yet it is difficult to ascertain the Indian bureaucracy's role in the creation of universal adult franchise, an elected chief executive or an array of civil liberties. Any explanation of India's democratic origins must first establish why and how its dominant political party was both capable and desirous of speedily adopting democratic institutions upon Independence.¹⁵

In this vein, political scientists and historians alike have in fact emphasized the pivotal role of India's dominant political party, the Indian National Congress, upon Independence, in spearheading the creation of India's democratic institutions. However, these writings tend to emphasize disparate characteristics of the party as causally responsible for the creation of democratic institutions. If, as Kothari (1970) has suggested, India was effectively governed by the Congress 'system' upon Independence, then what exact characteristics of this party system were responsible for India's adoption of constitutive democratic institutions? Specifically, any claims that Indian democracy was created by its dominant political party should precisely establish *who* took the decision to create India's constitutive democratic features, *how* those decisions were taken, and *why*. The scholarly literature investigating the role of India's dominant political party in creating Indian democracy has tended to centralize four characteristics in explaining its decision to adopt the constitutive features of democracy. The explanatory weight of these four characteristics—exceptional leadership, elite self-interest, class origins, and internal party organization—is evaluated each in turn.

Exceptional leadership

It is tempting to assume that extraordinary leadership is primarily responsible for the creation of Indian democracy. Who, after all, can understand India's embrace of political equality without discussing Mahatma Gandhi or Jawaharlal Nehru? As Varshney (1998) asserts, 'In many and perhaps most postcolonial societies, the leaders who came to the fore during the Independence struggle had so much prestige that, far from being compelled to subject themselves to democratic norms, they could easily have reversed the process and could have fixed or changed norms and procedures according to their own personal preferences. India was fortunate that its first generation of post-independence leaders resisted such temptations ...'¹⁶ Similarly, Rudolph and Rudolph (2008) have argued that the charisma and unique political ideology of Mahatma Gandhi were crucial to the party's embrace of political equality.

Though the embrace of egalitarian political ideology by Indian leaders and their foresight facilitated Indian democracy, attributing India's adoption of democratic institutions primarily to exceptional leadership likely overestimates the role of leadership per se as opposed to the role of its dominant political party in creating such leadership. Again, a contrast with Pakistan's dominant party leadership and subsequent regime trajectory is useful in determining causal linkages. Both Mahatma Gandhi and Mohammed Ali Jinnah were considered the spiritual and political fathers of their respective nations and various scholars have ascribed their leaderships with causal relevance in explaining these states' respective regime trajectories.¹⁷ Moreover, both leaders passed away within a few years of colonial Independence. However, whereas the unity of Pakistan's dominant political party quickly fractured without Jinnah's leadership to smooth over a fractured and weak group, Gandhi's leadership was no longer critical to the functioning of India's dominant party. In fact, its dominant party had functioned with Gandhi's leadership for well over a decade, overruling him on several occasions.¹⁸ It was this political party, *without* its foremost leader, which inaugurated constitutive democratic institutions upon Independence.

One might instead contend that the leadership of one or two other top Congressmen was critical to the creation of democracy, particularly its two top lieutenants upon Independence, Jawaharlal Nehru and Vallabhbhai Patel.¹⁹ Yet this claim is also somewhat misleading. India's Congress Party possessed a whole cadre of high-level leaders who were, on the strength of their testaments in Constituent Assembly debates, supportive of the decisions to adopt universal adult franchise, an elected chief executive and civil liberties. Thus, even though the Congress-led Constituent Assembly frequently made decisions by following the 'Congress high command,' as its top leadership was called, this high command included men of considerable stature within the party who challenged Nehru and Patel on numerous issues, such as Rajendra Prasad, Chakravarti Rajagopalachari, K.M. Munshi, A.K. Aiyar, and B.R. Ambedkar.²⁰

Finally, it is worth noting that in the pre-independence decades, India's Independence party had continued to be politically active while its top leaders languished in jail, evidencing how the Congress Party consisted of more than charismatic leadership. Even though leadership may well have been important in shaping the decisions to adopt democratic institutions, a review of constitutional decision making reveals that many individuals who had risen up through the ranks of India's dominant political party were responsible for the post-independence installation of universal adult franchise.²¹ Because these individuals had for the most part had their political careers defined by party service, leadership alone cannot be held primarily accountable for India's early democratic trajectory.²²

Elite self-interest

Another important strain of scholarship has argued that India's democratization was spearheaded by its dominant political party but that this party represented only a tiny group of a powerful,

self-interested and incoherent political elite. Such an historical interpretation finds its theoretical counterpart in democratization literature. Given a definition of elites as individuals who are in a position to strongly and regularly influence the exercise of political power,²³ scholars have argued that democratic institutions are most directly created through elite pacts, or groups of heretofore disunited elites coalescing around democratic procedures because they positively assess the relative benefits and costs of tolerating democratic institutions.²⁴ Since elites in Congress were responsible for the decision to adopt constitutive democratic features, could narrow self-interest also plausibly be said to explain the inauguration of Indian democracy?

This is indeed the assertion of the Cambridge School of historians, who argue that Congress leaders were a multi-generational hodgepodge of English-educated, indigenous elites who simultaneously ‘competed and collaborated’ with the colonial state, eventually coming together to create the Indian National Congress to promote their own socioeconomic mobility.²⁵ Scholars in this school generally contend that Congress elites were *not* motivated by nationalist ideals but instead were solely concerned with the local pursuit of political power and economic privilege. According to this interpretation, Congress nationalist rhetoric masked predominantly narrow concerns with upward mobility.

In successfully demonstrating that Congress elites were not exclusively or even primarily idealistic nationalists, a focus on elite self-interest likely formed a useful corrective to the predominant focus on the nationalist ideals in Indian historiography at the time that such scholars wrote. However, a single-minded focus on the elite pursuit of power and economic mobility, while able to account for the creation of India's Congress Party, is unable to account for that party's subsequent installation of India's constitutive democratic institutions. The leaders of the party who created constitutive democratic institutions in India represented a tiny, typically high-caste and highly educated demographic. Universal adult franchise was adopted at a time when India's dominant political party was led by these elites and at a time when there existed virtually no popular pressure in India for the adoption of a representative system of government. Any plausible account of India's democratization by Congress leaders must explain why these elites, if motivated solely by self-interest, willingly adopted a democratic constitutional structure upon Independence that eventually enabled subordinate political mobilization and subsequent challenges to their power bases. An account of Congressmen as elites interested only in aggrandizing material benefits and political power cannot explain why such elites institutionalized democracy in the absence of subordinate political pressure.

A second shortcoming of an elite account of India's dominant party is that centralizing elite autonomy tends to overlook that individuals are considered ‘elite’ precisely because they represent, informally or formally, important social or political groups within societies. Indeed, Congress leaders at state and local levels often represented key social groups—castes or social factions—which came together under the umbrella of Congress.²⁶ Elites did *not* have full autonomy to act in pursuit of their individual self-interest, but instead were regularly and continually constrained by the need to marshal among their core constituencies. The narrow pursuit of elite self-interest cannot explain why Congress elite leaders so readily established the constitutive democratic institution of universal adult franchise.

The class origins of India's dominant party

Conceptualizing Congressmen as more than a group of disparate elites and instead as a segment of the urban middle class seeking to gain and maintain political support from the rural middle class provides a more compelling explanation of India's democratic origins for at least three reasons. First, there is ample evidence that Congressmen came to share the belief that colonialism was

responsible for their shared lack of upward mobility and that this belief motivated the creation of a political party to pursue common interests. Second, if one accepts that Congress leaders came to understand their shared class interests as being represented by a nationalist ideology, then the self-interested pursuit of class mobility *as well as* the nationalist ideals espoused in the pursuit of that mobility could help explain why Congress leaders formalized democratic institutions upon Independence. Finally, an emphasis on the pivotal role of the middle class in leading democratization is able to explain convincingly why India democratized and why Pakistan did not.

First, a class-based conceptualization of the Congress Party better explains why elites were able to come together and create a political party that pursued their long-term economic and political interests. While the Cambridge School contends that the pursuit of power by an English-educated elite was primarily narrow and local, a class-based conceptualization of the Congress movement explains why these narrowly self-interested elites successfully bound together in an organization that occasionally overrode narrow self-interest, namely because these individuals jointly perceived colonialism to impede their ability to move up the socio-economic ladder. It is both the *consciousness* of a shared socioeconomic position as well as a shared *attribution* of fault for this position that defines a 'class for itself.' As Weber wrote, 'The fact of being conditioned and the results of the class situation must be distinctly recognizable. For only then the contrast in life chances can be felt not as an absolutely given fact to be accepted but as a resultant from either (1) the given distribution of property, or (2) the structure of the concrete economic order. It is only then that people may react against the class structure not only through acts of intermittent and irrational protest, but in the form of *rational association*.'

²⁷

Indeed, the Congress Party was formed only after such a consciousness and shared attribution of blame was articulated and popularized. During the latter half of the nineteenth century, the educated segment of the indigenous middle class in colonial India increasingly became convinced that their socioeconomic mobility was impeded by colonialism and created the Indian National Congress in order to pursue more rationally these shared interests. The foremost nationalist critique of colonial rule was the so-called drain theory, expounded largely by Dadabhai Naoroji, M.G. Ranade, and R.C. Dutt. These early Congressmen charged that a large part of India's capital and wealth was being drained out of India in the form of salaries and pensions of British officialdom, the profits of foreign capital, the expenses of the British Indian government, and the excess of cheap imports over Indian exports.²⁸ This drain, they argued, was the primary source of India's poverty and the primary obstacle to its industrialization. Replacing foreign capital with indigenous capital and foreign political structures with indigenous ones was the proposed solution. By 1885, a series of pointed failures on the part of local and regional associations to further these goals was the primary impetus behind the creation of the Indian National Congress. Congressmen could thus be termed a 'class' not only by virtue of their shared material interests in breaking open access to the colonial state but also by the shared attribution for their limited socioeconomic mobility to the workings of the colonial state.

The second way in which a class-based account of India's dominant political party better explains Indian democratization is that it enables Indian nationalism to be causally relevant in motivating political behavior. A class-based account of Indian democratization explains why, in the absence of any popular pressure, a group of educated elites institutionalized constitutive democratic institutions. As Anderson (1983) argues, the indigenous, educated individuals staffing far-flung colonial empires were often the originators of nationalist ideologies. The initial conceptualization of an indigenous society as political equals, he argued, often resulted from a particular historical and socioeconomic environment in which indigenous elites were socially excluded from both colonial and indigenous societies. Through print capital and a common

language, these elites became aware of their shared alienation from the colonial state and expounded nationalism, *both* because nationalism furthered their material position as well as because it became a meaningful expression of the contradictions of their socioeconomic position.

This description closely approximates the position of the English-educated indigenous elite staffing the lower-to-middle administrative ranks of the British Indian colonial state in the late nineteenth century. A common *participation* in urban and professional life, a common *alienation* from both the uppermost echelons of power within the colonial regime (because institutionalized racism limited upward mobility) as well as from mainstream Indian society (because of their education in English educational institutions and their inculcation with its different values), and a common *language* encouraged the forging of ideational bonds among such individuals. To be sure, these individuals initially organized into the Congress Party in order to promote their shared material interests, but the motivation for doing so did not remain exclusively material in nature.

These individuals grew motivated by and institutionalized the shared ideational framework of Indian nationalism. In 1920 Congressmen embraced the leadership of M.K. Gandhi instrumentally, because Gandhian tactics had proven successful in gaining political reform where Congress had heretofore failed.²⁹ Over the course of decades, however, Congressmen preached and practiced this egalitarian nationalism in order to maintain a prolonged, multi-class struggle against colonial rule. During this time, the promotion of egalitarian Indian nationalism came to be understood as a matter of self-interest among Congress leaders, helping to motivate the post-independence institutionalization of democracy.

Beginning in 1920 and throughout the 1930s, Congress leaders strengthened alliances with merchant groups, capital, labor, but most especially with the rural 'middle class' or well-to-do 'dominant peasant,' by mobilizing on the basis of grievances that clearly divided the interests of the British colonial regime from that of the indigenous population.³⁰ Though the economic and social plight of subordinate social groups was rhetorically centralized in Congress' platform, Congress policy platforms were careful to protect the interests of the rural middle class. Congress leaders carefully selected symbolic issues for mass mobilization which divided colonial from indigenous interests, such as a lower salt burden, lower land revenues, and the boycott of foreign cloth. That Congress was successful in this attempt is evidenced by its success in the 1937 provincial elections, in which the party won outright majorities in most of the colonial direct-ruled provinces, based on a limited suffrage of approximately one-tenth of the population.

The need to gain and maintain political support among a wide array of social groups, but especially the new, upwardly mobile middle class, was one important motivation for Congress leaders to institutionalize universal adult franchise within the party platform well before Independence. Elections based on universal adult franchise were endorsed as official Congress policy in the 1928 (Motilal) Nehru Report, and the rationale for its adoption clearly stated that universal adult franchise was the easiest way of dealing with the different claims of religious communities to political representation.³¹

Similarly, the basis of the 1932 Poona Pact between Gandhi and Ambedkar accepting joint electorates for the lowest-caste Hindi community, rather than the separate electorates proposed by the colonial regime, further underscores how electoral solutions helped maintain a unified Congress movement. In general, Congress represented the economic interests of the urban, educated middle class as well as the upwardly mobile peasantry, but it also offered subordinate social groups social equality and some access to political power, most notably through universal adult franchise. Only the landed aristocracy firmly aligned with the British colonial regime was excluded from the Congress movement. That Congress electorally represented this broad multi-class coalition is demonstrated by its overwhelming success in the 1952 general elections based

on universal adult franchise and by the remarkably little attention that the question of *zamindari* (landlord) abolition evoked in Constituent Assembly debates.³²

Another example of how the Congress Party created an institutionalized commitment to Indian nationalism that explicates its subsequent creation of democracy is Congress' campaign against caste untouchability. Historically, the Indian sub-continent had proved resistant to unifying political movements in no small part due to the institution of caste—that is, socially endogamous groups the ritual status of which dictated virtually all manner of social interactions.³³ Before 1920 then, the conceptualization, much less acceptance of basic political equality that is so central to the establishment of democracy was highly unlikely in a society where every realm of social interaction was ordered by status rankings. The development of a social sphere in which these caste identities were conceived of as 'private' or separate from a public sphere was thus central to the embrace of political equality that substantively defines a democracy.

The Congress Party was critically responsible for the creation of a limited, egalitarian public sphere in the decades before Independence. Under Gandhian leadership, Congress leaders preached and practiced the public recognition of caste equality. Congressmen spoke up against the *public* recognition of caste differences (for example, on roads, at wells, and at temples) while sanctioning the private distinctions of caste (those related to marriage, for example) as acceptable.³⁴ Provincial Congress committees regularly took up the violations of caste strictures in public places in order to advance the cause of public equality. While the depth of Congress' embrace of caste equality varied, with class, caste and regional particularities all affecting whether and how the campaign against public caste discrimination was advanced,³⁵ the Congress Party did broadly and consistently mobilize against the public recognition of caste distinctions, a relatively radical cause at that time. Moreover, that mobilization did have tangible effects on the extent of caste discrimination in public places.³⁶

To be sure, there was an instrumental motivation for espousing egalitarian nationalism because this conception was a useful way of unifying disparate social classes in a decades-long struggle against colonial rule. Nonetheless, the mobilization for caste equality cannot be understood only as an instrumental means of achieving the end of political reform, both because the rejection of caste strictures entailed significant short-term social costs and because Congress' top leader strenuously objected to caste distinctions being utilized *in favor* of achieving this political reform.³⁷ That caste distinctions were not used to advance Congress' political goals evidences that egalitarian nationalism became meaningful independently of the political goals they were initially adopted to help achieve.

Similarly, Congress' early adoption of universal adult franchise well before Independence militated towards the continuation of such a policy after Independence. Universal franchise had for decades been a part of the Congress platform. Congressmen could have retrenched on the promise of universal adult franchise at a time when the Congress Party stood at the apex of its institutional legitimacy and when its leaders enjoyed a virtual monopoly within the Constituent Assembly. Its leaders might have sought to limit adult suffrage in some way, particularly since the party's top leadership was nearly exclusively composed of upper-caste members of the educated middle class. Indeed, upon Independence there was no longer an immediate need to mobilize subordinate social groups against the colonial regime while there was still, given Congress' primary support base among the upwardly mobile peasantry, a need to control bottom-up redistributive demands.

However, instituting property or educational franchise requirements would certainly have alienated some of Congress' support base at the same time that the Independence struggle had amply demonstrated the party's ability to control the nature, form and extent of subordinate political mobilization. On the whole, then, instituting universal adult franchise did not appear

to threaten Congress' political success at the same time that retrenching on universal franchise may have cost the party political support. Consequently, while the Congress-dominated Constituent Assembly did debate the *form* that universal suffrage would take, there was very little debate about *whether* universal adult franchise should be adopted.³⁸ Even though adopting universal adult franchise did not strictly speaking advance narrowly defined self-interest, it facilitated the creation of an enduring multi-class alliance, meaning that it was substantially less likely to be rejected upon Independence.

If these egalitarian practices, such as the public equality of castes and an unabridged right to vote, did come to be understood as defining Indian nationalism and therefore as a matter of self-interest for Congress leaders, then the adoption of egalitarian institutions in the Indian constitution at a time when they were not strictly required to advance class interests becomes easier to comprehend, since class-centered understandings of democratization allow for ideas to be important when certain ideational frameworks become institutionalized basis for political organization.³⁹ An expansive definition of class, in which Congressmen formed a class not just by virtue of their shared interest in breaking open the colonial state to indigenous employment, but also by virtue of the associated ideologies of their class position, possesses considerable traction in explaining India's democracy.

Finally, a class-centered conceptualization of Congress appears compelling because it can explain why India democratized, as well as why Pakistan did not. Partly as an accident of history and partly because urban middle class merchants in modern-day Pakistan were Hindus who fled to India upon Independence, Pakistan did not inherit a sizeable urban middle class.⁴⁰ If, as some democratic theorists have argued, the presence of a middle class promoting more representative (even if limited) political institutions is necessary (though not sufficient) for democracy to emerge,⁴¹ then the fact that India inherited a relatively sizeable, politically organized and influential middle class and Pakistan did not helps to explain their divergent regime trajectories upon Independence.

Party institutionalization

If a broad class-based conceptualization of the Congress movement helps to explain why India's Congress-led Constituent Assembly embraced constitutive democratic institutions such as universal franchise, then the fact that the Congress Party itself was well-institutionalized also aided in the creation of constitutive democratic institutions because such robust infrastructure facilitated the resolution of post-independence political conflicts and helped to avoid the political stalemates that led to the breakdown in democracy in other newly independent colonies.

India's Independence party had evolved a robust but internally democratic governing structure by the time of Independence. In 1920 a new Congress constitution created seven layers of successive party tiers, each ascending organizational layer drawing its representatives from a subordinate organizational layer. The top-level Congress organizations possessing executive decision-making authority were elected at annual sessions and all decisions within these bodies were taken by majority vote. Together, this organizational infrastructure provided for a regularized, streamlined and democratic method of decision making that enabled forceful leadership from above as well as for some reflection of localized grievances within the upper echelons of the party. Crucially for evidencing the independent causal relevance of party organization, Congress leaders were able to discipline provincial governments into toeing the party line, even when doing so contradicted narrowly defined class interests. For example, Congress leaders were able to prevent Punjabi and Bengali Congressmen from openly condemning the 1932 Communal Award, despite the fact it underrepresented their voice in provincial politics.⁴²

Congress had successfully led a decades-long anti-colonial struggle and governed on the basis of this organizational template, and the same template successfully resolved post-independence governance conflicts, with Congress rank and file members being ideationally and organizationally primed to seek accommodation within the party in pursuit of political power. The Congress-created Assembly Party—an organization created by Congress leaders to enable Congressmen to debate freely constitutional issues off-record before they were formally brought to the Constituent Assembly floor—was one clear example of Congress' organizational prowess facilitating early regime stability. By creating such an organization, the party served as the harbinger of accommodation, though constitutional debate was still frequently acrimonious.

The importance of party organization in promoting speedy constitutional compromise, and therefore in facilitating India's early democratic stability, is evidenced in a number of additional ways. Important but divisive questions—the expropriation of private property and the recognition of linguistically-determined states—were deliberately left until the end of the Constituent Assembly's work at the behest of its key leaders, allowing the constitution to take shape almost entirely before the most contentious issues were tackled. The party president, rather than the governing executive, presided over the Constituent Assembly, preserving the official dominion of the party over the constitution-making process. This meant that the Assembly was to some degree insulated from being used as a means to pursue specific policy goals. The Assembly whip also occasionally worked to keep party members in line with the majority of the party.⁴³ Finally, during the discussion of difficult issues, such as how much power would be relegated to the central versus provincial governments in defining federal powers, appeals to the programmatic content of Indian nationalism helped to create consensus on the need for a relatively strong federal government.⁴⁴ All this was evidence of the decision-making effectiveness of the party itself, an effectiveness created during the party's prolonged anti-colonial struggle.

Indeed, the Congress Party was, relative to its colonial counterparts elsewhere around the world, an exceptionally well-developed political party upon Independence. If political parties crucially broker regime stability via the extent of their organization, then India's dominant political party upon Independence is one of the few in the post-colonial world with a genuinely mass organizational base.⁴⁵ Although to be sure, Congress' ideational commitment and organization hardly approximated the military-like infrastructure of, say, a well-developed communist party, it nonetheless represented a coherent redistributive coalition, it institutionalized an ideology in the pursuit of self-interest that began to define the party independently of class interests, and it developed an organizational infrastructure which, while imperfect and based on local patronage networks, nonetheless enabled all significant social groups to engage in internal bargaining.

Conclusion

To restate in summarized form, this essay has suggested that the puzzling creation of Indian democracy is best explained through a class as well as an institutional dynamic. The Congress Party was initially created to represent the interests of India's urban, educated middle class, a class interested in upward mobility via access to the colonial state. In the course of a prolonged anti-colonial struggle to achieve Independence, this class allied with the rural, upwardly mobile peasantry, thereby forging a coherent coalition that was not just interested in redistributing power and wealth away from the colonial state and its collaborators and towards itself, but also in preventing downwards redistribution.

Because it represented a coherent coalition that shared long-term redistributive interests, India's dominant political party was able to espouse a meaningful national interest and develop a

robust organizational infrastructure with its own causal relevance to political decision making by the time of Independence. After Independence, the ideational frameworks and coalitional bases of this strong, dominant political party motivated the institutionalization of such constitutive democratic institutions as universal adult franchise.

Notes

- 1 The exception being a 21-month period between June 1975 and March 1977, when Prime Minister Indira Gandhi suspended elections and an array of civil liberties.
- 2 Democratization literature has conceptually distinguished between factors said to aid the creation of democracy and factors responsible for its maintenance. Some of the notable works concerned with the ongoing *maintenance* of Indian democracy include Kothari (1970), Kohli (1990, 2001), Jaffrelot (2003), Varshney (2003), and Wilkinson (2006). This essay is centrally concerned with how Indian democracy *initially* came to be created and institutionalized, however.
- 3 The most regularly employed definitions of democracy include Schumpeter (1950), Dahl (1971), Sartori (1987), Di Palma (1990), and Huntington (1991).
- 4 A number of objections to this definition of democracy may obtain. One of these, common in Indian historiography, is that this procedural conceptualization of democracy is excessively elite-centered. Yet the historical inheritance of Indian democracy is still worthy of scholarly investigation because, though some argue that electoral competition between a handful of elites hardly constitutes a democracy, the existence of political elites is almost certainly inevitable in all modern societies relying on mass political organization. See Bottomore (1964) and Higley and Burton (2006). Thus, the relevant question should not be whether a limited elite dominates politics but whether such elites allow new political competitors to organize and openly compete for access to political power. Another prevalent critique of studying a procedural democracy is that such formal institutions have often not conducted socio-economic betterment for much of the population. Not only has Sen (1999) argued that procedural democracy is nearly universally valued as a form of political organization in and of itself, but Jaffrelot (2003) has shown how the institutionalization of procedural democracy was a necessary accompaniment to the gradual entry of lower castes into the political power structure of northern India.
- 5 For an argument specific to the Indian case, see Weiner (1989). For arguments specifying how and why British colonialism more generally may have been pro-democratic, see Huber *et al.* (1993: 80).
- 6 Coen (1971: 3).
- 7 Potter (1986: 117) writes that by 1941, of the 508 'Indian' (that is, non-British) civil servants in the higher administrative service that effectively ran the colonial state, the Indian Civil Service (ICS), 20% of them, or 99 officers, were Muslim. This means that Muslim officers were proportionate to their population in the ICS. However, he also shows that about two-thirds of these officers were recruited not by competitive examination, but rather by a nomination policy designed to keep minority communities represented in the civil service (*ibid.*: 91). Since the vast majority of Muslim civil servants joined Pakistan upon Independence and since a majority of those civil servants were nominated rather than competitively selected, one could infer (though Potter does not directly) that the level of professionalization in the subsequent Pakistani civil service was lower.
- 8 '*The different colonial inheritances of a central state apparatus*, the relatively milder impact of the strategic and economic consequences of partition on India than on Pakistan and the nature of their international links were the most important factors leading to alternative outcomes in the two countries.' Jalal (1995: 33, emphasis added). However, the central theoretical thrust of this book is to equate Pakistani and Indian regime outcomes, citing them as theoretically equivalent, an assertion with which few political scientists concur.
- 9 Potter (1986: chapters 1 and 2).
- 10 'There was a mass exodus of European ICS officers from India (but not Pakistan) upon independence.' Potter (1986: 143).
- 11 Yong (2005: 131).
- 12 Higley and Burton (2006).
- 13 Austin (1972: 8–10).
- 14 Independence was granted on August 15, 1947 and the final constitution was ratified on January 26, 1950.
- 15 Democratic theorists have long contended that the emergence of restrained power-sharing norms between elites are constitutive features of democracy. See for example, Dahl (1971) and Higley and

- Burton (2006). Thus, though Pakistan may have inherited a weaker civil service and a stronger military, the initial instability in Pakistan's constitutional process is fully attributable to party politics as well, with its dominant political party also representing a vast majority of its Constituent Assembly. Yet Pakistan's party was unable to agree on a constitution while India's quickly did. This difference can be much more readily linked to early regime divergence between India and Pakistan than the institutions of state per se.
- 16 Varshney (1998: 46).
 - 17 Jalal (1985) and Rudolph and Rudolph (2008: 62).
 - 18 Moreover, Congress members had chosen to make Gandhi their leader in 1920 because his successful mediations of peasant grievances in the Indian countryside illustrated how Congress' goal of advancing political reform might be linked up with rural grievances. Tudor (2010: 80–83).
 - 19 Varshney (1998: 46–47).
 - 20 Austin (1972: 314).
 - 21 Tudor (2010: chapter 5).
 - 22 Careers defined by party service is a constitutive characteristic of a developed party organization. Levitsky (1998).
 - 23 Bottomore (1964: 7).
 - 24 Dahl (1971), O'Donnell and Schmitter (1986), Burton *et al.* (1992), Bermeo (1997), and Higley and Burton (2006).
 - 25 The foundational works in this tradition are Seal (1968) and Gallagher *et al.* (1973). Additional works in the Cambridge School are Bayly (1975), Brown (1972), Brown (1977), and Tomlinson (1976).
 - 26 Low (2006).
 - 27 Weber (1991: 184, emphasis added).
 - 28 Chandra *et al.* (1989: chapter 7).
 - 29 See, for example, Jawaharla Nehru (1945: 45); also Tudor (2010: 80–84).
 - 30 For the central role of the dominant peasantry in supporting across colonial India, see Low (2006). For a discussion of India's class alliances, see Tudor (2010: chapter 4).
 - 31 Nehru Report of 1928, Indian National Congress Papers, Nehru Museum and Memorial Library: 92–93.
 - 32 Congress' support structure was clearly based on patronage politics, with upwardly mobile peasant groups often standing at the apex of the village-based social structure. Thus, the support of intermediate and lower social classes/castes was often brought along by the dependency of these lower social groups on the prosperous peasantry.
 - 33 See, for example, Hutton (1951).
 - 34 Gandhi, as quoted in Ambedkar (1979: vol. X, 279); or Gandhi (1958: vol. XXVI, 289).
 - 35 Jeffrey (2006: 464), Arnold (1977), McDonald (2006). For an excellent general overview of regional variations in the pre-independence Congress movement, see Low (2006).
 - 36 For example, Aiyappan (1965) discusses the role of the Kerala Provincial Congress Committee in leading anti-caste agitations during the 1920s and 1930s, which substantially attenuated the practice of caste discrimination in public places.
 - 37 See Gandhi's letter in *Young India*, dated February 16, 1921. Gandhi (1958).
 - 38 Indian Constituent Assembly Debates, Vol. XI: 835–50.
 - 39 Gramsci (1971).
 - 40 See Chibber (2003) for argument that India had a sizeable bourgeois middle class, especially relative to other colonial states.
 - 41 Rueschemeyer *et al.* (1992) and Bellin (2004).
 - 42 See, for example, Chatterjee (1994: chapter 3).
 - 43 See, for example, Constituent Assembly Debates, Vol. X: 3–7.
 - 44 See, for example, Constituent Assembly Debates, Vol. V: 77–99.
 - 45 See Diamond and Gunther (2001: 13, 24). Though they give the Indian National Congress a middling score in terms of its organizational development, the Sridharan and Varshney article in their volume does cite an 'elaborate organizational machinery at the provincial, district, and lower levels,' which 'went all the way down to the village level in large parts of the country.' Thus, while India's dominant political party may have been underdeveloped relative to some socialist parties in developed countries, Congress' organizational machinery was very well developed relative to many if not most political parties in post-colonial contexts. See Kothari (1970: chapter 5).

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I.II

Leaders

3

GANDHI'S INDIA, THE WORLD'S GANDHI

Gandhi at home and in the world

Susanne Hoeber Rudolph and Lloyd I. Rudolph

Gandhi's India

Gandhi and Indian identity

We have chosen to write about 'Gandhi and Indian identity' rather than the conventional topic 'Gandhi as nationalist' because, as Ashis Nandy has argued, Gandhi (like Tagore) was an anti-nationalist. Partha Chatterjee, too, argues that 'Gandhi does not think within the category, "nationalism"' (Chatterjee 1993: 91). If India was not a nation in the usual sense, what manner of country was it? Nandy puts it this way:

Gandhi was always keen to define his nationalism as part of his universal struggle for justice and equality and he made it clear in so many words that the other name for armed nationalism was imperialism and he considered it a curse.

(Nandy 2010: 244–45)

Gandhi opposed assuming the kind of exclusive identity for which 'integral' nationalism (Hayes 1931) called and which was manifest in its extreme form in twentieth-century Europe with Hitler's rise to power in Germany. The nation tended to subsume, even obliterate, all other identities and to treat 'the other' at home or abroad at best as lesser beings, at worst as less than human.

The question whether Gandhi did or did not speed Britain's exit from India provides a distraction. Although Gandhi no doubt contributed to Britain's exit from India, it can be argued plausibly that Britain would have departed from the subcontinent after World War II whether or not Gandhi occupied the historical stage. What may prove to be his most important contribution is what he did for Indian character, capacities and political culture. Gandhi's leadership, regardless of its objective success or failure, had important subjective consequences, repairing wounds in self-esteem inflicted by generations of imperial subjection, restoring courage and potency, helping India to acquire national coherence, recruiting and mobilizing new constituencies for the cause of Independence.

As the psychological and moral effects of Britain's conquest and subjection of India spread and deepened, Britons convinced an increasing number of Indians that passivity, weakness and cowardice were the norms of Indian culture and character. These beliefs led many Britons to think that the superiority of British power and culture was an inherent rather than an historical phenomenon. Indians, too, came to believe that they lacked courage and moral worth.¹ The young Jawaharlal Nehru who became independent India's first prime minister, and who often questioned the Mahatma's political strategy and tactics, concedes again and again his effect on the nationalist generation.

Much that he said we only partially accepted or sometimes did not accept at all. But all this was secondary. The essence of his teaching was fearlessness and truth and action allied to these ... So, suddenly, as it were, that black pall of fear was lifted from the people's shoulders, not wholly, of course, but to an amazing degree ... It was a psychological change, almost as if an expert in psychoanalytic method had probed deep into the patient's past, ... and thus rid him of that burden.

(Nehru 1958: 361–62)

Gandhi also shaped Indian identity by transforming India's political culture. Soon after returning to India in January 1915 after 21 years in South Africa he began to intervene in a battle that began in 1905–06 between moderates personified by Gopal Krishna Gokhale and extremists by Bal Gangadhar Tilak. Gokhale argued that *swaraj* or self-government within the empire could be achieved by gradual and incremental constitutional reform. The extremists led by Tilak stood for *swaraj* defined as complete sovereignty achieved through constitutional means if possible but if necessary through collective direct action that could result in violence.

Gandhi followed Tilak in calling for direct action in the form of civil disobedience, non-cooperation and *satyagraha*, but made direct action compatible with Gokhale's constitutional methods by making non-violent means an essential aspect of direct action. Gandhi created an effective alternative to Gokhale's ultimately ineffective constitutionalism and Tilak's ultimately violent extremism. Reshaping Indian political culture by making right means an essential requirement contributed after Independence to the viability of constitutional democracy in India.

Gandhi's successful insistence on right means, and that means determined ends, became a central component of India's political culture in the 1920s and 1930s, decades that witnessed the rise of fascist and communist ideologies and regimes that radically subordinated means to ends. For Gandhi the opposite was true:

For me it is enough to know the means. Means and ends are convertible terms ...

(Gandhi 1946: 424)

We have always control over the means but not over the end [so that] our progress towards the goal will be in exact proportion to the purity of our means.

(Tendulkar 1962: 366)

Another way Gandhi shaped Indian identity was by putting the village and the villager at the center of India's political imagination and strategy. Again Ashis Nandy:

Gandhi took India's freedom movement to the village. He thought of the village as the basic unit of Indian civilization; and he envisioned the future of India around that of the village.

(Nandy 2010: 258)²

However, it wasn't always that way. Like almost all the leaders of India's freedom struggle Gandhi started out as a city boy. As he tells us in his autobiography, he was born in a city, Porbandar, where his father was prime minister of a small princely state. 'For three generations, from my grandfather, [the Gandhis ...] have been Prime Ministers in several Kathiawad States' (Gandhi 1957: 3). He was educated at an elite college, the Rajkumar College in the city of Rajkot where the children of rulers and those who served them were sent. He qualified for the bar at the Inns of Court in London, a city that served as the hub of the British empire. During his years in South Africa he lived and worked as a lawyer in cities, mainly Durban but also Johannesburg.

So how did Gandhi come to exemplify and speak for village India? Ashis Nandy speculates that there was a 'retrievable imagination of the village ... based on the rituals, folklore, epics, legends, and myths to which he was exposed ... that ... was waiting to be reclaimed.' This latent village made manifest 'became Indian public life's first village' (Nandy 2010: 260).

'Creative Indians,' Nandy argues, were responsive to Gandhi's imagined village because they were prepared to invoke 'the fantasy of the "archetypical", "remembered", but nevertheless living Indian village' (Nandy 2010: 258). They were aided and abetted in their fantasy by the filmmaker Satyajit Ray, who created 'Indian public life's first village ... in his debut film, *Pather Panchali*' (Nandy 2010: 260); by the novelist R.K. Narayan,³ whose 'Malgudi stories supply clues to the imagery of the village that empowers the creativity of Gandhi and Ray' (Nandy 2010: 263); and by M.N. Srinivas whose *The Remembered Village* is the 'first Indian village of the social sciences' (Nandy 2010: 265).

Gandhi's imagined village began to become manifest early in his years in South Africa. In 1904 he read Ruskin's *Unto This Last* on an overnight train from Johannesburg to Durban. He resolved the next morning 'to change my life in accordance with the ideals of this book' (Gandhi 1957: 298). He did so by establishing an agricultural settlement on 100 acres 14 miles from Durban, Natal's largest city and its principal port. Known as the Phoenix Settlement, it 'marked an important stage in Gandhi's progressive self-disentanglement from city life ...' (Green 1993: 158).

In 1909 he wrote *Hind Swaraj*. In it, he critiques and rejects 'modern civilization,' the civilization spawned by the industrial revolution that created the modern city. He tells his readers in the Foreword that 'the views I venture to place before the reader are, needless to say, held by many Indians not touched by what is known as civilization ...' (Gandhi 1997: 10), i.e. those living in villages beyond the reach of the British Raj's colonial modernity.

The catalyst for Gandhi's imagined village in India was his political guru and mentor, Gopal Krishna Gokhale, who advised him soon after he returned to India in 1915 after 21 years in South Africa to get to know rural India better.

Nandy's story about an imagined retrievable village doesn't tell us *why* Gandhi should take India's freedom movement to India's villages. Could it be that Gandhi, a strategic as well as a moral political thinker, recognized that the village was where most people lived and that as a person committed to mobilizing and serving the community, he could and should address villagers' poverty and exploitation? However, what about a proximate cause, a triggering mechanism, that would lead him to India's villages?

Out of the blue at Congress's December 1916 session in Lucknow Gandhi was approached by Rajkumar Shukla, a simple but intrepid agriculturalist of Bettiah near Champaran, located in the heart of Bihar's indigo plantations, 'far up north of the Ganges, and right at the foot of the Himalayas in close proximity to Nepal' (Gandhi 1957: 411). Shukla pursued and badgered him until he agreed to travel to distant Bihar to investigate the condition of Indigo farmers.⁴ There he learned that at a time when the availability of commercially manufactured indigo had radically reduced the price of naturally grown indigo, tenants like Rajkumar Shukla were required by law to plant three out of every 20 parts of their land with unremunerative indigo.⁵

Gandhi along with a team of voluntary educated helpers (including the future president of India, Rajendra Prasad) spent almost two months (April and May 1917) in and around Champaran taking testimony from thousands of impoverished tenant cultivators, writing a report and conducting negotiations with government officials and leaders of the Planters Associations. The result was that 'the *tinkathia* system ... was abolished, and with it the planters' raj came to an end' (Gandhi 1957: 425).

More important than the successful result for Gandhi's conception of village India was his initial reception in this remote region of the country, a reception which taught him that he could be effective in a village context and encouraged a belief that the village might be the site of an alternative to the modern city.

No emissaries had ... been sent there ... to prepare the ground for our arrival ... No political work had yet been done amongst them. The world beyond Champaran was not known to them. And yet they received me as though we had been long lost friends. It is no exaggeration ... to say that in this meeting with the peasants I was face to face with God, Ahimsa and Truth ... That day in Champaran was an unforgettable event in my life ...

(Gandhi 1957: 412)

Gandhi's identification of India with its villages did not go uncontested. Prime Minister Nehru's India was to be urban and industrial. Big dams were to be the temples of modern India. Indeed, several generations of civil servants, intellectuals and Congress politicians shared Nehru's conception of a modern industrial and urban India.

In October and November 1945 Gandhi initiated an exchange of letters with Nehru to explore what kind of a future each of them envisioned for independent India. Would Nehru speak his language after he was gone? 'If the difference [between us] is fundamental then I feel the public should also be made aware of it ... I still stand by the system of Government envisaged in *Hind Swaraj*' (Gandhi 1997: 149). The exchange that follows reveals Nehru's incomprehension of and indifference to *Hind Swaraj*, Gandhi's 1909 critique of modern civilization and his alternative to it.

Gandhi's development goals start with the village and villager, with local *swaraj* and local employment using appropriate technology in small-scale industries, craft production and agriculture. Nehru's development goals start with the city and urban life and with industrialization that will 'occupy the commanding heights of the economy' through centralized state planning and work in large-scale, impersonal factories and offices.

'You will not understand me,' Gandhi wrote, 'if you think that I am talking about the villages of today. My villages ... exist in my imagination.' He alerted Nehru that his vision of a modern industrial India was an imagined one too: 'After all, every person lives in the world of his own imagination' (Gandhi 1997: 150).

The village of Gandhi's imagination would be self-reliant, not self-sufficient.

I can think of many which will have to be produced on a large scale. Maybe there will be railroads, so also post and telegraph. What it will have and what it will not, I do not know, nor do I care. If I can maintain its essence, the rest will mean free facility to come and settle.

(Gandhi 1997: 150)

Gandhi's imagined village was to be voluntary, another experiment with truth.

Nehru anticipated Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar's denunciation of the village in the Constituent Assembly where Ambedkar asked, 'What is the village but a sinkhole of localism, a den of ignorance, narrow-mindedness and communalism?'⁶

Nehru replied to Gandhi:

I do not understand why a village should necessarily embody truth and non-violence. A village, normally speaking, is backward intellectually and culturally and no progress can be made from a backward environment. Narrow minded people are much more likely to be untruthful and violent.

(Gandhi 1997: 150)

Nehru then proceeded to attack what he believed to be the source of Gandhi's village commitment, his critique of modern civilization in *Hind Swaraj*:

It is many years since I read *Hind Swaraj* ... But even when I read it 20 years ago it seemed to me completely unreal ... It is 38 years since *Hind Swaraj* was written. The world has completely changed since then ... Consideration of these questions [of development goals] must keep present facts, forces and the human material we have today in view, otherwise it will be divorced from reality.

(Gandhi 1997: 152–53)

On November 12, 1945 Nehru found the time to meet with Gandhi to discuss what development should mean and be in independent India. The only account we have of this conversation is the memo Gandhi sent to Nehru summarizing what he took to be the gist of their discussion. After noting that 'there is not much difference in our outlook,' Gandhi listed what he took to be four areas of agreement. The third was that 'the condition of the countryside and the city should ... be similar in respect to food and water, habitation, clothing and recreation ... ,' and the fourth that 'the basic unit must be an imaginary [self-reliant] village' (Gandhi 1997: 155).

Nehru did not respond but his silence speaks for itself. Gandhi for his part didn't press for more meetings.⁷

Nehru's and Gandhi's mutual silence on the eve of Independence with respect to the standing and place of the village in India's future marks a watershed. On one side lies Gandhi's, Satyajit Ray's, R.K. Narayan's and M.N. Srinivas's village, on the other Nehru's and Ambedkar's: the imagined village as utopia and the imagined village as dystopia.

Today, a century after *Hind Swaraj*, half a century after Independence, the imagined village, utopic, dystopic or statistical artifact, continues to mark India's identity.

Clothing matters⁸

Gandhi also shaped Indian political identity through political theatre. He learned early on that clothing mattered. Clothing communicated a message about himself and about his relationship to others. Soon after his arrival in London in late October 1888 to study law at the Inns of Court he tells us that he attempted to 'play the English gentleman.' His use of the phrase gives us a clue to the self-consciousness with which he was to treat his future presentations of self. Was he 'putting us on,'⁹ engaging in political theatre, occasionally even 'ceremonial profanation' (Goffman 1959) in his efforts to harmonize his inner self and outer persona? In order to play the English gentleman he took violin, elocution and dancing lessons and spent a lot of time in front of a mirror trying to 'part his hair in the correct fashion' (Gandhi 1957: 50–51).

I went in for a chimney-pot hat costing nineteen shillings—an excessive price in those days ... I wasted ten pounds on an evening suit made in Bond Street, the center of fashionable life in London ... This infatuation must have lasted about three months.

(Gandhi 1957: 50)

If Gandhi abandoned the project of ‘playing the English gentleman,’ he did not abandon using clothing to send a message about who and what he was. His aborted effort in London to dress like an English gentleman was resumed in South Africa (1893–1914), where he wore fashionably tailored three-piece suits with striped tie and starched white collar appropriate to an Anglicized £5,000-a-year barrister (Fischer 1950: 74). When he returned to India after 21 years in South Africa at the invitation of his ‘political guru,’ Gopal Krishna Gokhale, with a possibility that he might become a leader of the Indian National Congress, he was ready to provoke the Anglicized reception committee in Bombay. He clothed himself and his entire family in Kathiawar village costume and pointedly spoke in Gujarati rather than English (Green 1993: 251; Tarlo 1996: 69).

Gandhi’s change of dress became increasingly radical, culminating in a loin cloth which he first used in September 1921 in connection with the deadline set by Congress for the achievement of *swaraj*. The loin cloth was highly controversial even among his friends and admirers. Gandhi realized it could be misinterpreted and was aware that some would regard it as indecent or primitive (Tarlo 1996: 72). Notoriously, Gandhi’s lifelong adversary, Winston Churchill, did so in 1930 after the Salt *satyagraha* when he remarked that:

it is alarming and nauseating to see Mr. Gandhi, a seditious middle temple lawyer, now posing as a fakir of a type well known in the east, striding half-naked, up the steps of the vice-regal palace ...

(Tendulkar 1962: III, 53)

Emma Tarlo saw it differently:

while the loin cloth was indeed a full scale promotion of Indianness, it was not a glorification of poverty. Rather, through his nakedness, Gandhi hoped visually to expose Indian poverty while simultaneously suggesting its resolution through hand-spinning, weaving, and freedom from British rule.

(Tarlo 1996: 75)

By 1931, while in London for the second round table conference on Indian constitutional reform, Gandhi could sum up the meaning of the loin cloth: ‘I am here on a special mission and my loin cloth ... is the dress of my principals, the people of India’ (Gandhi 1929–30: 79–80). Gandhi’s clothes were a sartorial expression of his inner mental evolution from barrister to mahatma. As Millie Polak, who had spent some years with him in South Africa, commented: ‘What different phases in Gandhi’s mental career had been proclaimed by the clothes he wore! Each costume, I think, denoted an attitude of mind’ (Polak 1950: 142). Susan Bean goes further:

He used his appearance to communicate his most important messages in a form comprehensible to all Indians. Engaged in the simple labor of spinning, dressed as one of the poor in a loin cloth and chadar, this important and powerful man communicated the dignity of poverty, the dignity of labor, the equality of all Indians, the greatness of Indian civilization, as well as his own saintliness. The communicative

power of costume transcended the limitations of language in multilingual and illiterate India.

(Bean 1989: 368)

However, the power of clothing in shaping India's identity was not limited to what Gandhi wore. It extended to what he induced others to make and to wear. Emblematic of Gandhi's influence on national dress was the decision by the highly Anglicized Motilal Nehru to shed, at Gandhi's behest, his Savile Row suits for homespun *khadi* and a Gandhi cap (Tharoor 2003). Motilal Nehru was one of the wealthiest men in India, a leader of the bar and, in the mid-1920s, of the liberal Swaraj party, and father of Jawaharlal, whom he had sent to Harrow. Father and son, like thousands of their rank and station, signaled their support of Gandhi's ideas and practices by adopting khadi dress and khadi making.

For Gandhi the making, marketing and wearing of khadi symbolized the possibility of self-reliant village industries based on craft production and appropriate technology.¹⁰ However, it had other meanings. Khadi became a sort of uniform, publicly marking a person's politics. It was a leveling force, rubbing out the visual markers of status. Congressmen were required to wear as well as make khadi, which became a marker of common national identity and purpose (Trivedi 2007).

A country of many languages

Gandhi shaped Indian identity not only by having the Anglicized nationalist elite wear peasant clothing but also by having the English-speaking elite that dominated the Indian National Congress (INC) recognize and adopt the vernacular languages of India's regions as its medium of communication. Doing so began a process that in time institutionalized a multilingual India of linguistic states that share sovereignty in a federal system.

In December 1920, when Gandhi took charge of Congress affairs at its Nagpur session, he re-wrote its constitution in ways that transformed it from an elite, unmanageable English-speaking organization into an effectively functioning popular one that communicated in regional languages.¹¹ The pre-1920 Provincial Congress Committees (PCCs) could not accommodate the popular membership base Gandhi sought to create because their boundaries, which coincided with the administrative boundaries of British India, cut across those of language. The consequence was that English literacy was virtually required for participation in Congress affairs. 'In so far as Congress is concerned,' Gandhi held, 'we should re-divide India into provinces on a linguistic basis' (Gandhi 1919: 289). Gandhi proceeded to do so by creating 21 Provincial Congress Committees, each corresponding to a linguistic region of India. The new PCCs succeeded, although not as well as Gandhi expected they would, in transforming Congress from an elite to a popular organization, and in laying the basis for the multilingual India (Gandhi 1920–21: vol. XIX, 191).

Gandhi had begun his effort to break the hegemony of English in the Congress in January 1915 when he spoke Gujarati rather than English at his arrival in Bombay from South Africa. Throughout his career in India he continued to promote multilingualism in his writing, publishing and speaking. He addressed the question of a common language for India by favoring the more inclusive Hindustani, understood as a combination of Urdu and Hindi written in a Devanagiri script, over the more exclusive Hindi, the language that won out in the constitution by a narrow one-vote margin (Sarangi: 2010; Austin 1999). After Independence, state reorganization in the 1960s created a federal system in which linguistic states shared sovereignty with the Delhi-based central government.

Equal respect for all religions: Gandhi's secularism

Another way Gandhi shaped Indian identity was by making it possible for religion to contribute positively to public life and by insuring that religious diversity could flourish. He began by respecting Hinduism because it tolerated diverse faiths, but learned from Vivekananda to go beyond the toleration of diverse faiths to their acceptance. In 1930 he shifted from the discourse of toleration to one that spoke of 'equal respect for religions' (Chatterjee 2005: 33), but Gandhi and those he influenced went beyond toleration and respect for all religions to finding truths in all religions and learning from them.

What did Gandhi mean by religion? Unlike most philosophers, he rejected the separation of ethics and religion. For him, *dharma* included ethics and religion (Chatterjee 2005: 12). The essence of religion, he tells us in *Hind Swaraj* (Gandhi 1997: 67) and in the introduction to his autobiography (Gandhi 1957: xxvii), is morality. Religion understood as ethics or morality helped to answer the Tolstoy questions that preoccupied Gandhi: 'What shall we do and how shall we live?'¹² Gandhi's answer was to be absorbed in the service of the community:

The reason behind it was my desire for self-realization. I had made the religion of service my own, as I felt that God could be realized only through service ...

(Gandhi 1957: 159)

What I want to achieve [through service], is ... to see God face to face, to attain *Moksha*.

(Gandhi 1957: xxvi)

For Gandhi the divine was immanent and personal; he was 'overwhelmed' by Tolstoy's *The Kingdom of God is Within You* (Gandhi 1957: 137).

Gandhi's view of religion did not go uncontested during the nationalist era, an era that did so much to reshape and define India's identity. His principal opponents were his designated heir and successor, Jawaharlal Nehru, whose secularism had no place for religion, and Hindu and Muslim communalists who made Hindu and Muslim the only markers that mattered for identity and collective action.

Nehru, an enlightenment rationalist who had taken science tripos at Cambridge, placed his faith in scientific truth and foresaw a time when religion would be discredited as a form of knowledge and fade from view.¹³ After his death, a call to the country by his close followers to reject religious communalism and to adopt a 'scientific temper' fell largely on deaf ears (Wang 2001: 170–74; Haksar *et al.* 1981; Gregorious 1981).

The struggle over religion between Nehru and Gandhi turned in part on their respective views of secularism. Gandhi was a pluralist not only with respect to religion but more generally. He rejected communalist identity politics not least with respect to religion that reduced a person or a group to a singular belief or characteristic (Chatterjee 2005: 12). Gandhi's secularism rested on his conviction that all religions convey truth, that they give meaning to moral life, and that Indian society can be built on a community of religious communities. Nehru, his political heir and successor, held a different view of secularism, one that denied the validity of religious knowledge and saw it as an impediment to the realization of a modern India.¹⁴

During the nationalist era the principal voices of religious exclusivism were the Hindu Mahasabha and the Muslim League, communal parties that resisted or opposed sharing the state power or social space with a religious other. Under the leadership of Madan Mohan Malviya the Mahasabha's goal became 'the maintenance, protection and promotion of the Hindu race, Hindu culture and Hindu civilization for the advancement of Hindu Rashtra [nation]' (Mansingh

1998: 173–74). Mohammed Ali Jinnah, the architect with Bal Gangadhar Tilak of the Lucknow Pact in 1916 that united the Congress and the Muslim League in the nationalist effort to rid the country of British rule, in the end gave up on his effort to have Congress share sovereignty with India's Muslim minority by opting for a Muslim Pakistan (Rudolph 2006).

Gandhi had made Hindu-Muslim unity an essential goal of his quest for an independent India. Many interpreters of Gandhi's life and career, and not least Gandhi himself, count the partition of India into a Muslim Pakistan and secular but Hindu-majority India as marking the failure of Gandhi's religious inclusivism and pluralism. The latest such interpreter of Gandhi's life, Joseph Lelyveld, echoed others when he said that the communal mayhem, murder, and migrations of partition brought Gandhi's 'whole life into question' (Lelyveld 2011: 293).

However, Gandhi's view of religion, that it was a source of morality and as such constitutive of social life and of standards in politics (Madan 1987: 752), survived the fires of partition. His view of secularism, which called for the state to give equal respect and equal rights to all religions, found constitutional expression in Article 25, guaranteeing all persons 'the right to profess, practice and propagate religion',¹⁵ and Article 26, guaranteeing '... every religious denomination ... the right ... to establish and maintain institutions for religious and charitable purposes [and ...] to manage its own affairs in matters of religion ...' (Basu 1999: 224).¹⁶

Despite the use after Independence of religion for communal purposes by Hindu nationalists, Gandhi's legacy continues to mark India as a country the soft power of which includes the influence of religion on public life.

The world's Gandhi: Gandhi as world historical figure

The other West

The 1909 Foreword and the 1910 Preface of *Hind Swaraj* (*Indian Home Rule*) make clear that Gandhi was involved in a larger movement of European thought that questioned and resisted violent imperialism and dehumanizing industrialism. In its time and subsequently that movement has proved to have global reach. It is the European doubters and dissenters who motivated and helped Gandhi formulate his critique of modern civilization and articulate an alternative to it.

Gandhi thought of European dissenters as the 'other' West. It was a West that shaped his civilizational hybridity and countercultural mentality. It was a West to which, in time, he made major contributions. The 'other' West was defined in part by the 14 authors and 20 books Gandhi listed in an appendix to *Hind Swaraj* and in part by public figures of the 1880s and 1890s who influenced him, such as William Morris, George Bernard Shaw, Annie Besant, John Burns, Maurice Hyndman, Edward Carpenter and Henry Salt.¹⁷ The authors and public figures imagined another way to live and marched to a different drummer. Gandhi's co-conspirators said no to modernity's siren call of progressivism and maximalism, and to empire's awesome violence and splendor. In the Preface and Foreword to *Hind Swaraj* Gandhi tells us what he learned from and shared with the other West:

Whilst the views expressed in *Hind Swaraj* are held by me, I have but endeavoured humbly to follow Tolstoy, Ruskin, Thoreau, Emerson and other writers besides the masters of Indian philosophy ... For ready reference some of the books are mentioned in the Appendices.¹⁸

(Gandhi 1997: 6)

In the Foreword he tells us:

These views are mine, and yet not mine. They are mine because I hope to act according to them. They are also part of my being. But yet, they are not mine, because I lay no claim to originality. They have been formed after reading several books. That which I dimly felt received support from these books.

(Gandhi 1997: 10)

Gandhi argues that colonialism and imperialism and the modern civilization they imposed on the West as well as India did not eliminate the possibility of a Ruskin or a Tolstoy speaking from within the West for an 'other' West. For Gandhi in 1909, countercultural dissent and resistance to the hegemony of modern civilization were already global phenomena.

Gandhi and the making of an other West

Gandhi began to contribute to the 'other' West soon after World War I, when his significance reached well beyond the Indian subcontinent. He first appeared on the world stage in 1919 in the immediate aftermath of the war. The war had dealt a devastating blow to the promise of technological and moral progress in the Western world. European and American consciousness was radically transformed. The fervid patriotism and lofty idealism that led millions to offer their lives for their country disappeared from view. For a time, war was discredited as a test of national greatness and as an instrument of policy. In the new anti-war climate, pacifism achieved a greater measure of credibility and public standing, a circumstance that helped to open the way to Gandhi's ideas and practice.

In Europe, Romain Rolland, who in 1915 had won the Nobel Prize for literature, took a critical attitude toward the great butchery of 1914–18. Rolland in his widely translated 1923 biography, *Mahatma Gandhi* ([Rolland 1924], linked Europe's post-war tilt toward pacifism to Gandhi's world view. Rolland's biography put Gandhi on Europe's mental landscape.

In post-World War I America Gandhi attracted the attention of a leading liberal theologian, John Haynes Holmes, from 1919 until 1949 minister of the Community Church of New York and editor of the liberal, internationalist and pacifist journal, *Unity*. Holmes announced to much fanfare in April 1921 that he would deliver a sermon, 'Who is the Greatest Man in the World?' The answer he gave was M.K. Gandhi. Holmes found Gandhi credible as a 'mahatma,' which he translated to his attentive congregation not as 'great soul' but as 'the Saint,' a characterization which he made intelligible in Christian terms.¹⁹

Holmes's rival for interpreting Gandhi to America was Reinhold Niebuhr, the eminent theologian who was among the most influential public intellectuals in the decades preceding and following World War II. Niebuhr, who was called 'the father of us all' by 'realists' (Fox 1985: 238), characterized Holmes as the 'ultimate symbol of the sentimental liberal pacifist' (Fox 1985: 130). However, Niebuhr, in his immensely influential and most important 1932 book, *Moral Man and Immoral Society*, presented a Gandhi more in keeping with Holmes's view:

The advantage of non-violence as a method of expressing goodwill lies in the fact that it protects the agent against the resentment which violent conflict always creates in both parties to a conflict, and that it proves this freedom of resentment and ill-will to the contending party in the dispute by enduring more suffering than it causes ... One of the most important results of a spiritual discipline against resentment in a social dispute is that it leads to an effort to discriminate between the evils of a social system

and situation and the individuals who are involved in it. Mr. Gandhi never tires of making a distinction between individual Englishmen and the system of imperialism which they maintain ... The discovery of elements of common human frailty in the foe and, concomitantly, the appreciation of all human life as possessing transcendent worth, creates attitudes which transcend social conflict and thus mitigate its cruelties.

(Niebuhr 1953: 234, 247–49, 255–56)

Ultimately, Niebuhr tried to have it both ways: idealism and realism. Despite his fulminations against sentimental liberalism, he allowed himself to admire, even to identify with, Gandhi the prophet and statesman who could command a nation and humble an empire.

Gandhi also entered American consciousness as a successful opponent of British imperialism in India. His success in using non-violent, collective action in challenging the world's mightiest empire in India intersected with political and ideological currents in the USA. Ironically, it was the proponents of American imperialism who were the arch enemies of British imperialism. The leading voice among them was press baron William Randolph Hearst. By 1922 Hearst had become an early advocate of Gandhi's cause. Seizing the opportunity to twist the lion's tail that Gandhi's challenge to the British empire offered, he inveighed against 'England and her domination of India against the will of its 300,000,000 people' (Jha 1973: 124).

Colonel Robert R. McCormick, publisher of the *Chicago Tribune*, joined Hearst in publicizing Gandhi's challenge to British rule in India. It suited both publishers' anti-British imperialism goals to praise and support Gandhi. It was McCormick who sent William Shirer to India to report on Gandhi and Indian affairs for the *Chicago Tribune*. The sea change that occurred after World War I in the USA's outlook toward war and imperialism helped make the *dhoti*-clad, bare-chested Gandhi the hero of pacifists whose opposition to the war now seemed justified. American opinion was ready to celebrate a nationalist leader who was Asian, non-violent, and 'spiritual.' By 1930, the year of the great Salt March that shook the foundations of British rule in India, *Time* magazine declared him 'man of the year.'

Gandhi's standing as a world historical figure grew after the success of the salt *satyagraha* in 1930 made the practice of non-violent resistance and non-violent civil disobedience credible possibilities for the conduct of politics. Among the major figures who learned from him and came to practice non-violent resistance were Martin Luther King in the USA, Lech Walesa and Vaclav Havel in Eastern Europe, and Nelson Mandela in South Africa.

Gandhi did not regard non-violent resistance as universally applicable. Quite the contrary, it could be used only under limited, special circumstances. *Himsa* or violence was ubiquitous, a condition of living, breathing and acting in the world. *Ahimsa* or non-violence was rarely achieved and difficult to sustain. Gandhi himself participated in four wars: the Boer War and the Zulu rebellion in South Africa where he organized and led medical corps; World War I where he recruited soldiers for the Indian Army in Gujarat to fight; and World War II where he was prepared to commit India to fight with Britain against Hitler if Britain would commit to India's Independence when the war ended. He justified his participation in these wars after finding that there was no non-violent way to prevent or stop them and that he was obliged to support the government, the laws and protection on which he relied.

Martin Luther King's use of non-violence in the American Civil Rights movement may have been non-violent resistance's greatest success. As leader of the Southern Christian Leadership Conference, King made Gandhi a household name in the USA by embracing his ideas and methods. Through King, Gandhi affected the conduct of the Civil Rights movement that began in the mid-1950s and crested in the mid-1960s. King discovered Gandhi early in his career, made Gandhi's ideas and practice his own, and remained faithful to them when, in what

turned out to be the last years of his life, many of those whom he had previously influenced and led abandoned *satyagraha* and non-violence.

Prior to reading Gandhi I had about concluded that the ethics of Jesus were only effective in individual relationships ... Gandhi was probably the first person in history to lift the love ethic of Jesus above mere interaction between individuals to a powerful and effective social force on a large scale ...

(King 1958: 47)

In the 1980s Gandhi began to influence European public life. He was acknowledged by the architects and heroes of the non-violent revolutions in Eastern Europe, Lech Walesa in Poland and Vaclav Havel in Czechoslovakia. Havel shared Gandhi's sense of the value of situational truth that the practice of *satyagraha* could achieve. Such truth, Havel argued, enabled humans to recognize 'an elementary sense of justice,' 'the ability to see things as others do,' and 'a sense of transcendental responsibility ...' (Havel 1992), and made them recognize politics as 'morality in practice' (Havel 1995).

In the 1990s the Dalai Lama began to invoke Gandhi in his non-violent efforts to gain autonomy for Tibet (Gyatso 1990) and Nelson Mandela publicly acknowledged that 'the Gandhian influence dominated freedom struggles on the African continent right up to the 1960s.' Mandela tells us that:

I followed the Gandhian [non-violence] strategy ... because of the unity it forged among the apparently powerless ... for as long as I could ... [The African National Congress] chose sabotage [rather than retaliatory violence] because it did not involve the loss of life and offered the best hope for future race relations.

(Mandela 1999: 74)²⁰

In 2011, Gandhian non-violent resistance was available again in the struggle for justice and equality in Cairo's Tahrir Square, emblem of the Arab Spring that challenged and sometimes toppled authoritarian regimes. Non-violent resistance delegitimized the state's violence even as it legitimized the protesters' cause. Gandhi had shown another way to fight.²¹

Notes

- 1 We develop these historical themes in Rudolph and Rudolph 2006: chapter 5.
- 2 A decade earlier Nandy presented a more complicated story of the place of the village and of the city in the shaping of Indian identity: 'The Journey to the Past as Journey into the Self: *The Remembered Village and the Poisoned City*' in Nandy 2001: 1–41.
- 3 For more on R.K. Narayan, arguably the first Indian novelist writing in English to achieve worldwide literary standing, see Ram and Ram 1996.
- 4 See Part V, chapter XII of Gandhi 1957: 404–6. Gandhi devotes eight chapters of Part V, chapters XII–XVIII, of his autobiography to his Champaran experience. Gandhi 1957: 404–24.
- 5 This system was known as the *tinkathia* system, as three (*tin*) *kathas* out of 20 (which make one acre) had to be planted with indigo.
- 6 An untouchable himself, Ambedkar emerged in the nationalist era as a leader of the untouchable community when he challenged Gandhi's efforts to represent and speak for the untouchable community. Nehru appointed him law minister in his first post-independence cabinet. As Chairman of the Drafting Committee in the Constituent Assembly he played a leading role in shaping the 1950 Constitution. beyondcapital.wordpress.com/2011/01/1marx-ambedkar-villages/ Marx, Ambedkar and Indian Villages (accessed August 18, 2011).
- 7 For an examination of the debate including why both protagonists lapsed into silence see Rudolph 2006: 23–27.

- 8 The term is of course the title of Emma Tarlo's wonderful book (Tarlo 1996).
- 9 Mark Juergensmeyer in his essay, 'Saint Gandhi' suggests that Gandhi may have been putting us on in dressing like a mahatma. He remarks that 'Gandhi seems to have become a saint by pretense and enticement.' Gandhi he suggests from time to time cultivated a saintly demeanor in ways that took advantage of Western credulity (Juergensmeyer 1987: 193 passim).
- 10 Toward the end of 1934 Gandhi retired from Congress to set up the AIVIA, the All-India Village Industries Association, for 'the economic, moral, and hygienic uplift of the rural population.' He wanted to facilitate the creation of local village industries that would supply local village markets (Green 1993: 327–28).
- 11 For an account of Gandhi's transformation of the Congress at the Nagpur session of the Congress in December 1920 see Rudolph and Rudolph 2006: chapter 8, 230–52).
- 12 These are questions raised by Leo Tolstoy (1987). For a discussion of how Gandhi and Max Weber intersect with Tolstoy in relation to these questions, see Rudolph and Rudolph 2006: 19. Being aware of these questions helped Gandhi to reject another philosophical dichotomy: that between consciousness and conscience (Chatterjee 2005: 12–13).
- 13 That Nehru viewed religion as false and dangerous knowledge is attested to by what he had to say about it in his autobiography. 'The spectacle of what is called religion ... in India and elsewhere has filled me with horror, and I have frequently condemned it and wished to make a clean sweep of it ... It seems to me to stand for ... dogma and bigotry, superstition and exploitation ...' (Nehru 1958: 241). According to Craig Calhoun *et al.* 'Jawaharlal Nehru ... described secularism as one of the "pillars of modernity." In his mind, it was unthinkable that India could progress into the modern world laden with what he regarded as the prejudices and superstitions of its religious past' (Calhoun *et al.* 2011: 6–7).
- 14 According to T.N. Madan, Nehru's secularism is 'the dream of a minority which wants to ... impose its will upon history but lacks the power to do so ...' (Madan 1987: 748).
- 15 For a comprehensive, analytic and critical analysis of constitutional law relating to religion, see Sen 2010.
- 16 Durgas Das Basu explains the meaning of the word secular inserted by the 42nd Amendment in 1976 into the preamble of the Constitution as it was interpreted by a nine-judge Bench of the Indian Supreme Court in *Bommai v. Union of India* 1994. The Bench held that the term 'secular' not only prohibited the state from establishing any religion of its own but also 'enjoining it to accord equal treatment to all religions ...' (emphasis in the original). It is notable that the insertion of the word 'secular' in the Preamble to the Constitution was not interpreted by the Supreme Court in a Nehruvian manner, although that was likely to have been Indira Gandhi's intent when she had the word 'secular' added to the Preamble by the 42nd Amendment.
- 17 Green 1993: 91.
- 18 Gandhi 1997: 120. The following books are recommended for perusal to follow up the study of the foregoing: *The Kingdom of God Is Within You*, Tolstoy; *What is Art?*, Tolstoy; *The Slavery of Our Times*, Tolstoy; *How Shall We Escape?*, Tolstoy; *The White Slaves of England*, Sherard; *Civilization: Its Cause and Cure*, Carpenter; *The Fallacy of Speed*, Taylor; *A New Crusade*, Blount; *On the Duty of Civil Disobedience*, Thoreau; *Life Without Principle*, Thoreau; *Unto This Last*, Ruskin; *Duties of Man*, Mazzini; *Defence and Death of Socrates*, From Plato; *Paradoxes of Civilization*, Max Nordau; *Poverty and Un-British Rule in India*, Naoroji; *Economic History of India*, Dutt; *Village Communities*, Maine. In *Gandhi and in Mountain of Truth* Green pioneered the study of the 'other West' which, from his student days in London, helped to shape Gandhi and to which Gandhi subsequently contributed.
- 19 See Mark Juergensmeyer (1986) for a critical discussion of Holmes's characterization of Gandhi as a saint in a Christian context.
- 20 Mandela continues: 'Nonviolence was the official stance of all major African coalitions, and the South African ANC [African National Congress] remained implacable, opposed to violence for most of its existence ... I followed the Gandhian strategy for as long as I could ... Even then [after adding "a military dimension to our struggle"] we chose sabotage because it did not involve the loss of life, and it offered the best hope for future race relations' (Mandela 1999: 74).
- 21 See *The Worden Report: Gandhi as Model for the Arab Spring*, thewordenreport.blogspot.com/2011/07/gandhi-as-model-for-arab-spring.html (accessed August 19, 2011).

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4

NEHRU AND HIS LEGACY

Jivanta Schoettli

As the first prime minister of independent India, Jawaharlal Nehru led the country for 17 crucial years. Initially head of the interim legislature (1947–52), he was prime minister following three successive general elections in 1952, 1957, and 1962. From 1951 to 1955 he was also president of the Indian National Congress (INC) party in addition to holding several ministerial posts including minister of external affairs throughout, and for a few months also minister of finance in 1958 and minister of defense in 1962. Imprisoned for more than nine years during India's freedom struggle, he was widely regarded as the anointed successor to Mahatma Gandhi and attained a larger-than-life stature in Indian politics. His impact has been long lasting and far reaching. Admirers and critics alike attribute the resilience of India's democracy to his stewardship during the crucial decades after Independence, from the years 1947–64.

Several important biographies of Jawaharlal Nehru exist and every commentator and observer of Indian politics has an opinion on his personality, achievements, weaknesses and legacy. Among the best-known biographers are Michael Brecher (1959), Michael Edwardes (1971), S. Gopal (1975–85) with his three-volume official biography, B.R. Nanda (1995), Stanley Wolpert (1996) and Judith Brown (2003). Generally speaking, it is possible to distinguish two 'generations' of Nehru scholars. Writers like Brecher, Edwardes and Gopal were contemporaries of Nehru, either observing his politics first hand or, as in Gopal's case, as a public official. As a result, they approach the subject matter with a natural sensitivity for the context, aware of the many pressures as well as the historic opportunities that Jawaharlal had as prime minister. Hence their writing is unconsciously multi-layered. In contrast, authors like Brown, Wolpert and, most recently, Benjamin Zachariah (2004), and Shashi Tharoor (2003) represent a shift towards a more systematic study of the man and his times but nevertheless appear colored by a sense of nostalgia for bygone days. The general trend has been towards an ever-greater magnification of Jawaharlal's vision at the expense of deciphering his tactical and strategic behavior as a political actor. As a result, Jawaharlal Nehru has remained the country's philosopher king, the ideal leader who combined virtue and wisdom. Such an insight, however, does not really help in analyzing the long-term impact that India's first prime minister had on the country's subsequent political development.

The position and status that Nehru had achieved by the mid-1950s both within the Congress Party and in Parliament provided him with tremendous room to maneuver. However, in addition to his vision of and aspirations for an independent and democratic India, it is useful to

delve into some of the compromises that actual policymaking entailed (Schoettli 2011). The decade of the 1950s is in many ways the wellspring of contemporary Indian politics given that core values were hotly debated, negotiated and institutionalized. Amongst these were secularism, planning, non-alignment, federalism, industrialization and the linguistic reorganization of the states. Nehru's *Letters to Chief Ministers*, spanning 1947 to 1964, provide an excellent insight into the multitudinous administrative challenges and the range of policy issues that confronted the government. While his comments and analysis on numerous tasks and issues are admirable for their breadth and scope, the letters also come across as pedantic and at times obsessive in their detail, indicating an inherent desire to command and control. However, to understand Jawaharlal Nehru the prime minister and politician, it is necessary to identify some of the formative experiences during his early years and political career.

Jawaharlal's pre-independence career

Jawaharlal was born in 1889 into a wealthy, Brahmin family originally from Kashmir but which had settled in Allahabad, a city in today's northern state of Uttar Pradesh. In his childhood he was exposed to great religiosity on his mother, Swarup Rani's part and the strongly Westernized habits and views of his father, Motilal Nehru, who was a highly successful barrister and influential INC figure. From 1901 to 1904 Jawaharlal was educated at home by a European tutor. Then at the age of 16 he was sent to Harrow and from there to Trinity College, Cambridge, from which he graduated with a Lower Second in the Natural Sciences Tripos in 1910. Fulfilling the wishes of his father, Jawaharlal went on to read law at Gray's Inn, London, where before him Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi and Muhammad Ali Jinnah, among others, had studied. It was during these early years in Britain that Jawaharlal gained an interest in Indian politics.

Returning to India in August 1912, Jawaharlal initially worked for his father's law practice in Allahabad, gradually engaging himself in politics, for example through Annie Besant's Home Rule League. Meeting Gandhi for the first time in late 1916 at the Lucknow Congress of the INC, Jawaharlal notes in his autobiography that 'he seemed very distant and different and unpolitical to many of us young men' (Nehru 1936: 35). However, by 1919 he was swept up in Gandhi's first all-India *satyagraha* (the use of non-violent, civil disobedience) to protest the Rowlatt Act which extended wartime repressive legislation into peacetime. In the wake of the Jallianwala Bagh massacre of 1919, the youthful Jawaharlal worked closely with Gandhi, organizing relief work in the Punjab and setting up the Congress Party's own enquiry committee. These experiences set the foundation for what was to become one of the most crucial and successful political partnerships in Indian politics, with Jawaharlal eventually carrying Gandhi's mantle while more senior and veteran leaders like Vallabhbhai Patel assumed less of the spotlight.

In 1920 Jawaharlal Nehru participated in the Congress Party's Allahabad district conference and was elected vice-president of the district committee, his first official position. This was also the year when he 'discovered' the peasants in his first rural campaigns within the *Kisan* (farmers) movement. 1920 was also the year Gandhi gave his support to the *Khilafat* movement, exposing the young Jawaharlal early on to tensions between the Congress Party and the Muslim League and the question of who rightfully represented Muslim opinion.

On December 6, 1921 Jawaharlal and his father Motilal Nehru were arrested and sentenced to six months in jail. Three months later, at what seemed to be the peak of non-cooperation, Gandhi called off the movement in response to an outbreak of violence in the United Provinces town of Chauri Chaura. Shocked by Gandhi's unexpected move, Jawaharlal felt as though the cause of the movement, as well as his own sacrifices, had been betrayed. Although he never

came to the point of actually breaking with Gandhi, Jawaharlal did not always agree with his methods and priorities. By the mid-1920s the aftermath of the Russian Revolution had been felt in India with the growth of left-wing parties, workers' and peasants' parties, an increase in trade unionism, workers' agitations and strikes. Jawaharlal, who had always been attracted to radical action, began to veer more towards the left.

In March 1926 Jawaharlal, his wife and daughter left for Europe to treat his wife's tuberculosis. During this stay, he travelled to major European cities and met with prominent intellectuals. For example, at the International Conference against Colonial Oppression and Imperialism at Brussels, which he attended as a representative of the INC, Jawaharlal encountered Romain Rolland, Albert Einstein and Sun Yat-Sen's widow, Song Qingling. Playing a large part in the proceedings, in the drafting of resolutions and making a number of public statements, Jawaharlal was beginning to carve out for himself an international persona.

His return to India saw the arrival of the Simon Commission which was to review India's progress towards higher political development and to determine its capability for self-government. Adding insult to injury, the Commission was composed of all-white members. While Motilal Nehru and others continued to favor constitutional reform and gradual progression from dominion status to eventual Independence, Jawaharlal piloted a provocative resolution at the INC Madras session in December 1927 declaring 'independence with full control over the defence forces of the country, the financial and economic policy and the relations with foreign countries' (Gopal 1989: 3). One year later, when no concessions had been offered by the government, the Congress passed the *Purna Swaraj* (Complete Independence) Resolution in Lahore on December 31, 1929 and on January 26, 1930, the flag of the INC was unfurled and hoisted as the national flag and 'Independence Day' marked across India (a date that is commemorated today as Republic Day). This high point coincided with Jawaharlal's election to Congress Party president in late 1929.

The following years leading up to the outbreak of World War II saw Jawaharlal Nehru emerge to become one of the INC's most prominent figures. In and out of jail, this period was also used for his many publications which have provided valuable insights into the formation of his ideas about India, his policy goals and views on world politics. A book of essays and letters to his daughter Indira written during this time was published as *Glimpses of World History* in 1934. To quell growing curiosity about his intellectual and political inclinations, Nehru published *Whither India* in October 1933—a pamphlet of questions and answers about what he believed was to come after Independence and a depiction of how he envisioned socialism could be implemented in policies. Arrested again in February 1934 for denouncing imperialism and tried for sedition, he was sentenced to two years' imprisonment during which he wrote *An Autobiography* (published in 1936).

By this time Jawaharlal Nehru had honed a careful balancing act. Capable of issuing strong statements denouncing religion, for instance depicting religion as an opiate to dull men's desire for freedom and pushing for a sweeping list of fundamental rights, he also knew not to go too far as to alienate completely the more conservative members as well as influential businessmen backing the Congress Party. As a result, he managed to disappoint his far more radical contemporary Subhas Chandra Bose, who felt that Nehru did not have the courage to pursue his socialist inclinations if it risked breaking with the party, a risk Bose took in 1939 when he stood for and won re-election as Congress president against the wishes of Gandhi. Having taken this step, however, Bose was eventually compelled to resign.

Nurturing a more cautious and even-handed approach to politics, Jawaharlal was able to let events guide him—a flexibility which he perhaps lost during his time later as prime minister. For instance, while he was initially against the Congress participating in the provincial elections

set for 1937, he threw himself wholeheartedly into the act of governing and administering following the party's sweeping victories. Taking it upon himself to become the 'conscience of the ministries,' Jawaharlal reprimanded premiers of various provinces on their policies and statements. Concerned that the day-to-day running of provincial administrations was distracting Congress members from the long-term goal of Independence, and observing growing fractionalization within the party, the 'Mass Contact Program' was launched in 1937 with Jawaharlal Nehru at its helm—an initiative which turned out to have mixed results for the party.

Aimed at bringing Congress into close contact with those who were not yet Congress supporters, *Muslim* mass contact was deemed a priority. Drawn into 'high' politics more directly, Jawaharlal's views on the role of religion in politics and the potential for communal violence took on a harder line. Writing in 1937 to Stafford Cripps, a major Labor party leader, Jawaharlal claimed that, 'I come into greater touch with the Muslim masses than most of the members of the Muslim League. I know more about their hunger and poverty and misery than those who talk in terms of percentages and seats in the councils and places in the state services' (quoted in Wolpert 1996: 223). Issuing such an open challenge, especially when it was released in the form of a statement to the press, Jawaharlal's actions had the effect of spurring the Muslim League to launch a far more successful 'mass contact' campaign of its own, as well as setting the leader of the Muslim League, Muhammad Ali Jinnah, on a war path. Approaching the problem of communal politics in highly dichotomous terms, Nehru more often than not depicted the Congress as 'an advanced organization' pitted against 'a politically reactionary organization like the League.' This ruled out the possibility of Congress sharing power in the provincial ministries, a move which could have helped dispel the accusation that Congress provincial rule, particularly in heavily Muslim-populated provinces, was discriminatory and repressive against Muslims.

Amongst his contemporaries, with the exception of Subhas Chandra Bose, Jawaharlal Nehru was probably the most interested in international affairs and his writings indicate that foreign travel was a respite and source of inspiration for him. In 1937 he travelled to Burma and Malaya and in June 1938 left for Europe, where he visited Spain during the Civil War, making numerous public appearances in which he spoke on subjects such as the dangers of fascism, imperialist aggression and the world situation. Witnessing the Munich pact of 1938, Jawaharlal Nehru observed, first hand, the increasing sense of crisis and approaching war that was building up in Europe. By December 1939, when the Congress ministries had resigned in protest against Britain's declaration of war on India's behalf without consulting any of its 'representative' bodies of Indians, the Congress Party's organizational capabilities had been diminished, a right-left fault line had been exposed, and communalist politics was on the rise. For most of World War II Nehru was behind bars, jailed from November 1940 to December 1941, and again from August 1942 to June 1945.

Barely out of jail, Nehru plunged into intensive negotiations with London and the Viceroy of India, Lord Wavell, and engaged in preparations for the provincial elections of 1945/46. Reflecting growing schisms and battle lines, the Congress lost some of its previously held general seats in the Central Assembly whilst the Muslim League swept all 30 Muslim seats. On July 8, 1946 Nehru was elected Congress president, securing his way to becoming independent India's first prime minister. Jawaharlal was invited to form an interim government on September 2, 1946 and the first meeting of India's Constituent Assembly was convened in New Delhi on December 9, 1946.

Early crises: partition, Kashmir, Hyderabad and Junagadh

Even before Independence was officially granted on August 15, 1947, the government-in-waiting faced one of the greatest crises in modern times: partition of the sub-continent, which

entailed dividing vast tracts of territory, enabling the exchange of millions of people and the onset of mass communal violence which resulted in deaths estimated at several hundred thousand to 1 million. Jawaharlal Nehru's role in the negotiations leading to Independence has not been studied conclusively. Many have found evidence that Nehru was adamant and uncompromising towards his rival and, by this time, arch enemy, Mohammad Ali Jinnah. As a last measure Gandhi proposed an all-India Jinnah government but Nehru simply refused an arrangement that could jeopardize his hard-won power (Wolpert 1996: 387). In a recent and controversial book, politician Jaswant Singh (2009) argues that Jawaharlal Nehru simply failed to understand the majoritarian concerns of Jinnah. Much archival work, however, remains to be done to unravel the intricate mesh of pride, ambition, personality and British machinations that conspired to produce the Partition.

The next crisis came to the fore when in October 1947 tribesmen crossed over from Pakistan's northwest frontier province into the Indian side of Kashmir, prompting the Hindu Maharaja to plea for military help from Delhi. With the Indian Army in the valley, this has come to be known as the first Kashmir war between India and Pakistan. On January 1, 1948 India opted to put the Kashmir issue to the United Nations (UN). Here again, Nehru's judgment has come under scrutiny for this was carried out on the advice of his confidante and newly installed High Commissioner to the United Kingdom Krishna Menon, and India's Governor-General Lord Mountbatten. Rather than produce a solution, his decision to internationalize the problem resulted in a stalemate with all too well-known consequences that continue to embitter relations between India and Pakistan. Further questions arise given the fact that on other, almost parallel cases of disputed accession, that of two other princely states, Junagadh and Hyderabad, troops were used to obliterate decisively any option of Independence or union with Pakistan. On Kashmir, however, a number of reasons have been proposed for Jawaharlal Nehru's vacillation. His ancestral ties to the Vale of Kashmir, a complicated relationship with Sheikh Muhammad Abdullah, the 'Lion of Kashmir' and leader of the National Conference, may have clouded his judgment. Even more credible is the explanation that Nehru favored a settlement where the international community would endorse India's position. Convinced that the UN would support India's case he later confessed to feeling shocked that 'power politics and not ethics' were guiding the UN's verdict (Guha 2007: 73).

The challenges provided by the Partition and Kashmir emerged from a wider context of unrest, agitation and uncertainty whipped up during the final days of the British Raj, to which Nehru could only react and attempt to resolve. In contrast, the three policies considered below were closely framed, formulated and institutionalized under his guidance and approval. The Planning Commission established in 1950, the Panchasheela Agreement signed in 1954, and the four bills in 1955 and 1956 comprising the Hindu Code, act as an entry point into the larger issues of economic/industrial policy, foreign policy and social reform, respectively. Each serves to showcase Nehru's particular contribution and the imprint his choices have left on contemporary Indian politics.

Shedding light on Nehru's legacy

Facing a still uncertain future in 1949 and 1950, Jawaharlal was careful to tone down the socialist rhetoric when launching the Planning Commission in 1950, making sure to establish a broad consensus on the need for planning. This was less of an overwhelming challenge thanks to a gradual leaning towards planning which had taken place in the decade before Independence. In 1938 the Congress National Planning Committee had been constituted with Nehru as its chairman and towards the end of World War II the British Indian government had contemplated

‘planning’ as a measure to cope with post-war reconstruction needs. By 1944 three ‘private plans’ had been proposed by Indian industrialists, leftist leaders and advocates of Gandhi’s ideas about the rural and village economy.

Tracing the origins of planning and the way in which the Planning Commission came about is interesting for two reasons. First, because it reveals that planning was not framed in terms of an ideological choice, but instead justified by paying homage to the welfare and egalitarian goals embodied in the Directive Principles of State Policy in the Constitution of India. The Second Five-Year plan of 1956, on the other hand, carried Nehru’s phrase, the ‘socialist pattern of society’ and planning took on a distinctive political meaning, referring to rapid modernization through heavy industry, self-reliance and checks on the private sector. This shift towards a more ideological stance on economic policy occurred once Nehru’s position within the Congress Party was secured and he surrounded himself with trusted advisors and allies. As a result, Nehru was able to give shape to his vision of steel plants, dams (the temples of modern India as he famously described them) and science. Two major scientific institutions owe their existence to Nehru’s support: the Tata Institute of Fundamental Research and the Atomic Energy Commission in addition to India’s successful engineering schools.

On foreign policy, Nehru quickly sought to establish himself as a grand statesman on the international scene. During the days leading up to Independence, an Asian Relations Conference was held at the end of March 1947, at which 28 countries were represented. While Nehru gave priority to developing an international profile through initiatives such as the 1955 Bandung Conference, within the UN and as a founding member of the Non-Aligned Movement, the greatest challenge to and ultimately failure in India’s national security came from relations with China. Facing an unpredictable and relatively unknown neighbor in the Communist People’s Republic of China (PRC), Nehru seemed to go out of his way to try and please the new regime. Hence, on the issue of membership to the UN he threw his support firmly behind the PRC over the Republic of Taiwan. He refused to condemn the 1950 military ‘liberation’ of Tibet and finally the 1954 Panchasheela Agreement, hailed as a crowning achievement of Indian foreign policy, referred to Tibet as the ‘Tibet Region of China,’ clearly endorsing China’s position. This positive disposition culminated in the visits of Nehru to China in late 1954 and Premier Chou En-lai to India in 1956, epitomizing the *Hindi-Chini bhai bhai* (‘India-China brother brother’) spirit of the times.

A purview of parliamentary debates surrounding Indian foreign policy and particularly relations with China, reveal a remarkable degree of dissension in the early 1950s, with various opinions being voiced about priorities, dangers and strategy. However, from the start Nehru projected his own reading of international politics, rarely taking different opinions in Parliament or in the press into account. As a result, his closest advisors such as K.M. Pannikar (ambassador to Beijing), Krishna V. Menon (defense minister in 1957–62) and Vijayalakshmi Pandi (Nehru’s younger sister and top diplomat) tended to mirror and reinforce his predilections. The run-up to and growing tensions between India and China leading to the disastrous (for India) border war of 1962 can in many ways be attributed to the high-handed foreign policy-making style of Nehru.

In the realm of social and legal reform, the Hindu Code stands out as the most controversial and far-reaching piece of legislation during Nehru’s rule. The codification of law has a long and ambiguous pre-history, used as it was by British administrators to modernize and rationalize an uncivil society but also as an instrument of divide and rule. Personal laws of different religious communities relating to marriage and divorce, inheritance, guardianship were generally untouched, leaving the new Indian government with the dilemma of whether or not to stir the hornet’s nest. On the one hand, Article 44 of the Constitution exhorted the state to secure a uniform civil code throughout India and, at the same time, politicians were unsure to what

extent the state should be seen to interfere in religious matters. In 1951, just before the country's first general elections, Jawaharlal Nehru found himself in just such a catch-22 situation. Initially expressing strong views on the retrograde impact of religion, its inevitable redundancy and the need for a common civil code, Nehru chose to backtrack for fear of a backlash. While this may have been a sensible step given the precarious social and communal relations of the time, it is notable that Nehru continued to advocate codification of *Hindu* personal law without raising the prospect of reforming any other community's personal law.

An assessment

Early observers of Indian politics predicted fragmentation (Harrison 1960), endemic backwardness and inefficiency (Moore 1966), as well as instability due to excessive mobilization coupled with under-institutionalization (Huntington 1968) and an inevitable reversal into dictatorship (quoted in Guha 2007: 325). Nevertheless, despite the odds of multiple languages, religions, ethnicities, illiteracy, poverty and hostile neighbors, India managed to retain its territorial unity (apart from the loss of Aksai Chin) and democracy (apart from a state of Emergency declared in 1975–77). During Nehru's three full terms in elected office (a feat unparalleled in other newly independent countries) numerous shocks to the system were sustained: disputes over territorial accession, a major redrawing of state boundaries along linguistic lines, a tribal insurrection in the northeast and a humiliating defeat in the border war with China. The resilience of the Indian system has to be attributed in part to the fact that Nehru did not seek to undermine central institutions such as elections, Parliament, and the judiciary. However, it is also clear that he derived his authority and legitimacy largely from the impact of his charisma rather than from the two other sources of leadership identified by Max Weber: rational-legal and traditional authority.

Assessing Nehru in terms of policies implemented and their impact on society, politics, the economy and security of the country, the record card seems to have been a mixed one. While industrial production doubled between 1950 and 1960, agriculture suffered; though redistribution was a top priority of the Third Plan, over half the population continued to live in poverty without experiencing much improvement in primary education. It has been suggested that the greatest unfinished business was the failure to reach a negotiated settlement on Kashmir. In 1964 a flurry of events indicated an attempt by Nehru to break the impasse with Pakistan. The sudden release of Sheikh Abdullah who had been incarcerated from 1953 to 1964 (with a brief respite in 1958), talks that were held between Nehru and Abdullah, and finally Abdullah's journey to Pakistan to meet General Ayub Khan. While the full intentions behind the interactions remain unknown, various arrangements and scenarios including that of a confederation between India, Pakistan and Kashmir were raised. Unfortunately, Nehru passed away before Abdullah could return to brief him and according to Guha (2007: 356), Nehru's own papers on the issue remain closed to scholars, leaving plenty of room for speculation.

Upon Nehru's death on May 27, 1964 there was no obvious successor but a search quickly yielded Lal Bahadur Shastri who had been minister of home affairs. Two years later Indira Gandhi was sworn in as prime minister after Shastri's untimely death. Having viewed politics first hand all her life, approving and disapproving of her father's choices, this delayed dynastic transition ensued with the legacy of Nehru both preserved and subverted during the rule of his daughter.

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5

INDIA'S MINORITY LEADERS

Niraja Gopal Jayal

A people who do not share what they regard as the central symbols of the society invariably view themselves as a minority. It is not simply that a community lacks power but rather that the symbols of authority, the values that are propagated from the centre, and the culture that emanates from the centre are viewed as not theirs. To members of a minority community symbol sharing may be no less important than power sharing. Members of a minority community may refer to those of its members holding high office as having been 'co-opted' if they share power without the symbols.

(Weiner 2006: 243)

In India's political discourse, the term minority is generally used to denote religious minorities such as Muslims or Christians. The definition adopted in this essay departs from this usage, and conforms instead to that used by Myron Weiner in an influential article in which he identified four types of minorities in India: linguistic, religious, caste and tribal. As the epigraph suggests, symbolic power lies at the very heart of the practice and display of political power, so that minority leaders who do not share the symbols of authority are found to be as wanting as those who adopt the symbols of the majoritarian center.

India's minority leaders have come to leadership positions and public office in broadly two ways: first, through nomination by majority political leadership, which results in their being criticized as being symbolic at best and legitimizing the politics of dominant groups at worst; and second, through political mobilization and direct appeals to the communities to which they belong and claim to represent. The first route does not entail a representative claim; the second cannot be sustained without such a claim. This necessarily predisposes political and policy outcomes in particular ways. Those who enter by the first route are poster-persons for politics and policies that claim to be inclusive, and so tend to underplay their difference and emphasize unities. They are the individuals who share power without in turn sharing the symbols. A classic example of this would be Dr. Zakir Husain, President of India in 1962–69, who fitted the stereotype of the 'nationalist Muslim,' signifying a Muslim politician who was not a separatist but was committed to a universalist vision of India. At the time, Dr. Husain's appointment was testimony to the secular and plural nature of the Indian republic, and the composite culture that was believed to underlie it. In more fractious and cynical times, the presence of such individuals in positions of importance tends to be viewed as legitimizing not merely the majority, but also underscoring the marginality of the minority group to which they belong and of which they are but token representatives.

On the other hand, for those who enter politics through the second route, the reinforcement of difference and repeated reminders of discrimination or disadvantage are necessary ways of not merely proving their loyalty to their community constituency, but also shaping the self-definition of the community itself. It is expected of such minority leaders that they be seen to provide goods, chiefly symbolic, but sometimes also material. Without the insistence on difference, their own representative claim is rendered vulnerable, and the prospects of getting re-elected or continuing to represent the community cannot be validated. For their claim is centrally a representative claim. Mayawati is a good example of this type of leader, someone who in her time grasped the significance of symbols and of the *performance* of representation (Saward 2006). Other Dalit leaders—such as Ambedkar or Jaggivan Ram—arguably could not make the representative claim in quite the way that Mayawati did. It could also be argued that the first route to leadership results in descriptive representation while the claim to substantive representation is the exclusive prerogative of those who enter politics via the second route.¹ The question that remains intractable is: how should the outcomes of such representation be assessed, and by whom? Are members of the community alone entitled to pronounce on the performance of minority leaders, or are all citizens of a democratic polity qualified to do so?

Let me turn now to a survey of some of India's most important minority leaders over the past decade or so in terms of the conceptual framework I have outlined. Those who entered politics by the first route are India's Prime Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh (prime minister since 2004), and its last two presidents, A.P.J. Abdul Kalam (President of India 2002–07) and the late K.R. Narayanan (President of India 1997–2002). Manmohan Singh is a Sikh, Kalam is a Muslim and Narayanan was a Dalit. All three made a lateral entry into politics. Narayanan and Kalam did so after long service in the government, the former as a career diplomat and the latter as a scientist in the official nuclear defense establishment. Manmohan Singh was a professional economist who had spent some time in academia and rather more in government as economic advisor in the ministries of finance and foreign trade, as deputy chairman of the Planning Commission, governor of the Reserve Bank of India, and Finance Minister, among others.

While Manmohan Singh is the head of India's government, Kalam and Narayanan were heads of state, occupying the largely decorative office of president, with limited powers, rather like a constitutional monarch in the Westminster system. The presidency entails a requirement to be non-partisan, while the prime minister, as the executive head of the government, cannot but be a person firmly grounded in politics. However, Singh has consistently sought to project himself as being remote from, even on occasion above, politics. Keeping a safe distance from party affairs, he has tended to behave like a technocrat at the helm of the state, a statesman rather than a politician.

This is due in no small measure to the circumstances in which he got catapulted into the top executive position. The Congress victory in the general election of 2004 was led by Sonia Gandhi, the president of the party and a Catholic of Italian birth, but the daughter-in-law of the Nehru–Gandhi family and a naturalized Indian citizen. Although there is no legal bar to Gandhi holding any public office in India, she relinquished her legitimate claim to the office of the prime minister anticipating extreme opposition from the Hindu nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), and 'appointed' in her place a trusted aide, Manmohan Singh. Singh was at the time and remains even today a member of the upper house of Parliament. Hence, though he holds the highest executive office, he did not come to it with any backing of popular support from a parliamentary constituency. Though he is the first non-Hindu prime minister India has ever had, he was not appointed on account of his religious identity, much less as a leader of the Sikh community. Of course, a Sikh prime minister is more politically acceptable than one from any other religious minority, and clearly more so than an Italian-born Catholic.

As prime minister, Manmohan Singh's main interest has been in policies relating to economic growth. Nevertheless, he did set up two important commissions to investigate the socio-economic condition of religious minorities. The first of these, headed by Justice Rajinder Sachar, was mandated to enquire into the social, economic, and educational status of Indian Muslims; the second, headed by Justice Ranganath Mishra, studied linguistic and religious minorities in general. The Sachar Report (2006) highlighted the 'development deficit' of Muslims, and made recommendations for more educational and employment opportunities. The Mishra Commission (2007) proposed the institution of a 15% quota for minorities, of which 10% would be reserved for Muslims. A quota for Muslims is currently under discussion both within and without the community, though the Congress government has tended to broadcast mixed signals and may well hedge its bets through a covert or differently packaged introduction of the principle, such as the proposal for Muslims belonging to the other backward castes (OBC) category. The fact that neither of these policy initiatives is associated with any particular leader, much less a leader belonging to the specific group(s) that are favored by them, reinforces the point that minority leaders who are chosen by the majority rather than by the minority community are shy of sponsoring policies designed to promote the interests of their community. Not only are they reluctant to sport their own inherited identities, they are also generally predisposed to underplay difference.

As president, K.R. Narayanan—a sophisticated, intellectually accomplished and politically dependable individual—was not expected to do more than play the constitutionally mandated role of a token presence. Nevertheless, Narayanan surprised those who sponsored his candidature for the presidency by making a sharp comment in a noting on a file sent for his assent to the appointment of four new judges to the Supreme Court. The President observed that 'it would be consonant with constitutional principles and the nation's social objectives if persons belonging to weaker sections of society like SCs [Scheduled Castes] and STs [Scheduled Tribes], who comprise 25 per cent of the population, and women are given due consideration' (*Frontline*, February 12, 1999). This led to the appointment of Justice K.G. Balakrishnan, who eventually became the Chief Justice of the Supreme Court, though his tenure was marked by controversy and tarnished by accusations of corruption. On the whole, Narayanan—who liked to describe himself as 'citizen President'—was a stickler for constitutional propriety and norms.

So was his successor, Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, frequently labeled 'the people's President' for his immense popularity with citizens. Kalam applied his scientific training to constructing a model for sustainable development, called PURA (Providing Urban Amenities to Rural Areas). This became such an obsession with him that every visiting dignitary from the president of Pakistan to the president of the USA was administered a PowerPoint presentation on PURA on a plasma screen (Nair 2008). However, the politics of the timing and context of Kalam's elevation to the presidency are significant. His nomination, in 2002, by the National Democratic Alliance, the ruling coalition led by the BJP, was interpreted as a cynical political attempt to whitewash the bloodstained hands of Narendra Modi's government in Gujarat, and assuage Muslim feelings of anger and vulnerability after the Gujarat riots earlier that year. The BJP's aggressive pro-nuclear strategy also made him a strong candidate. In media interviews, Muslim citizens responded to the appointment by pointing to the symbolic nature of the office (held by two Muslims before Kalam) and the low likelihood, therefore, of his being able to improve the condition of Muslims. They nevertheless hoped that he would stand up for the community should it become the target of violence again.² A university teacher in Delhi commented:

No post should be given or taken on the basis of a person's religion. It will weaken both the Muslim community and Kalam himself. I believe it would have been better

had Kalam stuck to his research ... I do not buy that he will be the voice of Muslims. The Indian Muslims are not rallying behind any Muslim leader now. For no Muslim leader has done anything for them.

(www.rediff.com/news/2002/jul/12spec.htm)

A comment in a leading Muslim newspaper, the *Milli Gazette*, pointed to the fact that both previous Muslim presidents, Zakir Husain and Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed, had been unsuccessful even in their modest initiatives to protect the Urdu language and set up an Urdu Academy. While no positive outcome could therefore be expected of this non-political office, the risk this appointment carried was significant.

Indian Muslims may not be better or worse if Dr. A.P.J. Kalam is elected President of India. However, a risk is there. He may be touted as the ideal Muslim, meeting the norms advertised by RSS [Rashtriya Swayam Sevak Sangh] leaders.

(www.milligazette.com/Archives/01072002/0107200255.htm)

The route through which minority leaders enter politics is thus as important as the public office they hold. If the presidency has little potential as a launching pad for ameliorative or even protective policies for minorities, the prime ministerial office under Dr. Manmohan Singh has also proved to be equally lackluster, because Dr. Singh has never projected himself, or indeed been projected by his party colleagues, as a Sikh leader. The symbolic leadership of the communities to which these individuals belong is not theirs to begin with, and it is only in rare situations that they choose to affect it, for the most part sticking to a non-identitarian path, emphasizing sameness rather than difference and definitely eschewing any representative claim.

It is, on the other hand, the representative claim that is central to leaders like Mayawati, whose political trajectory took the second route identified at the beginning of this essay. Chief Minister of India's largest state, Uttar Pradesh (UP) from 2007–12, Mayawati headed the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) and is the acknowledged political leader of Dalits, at least in northern India. The nomenclature of the party—*bahujan samaj*, literally the society of *the many*, defined as encompassing the Dalits, the OBCs and the minorities—expresses its claim to represent 85% of the Indian people, variously disadvantaged by their caste status or their religious identity. Implicit in the name of the party is the idea that it is the majority—albeit a collection of ascriptively defined minorities—that is marginalized from the mainstream of Indian society, and Mayawati's early rhetoric promised a political agenda that would be inclusive in the representation of its interests. Over time, this evolved into an agenda for the *sarvajana samaj* (literally, the society of *all* people). The political instrumentality of this approach needs little comment for winning elections required Mayawati to appeal to a constituency broader than the Dalits, who provide a reliable but not numerically invincible foundation for guaranteed electoral success.

On her home turf of Uttar Pradesh, Mayawati, however, made little headway with the OBCs, who populate the pocket boroughs of Mulayam Singh Yadav and his Samajwadi Party. Indeed, there is a fundamental contradiction here, as the source of the oppression experienced by the Dalits in the countryside emanates from the OBCs rather than from upper castes like Brahmins. In both class and caste terms, it is the ritually proximate OBC groups that are viewed as the immediate tormentors of Dalits, and even Dalit intellectuals have long argued that the Shudras (OBCs) merely use Dalits to acquire power, and having done so, behave like the Brahmins themselves, treating Dalits as their subjects (Prasad 2001). This may explain Mayawati's attempts, in later years, to reach out to the upper castes for political support. This is a small constituency but in a scenario where political parties compete for the favors of disadvantaged

groups, it is one that is perceived as having few takers. From Mayawati's perspective, even as she maintained a firm grip over her core constituency of Dalits, her larger political ambitions forced her to go beyond it. This is a curious paradox for a politician whose original success depended upon her representation of the community, but whose quest for greater glory, such as a national leadership role, will necessarily led her to search for a broader support base, which could even risked compromising the core constituency.

Though the strategy of broad-basing her political appeal may thus have appeared instrumentally necessary for Mayawati, there is some irony in the fact that the very detractors who accuse her of such instrumentalism are wont to simultaneously accuse her of a sectarian political agenda and an exclusive focus on Dalit welfare. For, notwithstanding her attempt to appeal to non-Dalit groups, Mayawati is perceived by Dalits and non-Dalits alike as a quintessentially Dalit leader. Her policies have invariably targeted Dalit pride, especially the aspect of symbolic power sharing that Weiner emphasized. As Badri Narayan's recent study of Dalits in a village near Allahabad shows, they want her to be prime minister so that 'the *value of Dalits* in India would increase manifold. Moreover, Dalits *would be the subject of greater concern* as a result of her appointment' (Narayan 2011: 98, emphasis in original). However, while political power is indispensable to the achievement of Dalit aspirations, Narayan shows the discussion moving from the desire for self-respect and recognition to that for developmental goods such scholarships, ration cards, water supply, electricity and residential colonies (ibid.). In the broadest terms, Mayawati's developmental policies—such as the Ambedkar Village scheme³—have indeed been explicitly about Dalit welfare. Her demands for quotas kept pace with new trends in the economy. Thus, in addition to her insistence on quotas for Dalits in the private sector, she also experimented with policies of supplier diversity, privileging Dalit suppliers in official procurements. Her commitment to other disadvantaged groups is nominal by contrast. In a letter to the prime minister shortly before leaving office, she sought reservations for poor members of the upper castes, admittedly her only offering to the latter, and one that has been construed as an inducement for the 2012 state election. As for the Muslim minority, the BSP is only one among several parties—including the Congress and the Samajwadi Party—that are currently vying with each other to sponsor quotas for Muslims.

There is a widespread belief that Mayawati's public expenditure on dignity-oriented projects, such as those intended to empower Dalits through the monumentalization of Dalit leaders, has been greater than that on programs of education or health. Most recently, this took the form of comparing her government's expenditure on the 33-acre National Dalit Inspirational Memorial (Rashtriya Dalit Prerna Sthal) in NOIDA near Delhi, allegedly built at a cost of Rupees (Rs.) 685 crore (US\$132 million), with the outlay of Rs.18 crore (\$3.4 million) for tackling the encephalitis epidemic which has claimed the lives of 500 children in the state of Uttar Pradesh. The importance of the Dalit Memorial and what it does for Dalit pride cannot be underestimated or derided. At its inauguration, Mayawati herself drew a comparison with all the memorials of national leaders (the Nehru-Gandhis, in particular) on the other side of the river Yamuna. Memorials may well fulfill a craving for symbolic power, but they evidently need to be supplemented with material aspects of wellbeing to retain her core constituency. Media reports have pointed to some dissatisfaction among Dalits about what Mayawati's tenure as Chief Minister brought them in material terms.

Awadhesh, a 24-year-old Dalit from a village outside Lucknow, says: 'Behenji's emergence to power in 2007 had raised a lot of hope among the Dalit youth that they would now get jobs without discrimination. But what we experienced was discrimination of another kind: those who can pay bribes have a clear edge.'

(Outlook, November 14, 2011)

Even Mayawati's not altogether successful attempt to build a coalition of Dalits and Brahmins in the UP election of 2007 suggested an inattentiveness to the symbolic dimension. As Narayan suggests, while Dalits could be united through a narrative of memories of shared oppression, no such narrative could possibly be constructed for the unity of Brahmins and Dalits. This unity could therefore only be electoral and political, not resonating in the popular imagination of either group in the way that cultural narratives can. Indeed, the gap between the Dalits and the upper castes 'can be bridged only when Dalits enjoy the same living standards as the upper castes—a situation that exists only in the realm of imagination right now' (Narayan 2011: 150).

In Uttar Pradesh, the threats to Mayawati's supremacy as the leader of the Dalits emanated from various sources—the Congress's attempt to recapture its Dalit base, however partially and unsuccessfully; the difficulty of forging a unity between the upper castes and Dalits; and above all, the fragmentation among the Dalits themselves, with many Dalit castes resenting the dominance of the Chamars in the BSP. Each of these emphasizes the significance of the symbolic dimension in the politics of minorities. The only threat that is emphatically non-symbolic is the continuing poverty and lack of development in the state of Uttar Pradesh, including in the designated Ambedkar Villages.

Minority leaders are thus more likely to take their role as representatives of minorities seriously if they have been elected on a minority platform, or see potential electoral gains in appealing to or mobilizing minorities for future elections. If these conditions do not obtain, they are unlikely to attempt more than token minority-friendly policies. In general, the effectiveness of minority leaders in advancing the cause of community constituencies appears to be a function of two interlinked factors: the route to political power and the nature of the public office. In the Indian republic, the ruling party at the central level has considerable clout in the (s)election of the president. Considerations of minority identity do matter in the choice of presidential candidates, if only because the office is not a politically consequential one. Indeed, to the extent such candidates have political power, it is symbolic and helps the ruling party that (s)elects them to establish its sympathy for the group that this individual represents, but very little beyond this. The route to political power is similarly significant. Mass leaders forge and even shape their political constituency, but individuals from particular communities may ascend political heights without any purchase for the community to which they belong.

Finally, however, what are the preferred policy strategies of effective minority leaders? What sorts of initiatives do they advance for the welfare of minorities? It is possible to identify three strategies, and to sequence them historically. The hallmark of the earliest phase, in the decades preceding and following Independence, was tokenism. This was when the tradition was inaugurated of choosing occupants (especially of ceremonial positions) keeping their identity in view. Not every color of the rainbow found representation, however. For instance, it was not until 1994 that P.A. Sangma, a member of the Scheduled Tribes, became the first ever cabinet minister from this group. In any event, the minority leaders who acquire power through nomination as token representatives of their communities tend to favor assimilationist strategies that presume that other individuals from such groups can acquire leadership positions as they have done. This is a perspective that privileges individual rather than collective attainment.

The second phase was one in which minority leaders committed themselves to ever more quotas in public institutions, as a way of delivering what they perceived to be simultaneously symbolic and material goods to members of their constituencies. This trend became particularly marked in the 1990s, with the increasing power of the parties associated with the OBCs, the iconic moment being the acceptance of the Mandal Commission Report's recommendations in 1990. This continues to be a favored strategy even today, as the debate on quotas for Muslims suggests. However, this strategy has reached a plateau with respect to groups that already enjoy

quotas but still matter enough politically for new policies to be necessitated. It is this imperative that makes for the shift, in the third and most recent phase, from reservations to development programs, for the approach adopted by the Sachar Committee Report and for newer initiatives such as supplier diversity. Such developmental initiatives do not, however, entail any attrition of the quota regime, only an additional expansion of the arenas of 'presence.' Not just Mayawati's recent initiatives, but also those of many other parties, reflect such an orientation. What remains to be seen is whether this presages a shift, to use Fraser's categories, from recognition and representation to redistribution (Fraser 2008). Until such time as it does so, India's minority leaders will continue to captivate our attention and to engage and surprise us.

Notes

- 1 Feminist scholarship makes a distinction between the descriptive representation of women (DRW) and their substantive representation (SRW), which is helpful in considering the outcomes of policies, such as quotas, for disadvantaged groups. In feminist debates on representation, there is some consensus that 'judgements needed to be made about the "quality" of SRW, in order to assess the outcomes of SRW' (Mackay 2008: 126). An empirical study of women's representation in 36 countries came to the rather disturbing conclusion that 'descriptive representation is severely limited as an avenue for providing substantive representation' (Weldon 2002: 1171).
- 2 It has generally been assumed that Dr. Kalam is a non-practicing Muslim. However, in a book on Kalam, his private secretary, P.M. Nair, writes that Kalam is in fact 'a devoutly religious man' (Nair 2008: 87).
- 3 This was a program initially inaugurated in 1990 by the Samajwadi Party government of Mulayam Singh Yadav. Mayawati revived it and gave it her own imprimatur. Essentially, Ambedkar Villages were selected on the basis of their Dalit population (ranging from 22% to 30%) for special developmental initiatives in housing, schooling, drinking-water provision and electrification (cf. Bose 2008: 107).

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I.III

Political institutions, state institutions

6

PANCHAYAT RAJ INSTITUTIONS

Rani D. Mullen

In early 1993, the government of India passed two constitutional amendments intended to decentralize political power to elected representatives in urban and rural areas, thereby seeking to mandate them and deepen democracy. Of the two amendments, the 73rd Amendment pertained to rural representative bodies at the sub-state level, known as the *Panchayats*. This amendment mandated a three-tiered structure of local governments and recognized Panchayats as a third level of government after the Center and the State levels. The constitutional amendment envisioned the devolution of powers and responsibilities to the Panchayats in order to ‘enable them to function as institutions of self-government’¹ or local self-rule, known as the Panchayat Raj. The process leading up to the passage of the 73rd Amendment was a lengthy one. Since then, implementation of Panchayat Raj Institutions (PRIs) has been gradual in most regions and the extent of implementation has varied greatly by state. Overall, however, decentralization has led to a rebalancing of state structure from a largely centralized state to an increasingly federal union. PRIs have also led to increased representation of formerly disenfranchised groups such as women, Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs).² Moreover, in those states that have decentralized power for social and economic development to local government institutions, and have done so in an environment of political competition and a socially mobilized society, local government institutions have been able to help further social wellbeing.

Historical background

Panchayat Raj Institutions have had a long history and were a crucial aspect of the discussions on the structure of government in India. Panchayats, literally ‘assembly of five,’ already existed in India during the pre-colonial period. Traditionally they consisted of meetings held by five village elders, usually men of upper-caste background, to regulate and adjudicate village affairs. Despite a brief respite where the British colonisers attempted to eliminate the Panchayat Raj, these informal Panchayats gained institutional recognition. During the later period of colonial rule, Mahatma Gandhi’s Independence movement built upon the idea of self-governing village Panchayats as the building block for an independent India. After attaining Independence, the federal system of government in India evolved from a de facto centralized system of government at Independence to an increasingly decentralized one with the ratification of the 73rd Constitutional Amendment.

At Independence in 1947, individual states formed the Union of India and the 1949 constitution established the government of India as a *federal union* of what are now 28 states and seven union territories. However, in reality the federal structure of government was only 'quasi-federal.' The structure reflected tensions in the constitutional debates on whether political power should be decentralized and villages empowered, as envisioned by Mahatma Gandhi, or whether the requirements of a newly independent country and the need to modernize and foster development by the state required a centralized government.³ In the end, the majority view on the necessity of a federal structure with a strong center prevailed in the constitution though, in a concession to Gandhi, mention of self-governing Panchayats were included in the non-mandatory section of the constitution.⁴ The asymmetric federal structure of the Indian government, with a dominant centralized government that emerged from the constitution, was reflected in the powers of the central government with regards to several states, most notably Kashmir. The central government had the ability to dismiss state governments and directly rule states when no party was able to form a government or when there was violent, political unrest in the state.

During the four intervening decades between the writing of the Indian constitution and the 1993 constitutional amendment enshrining decentralization, the rhetoric of promoting decentralization was punctuated by a series of committees set up to further investigate the structures of decentralization in India. In 1956, government recognition that utilization of local government structures was not progressing led the National Development Council to appoint the Balwantrai Mehta Committee. This committee was charged with evaluating the extent to which the national community development programs worked together with decentralized government structures. The committee recommended the organization of 'statutory representative bodies' by all states in India at three sub-state levels: the district, block, and village levels. It also recommended that genuine power and responsibilities be transferred to these institutions of local government, that they be granted adequate resources, and that all rural development programs be channeled through them (Government of India 1957). However, the Balwantrai Mehta Committee's suggestions did not have the power of law. It was left up to individual states to enact legislation to institutionalize and empower local governments. Over the next two years most states passed panchayat legislation and by the early 1960s local governments had been elected in most parts of India. Yet, while most states enacted some form of panchayat legislation, none followed the spirit of the Mehta Committee's recommendation to transfer resources and genuinely empower local governments. Political power remained with the central government.

In 1963 another committee was appointed to investigate how to provide greater financial autonomy to local governments. Yet again the government did not institutionalize the recommendations. Moreover, without attention to elite domination of village politics, local elections turned out local governments that were democratic in name only. As with politics at the national level in India, where the Congress Party ruled with hegemonic powers, the same elites who had traditionally governed India were elected. Furthermore, without any enforcement of local elections by the central government and opposition to decentralization by vested interests ranging from state governments and civil servants to local political party bosses, the subsequent elections were dropped in most states, and local governance structures soon reverted to the previous rule by patriarchal, caste-based elites.

By the early 1970s panchayat elections were virtually defunct in all Indian states, while the one-party rule of the Congress Party under Prime Minister Indira Gandhi appeared to have solidified Congress' hold at the national as well as state level. However, by the mid-1970s the calculus between the states and the federal government started to change. Prime Minister Gandhi's strong-arm tactics, which were aimed at bypassing the old guard-dominated, clientelistic structure of

the Congress Party and directly appealing to voters, started to backfire. The 1975–77 Emergency rule declared by Indira Gandhi resulted in a groundswell of anti-Indira Gandhi and anti-Congress sentiment at the state level and led to the first national electoral defeat for the Congress Party in 1977 by the Janata Party. The Emergency period not only led to the ousting of the Congress Party at the national level, but also changed the federal bargain between the states and the center. Henceforth, any attempt by the center to consolidate or even expand power at the expense of the states was going to be perceived as illegitimate, setting the path for the growth of political parties as well as legitimacy of decentralization of political powers.

When the Janata Party briefly came to power it sought to establish itself at the national as well as state and local levels. It is likely that it was Janata Dal's need to break the political patronage network that was firmly controlled by the entrenched Congress Party which led to its focus on the decentralization of power. Under the national Janata Dal government the Ashok Mehta Committee was appointed in 1977 to suggest avenues for rekindling the local government structures and thereby elicit greater grassroots participation in development.⁵ The Ashok Mehta Committee Report suggested a two-tiered local government structure, with one sub-national government at the district level and another at the block level below the district. The Committee also suggested linking local governments with development efforts.

Many of the suggestions made by the Ashok Mehta Committee, from representation of lower castes in local government elections (on the basis of their population) and participation of political parties in PRI elections to the devolution of development functions to local governments, would later become institutionalized in the 73rd Amendment. At the end of the 1970s only four states—West Bengal, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, and the state of Jammu and Kashmir—took the Committee's recommendations as a mandate to change their state's laws to strengthen their panchayat system. Moreover, when there was a change in government at the national level in 1979 with the Janata Party losing power back to the Congress Party, central government support for decentralization ebbed again. This shifted the impetus for decentralization onto the individual states. The states, other than Karnataka for a brief period in the late 1980s and West Bengal under Communist Party rule since 1977, had no incentive to give away political power to local governments. The recommendations of the Ashok Mehta Committee languished in Parliament, as those of such committees had before, without serious effort by any political party to institutionalize local governments.

By the late 1980s Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi rekindled central government support for Panchayats, by championing the idea of a constitutional amendment to strengthen local governments. In May 1989 the 64th Amendment Bill, based largely on the Ashok Mehta Committee's recommendations, but also seeking to bypass state governments and establish a direct link between central government and local governments, was introduced to Parliament. While the bill received the required two-thirds majority in the Indian lower house of Parliament, it fell two votes shy of the required numbers in the upper house. At the same time the government of Rajiv Gandhi was defeated in the 1989 elections and a coalition government under the banner of the 'National Front' came to power.

In 1990 the National Front government introduced a revamped 64th Amendment, known later as the 73rd and 74th Amendments, which included urban and rural local governments. This amendment also languished in Parliament, while the National Front focused on trying to keep its coalition government together. The National Front government was short-lived and soon replaced by a Congress Party-led government. Yet despite the inability of the National Front to push adoption of the 74th Amendment through Parliament, both the incoming Congress Party as well as opposition leaders publicly voiced support for legally enshrining elected local governments.

The increased commitment of all political parties in India to political decentralization was a reflection of the changing nature of politics in India by the early 1990s, especially the demise of Congress Party hegemony and the entrance of a variety of new political parties, many with regional, linguistic, identity-, and caste-based constituencies. This democratization of political space at the national level allowed newer parties to seek alliances at the state and sub-national levels to build their political base.

Decentralization presented the perfect vehicle for these newer parties to establish links at the grassroots level and thereby form a more formidable counter to the entrenched and far-reaching Congress Party machinery. For the Congress Party, the greater challenges to its authority, at the national and also the state and sub-national levels, presented by the increasingly crowded field of political parties, necessitated reinvigorating its political base. Decentralization of power to sub-national institutions seemed to present the perfect opportunity for the Congress Party to use its established sub-national party structures to ward off the challenges presented by the increased competition to its political rule.

In the late 1980s and early 1990s, political space at the national level widened. This broadening of political space was reflected in the opening of India's (formerly closed) economy, the gradual shift in the balance of power from the central governments to the states, decentralization, and the resulting changes to India's federal system. States attained greater bargaining power through coalition governments, where state-level political parties were increasingly key partners in forming national, political coalitions. This changed the balance between the center and the states to a relationship characterized by growing empowerment of the states. The increasing demand for state autonomy was countered by the significant leverage the central government maintained through the transfer of revenues to states. The relationship between the central government and states was, by the early 1990s, turning center-state relations into a more pluralistic federal system. This opening of political space and rebalancing of federal structures created an environment friendly to political decentralization.

By the early 1990s the political environment at the national level changed to one where newer political parties, as well as the formerly dominant Congress Party, saw support for sub-national political institutions to be in their long-term interest. While earlier decades had seen political parties pay lip-service to decentralization, the entrance of new political parties trying to establish grassroots support as well as a Congress Party which saw decentralization as a path to rebuilding their increasingly threatened dominance of Indian politics changed the overall political landscape in India to one where most parties supported decentralization. The parliamentary support was set for passage of constitutional decentralization culminating with the legal empowerment of PRIs.

The 73rd Constitutional Amendment

With increased support in the Indian Parliament for political decentralization, the Congress-led government introduced two bills seeking constitutional amendments to enshrine rural and urban Panchayats in 1991. In late 1992, both amendments were passed by the Indian Parliament and ratified in early 1993, legally mandating decentralization in rural and municipal areas in India. These constitutional amendments made India one of the most politically decentralized countries in the world.⁶ The years of the legislative branch's reluctance to decentralize political power did not prevent it from formulating a decentralization law that was far-reaching in its implications for participatory democracy and improvements in people's social wellbeing.

The 73rd Constitutional Amendment set the framework for the structure of local government in rural areas and required every state to enact legislation or amend its existing panchayat

laws by April 1994 to conform with the constitution. It also prescribed the delegation of political powers to local governments in rural areas and the holding of local government elections by April 1995. Political powers as well as fiscal transfers were intended to form the package of political decentralization. The wording of the amendment clearly conveyed its intent: local governments were to become institutions of self-government, where the participation of citizens in direct, and representational democracy at the village level would lead to greater citizen involvement in the process of planning for development resulting in greater social justice. Direct citizen participation in the selection of beneficiaries for anti-poverty programs was to root democracy at the village level.

The structure of decentralized government for rural areas set out by the 73rd Amendment was a uniform, three-tiered structure of sub-national governments throughout India's large states and a two-tiered structure in small states. The uniform three-tiered local government structure in all Indian states was to include elected representatives at the district level (the administrative unit right below each Indian state in rural areas), village or gram panchayat level (or a group of villages if so specified by the governor of the respective state), and an intermediate level 'between the village and district levels specified by the Governor of a State by public notification to be the intermediate level.'⁷ All local governments were to have uniform five-year terms throughout India, with direct elections to constitute new Panchayats to be held before the expiry of the five-year term. An independent Election Commission was mandated for each state in order to supervise and direct the electoral process of local government elections.

Of particular note was the 73rd Amendment's defining of the Gram Sabha as constituting all registered voters within the Gram Panchayat. These Gram Sabhas were to meet regularly and were seen as the backbone for providing accountability and citizen feedback in the local government system. By being entrusted with the reviewing of the Gram Panchayat accounts and reports, the Gram Sabha was essentially given an auditing function. Most importantly, Gram Sabha meetings were to identify the village beneficiaries of anti-poverty programs. This also resulted in providing the village assembly electorate tools for holding local governments accountable and enabling the village electorate to play a significant role in participatory democracy that would help direct resources to the villages' indigents.

One of the most path-breaking aspects of India's constitutional decentralization was its mandating of quotas or 'reserved seats' for formerly disenfranchised groups. One-third of all panchayat seats, urban and rural, at all tiers of local government, including the seats for the chairperson of the respective Panchayats, were reserved for women. Furthermore, a percentage of panchayat seats that reflected the percentage of SCs and STs in the local district's population were reserved for SCs and STs, including seats for the chairperson of the Panchayats. Of the seats reserved for the SC/ST population, one-third had to be reserved for SC/ST women. The reserved position of chairperson of the Panchayats was to be rotated among different Panchayats within a district. State legislatures were given the additional powers to reserve further Panchayat seats for vulnerable or 'backward' groups within their state.

Moreover, in 1996, the Panchayat Act was extended to cover the tribal areas of states that had not been covered by the 73rd Amendment. The *Provisions of the Panchayats (Extension to the Scheduled Areas) Act, 1996*, was added to ensure that local government structures would respect the customary law, social, and religious practices, and traditional community-resource management of the respective tribal communities. The Act also defined the duties of the local governments, and the Gram Panchayat in particular, and further emphasized the role of the Gram Sabha as being the key institution through which participatory democracy would be enabled.

The Gram Sabha was given the responsibility of approving all public socioeconomic development programs and projects for their village before they were implemented. Gram Sabhas were

to identify or select the beneficiaries of these development programs. By reiterating that the power to give final approval to social and anti-poverty programs and select beneficiaries for these programs rested not with Gram Panchayat representatives but instead with the village electorate, this Act further clarified that the local village electorate was to play an integral part in the targeting and delivery of public programs aimed at improving social wellbeing.

How are the Panchayat Raj Institutions working?

Political decentralization from the district to the village level was legally mandated by the 73rd Amendment and has been implemented in virtually all of India. In contrast to political decentralization, administrative and fiscal decentralization were not mandated by the 73rd Amendment and have lagged in comparison. Administrative decentralization involves the transfer of responsibility of specified public functions from central governments, ministries, and agencies to the field units of these agencies. The goal is that local civil servants fall under the jurisdiction of local governments but this was only implied by the 73rd Amendment and left to the states' discretion. Subsequent attempts to focus on this aspect of decentralization have been minimal and have been resisted by state legislators as well as civil servants throughout India. A series of World Bank studies commends Indian decentralization overall for being among the top performers in developing countries in terms of political decentralization, though in terms of overall administrative decentralization India is found to perform poorly.⁸

In contrast to the weak focus on administrative decentralization in the 73rd Amendment, the law did suggest avenues for financial decentralization and subsequent measures have tried to deepen it. Article 243I of the Amendment required the setting up of State Finance Commissions within a year of the passage of the 73rd Amendment, and every five years thereafter, in order review the financial allocations to and financial positions of Panchayats. This requirement has been implemented.

Moreover, transfers from central to state government to local government increased in the post-1993 period. As states and local political leaders became more vocal and the participation of political parties more pluralistic, greater demands for sub-national and local resources were met with increased resource flows. Transfer of financial resources from central to state and local governments as a percentage of central government gross domestic product (GDP) were at their highest level ever in 2010 and total revenue of local governments has increased dramatically over the past few years, as highlighted in Figure 6.1. Moreover, the central government has slated to increase further these transfers of funds to local government for the 2010/11–2014/15 period.

Fiscal decentralization in terms of local governments receiving an increased amount of monies at their disposal, in addition to the public programs the overall targeting and management of which is under the purview of the local governments, has occurred over the past two decades in India. Yet resource mobilization by local governments continues to be limited and many decisions on allocations of funds today remain within the purview of the district and state governments. Moreover, the increased monies to local bodies are largely earmarked for a particular activity or constituency, with Gram Panchayats having little autonomy over this increased flow of money.

With an increase in resources flowing to local governments yet little autonomy of local governments over these resources, the Indian government made attempts to ensure that Gram Panchayats and Gram Sabhas in particular played a greater role in the management of these resources. The central government also increased incentives to state governments to deepen decentralization. In addition to leveraging the discretionary resources of the central government and publicizing the ranking of states by a measure of their attempts to decentralize, the central

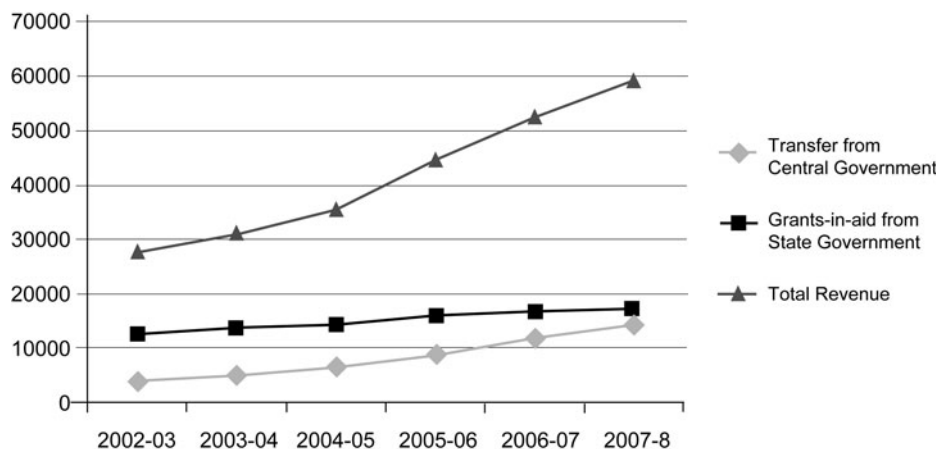


Figure 6.1 Financial transfers to local governments, 2002–08
Source: (Finance Commission of India 2010)

government turned to publishing available information on the degree of state compliance with the legal mandate of fiscal decentralization.

Yet by 2010 states varied greatly in their speed of delegating resources and transferring specific tasks to Panchayat-level functionaries, with very few states following the spirit of the 73rd Amendment by not delegating responsibility and funding to the village Panchayats. Fiscal decentralization entails not only expenditures and transfers, but also revenue decentralization. In this area there has been little progress in delegating powers and responsibilities to local governments and the actual revenues raised by local governments remain negligible. Gram Panchayats are constrained by their legally narrow revenue base and are rarely willing to impose taxes.

Any final assessment of India's Panchayat Raj Institutions, however, has to be measured against the law and its intentions. The political powers entrusted to village governments by the 73rd Amendment and the quotas detailed to ensure the participation of disadvantaged groups represented a decisive attempt at building local democracy and social engineering. Prior to the passage of the 1993 Amendment, the election of local governments had been at the discretion of the individual state governments. This meant that with a few exceptions, local government elections had not taken place for several decades. Moreover, rural development was managed by state government-appointed officials and civil servants charged with implementing rural development and anti-poverty programs. Political and administrative power, oversight, and accountability rested at the district or state level. Before implementation of the PRIs there was also no institutional mechanism for citizens of a village to communicate with the government or to have any mechanism for holding accountable the civil servants who delivered the rural development programs to a village.

The passing of the 73rd Amendment changed this, shifting some of the political locus of power to the sub-state level by urging states to devolve powers and responsibilities for 'the implementation of schemes for economic development and social justice'⁹ to local governments. In theory it provided village residents with a direct role in managing rural development programs, by devolving the list of 29 subject areas to the village Panchayats. These subjects ranged from implementation of poverty and social welfare programs to the delivery of education and health services, land reforms, and physical infrastructure. The transfer of responsibility to local governments in India

was significant because the central government had an extensive anti-poverty program in place for several decades, yet the efficiency and effectiveness of the delivery of these programs had been low. The 1993 Act was a conscious move by the legislators to anchor at the village level a wide range of central government-funded programs aimed at rural development.

Since compliance with the 73rd Amendment, at least three rounds of panchayat elections have taken place in all states and mandatory aspects of the law such as reservations for SCs/STs as well as women have been respected. However, the implementation of not only the mandatory aspects, but also the spirit of the law is decidedly mixed. As of 2010, states like Bihar, Punjab, Gujarat, and Goa had not yet transferred responsibility for most of the 29 areas related to rural development to Panchayats, while other states like Karnataka and Kerala have been at the forefront of decentralization by going beyond the measures required by law.

The impact of political decentralization and empowerment of women and SCs/STs has varied widely. Women and SCs/STs are getting elected to village governments in larger numbers than ever before, and in some cases in larger numbers than their mandatory quotas. While there continues to be cases of women and also SCs/STs who are representatives in name only, with men and/or upper-caste members dominating local governments,¹⁰ some studies have also found that both women and SC heads of Gram Panchayats are more likely to make decisions that benefit women and the SC population.¹¹ Moreover, some studies are documenting that having female local government representatives can have other positive benefits. For example, a recent study of Gram Panchayats in different Indian states found that an increase in female representation in local governments led to an increase in reporting of crimes against women, due to the increased proximity of political representatives who are women.¹² These findings underscore the important potential social implications of the 73rd Amendment, where the attempt at instituting quotas in order to provide access to representation and political power for constituents generally disenfranchised in the Indian political system, is bearing fruit. Though the reservations for women and SCs/STs might only be enabling conditions for the larger project of empowerment and outcomes might not be uniform, guaranteed or immediate, these initial studies nevertheless point to the ability of reservations to increase the social impact of the Indian local government system.

Have Panchayat Raj Institutions in India mattered for democracy and social wellbeing? Here again the evidence is mixed. Decentralization has not by itself changed the performance or impact of local governments. In many villages in states such as Uttar Pradesh, where social cleavages dominate and social awareness and mobilization remains low, decentralization has provided new opportunities for local elite capture of local government resources and powers. In such cases, decentralization is highjacked, undermining its very impetus. In other states such as West Bengal, Kerala, and Karnataka, caste and socioeconomic cleavages are less dominant and the citizenry more mobilized to organize labor and demand their rights. Moreover, some non-governmental organizations, such as the Right to Information Campaign, have helped spread awareness of rights and have therefore improved local government accountability. However, in the case of West Bengal, social mobilization is counteracted by the lack of political competition, which has enabled capture of Panchayats by members of the dominant political party, thereby also decreasing their efficacy to root democracy and target social programs to those most in need. In Karnataka and Kerala, at the forefront of decentralization, where social cleavages are low and social mobilization and awareness high, and where there is political competition, the institutionalization of Panchayats has enabled a rooting of democratic structures and more targeted delivery of social development programs and services. Recent research¹³ points out that democratic empowerment of groups traditionally excluded from local political power in India can lead to Gram Panchayats acting as agents of change and undermining traditional hierarchies of power.

A state's history of decentralization, political competition, local elite buy-in and social mobilization are key ingredients in determining the ability of village governments to deepen democracy and impact their citizens' wellbeing. Different combinations of these key ingredients have led to varying degrees of democratic rooting and efficacy of local governments in implementing the centrally mandated decentralization to Panchayat Raj Institutions. Emerging field studies are highlighting the state-level constraints to full implementation of the 73rd Amendment. These state-level findings should enable fine-tuning of public policies to increase the efficacy of local governments in India and thereby help further to root democracy.

Acknowledgement

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Notes

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- 3 Government of India (November 25, 1949). Constituent Assembly Debates, XI: 11.
- 4 Article 40 in Part IV of the Indian constitution states: 'The state should organise village panchayats and endow them with such power and authority as may be necessary to enable them to function as units of self-government.' The Constitution of India, lawmin.nic.in/coi/coiason29july08.pdf (accessed January 10, 2010).
- 5 Singh 1994.
- 6 The World Bank (2004).
- 7 Government of India (1993).
- 8 The World Bank (2000).
- 9 Government of India (1993).
- 10 See in particular the chapter on Uttar Pradesh in Mullen (2011).
- 11 Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2004).
- 12 Iyer *et al.* (2012).
- 13 See in particular: Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2004); and Mullen (2011).

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7

THE CHANGING FORTUNES OF THE BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

Amrita Basu

The rise of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), from its origins in the relatively small and marginal Jan Sangh, to one of the two major national parties and ruling party (1999–2004), is one of the most important developments in Indian politics in the past quarter century.¹ The BJP played a more important role than any other political party in challenging Congress dominance and bringing about the creation of a multi-party system. It did so in part by forming alliances with, and thereby strengthening regional parties, and drawing on a cross class and caste base of support. However, the BJP's relationship to democracy has been double edged. While it has deepened democracy in some respects, it has also undermined it through its explicit commitment to Hindu majoritarianism, its periodic engagement in anti-minority violence, and its close ties to non-elected, undemocratic civil society organizations.

The BJP's defeat in two successive national elections (2004, 2009) raises questions about the BJP's national strength and demonstrates its vexed relationship to Hindu nationalism. Although the Election Commission designates the BJP a national party, it is weak in several states that command a large number of parliamentary seats. The 2009 elections in which key state parties left the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) demonstrated the fragility and importance of these alliances. Prior to the 2009 elections, the BJP recommitted itself to Hindu nationalist goals, including constructing a temple in Ayodhya, stepping up anti-terrorist activities and deporting Bangladeshi terrorists. It thereby sought to placate the Rashtriya Swayam Sevak Sangh (RSS) and its affiliates (who designate themselves as the Sangh Parivar or the RSS family). Although these issues were electorally unpopular, the RSS pressured the BJP to further demonstrate its Hindu nationalist commitments in the aftermath of its defeat. The BJP's relationship to the RSS will be a key determinant of its future prospects.

The Jan Sangh

The BJP's predecessor, the Jan Sangh, formed in 1951, was virtually unique among political parties in its commitments to Hindu majoritarianism, deregulation of the economy, expansionist foreign policy and a unitary state. Unable to challenge the Nehruvian consensus, it performed poorly in the first three general elections: its share of the vote was 3.1% in 1952, 5.9% in 1957, and 6.4% in 1962.

Congress Party factionalism and corruption following Nehru's death in 1964 and Indira Gandhi's rise to power contributed to the Jan Sangh's growth. It won 9.4% of the vote in the 1967 parliamentary elections and formed coalition governments with the Samyukta Socialist Party and Swatantra Party in Bihar, Rajasthan Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, Punjab, and Uttar Pradesh (UP). Jan Sangh members also acquired important roles in the state governments of Haryana, Orissa and UP.

The Jan Sangh, and its affiliated student group organized agitations against inflation and the scarcity of commodities in Gujarat and Bihar in 1974–75. It participated in a powerful mass movement that the Gandhian Socialist leader, J.P. Narayan, led against corrupt practices of Congress state governments. It thereby gained the support of middle-class students and consumers and middle- and lower-caste farmers. The Jan Sangh joined other opposition parties, in the Janata Front, which contested the 1977 general elections. It became an important constituent of the Janata government (1977–80).

The emergence and rise of the BJP

The Jan Sangh split from the Janata Party when it prohibited Jan Sangh members from participating in the RSS in March 1980. Some 3,500 people, including 15 of 28 Janata MPs, split and formed the BJP on April 5, 1980. In its early years the BJP subscribed to integral humanism and Gandhian socialism and neglected Hindu nationalism. In the 1984 general election, Congress gained the Hindu vote: the BJP won only two seats in Parliament and 7% of the national vote; it was decimated in the Hindi-speaking belt.

In the aftermath of that electoral debacle, many rank and file members pressed the BJP to play an activist role. In a major reorientation in 1986, it supported the abrogation of Article 370 of the constitution, providing autonomy to Kashmir, and the passage of a uniform civil code. L.K. Advani, who became party president, identified with Hindu nationalist goals.

The Janata Dal (successor to the Janata Party), primarily represented the interests of farmers and the lower castes and subscribed to socialist principles but needed the BJP's support to win the 1989 elections. It did not nominate candidates to contest the BJP in most constituencies. The BJP decided to support the Janata Dal while engaging in militant Hindu nationalist activities. With 85 seats and 11.5% of the vote, its performance improved significantly. The February 1990 Legislative Assembly elections brought the BJP to power in Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, and in a Janata Dal-led coalition in Gujarat.

The Janata Dal was the major victor in 1989 but lacking a majority, unconditionally accepted the BJP's support. With reinvigorated commitment to the Hindu cultural nationalism (*Hindutva*) agenda, the BJP took a hard line on Kashmir, pushing the government to squelch Kashmiri demands for greater autonomy. However, tensions soon emerged between the National Front government led by V.P. Singh and the BJP. Partly to counteract the BJP's mobilization of Hindus, V.P. Singh decided to implement the recommendations of the Mandal Commission and provide reservations for the so called other backward castes (OBCs). The BJP retaliated by mobilizing a massive campaign in Ayodhya (described further below). The National Front government collapsed when the BJP withdrew its support in October 1990.

On December 6, 1992, with the support of its own government in Uttar Pradesh, the BJP participated in an even more massive campaign which destroyed the mosque in Ayodhya. Over a thousand people were killed in the violence that followed. The ruling Congress Party dismissed BJP state-governments and ordered the arrest of its major leaders. The 1993 elections reflected public disapproval of the BJP's militancy. Significantly, the party's losses were greatest in Madhya Pradesh followed by Uttar Pradesh, where its posture was most militant and riots were

most numerous. The BJP was only elected in two states in the 1994 and 1995 Assembly elections

The BJP reversed course. It affirmed its commitment to a secular state and downplayed the need for a temple in Ayodhya. It sought to broaden its caste constituency and form coalitions with state parties. In the 1996 general elections, the BJP gained a plurality of parliamentary seats (29.6%) but won only 20.3% of the popular vote. The national government it formed in May 1996 was unable to survive a vote of confidence.

Prior to its electoral victory in March 1998, the BJP published a national agenda which dropped the issues of the temple, the uniform civil code and Kashmir's special constitutional status and focused instead on nuclear policy, foreign investments, and a review of the constitution. The BJP captured 179 seats (25.5% of the votes) in the 1998 general elections. It forged alliances with state parties. However, the government collapsed because it was unable to secure a parliamentary majority.

By the 1999 general elections, the BJP was even more committed to depicting itself as a moderate, centrist party. Vajpayee placed a moratorium on such contentious issues as the Ram temple, abolishing Article 370 of the Constitution, and the uniform civil code. The NDA briefly took office (March–April 1999), followed by a full term (October 1999–January 2004). With the support of coalition partners and 23.8% of the vote (339 seats), the BJP was the dominant party in the coalition.

The BJP and the Sangh Parivar

Among Indian political parties, the BJP has two great strengths: an ideologically committed and cohesive organization; and close ties to equally powerful and even more dedicated Hindu nationalist organizations, led by the RSS.

The RSS has been devoted, since its creation in 1925, to *Hindutva*, the crafting of a shared religio-nationalist identity. It equates Indian nationalism with the interest of the Hindu majority and considers Christian and Muslim minorities and the state's protection of their rights, threats to the Hindu majority. RSS *shakhas* or branches, engage small groups of men in studying and propagating its principles. The RSS created the Visva Hindu Parishad (VHP) in 1964 as its religious wing. The VHP has engaged in religious conversions, campaigns to construct temples on the sites of mosques, and social service activities among Hindus.

Until the early 1990s the Jan Sangh and later the BJP achieved their most significant electoral gains by participating in militant Hindu nationalist activities (1967, 1977, and 1989). Following the Jan Sangh's prolonged agitation for a state ban on cow slaughter, its share of the vote increased from 4% in 1957, to 6% in 1962 and 9% in 1967. It paid for moderating its stance in the 1971 elections, when it received only 7% of the vote, and 1984, when it received just 6.4% of the vote. By 1989, at the start of the Ayodhya campaign, the BJP's share of the national vote increased to 11.4% and by the 1991 elections, when the campaign was in full flower, 20.1%.

The BJP forged close ties to the VHP in the late 1980s by supporting its campaign in Ayodhya. The VHP claimed that the sixteenth-century Muslim ruler Babar had destroyed a temple that commemorated the birth place of Ram and constructed a mosque in its place. The campaign assumed the form of a mass movement that generated violence against Muslims in many parts of north India. With the VHP's support, BJP leader L. K. Advani organized a procession from Somnath, Gujarat to Ayodhya, UP in October 1990 which triggered riots in many regions. In December 1992 they organized a much larger campaign which culminated in 200,000 activists converging on Ayodhya and destroying the mosque. The Ayodhya campaign identified Hindu pride and self-assertion with antipathy towards Muslims and polarized Hindu-Muslim relations.

In supporting the VHP's campaign around the temple in Ayodhya, the BJP attended to the profoundly important realm of social and cultural life which most parties tend to ignore. Through its ties to the VHP, the BJP claimed to speak from a domain of moral values rather than from the self-interested world of electoral politics. In UP in the early 1990s, the BJP short circuited the long, slow, hard work of party building by hitching its fortunes to the VHP. The BJP also benefited financially from the VHP fundraising in India and overseas.

However, the BJP's relations with the RSS and VHP have often been fraught. The VHP is a non-elected body that disdains procedural democracy and repeatedly states that it will not accept court judgments on matters of religious faith. The BJP's close connections to the VHP and thus to militant Hindu nationalist ideals have sometimes proved costly at the polls and in its relations with coalition partners.

With the formation of the NDA government, the BJP's relations with the RSS and VHP deteriorated. Hindutva activists charged that the BJP had abdicated its ideological commitments. The RSS and VHP attributed the BJP's reversals in Legislative Assembly elections in 2001 and 2002 to the BJP's backtracking on Ayodhya and demanded that the government clear the legal obstacles to building the Ram temple. The RSS issued guidelines to the BJP on how it should function, called for regular meetings with senior BJP members and demanded the right to veto government policy decisions.

BJP structure

The BJP defies familiar models of political parties. It is not simply a catch-all party, for its leadership and constituency are largely drawn from upper-caste Hindus in north India. It has failed to capture Muslim support and only captured significant tribal and Dalit support in six states. It has grown primarily by allying with regional and caste parties. The BJP has been termed a cadre-based organization, with some justification, for a core of committed leaders exercise inordinate power over a centralized organization. It also aptly characterizes the high level of ideological commitment expected from active members. However, 'cadre party' does not capture the complexity of the BJP's organization.

Following its 1984 electoral setbacks, the BJP decided that it should reconstitute itself as a 'cadre-based mass party.' While remaining highly centralized, it created *morchas* or cells to mobilize peasants, workers, tribals and other groups. It also began organizing training camps to strengthen cadres' ideological commitments and organizational abilities. See Figure 7.1 for the organizational structure of the party.

The BJP in power

The BJP has regularly occupied office in several states since 1990 and had a more uneven trajectory in others.² Variations in the BJP's electoral success across federal states are determined by multiple factors. Although national trends play some role, regional determinants are more significant. Strong ethnic and caste parties, which differ across federal states, may either ally with or contest the BJP at different points in time. The BJP is more reliant on the support of the RSS and VHP in some states than in others and the extent to which it receives this support has varied. In states like Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh and Rajasthan, which have developed two-party systems, the BJP's electoral prospects are influenced by whether or not it is the incumbent party.

The BJP-led NDA government to some extent moderated its stance and assumed a centrist posture in response to pressures from coalition partners, the international community and the centrifugal pressures of democracy. It demonstrated greater moderation and flexibility in its

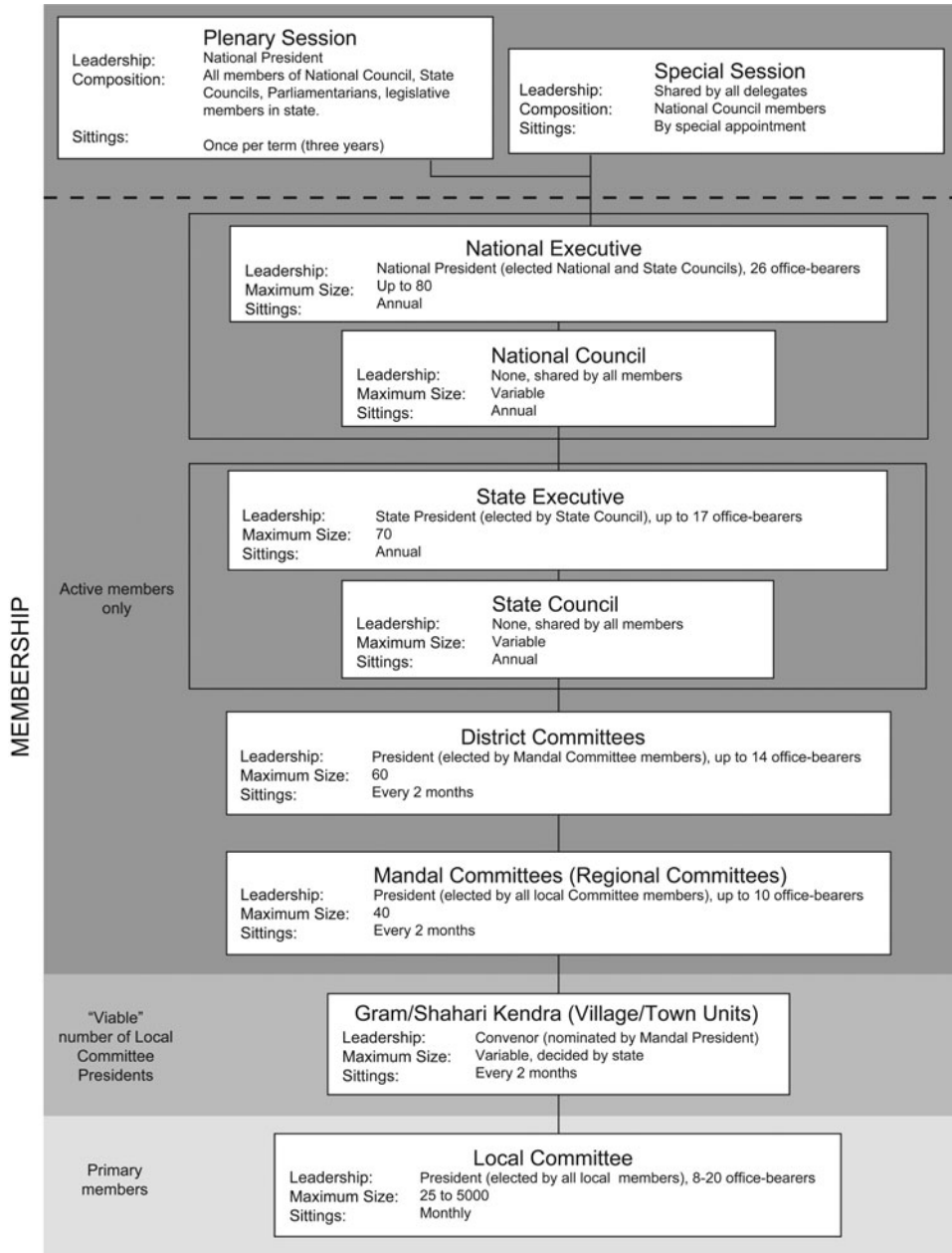


Figure 7.1 BJP organizational structure

economic and foreign policies than in its treatment of minorities. The BJP has been more centrist in office at the national than at the state level though the NDA government never prevented BJP state governments from pursuing anti-minority policies. This was demonstrated in extreme fashion when the BJP government in Gujarat orchestrated a campaign of violence against Muslims which resulted in 2,000 deaths in February–March 2002. The national party did nothing to stop the violence or to sanction the Gujarat government.

The BJP has collaborated closely with the RSS and VHP in pursuing Hindu nationalist goals in states it governs. Two of the most important, banning cow slaughter and religious conversion, are described below.

Banning cow slaughter

BJP state governments that took office from the early 1990s on introduced stringent legislation banning (sometimes partially) cow slaughter and the sale of beef. The Delhi government introduced a bill banning cow slaughter in 1994. Rajasthan banned the slaughter of all bovine species the following year. In 2003 BJP governments and coalition governments in Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat and UP instituted far-reaching legislation against cow slaughter. Following VHP-sponsored protests, the Jharkhand Assembly passed a Cow Protection Commission Bill in 2005 which made the killing of, cruelty to and smuggling of cows a crime. Uttarkhand and Karnataka followed suit in 2007 and 2010, respectively.

The BJP claimed that this legislation would make more milk available, curtail cruelty to cows and, above all, signal the sanctity of cows to Hindus. Although most states had already adopted legislation along these lines, the new legislation increased the state's authority to engage in surveillance and punishment. In Delhi, for instance, authorities were empowered to enter, search and seize property including cattle from people's homes, businesses and vehicles, while placing the burden on the accused to prove that confiscated meat was not beef.

These measures, along with hefty fines, deny poor Muslim and Dalit families affordable meat and income from leather-related trades. They generate suspicion that Muslims are engaging in anti-Hindu, criminal activities. Not surprisingly, the VHP and its youth wing, the Bajrang Dal, have engaged in violence against Muslims whom they suspect of slaughtering cows.

Religious conversions

BJP state governments introduced anti-conversions laws that toughened legislation that the Jan Sangh has passed in the 1960s. The proposed laws sought to discourage conversion out of Hinduism while encouraging conversion into it by deeming it 'reconversion.' The Rajasthan Bill, for example, stipulated that returning to the forefathers' original religion or to one's own original religion would not be deemed conversion.

Anti-conversion campaigns depict Christian missionaries as powerful and coercive foreigners. The laws in Tamil Nadu, Gujarat and Rajasthan impose the stiffest penalties on those who convert Dalits, women and tribals, thereby treating them like gullible, passive victims who must be saved by powerful Hindutva activists.

The laws increased the state's authority to engage in surveillance and punishment while undermining individuals' abilities to choose freely their religious identities. The laws passed in Gujarat in 2003 and introduced in Chhattisgarh, Himachal Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh in 2006 made conversions that were deemed to have entailed force or allurement non-bailable and cognizable. They harshly penalized those who violated the law. The new laws also allowed district magistrates to appoint any agency they wished to determine whether conversions entailed force or coercion. They required individuals to inform the district magistrate about their intention to convert (in Gujarat a month before the conversion, and in Madhya Pradesh and Himachal Pradesh within a specified time afterwards). Narendra Modi's government in Gujarat went even further with a 2006 amendment which deemed that Jains and Buddhists were Hindus.

Ultimately the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government blocked passage of several of the proposed amendments—in Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan. Tamil Nadu passed the

Bill in 2002 when the BJP participated in a coalition government but repealed it two years later after the BJP lost the national elections. However, the BJP and its affiliates engaged in large-scale conversion activity during the years between the introduction and defeat of bills in Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh.

Economic policy

On matters of economic reform, there are striking differences in the stance of the BJP before and after it attained national office and between the RSS and the BJP. The economic policies of the Jan Sangh and later the BJP as opposition parties were shaped by two forces. One was electoral considerations and the other was compliance with the RSS which was committed to *swadeshi* (self-reliance), in keeping with its nationalist commitments. After attaining national power, the BJP was less beholden to the RSS and more anxious to secure support from the Indian middle class, non-resident Indians (NRIs), and global corporations and financial institutions.

The Jan Sangh was deeply critical of state restrictions on foreign and private capital in Nehruvian India. It moderated its criticisms of Congress in the early 1970s because of the popularity of Indira Gandhi's anti-poverty programs. As the Congress government came to support economic liberalization, the BJP became a proponent of *swadeshi*. Until 1998 it opposed external liberalization (large influxes of foreign capital and control of Indian companies), while supporting internal reforms to make the Indian economy stronger. The BJP participated in several RSS campaigns against multinational corporations.

After achieving national power, the BJP reversed its earlier stance. It claimed that *swadeshi* had to be redefined in light of India's changing place in the global economy. It sought to fulfill its commitments to the World Trade Organization (WTO) by phasing out quantitative restrictions on imports, including consumer goods, and reversed its previous policy of protecting small-scale domestic producers. It authorized the sale of public-sector units to private industrialists and passed a bill allowing product patents. It allowed foreign companies to invest up to 40% in the insurance sector. It allowed foreign direct investment in a number of industries including liquor and tobacco. Several BJP state governments energetically embraced globalization. Chief minister Narendra Modi thereby gained enormous dividends from diaspora and entrepreneurial Gujarati communities.

The RSS and its affiliates—the Bharatiya Kisan Sangh, a farmers' organization, the Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh, a workers' organization, and most importantly the Swadeshi Jagran Manch, Front for the Awakening of Mass Nationalism—vigorously opposed NDA government policies. They denounced the Vajpayee government and organized protests across the country urging the BJP government to scale back economic reforms.

However, RSS opposition did not deter the NDA government. The global economic and political climate made commitment to *swadeshi* seem obsolete. Furthermore the *swadeshi* campaign had never attracted mass support. Thus the BJP could placate the RSS by pursuing policies that appealed to Hindus (cow protection, religious conversions and temple construction) while rejecting its stance on globalization.

Foreign policy

The BJP's positions on foreign policy reflect both the influence of the RSS, which is committed to assertive, expansionist nationalism, and its own pragmatic interests in improving relations with Pakistan and strengthening its ties to the USA. As with economic policy, the BJP's foreign policies have differed when it has been in power and in opposition. However, the BJP has made

more concessions to the RSS in foreign than in economic policy because the Indian middle classes favor India playing a more assertive role in the global arena.

The BJP and the Jan Sangh opposed Nehru's commitment to non-alignment, disarmament and improved relations with Pakistan and supported fortifying the military and regaining control over Kashmir. The BJP demonstrated its willingness to stand up to the USA by refusing to sign the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) and the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty (CTBT) and testing a nuclear device on May 11, 1998.

The BJP also mobilized nationalist support following Pakistan's infiltration beyond the line of control, leading to India's military victory in the 1999 Kargil war. The RSS and some BJP leaders favored military action against Pakistan in the aftermath of a series of terrorist attacks on the Jammu and Kashmir Legislative Assembly in October 1999, an airline hijacking in December 1999 and especially after the attack on the Indian Parliament in December 2001. Although the NDA government did not go to war, it engaged in a massive troop build-up along the Pakistani border and announced a policy of 'hot pursuit' of terrorists in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir.

There are important differences between the RSS and segments of the BJP in the sphere of foreign policy, as with economic policy. Following the nuclear tests, which drew global condemnation, the NDA government declared a moratorium on further nuclear testing and stringent controls on the export of nuclear and missile technology. Prime Minister Vajpayee traveled by bus to meet with Pakistan's president Nawaz Sharif in 1999 and the two countries engaged in diplomatic negotiations in 2001. These two faces of the BJP reflect the differences between the ideologically driven positions of the RSS and the pragmatic considerations of the governing party. The BJP has sought to reconcile its patriotism with its desire to sustain the support of NRIs and maintain closer relations with the USA.

The BJP returns to the opposition

The BJP suffered two consecutive defeats, in the 2004 and 2009 general elections. The Congress-led UPA defeated the BJP-led NDA alliance in the 2004 general elections by a wide margin. In 2004 Congress captured 145 seats and 27% of the vote, while the BJP won 138 seats and 25% of the vote. The BJP and the NDA suffered an even more significant defeat in the 2009 elections. The BJP won 116 seats (17.9% of the vote) in contrast to Congress which won 206 seats (27.3% of the vote).

The BJP's 2009 defeat revealed its weaknesses in key federal states including Kerala, West Bengal, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu. It was unable to compensate for the loss of important coalition partners which feared that they would lose minority votes by remaining part of the NDA in the aftermath of the Gujarat pogrom. The BJP did not appreciate the popularity of the UPA government's rural employment guarantee scheme or develop poverty alleviation schemes itself. The BJP's image of a cohesive and disciplined party was tarnished by conflicts among its leaders.

The elections also revealed the lack of popular support for Hindutva. The BJP's 2009 election manifesto promised to explore all possible means of building a temple in Ayodhya. It vowed to 'protect and promote the cow and its progeny.' It took a strong stand on the question of national security, promising within 100 days of achieving power to revive the anti-terrorism mechanisms that the UPA government had dismantled. It promised to launch a massive campaign to detect and deport illegal immigrants, introduce national identity cards and promote the development of nuclear technology. The BJP projected Advani as prime minister and made Narendra Modi, the architect of the Gujarat pogrom, its star campaigner. It refused to concede to the Election Commission's suggestion that it drop Varun Gandhi from its list of candidates following his vitriolic anti-Muslim statements for which he was briefly imprisoned.

(Gandhi, who was already a member of the BJP's national executive committee, was elected to Parliament. The BJP made him its national secretary in March 2010.)

The BJP's defeat in two successive elections triggered a major crisis in the BJP and its relations with the RSS. The RSS delayed announcing its support for the BJP's candidacy in the 2004 elections. Despite BJP pleas, it did not stop the VHP from embarrassing BJP leaders and denouncing Prime Minister Vajpayee. The VHP did not campaign for the BJP or express disappointment at its electoral defeat.

Empowered by the BJP's defeat in 2004, the RSS persuaded the BJP to restructure the party. The BJP National Council amended the party constitution to give key positions to RSS members. Organizing secretaries, who are generally of RSS backgrounds, were made more powerful than state presidents. The National Council also supported the appointment of hardliner Narendra Modi to the BJP's parliamentary board and Vinay Katiyar, VHP leader in the Ram temple movement, as BJP general secretary.

After the BJP's defeat in the 2009 general elections, the RSS further increased its control over the party. It ensured that the BJP enlisted a large number of its members and gave priority to promoting party members of RSS backgrounds. It played a key role in selecting its stalwart Nitin Gadkari as BJP president.

Conclusion

The BJP has described itself aptly as 'not just another party in search of power,' but 'a party with a difference.' In contrast to most political parties which lack a coherent ideology, the BJP has had long-standing and unwavering commitments to Hindu nationalism. Some of the major BJP leaders were Jan Sangh members and most of them belong to the RSS. For all its reversals on economic policies and a centralized state, its positions on minority rights and representation have been remarkably consistent.

Two sometimes conflicting influences have determined the extent to which the BJP has translated its beliefs into practice. First, its powerful ties to the RSS have prevented the BJP from becoming a centrist party. The BJP today is more closely tethered than ever to the RSS and the prospects of it breaking ties with the RSS are remote.

The second concerns the response of the electorate and other parties to Hindu nationalist appeals. The constraints imposed by coalition partners, international actors and other governing institutions have prevented the BJP from adopting militant positions at the national level. Hindutva failed to capture popular support in the last two elections. However, BJP state governments have had greater latitude than the national government to mobilize Hindus in anti-minority violence and implement policies that advance Hindu nationalist goals. They have done so in close association with other constituents of the Sangh Parivar. Thus the regionalization of Indian politics provided the BJP latitude in Gujarat in 2002 (and on a smaller scale in states like Karnataka thereafter), but prevents the BJP from engaging in such militancy in most states. A national party with nationalist appeals and a national agenda, the BJP has had a far-reaching impact on the discourses of Indian politics while constantly battling the structural constraints of Indian democracy.

Notes

- 1 Major works on the Jan Sangh and the BJP include: Bruce D. Graham, *The Challenge of Hindu Nationalism: The Bharatiya Jana Sangh*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990; Partha Ghosh, *BJP and the Evolution of Hindu Nationalism: From Periphery to Centre*, New Delhi: Manohar Books, 1999;

Christophe Jaffrelot, *The Hindu Nationalist Movement in India*, New York: Columbia University Press, 1996; Yogendra K. Malik and V.B. Singh, *Hindu Nationalists in India: The Rise of the Bharatiya Janata Party*, Boulder: Westview Press, 1994; and A.G. Noorani, *The RSS and BJP: A Division of Labour*, Delhi: LeftWord Books, 2000.

- 2 The BJP has occupied office in numerous states (including Himachal Pradesh, UP, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Uttarkhand, Karnataka, Bihar, Punjab, Chattisgarh, Nagaland, Jharkhand and Orissa) independently or in coalition governments.

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8

REGIONAL AND CASTE PARTIES

Suhas Palshikar

For observers and students of Indian politics, the decade of the 1990s may appear as the decade of the ‘regional’ parties. In this decade, regional parties proliferated, occupying a central position in the politics of many states, playing a crucial role in the formation of national government, articulating many hitherto less expressed interests, and generating the hope in some circles that politics in India would be more democratized and take a federal turn as a result of the ascendance of regional parties. The present overview aims at discussing regional parties in this context and making an assessment of their role in contemporary Indian politics. In section one we very briefly touch upon the definitional issues and issues of nomenclature. Then section two reviews the history of regional parties since Independence until they became prominent in politics and academic literature on Indian politics. In the third section we report the performance of the regional parties and the role they have played since the late 1980s. In section four we discuss the complex relationship between caste parties and state-level (regional) parties. In the last section, we turn to explanatory frameworks for understanding the phenomenon and the larger questions involved.

Definitional issues and issues of nomenclature

While there seems to be agreement about the importance of the emergence of regional and caste-based parties, there is some debate over what is driving this phenomenon. Observers and analysts, accustomed to the framework of Congress dominance and ‘alternatives’ to Congress, found the rise of so many competitors to Congress in the post-Indira/Rajiv era somewhat baffling. The implicit question often was/is: why could politics not be more disciplined and tidy? Therefore, journalistic commentators described regional parties as local or regional *satraps*, implying that they were somewhat less legitimate claimants to power, particularly at the national level. Scholarly writings traditionally employed the term ‘regional party’ to denote parties that adopted a ‘regionalist’ stand. As many parties emerged at the state level but did not necessarily employ a regional appeal, the issue of terminology or label became important. Therefore in the post-1989 period, scholars have used the terms regional parties (Palshikar 2003), state parties (Palshikar 2004) or state-based parties (Chhibber and Nooruddin 1999), as also single-state parties (Wallace 1999) interchangeably. The term ‘regional parties’ can be potentially misleading—a region may refer to a territory beyond one state, as in the case of south India or the northeast. It is also misleading because while it refers

to the party that invokes ‘regionalist’ sentiment, many regional parties do not invoke such sentiments as their primary platform. Moreover, in the Indian context, the term region also sometimes refers to regions within a state and thus, a regional party could as well be a party based on intra-state regional sentiment like the Telangana Rashtra Samiti (TRS—a party demanding a separate state for the Telangana region of Andhra Pradesh), or Gorkha parties such as the Akhil Bharatiya Gorkha League (ABGL) and Gorkha National Liberation Front (GNLF), demanding fair treatment/autonomy/liberation for the Darjeeling hill areas of northwest Bengal. On the other hand, it is not exactly convincing to use the terms state party and national party as defined by the Election Commission of India (ECI). The ECI goes by a combination of the seat and vote criteria at the state level and recognizes a party as ‘national’ if that party fulfills the criteria in at least four states (ECI 2000)—this distinction is crucial for parties since a state party gets a symbol reserved for it throughout that state and a national party gets a symbol that is reserved nationwide (thus, for instance, in the 2009 elections there were seven parties recognized by the ECI as national parties and 39 parties recognized as state parties; for details of number of state parties for each election, see Table 8.1). By the definition of ECI, however, many parties with effective political salience in only one or two states may get classified as national parties.¹ For instance, the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) is a ‘national party,’ but students of party politics in India would at best be amused by this classification of the NCP since they know that two different leaders lead this party in two different states (Maharashtra and Meghalaya), and beyond those two states the party has only a nominal existence in most other states. Therefore, if one were studying the NCP, the focus of analysis would be only on the two states. We hope to capture the phenomenon of the rise of parties as players often in only one state, who are confined to that state either by design or by circumstances. Of course, it is true that many ‘state parties’ are not strictly single-state parties; they often try to expand beyond one state (as in the case of the Samajwadi Party—SP). Given this complexity of actual politics, the multiplicity and interchangeability of labels is understandable. Some parties may remain confined to one state only mainly because of their organizational and resource limitations (as for instance the Peasants and Workers Party—PWP—of Maharashtra); some because of the expressly ‘regionalist’

Table 8.1 Number of state and national parties as listed by ECI, 1952–2009

	<i>National</i>	<i>State</i>
1951	14	30
1957	4	11
1962	6	21
1967	7	14
1971	8	17
1977	5	15
1980	6	19
1984	7	17
1989	8	20
1991	9	28
1996	8	30
1998	7	30
1999	7	40
2004	6	36
2009	7	39

Source: ECI reports for years 1951–2004, and for 2009 ECI Notification No.56/2009/PPS-II of March 14, 2009.

position of the party (like the Assam Gan Parishad—AGP); some due to the specificity of political context in which they chose to operate (like the Trinamool Congress of West Bengal which emerged as a strong force opposed to the Left Front of West Bengal); or, finally, some parties remain confined to a state because of the way in which the party defines contours of social cleavages—often in terms of caste or religion (Akali Dal is one such example and we shall discuss below more examples based on caste/caste group). Therefore, while the term regional party may be used, all regional parties may not be regionalist; while the term state parties or state-based parties is used, all such parties would not be strictly single state and may nurse cross-state political ambitions. While some analyses may use the term caste parties or caste-based parties (or ‘ethnic parties’, such parties can and do certainly have a more diverse electoral base, leadership profile and social composition of its activists than the label may imply.

Thus, while the term regional parties has been more commonly used, given the multiple meanings attached to it, terms like state parties or state-based parties might prove preferable in the discussion of the phenomenon of smaller parties having limited geographical scope either by design, by ideological choice or by compulsions of competitive politics.

The history of regional parties from Independence to prominence

Let us now return to the point made at the beginning: that the decade of the 1990s *may appear* as the decade of the regional (state) parties. This could be stretched back to the 1980s if one takes into consideration the fact that the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) and the AGP emerged during the 1980s. The rise of these parties and the defeat of the Congress in the 1989 elections (but more particularly in the 1990s) prompted some observers to argue that the rise of state parties in the 1990s originated in the transformation situated in the 1980s and that it was closely associated with the decline of the Congress (Pai 1996, 1998). Such interpretations often divide the Indian experience of competitive democratic politics into two phases—one where dominance of the Congress Party precluded formation of effective state parties and the other, coinciding with the decline of the Congress, when a multitude of state parties emerged and transformed the party system into a more competitive and more federal one. As Table 8.1 shows, even by ECI categories, the number of state parties declined from 1951 to 1957 and again from 1962 to 1967. As Table 8.2 shows, state parties existed in the period 1950–67, but won only a few seats in the Parliament. After 1951–52, their share both in seats and votes dwindled. During this phase, state parties did not have much role to play at the all-India level since the Congress was always in a comfortable majority through the first 20 years of Independence. However, they played a crucial role at the state level in quite a few states between 1952 and 1967.

While state-level parties emerged also out of the agitations for formation of linguistic states, very few of such formations later proved to be durable as a political force in the politics of the respective states. A quick review shows that state-based political parties always played an important role in Jammu and Kashmir and Punjab; later, in the 1960s, state parties became important in Tamil Nadu (then Madras), Orissa, UP and Bihar. In fact, the first ever serious challenge to the Congress Party came from the state-level parties in the Assembly election of 1967. In 1967, state parties came to the forefront in many more states than before. In no state except in Tamil Nadu, however, could a state party singlehandedly remove the Congress from power. Congress was replaced by various coalitions in Kerala, West Bengal, and Orissa, as also by coalitions which came to be known as *Samyukta Vidhayak Dals* (post-election coalitions, often carved out of many small parties, factions and independent members of the legislative assembly—MLAs) in Haryana, UP, and Bihar. These coalitions with state parties formed the

Table 8.2 Regional parties in the Lok Sabha, 1952–84

	Total seats	National parties		Other parties		Independents		ENP*	
		Seats**	Votes	Seats	Votes	Seats	Votes	Seats	Votes
1951	488	412	73.11	38	10.99	38	15.90	1.798	4.530
1957	494	427	75.15	25	5.53	42	19.32	1.757	3.978
1962	494	443	81.33	31	7.60	20	11.07	1.849	4.404
1967	520	440	76.17	45	10.09	35	13.74	3.162	5.192
1971	518	451	77.84	53	13.79	14	8.37	2.120	4.630
1977	542	478	82.95	55	11.56	9	5.49	2.628	3.398
1980	529	485	85.07	35	8.52	9	6.41	2.275	4.248
1984	542	458	76.14	79	15.73	5	8.13	1.688	3.990

Notes: * Denotes effective number of parties derived by Taagerpera and Shugart (1989: 77–91); ** This column shows the total number of seats for which elections were held.

Source: Calculated from the official results compiled and presented by CSDS Data Unit in the Statistical Supplement to the *Journal of Indian School of Political Economy* Vol.15, Nos. 1–2, January–June 2003 (for the 1951–99 elections), and the Statistical Supplement to the *Journal of Indian School of Political Economy* Vol.20, Nos. 1–2, January–June 2008 (published in 2010) (for the 2004 and 2009 elections). For a list of parties considered as national parties for the purposes of this tables, see Appendix 1.

bulk of the non-Congress political spectrum which neither the left nor the right could singly occupy across states. While the Congress claimed the all-India space, it managed to localize politics in such a manner that opposition to the Congress could emerge only at the state level (for instance, one study argues that the Congress was in fact a party consisting of various state parties; see Chhibber 1999). Therefore, ‘opposition’ could emerge through a state Congress faction forming a separate party or an alternative to state-level Congress forming into a state party. As a result, anti-Congress politics could not transform into a national or nationwide phenomenon. Ironically, the Congress Party itself contributed to such a transformation of its opposition. The larger-than-life image of Indira Gandhi in the post-1970 period, her towering victory in 1971–72 and the clamping of national Emergency in 1975 led to a plebiscitary politics that focused exclusively on removal of congress from power. This also led finally to the formation of the Janata party as a united opposition party in the election of 1977. Though two state parties (Akali Dal and All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam—AIADMK) rose to national level prominence as they joined/supported the first ever non-Congress government led by the Janata party in 1977, the formation of the Janata party and the subsequent struggle between it and the Congress Party temporarily sidelined the role of regional/state parties.

A careful look at the 1967–71 period indicates that the process of emergence of state parties in competition to the Congress had already commenced during that period. As Table 8.2 shows, the *effective* number of parties, i.e. parties that mattered in shaping electoral competition, rises for the first time in 1967: in terms of votes, the effective number of parties rose to five and in terms of seats, it rose to over three. In other words, the one-party dominance system had already started shifting to a multi-party system in 1967. The dramatic developments of the 1970s postponed the process by almost a decade as the effective number of parties declined only to start rising again in the late 1980s. This time, too, the shift occurred more because of state-level formations than by the rise of large national-level parties competing with the Congress at the all-India level.

The performance of the regional parties and their role since the late 1980s

When non-Congress parties sought to mobilize voters in the 1960s and later in the early 1970s, their language was not much of regional identity; instead they spoke the language of democracy,

non-congressism, opposition to personality cult, and so on. With the defeat (and return) of the Congress Party and also of Indira Gandhi personally, these issues became somewhat irrelevant in the post-1980 scenario and in this sense, a new phase began to shape where the language of politics and the emotive points of reference shifted. While the formation of the Janata government and its failure to hold on to power occupied much attention in the 1977–80 period, the Punjab and Assam agitations gave rise to strong state-level parties with a regionalist rhetoric in those two states. The Akali Dal underwent many crises because of the Khalistan movement, but the agitation for Khalistan accentuated regionalist sentiment and gave a lease of life to the various Akali factions. The AGP acquired center stage in Assam through the agitation and the subsequent accord with Rajiv Gandhi. In Jammu and Kashmir, the accord between Indira Gandhi and Sheikh Abdullah in the mid-1970s had already rejuvenated the National Conference. With the rise of the TDP in Andhra Pradesh, ‘regionalism,’ regional autonomy and identity suddenly began to appear as the mainstay of the new political formations across different states. Thus, the 1980s were marked by the inability of a ‘national’ opposition to Congress to hold its own and the rise of politics of region-based identity. Realizing the limitations of the Janata Party experiment in providing an alternative to Congress, V.P. Singh encouraged the alliance of ‘regional’ parties, claiming that the rise of regional parties was in fact a sign of democratization. This strategy brought in the new era in 1989 when a National Front consisting of many small and state-level parties was formed with Janata Dal (itself an all-India party with a limited geographical base) as its main anchor. This development was catalytic for three reasons: first, it provided a new legitimation for small and state parties taking a regionalist view of state power; second, the National Front experiment brought state parties to national-level politics, allowing their leadership to play a key role in formation of national government and also in formation of national-level policy. This latter also fed into the process of their legitimation because state party leaders were no longer perceived merely as protecting regional interests but as jointly defining and pursuing the national interest. Third, it claimed that a government need not be a single-party affair, that coalitions and resulting compromises were a natural and necessary part of government formation. All these three factors continued to be the main features in the role played by state parties in the following decade. In spite of the temporary and paradoxical comeback of the Congress in 1991 parliamentary elections, the role of state parties and their ascendance did not dwindle drastically—as Table 8.3 shows, the number of MPs elected from state parties increased—and the Congress

Table 8.3 State parties in the Lok Sabha, 1989–2009

	Total seats	National parties		Other parties		Independents		ENP*	
		Seats**	Votes	Seats	Votes	Seats	Votes	Seats	Votes
1989	529	473	79.87	44	15.24	12	4.89	4.347	4.803
1991	537	474	77.12	49	19.21	2	3.57	3.704	5.102
1996	543	402	69.75	133	24.05	8	6.20	5.826	7.113
1998	543	376	66.23	161	31.67	6	2.10	5.277	6.911
1999	543	347	63.10	190	34.16	6	2.74	5.868	6.736
2004	543	355	61.42	183	34.33	5	4.25	6.526	7.556
2009	543	363	60.56	171	34.28	9	5.16	5.011	7.738

Notes: * Denotes effective number of parties derived by Taagerpera and Shugart (1989: 77–91); ** This column shows the total number of seats for which elections were held.

Source: Calculated from the official results compiled and presented by CSDS Data Unit in the Statistical Supplement to the *Journal of Indian School of Political Economy* Vol.15, Nos. 1–2, January–June 2003 (for the 1951–99 elections), and the Statistical Supplement to the *Journal of Indian School of Political Economy* Vol.20, Nos. 1–2, January–June 2008 (published in 2010) (for the 2004 and 2009 elections). For a list of parties considered as national parties for the purposes of this table, see Appendix 1.

government could survive in power mainly because of the ‘outside’ support extended by AIADMK (11 MPs), Kerala Congress (one MP), Indian Union Muslim League (two MPs) and Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (five MPs).

The mid-1990s witnessed a further proliferation and ascendance of state parties: on the one hand factions of Congress leaders at state level formed state-level parties, some of which played a crucial role in the time to come—the Tamil Maanil Congress in Tamil Nadu and Trinamool Congress in West Bengal, as also many smaller Congress groups (Himachal Vikas Congress, Madhya Pradesh, Vikas Congress, Rajiv Congress, Loktantrik Congress and so on); on the other hand, the Janata Dal kept on disintegrating and thus a large number of parties belonging to the ‘Janata family’ emerged at the state level. These included the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) in Orissa, Samajwadi Party (SP) in UP, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) in Bihar, Samata Party in Bihar, Lok Janshakti Party (LNJP) also in Bihar, Lok Shakti Party in Karnataka, Indian National Lok Dal (INLD) in Haryana, Lok Dal (Ajit Singh) in UP, and so on. In contrast to the 1980s, however, the ‘regionalist’ rhetoric was *not* the driver of this development. Therefore, this development has been described more as ‘regionalization’ of the parties and party system.

With both Congress and BJP unable to win a majority in the Lok Sabha, various experiments at coalition formation took place in the 1990s and the state parties played a crucial role in government formation from the 1996 elections onwards. The state parties never had a uniform direction to their political choices and alliances; however, we can discern three broad patterns: keeping distance both from Congress and BJP; veering towards the BJP; and a more or less clearly defined bipolarity. Both in 1989 and in 1996, the dominant theme was to provide a ‘third alternative’—to provide a platform of parties away from Congress and the BJP. In 1989 V.P. Singh, and in 1996 the left parties sought to intellectually lead this political maneuver. However, this exercise was fraught with practical difficulties and thus, in 1989, the National Front government relied on ‘outside’ support from BJP and the Left Front, and in 1996 the United Front government depended on similar support from the Congress. Clearly, for the former, non-congressism was more important than shaping the third alternative, while for the latter keeping the BJP away from power mattered more. Therefore, the pattern of ‘equal distance’ never really worked either in theory or in practice. Both these experiments also proved to be short lived. State-level considerations, possibilities of sharing power at the national level and an overall anti-Congress mood pushed many state-level parties towards the BJP. During this phase of the evolution of state parties, the Congress was in a decline mode while the BJP was on the ascendance. The BJP offered the state parties a share in power at the all-India level, ensured their domination at the state level (by playing a subsidiary role in matters of state-level politics), and also offered to tone down its Hindutva (Hindu cultural nationalism) rhetoric so that the state parties that did not share its Hindutva need not be embarrassed by the rhetoric. In fact, barring the Shiv Sena, no other party shared or supported the BJP’s Hindutva ideology, and yet the BJP was successful in forging alliances with a large number of state parties. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) led by the BJP came to power in 1998 and again in 1999. The second time, it ruled the entire term comfortably. Since 1999, Congress has initiated serious efforts to counter the BJP and NDA by forming an alternative coalition. It bore fruit in 2004 when the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) came to power (with support from the Left Front parties). In retrospect, we can say that three factors facilitated the bipolarization of politics of the state parties. First, the deep-rooted bipolarity of Tamil politics meant that when one major Tamil party joined one alliance, the other would be available for alliance with any rival grouping. Accommodating both the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and AIADMK was something that the NDA could not achieve. This left room for an alternative coalition. Second, the steadfastness with which Lalu Prasad and his RJD party kept their distance from the BJP and

NDA made room for an alternative (non-BJP) coalition. Third, after splitting with the Congress Party and forming the Nationalist Congress Party, Sharad Pawar did not find it advantageous to join the NDA and instead retained an ambiguous position nationally while aligning with the Congress at the state level in Maharashtra following the assembly elections of 1999. These three factors meant that the political space for an alternative maneuver was available. This facilitated a bipolar division of the terrain of state parties. In the post-UPA phase, very few state parties such as the SP kept away from both of the alliances. For state parties, the option was now restricted to either joining the NDA or joining the UPA (besides of course, the state parties in Kerala and West Bengal that have long been aligned to the Left Front). This bipolarity, however, is not cemented either by ideology and program or by complementarity of social base. Therefore, this bipolarity is beset with a contingent nature: the NDA shrank in 2009 when the AIADMK, BJD, TC and TDP chose to part ways with it. On the other hand, the Congress refused to accommodate the Samajwadi party, RJD and LJNP both before and after the parliamentary elections of 2009. These developments imply that the bipolarity is somewhat ephemeral and related to the electoral fortunes of the two larger parties, BJP and Congress. Besides, state parties continued to be a deciding factor in a large number of states even after the rise of bipolarity: besides the smaller states in the northeast, state parties are crucial in Assam, Jammu and Kashmir, Punjab, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh (MP), Orissa, West Bengal, Bihar and UP. If one were to juxtapose the state parties with all-India parties, in the first decade of this century Congress regained power from state parties only in two states—Andhra and Assam—while the BJP sidelined the Janata Dal (Secular) (JD(S)) in Karnataka to gain power at state level on its own strength. This indicates the continued significance and clout of the state parties.

The role of state-based parties during almost three decades (1977 onwards) may be summarized in the following manner: issues have become state/region specific, with so-called all-India issues like communalism, globalization, etc., making sense to the electorate only when translated into the context of the state; leadership is shaped and legitimized at the state level only, and people relate to national-level politics through state-level leadership; both for state parties and all-India parties, the social base is defined chiefly in terms of the support obtained at the state level, and a party may have different constituencies to support it in different states; electoral choices are often state specific; and finally, competition is structured at state level and, therefore, outcomes of political competition also emerge and make sense at the state level (Palshikar 2006: 271–72; some of these points are reiterated and elaborated also in Yadav and Palshikar 2008).

The relationship between caste parties and regional parties

Along with the rise of state parties the decade of the 1990s is also famous for the prominence of the caste factor and in particular the rise of backward class politics known as ‘OBC politics.’ This development needs to be taken into consideration here because of its close links with the phenomenon of state parties. Since the late 1980s, political mobilization among the backward castes took shape in many states of India. The controversy over the implementation of the Mandal Commission Report and the subsequent language of social justice inaugurated a new phase in the politics of caste. Because of their claimed numeric preponderance, the ‘other backward classes’ (or castes—OBCs) were identified as *Bahujan*—the majority of the masses. Two different but interrelated attempts at coalition building marked this phase of OBC politics. One was the effort to build a combined political force of the OBCs. The other was aimed at forming larger social and political alliance of the Scheduled Castes (SCs, or Dalits) and OBCs (Bahujans). In fact, many of the parties of this period are a product of these developments. For instance, in Maharashtra, a party was formed in 1993—the Bahujan Mahasangh, which aimed at uniting the

OBCs of the state. This initiative came from the leadership of a Republican faction—the Bharatiya Republican Party (BRP). The two always contested elections together and the chief leader of both the parties happens to be the same—Prakash Ambedkar. The formation of a twin party was ostensibly to recognize the fact that Dalits and OBCs did have some differences and needed to retain their separate identity and political vehicles while at the same time recognizing the need to politically unite for larger purposes of social transformation and Bahujan politics. The 1990s also witnessed the more formal and disastrous attempt of a Dalit party and an OBC party forming a coalition government in UP: the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) and SP coming together briefly and then parting on a very bitter note. Third, in Bihar, RJD led by Lalu Prasad Yadav succeeded—at least initially—in bringing together the SCs and OBCs under its fold. At the same time, the SP in UP and RJD in Bihar were seen primarily as parties representing the OBC interests in these two states. In the southern state of Tamil Nadu, a slightly different process unfolded: instead of a party of the OBCs, Tamil Nadu witnessed the emergence of parties of specific castes, like the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) as the Vanniyar caste party. In Karnataka too, one faction of the Janata Dal led by Deve Gowda assumed the character of a single caste party—of the Vokkaligas. How does one understand this complex phenomenon of vacillation between grand social coalitions of Dalits and Bahujans on the one hand and single-caste parties on the other?

While the idea of OBC politics hinged on the ‘democratic claims’ by the entire mass of underprivileged castes vis-à-vis the upper/dominant castes, the same democratic claims triggered a competition among different castes (as separate from caste blocs) for staking their claims over the Indian state, in terms of representation, symbolism and distributive share. While the former led to formation of caste blocs and therefore to formation of parties claiming the ground on behalf of the entire segment called the OBCs, the latter always punctuated that development and led to the formation of single-caste parties. Moreover, even the grander claims to OBC representation often boiled down to advancing the interests of only one (more advanced/numerous/dominant) caste among the OBCs.

However, there is a more crucial factor that requires attention in this context. The attempts to build coalitions of Dalits and OBCs, and also among the OBCs, are predicated upon a certain political construction that interests and political aspirations of these segments are similar or congruent. However, any recourse to caste as a basis for political organization/mobilization hits a roadblock on account of the specific territorial frame within which a caste exists or operates. As a social unit and also as a political unit, caste operates at the local level: this factor of *locality* narrows it down to a few villages in case of marriage and other close contacts among members of the same *jati*; it expands to the district or a region within a state for purposes of pursuing common identity issues, material demands and political aspirations (for details see Palshikar 2006). The efforts to organize jatis into caste associations have always tried to territorially broaden the phenomenon of caste, claiming an ‘all-India’ nature of that association and the caste it aims to mobilize. In the 1990s this process gathered momentum and caste associations claiming pan-state and pan-Indian spatial spread emerged all over the country (for more discussion of the caste associations and their ‘politics,’ see Deshpande 2010). In the late 1980s and early 1990s, political leaders of various backwards castes realized the need to expand the political space available to caste-based political maneuvers. This led to more conscious attempts to build larger coalitions of castes, giving rise to ‘OBC politics.’ However, to the extent that these attempts relied on invoking caste as people’s lived-in socio-cultural life experience, regionalization of such caste-based politics was inevitable. Thus, while Lalu Prasad (RJD) or Mulayam Singh (SP) employed the rhetoric of OBC politics and claims of backward classes in general, their politics remained confined not only to one state but also came to be identified with only one

caste—the Yadavs of Bihar and Yadavs of UP, respectively. They could not cross the threshold of the state, nor could they cross the threshold of one caste. Initially, both attracted non-Yadav castes from their respective states suggesting that they may be crossing the caste threshold, but survey data show that the capacity of these parties to attract non-Yadav votes declined considerably and gave rise to alternative political forces: in Bihar, Kurmis veered towards the Samata Party/JDU and some smaller backward castes also appeared to be supporting that party at least in the 2005–09 period; Pasis or Paswans of Bihar continued to rally behind the Lok Janshakti Party but other non-Pasi SCs did not support that party so strongly. In Uttar Pradesh, the Kurmis formed the Apna Dal; Jats continue to support the Lok Dal faction led by Ajit Singh; non-Yadav OBCs—mostly lower OBCs—supported the BJP in the 1990s and a large section of these castes supported the BSP in the 2007 Assembly election. The examples from UP and Bihar thus amply show how caste-based politics necessarily gets regionalized. This also helps explain the sudden rise in the number of parties across the country. On the one hand most of these parties appear to be single-leader phenomena. However, many of them also aim at representing and negotiating on behalf of one caste community or another that is mostly confined to a specific region within a state or a few districts. Thus, caste mobilizations circumscribed by territoriality of castes as well as of caste blocs contributed to the rise of so many ‘regional’ parties (and incidentally, this development, though dramatic in its proportion and effect, is not something new: even in the pre-1989 period many small parties had these twin characteristics of territoriality and caste-community basis—for details see Palshikar 2006).

Given the caste-specific nature of most of these parties, can we distinguish between the social base enjoyed by all-India or national parties and the social base of state-/caste-based parties? From available data on party preferences of different segments of Indian voters, it can be surmised that voters from the ‘OBC’ category tend to vote more for the state parties and similarly, on many occasions, voters from peasant proprietor intermediate castes also vote for state-level parties more than the national parties. Muslims, Adivasis (Scheduled Tribes, or STs) and Dalits (SCs) have voted more often for the all-India parties, though; there have been periods when a substantial proportion of Muslims voted for state parties, too (in the 1990s). The upper castes, too, ordinarily rally behind all-India parties more. Thus, state parties draw support more from OBCs and intermediate castes, which are also more regionally differentiated and therefore tend to veer towards state-level political formations (these observations are based on analysis of survey data on voters’ choices; for details see Heath and Yadav 2010). This overall picture, however, hides some interesting variations: quite a few state parties also draw support from upper castes in the respective states—AGP in Assam, Trinamool in West Bengal, and BJD in Orissa. This variation is not restricted only to the caste base of the parties; it similarly obtains in the case of class. Many state parties derive substantial support (more than their overall vote share) from the middle or upper classes of the hierarchy. This includes the Akalis, the AGP, Trinamool Congress, and BJD (these observations are based on Assembly surveys of various states conducted by the Lokniti Program of CSDS during the period 1996–2009; the data are made available by the CSDS Data Unit). This discussion of caste parties cannot be complete without reference to the BSP. Given its strength since the 2004 parliamentary elections, most observers treat this party as an all-India party rather than a state party. It has made some impact from time to time in the Jammu region of Jammu and Kashmir, in Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Rajasthan, Haryana, Delhi Chhattisgarh and MP. However, if one looks at the support base and seats won by the BSP, we find a more confusing story: most of its MPs are elected only from one state, UP. This is mainly because of the constituency the party cultivates—the SCs generally, but mainly the Jatavs among the SCs. As a result, it encounters difficulties in spreading outside of the areas where the Jatav identity is relevant. For instance, in UP, the BSP gets huge support among the Jatav

Table 8.4 Performance of the BSP in the Lok Sabha elections, 1989–2009

Year	Seats won from UP	Seats won from states other than UP	Votes polled in UP	Total votes polled
1989	2	1 (Punjab)	9.9	2.07
1991	1	2 (MP, Punjab)	8.7	1.80
1996	6	2 (MP) +3 (Punjab)	20.6	4.2
1998	4	1 (Haryana)	20.9	4.7
1999	14	—	22.1	4.2
2004	19	—	24.7	5.3
2009	20	1 (MP)	27.4	6.2

Source: For 1989–1999, Statistical supplement to *Journal of Indian School of Political Economy* Vol.15, Nos. 1–2, January–June 2003; for 2004–09, Statistical supplement to *Journal of Indian School of Political Economy* Vol.20, Nos. 1–2, January–June 2008. Compiled by CSDS Data Unit.

community—National Election Studies (NES) show that between 60% and 80% of Jatavs support the BSP, far in excess of its overall votes even in UP. Table 8.4 shows that while the BSP has crossed the one-state threshold the party remains mostly confined to one state, Uttar Pradesh, in terms of practical politics. In short, the BSP represents the complexity of the nexus between caste and region and also the difficulty involved in nomenclature and classification. More than that, though, it draws our attention to the difficulty faced by political parties in expanding their base both socially and spatially. In a sense, the example of BSP tells us why so many state-based and caste-based parties have emerged since the 1980s.

Understanding the phenomenon

Discussion of state/caste parties so far has brought out four key foci around which these parties emerge and operate. First, historically, state parties emerged in opposition to the dominant party—they sought to compete with the dominant party only at state level for specific local reasons or they could effectively compete only at the state level and hence remained state parties. The latter process was characteristic of the 1960s while Trinamool Congress could be an example of the former variety. Second, many state parties originated in and drew their sustenance from regional sentiments. We have mentioned examples of this from both the pre-1980 and post-1980 periods. Third, party factionalism, particularly in the so-called all-India parties, often leads to formation of parties that subsequently become viable only at state level. Congress has given rise to such parties from time to time while the inability of the Janata party and later Janata Dal to hold together their factions led to a large number of state parties in the post-1977 period. Lastly, competitive mobilization among different caste groups is another factor around which many state parties emerge/sustain themselves. Taken together, Table 8.5 makes an attempt to map different regional/state/caste parties across these four foci.

How can one approach the phenomenon of state and caste parties? What possible explanatory frames are employed for making sense of this phenomenon?

It is possible to imagine five explanatory frames, some of which are not necessarily mutually exclusive. The first of these is less fashionable in Indian academic circles and also in overall comparative political analyses. In that sense, it is less of a serious academic framework and more of a residue of the pre-1990 idea of all-India politics. In this view, state parties may be seen as ‘regional’ and caste based and, therefore, with some apprehension about their effects on democratic politics as well as on the shaping of the ‘national.’ Even in the 1990s, media coverage often represented state parties as detrimental to the formation of a ‘stable’ regime. Regional parties are

Table 8.5 Mapping of state/caste parties according to four key foci

<i>Opposition to the dominant party</i>	<i>Factionalism</i>	<i>Regional sentiment</i>	<i>Caste mobilization/caste fragmentation</i>
DMK (vis-à-vis Congress in TN), TDP (vis-à-vis Congress in AP), Trinamool Congress (vis-à-vis Left Front in WB), BJD (vis-à-vis Congress in Orissa)	Congress—Trinamool Congress, NCP, TMC, Janata—Lok Dal, Samajwadi Party, RJD, BJD, JDS, INLD, BJP—Vaghela, Uma Bharati	MNF, AGP, TRS, Shiv Sena, MNS, TDP, DMK, Akali Dal, NC, PDP	Apna Dal, SP, RJD, LJNP, NCP(?), BSP, PMK

also seen as being parochial and narrow in their understanding of the larger public interest. Similar objections are raised vis-à-vis the caste parties which, too, are mostly state based. While many of these criticisms can be seen as simplistic, we can imagine a broader explanatory frame: a unified conception of public interest as opposed to a fragmented and sectionally conceived public interest. The former discourages state parties; the later necessitates state parties.

A second explanatory frame, in sharp contrast to the above, is to argue that state parties represent the moment of federalization of the polity: that in a diverse society like India, it is necessary that political forces shape on a regional basis because only then do the diverse interests located at different states/regions get adequately represented and integrated in public policy. Many proponents of this explanatory frame also view this process as integrally necessary for federalism; in fact, they see this as a necessary characteristic of a federal politics (Arora 2000, 2002; Verney 2002). Accordingly, the rise of so many state parties is seen as a process strengthening federalization of the polity. Thus, while the first privileges the factors of unity and homogeneity, this approach privileges federalization not only in a structural sense but effective political federalization in terms of mobilization and power sharing among regional political societies. However, this explanatory frame does not take into account the phenomenon of caste-based parties that become regional or state based because of the linkages between caste and region.

A third approach, only a variant of the second, is to argue that ‘regionalization’ is only a natural or obvious development. We may call this the ‘normalization’ approach. Like the second one, this, too, starts by assuming that regional/state parties are something related to the regional (and sectional) diversity of India. It was only due to historical specificities of the immediate post-independence period that one party dominance system emerged. That was a sort of excess or exaggeration and over time, the competitive democratic polity is reaching equilibrium by moving away from the dominant party system model. So, the transformation of the 1990s was only part of this shift towards a natural equilibrium, involving a multi-party system and regionalization of political competition (Pai 1996, 1998; Nigam 1996; Rangarajan 1999). This approach also subscribes, implicitly, the federalization argument stated above, though it does not specifically address the issue of caste-based parties.

Fourth, state/caste parties may be seen in the context of caste and various efforts and constructing caste blocs (Palshikar 2006). This approach emphasizes caste factor in the formation of parties and also in their operation (agenda, candidate selection, programmatic inclination). Caste/caste blocs also help these parties to sustain in competitive politics. Most of all, though, this approach views caste as a central factor in regionalizing or localizing the parties and, therefore, the proliferation of parties in proportion to the enhanced awareness of caste as a political claim. This approach allows us to understand the two-fold and contradictory process: caste-based mobilizations for purposes of claiming share in power and competitive caste mobilizations by all

parties resulting in fragmentation of the caste/caste bloc politically. The limitation of this approach, of course, is that it cannot capture parties like the AGP or Trinamool Congress on its analytical radar.

Fifth, there is the democratization argument which draws attention to the increased competitiveness of the party system as a consequence of the rise of so many parties (for instance, the number of parties, number of candidates, and the effective number of parties are discussed to drive home the point that the moment of the Congress decline also coincided with the moment of democratic upsurge; see Yadav 2000). Within the rubric of this argument, the social churning that took place in the post-1989 phase and the rise of OBC consciousness are also intrinsically related to the phenomenon of state-/caste-based parties. While influential and impressive, this argument tends to burden state parties with the responsibility of democratization and expansion of substantive choices before the voters. In practice, the state parties are not, and perhaps cannot be, much different from the so-called all-India parties in this respect; it is only the level or unit at which they compete that makes them state and/or caste based and being so does not *ipso facto* lead them to taking any more democratic position than the other parties. Particularly, we witness a tendency among all political parties to veer increasingly towards a convergence effectively restricting the menu before the electorate (for a discussion of this point see Yadav and Palshikar 2003, 2009). State/caste parties are no exception to this tendency.

Larger questions

In conclusion, we shall touch briefly upon the larger issue of the structure of competitive politics and its implications in order to contextualize the phenomenon of state parties. There are three larger questions: first, do state parties represent democratization? Many observers and scholars assigned a democratizing role to the state parties. It is true that state parties rose to prominence at a juncture when new social sections were also advancing their claims to a share in the political process. In this respect, it is argued that the phenomenon of state parties need not necessarily lead to greater democratization (Palshikar 2003), although their rise to prominence coincided with new claims to power sharing by many social sections. The second question is whether state parties and their role explain contemporary political processes in India adequately. Since the 1980s, two competing patterns of political competition have coexisted in India. On the one hand, the state has emerged as a unit of choices and contestations, while on the other hand the all-India level is still a reality. State parties only represent this duality. To the extent this duality continues, state parties will proliferate and share power with the all-India parties. Chhibber (2009) and Kailash (2010) have argued that the state may not fully explain or encompass all political competition; just like the state level, the all-India party may also have an independent existence and salience for politics. These arguments alert us to the fact that while state parties have achieved a high level of salience, state parties need not necessarily represent the 'normal' state of politics: that India's democratic politics has and will have space for all-India parties as much as the state parties. The third issue is about the nature of mobilizations. State parties represent a particular format of political mobilization and competition which is meaningful in the context of the state; however, is there space for shaping an all-India cleavage that would effect a further realignment also at the all-India level? In other words, if political parties can transcend the confines of region and caste in constructing political fault lines, the pattern of political competition can change. India's experience for the period 1989–2009—two decades—is perhaps not conclusive, though slightly tilted in favor of the view that state parties may play a crucial role in shaping the socio-political cleavages in contemporary India.

Appendix 1: national parties

As discussed in section one, the ECI classifies parties as national and state-level parties besides other parties. The norms for this classification change slightly over time. However, of late, the emphasis is on the ability of a party to win a certain number of seats as a minimum in the Lok Sabha elections from that state or the Assembly election. Since our purpose here is to understand the phenomenon politically rather than merely legally or juridically, we have treated the parties in the following list as national parties. In each case the name of the party is given with its abbreviation and the election year/s for which it is treated as a national party.

- 1 Akhil Bharat Hindu Mahasabha, HMS, 1951
- 2 Bahujan Samaj Party, BSP, 1989–2009
- 3 Bharatiya Jan Sangh/Bharatiya Janata Party, BJS/BJP, 1952–72/1984–2009
- 4 Bharatiya Kranti Dal, BKD, 1971
- 5 Bharatiya Lok Dal, BLD, 1977 (Janata Party contested elections on this party symbol)
- 6 Communist Party of India, CPI, 1951–2009
- 7 Communist Party of India (Marxist), CPM, 1967–2009
- 8 Indian National Congress, Congress (I): Cong./INC, 1951–2009
- 9 Indian National Congress (U), INCU, 1980
- 10 Indian National Congress (O), NCO, 1971
- 11 Janata Party, JNP, 1980–84
- 12 Janata Dal, JD, 1989–98
- 13 Kisan Mazdoor Praja Party, KMPP, 1951
- 14 Lok Dal, LKD, 1984
- 15 Praja Socialist Party, PSP, 1957–67
- 16 Ram Rajya Parishad, RRP, 1951
- 17 Republican Party of India, RPI, 1962
- 18 Samyukta Socialist Party, SSP, 1967–71
- 19 Scheduled Castes Federation, SCF, 1951–57
- 20 Socialist Party, SOP, 1962
- 21 Swatantra Party, SWA, 1962–71

Note

- 1 Arora, too, makes this point: see Arora 2002: 510; he uses the terms ‘polity-wide parties and state based or multi-state parties,’ Arora 2000: 184.

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I.IV

Identity and community politics

9

CASTE AND POLITICAL PARTIES IN INDIA

Do Indians vote their caste—while
casting their vote?

Christophe Jaffrelot

In the West, political scientists from the Marxist tradition used to claim that the electoral behavior of the voters was over-determined by class, whereas their colleagues from more liberal schools of thought argued that individuals make up their mind according to their free will and that elections are issue based.

A similar debate is taking shape in India with one additional complicating factor, that is caste, one of the building blocks of Indian society. According to common parlance, in this country, people do not cast their vote, they vote their caste. How far is it true and when as well as where is this assessment of the Indians' voting behavior observed?

To answer these questions, one needs first to present the caste system as well as its transformation. Then we will make the best use we can of the available surveys to assess the degree of 'casteization' of politics India is experiencing at a macro level. Finally, the last part of this chapter will disaggregate India and caste to see whether the national territory and the notion of caste are the relevant units of analysis.

Castes in India: from system to interest groups

The study of caste is one of the most controversial fields of Indian studies—not only among anthropologists, but also historians, sociologists and political scientists. Disputes have developed about the extent to which the society of castes formed a system and how far that system has changed in the course of time.

The caste system: varnas, jatis and 'sanskritization'

In the Sanskrit classic literature dealing with castes, Hindu society is divided into four *varnas* (colors): the Brahmins (the literati, including priests); the Kshatriyas (the warriors); the Vaishyas (crafts- and tradesmen), with whom finish the *dvijas* (twice-born) category; and the Shudras (servants of these aforementioned three categories). In 1931—the last census during which castes were taken into

account—the Brahmins represented 6.4% of the entire population, the Rajputs (the principal caste of warriors), 3.7%, and the Banyas (mainly merchants composing the third order), 2.7%. Shudras, forming the rest of society, were bound to represent a majority of society. The oldest presentation of this quadri-partition of society probably appeared in the Rig Veda, the first of the four Vedas. Its cosmogony or explanation of the origin of the world, reads as follows: a primeval man gave birth to society *and therefore to the world* by sacrificing himself. His mouth became the Brahmins, his arms the Kshatriyas, his hands the Vaishyas and his legs the Shudras. Such a metaphor of the body is not neutral in terms of social hierarchy, the head being superior to the legs, always.

One key criterion of social hierarchy in the Hindu society of caste is ritual purity. The Brahmin is at the top largely because of his superior purity that he needs to cultivate through, for instance, a strictly vegetarian diet. Other twice-born castes are pure too—hence their ‘twice born’ status—whereas the Shudra are considered impure. However, the most impure form is another category, which is not mentioned in the Rig Veda but is referred to in the Dharmashastras: the Untouchables, whose impurity is such that, as suggested by their very name, they are not supposed to be in contact with the rest of society. This segregation finds a topographical expression in the location of special neighborhoods out of the village.

The relative (im)purity of each caste coincides with their occupation. Brahmins will work with their brain, for instance in the administration of kingdoms where they’ll be recognized not only as prestigious, but as powerful too. Kshatriyas, who have conquered territories, will become local suzerains as landlords (zamindars, jagirdars or even Maharajahs). Vaishyas will concentrate on trade and economic activities in general (as money-lenders too, for instance). Most of the Hindu industrialists will come from their milieu in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. Shudras, who represent the largest numbers, work in the fields where they till the land they often do not possess and look after the cattle. Shudras are also artisans, sometimes in very prestigious fields like jewelry. The Untouchables are involved in the most degrading activities, working as tanners, shoemakers, butchers, sweepers, etc. Most of them are landless peasants.

Besides rural (im)purity and occupation, the third mainstay of the caste system is its endogamous character. For the system to continue, castes must not mix: inter-marriages are strictly prohibited in the Dharmashastras, which presents them as the recipe for chaos. As a result, the varna system encompasses a system of endogamous *jatis*, which are the real castes. The word *jati* derives from ‘jan’ (to be born) and indeed the *jatis* are endogamous: one is born in the caste to which one’s parents both belong; they are organized in a hierarchical way due to their status, given in terms of ritual purity, according to a continuum ranging from the Brahmins to the Untouchables. However, qualitative leaps exist in this gradation since the varna system gives a structure to the profusion of *jatis*. Each *jati* belongs to a specific varna. The *jatis* of the ‘twice-born’ varnas naturally enjoy a higher status than those that are placed at the level of the Shudras and even more among the Untouchables. This hierarchy of inherited status goes together with the economic functions sometimes extremely specialized, mentioned above. For instance, the main Untouchable *jati* of the north of India, the Chamars, are leatherworkers who are particularly impure because they work with the skin of the cow, the sacred animal par excellence in Hinduism.

The distinction one must always observe between varnas and *jatis* makes things more complicated because the sense of hierarchy we have highlighted in respect to the varnas is reproduced within the varnas at the *jati* level. As a result, Shudras are far from forming a social bloc but are highly differentiated, for instance.

The pervasiveness of hierarchy does not preclude the notion of a social *system*. On the contrary, because all the castes tended to pay allegiance to the upper castes, and especially to the

Brahmins, not only because of the authority (and sheer power) in their command but also because they looked at the Brahmin as embodying superior values everybody should emulate. Hence the notion of ‘sanskritization’ introduced by the Indian anthropologist M.N. Srinivas in the 1950s–60s. Srinivas defined it as ‘the process in which a “low” Hindu caste, or tribal or other group, changes its customs, ritual, ideology and way of life in the direction of a high, and frequently, “twice-born” caste that is the Brahmins, but also the Kshatriyas or even the Vaishyas.’¹ Low castes may, for instance, adopt the most prestigious features of the Brahmin diet and therefore become vegetarian. Such a process reflects a special consensus in society, all the groups admitting the values of the upper castes as the most respectable ones. As a result, ‘the mobility associated with Sanskritization results only in *positional changes* in the system and does not lead to any *structural change*. That is, a sub-caste moves up above its neighbours and another comes down, but all this takes place in an essentially stable hierarchical order. The system itself does not change.’² Indeed, the values sustaining the social system remain the same.

The making of interest groups

The cohesiveness of the caste system eroded in the course of time because of the modernization of India. The development of new means of communication like the railways, for instance, made the observation of caste segregation more difficult. Social reform movements started to fight caste discrimination during the British Raj. After Independence, the Constitution of India abolished untouchability, for instance. However, the most significant impact on caste was made by public policies of positive discrimination. The British started caste-based affirmative action programs in the late nineteenth century in the field of education. Schools were reserved for Untouchables who otherwise would have remained illiterate because of caste discrimination. As early as 1892, schools reserved for them were established.³ However, it turned out that educated Untouchables, though in small numbers, could not get jobs in relation to their qualifications. As a result, the British, under pressure from Dr. Ambedkar—the first Dalit, a word he introduced to designate the members of his caste group, to get a PhD—who had been the first victim of discrimination in the job market, introduced quotas for the Untouchables in the administration. In 1934 the government decided to reserve 25% of the vacancies in the administration for Muslims and 8.3% for the other minorities, including the Untouchables, who then represented 12.5% of the population according to the 1931 census. By that time, the Untouchables—who had been known as Depressed Classes—had been rechristened Scheduled Castes (SCs) and the list of the jati belonging to this category which had been established in order to reserve access to the quotas to the relevant beneficiaries was updated in the relevant ‘schedule.’ The latter quota was increased to this level—12.5%—in June 1946, which means that proportionality became the rule.⁴ This measure was extended by the first government of independent India and then, since the proportionality principle continued to apply, the quota for the SCs was increased to 15% when the 1951 census indicated that it was their share in the population. The same quota was implemented in the educational institutions and in the assemblies at the state as well as the national levels.

The systematization of caste-based quotas took another step when leaders of the Shudras, who saw the Dalits making progress thanks to positive discrimination programs, asked for the same. In 1953 the Kaka Kalelkar Commission, at the request of the government of India, concluded that those who were called Other Backward Classes (or Castes—OBCs) in the Constitution of India were, in fact, Shudra castes for which similar affirmative action measures should be taken. The Congress government dismissed its report lest these plebeians dislodge the upper-caste elite of power under the pretext that caste was bound to vanish in the course of India’s modernization. However, the Backward Classes Commission chaired by an OBC leader,

B.P. Mandal, in 1978 came to the same conclusion (the OBCs had to be equated with lower castes) and made the same recommendations (52% of the positions had to be reserved for these caste groups in the administration and in the education system). In 1990, when the Congress lost power and V.P. Singh became prime minister on a progressive agenda, these recommendations were implemented, provoking a huge protest from the upper-caste students who feared that the jobs they had almost monopolized so far would go to the OBCs. Hence unprecedented demonstrations to which the lower castes reacted by counter-mobilizations in the street. This agitation, which resulted in the death of dozens of upper-caste students (who immolated themselves in most cases) led the Supreme Court to suspend the implementation of the Mandal Commission's recommendations. However, the judges part validated them two years later, in December 1992.

Caste-based reservations have been instrumental in transforming castes into interest groups. After the 'Mandal affair'—a culminating and turning point in a century-long trajectory—castes no longer formed a cohesive system but competed for jobs and spoils at large. Caste identities had not vanished; on the contrary, they had hardened—as evident from their resilience in the matrimonial market—but castes could not be situated in a vertical arrangement any more: they were on a horizontal plane fighting in the public sphere, as in any democratic arena. In fact, caste-based reservations contributed to give birth to political parties with agendas dominated by their commitment to defend the implementation of quotas—so much so that these pressure groups led mainstream parties like the Congress to make caste-based reservations even more systematic, as evident from the decision of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, by the end of his first term, to reserve 27% of the places in the public higher education institutions to the OBCs, a measure that is known as 'Mandal II' because it had been suggested by the Mandal Commission but also because it was taking India one step further on the same route as the 1990 Mandal affair. For the opponents of this brand of positive discrimination, it was institutionalizing an institution—caste—that was supposed to be eradicated by these very public policies. However, to what extent has politics become more casteist in India over the last 30 years?

The Congress and the BJP: mainstream parties and antidotes to casteism?

If caste were a key variable in Indian politics, it should be reflected in the programs and the sociology of the two parties that have dominated the Indian political scene for almost 20 years: the Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). This is not the case, even if caste has become a more important factor for both parties.

The Congress, a catch-all party par excellence

Caste—like religion and language—has not been a legitimate identity marker for the Congress leaders who, since Mahatma Gandhi and Nehru, claim that their party represents all the citizens of India irrespective of their primordial links. In practice things have been more complicated, of course. Indira Gandhi and her son Rajiv have not been strictly secular, for instance, as evident from the Shah Bano affairs in the mid-1980s. However, after playing 'the Muslim card' (to use a phrase with which the Indian media are familiar), Rajiv tried to woo the Hindu voters by starting his 1989 election campaign from Faizabad, the headquarters of Ayodhya, the sacred city of Lord Ram which was then at the center of the Ramjanmabhoomi movement. Similarly, if the Congress plays 'caste cards,' it is not associated with one caste in particular. In fact, it is known for

Table 9.1 Evolution of the Congress vote by social group, 1967–2009

<i>Castes and tribes</i>	<i>% in population¹</i>	<i>1967</i>	<i>1971</i>	<i>1980</i>	<i>1996</i>	<i>1998</i>	<i>1999²</i>	<i>2004</i>	<i>2009</i>			
Upper castes	17.6	41.1	45.6	35.8	28.4	28.1	21	22	26			
Dominant castes ³							31	24	25			
OBC	52	38	39.4	42	21.7	22.5	35	Lower OBC 23	Upper OBC 24	Lower OBC 27	Upper OBC 22	
Scheduled Castes	15.05	49.4	47.8	50.5	31.6	29.6	40	26	27			
Scheduled Tribes	7.51	46.2	41.2	48.6	39.2	41.9	49	36	39			

Notes: ¹ These figures draw from the Mandal commission report. ² These figures concern the Congress and its allies.

³ As defined by M.N. Srinivas, a dominant caste is locally the most numerous and the most landed caste group.

amalgamating voters with contrasting caste backgrounds, as evident from the surveys by the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies.

Table 9.1 shows that the Congress attracted voters from all the caste groups. Of all of the three major categories registered in the 1967 survey—the first of its kind—between 38% and 49% supported the ruling party. The only caste group that was significantly underrepresented among the Congress voters were the OBCs. The fact that the Congress was not associated with any caste group in particular was evident from the over-representation among its voters of categories that were situated at the two poles of the social hierarchy: the upper castes at the top and the Dalits at the bottom of the pyramid. This state of affairs was one of the reasons why Paul Brass described the Congress sociology as relying on a ‘coalition of extremes’ in Uttar Pradesh (UP), the state where this arrangement was in evidence.⁵

The Congress started to decline in the second half of the 1980s, but in 1989 the Brahmins, the SCs, the Scheduled Tribes (STs) and the Muslims were still over-represented within the Congress (I) electorate. According to an opinion poll survey carried out after the 1989 elections, in which the Congress (I) won 39.5% of the valid votes, it received the support of 41% of the Brahmins who were interviewed, 44.2% of the SCs/STs, and 45.8% of the Muslims.⁶ Furthermore, when the Congress continued to lose ground, its losses were almost evenly distributed. True, between 1967 and 2009 its attraction vis-à-vis the upper caste was divided by less than two, when it was divided by more than two among the Dalits. However, with 27% of the Dalits supporting the Congress, the party is still first among them.

The BJP, an inverted pyramid?

Like its predecessor, the Bharatiya Jana Sangh (BJS), the BJP is even less willing than the Congress to admit that it pays attention to caste. The party aspires to embody the Indian nation (and more especially to represent the Hindus who, according to its ideologues, embody and epitomize the Indian nation). For the Hindu nationalists, castes are nefarious lines of cleavage which divide the nation. Certainly, this discourse reflects the interests of upper-caste elites who claim that caste conflicts are minor ones in order to retain their privileges, and the ethos—as well as the social composition—of the BJP is clearly Brahminical, something the Dalits have been prompt to realize. However, the BJP has been able to attract low castes which were not offered any special niche in the Congress Party. Not only has the BJP nominated many OBC candidates to contest state and general elections, but these candidates and others have attracted OBC voters in large numbers.

Table 9.2 Castes and tribes among the BJS and BJP voters

Castes and tribes	% in population	1971	1980	1996 ¹	1998 ¹	1999		2004		2009	
Upper castes		6.7	17.1	23.6	38.5	46		38		34	
Dominant castes								26		15	
OBCs		3.5	10	23.6	34.6	Lower OBC	Upper OBC	L O	U O	L O	U O
						19	21	24	22	22	22
SCs		2.1	14.3	14.4	20.9	12		13		12	
STs		4.1	5.4	19	25.6	19		28		23	

Note: ¹ BJP and its allies.

Source: For 1971–98, surveys by the CSDS data unit cited in Mitra and Singh 1999: 135–37; for 1999, *Frontline* 1999: 32; and for 2004 and 2009, Yadav and Palshikar 2009: 41.

Table 9.2 shows that while the BJP could not attract Dalits and has become the favorite party of the upper castes, more than one-fifth of the OBCs vote for it, a figure close to that of the Congress. Certainly, the BJP is not a catch-all party like the Congress, but it is not an inverted pyramid either: while the upper castes are massively over-represented, the OBCs are not absent from its ranks: far from it.

The 2009 elections: is India back to square one?

The idea, supported by the sociology of the two largest parties, that Indian politics was not that dependent on ascriptive identities, including caste, gained momentum after the 2009 elections. The key word of many commentators then was ‘renationalization,’ by which they meant that the Congress was being given a new mandate after five years in office—something no party had been able to achieve since 1971. The inclusive and multicultural polity that the party was promoting had succeeded in marginalizing the parochial and communal agendas of others.

Certainly, the 2009 elections were more ‘issue based’ than many others. The National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA), which institutes a minimum guaranteed wage (amounting to 100 days of work hours per annum, at government-fixed rates) to all rural casual workers has been remarkably popular and supported by the voters;⁷ the Right to Information Act, which obliges the bureaucracy to explain its decisions when asked by concerned citizens has also been well received, not only by the intelligentsia but by many peasants who use it. The urban middle class also appreciated the 2008 nuclear deal with the USA, through which Washington agreed to transfer civil nuclear energy technology to India in spite of the fact that the country had not signed the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), not only for the mark of international recognition it represented, but also because of its implications in terms of energy.

Politics have been also ‘renationalized’ because of the attractiveness of Congress leaders who embody multiculturalism. The prestige of the party President Sonia Gandhi has improved since 2004 because of the way she then gave up the trappings of executive power when she decided not to be the prime minister. Manmohan Singh, the outgoing prime minister, is also largely respected because of his reputation for integrity.

If the 2009 elections reflect some renationalization because of the role of these key leaders and the issues mentioned above, this development does not mean that the Congress is back to its heyday of previous decades, nor that politics has been de-ethnicized and emancipated from caste more especially.

The caste-based mosaic of Indian politics

The argument according to which Indian politics is emancipating from casteism because of the success of a Congress Party that is good at renationalizing politics is flawed in many ways. First, the Congress—and all the national parties for that matter—have not been able to contain the irrepressible rise of regional parties. Second, the relevant units of political analysis in India are more and more the states of the Indian Union—not only for the regional parties, but for the national ones too—and there caste continues to play an increasingly important role. Third, among the Dalits, a caste party, the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), is acquiring a national aura.

The myth of the re-nationalization of party politics

The impact of the capacity of the Congress and the BJP to gather together caste groups which may be poles apart must not be exaggerated given the fact that both parties have represented less than 50% of the voters since 1996. Their erosion has continued since then, one election after another, because of the difficulties of the Congress or the BJP—or both, as in 2004. The great beneficiaries of this structural decline of the big parties have been parties that really exist only in one state. These parties may be regionalist (advocating a cultural identity like the Dravidian parties in Tamil Nadu), or simply regional (like the BJD and JD(U) which hardly matter outside, respectively, Orissa and Bihar).

The rise of the regional parties reflects the growing importance of the states as the arenas of politics by excellence in today's India. Now, at the state level, caste plays a much more significant role at the time of elections, even for the Congress and the BJP.

States are often caste-based political arenas

Many of the regional parties, which now represent half of the Indian voters, are associated with one caste. This is largely due to the fact that the states themselves are often identified with a few jatis. This is the logical outcome of the redrawing of the map of India according to the linguistic criterion, a process which started in the 1950s. In fact, this redrawing of the frontiers of the state in great part stemmed from the demands of dominant castes. In 1947 India had inherited from the British Raj provinces with borders that had no cultural coherence. Most of them had been decided arbitrarily and gathered together several linguistic groups. The demand for linguistic states was spelled out in purely cultural terms—linguistic communities asked for homogenous entities for the sake of communication and education—but it was mostly articulated by dominant castes which spread, precisely, on the era of one vernacular language each. As a result of the redrawing of the Indian map, the Maratha became the dominant caste of Maharashtra, for instance.⁸ However, in most of the states there were two dominant castes. In Andhra Pradesh, Kammas and Reddys were locked in rivalry. In Karnataka, this was the case of the Vokkaligas and the Lingayats.

After the redrawing of the states' boundaries, these castes tended to align themselves with one party (for instance, the Kammas opted for the Communist Party of India (CPI) and the Reddys with the Congress), so much so that CPI was the brand name, but 'Kamma' the subtext. After some time these dominant castes decided to start their own party. The Kammas, to continue with this example, started the Telugu Desham Party (TDP) in the early 1980s, the very reference to the state language reflecting the claim of the party to represent Andhra Pradesh at large. The party leader, N.T. Rama Rao, a popular film actor, won the elections for the first time in 1983. However, the two-party system opposing the Reddy-supported Congress and the Kamma-supported TDP was disturbed by the emergence of a newcomer in 2008, the Praja Rajyam Party (PRP)

supported by a caste benefiting from rapid upward social mobility, the Kapus. Also a popular film actor, Chiranjeevi was responsible for launching a party that was conceived as a caste-based electoral machine:

Primarily, it emerged out of the aspiration of the elite among the Kapu community to see their man at the helm of the state government. In recent times they seem to have nurtured a grievance that under the rule of the Congress and the TDP only the other two communities, namely, the Reddys and the Kammas, exercised supreme political power although the Kapus enjoy analogous social status and are numerically as large as these communities. They were resentful of the asymmetry between their rise in social and economic prominence and their role as junior partners in power.⁹

A few months after his creation, the PRP was able to win 16% of the valid votes in Andhra Pradesh in 2009, thanks to the support of the Kapus. Some 59% of them voted for the PRP, 59% of the Kammas voted for the TDP and 59% of the Reddys voted for the Congress,¹⁰ a graphic illustration of the role of caste groups behind the electoral performances of parties at the state level, even when they claim that their ideology and politics are universalistic or multicultural.

None of the castes associated with political parties voted fully for one party: 59% is far from 100%. There may be many reasons why the 41% remaining have chosen a party not identified with their caste. First, in some constituencies, two parties or more might have nominated a candidate of the same caste, a commonplace development in places where intra-caste factionalism has developed. Second, citizens may not choose a party that is associated with their caste because they do not like it (charges of corruption, profiles of the candidates, past records, etc., naturally influence individual choices). However, the general pattern of voting behavior in India suggests that in 2009, 'caste or community continues to be the primary building bloc of political affiliation at the micro level.'¹¹

Indeed, there are many states in which the majority of a caste group aligns itself with one party. This is more true in states where a two-party system is well entrenched. In Rajasthan 74% of the Brahmins, 59% of the Jats and 55% of the Rajputs vote for the BJP when 66% of the Dalits vote for the Congress.¹² In Punjab 58% of the upper-caste Hindus voted for the Congress and 36% of them for the BJP and its Sikh ally, the SAD. For the Jat Sikhs, it is the contrary: 37% vote for the former and 54% for the latter.¹³ In Bihar, the Yadavs—a large OBC caste of cattlemen—continue to vote for the RJD of Laloo Prasad Yadav, whereas the upper caste sick to the BJP and its state ally, the JD(U): in six elections out of eight, between 63% and 77% of them have supported this coalition.¹⁴

One may wonder why and how a caste aligns itself with a party? To answer this question we must remember that caste groups are not only identity groups any more, but also interest

Table 9.3 National and regional parties, 1991–2009 (in % of valid votes)¹

Parties	1991	1996	1998	1999	2004	2009
Congress	36.26	28.80	25.82	28.30	26.53	28.52
BJP	20.11	20.29	25.59	23.75	22.16	18.84
Total	56.37	49.09	51.41	52.05	48.59	47.36
Regional parties	43.63	50.71	48.59	47.95	51.41	52.54
Grand Total	100	100	100	100	100	100

Notes: ¹ According to the list of national parties established by the Election Commission, except the Congress and BJP.
Source: Election Commission of India.

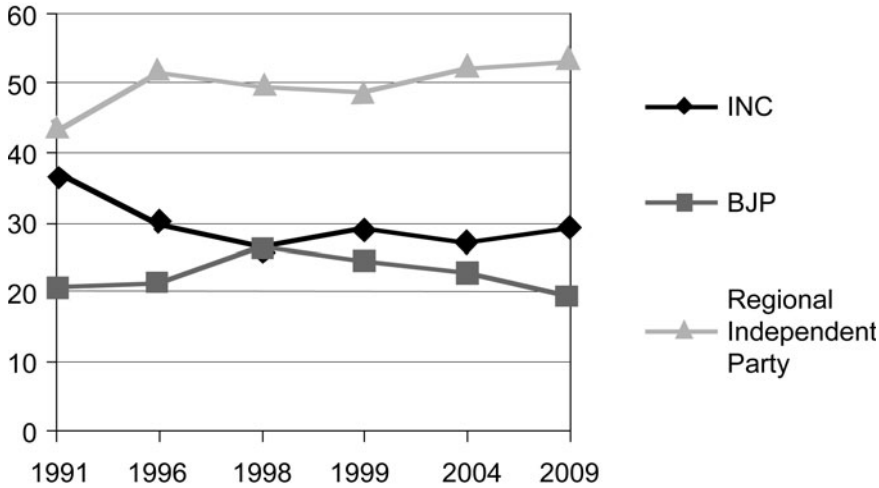


Figure 9.1 Vote share of the Congress, BJP and the other parties since 1991

groups. Therefore, the members of a caste will look for the party that may represent and promote not only their identity, but also their interests. For this, they will trust a party whose leader is from the same caste or whose candidates may be principally of the same caste or whose ally is associated for the reasons mentioned before with the same caste. How, though, do people who might be illiterate know all this and manage to adopt the same voting pattern? Indian society is highly politicized. People do not need to know how to read in order to talk about politics and if they vote their caste while casting their vote, it is because they are aware fully of the social conflicts that structure the local public sphere: they do not need to enter into widespread consultation in order to make up their mind—they think they know who would help them, and who would not, if voted into power.¹⁵

The BSP or the making of a Dalit party

So far, we have concentrated our attention on the caste-driven voting pattern of individual jatis or large aggregates like the upper castes, mostly at the state level. However, a new development needs to be scrutinized in a separate section: the emergence of a Dalit party which gives a new dimension to the casteization of the Indian polity because in this case several SC jatis are converging in a common Dalit political culture, not only at the state level, but at an all-India level.

The building of a pan-Indian Dalit party was the goal of Dr. Ambedkar for 20 years. He successively initiated the Independent Labour Party (1935), the Scheduled Caste Federation (1942) and the Republican Party of India (1956), but none of these made an impact, largely because individual Dalit jatis were not prepared to join hands and together support the same party. In fact, the Mahars—Ambedkar's caste fellows—were the only ones who tended to support his parties.

The BSP (party of the masses), which was founded in 1984 by a disciple of Ambedkar, Kanshi Ram, has gradually overcome this handicap. It has emerged gradually to become a full-fledged Dalit party because it was in a position to cash in on the development of a Dalit counter-culture (including a poignant literature) and positive discrimination programs that gave birth to a Dalit middle class likely to organize itself and to organize its caste fellows. The BSP

Table 9.4 The Dalit vote for the BSP in seven states (in %)

States	% of Dalit votes
Chhattisgarh	27
Delhi	23
Haryana	57
Madhya Pradesh	Jatavs: 27 Other Dalits: 6
Maharashtra	Mahars: 15 Buddhist Dalits: 37 Other Dalits: 9
Punjab	Hindu Dalits: 21 Sikh Dalits: 14
Uttar Pradesh	Jatavs: 85 Pasis: 64 Other Dalits: 61

Source: Verma 2009: 97.

benefited, too, from the public policies the government of Uttar Pradesh was in a position to design when the BSP took part in it (and even directed it) in the 1990s as coalition partner of the BJP or the Samajwadi Party. As these policies were intended to promote the interests of the Dalits at large, all the Dalit jatis were susceptible to be favorably inclined towards the BSP.

The 2009 elections showed that, indeed, the BSP is not the party of one Uttar Pradesh jati, the Chamars (the caste of its leader in the state, Mayawati), but the party of the UP Dalits at large and even a party for Dalits living outside Uttar Pradesh, as is evident from Table 9.4.

Since no individual Dalit jati represents more than 20% of the SCs in any state of India, the figures in Table 9.4 suggest that in Chhattisgarh, Delhi and, of course, Haryana, non-Chamars (or Jatavs) Dalits voted for the BSP in 2009. The same table makes this point explicit in the case of Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Punjab and Uttar Pradesh, where the party is now a full-fledged Dalit party since more than 60% of all Dalit jatis, which used to be locked in rivalry (especially the Chamars or Jatavs and the Pasis, or Dusadh), are now supporting the BSP together.

With 21% of the Dalits voting for the BSP (against 27% voting for the Congress), the party has become the third party of India, ahead of the CPI (Marxist) in 2009. This is the first caste-based and caste-oriented party to climb on the podium of the national parties (to be recognized as a ‘national party’—and not as a state party only—a party needs, among other things, to win more than 5% of the valid votes).

In February/March 2012 the BSP was shaken by a serious setback in the state of UP. Certainly its defeat is not as dramatic as its loss of seats suggests: while the party tally was reduced from 206 to 80 seats, its share of valid votes remained very high. In fact, the BSP’s performance was only reduced by 4.5 percentage points from 31.5% to 26.0% of the valid votes. However, the disturbing dimension of this result—if one goes by the CSDS surveys—lies in the declining popularity of the BSP among its Dalit supporters, including the Jatavs (from 86% to 62%) and the Balmikis (from 71% to 42%)—interestingly, the Pasis rallied behind the BSP in larger numbers (from 53% to 57%).¹⁶ In spite of this setback, the BSP remains clearly identified with the Dalits, and more especially the Jatavs.

Conclusion

The transformation of castes into interest groups, resulting in the erosion of the caste *system*, mostly under the influence of positive discrimination programs, has had a strong impact on the political system of India. Certainly, the largest parties—the Congress and the BJP—are not to be associated with an individual caste at an all-India level, but they usually are at the state level. Now, state politics is taking over national politics, more and more because of the decline of mainstream parties vis-à-vis regional parties, which are indispensable for the formation of a ruling

coalition at the center. In these vernacular arenas that are the states, parties are usually associated with one caste, especially with dominant castes, even in places where the party system includes more than two players. Besides state politics, the pervasiveness of caste considerations also stems from the emergence of a more-than-one-state-one-jati party, the BSP.

If the 2009 general elections have been analyzed as marking a renationalization of Indian politics, this is clearly a symptom of the 'interpretative deficit' that Palshikar and Yadav regretted in their own account of these polls.¹⁷ In fact, the success of the Congress which gave rise to this wrong interpretation was itself a result of the growing fragmentation of the party system, the largest party being in a position to win with fewer votes when it faced more opponents in a first-past-the-post electoral system.¹⁸ Now, several of the new parties are caste based, like the PRP, which, in Andhra Pradesh, was intended to give a voice to an upwardly mobile caste, the Kapus.

Notes

- 1 M.N. Srinivas, *Social Change in Modern India*, New Delhi: Orient Longman, 1995, 6.
- 2 Ibid.
- 3 For an overview of the reservation policy of the British, see B.A.V. Sharma, 'Development of Reservation Policy,' in B.A.V. Sharma and K.M. Reddy, eds, *Reservation Policy in India*, New Delhi: Light and Light Publishers, 1982.
- 4 Ibid., 2–3.
- 5 P. Brass, 'The Politicization of the Peasantry in a North Indian State—Part II,' *Journal of Peasant Studies* 8(1) (October 1980): 3–36.
- 6 *India Today*, April, 15 1991: 53.
- 7 According to the CSDS exit poll, 31% of the rural poor and 29% of the rural very poor said that they had benefited from the NREGA, which is more than the level of support for any other previous or existing poverty-alleviation program. See Yogendra Yadav and Suhas Palshikar, 'Between Fortuna and Virtue: Explaining the Congress' Ambiguous Victory in 2009,' *Economic and Political Weekly* Vol.XLIV, No.39 (September 26, 2009).
- 8 Something Ambedkar had anticipated and feared.
- 9 K.C. Suri, P. Narasimha Rao, V. Anji Reddy, 'Andhra Pradesh: A Vote for Status Quo?' *Economic and Political Weekly* Vol.XLIV, No.39 (September 26, 2009): 110–11.
- 10 Ibid.: 112.
- 11 Yogendra Yadav and Suhas Palshikar, 'Between Fortuna and Virtue: Explaining the Congress' Ambiguous Victory in 2009,' *Economic and Political Weekly* Vol.XLIV, No.39 (September 26, 2009): 38.
- 12 Sanjay Lodha, 'Rajasthan: Performance and Campaigning Paid Dividends,' *Economic and Political Weekly* Vol.XLIV, No.39 (September 26, 2009): 189.
- 13 A. Kumar and J.S. Sekhon, 'Punjab: Resurgence of the Congress,' *Economic and Political Weekly* Vol.XLIV, No.39 (September 26, 2009): 185.
- 14 S. Kumar and R. Rajan, 'Bihar: Development Matters,' *Economic and Political Weekly* Vol.XLIV, No.39 (September 26, 2009): 143.
- 15 This does not mean that electoral campaigns do not play a role in the coordination of this collective action par excellence that is caste-based voting patterns.
- 16 'Special Statistics: 2012 State Elections', *Economic and Political Weekly* Vol.XLVII (147) (April 2012): 81.
- 17 Yogendra Yadav and Suhas Palshikar, 'Between Fortuna and Virtue: Explaining the Congress' Ambiguous Victory in 2009,' *Economic and Political Weekly* Vol.XLIV, No.39 (September 26, 2009): 33.
- 18 For more details on this point see C. Jaffrelot and G. Verniers, 'India's 2009 Elections: The Resilience of Regionalism and Ethnicity,' *SAMAJ* No.3 (2010).

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10

DALIT POLITICS

Untouchability, identity, and assertion

Hugo Gorringe

Introduction

Dalit, the Marathi term meaning downtrodden, implies ‘those who have been broken, ground down by those above them in a deliberate and active way’ (Zelliot 1996: 267). Since the 1970s, it has been adopted increasingly by those at the foot of the caste hierarchy across India. Rejecting other appellations, activists seeking equality, justice and the implementation of the constitution have opted to highlight their continued oppression by calling themselves what they are (downtrodden). The term thus, Zelliot continues, contains ‘an inherent denial of pollution, *karma*, and justified caste hierarchy.’ Dalits—previously called untouchables, outcastes, depressed classes, *harijans* and *panchamas* (see Charsley 1996)—were those condemned to perform the most menial and degrading jobs, and considered to be carriers of pollution. Now, in calling themselves Dalits, activists have inverted the stigma associated with their lowly status. Although not all former untouchables use or recognize the term, it is widely employed in local, national and global politics and carries legitimacy in its stance against caste discrimination.

Indeed, in 2010, when the first black president of the USA addressed the Indian Parliament he paid homage to Dr. Ambedkar, the first law minister of India and pre-eminent champion of the lowest castes, referring to him as a Dalit. Seated alongside Barack Obama as he made that speech was Meira Kumar, the speaker of the house and also a former untouchable. Around that time Mayawati, the Dalit Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh, was touted as a potential future prime minister despite leading a mainly Dalit party. Notwithstanding her position and achievements, in 2008 a dominant caste farmers’ leader abused Mayawati in casteist terms from a public platform. The strength of feeling inspired by caste and the distance still to be travelled towards equality may be seen in the fact that neither of the two main political parties condemned the abuse. Would such silence have been acceptable had an opposition leader ridiculed Obama in racial terms? Whilst the Constitution of Independent India rendered untouchability a criminal offence and identified a number of ‘Scheduled Castes’ (SCs) as requiring positive discrimination to offset generations of subordination, it is the language of Dalithood and mobilization on that basis that has animated the fight against caste.

This chapter offers an overview of Dalit mobilization and engagement with politics starting with the colonial period. It provides a brief introduction to pre- and post-independence Dalit politics, parties and outcomes. For all the successes of Dalit politics, some have questioned its

ability to articulate an alternative (Omvedt 1994), to push on from its initial successes (Shah 2004), or to improve the lives of those it claims to represent (Pai 2002). I will, therefore, chart some of the diverse ways in which Dalits have sought to challenge caste hegemony. Whilst autonomous Dalit parties have increasingly gained political recognition and victories, they cannot be divorced from the social conditions faced by the majority of Dalits. Dalit parties, as Pai (2002) puts it, are always also social movements. Looking beyond political institutions reveals the social and cultural aspects of the Dalit struggle in fields such as religion, arts and literature. Dalit movements also operate on multiple scales: highlighting atrocities and practices of untouchability at the local level; forging alliances and raising demands at the national level; and engaging allies, institutions and governments across the world. Even as it has gained global currency, however, the term Dalit has lost some of its resonance for those on the ground and some Dalits across India are envisioning a post-Dalit future. I conclude by considering what such a future might look like, but begin by looking back to the origins of Dalit politics.

Roots of resistance: caste, colonialism and Independence

‘If traditional scholarship on caste were to be accepted,’ Gupta (2005: 411) observes, ‘then even those who were considered low or impure in the ritual order would consider their position to be just and befitting their status.’ Indeed, as recently as 1979, Moffatt concluded that untouchables accepted the cultural underpinnings of the dominant social order. Conceived like this, caste is a consensual, functional and harmonious system. More recently, however, historical research and advances in the theoretical understanding of power have suggested alternate ways of understanding caste (Gorringe and Rafanell 2007; Mosse 2007). Such work points to the antecedents of contemporary Dalit movements in the egalitarian *bhakti* (devotional) cults dating back to the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries (Zelliot 1996); in cases of flight or migration (Srinivas 1991); in conversion to ‘casteless’ religions like Buddhism, Sikhism, Islam or Christianity (Webster 1992); and in instances where whole castes—such as the Nadars in Tamil Nadu—attained upward mobility with political, economic and educational assets (Hardgrave 1969). Resistance of this nature, however, was rarely widespread, systematic or organized. It was the onset of British rule that paved the way for the modern Dalit movement.

The Raj unwittingly contributed to subaltern—including Dalit—mobilization in multiple ways. The move towards a centralized state expanded the horizons of previously segmented groups, opening up the possibilities for trans-local relationships, identities and politics. This process was augmented by the creation of meaningful pan-Indian categories like the depressed classes around which disparate *jatis* (local caste groups) could coalesce. If such categories provided identity options, the collection of census data by caste served to delineate and animate caste boundaries, enabling the emergence of state-wide caste associations (Rudolph and Rudolph 1967). Simultaneously, colonialism resulted in the separation of social and state power. This opened up avenues for social protest and mobility: those facing caste discrimination could now appeal to British courts; those wishing to change their social status could lobby census officials; those seeking caste-neutral jobs had greater opportunities; educational institutions were provided for (or opened to) lower castes; and improvements in transport infrastructure enhanced the movement of people and ideas (Omvedt 1994; Shah 2001; Jaffrelot 2003). Furthermore, commercialization, as Bayly (1988: 11) argues, meant not just the increase in the use of money in the economy but also ‘the use of objective monetary values to express social relationships.’ In short, these socio-structural changes eroded established hierarchies, and challenged the authority of dominant castes, monarchs and spiritual leaders (Dirks 1987). As a consequence, the gradual introduction of the institutions of self-governance was attended by multiple expressions of caste politics.

Six (overlapping) political currents in the pre-independence phase influenced and continue to shape the contours of Dalit politics. These are communist parties, Dravidian or non-Brahmin parties, the institution of reservations, Gandhi's views on untouchability, Ambedkar's politics, and the rise of Hindu nationalism. Communist or socialist movements in India have perceived the class struggle to be paramount and sought to unite the poor of all castes. Although there have been successful campaigns by peasants and agricultural workers (see Gough 1991), and state governments in Kerala and West Bengal have improved human development indicators, the lowest castes have tended to be excluded from leadership. They have been *represented*, rather than representing themselves. Even today Maoist or Naxalite movements emerge from the discrimination faced by the impoverished but are rarely led by them. 'Non-Brahmin' politics extended leadership beyond the highest castes, especially in the south where there are fewer representatives of the Kshatriya *varna* (or warrior class), and intermediate and lower castes mobilized around that administrative category (Irschick 1969; Gorringe 2005). Although they varied across states, most non-Brahmin movements gained forms of affirmative action and challenged Brahmin superiority and power. In northern states, by contrast, caste constituencies and landholding patterns precluded such developments (Jaffrelot 2003).

Already in the maneuvering of non-Brahmin castes we can see the influence of quota or reservation politics. Quotas for members of the SCs were introduced as early as 1892. The structure of reservations subsequently expanded significantly and remains central to Indian politics. Although reserved places in educational institutions and government jobs have had limited impact due to the number of unfilled places and the preponderance of SCs in more menial positions, they have facilitated the emergence of a Dalit middle class from which the leadership of contemporary Dalit movements is drawn (Shah 2001; Pai 2002; Jaffrelot 2003). The results of reservations in the political arena have been more ambiguous, largely due to the opposition between Gandhian and Ambedkarite visions of caste. Whilst Gandhi led the struggle for a free and united India, Ambedkar questioned the value of Independence under upper-caste rule (Gorringe 2008). Both saw untouchability as evil, but they articulated fundamentally different prescriptions for caste reform: Gandhi portrayed a functional system of socioeconomic cooperation in which each caste fulfilled different but equally essential roles. The key task before Hindus, therefore, was to embrace manual workers and lower castes as equals. Ambedkar, by contrast, felt that caste was inimical to equality and he confronted it through social agitation, political engagement and, ultimately, conversion to Buddhism (Zelliot 1996).

This clash of ideologies had material political consequences. At the Round Table Conference in 1931 Ambedkar argued that the untouchables could not select candidates who represented their interests unless they were empowered to vote separately from the rest of the population. When he won the argument, Gandhi went on a 'fast unto death.' Separate electorates, he insisted, would drive an irreversible wedge between the untouchables and the rest of (Hindu) society much as the Morley Minto reforms of 1909 were seen to have encouraged divisive Muslim nationalism. Ambedkar was forced into a corner, and the resultant Poona Pact established that there would be constituencies that were reserved for untouchable *candidates* (in proportion to their population), but were open to all voters (Zelliot 1996: 168). Since Dalits do not form a majority in any constituency, 'non-Dalits decide which Dalit should win' (Larbeer, in Gorringe 2005: 309). Requiring each party to field Dalit candidates, furthermore, means that Dalit leaders are badly divided and beholden to particular parties which 'tends to produce compliant and accommodating leaders' (Galanter 1991: 549). Reservations have, nevertheless, proved to be politically contentious and when the Mandal Commission (see Jaffrelot, this volume) recommended extending quotas to other low castes, advocates of the report clashed with higher caste adversaries. Mandal threatened the unity of the category Hindu, and was both a reaction to, and

further catalyst for, the politics of Hindutva (Muralidharan 1990). If nothing else, Mandal demonstrated the continued strength of caste sentiment.

Identity and its discontents

India, Corbridge and Harriss (2000: 21) argue, experienced a 'passive revolution' which saw radical changes in legislation and planning but stymied grassroots assertion or actual socio-structural reform. Some effects of such a 'revolution' can filter down and generate change—not least through a 'revolution of rising expectations'—and this encapsulates developments in Dalit politics. Disillusioned by the compromises built into the process Ambedkar declared that he himself would burn the constitution and led a mass conversion to Buddhism to emphasize his rejection of Hinduism (Omvedt 1994). Thus, whilst Congress was able to secure the support of a broad cross-section of society (including Dalits) in the post-war years, their legitimacy was always subject to question as reforms failed to match either legislation or rhetoric (Rawat 2003). Frustrated at the slow pace of change and the inability of Dalit parties to make political inroads, and inspired by struggles around the world, new Dalit movements emerged in the 1970s and 1980s. This wave of assertion is best characterized by the Dalit Panthers of Maharashtra who echoed the struggles of the Black Panthers in the USA and operated in social, cultural and political spheres (Joshi 1986). This phase witnessed the emergence of Dalit arts and literature and saw a revival of actions that confronted untouchability head-on by walking down high-caste streets, smashing up tea stalls that used separate receptacles for Dalits, and so on.

This phase, which gradually spread across much of the country, signaled a rejection of established parties and the 'token representation' (McMillan 2005) afforded by the election of 'tame' SC candidates. Kanshi Ram (1982)—who founded the Backward and Minorities Community Employees Federation (BAMCEF) which organized elite members of the SCs and the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) (see Pai, this volume)—captured this spirit of assertion in referring to Dalit politicians as *chamchas* (stooges). He portrayed them as 'internal others' and called for autonomous organization to achieve meaningful change. The issue of autonomy is crucial here. Initially it meant Dalit parties that were independent from, and opposed to, established political players. States across India witnessed the emergence of Dalit parties operating outside institutional politics before entering the political arena. Increasingly, however, the inability of such parties to gain electoral success saw their autonomy eroded. Dalit politics came to mean mobilization under Dalit leadership even if those parties were subsequently co-opted and incorporated (Omvedt 1994).

The premise of identity politics (or the politics of recognition) is that the oppressed can and should represent themselves. It presumes the pre-eminence of one out of the multiple identities available to (and assumed by) the group. Thus a Dalit is presumed to be a Dalit despite also being a worker, a woman, a Tamil, a parent, a Paraiyar and an Indian (not to mention possible affiliations to green politics or sports which may shape their self-definition). The forms of identity that can be adopted, however, are socially delimited. Despite his outstanding achievements, for instance, the President of India, K.R. Narayanan, was routinely depicted as a Dalit. He was pigeon-holed into a category of origin that was deemed to say more about him than any other label. The politicization of a chosen identity, in other words, can crystallize social boundaries (Gorringe 2005).

Identity-based Dalit mobilization has given the lie to the notion of Congress and others as 'umbrella parties' that represent the interests of diverse social groups. Collective action has mobilized previously inactive citizens, increased their consciousness of rights, raised the issues in the public domain and opened the portals of institutional politics to hitherto unrepresented and

marginalized actors and issues. Furthermore, by mobilizing around a stigmatized identity, Dalits successfully challenged stigma and offered a (re)celebration of hitherto neglected or despised cultural forms. Given the centrality of notions of honor to everyday interaction across India, the struggle for self-esteem is critical in the search for socio-political inclusion. Symbolic politics have been central to this endeavor. Dalit movements have colonized the public sphere both physically (through marches, fasts and rallies) and symbolically (Gorringe 2005; Waghmore 2010). A process of 'Ambedkarization,' especially since 1990 (his centenary year), has seen statues, street and estate names, portraits, murals, posters and plaques pay homage to Ambedkar in many states. He is usually depicted as a blue-suited, bespectacled man with a large book (representing the constitution) under one arm. These statues stand as metonyms for Dalit assertion and the unfinished business of nation building. Though all parties now honor Ambedkar's birthday, it is Dalits who perceive him as one of their own and jealously guard his image—resorting to violence where it is demeaned (Jaoul 2006).

There is a paradox here. Whilst the occupation of public spaces with such symbols inspires Dalits with aspirations and pride, Ravikumar—activist-theoretician of the Dalit movement and Tamil Member of the Legislative Assembly (MLA) in 2006–11—argues that 'if we allow caste pride, we can never achieve the annihilation of caste, nor even equality among castes' (Ravikumar 2009: 280). Indeed, Dalit movements have prompted the formation of (often aggressive) counter-movements which have responded to Dalit assertion with 'extravagant revenge' (Mendelsohn and Vicziany 1998: 54). The phrase describes instances in which challenges to caste norms (such as walking down a high-caste street or wearing Western clothes) have been met by disproportionate violence calculated to 'keep Dalits in their place.' Radical Dalit groups have responded by advocating a counter-violence of the oppressed—a strategy that has, at best, mixed results (Gorringe 2006; Jaoul 2008). Alongside the jubilation at shedding a 'slave mentality' has been the anguish and fear that attends caste atrocities. Exclusive mobilization can rob Dalits of their individuality by casting them as representative of the entire group (and punishable as such) (cf. Shah *et al.* 2006). Sectoral mobilization can also limit successes, as when movement demands are met by compartmentalizing the issues and creating a 'commissioner for Scheduled Castes.' Such legal exceptionalism, Rao (2009) argues, reinforces distinctions and increases vulnerability in the act of legislating against it.

Such politics also raise questions pertaining to organization and constituency: if a group can only be represented by a group member, then who defines the parameters of the group? How specific should identity claims be? Should Dalit movements organize at the national, state or local level, and along lines of category, caste or sub-caste? Furthermore shouldn't due consideration be given to the divergent interests of Dalit women, workers and students? Such questions have partly fuelled the fragmentation of Dalit politics. Most parties are overly centralized, and since Dalit parties tend to lack resources this encourages ambitious secondary leaders to form splinter groups. The rhetoric of authenticity and representation also drives the formation of caste-specific organizations, often in competition with each other for votes, resources or even reservations (as in the demand for sub-reservations within the SC quota). As Omvedt (2001: 156) observes, the rise of independent parties has shattered the image of the Dalits as a homogeneous vote-bank to be bought off in elections. Instead we have 'voting blocs—autonomous, acting on their own and bargaining with the larger parties. But these have proved to be *jati*-based blocs,' thus impairing the transformative potential of a broader Dalit politics, fostering intra-Dalit competition and focusing attention on relative deprivation *between* Dalit castes.

Somewhat more positively, the recognition of identity has resulted in a welcome recognition of gender issues. Given that gender and caste combine to render Dalit women more vulnerable to caste discrimination, the opportunity to voice concerns and highlight issues in 'women's

wings' creates a 'space within the struggle' (Sen 1990). Again, though, the separation of issues means that the female strand of the movement can be accorded secondary importance: 'the caste struggle first and then we'll think about patriarchy,' in a stance that ignores the patriarchal lives of many Dalit activists (Dietrich 1988). Arguably, the goal of commanding or sharing political power has come to dominate Dalit politics. The neglect of gender concerns and the willingness to forge alliances with communal parties suggests an overly political focus, and even where Dalit parties have reached out to non-Dalits, this engagement has been political rather than social (Shah 2001), as witnessed by the problems of reaching out to Muslim and Christian 'Dalits' (Govinda 2009). Whilst the move to politics was partly a response to repression, the emphasis on gaining political power rather than challenging caste in its everyday manifestations means some activists still struggle to eat, drink and work with those from lower Dalit castes (Gorringe and Rafanell 2007).

Dalit politics at an impasse?

Dalit movements, in other words, are being 'institutionalized,' whereby they 'develop internal organisation, become more moderate, adopt a more institutional repertoire of action and integrate into the system of interest representation' (Della Porta and Diani 1999: 148). This process has alienated many supporters (*EPW* 2009a), reinforcing the point that electoral success in itself does not necessarily reflect the interests of the disadvantaged (Jeffery *et al.* 2001). Pai (2002) contends that the BSP primarily pursues empowerment from 'above,' viewing it in purely political terms. The BSP has, thus, allied with parties opposed to Dalit assertion, weakening attempts to eradicate caste inequalities. Dalit parties in Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu have suffered a similar fate (Omvedt 2003), indicating an enduring tension between radical movements seeking to transform social relations and political parties seeking poll success. A scathing *EPW* (2009b) editorial argues that the BSP's politics of symbolism masks a failure to tackle enduring hierarchies and forms of exploitation. Dalit parties' inability to implement policies such as land reform or ensure that atrocities are punished and reservations filled, jars with the increased expectations of followers, resulting in the argument that Dalit politics has 'reached an impasse' (Shah 2004: 131).

Given the successes of Dalit politics, especially in Uttar Pradesh (UP)—where the BSP's formation of state-level governments led some commentators (Kohli 2001; Jaffrelot 2003) to identify a 'Dalit revolution' in northern India even before it won an unparalleled absolute Assembly majority in 2007—some might question the idea of an impasse. The BSP undoubtedly has effected significant social and political alterations in UP, expanded the public sphere and underscored the ability of Dalits to wield political power (Pai 2002; Ciotti 2010), but electoral alliances, voters polled and seats contested say little about the micro-dynamics of caste politics. Jeffrey *et al.* (2008: 1366), therefore, critique the tendency to focus on state- or national-level impacts of political shifts at the expense of 'people's consciousness of political change,' and highlight a 'marked disjuncture between formal political change and ground-level political realities' (*ibid.*: 1392; Lerche 2008). Elsewhere, studies suggest that cadres from established parties refuse to campaign or vote for Dalit coalition partners (Gorringe 2007; Wyatt 2009). The 'impasse,' thus, refers to the fact that significant symbolic victories co-exist with continuing casteism and deprivation (Pai 2009).

Mehrotra's (2006) finding that Tamil Dalits fare better in social indicators than their UP counterparts, suggests that Dalit power is no panacea. Harriss (2006: 238) points to three key variables that impact on the performance of pro-poor policies: first, agrarian power relations and interactions between the local and state level; second, the nature and competitiveness of party systems; and finally, the existence of an organized left that can challenge landed elites and

deliver some agrarian reforms. He also (ibid.: 236) highlights the importance of political participation amongst the lower castes and classes for the implementation of such programs, and the negative impact of upper-caste domination. From this perspective, it is unsurprising that general programs such as the Public Distribution System, the Mid-day Meals Scheme, Employment Guarantee Schemes and basic health and education drives may benefit SCs more than programs targeted specifically at them (which face opposition as a consequence) (Heyer and Jayal 2009). It also highlights the potential (as yet unrealized) of *Panchayat* reservations 'to transform the lived experiences of caste and gender' (ibid.: 14).

Caste, this reminds us, is based on social rather than political relations, meaning that we need to shift our focus beyond formal institutions. Whilst Dalit parties have been said to neglect bottom-up mobilization, Waghmore's (2010) study of Dalit politics in Maharashtra argues that we can only speak of an impasse if we ignore the ferment of activity at the local level where increased awareness is translating into multiple struggles for land, rights and dignity. Perhaps the most enduring legacy of Dalit mobilization will be the erosion of fear and the multiplicity of projects across India which it has spawned to contest caste discrimination and render it socially unacceptable. Dalit literature, arts festivals, histories, writing and nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) all move the issues beyond the institutional realm and open up new spaces in the struggle for equality.

Not the least of these spaces is the increasingly global engagement of Dalit activists. Whilst Dalit politics emerges out of the everyday experiences of caste, it is at the global level where a truly *Dalit* politics transcending markers of caste, class and region has emerged. The declaration that 'Dalit Rights are Human Rights' has seen Dalit mobilization extend beyond the confines of the state (Lerche 2008). Similarly, innumerable Dalit representatives attended the International Conference on Racism in Durban in 2001, and ensured that caste discrimination was placed firmly on the United Nations (UN) agenda (Hardtmann 2009). Dalit leaders addressed the World Social Forum in Mumbai to argue that defeating the twin evils of casteism and communalism required Dalits to unite with other 'radical, progressive and democratic forces' (Thirumaavalavan 2004: 239). They also echoed critiques of neo-liberalism, pointing to their corrosive effect on state provision which is essential for so many Dalits. Operating at the local, regional, national and global spheres, Dalit politics have opened up multiple arenas of resistance and have shifted the 'moorings of caste' (Heyer 2010).

New directions and post-Dalit politics?

Deliège argued that Untouchables suffer from a 'paradoxical marginality,' because they are 'socially excluded but economically indispensable' (Deliège 1997: 104). Their 'paradoxical marginality' clearly extends into the political sphere where Dalits are indispensable to electoral competition as voters, and reserved candidates (very few Dalits stand in general constituencies), but are simultaneously excluded from real decision-making power and responsibility. Since the 1970s Dalit movements have tried to move their concerns into center stage by forming independent parties and voting for themselves. The successes of such parties should not be discounted. Indeed, Ciotti (2010) notes how empowered female BSP activists are shedding the Dalit label—which continues to be a marker of caste, powerlessness and stigma—not in a strategic search for leverage or resources but because it does not capture their experiences. Just as the rejection of harijan and SCs heralded a new phase in the struggle against caste, so might the increased questioning of Dalit signal 'a new politics of caste.'

Dalit parties are deliberately shifting their horizons towards larger constituencies, most notably in the BSP's transformation from *bahujan* to '*savarjan* party' representing all castes and classes (see

Pai, this volume). Ciotti's (2010: 54) analysis suggests that Dalit identity may be a staging post towards a more egalitarian society, but if this applies only to an elite who abandon the less empowered to their victimhood then a 'post-Dalit' politics will be limited indeed. Dalit politics has deepened and democratized India's political institutions and significantly shifted social attitudes. No political party can now ignore Dalit issues, few would question the desirability of equality as a social norm and some blatant expressions of untouchability have declined, as has the dependence of Dalits on higher-caste landlords or patrons. There has been also significant social mobility for middle-class Dalits. Increasing differentiation on class lines, however, brings material concerns to the fore. As Mendelsohn and Vicziany (1998: 270) observe, it would be scant comfort for the Dalits if social liberation were 'attended by perpetual poverty.' If mobilization becomes merely a means to political ends, then the aspirations and ambitions of Dalit citizens will continue to be frustrated and the potential for violence will remain.

'Isolation, political marginalisation and social exclusion are ... central to poverty and need to be addressed before long-term economic initiatives can be successful' (Thorp *et al.* 2005: 917). Heyer's meticulous, longitudinal study of a deprived and marginal Tamil Dalit caste offers an overview of the position of Dalits in a changing economy. She documents the erosion of dependency, the increase in aspirations and education and the rise in political engagement. Despite this, she notes continuing exclusion and discrimination and concludes that, 'It is all too easy to see a future in which their relative position continues to deteriorate, unless they can mobilize effectively to force changes' (Heyer 2010: 241). Dalit politics, in other words, remains as significant to the democratization of India as ever, but it continues to be defined by protest and lacks a coherent transformative agenda (Omvedt 1994; Pai 2002).

Dalit politics has arguably been clouded by the quest for formal power, but democracy is as much a social practice as a system of political representation. Dalit movements have, effectively, been anti-untouchability, not anti-caste. In focusing on state power and mobilizing around caste they not only animate the spirit of status competition on which the caste system is predicated, but neglect the relations and structures that sustain it. There is a certain resignation about the 'compulsions and compromises' of politics, but issues arise when the leadership become divorced from the masses. Thachil and Herring (2008) note that the Hindu Right gained Dalit votes by organizing at the grassroots and providing welfare. Ambedkar arguably failed in elections because he neglected the organizational and programmatic aspects of party development which translated into a lack of popular support (Bandyopadhyay 2000). Contemporary Dalit parties likewise need to confront issues of internal democratization, accountability and openness with regard to leadership, gender, (sub)caste identity and ideology, and nurture the grassroots networking and organization that carried them to power in the first place.

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11

CLASS POLITICS IN INDIA

Euphemization, identity, and power¹

Ronald J. Herring

Class? Politics?

Class is a pervasive force in all societies. Like race, its effects may be subtle or overt, unmentioned in polite society or explosive. The methodological problem is similar: euphemizations of race and class are common; there are strong interests in disguising or denying effects, particularly among those especially advantaged. What we observe empirically is frequently difficult to code, and inevitably entangled with other identities and causes. Partly as a result of uncertainty, partly because of ideological commitments embedded in class analytics historically, mis-recognition of class politics is pervasive.

Class politics in much of the academic literature and media coverage is specifically associated with overtly contentious politics—strikes, lock-outs, demonstrations—or with the electoral politics of parties espousing a class agenda: the rise or fall of ‘the left.’ These behaviors are observable and widely recognized. Their relative infrequency has led many practitioners of dominant scholarship on Indian politics to discount class politics explicitly or implicitly (e.g. Rudolph and Rudolph 1987). There are good reasons for this silence. The effects of class on politics that are not readily observable as proximate causes, but enable and limit conditions for other forms of political behavior, are difficult to access and account for. As James Scott noted for ‘peasant politics,’ the focus on the dramatic and legible struggles obscures and silences the pervasive ‘slow, grinding, quiet struggle’ of rural under-classes in ‘quotidian’ politics of resistance, springing from ‘hidden transcripts’ that challenge the normative order (Scott 1985: 35–36, *passim*). Coding the importance of class politics by whether or not left fronts are winning or losing may reveal little about the pervasive structuring effects of class. Nor is proxy of an essentially relational concept with indicators of individuals such as income or wealth theoretically satisfactory in the context of class structural effects. The discussion that follows sketches some exemplars that indicate uses and limits of class analysis in Indian politics. Proximate and readily observable class politics such as rural insurrection and communist electoral victories will be paralleled by reference to distal structuring effects of class in terms of quiescence, clientelism, populism and social-movement dynamics. Of necessity in so brief a chapter, all will receive only indicative treatment.

What is class?

So many involuted and baroque theoretical discussions have treated this question that we forget the stunning simplicity and power of Marx’s primary formulation: the world made by capitalism

is divided into those who have to sell their labor power in order to survive and those who do not.² The welfare of the former depends on market conditions of supply and demand for commoditized labor power. This fundamental dependency renders life chances typically more precarious and limited than those of citizens who buy labor power and profit from its deployment, or sell less commoditized skilled labor (e.g. professionally certified labor, as in medicine, law, management, etc.). In the simplest terms, class determines what one *must* do to survive and what one is *free* to do (Wright 1997a, 1997b). For all the fussiness in theory, this is the basic class question. Some children must work long hours daily, others are free to attend school, others are free to choose among the best schools. These compulsions and freedoms have life-long, path-dependent effects on skills, networks, cultural capital and life chances generally.

The essential elements of a class framework to explain political phenomena are four: *class structure* (class-in-itself for Marx), *class consciousness* (understanding by individual actors of their objective class interests), *class formation* (collectively organized actors of similar structural position, constituting a class-for-itself in Marx), and *class struggle* (collective practices of actors for the realization of class interests against interests of other classes). A class structure is formally the articulation of classes in a particular society at a particular time, but operationalization creates formidable difficulties. Even what constitutes a class is variable across analysts—and, more critical to class politics, across individuals occupying positions in that imagined class structure. There are both lumpers and splitters of classes, yielding either very few (Marx) or very many (stratification sociology) (Herring and Agarwala 2006). Class politics in a behavioral sense presupposes first a class identity, and shares with other political identities the fundamental problems of variable recognition, salience and stability. For Marx, the central political problem of a class was making the transition from a class-in-itself to a class-for-itself—that is, from objective standing in an economic structure—worker, farmer—to subjective identification as a member of a collectivity sharing common goals (Elster 1985; Agarwala 2006). The success or failure of this transition is a central problematic for class analytics; its common failure tells us much about problems of collective action and cultural constructions of identity, but does not indicate any reason to ignore class structure as a cause. Indeed, though analysts often make the easy assumption of political relevance of ‘identity politics,’ there is evidence that political identities are unstable over time, subject to strong suggestibility and situational pressures, and only poorly predictive of policy preferences (Kuo and Margalit 2010). Class identities suffer the same problems as other identities for political analysis.

What is politics?

Again to simplify for sake of argument, I find it useful to rely on Harold Lasswell’s (1936) classic position: politics is ‘who gets what ... and how.’ The overlay of politics with class position is then immediately apparent. Much of what one gets, and how, is dependent on position in a class structure. From some class positions, lack of resources and connections leaves few options other than direct action: demonstration, petition, *hartal*, riot, insurgency. At the opposite end of the class spectrum, getting what one wants may require no overtly political behavior at all, since the structural power of capital exerts great force on politicians and the state, independently of class mobilization. Likewise, from some class positions, deep connections through class networks yield a broad range of special entitlements or political connections. Mechanisms at the top of the class ladder are difficult for the external observer—even an observer of comparable class standing—to analyze. It is remarkable how little we actually know about class politics at these levels; there are interests involved in obscuring privilege and access, or masking both in terms of ostensibly meritocratic necessity. This is a class politics of euphemization and stealth.

The most consequential class politics in democracies typically requires stealth and symbolic politics to be effective. An appeal to mass publics to vote for further enriching the already rich at the cost of their own interests would seem to be politically fruitless, but it works, frequently. In the place of blunt and unattractive class appeals, symbolic politics around a narrative of abstract nouns covers many shifts in redistribution of life chances to the advantage of some classes and not others (Edelman 1967). 'Development' has certainly been among the most powerful of these narratives. Development imposes a set of imperatives inimical to the interests of lower orders. As the poor have a very low marginal propensity to save (and invest) they can hardly serve as an engine of growth. Instead, public policy often takes the form of enticing capital to invest via tax and fiscal incentives. Once invested, the great strategic advantage of the rich is that the structural power of capital works for their interests. The structural power of capital is evident in the imperative facing every regime of whatever nominal ideology to maintain 'business confidence,' or spur investment, increase growth rates and employment, improve foreign exchange positions, or improve geo-political security (Herring and Mohan 2001). No explicit mobilization is necessary for these outcomes; if capital is not pleased with state policies, it will move away or stop investing. Regimes of necessity must heed market imperatives, but it is never clear what exactly the market demands. Structural imperatives imposed by the market require interpretation by modern oracles predisposed to find market rigging for the lower orders unsustainable—this was the core of the so-called 'Washington Consensus.' Politics so enabled maintain or enhance a distribution of privilege without its beneficiaries having to make a fuss in the streets or at the polls.

Much discussion of class politics curiously ignores this most materially significant element of class power. In poorer countries, distribution and redistribution are typically covered by the elusive term 'development.'³ However, the phenomenon is general. A recent massive redistribution of income up the class ladder was a political project of the administrations of George W. Bush in the USA; officials and supporters denounced any critique of redistribution of income to the already wealthy as 'inciting class war.' *The New York Times* columnist Paul Krugman (2006: A19) rightly asked: 'So what's our bitter partisan divide really about? In two words: class warfare.' Class is taboo in American political praxis; in India, as in Europe, the ideological spectrum is much broader, but some obfuscation of class universally serves political interests. Regimes seeking credit for growth emphasize aggregate gains, not uneven distribution or deprivation (Herring 1999). The ruling coalition in India in the 2004 elections claimed success for an aggregate 'India Shining'; opposition parties tried to disaggregate the picture into winners and losers. Because the 'nation' needs 'development,' some people are going to lose land, subsistence livelihoods, living space, and others are going to make out like bandits. The strategy in class terms is to obscure differential rewards of aggressive capitalist development in favor of universal valents summarized by a growing gross domestic product (GDP). In India, much of the 'tribal' confrontations with the state historically, and currently in the Maoist insurgency mentioned below, are explicit rejections of both the right to commoditize and appropriate natural resources and the exclusion from development of peoples in poor areas containing natural resources.

This chapter approaches the politics of class by asking first: in what sense can class be said to determine what modes of political behavior are necessary or available to individuals: what they must do, what they are free to do? This is the fundamental divide that class imposes on political behavior, but in a more subtle form than in the case of economic behavior. Many visible forms of politics are conditioned by class structure, though described, perhaps experienced, in ways innocent of the concept of economic class.⁴ We then move on to consider a central critique of class analytics: if class is of central importance in politics, why are class politics only intermittently successful in formal institutional spheres such as elections? Finally, we will consider those rare

conditions under which class politics produces transformative structural change, within and outside the limited sphere of elections, largely from an agrarian, not industrial, base.

Class and classes in India

Objectively, class differences in India are significantly changing form and magnitude. Since initiation of liberalization policies in 1991, economic growth has accelerated. Per capita income differentials across states have risen, along with inequality within states. These trends have moderated the effects of economic growth on poverty reduction (Deaton and Drèze 2002). There is almost certainly more mobility of labor, and thus more opportunity, along with greater volatility and insecurity in labor markets. The historic ideal of India's developmental state posited a secure, protected labor force—though for only a tiny fraction of the working classes, the 'organized' or 'formal' sector (Teitelbaum 2011). This ideal has been replaced by a regime that recognizes the aggregate (growth) advantages of flexible informal workers without state protection. The 'informal sector,' which already dwarfs the formal sector, is gaining workers; the formal sector is losing workers proportionately (NSSO 2001). A growing 'middle class' is celebrated as evidence of increased opportunities, and by some accounts is increasingly active in forming itself politically (Fernandes and Heller 2006). Rural class structure is changing as well. Agriculture accounts for a smaller percentage of the workforce each year, though the change is slow by comparative historic standards. In 1951, four years after Independence, 82.7% of the population was rural; 71.9% of rural people were cultivators, 28.1% were (mostly landless) agricultural laborers. Rural society was thus dominated numerically by farmers, with a significant rural proletariat. One could then legitimately speak of a peasant society. By 2001, only 72.2% of the population was 'rural,' but farmers were a bare majority of the rural population: 54.4%. Agricultural workers—now more diversified in employment—constituted 45.6% of the rural population (GOI 2004). This agrarian proletariat is the truly awkward class: increasingly not attached to anyone's land or patronage, selling labor power in an unpredictable market, often uprooted by pushes and pulls of market forces, and largely without political representation.

Rural politics of class in India have run the spectrum from abject dependence and quiescence to insurrection. Neither is understandable without an analysis of class structure and conditions for class mobilization. Quiescence has been rooted in the dyadic dependency of agrarian relations; it is typically irrational for subordinates to attack the system given the balance of power locally and connections of superordinates to the local state. Even state schemes to uplift subordinate classes via land reform often failed precisely because the poor knew how irrational alienating their masters would be. Because big men in villages had power over under-classes through dependency relations, they could credibly claim to control 'vote banks' attractive to politicians otherwise unconnected to the villages. Mobilization of vote banks blunted redistributive policy along class lines and skewed distribution of state resources of development schemes to superordinate classes along lines of region and primordial loyalties. Rural elite power sustained business as usual, whatever the rhetoric of land reforms (Herring 1983). At the opposite end of the spectrum was sporadic agrarian radicalism rooted in demands for social justice, more *jacqueries* than programmatic movements.

The great puzzle of the twentieth century for orthodox Marxists was that revolutions were made through agrarian upheavals, not the proletariat (Wolf 1969; Paige 1975). Marx had evidently assigned agency to the wrong class. India became the center of a global debate around models of peasant economies and trajectories under capitalism. The technical change that underlay improvements in material production attracted special *angst*: might the 'green revolution turn red'? This possibility seemed real in the wake of the Maoist-influenced Naxalite movement, and

of widespread ‘agrarian tension’—as officially described in a report of the Ministry of Home Affairs in 1969. However, contrary to some expectations, rural capitalism and state responses generated not revolution, but what Terry Byres referred to as ‘partial proletarianisation’; marginal peasants continued to reproduce themselves rather than either waging class war as predicted by class theorists or disappearing as predicted by developmentalists (Byres 1981; Harriss 1994; Harriss-White and Janakarajan 2004). This process was sustained materially not only by Chayanovian self-exploitation, but increasingly by migration, associated remittances, diversification of employment outside agriculture and improved productivity of agriculture. Constantly shifting development ‘schemes’ contributed as well—rural public works, micro-finance programs, intermittently subsidized credit—and by minimalist state welfare.⁵ A democratic state preserved a peasantry of sorts, but not with the income supports of a Japan or a European Union (EU).

Diversification of rural livelihoods and increased importance of nonagricultural employment, both locally and in distant places, have altered relations between agrarian capital and rural labor. The ‘patron-client relationship’ romanticized in academic work is fading as personal relations among families in hierarchical class relations diminish. Where rural poverty has declined, it has been because of purposive public policy or the tightening of labor markets, both of which may reduce abject dependence of labor on capital. As both ascriptive status and economic class converted less easily to political power at the top of village society, one found emergence of new local leaders from among educated but often unemployed younger men (Krishna 2002, 2003). Erosion of the political power of the big landlords was hastened to some extent by land reforms, but as importantly by the widening of the opportunity matrix for the relatively well-off. For considerations of economics and social standing, big landowners often abandoned agriculture. Likewise, subordinate assertiveness contributed to what Frankel and Rao described as ‘the decline of dominance.’⁶ Ties of dependency of the rural poor in agrarian class relations thus loosened, but their interests were only weakly articulated politically—except in regional pockets and in the ‘red belt’ of Kerala and West Bengal. For all these reasons, the relational class power of ‘rich farmers’ of higher-ranked castes appears to have declined significantly. Yet the power of poor farmers and landless workers in political parties and public policy has not noticeably increased.

Globalization and accompanying neoliberal policies have increased pressures on the agricultural sector, but means of class formation remain elusive. One attempted formulation has been a politically imagined super-class led by more prosperous farmers, but incorporating a diverse class coalition. This aggregated class conceived of agriculturists as an exploited sector of society. Promulgators of the class coalition conceived of *Bharat* as a place, agriculture as an occupation: both neglected and culturally denigrated. India lived well in its cities, *Bharat* lived miserably in rural squalor. The *Bharat*-vs.-India formulation attempted cultural and economic synthesis of rural society as a class for itself, focused on rolling back ‘urban bias’ in development policy. Collective action of farmers reached a high point in the 1980s, built on multi-class, sometimes caste-based, mobilization around costs of production and prices of outputs.⁷ Euphemization of the power of rich farmers was nominally apparent: most rural households were food deficit, and thus increases in prices would harm, not help, most denizens of *Bharat* absent significant price controls and subsidies from the state. That outcome is possible, but class structure in this case deterred an otherwise attractive political option. The movement demonstrated the difficulty of collective action based on coalitions of classes: the farmer’s cost is a laborer’s wage. Subsequently, the ability of this imagined aggregate class to influence prices and subsidies was diminished by failure of political organization: it had no national party nor alternative mechanism to obtain its goals.⁸ Defeat of this attempt at an agrarian class coalition marked the beginning of a decline of collective action by agrarian classes at the national level.

Technology and material progress have remained sources of mobilization and conflict, but not on a national scale. Some of the largest collective actions of farmers in recent years mobilized against Delhi's restrictive regulation of genetically engineered (Bt) cotton seeds, beginning in 2001 (Omvedt 2005; Herring 2005). The issue was again urban bias, in different form; farmers demanded access to knowledge—biotechnology—that regulators in Delhi sought to 'bottle up in the cities' (Joshi 2001). Urban groups that claimed to represent farmers took an anti-biotech line inconsistent with farmer interests, leading to significant fracturing of rural representation of any kind (Herring 2006).

Though the national coalitional class strategy—a rural class for itself—largely failed, other rural class movements succeeded at the local level. In the two states with more successful mobilization of subordinate agrarian class power, policies diverged. Kerala's dominant communist party—the Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI(M))—organized agricultural workers as a class, not as a subset of an organization of farmers who pay their wages. West Bengal's CPI(M) preferred the national *kisan sabha* construction that assumes class interests in agriculture to be complementary, not antagonistic. Bengali communists papered over the class contradiction between labor-hiring farmers and labor-selling workers; Kerala communists accepted the reality of conflict and built organizations accordingly. Kerala's communists knowingly risked *embourgeoisement* by turning tenants into owners with a radical agrarian reform that abolished landlordism and passed all land to tenants. Bengali communists left the sharecroppers in a subordinate class position, but with enhanced rights (Herring 2001, 2003; Mallick 1993). Judging by electoral results, the Bengal model of rural class cooperation—and dependency on the party-state—worked better politically than Kerala's confrontationist model.⁹ The Bengal communists won elections continuously for 33 years before a decisive electoral defeat in 2011.

In the state's view of rural India, the specter has long been rural class violence. The cycle has recently returned with fears of 'Maoist' insurgency. In April 2006, India's Prime Minister Manmohan Singh addressed chief ministers of six states affected by violent agrarian confrontations: 'It would not be exaggeration to say that the problem of Naxalism is the single biggest internal security challenge ever faced by our country.'¹⁰ Ranjit Kumar Gupta, former police commissioner of Calcutta, estimated that the Naxalite movement had spread to 20% of India's districts (159 districts in 14 states) since it began in 1967 (Gupta 2004). In neighboring Nepal, Maoist rebels exercised total sovereignty over vast areas with de facto freedom to operate in virtually all rural areas by 2005 (Kalyvas 2006: 211), and subsequently succeeded in altering Nepal's political structure. Agrarian radicals in India, as in Nepal, claim to be fighting a class war, a war for a classless society. They assassinate 'class enemies' and confront military forces and police in pursuit of a new system of class justice. This insurgency is too complex to render in a short piece, but it seems clear that failures in the euphemizations of development as a national project account for much of the moral outrage of rebels. Many of the affected areas are 'tribal,' with two consequences: decades of neglect by state authorities and political parties have left many people poor and desperate; simultaneously, India's aggressive growth process has led to intensified exploitation of natural resources in areas claimed by Adivasis ('tribals') as sovereign terrain. Beneficiaries of the growth machine so enabled have not needed to mobilize along class lines for appropriation of new opportunities. On the other hand, the threat of exploitation to people in the 'tribal' areas is both economic and political; the defensive reaction has been violent, in line with other trends in India's democracy (Chandra 2011). The obstacles to mobilization along class lines involve serious risk of detention and death: under these circumstances it is not surprising that a class project faces daunting odds.

Anti-globalization campaigns portray in India a severe and generalized agrarian crisis, as indicated by what is held to be a rising tide of farmer suicides.¹¹ That picture is not entirely

true; some crops have done remarkably well and many farmers have made a lot of money, especially in cotton, in which India recently surpassed the USA in exports. More accurately, class in rural India continues, much as before, to manifest widespread insecurity of direct producers; multiple dimensions of degradation and inequality continue to fuel misery, migration and occasional confrontation. Typically, though, there has been no electoral party with both the credible commitment to removing agrarian exploitation and reasonable probability of success to produce social-democratic outcomes based on a rural uprising of the sort witnessed in Kerala historically.

Distal conditioning of ordinary politics

It is common to pose explanatory frameworks in either/or terms—as opposed and mutually exclusive theoretical options. If class has the fundamental structuring effects suggested above, class analysis is compatible with forms of theorizing politics that take for granted structural inequalities. In this case, class operates as a more distal cause than is the case for rural insurrection or land invasions in which explicitly class demands are overt and decisive. For purposes of illustration, we can consider three forms of competing characterizations of Indian politics.

Though class politics is usually associated with parties of the left, much political behavior coded as decidedly non-left is deeply conditioned by class structure. Consider the electoral success of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), a party associated with upper-class support, neoliberal economic policies, and religious-fundamentalist prescriptions for resurrection of *Hindutva*—a reign of Hinduism as national policy. Its cultural politics appeal to a tradition that relegates outcast status to some subordinate groups, including Dalits (the former ‘untouchables’) and Adivasis. Surprisingly, BJP electoral support among the most oppressed social groupings, dalits and adivasis, is quite strong in many Indian states. In some states, the BJP wins a plurality of the dalit/adivasi vote (Thachil and Herring 2008: figures 1 and 2). This is an anomalous outcome for a party typically considered a ‘high’-caste party with strong inclinations toward *Hindutva* as social policy. Though there is great variance across states—illustrating decisively the problem of ‘caste-ist’ or ‘identity’ explanations of voting—the BJP does especially well with oppressed sections of society in states that fail in developmental terms, as indicated by a very low Human Development Index ranking.

The reason for success of a ‘religious’ party in such unlikely populations is not explained by ideational shifts or false consciousness (Thachil 2009). Rather, the BJP is capable of meeting un-met class needs in these populations. The party is the electoral wing of a social-movement coalition of service organizations—the Sangh Parivar—which influence voters by provision of social services, much like some Islamist parties in West Asia. Village-level workers of the Parivar provide basic human needs—especially in health and medical care—that many states fail to provide (Thachil and Herring 2008: 452–56). That some identifiable populations lack, and need, these services provides a precondition for this episodically successful party strategy. Such conditions also provide an explanation for electoral behavior. People who lack critical services such as education also lack the resulting asset, precisely because of their class standing. If they were rich, they would not need the BJP’s ancillaries to provide education; if they lived in states such as Kerala, where social democracy has operated to equalize life chances to some extent, they would likewise not need the BJP, because of state provisioning. Failure in other states reflects the absence of lower-class political power of the sort that created social democracy in Kerala. The profile of social-needs spending in Kerala represents the outcome of anomalous class formation and mobilization from the bottom of society over time (Heller 1999; Herring 2007). Massive investments in organizational development by the Sangh Parivar in Kerala have not

paid off electorally, in part because of struggles that made social services public goods in the state. However, in states with little class mobilization from below, the poor lack access both to services and to a political vehicle for change (Drèze and Sen 1996: 10–128, *passim*; Ramachandran 1996).

Class likewise conditions two common modes of political tactics in India. One thinks of clientelism and populism, for example, as alternative politics to class, but what is the structural basis for the pervasive clientelism in local politics? A necessary condition is that people from some classes have the power to provide what people from other classes lack. The landlord may choose to become a patron; it is a matter of strategy and choice. The landless laborer is unlikely to become a patron, but instead probably needs one. We may euphemize clientage in many ways, but the basic structure of the power imbalance is control of resources, which is hard to understand without attention to class structure. Like the social services of BJP activists, social services of patrons are less needed in states with basic human needs provisioning, or in villages where mobilizations behind new leaders have provided better links with a balky state (Krishna 2002). The economic populism that is pervasive in Indian politics works on similar principles. Whatever the demonization tactic, or the us-them narrative of history, populism in India presupposes a susceptible population. The two-rupee rice scheme of the Telugu Desham Party had appeal because even this most basic food grain was too expensive for millions of voters. The noon-day meals provided by Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK)/Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (ADMK) populism in Tamil Nadu succeeded with voters too poor to afford school lunches for their children. Populist politicians in these two states had multiple sources of symbolic connections to the voters, including film stardom, but they also confronted an economically vulnerable population in need of material transfers to provide basic human needs.

Populism and clientelism are modes of politics that run counter to the programmatic politics of at least some political parties. Left parties in India are programmatic, especially with regard to class: they espouse educational reform, minimum wages, job security, land reforms, strengthening the safety net. As fewer political parties espouse believable policies, and as politics is increasingly perceived to be a ‘dirty river’ dominated by unsavory types and their goons (Harriss 2006), alternative politics of the programmatic sort has emerged in civil society. Nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) are archetypal—at least in their presentation of self and their common image in Europe. Because NGOs have policy goals, connected to their transnational advocacy networks, they seek to influence political parties. A cliché of contemporary Indian politics is that the left is plagued by ‘NGO-ization’ and NGOs are plagued by ‘projectization.’ ‘NGO-ization’ means abandoning traditional class projects in favor of NGO visions. ‘Projectization’ means that visions will be attuned to funding sources, typically multilateral financial institutions, EU foreign aid, or international nongovernmental organizations (INGOs) such as Greenpeace.

NGO visions may or may not accord with material class interests on the ground, but it seems clear that class structure conditions the prospects of social-movement dynamics in civil society, sometimes because class interests are mis-recognized by NGO practitioners. One example will serve to illustrate the dynamic. ‘Operation Cremate Monsanto’ attempted to block the entry of biotechnology into Indian agriculture. It failed because middle-class advocates of banning Bt cotton had interests that were diametrically opposed to the material interests of cotton farmers. Part of what it means to be ‘middle class’ in contemporary India is to engage in some form of activism (Harriss 2006), but because of their class position, activists in the movement faced no consequences from the success or failure of cotton crops, and hence no pressure to get the facts on the ground right. Cotton farmers, who lack this freedom, face compelling economic pressure; seed choice is critical to livelihood. They experimented with Bt seeds, and in the aggregate adopted them rapidly for increased income and lessened pesticides on their

land. Operation Cremate Monsanto failed in part because activists misunderstood class interests in biotechnology, its property configuration and production relations: particularly the capacity of farmers to appropriate the technology via stealth seeds under the radar of both Monsanto and Delhi. As important, the failure of movement leaders to take a class perspective hindered their ability to represent the class they claimed to represent (Joshi 2001; Herring 2006, 2008b). Amita Baviskar (2005) noted a similar division in class representations of environmental movements but concludes that strategic ambiguity about divergent class objectives may in some cases contribute to movement strength, not failure.

Electoral politics: under what conditions does class mobilization win?

Indian politics is often described by journalists as the moving about of blocks on a chess board—this caste supports X, this caste Y, and so the election went. Empirically, there is little support for the collectivist social-morphology view of voting (Thachil and Herring 2008: 441–49; Krishna 2002, 2003). Missing from the vote-bank, voting-bloc or primordial-affiliation views of voting are individual choice and agency, and the resultant variance within imagined groups. Electoral behavior is inherently over-determined; causes are multiple and over-lapping, temporally unstable and often inaccessible to outside observers. Voters have multiple possible identities which may be engaged by particular issues in particular elections—sector, region, nation, gender, caste, ethnicity, religion, and so on. The ‘class’ element of voting is like other dimensions of social being: at some times more relevant to electoral behavior than at others. The relationship of class to elections is contingent on situational variables: what candidates, what alliances, what platforms?

Under what conditions might class drive electoral processes to favorable outcomes for workers and other property-less classes? The first class distinction is clear: collective action will be required. The lower orders cannot generally rely on the state’s recognition of their structural power. Conditions for success are then quite daunting, and explain both the exceptions and the rule in Indian electoral politics: property-less classes are only intermittently and marginally successful (Herring and Agarwala 2006: 325–31).

Consider the individual subordinate-class voter: should she vote her class interests? The conditions for doing so are: first, the presence of a programmatic party of the left with plausible policies for altering the distribution of life chances; second, candidates who can be trusted to carry out programmatic pledges once elected (as opposed to the common assumption about politicians: *sub chor henh*—all are thieves); third, organizational effectiveness of such parties to reach voters; fourth, elections in which class issues are available for choice (if no party supports land reform, for example, landless laborers may choose on other criteria, such as populism, clientage, caste identity); fifth, a meaningful probability that the party could win—i.e. that a vote will not be wasted; and finally, and most contested theoretically, fifth, choosing class identification over alternatives if there is conflict.¹²

These conditions are rarely met. Variation across Indian states is in part a reflection of different party systems: a vote for a communist in Gujarat is likely wasted, but in Kerala potentially effective. Communist parties have been successful only in pockets, most importantly Kerala and West Bengal, but in much of India the choices facing voters are not favorable to class voting. Historically, expressing left politics in much of India would be difficult because programmatic parties are not contenders. In some cases, left politics could lead to reprisals. At the extremes of party *systems*, consider that left politics in Pakistan could get one killed (Candland 2007), whereas the same behavior in Kerala or Bengal could lead to a comfortable career (Mallick 1993, 1994). Moreover, it is increasingly unclear that platforms of left parties coincide with the interests of subordinate classes or will be acted on by ordinary politicians once in power. In

contrast, non-programmatic parties have great latitude in adopting symbols to mobilize support, deploying social identities, charismatic leadership, populism and other strategies. The disintegration of the Congress system made for a politics of opportunistic alliances that rendered all political parties less programmatic and simultaneously less relevant to redistributive politics (Thachil and Herring 2008). Under these systemic conditions, the possibilities for obfuscation of material interests via alternative identities ramify: nation, region, caste, community. Though academic analysts oppose class politics with identity politics, the interpenetration of class and identity is present in all societies. As identity politics was sweeping academic treatments in the 1980s, a strong leftist coalition led by the CPI(M) was consolidating in West Bengal, a state of 82 million people, a government continuously elected over the last 33 years, an electoral success unprecedented for India and rare anywhere in the world. However, class is only one of many possible political identities. We really know little about the conditions under which different appeals will resonate. Political parties do exploit existing cleavages in society—the basis for much of the left-right conceptualization of political parties based on the European experience—but such cleavages may not be phenomenologically relevant to voters, or subject to credible mobilization. In these circumstances, non-programmatic parties are free to ‘suture’ together themes and practices that create new collective actors (Leon *et al.* 2009).

When parties do claim to offer programmatic support for subordinate classes, as in West Bengal, class structure itself intermittently raises strains within class coalitions. Such conflicts within multi-class coalitions are inevitable when classes are politically mobilized. Use of eminent domain to obtain land from farmers for industrial parks created major conflicts in West Bengal in the 2000s. Certainly the dynamics around Singur and Nandigram, where confrontation was severe, contributed to the CPI(M)’s loss of electoral support in rural areas of the state in 2009, and ultimate loss of office in 2011. Nevertheless, in a worker/peasant alliance, there are objective contradictions in interest—the price of food if nothing else, but also investment priorities, taxes and the like. The party lost some rural support in trying to open new jobs for workers by encouraging factory development, but there were some gains among non-farm workers in comparison to previous elections.¹³ That state acquisition of agricultural land for industrial development would not play well electorally in the farm sector, but would play better among industrial workers, is not surprising. What is surprising is that this coalition has kept together through so many electoral cycles given that structural tension. Governing parties of the left are vulnerable to class conflicts within a mobilized base. To win, they must become class coalitions. These periodic contradictions of interest are difficult enough, but political parties also have periodic compulsions that have nothing to do with material class interests. One such issue for the CPI(M) was India’s nuclear pact with the USA. The party in 2009 withdrew support from the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) coalition governing in New Delhi because of the nuclear pact and therefore lost the opportunity to campaign on achievements of a government they had backed, such as the National Rural Employment Guarantee and forgiving of farm loans. In contemporary India, parties increasingly hang their electoral chances on coalition choices; in this case, the CPI(M) made a poor choice strategically. That left parties make poor choices does affect votes, and illustrates how difficult electoral expression of even mobilized class politics can be, but consequent reversals hardly disqualify class analytics.¹⁴

How important the electoral sphere is to class interests is a debatable proposition in any event. As states cede more authority to markets, electoral success may prove less efficacious in improving life chances of subordinate classes. Simultaneously, globalization and liberalization are widely held to reduce the efficacy of working-class options outside the electoral sphere. Global competition among firms puts downward pressure on job security. Informalization of work means fewer protections for workers; in the formal sector, states reduce implementation of laws

protecting workers' rights (Tilly 1995). Though social scientists have long written off the Indian formal-sector working class as divided and weak, new empirical work indicates otherwise (Teitelbaum 2006, 2011). However, the informal sector dwarfs the formal sector and is especially difficult to organize. Nevertheless, new class-based organizations among informal workers are appearing. Rina Agarwala's field work confirms the most basic premise of class theory: changing production relations lead to changes in class struggle. In these cases, some organizational success among informal workers resulted from adapting their tactics to increasingly fragmented and unstable capital—a bewildering and shifting coterie of sub-contractors beyond state labor law. The factory floor of a single firm is becoming more rare, and to meet this change in production relations workers have developed new tactics to carry on a struggle for recognition and rights (Agarwala 2006, 2013).

Conclusions

Dueling orthodoxies and partisan theoretical product differentiation have certainly obscured recognition of class politics in India (Chibber 2006; Hutnyk 2003; Sinha 2009). However, even without obscurantist theory, some of the most important elements of class politics are inherently difficult to delineate. This difficulty runs on a gradient depending on the explanandum: what exactly do we expect class theory to do? By one definition of politics, class is indisputably of direct and pervasive causal importance. Economic class determines not only who gets what, but how: what must be done, can be done, to alter life chances? That is the most fundamental effect of class on politics and politics on class. Most important for the politics of reproducing or replacing class inequality, the structural power of capital is widely recognized by regimes and the political class. Euphemization of this privileged position does not obscure its reality, though narratives built around euphemization have proved remarkably effective in mass politics. The problem for subordinate classes is that they lack the structural power of capital; states are not compelled to improve their prospects in the 'national interest.' Subordinate classes must therefore engage in ordinary politics to gain common objectives, or engage in contentious politics outside the boundaries of institutionalized forums. Class structure thus determines to some extent who has to do what to succeed in class-specific, political projects.

Structure can be said to have effects when mechanisms can be demonstrated. Those mechanisms for subordinate classes typically involve some form of collective action. Success in large-scale, collective action in general is difficult for reasons well understood in social science; for lower classes, collective action offers especially daunting prospects. First, the formation of collective identities is inherently difficult for large numbers of disparate individuals. The 'fragmentation' and segmentation of Indian society is one of the reasons Barrington Moore, Jr, gave for the seemingly surprising absence of communist revolution in so deprived and degraded a peasantry. Second, should that recognition of common class standing be achieved, or politically manufactured, organization remains a daunting precondition for collective action (Wade 1988). Organizations first need resources, precisely what is in short supply in deprived communities. Moreover, organizations themselves frequently produce their own pathologies; this is true of political parties, trade unions and NGOs. In sum, vehicles for advancing class interests of the poor are likely to be rare or ephemeral. Even in the electoral sphere of a vibrant democracy, the opportunity structure facing voters may offer little prospect for expressing class solidarity and goals. Party system matters. Few viable parties with credible prospects for winning office address subordinate class needs in India; fewer act on their campaign promises when elected. For these reasons, historical path dependency runs deep; credible parties with appropriate practical theory have evolved over time through incorporation and learning from residues of past

conflicts—both victories and defeats—but the re-running of history is not an option for political entrepreneurs.¹⁵

These multiple disabilities of class politics at the bottom of society helps explain the infrequency of success; a class perspective on politics helps us understand why poor majorities may remain poor, even in vibrant democratic settings. Whether forces espousing alteration of the class structure win or lose in any particular juncture, class remains a pervasive force in the many forms politics may take, and thereby profoundly influences future distributions of life chances and new forms of politics. Despite the current decline of class as a lens through which to view India and its politics (Chibber 2006), much is eclipsed and lost in that analytical choice.

Notes

- 1 This essay owes much to collaborative work with Rina Agarwala, Tariq Thachil and John Harriss, and to critiques, insights and discussions from and with Rumela Sen, Patrick Heller, Subir Sinha, Leela Fernandes, Emmanuel Teitelbaum, Atul Kohli and the late Smitu Kothari.
- 2 More expansive treatments of the ideas sketched below are available (Herring and Agarwala 2006). Positions on class per se are similar to those of Wright 1997a, 1997b; Elster 1985.
- 3 For representative views of the class consequences of developmental policy in India, see for example Bardhan 1984; Chibber 2003; Herring 1983; Drèze and Sen 1996; Corbridge and Harriss 2000.
- 4 The idiom of 'caste' in India is frequently deployed both for strategically dividing class formation and for facilitating class collective action by appealing to an existing identity. There is no space here for examining the caste-class dynamic, but an indicative account can be found in Herring and Agarwala 2008. On the declining significance of caste as a basis for local leadership or political affiliation, based on village studies in Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, see Krishna (2002: 6–7, 48, 53, 156ff, 181).
- 5 Harriss-White and Janakarajan 2004: 195–295; Herring and Edwards 1983; Herring 1985; Bhaduri *et al.* 1986; Gaiha 1996.
- 6 Frankel and Rao 1989: 2; see also Mendelsohn 1993; Harriss 2003.
- 7 Omvedt 1993; Brass 1995; Lindberg 1995; Teitelbaum 2007.
- 8 Varshney 1998; see also Lindberg 1995; Brass 1995.
- 9 Patrick Heller (1999: 237–48) emphasizes the resultant pressure on Kerala communists to make their own class compromises, which he finds to have enhanced prospects for economic development.
- 10 Singh's comments in GOI 2006. Members of the People's Guerrilla Army, People's War Group (PWG), Maoists Communist Center (MCC), Communist Party of India (Maoist), and the Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Janashakti are called ultra-leftists or Naxals, after the 1967 agrarian uprising in Naxalbari, West Bengal. See Jaffrelot 2011 for analysis.
- 11 A highly politicized, media-driven event, the tragedy of farmer suicides cannot be empirically verified nationally, nor connected to Bt cotton. See Vaidyanathan 2006; Herring 2008a; Gruère *et al.* 2008. At the popular level, a good explanation of some dynamics is available in the film *Peepli Live*.
- 12 Gail Omvedt's *Reinventing Revolution* (1993) is tellingly subtitled 'New Social Movements and the Socialist Tradition in India.' On material interests in ethnic politics, see Herring and Esman 2001; Chandra 2004; on the critical role of party and organization, see Kohli 1987; on parties and land reform, see Herring 2007.
- 13 National Election Study 2009 results as reported in 'How India Voted,' *The Hindu* (May 26, 2009), online edition www.hinduonnet.com/nic/howindiavoted2009/page5.pdf (accessed June 19, 2009).
- 14 The Kerala vote in 2009 was reflective of a long-standing cleavage in the state: the rich are more likely to vote Congress and allies; the poor, Communist and allies (*ibid.*).
- 15 Certainly this was the case for Kerala (Herring 2008a).

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12

RESERVATIONS

Gurpreet Mahajan

In India, the term reservations is used to refer to policies by which a fixed number of seats are set aside and reserved as quotas for specific communities. Although the reference is usually to policies that were initiated after Independence, the system of quotas existed even in pre-independence India. Under the British rule seats were reserved for identified religious communities: in 1909 a quota of seats was reserved in legislative bodies for Muslims through a system of separate electorate, and this arrangement was extended in 1919 and 1935 to include Sikhs and Christians. Even before these policies were initiated for religious minorities, the British had turned their attention to the lower castes. By the late nineteenth century, they had started preparing a list of 'depressed classes'—a group created by identifying the lower castes, some of whom were victims of the practice of untouchability. Special schools and scholarships were set up for their welfare and eventually, in response to their political assertions and demands, seats were reserved for them in legislative assemblies in 1935 albeit through a two-tier system in which candidates selected through separate electorate would compete for the votes of the entire population through the mechanism of a joint electorate.

Prior to these community-specific policies, some princely states had introduced a different system of quotas. In the princely state of Kolhapur (Maharashtra), Shahu Maharaj reserved seats for the backward castes, with a view to curbing the influence and domination of Brahmins over his administration. By 1902, almost 50% of the vacant positions were set aside in his kingdom for non-Brahmin castes. Quotas of a similar kind also existed in the princely states of Mysore, Baroda and Travancore.

Thus, policies involving the fixing of quotas for specific communities have a long history in India. Yet, reservations remain one of the most debated and contested issues in independent India. While there is wide-ranging support for the idea that some communities may require special consideration, the policies of reservations that have come into effect through a series of constitutional amendments and governmental interventions both at the level of state governments and the centre, continue to be a subject of dispute. If some see these policies as the single most important tool for minimizing the effects of 'backwardness,' others question the efficacy of reservations in promoting equality. It is this difference in perception and assessment that makes reservations a complex issue that must be understood and examined through the specific history of these policies and the form they have taken in India.

The constitutional framework

The system of quotas that existed before Independence was significantly different from the policy framework of reservations that was introduced through the Constitution of independent India. Prior to Independence, quotas existed primarily to ensure a degree of communal balance, but when India gained Independence, reservations were conceived as an instrument of promoting equality. The framers of the constitution acknowledged that in the past some communities had been excluded—coercively isolated—from the rest of society.¹ Since society as a whole was responsible for this predicament it must now shoulder the responsibility for undoing the effects of its past actions. Blatant forms of discrimination, such as untouchability, could not be allowed in democratic India and, even more importantly, an effort had to be made to include these previously segregated communities. Reservations were expected to assist in the realization of this goal. It was believed that by formally including previously excluded populations they would also help to create a more equal and just society.

While the framers of the constitution recognized the harm done to communities that were forcibly excluded and stigmatized by the actions of the state and society, reservations were not envisioned as a form of compensatory justice.² Instead, most members spoke of collectively responsibility and evoked a vision of an equal society to advocate special consideration for some identified groups. This rationale for special consideration, particularly reservations, translated into policy measures that were quite different from policies that had existed earlier. In colonial India separate quotas existed for identified religious communities and in the case of some princely states seats were reserved for non-Brahmins and backward castes in administrative positions. The Constitution of independent India did not give separate representation to any religious minority. Although this was initially considered, eventually the minorities themselves withdrew the claim for a separate quota of seats.³

The Constitution only reserved seats in the 'House of the People' (Lok Sabha, the lower house of the central Parliament) and legislative assemblies of states for communities identified as Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs). Under Articles 330 and 332, seats were reserved in these legislative bodies for both these groups in proportion to their size in the total population.⁴ These reservations were granted in the first instance for a limited period of time and unless extended by the Parliament, they were to cease at the end of 10 years. The Chairman of the drafting committee of the Constituent Assembly, a prominent leader and spokesperson of the interests of the lower castes, Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, argued for this arrangement on the grounds that the representatives of the people in the Parliament must be free to determine the fate of these provisions.⁵

In addition to this constitutionally mandatory provision for reservation of seats in legislative bodies, Article 335 stipulated that 'the claims of the members of the SC and ST shall be taken into consideration, consistently with the maintenance of efficiency of administration, in the making of appointments to services and posts in connection with the affairs of the Union or of a state.' Although no quotas were stipulated here for appointments to various public positions and services, a positive provision was made that placed the obligation upon subsequent governments to formulate policies that were cognizant of the claims of SCs and STs without sacrificing the efficiency of services. To protect further the interests of these previously excluded populations, the constitution also made a provision for a Special Officer for the SCs and STs (Article 338).⁶

From among the different kinds of marginalized and disadvantaged groups the constitution had singled out the SCs and STs for separate treatment and mandated reservations for them in legislative bodies. It addressed the concerns of all other 'backward' groups in the chapter on fundamental rights. While protecting equality of all citizens before law (Article 14) and ensuring 'equality of opportunity in matters of public employment' through Article 16, it included,

under the latter, a sub-clause which allowed governments to make 'any provision for the reservation of appointments or posts in favour of any *backward class of citizens* which, in the opinion of the state, is not *adequately represented* in the services under the state' (emphasis added).⁷

What needs to be reiterated here is that the constitution gave the right to equality. Reservations could be made in favor of the backward classes, if governments so chose, but they were *not a matter of right*. Further, the constitution gave the state space to reserve seats for backward classes in matters of public employment. While equality before law was formally established (Article 14) and the principle of non-discrimination was stipulated in social and public life (Article 15), state intervention through reservations or other positive measures was permitted, not mandated or specified, in matters of public employment (Article 16).

Even more importantly, the constitution spoke of 'backward class of citizens.' While identifying beneficiaries of positive measures, the members of the Constituent Assembly spent considerable time deliberating upon the appropriate conceptual term. Should the generic term 'minorities' be used for the beneficiaries, as it would include all forms of marginalized communities? Or, given the association of the term minorities with religious minorities, would it be preferable to identify them as 'backward classes like Scheduled Castes,' or 'minorities and other classes,' 'minorities and backward classes,' or 'minorities and backward communities'? Eventually the term 'backward classes' was used, in the belief that this would include all forms of minorities (Shiva Rao 1967: 262). This is particularly significant because in post-independence India, governments began to identify backward *castes*. Caste became the marker of backwardness and beneficiaries got identified as members of specific castes.

The most striking feature of the constitution was that it did not explicitly continue with the quotas for backward castes that existed in some states before Independence. It made room for such provisions but did not endorse the prevailing arrangements.⁸

Judicial interpretations and legislative interventions

The space that the Constitution had offered for making policies for the advancement of backward classes was used by many state governments, particularly in the southern states of India, to introduce quotas for identified backward castes in educational institutions and government jobs. These policies were challenged in the courts of law and in most cases the Supreme Court offered an interpretation of the constitutional provisions that questioned the reading that was offered by the elected representatives in legislative bodies. Among other things, the Court questioned the validity of using caste alone as the criterion for reservations, as it made a distinction between the criteria that could be used for reservations in educational institutions from that which was applicable for reservations in posts. It read reservations for appointments of public posts to imply availability of quotas only at the entry level; it restricted the extent of seats that might be reserved in a year. These differences in interpretation led to a series of amendments to the Constitution and it is through these changes that the reservations have now been extended to cover new spheres of public life, institutions that were previously excluded and, of course, new beneficiaries.

The Constitution of India had made space for reservation of seats in some areas, so the legality of reservations as a policy involving special consideration for some was not a subject of dispute. The main points of contention were: first, the identification of the beneficiaries; and second, the extent of reservations. Shortly after the Constitution came into operation in 1950, the Court was called upon to interpret the provisions of the constitutional clauses when Champakram Dorairajan challenged the quotas on the basis of caste that had been introduced by the state government for admission to engineering and medical colleges in the state of Madras. The Supreme Court decreed that the government order that prescribed a quota of seats

for different caste groups in the region in educational institutions violated the fundamental rights granted by the constitution.⁹ This was the first of the many judgments where the Court ruled that caste could not be the *sole* criterion for identifying the beneficiaries of reservations (see *M.R. Balaji vs. State of Mysore*, 1963 AIR, SC649). For the next three decades the Court continuously maintained that the constitution referred to backward classes, so while caste could be a consideration in identifying beneficiaries, by itself it was not enough. A range of other factors, like poverty, place of habitation, and education have an impact upon the position of a person and her capacity to access resources and opportunities; hence, due consideration had to be given to factors other than caste in identifying the beneficiaries of reservations. It was only in 1996, in the *Indra Sawhney* verdict¹⁰ that the Court accepted reservations on the basis of caste. It nevertheless brought in the concerns of class by excluding the ‘creamy layer’ (economically better-off) among the other backward classes (or castes—OBCs).

The verdict of the Court against caste quotas in educational institutions prompted the first amendment to the constitution in 1951, whereby clause 4 was added to Article 15 of the constitution, stipulating that ‘Nothing in this article or clause 2 of article 29 shall prevent the State from making any special provision for the advancement of any socially and educationally backward classes of citizens or for the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes.’

In the many cases that have come up before the Supreme Court with regard to Articles 15(4) and 16(4) involving reservations for socially and educationally backward classes in educational institutions and reservations in appointments for backward classes that are not adequately represented, the Court has maintained that the extent (quantum) of reservation cannot violate the ‘fundamental rights of citizens constituting the rest of society.’¹¹ Special treatment through reservations must be balanced with the concern for equal treatment. Keeping in mind the need to balance these two different concerns, the Supreme Court has stipulated that reservations should be less than 50%.¹² Further, the Court has maintained that reservations under 15(4) and 16(4) must be read in association with Article 335, which specifies that special provisions must be compatible with the concerns of efficiency. Even in public services and employment, ‘reservations cannot be so extensive as to nullify the rule’ (of equality of opportunity), and ‘efficiency of administration should be maintained and not allowed to suffer.’¹³ Applying the same principle to higher education, it observed that ‘... we cannot overlook the fact that in meeting that demand *standards of higher education in Universities must not be lowered*.’¹⁴

From 1963 onwards, the majority view of the Court has maintained that reservations under 16(4) apply only to the *point of entry* into the services and did not apply to subsequent promotions in service.¹⁵ Also, the total number of seats falling under reservation, including those occurring through the *carry forward* rule,¹⁶ in a given year must not exceed 50% of the total seats.¹⁷

While determining the scope of reservations the Supreme Court specified that in aided professional institution, the government can ask that due consideration be given to students from the weaker sections, but in a minority or non-minority unaided educational institution, ‘neither the policy of reservation can be enforced by the state, nor any quota of percentage of admissions can be carved out to be appropriated by the State.’¹⁸ These unaided institutions may voluntarily set aside quotas for identified communities but such measures cannot be prescribed or mandated by the government.¹⁹

While the Supreme Court has interpreted the constitutional provision to set certain limits within which policies relating to reservation must apply, the legislative bodies have pushed in the opposite direction. They have amended the constitution and steadily increased the scope of the reservation policy.

When the Supreme Court intervened and ruled against reservations in promotions,²⁰ the Parliament responded by amending the constitution in 1995. It introduced sub-clause (4A) to

Article 16, which stated: 'Nothing in this article shall prevent the state from making any provision for the reservations in matters of *promotion* of any class or classes of posts in the services under the state in favour of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes which, in the opinion of the state are not adequately represented in the services under the state.'²¹

In 1997, the 81st Amendment inserted clause (4B) to Article 16 to overcome the norm that the total quantum of reservations in a given year must not exceed 50%. In 2000 the 82nd Amendment inserted the following proviso at the *end of Article 335*: 'Provided that nothing in this article shall prevent in making of any provision in favour of the members of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes for relaxation in qualifying marks in any examination or lowering the standards of evaluation, for reservation in matters of promotion to any class or classes of services or posts in connection with the affairs of the Union or of a State.'²²

In 2002, the 85th Amendment to the Constitution made a further change in Article 16(4A). It inserted the phrase, 'with consequential seniority,' so that reservations in promotions will also grant the beneficiary consequential seniority.

In 2005, the 93rd Amendment introduced the clause (5) to Article 15 of the constitution and this extended reservations to the private, aided and unaided educational institutions—all except minority educational institutions.²³

The constitutional provisions have thus been significantly revised. Initially reservation was made only in legislative bodies (lower house) and allowed in appointments made in public services; today, reservations are made at the time of appointment and in subsequent promotions; reservations are mandatory in educational institutions, including private professional institutions; and unfilled reserved posts may be carried forward even if that means that the total number of reserved seats increases beyond 50%. There are, however, two norms, set by the Supreme Court, that have by and large been accepted: first, that the total percentage of seats reserved for different categories (SCs, STs and OBCs) must not exceed 50%²⁴; and second, that the creamy layer among the OBCs must be excluded from the benefits of reservations.²⁵

Reservations for OBCs

At the center (federal government), reservations for the SCs and STs came into effect immediately after Independence but reservations for OBCs were introduced only in 1990. Prior to this the government of India set up two Backward Classes Commissions, the first in 1953 with Kaka Kalelkar as chairman,²⁶ and the second in 1978 with B.P. Mandal as its chairman.²⁷ Although these commissions recommended reservation for OBCs no seats were set aside for them in central government or in centrally funded educational institutions. State governments, however, set up separate Backward Classes Commissions and most of them had their own reservation policies with regard to the OBCs. It was only when V.P. Singh became the prime minister in 1990 that the government decided to implement reservations for OBCs at the center. The decision of the government met with considerable resistance; it polarized society quite sharply and as V.P. Singh resigned reservations for OBCs were introduced only in central services and not educational institutions. More than a decade later, in 2006, the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government decided to extend reservations for OBCs to all educational institutions, aided and unaided, except those designated minority institutions.²⁸ Reservations have now been extended to Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs) and medical colleges—institutions to which admission is highly competitive and much sought after.

Two points need to be noted here: first, the list of OBCs includes groups from different religious communities. Unlike reservations for the SCs that included lower castes among the

Hindu community Sikhs and Buddhists,²⁹ the list of OBCs at the center as well as the states includes some Muslim and Christian communities. Weaker sections among these communities have been demanding reservations and the quota for OBCs has allowed political parties space to accommodate them. Second, the quota of reserved seats for OBCs differs significantly from state to state. Even within a given state the criteria, and with it the list of beneficiaries, has been continuously revised and changed. As the criteria used for inclusion and exclusion in the list has varied both within a state and across states, what we have in practice is a complex schema where some communities are beneficiaries in one state but if they move to a neighboring state, they may not be in the list of beneficiaries.

Assessment of the reservation policies

Policies of reservations have, over the years, been discussed and debated fiercely in public forums. Most of this debate has been triggered by the extension of reservations to OBCs because this category contains within it groups that are politically influential and at times even economically well-off (Gupta 2007a, 2007b; Chaudhury 2006, 2007; Radhakrishnan 2006). Some of them are the dominant agricultural castes in the region and in certain cases responsible for the oppression of the SCs in the region (Choudhary 2006a, 2006b). Indeed, there are instances where, despite the recommendations of the state-level Backward Classes Commissions, political parties have been reluctant to take the more powerful groups in the region off the list of reservations.³⁰ The politics associated with the identification of beneficiaries (see Sheth 1987) has been a source of considerable contestation,³¹ with new groups seeking inclusion in specific categories of beneficiaries (that is, as SCs or STs and not OBCs) and others resisting their exclusion. The desire to access opportunities through the modality of reservations has unleashed a form of identity politics. This has significantly altered the nature of democracy and often diverted attention away from the more important issues relating to economic inequalities—lack of access to basic public goods like water and healthcare, and loss of productive assets.

Although the identification of beneficiaries has become the focus of debate today, one needs also to consider just what has been achieved through the policies of reservations. Reservations were expected to provide opportunities in higher education and jobs to the identified backward classes and excluded populations. This did not happen immediately but by the 1990s the picture began to change significantly. Between 1994 and 2004 in the premier all-India services (Indian Administrative Service (IAS), Indian Foreign Services (IFS) and Indian Police Services (IPS)), which rank among the most coveted jobs in the country, on an average 12%–15% of the vacancies were filled by SCs and 6%–8% by STs.³² At the beginning of 2005, representation of SCs and STs in central government services, Group A, was 11.9% and 4.3%, respectively; in Group B they were 13.7% and 4.5%, respectively.³³ In 2004 in public-sector banks, in the officers category SCs and STs were 27.61% and 33.34%, respectively.³⁴ These numbers are important as they show that the identified beneficiaries now hold prestigious positions in society and this has provided them avenues for social mobility that did not exist previously. In the case of previously excluded populations, like SCs, this is of enormous significance. However, despite this success in bringing new groups in, it is difficult to say that reservations have mitigated the effects of social and economic inequality.

Available data indicate that the incidence of poverty remains high among the SCs and STs when compared with the national average; the literacy rate among these populations is also lower than the national average. While there has been some advance towards equality, it is questionable whether these differences and inequalities can indeed be overcome through policies of reservation (Guru 2000).

As things stand, only a small fraction of the SCs and STs have been able to access the benefits granted under the system of reservations. At the end of the last decade it was estimated that just about 8% of graduates were SCs and about 3% were STs.³⁵ It is from this small pool that reserved public positions are being filled. So it is only a small group from among the worse-off that are in a position to avail themselves of the opportunities provided by reservation policies. Even within this small group, members of some communities have been more successful in getting the benefit of reservations. Although the differences in the capacity of groups to access benefits (seats and posts) offered by reservations is a consequence of their past group history and location, nevertheless the so-called 'cornering' of benefits by some has yielded intense rivalry and conflict among the groups identified as beneficiaries.³⁶

Caste groups that have been relatively unsuccessful in accessing the spaces available through reservations have become easy targets of promises and mobilization by political parties. While parties have in some states (for instance, Karnataka, Punjab³⁷) addressed the concerns of these internally worse-off groups³⁸ by creating sub-quotas within the existing system of reservations, conflicts between beneficiaries are growing and becoming more complicated. To take one case as an illustration, in recent times the Gujjar community in Rajasthan has been protesting to demand ST status. Although the community is recognized in the list of OBCs and is eligible for reservations in that quota, it finds itself edged out by other, better-off groups within the OBCs. So it wants recognition under a different category. However, its claims for recognition as an ST are being opposed strongly by the Meena community—the most influential ST community in the region. Contestations of this kind are a fall-out of the logic of the reservation policy. It is not surprising, therefore, that conflict between beneficiaries is surfacing in many different states and it is becoming exceedingly difficult to accommodate the claims of different groups through the system of reservations.³⁹

If reservations have created friction between caste groups who are potential beneficiaries, it has also created tension among the beneficiaries and the non-beneficiaries. Part of the problem is that the functioning of the reservations is skewed by the fact that this policy is applied at the stage of higher education and appointments—i.e. well after differences arising from differential access to primary goods have accumulated and been reinforced. There are, therefore, many who feel that affirmative action policies should have a stronger presence at the early stages of education as this will help to nurture talents and develop skills from a young age. However, this is an aspect that has remained neglected by political parties and policy makers. Even today, the large majority of SC and ST children study in government schools, which are notorious for their poor educational standards. As a result, differences arising out of social circumstances are accentuated.

A further consequence of this neglect is that reservation policies that are in effect at a higher stage have to rely on lowering qualifications at the entry level. The extent to which qualifications or entry marks are lowered is formally determined by the relevant institutions but given the political pressure to fill the quotas there is often a significant gap between entrants from the open list and the reserved list. When this happens in institutions to which entrance is extremely competitive, it becomes a source of resentment and anger among non-beneficiaries of the reservation policies.

The polarization of society into pro- and anti-reservation lobbies has been compounded by the peculiarity of the reservation system in India. While candidates from the weaker sections qualify on merit and through the open list everywhere, their presence does not count towards the completion of the reserved quota of seats. The latter are always filled by lowering the cut-off mark; the list of reserved seats is thus a parallel list. Not all institutions lower the minimum grade required for granting degrees, but some do. This has reinforced a stigma that is associated often with policies of positive discrimination.⁴⁰

Reservations have thus created a peculiar paradox: on the one hand, there are new aspirants—groups that wish to be included in the list of beneficiaries, and on the other, increasing hostility between identified beneficiaries and between beneficiaries and non-beneficiaries. Can these competing claims be adjusted and accommodated fairly? Given the scale of emerging demands it is difficult to answer in the affirmative. Since powerful groups in different regions are either seeking special status as beneficiaries or resisting giving up these facilities, the matter can only have a political solution. This means that despite the increase in the quantum of reservations or its extension to other spheres, the most marginalized groups may still be left out and they may not even be able to obtain the benefits that are available through the reservation policies.

These are some of the reasons why inequalities persist despite reservation policies. Yet, successive governments have tended to overlook problems that have been thrown up by the workings of the reservation policies. In competitive democratic politics, the promise of extending reservations remains an easy way to reach out to groups and seek their support, and almost all political parties have taken this softer option. It is the opportunistic use of reservations that has in fact vitiated the environment and weakened the consensus that once existed around reservations. The need of the hour is to rebuild some degree of social agreement around these policies but that will be possible only when we are willing to critically reflect upon the existing provisions for reservations, the practices around them and the experience they have yielded. It is only through such an engagement that we can hope to make these policies stronger and more relevant for democratic society.

Notes

- 1 If lower castes, particularly those designated then as 'untouchables' were forcibly segregated within the village, tribal communities were pushed into remote and isolated regions (see Beteille 1980).
- 2 In the USA, for instance, positive discrimination is justified as a form of compensation for past harm/injury done to certain groups. In India this language of compensation was not used; if anything, it was collective responsibility that figured more prominently. Further, if the colonial policies seeking to strike a balance between communities absolutized difference, the new framework assumed reciprocity and some degree of sharing and even commonality.
- 3 In May 1949 H.C. Mookerji, Chairman of the Sub-committee on Minorities, formally withdrew the claim for separate representation, yet analysts continue to question this decision. Some hold national leaders like Nehru and Patel responsible for this decision of the Sub-committee; others point to the insufficient representation of Muslims in the Committee (Ansari 1999). The Muslim League did not participate in the deliberations of the Constituent Assembly and it is also well known that the partition of India altered the situation and made many leaders apprehensive about separate representation, especially for religious communities. The minority community members took note of this sentiment, reflected on the changed scenario and while giving up the claim for separate representation, bargained for other benefits for their respective communities and stronger cultural guarantees for their autonomy.
- 4 Accordingly, today at the center 15% of seats are reserved for SCs and 7.5% for STs. The percentage of reserved seats varies in each state reflecting the size of these groups in the total populations of the states.
- 5 The Parliament has successively extended the period of reservations, and even today seats are reserved for SCs and STs in legislative bodies. At present seats are reserved in the Lok Sabha, the Vidhan Sabhas (legislative body in the states), municipalities (Article 243T), in various *Panchayat*-level bodies, namely village, taluk and district (Article 243D).
- 6 This office, stipulated by the constitution, was replaced by a multi-member commission in 1978, and in 1990 it was renamed the National Commission for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes. In 1994, following the constitution (89th Amendment Act, 2003), a separate commission was set up for the SCs and another for the STs. There are today a set of institutions to protect and promote the welfare of the SCs and STs. The Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, Ministry of Tribal Affairs and Committee of Parliament on Welfare of SCs/STs are the central bodies entrusted with the task of making policies and programs for the benefit of these groups. The Department of Personnel and Training (DOPT), a Division of the Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions,

regulates and monitors the reservation policy in government services. Besides initiating new rules and enforcing them, the DOPT monitors the fulfillment of the prescribed quotas in central government services.

- 7 Article 16, Equality of Opportunity in matters of public employment. Sub-clause 4: 'Nothing in this article shall prevent the State from making any provision for the reservation of appointments or posts in favour of any backward class of citizens which, in the opinion of the State, is not adequately represented in the services under the State.' This was, as (Beteille 2005: 19) points out, an enabling provision and not a mandatory one. That is, it did not say that the state *must* or *shall* make provision for the reservation of posts; it simply left it to the discretion of the government in office. The sub-clause ensured that if reservations were indeed made for them, it would not be considered a violation of the right to 'equality of opportunity.' The constitution made a strong recommendation in the directive principles of state policy (Article 46), which specified: 'The State *shall* promote with special care the educational and economic interests of the weaker sections of the people, and, in particular, of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes, and shall protect them from social injustice and all forms of exploitation' (emphasis added). However, as has often been pointed out, the Directive Principles were more in the form of recommendations and commitments rather than rights that could be upheld by a court of law.
- 8 This has led some analysts to say that the Indian elite eclipsed caste and undid the 'progress' that had thus far been achieved with regard to the welfare of the backward castes (see Jaffrelot 2005: 41–45).
- 9 The State of Madras vs. Srimati Champakam Dorairajan, AIR 1951, SC226.
- 10 Indra Sawhney & Others vs. Union of India & Others, 1992, supp 3, SCC217.
- 11 M.R. Balaji vs. State of Mysore, 1963 AIR, SC649.
- 12 Ibid. This is reiterated subsequently on a number of occasions. See, for instance, P. Rajendran vs. State of Madras, AIR 1968, SC507, and P. Sagar vs. State of Andhra Pradesh, AIR 1968, SC1379.
- 13 T. Devadasan vs. Union of State and Another, AIR 1964, SC179.
- 14 M.R. Balaji vs. State of Mysore, 1963 AIR, SC649 (emphasis added).
- 15 Lowering of qualifying marks in matters of promotion is not permissible (S. Vinod Kumar vs. Union of India 1996).
- 16 That is, reserved seats that were not filled in a given year and were then transferred to the next year.
- 17 Indra Sawhney & Others vs. Union of India & Others, 1992, supp 3, SCC217.
- 18 T. Devadasan vs. Union of India, 1964 AIR 179. The 50% rule (i.e. total reservation for all categories at any time must not exceed 50%) was reiterated in Indra Sawhney & Others vs. Union of India & Others, 1992, supp. 3, SCC 217.
- 19 The Court has maintained that so long as the admission procedures are fair and transparent, and merit is adequately taken care of, the government or the university are not entitled to interfere. P.A. Inamdar & Others vs. State of Maharashtra & Others, AIR 2005 SC 3226.
- 20 However, it gave the government a period of five years within which the policies were to be suitably amended.
- 21 Following upon this 77th Constitutional Amendment, the Ministry of Personnel issued instructions on August 13, 1997 to continue the reservation in promotions for the SCs and STs in the services/posts under the central government beyond November 15, 1997 'till such time as the representation of each of these categories in each cadre reaches the prescribed percentages.'
- 22 This change came in response to the Court's ruling that lowering of qualification marks was not permissible (Indra Sawhney & Others vs. Union of India & Others, op.cit.).
- 23 Three kinds of institutions were exempt from the provisions of the Central Educational Institutions Act 2006: minority institutions (even those receiving financial support from the government); Central Educational Institutions established in the tribal areas referred to in the sixth schedule to the constitution; and institutions of excellence, research institutions, institutions of national and strategic importance specified in the schedule to this Act.
- 24 The Court's ruling that at least 50% of the seats must be left open had far-reaching consequences. Almost all the states revised their quota policy to meet the new norm. The one exception to this rule is Tamil Nadu, which continues to reserve 69% of total seats. The central government approved the relevant Bill and placed it under the ninth schedule, thereby exempting it from the scrutiny of the Court.
- 25 It should be noted here that it is reservations in educational institutions and jobs that have been the main focus of debate. Reservations in legislative bodies have periodically been renewed and even though concerns have been expressed about these representatives actually voicing the interests of their

constituencies, these quotas have not been questioned. The Courts have been asked to determine whether a particular person can be the beneficiary of reservation policies, particularly in situations involving conversion of lower castes (erstwhile scheduled caste to another religion), or marriage across communities (for more details, see Galanter 1991: 240–312). It may be pertinent to mention here that electoral politics has thrown up a number of important leaders from among the SCs and STs, many of whom do not simply serve a ‘reserved’ constituency.

- 26 The Commission made a list of 2,399 castes and listed them as OBCs, but the recommendations of the Commission were mired in controversy as its chairman presented the report with a personal letter wherein he criticized the use of caste as the basis of identifying OBCs.
- 27 The Mandal Commission also used the last census on caste (1931 census) and identified 3,742 castes as OBCs. The Mandal Commission evolved three criteria of social, educational and economic backwardness, but weighted indicators of social backwardness three times more than those of economic backwardness. The end result was that many castes that were low in caste ritual hierarchy but economically well-off were also included.
- 28 Exemptions were granted to three kinds of institutions. For details, see Note 23.
- 29 Caste, and with it untouchability, was seen as a feature of the Hindu community so the list of SCs included only groups from this religious community. The one notable exception to this was that lower castes among the Sikhs were also included; this was a concession that the community leaders obtained at the time of the framing of the constitution.
- 30 To give an example, the Karnataka State Commission for Backward Classes, Special Report 2000, points out that ‘Contrary to the findings of the Second Backward Classes Commission, it [the government ...] went on to add new castes and communities ... [T]hese communities were added arbitrarily without subjecting them to any test whatsoever’ (10–11). The report further stated: ‘At every step new additions have been made without the newly added castes being identified by any Backward Classes Commission, but on the contrary, directly against the findings recorded by such Backward Classes/Commissions ... while the percentage of population identified as backward by the Havanur Commission was 44.52 and 41.67 under Articles 15(4) and 16(4) of the Constitution respectively, the newly added population of castes and communities *not* identified by any Backward Classes Commission would come to about 30%’ (ibid.: 12–13). Indeed, many of the castes included had been identified as ‘forward’ castes by the Chinappa Reddy Commission.
- 31 Most of the time the recommendations of the national Backward Classes Commissions have been based on the 1931 census—the last census that recorded caste identities. Based on these data the Mandal Commission in 1980 estimated that 52% of the population were OBCs. This has remained the basis of government projections. However, the 1999–2000 National Sample Survey placed the OBC population at 32.1%. The Survey reached this estimate by asking the respondents to identify their caste, and then tallying /sorting the population by referring to the list of castes identified by the states as OBCs. This estimate was closer to the results of the National Family Health Survey 1998–99, which placed the OBC population at 32.4%, and within it the non-Muslim OBCs at 29.8% (Bhalla and Jain 2006).
- 32 Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions, *Annual Report*, 1999–2000, 2000–01, 2004–05, 2005–06. Indeed, the reports of the last five years show that almost all seats reserved for SCs and STs, and in recent times even for OBCs, have been filled.
- 33 Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions, *Annual Report* 2007–08.
- 34 As we go down to Class III and IV, the percentage representation of SCs and STs increases substantially.
- 35 *Annual Report of the University Grants Commission*, 1999–2000, quoted in the sixth report of the National Commission for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, 1999–2000, and 2000–01, p.153.
- 36 It is this difference in the capacity to access benefits that has placed Madigas against Malas in Andhra Pradesh, Matangs against Mahars in Maharashtra, Balmikis against Chamars in Punjab and other neighboring regions.
- 37 In the mid-1970s the Congress government in Punjab created a sub-quota for the Balmiki and Mazhabhi Sikhs (see Mahajan and Jodhka 2008); in Tamil Nadu a distinction is made between Backward Castes and Most-Backward Castes; in Karnataka in the 1980s the Venkatswamy Commission divided the beneficiaries into five groups, and subsequently a fourfold distinction was introduced in the form of Most Backward, More Backward, Backward, Occupational. This classification was further modified in 1994.
- 38 While the beneficiaries of reservations are all seen as being ‘backward’ (that is, lagging behind), within this category there are some who are worse-off even when compared with this marginalized population. These groups are referred to as the internally worse-off.

- 39 There are also new claimants for these benefits. Over the years, lower castes that had converted to Islam or Christianity (Dalit Muslims and Dalit Christians) are seeking recognition for this purpose. Since the Sachar Committee Report many sections of the Muslim population have also claimed similar benefits and now economically weaker sections of the majority religious community are also making similar demands. Indeed, in some states a small quota of seats in the reserved category is set aside for the latter two. What needs also to be underlined is that these conflicts among beneficiaries have further strengthened the politics of identities and allowed political parties to play on the vulnerabilities of the marginalized sections. This has in turn triggered the demand for excluding the past beneficiaries of reservations so as to make space for new entrants.
- 40 The complexity of the issues raised by the reservation system has often been lost in popular debate where everything is reduced to the question of merit and caste consciousness—both of which are seen as diluting the commitment to building an egalitarian, liberal society. It is perhaps important to realize that concerns of merit arise because of the peculiarity of the reservation system in India (see Mahajan 2009).

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13

THE STATE AND CIVIL SOCIETY IN COMMUNAL VIOLENCE

Sparks and fires

Ashutosh Varshney and Joshua Gubler

This chapter deals with a classic, but unresolved, analytic puzzle: how should one conceptualize, or theorize, the role of the state in communal violence?¹ Because it is the responsibility of the modern state to maintain law and order, a great deal is nearly always said about how the state is involved, or implicated in, ethnocommunal riots when they do take place. However, despite a plethora of literature, we still do not have a plausible theory of the relationship between the state and ethnocommunal violence.²

A good theory must specify, first, the conditions under which the state develops an *interest* in touching off, or worsening, communal riots, instead of preventing or containing them; and second, it must also clarify whether the state always has the *ability* to prevent or contain riots, even if it has an interest in doing so. In short, the key question for theory is: what makes the state unwilling and/or unable to enact its constitutionally assigned riot-preventing or riot-containing role?

In developing our answers, we approach the state indirectly. We first ask: under what conditions are preexisting interethnic or intercommunal *civic* (i.e. non-state) ties destroyed? Under what conditions are such ties built? We then draw some inferences about the role of the state.

Why do we focus on interethnic or intercommunal ties, or what has, following Putnam (2000), come to be called bridging, as opposed to bonding, social capital? Much of the classic theoretical wisdom in the field (Lijphart 1977), as well as some of the more recent work (Fearon and Laitin 1996), emphasizes how peaceful interaction between ethnic groups is, paradoxically, founded on the possibility of intense in-group interaction and institutions. A principal message of this literature is that the greater the *in-group* cultural life and/or interaction, the larger the possibility of *inter-group* accommodation and peace.

In contrast, on the basis of materials gathered on Hindu-Muslim relations in India, Varshney (2002) argued that *intercommunal* ties between Hindus and Muslims, not *intra*communal ties among Hindus or among Muslims, were a strong bulwark of communal peace. If towns and cities were organized only along intra-Hindu or intra-Muslim lines, the odds of riots (*fires*) breaking out, given a *spark* (tensions, rumors, small clashes), were very high. In Indian cities, bonding social capital was highly correlated with Hindu-Muslim violence, but bridging ties could put out sparks very effectively, not allowing them easily to disrupt the local equilibria of peace.

In this chapter, we wish to turn a cross-sectional comparison into an inter-temporal one: how is bridging social capital built or destroyed? Though Putnam (2000) explains how social capital was undermined in twentieth-century USA, we should note that we have no such studies for India or the developing world. Varshney (2002) simply asked what differentiated cities where Hindus and Muslims lived peacefully from those cities where endemic violence marked their relations, thereby comparing equilibria of peace with equilibria of violence. In effect, Varshney's inter-city comparison was cross-sectional. We now ask how peaceful cities become violent, and how violent cities turn towards peace. A new analytical candidate—the state—is beginning to emerge in the sites where we can already answer this question well.

While we are unable to develop a full-blown theory, we propose some building blocks, and a classification scheme for the types of state involvement in times of communal tensions and violence. We start with a summary of Varshney (2002). We then turn to three Indian analytical narratives: one at the state level, and two at the town level. In the third section, we turn our critical attention to those scholars who have proposed a state-based theory of communal violence. Next, we draw implications of our case narratives, focusing on the role of the state in building or undermining civic ties. The final section presents conclusions.

Bridging, bonding, and ethnocommunal violence

Why does communal violence take place? Varshney (2002) sought to answer the question by comparing Hindu-Muslim relations in six cities of India. Substantively, the main conclusion was that the presence or absence of inter-ethnic, or inter-communal, civic organizations—business associations, professional organizations, labor unions, political parties, reading clubs, sports clubs, film clubs, nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), and political parties—was critical to explaining why some cities had chronic ethnocommunal violence, while others, despite huge provocations, remained always, or nearly always, peaceful. Integrated associational life allows strong ties to be formed across communities, acting as a serious constraint over the polarizing strategies of those groups that would benefit from violence, including political parties and organizations.

How did this argument emerge? First, a large-n analysis of all recorded Hindu-Muslim riots during a 46-year period (1950–95) was carried out.³ It led to two important results. First, Hindu-Muslim riots were predominantly urban. A mere 4% of deaths in Hindu-Muslim riots took place in rural India, where roughly 70% of the country's population still lives and a much bigger proportion did in the 1950s. Second, within urban India, riots were highly locally concentrated. Eight cities—Ahmedabad, Bombay, Hyderabad, Baroda, Aligarh, Meerut, Delhi and Calcutta—accounted for a hugely disproportionate share of communal violence in the country: 49% of all urban deaths (and about 46% of all deaths, urban plus rural) in Hindu-Muslim violence. As a group, however, these eight cities today have a mere 18% of India's urban population (and about 6% of the country's total population, both urban and rural).

Hindu-Muslim violence was thus remarkably town or city specific. Often, a town just 40 miles–50 miles away from a riot-prone city remained calm. For example, an almost entirely peaceful town of Bulandshahar is a mere 50 miles away from the riot-prone Aligarh. Other examples are Surat and Baroda in the state of Gujarat, and Hyderabad and Warangal in the state of Andhra Pradesh.

State or national politics certainly played a role, but even the most inflammable periods of national or state politics did not fully undermine the local patterns of Hindu-Muslim relations. These larger political trends at the national or state level could essentially be conceptualized as 'sparks': depending on the local textures, not all of them became 'fires' in different towns.

To probe causal mechanisms, Varshney (2002) selected six cities and arranged them in three pairs. Each pair had a city/town where communal violence was endemic, and a city/town where it was rare, holding Hindu-Muslim percentages in the town population constant.

What causal mechanisms did the three pairs yield? On the whole, two mechanisms were identified. First, prior and sustained contact between members of different communities allowed communication between them to moderate tensions and preempt violence, when new tensions arose in the country, state or nearby towns. In cities of thick interaction between different communities, peace committees at the time of tension emerged *from below* in various neighborhoods. Such highly decentralized tension-managing organizations killed rumors, removed misunderstandings, and often policed neighborhoods.

Second, in cities that had associational integration as well, not just everyday integration, the foundations of peace were stronger. In such settings, even those politicians who would, in theory, benefit from ethnic killings found it hard to instigate violence. Without a nexus between politicians and criminals, big riots and killings were highly improbable.⁴ In all violent cities in the India project, a nexus of politicians and criminals was in evidence. Organized gangs could easily undermine neighborhood peace, often causing migration from integrated to segregated neighborhoods. People moved in search of physical safety.

In contrast, if labor unions, business associations, middle-class associations of doctors and lawyers, film clubs of poorer classes (as in south India), and at least some political parties were integrated, even an otherwise mighty politician-criminal nexus was unable to rupture existing links. Everyday engagement in the neighborhoods might not be able to stand up to the marauding gangs protected by powerful politicians, but the strength of organizations constituted a forbidding obstacle for politically shielded gangs. A synergy emerged between the local wings of the state and local civic organizations, making it easier to police the emerging situation and preventing it from degenerating into riots and killings. *Local civil society, in and of itself, did not ensure peace. Rather, if communally integrated, it made the functioning of the local wings of the state more effective.*

State involvement: some analytical narratives

In light of the discussion above, how should we conceptualize state involvement in communal violence? We present three analytical narratives below. The narratives are important for they lay out the process through which peace is obtained, or violence erupts.

We begin with Gujarat 2002, one of the most obvious examples of state involvement in Hindu-Muslim riots in post-independence Indian history, where nearly 1,500 people, mostly Muslim, were killed and many thousands made homeless. We ask in what sense was this Gujarat violence consistent with, and/or different from, the theory presented above. We then move to two city-level cases: Ahmedabad and Bhiwandi. In the former, by the late 1960s, a long phase of communal peace turned into a new period of endemic violence. In the latter, the opposite happened: endemic rioting gave way to communal peace. In different ways, the state was an important variable in each change.

***Gujarat 2002: pogroms, not riots*⁵**

After a train carrying Hindu pilgrims was torched, allegedly by a Muslim mob, on February 28, 2002, the worst carnage of India's independent history took place. Up to 1,500 people lost their lives, mostly Muslims. Based on the 1950–95 time series, Gujarat was clearly the worst state in India for Hindu-Muslim violence (Varshney 2002). Moreover, the data also clearly specified

three Gujarat towns—Ahmedabad, Baroda and Godhra—as the most violence-prone. These three turned out to be the worst sites of violence in 2002 as well.⁶

Not everything about Gujarat violence was, however, predictable. In one respect, the 2002 violence was shockingly different from previous violence. Unless later research disproves the proposition, the existing reports give us every reason to believe that the *riots* in Gujarat were actually full-blooded *pogroms*. Two common reference sources define pogrom as follows:

An organized, often officially encouraged massacre or persecution of a minority group, especially one conducted against Jews.

(www.dictionary.com)

a mob attack, either approved or condoned by authorities, against the persons and property of a religious, racial, or national minority.

(www.britannica.com)

After the train was torched, the state made no attempt to prevent, or stop, revenge killings. State police looked the other way, as gangs murdered scores of Muslims with remarkable ease.⁷ The statements of NGOs most closely associated with the Gujarat state government, run by the Hindu nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), openly supported anti-Muslim violence. According to the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP), the BJP government did what was absolutely necessary: namely, allow Hindu retaliation against the Muslims, including those who had nothing to do with the mob that originally torched the train in Godhra.⁸ From a constitutional perspective, of course, it is not the duty of the government, whatever its ideological color, to stoke or allow public anger and violence, no matter what the provocation. No elected government that takes an oath to protect the lives of its citizens should behave like criminal gangs, hungry for a tit-for-tat. In 2002 the distinction between the constitutional and the ideological, however, disappeared in Gujarat.

Gujarat violence calls for a conceptual distinction between riots and pogroms. Riots are a clash between civilian groups, in which state neutrality may be in doubt, but state neutrality as a principle is not abandoned. Pogroms are state-approved or state-condoned attacks on a hapless minority, often not in a position to retaliate (Varshney 2007). The state is, thus, integrally linked to violence in pogroms, but its role in riots cannot be derived from an understanding of its role in pogroms. To understand how the state deals with riots, we present two different narratives below.

State power as a source of civic entrapment: Ahmedabad, Gujarat

The pattern of communal relations has changed dramatically in the city of Ahmedabad, also located in the state of Gujarat, India.⁹ During 1920–69 the city was on the whole communally peaceful, but the five-day carnage during September 1969 turned out to be a major turning point. About 630 people were killed. During 1969 and 2002 Ahmedabad became one of the most riot-prone cities of India. In 2002 alone, an estimated 800–1,000 people died during two weeks of rioting. What were the foundations of Ahmedabad's communal peace until 1969? How did the structures of peace break down?

The inter-communal civic life of Ahmedabad rested on four large organizational pillars: a cadre-based political party engaged in mass politics; mass-based labor organizations; a long tradition of strong business organizations; and social and economic organizations inspired by Gandhian ideology. All brought Hindus and Muslims together. Of the four pillars, we will concentrate on the first two only, far and away the most important given their organizational strength and the numbers of people involved in them.

The Congress Party, the city's first organizational pillar of peace, took to mass politics in the 1920s under Mahatma Gandhi's leadership and influence. The party reached the acme of its strength in Gujarat, especially Ahmedabad, in the first half of the twentieth century.¹⁰ The cadres were trained in the party's ideology of Hindu-Muslim unity.

After Independence in 1947, the Congress Party took control of government from the departing British rulers.¹¹ The decline of the party as a civic organization followed its ascent to state power. The more the party ran governments, the more it attracted people interested in power and its benefits, not cadres committed to ideology and grassroots work. A lot of those who joined the Congress when it fought British rulers, did not do so because they could exercise governmental power. If anything, imprisonment was more likely than a shot at rule. A commitment to the ideology of the movement was a key motivating factor.¹²

An intercommunal trade union

Ahmedabad was a leading center of Indian textiles for much of the twentieth century. Founded by Gandhi, it also developed a major city-wide union, called the Textile Labor Association (TLA). In the 1920s and 1930s the TLA became a formidable mass-based organization. It was not only concerned with wages and conditions in the workplace, but also ran adult literacy schools for workers, schools for children and scholarship schemes. It developed reading rooms and libraries, girls' dormitories, and women's welfare centers; created housing, credit, and consumer cooperatives; managed social and cultural centers to provide meeting places for cultural programs; and formed neighborhood inspection committees to deal with routine complaints of workers. Tens of thousands of workers and their families thus came under its influence.

The TLA was funded primarily by workers' subscriptions. It maintained close contact with the Congress Party, though it remained organizationally distinct. When the Congress Party came to power at Independence in 1947, the TLA was made the only 'representative union' in Ahmedabad textiles by law. Only a representative union had the legal authority to represent workers in courts, and in negotiations with employers and government.

So long as the TLA was required to compete with other unions, as in the 1930s, it had no choice but to undertake organizational work for survival and growth. Once government patronage was available, the TLA became a victim of its monopoly status. It did not have to work as hard. The organization increasingly lost touch with the base.

The TLA's civic consciousness and involvement prevented riots in the city's vast workers' quarters at the time of India's partition, when so much of the country witnessed Hindu-Muslim violence. A vibrant union knew what it took to keep working communities together. By the late 1960s, it was strong enough to run relief camps after riots, but not vigorous enough to *prevent* riots in working-class neighborhoods.

Ahmedabad demonstrates how civic organizations can deteriorate if they get, or seek, state patronage. The desire for greater power via government patronage may be tempting, but such moves can seriously undermine civic and organizational fervor.

State power as a source of civic regeneration: Bhiwandi, Maharashtra¹³

Bhiwandi, a town just outside Bombay, was infamous for Hindu-Muslim riots in the 1970s and 1980s. Nearly 200 lives—large numbers for a small town—were lost in riots during those years. The pattern changed, however, after a new police chief arrived in 1988 and started an organizational experiment.¹⁴ In the following three years, Bhiwandi became a peaceful town. It could keep communal peace even in the worst of times, as between 1988–93, when the Ram Janmabhumi

movement was under way, and again in 2002, when awful riots in the nearby state of Gujarat took place. Building Hindu-Muslim contacts around common issues of concern turned out to be the critical organizational device.

The police chief believed that instead of fighting fires at the time of riots, it was better to prevent riots by bringing Hindus and Muslims together in normal times. If the Hindus and Muslims could meet each other often enough and discuss common problems, an edifice of communication and perhaps trust would be created, which could be used for peace at the time of communal tensions. The police chief decided to put together neighborhood committees (*mohalla samitis*) for the whole town. They would meet once a week in the normal course, but daily in times of tension, with a police officer presiding. Over time, the committees became so successful that even non-members started attending.

How did this structure help? During 1988–91 riots were widespread, as the Hindu nationalist mobilization for the destruction of the Baburi mosque took off. In Bhiwandi:

when passions ran high ... , members on both sides came together and voluntarily undertook the task of patrolling the streets for nights on end. Rumours were suppressed on the spot and rumour-mongers handed over to the police ... [As a result], the evil-doers preferred to lie low ... [and] were totally isolated by the constant vigilance against them by committee members.¹⁵

In 1991, after the police chief was transferred at the end of his three-year term, his successor kept the committee structure. By December 1992, when the Baburi mosque was torn down, Bhiwandi's Hindus and Muslims had developed such understanding, resolve and confidence that peace was successfully kept. No lives were lost.

In 2002 again, when awful riots broke out in the neighboring state of Gujarat, Bhiwandi remained peaceful. The head of the local Bajrang Dal, an extreme Hindu nationalist organization, was murdered. That is normally a big spark in a town, very likely to lead to terrible fires. The suspicion was that some Muslims had killed him to avenge the killings of fellow Muslims by Hindu nationalist mobs in Gujarat. Yet again, no riots broke out in the city. Tensions did emerge, but only to subside. The neighborhood committees have become an abiding feature of the town.¹⁶

To conclude, with a strong civic structure in place, the state can prevent riots with considerable ease. Some other cities have of late followed the Bhiwandi model of neighborhood committees, reporting considerable success (Barve 2003; Thakkar 2004).

Elections, minorities and the state

Unlike the argument above, there is a strand of scholarship that holds the state responsible for communal violence, and makes the case that if the state wants to prevent riots, it can, and it does. Why, then, would the state target the minorities? Political reasons provide the link between riots and the ruling party in a democracy—and therefore, to the state.

Brass (1997, 2003) has repeatedly made this argument. Consider his standard formulation:

What we can say with assurance is that the state government and the district administration have the knowledge and the power to contain and control riots when they develop and probably to prevent them before they happen. The Indian state and most of its state governments are not 'weak', lacking the authority or the power to act decisively when they choose to do so. When riots start, it is often because of intense political competition at either or both the district and state levels, that is, because at least one

strong party or other political force is willing to pursue the game of brinkmanship. When the authorities do not act decisively to contain and control riots, it is not because they do not have the means to do so, but because, for political reasons, they choose not to do so.¹⁷

There are two points to be made here. First, Brass leaves it unclear what the ‘political reasons’ are. If by ‘political’ Brass means ‘votes,’ then one can interpret his reasoning in two ways: either targeting Muslims is a way to garner votes for the party ruling the state, presumably votes of the Hindu majority; or it is advantageous for the ruling party to create a political situation, whereby providing protection to the Muslim minority during violence is a means of getting Muslim votes. The latter, too, would require violence to go on, for only if violence takes place can the ruling party blame it on the opposition and show that it can protect the Muslims. It is hard to imagine how the latter political game can repeatedly be played without the Muslim minority figuring out the intention of the ruling party. Muslims have to be under a thick and long-lasting veil of ignorance for this political strategy to work. There are, thus, missing links in the theory. We need evidence based on Muslim attitudes towards the riots, not simply inferences based on how the state behaved during times of violence; we also need evidence that the ruling party, regardless of its ideology or social base, would like to target Muslims. Hindu nationalists might well behave that way. Why would the Congress Party? The fact that a lot of riots in India have taken place under Congress rule only thickens the explanatory puzzle. It does not establish that the Congress desired riots and wanted Muslims to be killed.

Second, the research of Brass is essentially case-based, confined as it is to some towns and villages of Uttar Pradesh (UP). Indeed, his case materials rely heavily on the state’s three riot-prone towns: Meerut, Kanpur and Aligarh. He neither studies cases from outside Uttar Pradesh, nor does he study variations in outcome within the state. Close to each of the riot-prone cities he has analyzed towns that have never, or rarely, had communal riots, even though they have substantial Muslim populations. Bulandshahar is next to Aligarh, Saharanpur next to Meerut, and Lucknow very close to Kanpur. Bulandshahar, Saharanpur and Lucknow have not had Hindu–Muslim riots, at least since Independence.

Current methodological arguments in political science make it clear that while theories can be formulated on the basis of commonalities in cases (Gerring 2006), those based on variations in outcome have greater causal potential (King *et al.* 1994). One cannot really be sure that the factors identified as causal in the analysis of similar cases are indeed causal, unless these factors can be shown to be absent in cases radically dissimilar (Varshney 2002, 2007).

This is not a problem in the second, and a more recent, state-based theory. Wilkinson (2004) not only covers cases that look dissimilar, but he covers the entire gamut of variation by using large-*n* regression analysis covering all riots during 1950 and 1995. Echoing Brass, Wilkinson argues, ‘Whether violence is bloody or ends quickly depends ... primarily on the will and capacity of the government that controls the forces of law and order’ (ibid.: 5). What, then, will determine whether the state will use force to protect ethnic minorities from violence? ‘... [G]overnment will increase the supply of protection to minorities when ... minorities are an important part of their party’s current support base ... Or when the overall electoral system in a state is so competitive—in terms of the effective number of parties—that the governing party will have to negotiate or form coalitions with minority supported parties’ (ibid.: 6–7). In sum, the level of competitiveness at the state level and requirement of minority support for political survival decreases, or eliminates, riots.¹⁸

It needs, first, to be asked why one must have such faith in the capacity of India’s state governments, which control law and order. A cross-country comparison should make the skepticism clearer. Are not state capacity in the USA, Britain and France much higher than in

India? Yet the USA could not prevent the so-called Rodney King riots in 1992 (as well as the riots of the 1960s), while Britain witnessed racial rioting in the 1980s, and Arab migrants in France rioted in 2005. Los Angeles, Brixton and Paris burned, while the police wielded their batons and even shot to discipline the crowds. If Western states can have such problems, what can be the basis for the belief that prevention of riots depends ‘on the will and capacity of the government that controls the forces of law and order’?¹⁹

Moreover, Wilkinson uses the idea of an effective number of parties to measure electoral competition at the state level. Using that measure, Wilkinson argues that the clearest support for his theory comes from how Indian states handled the 2002 riots. Having a *bipolar* electoral arena split between the BJP and the Congress Party, Gujarat in 2002 was among the states with the lowest number of effective parties. It also contained a party in power, the BJP, which had *no need for Muslim votes*. In the states of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, the electoral arena had been *multipolar* for over a decade and a half. Both states have among the highest number of effective parties in India. Moreover, the ruling parties in both states were *dependent on Muslim support* in 2002. The states of Madhya Pradesh (MP) and Rajasthan—adjacent to Gujarat and like Gujarat having a bipolar electoral arena split mainly between the BJP and Congress—might have had a low number of effective parties, but the political party in power, the Congress, unlike the BJP in Gujarat, needed Muslim votes.

Thus, Gujarat in 2002 had the worst of both worlds; UP and Bihar (and Kerala) the best of both; and MP and Rajasthan were in between. In consequence, Wilkinson argues, Gujarat had gruesome violence, but UP, Bihar, MP and Rajasthan escaped it altogether.

Ironically, the Varshney-Wilkinson dataset (Varshney and Wilkinson 2006), on which much of Wilkinson’s argument is based, also provides many counter-examples, which we ought to consider. If Gujarat state was ruled by the BJP in 2002, the Congress Party, *which is known to be dependent on the Muslim vote in most states of India and has often systematically courted Muslims since the first Indian election in 1952*, ruled Gujarat on the following occasions when riots broke out: January 1982; March 1984; March–July 1985; January, March and July 1986; January, February and November 1987; April, October, November and December 1990; January, March and April 1991; and January and July 1992. The BJP, opposed to Muslims, came to power in Gujarat state only in 1995. Riots were endemic in the state of Gujarat for a much longer time.

Counter-examples from other Indian states, not simply from Gujarat, can also be cited. During Bombay riots in January 1993, the Congress Party was in charge of the state government. During the awful 1980s riots in the state of UP, the Congress Party ran state governments; moreover, at that time Indira Gandhi, who appealed for Muslim votes for most of her political life, ruled in New Delhi. Finally, and most remarkably of all, the riots of 1961 occurred when Nehru was India’s prime minister. As is widely known, Nehru had an unquestionable commitment to India’s Muslims. Moreover, almost all states of the country were Congress-ruled during his tenure (1947–64).

It is well known that large-*n* regression analysis is basically about the central tendency of a scatter plot of data points, something which a couple of outliers do not significantly alter. However, counter-examples undermining Wilkinson’s theory are simply too many to be brushed aside as outliers, or occasional deviations from the trend line. Wilkinson’s argument can at best explain why the BJP-led state governments might not want to protect Muslims, but why did Nehru, Indira Gandhi and Congress-led state governments repeatedly fail to stem riots?

Towards a different formulation

To our mind, the best explanation, which also looks at the role of the state, can be conceptualized as below. We have already used the metaphor of ‘sparks’ (small clashes, tensions, rumors) and

‘fires’ (riots and pogroms); we return to it to explain how, as a result of the state’s role, change occurs.

State behavior can constitute a spark. Or a spark, wherever and however it emerged, may be fanned by the state, even though it is the constitutional responsibility of the state to put disturbances down by any legal means necessary. It follows that to the extent that a state is controlled by a communal party, the sparks confronting local mechanisms will be that much bigger. Depending on the strength of the local bridging capital, however, the peaceful towns may still not witness the outbreak of communal fires. Under increasing assault, some of them may well come apart. We diagrammatically represent this process in Figure 13.1.

In an inter-temporal sense, then, the bigger the spark, the greater will be the possibility of a change to the prevailing distribution of peace and violence. Once allowed to grow by the state’s ruling political party, police or bureaucracy, the provocation may well be such that it overwhelms local structures that had made it possible for some towns, during earlier periods of violence, to remain peaceful. This would then lead to a greater dispersion of communal violence in a state than had been observed historically—by breaking the civic barriers that towns had constructed and by making the riot-prone towns even worse.

In light of this, let us now reinterpret the cases discussed in the second section of this chapter. First, when the state plays a role directly detrimental to peace, the state enters the process outlined above through sparks. Its behavior, actions and ideology could generate tensions, to which different towns with their varying civic texture react. Communal violence thus becomes a product of the intensity of the spark on one hand, and the strength of the bridging civic texture of the town on the other. The state may not put out the sparks, as mandated by the constitution, instead allowing them to become fires. Gujarat in 2002 is an example of such a role.

In contrast, when the state plays a positive role towards peace, it can enter the process in two ways: first, it can seek to ensure through its control over local police and administration that when communal tensions arise, they are nipped in the bud by administrative action; or second,

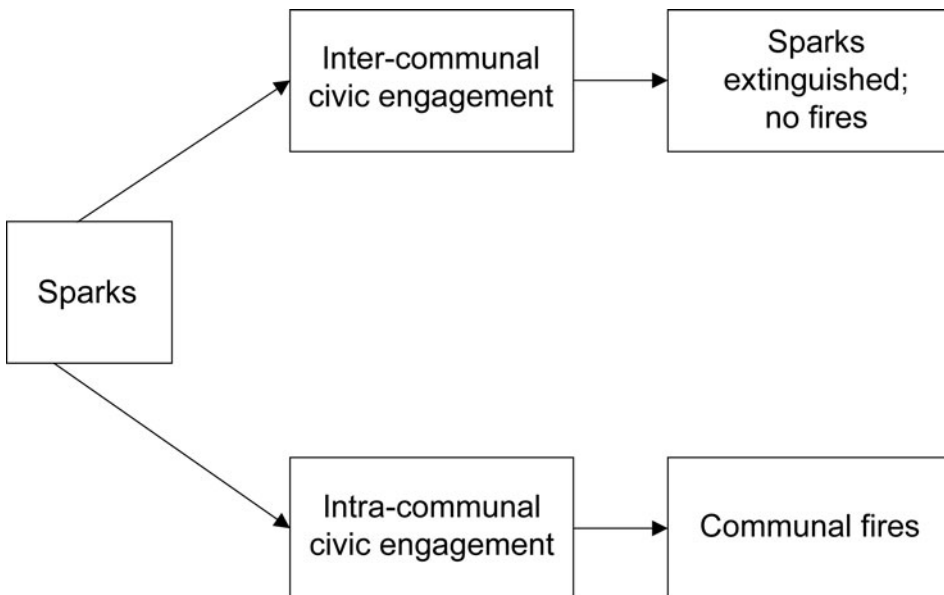


Figure 13.1 The state, civil society and communal violence

it can also do that through civic mechanisms—by building and nurturing bridging social capital and making the law-and-order function of the local police and administration easier, as lasting environmental support for police functions during riots is created. The Bhiwandi case is an illustration of this second option. The local state organs sought to build defenses against a future disruption of peace by establishing bridging institutions. That is why it has successfully contained tensions over the last two decades, even as nearby towns have burned.

A third possibility, exemplified by Ahmedabad in the 1960s, concerns the indirect role of the state. In this scenario, the state does not seek to destroy the bridging social capital. Rather, the organizations that embodied such capital seek state patronage and develop a special relationship with the state. While this gives them power, it also tends to reduce incentives to mobilize and engage in organizational work, thereby eroding their civic capacity. They develop feet of clay, and their capacity to generate intercommunal civic engagement declines. Under such circumstances, a small spark—for example, a clash over cows, as happened in Ahmedabad in September 1969, something not otherwise uncommon in India—becomes hard to contain. Brutal and gruesome violence can result.

Conclusion

It is certainly true that the *empirical* state, as opposed to the *juridical* state, is not abidingly committed to its constitutional role of keeping peace. The state can, indeed, side with the majority community and violently target minorities, or allow the majority community to do so. However, it is also highly imprecise to conceptualize the state as an actor *always* interested in, or capable of, violence for the sake of electoral ends on behalf of the ruling party. Pogroms and riots are two different conceptual categories. State-condoned or state-sponsored riots are pogroms; violent clashes between groups that the state is unable to stop are riots. Not all riots in India have been pogroms; only some have been. The state in India has played a variety of roles at the time of communal tensions, including those that are systematically peaceful. Understanding how the state behaves, and the outcomes of its actions, also requires an understanding of how civil society might be organized.

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Notes

- 1 In this chapter, we shall use the terms ‘ethnic,’ ‘communal,’ and ‘ethnocommunal’ interchangeably. For a rationale, see Horowitz 1985: chapter 1. For a plea that the term ‘ethnic’ should not be used widely, see Chandra 2006.
- 2 The most recent accounts of state involvement in riots are Brass (1997, 2003), and Wilkinson (2004). We discuss them in the third section of the chapter.
- 3 Constructed jointly by Steven Wilkinson (Yale University) and Varshney. This dataset is now publicly available with ICPSR. See Varshney and Wilkinson 2006.
- 4 However, see Petersen (2002) for a very different account from East Central Europe.
- 5 For a fuller analysis, see Varshney (2003).
- 6 In contrast to Ahmedabad or Baroda, Varshney (2002) identified Surat as a town that had managed to develop civic mechanisms to insulate itself from the state-wide trend. Yet again in March and April

2002 the violence in Surat was minimal, even as Baroda and Ahmedabad, not too far away, experienced carnage.

- 7 This narrative is based on a reading of the following newspapers: *The Times of India*, *The Indian Express*, and *The Hindustan Times*.
- 8 'Parivar Wars,' *The Times of India*, June 26, 2002.
- 9 This section is heavily abbreviated from chapters 9–11 of Varshney (2002).
- 10 Mahatma Gandhi's deputy, Sardar Patel, is widely viewed as the organizational genius behind the success of Gujarat's Congress Party.
- 11 The party had ruled earlier sporadically at the city and provincial level, but not with much power, as it was under British sovereignty.
- 12 In 1957, within 10 years of Independence, a well-known committee of the Congress Party noted the civic malaise. 'Congress workers at the base have lost contact with the people ... their discipline has become loose ...' (All-India Congress Committee 1957: 42). The committee warned that 'to combat the evils of communalism, it is necessary to establish properly functioning village, Ward or mohalla [neighborhood] Congress committees' (ibid.: 5).
- 13 For more details, see Varshney (2002: 293–97).
- 14 Suresh Khopade, a police officer in Maharashtra state, was appointed deputy commissioner of police for Bhiwandi. In his unpublished memoirs, *Bhiwandi Riots and After* (Khopade n.d.), he has given a detailed account of his initiatives. Varshney independently confirmed the account through interviews.
- 15 Khopade n.d.: 119.
- 16 Indeed, by 2008–09, the local power company was using the neighborhood committees to develop a better power distribution network and prevent electricity thefts. Based on interviews in April 2009.
- 17 Brass 1997: 287–88.
- 18 Wilkinson also argues that the level of electoral competitiveness at the local level, as opposed to the state level, produces the opposite result: namely, increase in riots. In the interest of space, we do not concentrate on this argument here. We do have a critique elsewhere (Varshney and Gubler 2012).
- 19 For implications of this analysis for a recent debate in India, see Varshney 2011.

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14

INSURGENCIES IN INDIA

Paul Staniland

Independent India is often hailed as a triumph of democracy in a poor, multiethnic society (Stepan *et al.* 2011). This success must be qualified by the armed challenges to the Indian state that have regularly erupted and endured during its modern history. Insurgencies in India have been motivated by religious, ethno-linguistic, and leftist ideologies, reflecting the heterogeneity of the peoples ruled by the Indian state. Separatist conflicts in Punjab, Jammu and Kashmir (J&K), Nagaland, Assam, Manipur, Mizoram, and Tripura have turned many of India's border regions into war zones for years—even decades. Maoist insurgents in West Bengal, Andhra Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, and Chhattisgarh operated and continue to operate in vast interior areas of the country. Insurgency and counterinsurgency has taken an extraordinary toll in human suffering, economic costs, and social dislocation. Internal conflict is an integral, if often under-studied, part of India's political experience (Ollapally 2008; Marwah 2009).

This chapter explores the historical roots of major insurgent movements and government responses. It begins with an examination of the federal structure of the Indian state and of those center-periphery tensions that this framework has been unable to manage peacefully. The major separatist insurgencies find their roots in problems of managing distinct political aspirations within a single political system: centralizing and repressive policies at the center, intra-ethnic political competition on the periphery, and the availability of external sanctuary and support have created volatile situations on India's northwestern and northeastern frontiers. It then deals with the specific separatist conflicts that have emerged from these political contexts, starting in the northeast and then addressing the wars in Punjab and J&K.

The outcomes of these conflicts have taken on quite distinct forms, creating variation that can improve our broader understanding of how insurgencies endure and end. For instance, there have been a formal peace deal in Mizoram, informal bargains in Nagaland, the military crushing of the rebellion in Punjab, and enduring low-level violence in Assam. The history of separatist insurgency in India thus provides fascinating diversity in the origins and trajectories of intense political violence (Ganguly and Fidler 2009; Gayer and Jaffrelot 2009).

The chapter then shifts focus to the leftist rebellions in India, which have roots in different areas and different causal dynamics. In regions affected by Maoist insurgency (known as the Naxalites), a mix of absent and predatory state presence, along with socially marginalized populations, have created areas ripe for rebellion. Here the problem of center-state relations has become important in shaping the responses of the government apparatus to insurgency. Coordinating across states

when facing a motivated, geographically spread-out movement has proven extremely difficult. The endurance of the Naxalite insurgency may pose the largest internal security threat to India because of its ability to fragment directly the state's monopoly of violence in the interior.

This chapter concludes by drawing out some general insights that help us understand the dynamics of violence in India. First, the roots of separatism crucially involve the ways that center-periphery relations intersect with political and militant competition within peripheral areas. Focusing on either Delhi or areas of potential separatism is insufficient. Second, the dynamics of Naxalism reflect the dual problems of insufficient and excessive state strength. Minimal or nonexistent service provision, basic law enforcement, and infrastructure create areas within which insurgents can mobilize, while crackdowns by poorly trained, often brutal security forces can trigger escalation and growing violence. Third, Indian counterinsurgency challenges conventional wisdoms. Some wars have been ended by the ruthless application of coercion and human rights abuses, while others have been resolved or at least stabilized by political bargains, tacit deals, and the creation of ambiguous nexuses of politics, violence, and criminality. Counterinsurgency analyses that have emerged in recent years do not reflect the numerous tools that states can deploy to manage (not necessarily monopolize) violence.

Federalism and social diversity in India

India is a federal state in which there is a division of responsibility between the federal government in New Delhi and state governments. For our purposes, it is important that the central government is responsible for national security and defense while, under most circumstances, state governments are responsible for law and order among other areas (Manor 2001). The federal system emerged after Independence as a means of managing ethnic and linguistic diversity: demands for autonomy could be accommodated more easily than in a unitary structure like that of Sri Lanka. Indian states vary dramatically in their languages, social structures, economies, and party competition, and the federal system institutionalizes these differences rather than attempting to homogenize them.

This federal structure generally has been successful, particularly in mitigating linguistic conflict in south India in the 1950s and 1960s. However, it relies on the center accepting the balance of responsibility. Article 356 of the Indian Constitution allows the central government to dismiss a state government on the recommendation of the centrally appointed governor of the state. The resulting President's Rule is only supposed to be applied in rare situations in which the state government has shown an inability to maintain the constitutional machinery of government. However, President's Rule can be abused by a central government that hopes to marginalize opposition parties at the state level. Article 356 can be used as a tool of centralization and political maneuvering rather than as a true Emergency measure. This abuse polarizes center-state relations and makes peripheral political actors less trusting of Delhi.

The tension also comes from the state level. A great fear of central governments is that state governments will become intimidated by or sympathetic to separatist insurgencies. In some cases, local political actors engage in processes of 'outbidding' within their ethnic or religious bloc in the direction of separatist sentiment. Sometimes their goal is simply to create a new state within the Indian Union, but sometimes it is at least formally Independence. The basic idea of the federal bargain is that states will retain loyalty to India even while acting with significant autonomy within it. Separatist rhetoric and positions—and connections with armed actors—can trigger center-state conflict and tension. Local political competition within states thus can be an impetus for the center to become more hostile and interventionist. This combination may lead to escalation, violence, and even insurgency.

The federal system demands a careful balance between local autonomy and central authority. This balance is manageable under most circumstances, but it is most clearly threatened when dealing with linguistic and religious groups that have access to external support and that see themselves as distinctive from the Indian heartland. When these relations break down and violence erupts, the Indian state deploys large numbers of Army and Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) forces—especially the Border Security Force (BSF) and Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF)—to target insurgents and political dissidents. In doing so, it often sidelines local police and politicians who are seen as infiltrated or untrustworthy. Variants of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act since 1958, as well as other pieces of legislation, have created immunity for central armed forces in the northeast and J&K, contributing to human rights abuses and heavy-handed behavior. It is possible to reclaim a stable equilibrium (as has happened in Punjab and Mizoram), but this outcome requires time and a careful combination of coercion and political bargaining that is easier suggested than done.

Separatist movements and the problems of center-state relations

The emergence of armed separatism in India is linked to the problems of center-state relations and of relations within states between political contenders. It is also important to keep in mind India's geopolitical environment to understand insurgency specifically, as opposed simply to contentious politics, protest, or political grandstanding. India's neighbors historically have shown willingness (even eagerness) to provide guns, money, sanctuary, and training to insurgent groups, thus creating a greater opportunity for armed groups to emerge and endure. The regional context makes the periphery particularly primed for violent conflict, as does the existence of distinct social blocs and networks that define themselves in reaction to the massive Indian 'mainland.' The international and domestic cannot be easily distinguished in these regions.

This section identifies the origins and evolutions of the major separatist insurgencies in India. In doing so, it comparatively analyzes the shared and distinctive features of each war. Two points deserve particular emphasis. First, the origins of separatist conflicts have combined central misperceptions and miscalculations with debilitating local political and military competition that escalated conflict. Military counterinsurgency policies often have been poorly adapted to circumstances, though there are possibilities for learning (Rajagopalan 2000). Second, there has been significant variety in the trajectories and resolution of these wars. Some have ended in formal deals, others in tacit bargains, and others through brute force, while yet other conflicts endure as low-level peripheral wars.

Northeast

India's northeast is a collection of seven states wedged between Myanmar (Burma), Bangladesh, Bhutan, and China. Though the region includes only about 4% of the Indian population, it is strategically important, includes remarkable linguistic and religious diversity, and has become a site of enduring violence and conflict (as well as some changes towards peace and diminishing violence). At Independence in 1947, the region consisted of the state of Assam, the princely states of Manipur and Tripura, and the North East Frontier Agency (NEFA). Manipur and Tripura became Union Territories in 1949 and then states in 1972. NEFA was part of Assam until becoming a Union Territory in 1972 and a state in 1987 as Arunachal Pradesh. Other states would emerge from Assam: Nagaland in 1963, Meghalaya in 1972, and Mizoram in 1987. Some of the areas of the original Assam state and its various successors have had autonomy or been substantially controlled by New Delhi.

These political reorganizations over time reflect the mobilization and tensions within the northeast, which are often intertwined. Insurgencies have occurred in contemporary Nagaland, Assam, Mizoram, Manipur, and Tripura, involving dozens of armed groups with complicated links to external states, illicit economies, and electoral politics (Lacina 2009). India's management of its northeastern frontier has combined violence and bargaining, and has been largely ignored in mainstream politics. The northeast is important for strategic reasons but lacks the emotional resonance and publicity of the Kashmir and Punjab crises, and thus sees different political dynamics than in those conflicts. The conflicts in the region are extraordinarily complex, and this chapter can only provide a bare sketch of their contours.

The original insurgency that emerged in the region in the mid-1950s was by Naga political entrepreneurs who believed that they had been granted autonomy and the option to leave India at the time of partition. The Indian government did not look sympathetically at these claims. Intra-Naga violence led to the introduction of Indian combat forces and the escalation of violence into a full-fledged insurgency in the Naga areas of eastern Assam state. Naga insurgents were able to find sanctuary in neighboring areas of Burma and, even after the creation of a Nagaland state within India, received support from China and Pakistan (Hazarika 1994). The state's politics have spilled over into neighboring states both through the mobilization of Naga populations in these states and through National Socialist Council of Nagalim (NSCN) training of and support for other separatist movements. During the 1970s, negotiations between the government of India and moderate Naga factions led to greater political participation and incorporation.

However, the NSCN broke away to continue the struggle, splitting into several factions, all of which have arrived at ceasefire deals with the Indian government. These ceasefires basically create distinct spheres of influence, with India and Naga elected politicians on the one hand, and Naga armed groups on the other, avoiding direct violence against one another. Much of the violence is instead between these Naga factions as they compete for influence within the Naga ethnic group. The conflict has transformed from a straightforward insurgency into a more complicated wartime political order (Baruah 2003). Though Indian forces and Naga insurgents have used significant coercion and violence over the decades, the state of play over the last 15 years has been one of stability, though not peace. This arrangement may be lasting but at some point it seems plausible that a more institutionalized deal could be arrived at.

The other major insurgency to break out in the early years after Independence was that of the Mizo National Front (MNF) in the mid-1960s. Following a famine in Mizo areas and the perception that the Assam government neglected the Mizos, the MNF violently mobilized for an independent state. Impressively organized, the MNF rapidly established significant influence and power. The Indian state responded with forced population relocations and influxes of troops. The 1971 India–Pakistan war ended the MNF's sanctuary in East Pakistan (now Bangladesh) and opened political space for other Mizo political forces to emerge. However, the key turning point was the decision by the MNF to cut a deal directly with Delhi, which finally occurred in 1986 and led to an MNF government taking power in the state of Mizoram. This is a case in which direct negotiation with an insurgent group paid dividends.

Other insurgencies in the northeast have been driven by interethnic competition, particularly the perceived threat of massive migration from the outside or by claims on a state by members of another ethnic group (Hazarika 1994). The clearest example is the rise of the United Liberation Front of Asom (ULFA) in Assam in the 1980s. Bangladeshi migration into Assam came to be viewed as an existential threat by Assamese 'sons of the soil' (Weiner 1978). Student mobilization and riots against Bangladeshi migrants in the late 1970s and 1980s accompanied the rise of ULFA as a major insurgent group that became extremely powerful in large swaths of Assam. Eventually Delhi imposed President's Rule and used the Army and MHA paramilitaries to restore order.

Insurgency and counterinsurgency dominated Assam during much of the 1990s. ULFA militancy spurred reactions from minority tribal and linguistic groups within Assam, particularly among the Bodos, which proliferated both armed groups and various autonomous governance structures. The government was able to pull away some ULFA splinters and to suppress the insurgency, which draws sustenance from cross-border sanctuaries and links to other armed groups. At present, ULFA is a contained and apparently divided force, but Assam remains heavily garrisoned and has seen outbreaks of various types of interethnic violence. As in Kashmir, Assam exists in a realm of 'ugly stability' in which the insurgency is marginalized but political normalcy is elusive.

In Manipur, an extremely complex insurgency arose from the early 1960s led by members of the Meitei ethnic group. This movement then became locked into ethnic conflict with Nagas and Kukis, with NSCN factions operating in Naga areas and Kuki armed groups growing. Communist and Muslim armed groups have also emerged (and in some cases disappeared) in the state, which remains heavily populated by a variety of insurgent organizations. The government response has combined coercion, bargaining, and amnesty offers without much overall success. Manipur remains extremely unstable and characterized by byzantine links between insurgents, politicians, crime, and the state.

In Tripura, another complex insurgency emerged in backlash against influxes of migrants in the mid-1960s and then again in the early 1980s. A proliferation of armed groups has developed during the conflict, many with links to other insurgents in the northeast and sanctuaries in Bangladesh. Rivalries between and within these groups, over politics, money, and personalities, complicate both policy and analysis. Violence in Tripura has diminished dramatically since 2000, though insurgent groups continue to operate.

The experience of the northeast reflects the difficulties of managing extraordinary diversity in areas with comparatively weak historical links to contemporary India, an international context that allows and encourages violence, and a lack of sustained political interest from the center. Large swaths of the region have been turned over to the security forces and local politicians to run as they see fit, reducing accountability or oversight from the central government and press. The deep political and organizational divisions within linguistic, religious, and tribal groups in the northeast have allowed the Indian state to play games of divide-and-rule but have undermined lasting political settlements.

The major success story is Mizoram, where a political bargain was struck. Militancy has been contained but not eliminated in Tripura and Assam, a tacit deal exists between the state and insurgents in Nagaland, and significant violence endures in Manipur. This variation reveals both the different types of insurgencies that exist—from highly cohesive in Mizoram to massively fragmented in Manipur—and the diverse types of Indian government response, ranging from intense repression to co-optation and bargaining. The northeast faces serious economic and social problems alongside the challenges of militancy and political disaffection, and it is likely to continue being an area of instability and local crisis for the foreseeable future.

Punjab

The roots of Sikh militancy in the Punjab are tightly intertwined with electoral and coalitional politics both in Punjab and in India more broadly. Sikhs were badly affected by Partition in 1947, being driven in large numbers from the Pakistani Punjab amidst intense violence. Sikhs found themselves a tiny minority in the new India. Ethno-linguistic reorganization led to the split of Haryana from Punjab, which created a Sikh majority in Punjab. The two states shared (and continue to share) Chandigarh as their capital city. Punjab was the home of a major, if often divided, Sikh political party, the Akali Dal, which would become a prominent opponent of

Indira Gandhi during and after the Emergency, creating endemic state-center tensions. The Green Revolution triggered economic growth in Punjab even as political instability grew in the 1970s. The Akalis were part of the coalition that opposed Indira Gandhi and which briefly supplanted her after the Emergency.

Conflict between the Akalis and Indira came to a head in the early 1980s. Indira returned to power and tried to recentralize power in Delhi. The confrontation between the two involved Indira dismissing state governments in Punjab and the Congress Party supporting a militant Sikh preacher, Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale, as a way of splitting the Sikh vote. In turn, the Akalis mounted a campaign of contentious politics and rhetorical escalation to counterbalance Indira's political maneuverings. The status of the capital, of water crucial for farming, and of language policy were also mobilized as issues of discontent with the center (Kohli 1990: chapter 12). Violence escalated from 1980 to 1984 as the state machinery began to break down, militant mobilization increased, and various attempts at cutting a deal failed. The Sikh militants received some limited support from Pakistan and extensive support from the diaspora as they pursued the goal of an independent Khalistan. The militants drew heavily from the Jat Sikh community and networks linked to Sikh gurdwaras.

Finally in 1984 the center decided to crack down on the militancy it had helped to create in Punjab. Bhindranwale and other militants had taken shelter in the Golden Temple in Amritsar, a Sikh holy site. The Army went into the Golden Temple in force in June 1984 in Operation Blue Star (Tully and Jacob 1985). The damage to the holy site incurred in this operation triggered outrage among many Sikhs, who saw it as a repressive case of government overreach signaling malign intentions toward the Sikh minority.

The aftermath of Blue Star was disastrous. Militant mobilization surged in Punjab. Indira Gandhi was assassinated by two of her Sikh bodyguards in October 1984, which in turn led to Congress Party-backed anti-Sikh riots in Delhi. Rajiv Gandhi attempted to bargain with Akali Dal leaders, but the fragmentation of the Akalis and pressures within the Congress Party undermined these efforts. Punjab became the site of deadly guerrilla warfare, with numerous Sikh armed groups facing off against the Punjab police and central military and paramilitary forces (Dhillon 2006). Civilians died in significant numbers, though not nearly at the level of Kashmir.

The state response was inconsistent during most of the second half of the 1980s, as policy alternated unevenly between crackdowns and negotiations. The military tide turned in the early 1990s. The Army sealed off the border with Pakistan and increased its deployments, the police were refitted and unleashed with few constraints, and the endemic fragmentation of the militant movement contributed to fratricide and lack of coordination. These dynamics combined to shatter the insurgency by 1993. This was not a case in which hearts and minds were won through the provision of services or major political concessions that satisfied core grievances. Instead, focused, often ruthless coercion and population control broke the back of the militancy, in large part by taking advantage of the internal splits within it. This was made easier by the relatively small number of hardcore militants relative to other conflicts.

The insurgency in Punjab clearly reveals how competition within groups on the periphery intersects with center-state relations to create unstable and dangerous political dynamics (Brass 1988). The existence of Pakistani support, a large and mobilized diaspora, and a Sikh population with a tradition of military service all made the Sikh militancy much more potent than many other possible separatist movements and encouraged violence rather than pure political bargaining. The government response to the insurgency varied over time as both Delhi and Punjabi politicians tried to figure out whether it could be politically managed. The ultimate reliance on significant force proved effective, but came at the price of human rights abuses. Punjab's politics have returned to normalcy, in stark contrast to most of the other conflicts studied in this

chapter, in part because coalition governments at the center have been much less aggressive in their centralization than Indira Gandhi.

Jammu and Kashmir

Jammu and Kashmir is India's most important area of separatist insurgency because of its link to conflict between India and Pakistan. J&K was a princely state under colonial rule, led by a Hindu maharajah but with a Muslim-majority population (Rai 2004). The maharajah attempted to maintain room to maneuver between India and Pakistan in 1947, but this failed in the face of a revolt by Muslim military veterans against his role, followed by a Pakistan-supported invasion by tribesmen from the northwest frontier (Whitehead 2007). The maharajah was forced to ask for Indian military support and as a condition of that support being provided he acceded to union with India. A conventional war between India and Pakistan then broke out, which left the former princely state divided. A ceasefire line emerged as the boundary even as both countries claimed the entirety of the state.

International tensions over Kashmir endured as the Indian government increasingly consolidated its control over the state government. J&K acceded to India with a greater level of autonomy under Article 370 of the Constitution (Behera 2006). The state officially retained significantly more control over the lives of its citizens than other state governments. However, after a falling out between Prime Minister Jawaharlal and Sheikh Abdullah, the prominent activist and then prime minister of Jammu and Kashmir, Delhi began to dominate the politics of the state. Patronage politics and manipulation of the state apparatus were useful tools of control as Sheikh Abdullah was jailed and his National Conference hollowed out (Bose 2003). This strategy was not unchallenged: cycles of mass protests would rock the Muslim-majority Kashmir Valley in the 1960s, for instance, and in the mid-1970s Sheikh Abdullah was able to return to power in Kashmir.

The return of Sheikh Abdullah provided a brief period of stability, but his death and succession by his son Farooq Abdullah in 1982 set the stage for the rise of a major insurgency in the state. Farooq lacked the credibility and skill of his father, and Delhi returned to its previous policy of manipulating the politics of the state. The 1987 state elections were marred by electoral irregularities aimed in particular at the Muslim United Front opposition coalition.

Mass mobilization erupted against the central and state governments (Varshney 1992; Ganguly 1996). Numerous armed groups would become involved in the rebellion (Staniland 2010). Initial militancy was spearheaded by the Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF), a revitalized version of an older separatist organization. The JKLF advanced a pro-independence ideology that aimed to see the Indian- and Pakistani-controlled sections of the former princely state reunited. It engaged in large-scale mass mobilization and found significant support in urban Srinagar, in particular. The JKLF received Pakistani aid and sanctuary in the 1988–91 period.

However, the JKLF suffered from two serious problems. First, its strategy involved rapid but fragmented mobilization that undermined organizational cohesion. JKLF leaders found it difficult to control the various factions, blocs, and ideological goals within its formal organization, and splits and feuds began to erupt. Second, internal unrest was accelerated by Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) strategies to marginalize the JKLF in favor of a new tide of pro-Pakistan armed groups. The JKLF would become increasingly divided and militarily ineffective, with the largest indigenous faction of the group eventually ending its violent campaign in 1994. The organization, and its various components, became focused on contentious politics and protests.

The dominant armed organizations in the 1990s became pro-Pakistan groups, often accompanied by an Islamist ideology of some sort. The key indigenous organization was the Hizbul

Mujahideen, built atop the social infrastructure of the Jamaat-e-Islami political party in J&K. Backed strongly by the ISI, the Hizb had reach across rural communities in the state, as well as strength around Sopore in the north. Other indigenous armed groups, including the Ikhwan-ul Muslimeen, Muslim Janbaz Force, and Al-Umar Mujahideen, were important players in the early 1990s (Joshi 1999).

Indian counterinsurgent forces responded with great force, combining population control, torture, abductions, and interdiction at the Line of Control (LOC) to suppress the insurgents (Ganguly 2009). The pro-Pakistan groups other than the Hizb were unable to maintain organizational resilience. Several splintered into fratricidal conflict. A number of these factions defected to the side of the Indian forces, operating as pro-state paramilitaries in coordination with the security forces (Staniland 2012). They were a ruthless and effective counterinsurgency tool in rural Kashmir. The Hizb was pushed back into the hinterlands, while still retaining networks of support.

A major shift accompanied the marginalization of the indigenous insurgents. Groups with a primarily Pakistani membership rose in importance, particularly the Lashkar-e-Taiba, Harakat-ul Mujahideen, and the Harakat splinter Jaish-e-Mohammed. They became known for suicide and suicidal attacks and posed a serious challenge to the Indian forces, especially in 2000–01. Politics in the state remained frozen by violence, with a 1996 state election widely viewed as dubious. Indian forces garrisoned the cities while creating a grid structure for population control in rural areas. Large numbers of civilians were killed in the conflict, and normal political and social life ground to a halt for most of the 1990s.

After the terrorist attacks of September 11, 2001 in the USA, Pakistan began to rein in armed groups operating in J&K. The 2002 state elections were more successful than in 1996, and an India-Pakistan agreement to reduce violence in 2003 and fencing of the LOC in 2004 led to a dramatic decrease in insurgency in J&K. Since 2008, the politics of opposition in J&K have centered on mass non-violent protests as well as increasing intellectual self-assertion. This type of contention poses a very different challenge to the Indian state than militancy and suggests the possibility of a significant transformation of Kashmiri politics. Insurgent violence continues but at a much lower level than previously. Estimates of deaths due to the conflicts vary dramatically, but many observers suggest very approximately 70,000 as a plausible number.

J&K remains a volatile place and an enduring issue between India and Pakistan and between Kashmiris and Delhi, but the era of intense insurgency appears to be over. This outcome reflects India's military successes in containing militancy and its political failure to arrive at an acceptable political arrangement for J&K. Though political competition within J&K has contributed to fragmentation instead of a clear united front, the primary axis of contention has been between the center and the state. It is here that Delhi has much more work to do before the state is likely to become 'normalized.' Building a new, stable equilibrium will require further bargaining with Pakistan and truly substantial reforms in how J&K is governed.

Maoist mobilization

A very different type of insurgency has become a major force in a swath of India stretching from West Bengal into northern Andhra Pradesh. Rather than the separatist militancy described above, India's Maoist Naxalite guerrillas seek to capture power in India and transform it into a communist state. This movement originated in West Bengal in the late 1960s amid the tumult of leftist mobilization and feuding during that period. After being suppressed, Naxalite organizers took to interior jungles and forests and maintained their war at a much lower level. Since the early 2000s, another surge of Naxalite activity has become hugely important in much of eastern

India. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh has called the Naxalites the largest internal security threat to India. The major center-state issue in this context has been coordination of counterinsurgency efforts across different states, each with its own capabilities and political interests.

The first wave

The 1960s were a time of ferment and dissension within the Indian left. Debates over the Sino–Soviet split and internal rivalries encouraged fragmentation and competition, particularly among West Bengal’s students and intellectuals. A movement aiming to equalize land holdings turned violent in 1967 (in the village of Naxalbari, giving its name to the movement). This led to a mix of confrontation and collusion between the Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI(M)) and radicals, even as the CPI(M) was in alliance with the Congress Party in the state. Members of the splinter CPI-Marxist-Leninist (ML) mobilized in West Bengal and in certain areas of Andhra Pradesh. Political competition between parties in West Bengal intersected with the center’s fears of the state spiraling out of control.

The Naxalites took advantage of this political space to launch an intense escalation of violence (Kohli 1990: chapter 10). Conflict occurred in rural areas as a somewhat disorganized guerrilla movement, and also in Calcutta in the form of bombings and assassinations. Intellectuals and students were heavily involved in both kinds of violence. Two bouts of President’s Rule were imposed amidst this chaos, followed by a Congress government that intensely repressed the Naxalites in 1972–77. A state government backed by the center proved capable of beating back the Naxal challenge. The movement was deeply internally divided, which made it easier for counterinsurgency to succeed. Naxalite cadres gave up the fight, were killed or arrested, or fled into the jungles. West Bengal transitioned to CPI(M) rule in 1977, marking a decisive shift into the institutionalization of non-violent leftist power in the state.

Naxalism revitalized

Despite the defeat of the Naxalites in West Bengal, the movement did not die off. Committed organizers retreated into poorly or ungoverned areas of eastern and central India, including Bihar, West Bengal, Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, and what are now the states of Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand. These areas historically lacked significant state presence and were not the focus of political interest or strategic importance. This context provided a permissive environment for mobilization. These organizers failed to create the mass uprising to which they aspired, but their persistence during decades of marginality kept the movement afloat. A number of distinct organizations operated during the 1980s and 1990s and were often involved in fratricidal feuding. Naxalites were able to involve themselves in caste and tribal mobilization, allying with the components of Indian society most repressed and victimized (Jaoul 2009). This proved a clever strategic move and gave activists access to communities that might otherwise be difficult. They were particularly linked to violent caste wars in Bihar in the 1990s (Nimbran 1992).

Consolidation of the movement occurred in the late 1990s and early 2000s with the merger of several leading Naxalite blocs. The movement remained fragmented but has clearly become more able to coordinate attacks and logistics. Naxal mobilization also occurred in areas with natural resources that were becoming increasingly valuable to large corporations. This set the scene for clashes over the use of tribal lands. Violence began to rise in particular in Andhra Pradesh, which responded with a reasonably effective reform of the police. West Bengal also faced a resurgence of Naxal mobilization in opposition to the party-state of the CPI(M). Brutal violence has erupted in clashes between the CPI(M) and the Naxalites in the state.

Even more problematic was the growth of Naxalism in Bihar, Jharkhand, and Chhattisgarh. These states are much poorer and less administratively capable than Andhra Pradesh and they have faced deep problems in responding to the Naxalite challenge. Chief ministers of these states have argued that they require more support from the center, which in turn suspects the chief ministers of inefficiency, corruption, and lack of political will. These tensions (which also include conflicts between neighboring states) have undermined the coherence of the response. The federal system is important not just in explaining why conflicts erupt but can also shape the government response to rebellions.

As attacks mounted in the second half of the 2000s, MHA forces became increasingly drawn into counterinsurgency and security operations. They have suffered serious losses in the face of a Naxalite movement that has taken advantage of weak state presence, byzantine political maneuverings at the state level, inaccessible terrain, and tribal discontent to prepare for a pitched war. Government responses have ranged from apathy to support for pro-state militias to sweeps of affected areas. Though there has been much discussion of development and good governance as a cure to the Naxal challenge, neither the central nor local government response has suggested much ability to implement this ambitious agenda. Similarly, massive expansion and training efforts have been put into motion to improve the security forces but their progress has been seriously uneven thus far.

The Naxalite crisis in India is the result of radical ideologies finding space to mobilize amidst marginalized populations far from state power or presence. Finding ways of bringing the state to these areas without engaging in full-scale repression will be difficult given the realities of local governance in India's interior.

Conclusions and implications

Insurgency and counterinsurgency in India have affected the lives of millions of people. Government responses to militancy have ranged from political deal making to sustained repression. Some of these responses challenge an understanding of India as a liberal democracy. Torture, human rights abuses, extrajudicial killings, and forced population displacement have all been used, often with legal impunity. Insurgent violence has also been regularly horrific. Significant swaths of India have been ravaged by brutal warfare since Independence, even though many of these conflicts barely register in studies of Indian politics and in the popular imaginary.

Yet other responses challenge our assumptions about the state's pursuit of a monopoly of violence. India's government has sometimes simply ignored insurgent mobilization, cut tacit deals with militants, and directly bargained with them outside of the electoral process. This heterogeneity in reaction to insurgency, across groups and conflicts, and over time, is quite remarkable. It hints at the complexity of insurgency as a political phenomenon: different rebellions threaten different interests and worldviews, and thus attract varying responses. The ultimate success of these policies has been mixed, with success in Punjab and Mizoram, but enduring instability in J&K and other areas of the northeast.

India's future holds more internal conflict. The Naxalite challenge poses a serious threat to the state's reach in large areas of the interior. Though this insurgency will never seize state power, it will nevertheless be able to disrupt normal economic and political life for millions of Indian citizens and drain the resources of the state. There is a risk that inept state responses will play into the hands of the Naxalites and contribute to the endurance of the conflict. India's northeast remains militarily volatile and politically unsettled, particularly Manipur and Nagaland. The Kashmir issue will haunt Delhi until it summons the political will to change how it governs the state. India's dramatic growth and democratic survival are remarkable and worthy of attention, but rebellion and coercion constitute politics in worrisomely large swaths of the country.

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15

PEOPLE'S MOVEMENTS IN INDIA

Jennifer Bussell

The post-independence period in India did not mark an end to the social movements that helped to overturn British colonial rule. Instead, the last 60 years of democracy have been characterized by the emergence not only of a robust electoral system, but also activity by a diverse set of actors in society with an interest in shaping the policy arena. These representatives of society, or people's movements, have played important roles in directing attention to areas of concern and shaping policy outcomes across a vast array of issues, from the environment and women's rights to lower-caste empowerment and anti-corruption. In the last 40 years, in particular, people's movements have grown in size (Katzenstein *et al.* 2001) and emerged as an important locus for political debate. Yet, the strategies used by these groups have differed both across organizations and across issue areas and the nature of movements themselves has evolved considerably over this period.

In this essay, I consider the evolution of people's movements in India and the ways in which actions of societal actors differ across groups and time. I consider first those groups that emerged in the early post-independence period, focused on issues such as the environment and women's rights, drawing on research that has identified differing strategies for shaping policies among these groups. In the subsequent section, I focus on a more recent people's movement, efforts in the last 15 years to increase transparency and reduce corruption in government.

Before discussing specific movements and organizations, however, it is important to clarify what we mean by 'people's movements' and how this term relates to broader conceptions of civil society in India. McAdam and Snow define a social movement as 'a collectivity acting with some degree of organization and continuity outside of institutional channels for the purpose of promoting or resisting change in the group, society, or world of which it is a part' (McAdam and Snow 1997: xviii). This definition applies well to the movements we observe in India, but in this context there is a tendency to place greater emphasis on the individuals who are threatened or constrained by some external actor or institution and, as a result, are not able to express themselves fully as free individuals in a democratic society. As the (Indian) National Alliance of People's Movements (1996) puts it, '[a] diverse range of individuals, groups and movements have opted to stay out of the structure of state power and work for the unfulfilled promise of a democratic, egalitarian and independent India. These efforts have extended from local issues based campaigns and agitations to lobbying for policy changes, to nation-wide mobilization on broader issues.' 'People's movements,' then, encompass a vast array of individuals and organizations focused on a diverse set of issues.

People's movements can also be differentiated from nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), the presence of which has increased significantly since the end of the colonial period. For our purposes here, NGOs may play a role in a people's movement, in that they are associated with a particular issue area, and may, in some cases, serve as a prominent representative of a movement, but they are conceptually distinct from movements themselves. In other words, the existence of an NGO does not imply the existence of a people's movement, and vice versa. NGOs are formal organizations, while people's movements are, in most cases, more organic entities with diffuse boundaries and ever-changing participants. This conceptualization does not in any way discount the importance of people's movements; it simply serves to set them apart from the parallel, and at times integrated, realm of NGOs.

People's movements in the post-independence period

Katzenstein *et al.* (2001) provide an insightful analysis of the strategies taken by diverse social (or people's) movements over the last few decades. Their discussion highlights efforts that have promoted policy changes via the legislative branch of the Indian government versus through the actions of the judiciary and bureaucracy. In the former case, identity-based movements, or those groups that base their goals on ascriptive characteristics and the nature of the group 'have captured (or have been captured by) electoral politics' (Katzenstein *et al.* 2001: 252) and are often embedded, to differing degrees, in political parties. Alternatively, interest-oriented movements are those that emphasize a particular issue or set of issues that may be identified with a particular group, but are not uniquely based on a concept of identity.¹ What differentiates an identity movement from one based on interests is 'that any particular issue is likely to be fungible, replaceable by some other issue that does the work of securing recognition for a community's selfhood' (*ibid.*: 251–52). I draw on this distinction for the purposes of organizing the following analysis and emphasize in particular those movements focused on interest-based goals. This is not meant to privilege one type of movement over the other, but rather to focus the discussion about early people's movement in the post-independence period.

Interest-based movements

Livelihoods and the environment

Many people's movements emerged from the daily experiences of citizens threatened by a proposed change to their local environment. Perhaps the most well known experience of this type was the Chipko Andolan. This movement began in the Himalayan areas of Uttar Pradesh (now Uttarakhand) in the 1970s, in response to deforestation activities that were perceived to threaten the livelihoods of local residents. This was not an 'environmental' movement per se, but rather one in which individuals resisted government actions that would potentially threaten their way of life. When the Forest Department planned to cut down trees in their vicinity, groups of women resisted because '[t]heir own lives were so intertwined with the existence of the trees that their very culture and survival was at stake without them' (Agarwal 2000). The movement spread throughout the region in the early 1970s (Shiva 1989: 70–74) and on a particularly memorable occasion in 1974, women in Reni village were faced with laborers intent on logging trees in the area. While the men of the village were away and could not resist the loggers, the women, led by Gauri Devi and Gunga Devi, formed 'vigilance parties' (Shiva 1989: 74) and hugged the trees to prevent them from being felled. They continued this protest for four days, until the loggers were successfully turned back (Tehelka 2004).

This movement is pertinent to our understanding of people's movements on multiple levels. The actions of these activists highlighted the continued relevance of non-violent protests in the post-independence period, with the movement emerging out of earlier social actions led by women in the area, a number of whom had been disciples of Gandhi (Shiva 1989: 67–70). In addition, these efforts were substantially important in that 'Chipko helped to shift attention to the centrality of renewable resources—soil, air, water, and trees—at a time of swift industrialization in India' (Haynes 2002: 230). The ideas of the movement resonated across the country, and inspired similar actions as far afield as Karnataka and Rajasthan, and resulted in legislation preventing the felling of trees for commercial purposes in areas of north, south, and western India (Right to Livelihood 1987). At its heart a movement about livelihoods, Chipko nonetheless inspired a broader range of activists in the realm of both the environment and sustainability more generally.

A second movement, that to oppose the Sardar Sarovar dam across the Narmada river, has also evoked concerns of both livelihoods and environmental preservation. In this case, the threat posed was to those individuals living in areas that would be flooded by the dam and increases in its height. Yet this movement also highlights the complications and trade-offs in development. Here, 'supporters see the project as a means of delivering critically needed water to drought-prone areas of north western Gujarat and Rajasthan, and electrical power to thousands of other rural and urban communities in Gujarat' Fisher (1995: ix). In contrast, '[c]ritics of the project cite its potentially negative environmental and social impacts, particularly the relocation of tens of thousands of people, the majority of them members of lower socioeconomic communities' (ibid.). The main opposition to the initiative has been led by Medha Patkar through the Narmada Bachao Andolan, and has entailed solidarity marches, hunger strikes, and petitions to the Supreme Court, but the central government and judiciary have repeatedly approved plans to increase the height of the dam. Nonetheless, this movement is notable for its success in encouraging the World Bank to withdraw its funding for the project as well as the international attention and support it received, which underlined the emerging importance in the 1980s 'of transnational alliances of nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) to local resistance movements and the ability of such alliances to promote public accountability and responsibility' (Fisher 1995: x).

Women's rights

Movements to promote the rights of women in India, while often regionally based (Katzenstein *et al.* 2001), were prevalent across the country after Independence. In this case, the issues raised by activists have been, at various points in time, both diverse and general. While certain issues found early, broad-based support, such as women's suffrage, others appeal only to sub-groups and debates over these issues can at times lead to disagreement among parts of the broader women's movement (Sen 2000). Initial efforts to promote women's rights emerged alongside the Independence movement and successfully resulted in equal rights within the constitution and universal adult suffrage. However, these outcomes, like many later legislative decisions, 'did little to bring about social and material change in the lives of most Indian women' (Sen 2000: 1).

It was in the 1970s that a range of efforts by women emerged to fill the spaces left by the early movement and to combat issues such as domestic violence, workers' rights, and consumer protection (Butalia 1997; Katzenstein *et al.* 2001; Sen 2000: 25). New organizations such as the Self-Employed Women's Association began to promote the interests of women in pockets across the country. These activities encompassed both efforts to improve legislation and to

advocate directly on behalf of women themselves. In the case of domestic violence, this meant 'awareness raising or conscientisation so that violence against women could be prevented, rather than only dealt with after it had happened' (Butalia 1997).

This period also saw renewed emphasis on more general issues, including the potential for reservation of seats in Parliament and other legislative bodies for women. The 1974 report of the Committee on the Status of Women recommended reservations across a range of bodies (Government of India 1974). Yet, women were divided on this issue during the 1970s and 1980s, due to disagreements about the likely benefits of reservation, and these disagreements reflected broader cleavages in the movement, based on differing preferences over particular issues and preferred outcomes (Sen 2000: 46–47). As a result, the movement as such remains a diverse and multifaceted entity, which is perhaps better understood as multiple sub-movements that advocate for particular issues in particular regions and moments in time, and not always in complementary ways.

Identity-based movements

The movements discussed up to now emphasize a particular, in most cases more bounded, issue and differ in substance from those that emphasize the relevance, and rights, of a particular identity. The importance of identity-based social movements in India is substantial, with Katzenstein *et al.* (2001: 251) positing that 'India's three most powerful social movements all derive their coherence from identity claims.' The linguistic states' movement, Dalit rights, and Hindu nationalism all derive from an assumption of identity through birth, rather than identification with a particular idea or cause (*ibid.*).

Because in the following section I will focus on an interest-based movement—that emphasizing government transparency and anti-corruption—I will devote less time here to identity-based movements. Key to understanding the nature of these movements, however, is the way that identity-based movements have been institutionalized within India's political system (Katzenstein *et al.* 2001: 252). Rather than pursuing their goals through the bureaucracy or judiciary, identity movements are more likely to become a part of the policy-making process, through the establishment of political parties founded on the notion of identity, such as the Hindu nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) or the Dalit-oriented Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP). For these parties, and the social movements that they reflect, representation of the community is primary to any particular issue.

The notion of 'people's movements' in India, then, is one that encompasses a wide range of substantive issues spanning the political spectrum. While people's movements emerged, in many cases, from the Independence movement and legacy of Gandhian social protest, they reflect the diversity of interests within the country and utilize a range of institutional and informal practices to promote their agendas. In the next section I consider a more recent movement and the ways in which this movement reflects the dynamic nature of Indian politics and society today.

People's movements in the 1990s and forward

While people's movements promoting the issues discussed earlier continue to play a role in shaping both political and market outcomes in the present era—the successful efforts to prevent Tata Motors from manufacturing Nano cars in Singur, West Bengal being just one example (*The Financial Express* 2008)—one of the potentially most significant sets of people's movements to emerge in recent years is that focused on increasing transparency and reducing corruption in

government. These efforts, which reflect the activities of a wide range of Indian citizens, have resulted in one major national policy reform to date, the Right to Information Act, and are currently shaping debates on a second piece of potential legislation, the Lokpal Bill. Yet, this is not a single movement and the various movements that make it up reflect diverse subgroups of the Indian public. The practices of these movements, and their relationship to other people's movements currently active in India, help to shed light on the evolving nature of civil society activities in democratic India.

Transparency, good governance, and anti-corruption

The right to information campaign can be seen as one of the most successful efforts to promote policies to increase transparency in government operations. This movement, the beginnings of which are associated with the Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan (MKSS, Workers and Farmers Power Organization) in Rajasthan, resulted in state-level and then national policy to increase the availability of government documents to citizens. What was initially an effort to improve access to information about government expenditures at the local level evolved into a broader vision that 'access to official documents was an essential part of the struggle to demand accountability from local authorities' (Jenkins and Goetz 1999: 604). If individuals had documentation of the injustices they faced in the delivery of public services, then they would be better prepared to demand justice in cases of fraud or malfeasance. In 1996 the MKSS joined with organizations pursuing similar goals in other parts of the country to form the National Campaign for People's Right to Information (NCPRI), which promoted a national law to ensure citizen access to government documents (Jenkins and Goetz 1999: 606–7). It was in 2005 that the central government responded to the pressure of these organizations with the Right to Information (RTI) Act, which provides that any citizen can request information from a government body and the body, often through a Public Information Officer, must provide the information within 30 days.

The success of the Right to Information movement in establishing national-level legislation was only the first step. The movement has continued with campaigns to educate citizens about the RTI Act and how to use it, but a study conducted in five states in 2009 found that only 13% of rural respondents and 33% of urban respondents had knowledge of the act (PriceWaterhouseCoopers 2009: 6). Assistance is also needed for those individuals who have been persecuted as a result of their efforts to gain access to information. A disturbing trend of violence toward individuals exercising the rights established in the RTI Act is emerging (Bhattacharya 2011) and this threatens any benefits of the reform.

In addition to, and perhaps in part because of, the difficulties in operationalizing the act, the RTI movement and related efforts have not been sufficient on their own to stem the corrupt behavior of India's politicians and bureaucrats. International efforts to measure corruption continue to rank India as one of the world's most corrupt functioning democracies (Transparency International 2008), and domestic surveys highlight the presence, albeit varied in scale, of corruption in all of India's states (Transparency International India and Centre for Media Studies 2005; Transparency International 2008). In 2010 and 2011 the prevalence of corruption was brought to the attention of the Indian public through a number of high-profile cases, including claims of fraud in preparations for the 2010 Commonwealth Games (Sexton 2010), a report estimating losses of 1.76 trillion rupees (around US\$40 billion) due to alleged mishandling of 2G spectrum license allocation (NDTV 2010b), and questionable provision of apartment units in a major Mumbai residential development to government bureaucrats and politicians, rather than military veterans (NDTV 2010a).

Anti-corruption and Anna Hazare

In response to these cases, a number of individuals, many of whom had been involved in anti-corruption activities in the past, began to coalesce into a new national movement. At the center of this movement was Anna Hazare, a social activist known for many activities including RTI activism and reforming his home area in Maharashtra as a 'model' village. The primary goal of this new anti-corruption movement was to convince the central Indian government to enact a law instituting an ombudsman organization that would have the power to accept complaints and investigate charges of corruption against government actors. While Parliament had its own draft Lokpal bill, the anti-corruption campaign promoted an alternative version, the *Jan* (people's) Lokpal, and demanded that representatives of civil society be given a role in drafting the bill. These efforts were successful, with the government acquiescing to the group's demands for representation, largely in light of Hazare's use of a hunger strike as a cornerstone of the protest. A Joint Committee was set up to draft the bill, with Anna Hazare and four other representatives of civil society invited to join (NDTV 2011a). However, the state and the anti-corruption movement have continued to disagree over the content of the bill and a draft bill is yet to be tabled in Parliament at the time of this writing.

Of particular interest here is the role of 'Team Anna's' campaign in bringing together diverse elements of civil society while also standing apart from some of the most prominent people's movements active today. The success of this anti-corruption campaign, in achieving the goals set forth by the activists as well as in fostering a nationwide upsurge in protests against corruption, can arguably be attributed to its ability to appeal to a number of diverse groups. Sitapati (2011) argues that this movement saw the coming together of multiple intellectual strands of the middle class, which had rarely promoted an issue together and found strength in a common cause. Legal activists, those wanting a smaller, more efficient government, and 'neo-Gandhians' all found elements of the campaign that resonated with their goals and strategies of action (ibid.). This, combined with mass discontent regarding the prevalence of corruption in daily life and the spate of recent high-level corruption scams, made for a potent combination of leaders and supporters in the movement.

At the same time, other elements of the middle class, as well as large portions of other people's movements, have not played a direct role in the anti-corruption campaign, even where their basic goals are aligned. Sitapati highlights the critiques of the Indian left, who want to look beyond the state, rather than reform it, and for whom '[l]ighting candles at India Gate is the very picture of glib middle class activism that repels them' (Sitapati 2011: 43). Mohanty (2011), in contrast, emphasizes the gaps between the Anna movement and other active social movements today. He highlights that '[a]ll major streams of the dalit and adivasi movements in the country remained outside this campaign' (Mohanty 2011: 16), as did movements against mining and industrial projects in east India, forest rights activists, and others (ibid.). The anti-corruption message either did not resonate with these movements or activists were dissatisfied with the campaign's middle-class image (ibid.: 17–18), something that was not an issue for Baba Ramdev's parallel campaign against black money (NDTV 2011b). Media coverage of Hazare's hunger strike helped to encourage mass support, but this was rarely filtered through existing structures of other movements (Mohanty 2011: 17–18).

An additional set of critiques about the ways in which this movement approached its goals were raised by analysts and bring into question, more generally, the role of people's movements within democracy. To date, most people's movements in India have pursued their goals through means that maintain the role of civil society as acting in 'the organizational space between the family on one hand and the state on the other' (Varshney 2011). In this case, however, critics have

argued that Anna Hazare and his colleagues have crossed at least two lines by demanding input, through the use of a hunger strike, on both participation by representatives of ‘civil society’ on a committee for drafting the bill and the contents of the bill itself.² First, the strategic use of a hunger strike is deemed questionable by multiple observers. Pratap Bhanu Mehta invokes B.R. Ambedkar, himself a vital element of the people’s movement for Dalit rights, to critique the coercive nature of a fast-until-death and argues that, ‘in a functioning constitutional democracy, not having one’s preferred institutional solution to a problem accepted, does not constitute a sufficient reason for the exercise of such coercive moral power’ (Mehta 2011).

Second, the inclusion of unelected individuals on a drafting committee for a bill is critiqued as inappropriate.³ Vyasulu (2011) posits that the actions of this movement, rather than providing a solution to a deep-rooted problem, pose a threat to democracy itself. By demanding representation on a drafting committee, these actors have used coercion, rather than an electoral campaign, to become legislators. As he puts it, India ‘is a representative democracy, and bills must originate in Parliament. Bypassing Parliament and contempt for elected representatives—however well deserved it may be in individual cases—is destructive of the institution of representative democracy’ (Vyasulu 2011: 9). Key to both of these critiques is the underlying assumption that India maintains a functioning state, one that can execute its duties within the realm of established institutions and thus should be allowed to do so. Whether this is the case is a key question for analyzing the appropriate role of people’s movements today.

Conclusion

People’s movements are important for the attention they bring to underpublicized issues and threats to both people and the environment in which they live. Yet, this discussion highlights the diversity of these issues and of the tools and techniques used by activists to advocate on behalf of people’s interests. These strategies, and the purposes to which they are put, evolve over time and in response to shifts in political, social, and economic conditions.

In the current era, the dynamics of the anti-corruption and transparency movements highlight what is perhaps one emerging shift in the nature of people’s movements in India. While representatives of the upper and middle classes have often played a role in earlier people’s movements, those being represented were often poorer, disadvantaged groups in society. In this case, while the poor would most surely benefit from reduced government corruption, recent growth in the size of the middle class implies that activists today are often acting in their own direct interests, rather than representing another group.

The ramifications of this shift are yet to be seen, but people’s movements will continue to evolve, both in response to new issues, changes in the nature of old threats, and innovations in the tools available to channel a movement’s message. Many movements of the mid-twentieth century responded to the livelihood threats of industrialization and these efforts continue today, but in ways that reflect new pressures on land and urban space. The anti-corruption movement utilized traditional techniques such as the hunger strike, but also mounted a substantial Internet- and mobile phone-based campaign to rally support for its agenda. Thus, people’s movements at once represent a constant element of Indian political society and at the same time they are a dynamic reflection of India’s rapidly changing socioeconomic character.

Notes

- 1 Katzenstein *et al.* clarify in their discussion that neither the environmental nor women’s movement is purely interest based, but that their tendency is in this direction. In the case of women’s rights, they note that, ‘[w]e see gender claims in India as being framed more often as interest claims than identity

- ones in the sense that issues of women's "difference" are rarely raised by women activists, whereas the language of women's "oppression" is the more widely employed frame' (Katzenstein *et al.* 2001: 255).
- 2 For these purposes I set aside claims and critiques about the quality of the anti-corruption campaign's Jan Lokpal Bill itself as, while of central importance to the current debate, this particular issue is of less direct relevance to a discussion about people's movements in general.
 - 3 This is not the only occasion on which non-elected individuals have participated in the drafting of a bill. Within this same broad movement, representatives of MKSS and the NCPRI were involved in the drafting of Rajasthan's RTI Act (Mishra 2003: 45).

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PART II

Political economy: Economic and
social development

16

INDIA'S ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

R. Nagaraj

Introduction

In 2009, with US\$1,192 per capita income at the current exchange rate, India was the world's 10th-largest economy in nominal gross domestic product (GDP), and the fourth largest in purchasing power parity (World Bank 2011; International Monetary Fund 2011). With 1.2 billion people, accounting for a sixth of the world's population, it ranked 132nd in per capita income, and stood 122nd on the Human Development Index in 2010.

India's economy has two distinct faces: it is a services economy with the tertiary sector contributing 57.4% of GDP in 2009–10; yet it is also an agrarian economy, with a little over half its workers engaged in subsistence agriculture, and 69% of its people (833 million) living in villages (see Figure 16.1). It is also a domestic-oriented economy with exports accounting for 22% of the output in 2009–10; its share in world merchandise trade was 1.4% in 2009, and it ranked 10th in world trade in services in 2010 (as per *World Trade Report* 2011).

Economic record

India circa 1950: the initial conditions

India was a dual economy, in the Lewisian sense, with a population of about 360 million, close to 80% of whom lived in about 500,000 villages, producing over half of domestic output, mostly dependent on subsistence agriculture and traditional household manufacturing catering to the local needs. The 'modern' sector consisted of export-oriented plantation crops like tea and coffee, a few port-based enclaves of large-scale manufactures producing mostly cotton and jute goods, located in and around Calcutta (Kolkata), Bombay (Mumbai) and Madras (Chennai), besides the civil services, defense, and railways. Though the size of factory manufacturing was modest, it largely met the domestic demand for modern consumer goods, with the rudiments of capital and intermediate goods industries also in place.

In the first half of the twentieth century there was practically no growth in per capita income, though a few islands of prosperity did come up with the spread of irrigation, plantation agriculture, and modern industry, mainly for exports (Sivasubramonian 2000). In social development, India was practically at the bottom of the world league table in 1950 (Morris and McAlpin 1982).

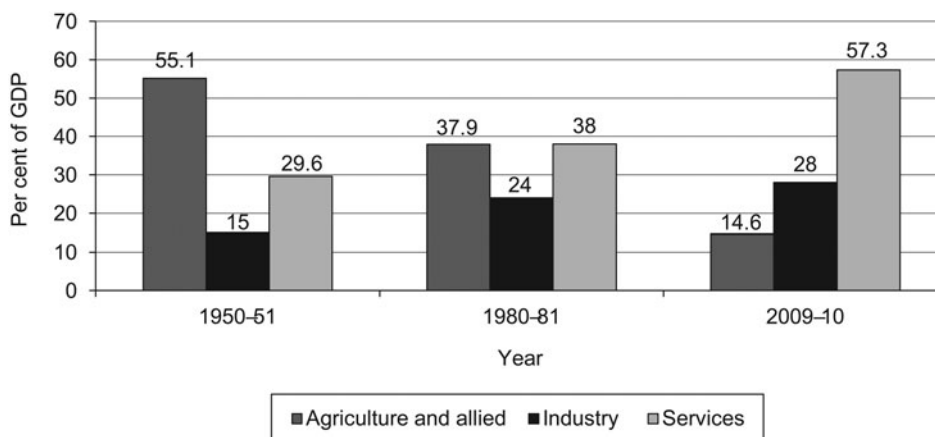


Figure 16.1 Composition of domestic output, 1951–2010

Economic growth, 1951–2010

Between 1951 and 2010, on a trend basis, the domestic output has grown by 4.6% annually, and per capita income at 2.4%. The output growth was 3.6% per year during the first three decades (1951 to 1980), accelerating to 5.5% in the 1980s, further to 6.5% per year in the 2000s (see Table 16.1).¹ With the demographic transition setting in since the 1990s, growth acceleration is sharper in terms of income per head—making India one of the fastest growing economies in recent years.

Agricultural output—both in quantity and in value terms—has grown annually at 2.6% over the 60 years; food grain output expanded at 2.3% per year, in quantity terms, which was marginally faster than the population growth rate, augmenting the access to food. Industry—the centerpiece of the development strategy—has grown at 5.5% per year, diversifying the manufacturing output (especially in ‘heavy industry’), to reduce import dependence. Starting with a higher share in GDP than that of industry, the services sector has grown the fastest during the entire period, at 5.8% per year. With the phenomenal growth of telecommunications and export-oriented business services (IT and IT-enabled services in the last decade), the services sector has overtaken industry to become the economy’s ‘leading’ sector since 1991.²

With sustained output growth and modest structural transformation of the labor force since the 1980s (see Table 16.2), India can now be better characterized as a three-sector economy: a

Table 16.1 Long-term growth rates of the Indian economy and its principal sectors, 1951–2010, % per year

Sector	1951–80	1981–2010	1981–91	1992–2010	1951–2010
1 Agriculture	2.2	3.0	3.1	2.7	2.6
2 Industry	5.4	6.4	7.0	7.0	5.5
2.1 Manufacturing	5.3	6.4	7.4	7.1	5.5
3 Services	4.6	7.6	7.0	8.5	5.8
4 GDP	3.6	6.0	5.6	6.8	4.6
5 GNP per capita	1.4	4.0	3.0	5.0	2.4

Note: Agriculture includes allied activities such as forestry, fishery, dairy. Industry includes mining; manufacturing; electricity, gas and water; and construction. Services include trade, hotel and restaurants; transport, storage and communications; banking and insurance, real estate, dwelling and business services; and community, social and personal services.

Source: *National Accounts Statistics*, various issues.

Table 16.2 Sectoral distribution of the labor force, 1951–2004/05, %

Year	Agriculture	Industry	Services
1951	72.4	10.6	17.0
1961	71.9	11.7	16.4
1971	72.0	11.5	16.5
1981	68.8	13.5	17.7
1983	68.0	15.2	16.8
1987–88	64.2	17.8	18.1
1993–94	63.3	16.7	20.1
1999–2000	59.8	18.0	22.2
2004–05	56.4	18.8	24.8
2009–10	51.8	21.9	26.3

Notes: Data for 1951–81 are from the decennial population census, and the remaining years from NSS five-yearly sample surveys on employment and unemployment. The data over the census years as well as between the census and the NSS estimates are not strictly comparable. However, they are adequate to show the broad pattern of change.

Source: Anant *et al.* 2006; Sundaram 2007; Rangarajan *et al.* 2011.

capital- and skills-intensive organized sector at the top contributing 40% of the domestic output, and employing about 8% of the workforce; agriculture at the bottom, producing about 18% of output and employing 53.2% of the workforce (in 2009/10). Between these two lies the non-farm unorganized or ‘informal’ sector, largely urban but increasingly rural as well, employing a growing share of the workforce producing a variety of labor-intensive goods and services. With a steady decline in agriculture’s share in domestic output, without a proportionate shift in the workforce out of agriculture (as was observed among the currently developed economies), output per head between agriculture and non-agricultural sectors has diverged significantly—the ratio of output per head between agriculture and non-agriculture standing at a little less than one-quarter—contributing to a growing economic disparity between town and country (of which, more later).

Inflation and macroeconomic balance

India is an inflation-averse economy: measured by the GDP deflator, the trend inflation rate over the last six decades is 7.4% per year. Food inflation, often caused by a poor monsoon, is a politically sensitive barometer of economic wellbeing, as more than 9 out of every 10 workers are employed in the unorganized (or informal) sector with no price indexation, where inflation contributes to worsening income distribution. Similarly, perhaps on account of the long history of colonial domination, macroeconomic policy attached a premium to minimizing external financial dependence: the current account deficit seldom has exceeded 3.0%–3.5% of the domestic output since Independence (see Figure 16.2). India’s external debt in 2009 at \$230 billion (22% of GDP) is a modest figure from a comparative perspective. Except for a few years of balance of payment crises, servicing the external debt has not been an onerous burden on the economy, as the costs of it were kept low with a greater reliance on concessional aid from multilateral and bilateral sources, though their share has shrunk lately. Perhaps, India’s impeccable external debt-servicing record makes the nation a poor yet proud international borrower.

However, India’s record in maintaining fiscal balance does not match its standing on managing external balance and inflation. Until up to the mid-1980s, India’s budget maintained a surplus on current revenue over current expenditure, using its borrowing (most of which is domestic) for public capital formation. However, after two decades of tax reforms and contraction in

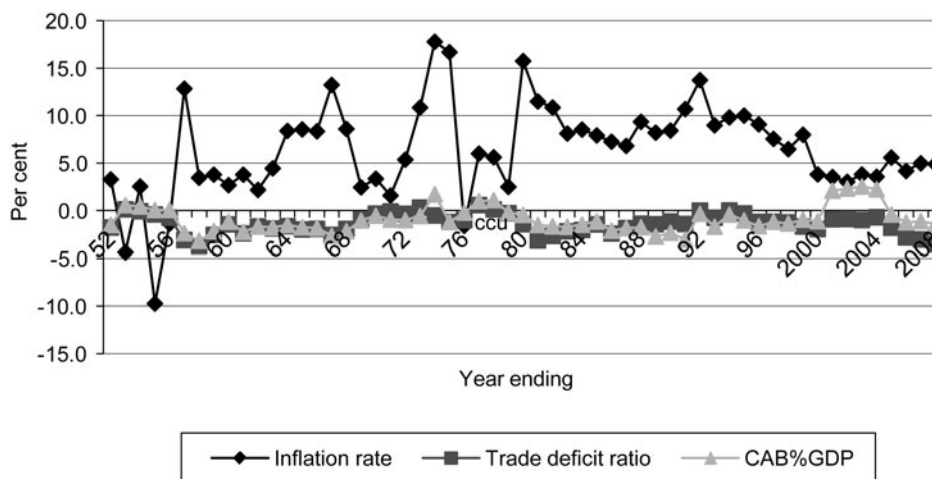


Figure 16.2 Inflation and external balance, 1951/52–2007/08

public expenditure (as a proportion of the domestic output) the fiscal balance is lately being restored with a turn-around in tax-GDP ratio, and improved public-sector financial performance (Nagaraj 2006).

Phases of growth

The development experience of the last six decades can be roughly divided into two equal periods of three decades, 1951–80, as a period of planned economic development when the growth rate was about 3.5% per year, also widely (and at times disparagingly) called the ‘Hindu’ growth rate (period I), followed by a period of economic liberalization that has witnessed a gradual acceleration of output growth (call it period II). In period I, the first half roughly coincided with the initial three five-year plans, followed by an episode of food and foreign exchange crisis, leading to changes in policy from industry to agriculture and poverty alleviation. There was, however, a gradual relaxation of controls on investment and output in period II, culminating in a tighter embrace of a market-led development path after 1991.

The planning era: 1950–65

This was a period of state-led import substituting industrializing to quickly acquire domestic capability to produce capital and intermediate goods, following the Mahalanobis model—named after the distinguished statistician who formulated the strategy for the second five-year plan. Assuming limited prospects for export growth to finance import requirement, the ‘heavy’ industrialization strategy sought to maximize long-term economic growth, though it implied a slower growth of output and employment in the near term. However, to meet the employment goal—the most pressing need in the labor surplus economy—the model advocated fiscal and physical controls to promote cottage industries for production of consumer goods, a policy that had considerable appeal among the Gandhians. The development strategy was predicated on land reforms and public investment in irrigation and flood control to augment food production and agricultural raw materials for meeting the growing demand from the industrial sector.

Witnessing a definitive break from the colonial period in output growth, industrialization helped reduce import dependence quickly, diversifying production to sustain a domestic

demand-led growth. Above all, the development strategy laid the material and institutional foundations for modern economic growth with self-reliance in a politically divided Cold War era. However, the growth process was interrupted as food demand outstripped domestic production in the face of two successive crop failures, causing price rises and a balance of payment crisis in the mid-1960s, accentuated by armed conflict with the country's neighbors.

The period of shocks and crises: 1966–80

The crisis led to a shift in priority to augment food production by harnessing the newly available high-yielding variety seeds of wheat and rice, using chemical fertilizers in regions of assured irrigation. Such a strategy, in effect, meant giving up radical land reforms and investment in public irrigation as a means of an egalitarian agrarian development. In industry, as the import substitution in metal and machinery manufacturing ran its course by the mid-1960s, there was a growing clamor for a more equitable distribution of the fruits of industrialization, which meant industrial licensing policy getting more detailed and specific, probably undermining efficiency.

This was also a period of many external and non-economic shocks like the end of the monopoly of rule by the Congress Party, the rise of left-wing radical movement Naxalbari, political Emergency during 1975–77, and the oil price shocks in 1973 and 1979.

The change in agriculture strategy helped increase market surplus of wheat and rice to feed urban demand, which was met through a public distribution system, and reduced dependence on US food aid, though the agriculture output growth rate did not really increase. However, during this period the industrial growth rate was nearly halved to between 4.0% and 4.5% per year for nearly 15 years—at a time when the East Asian economies surged ahead with state-led export-oriented growth. Mainstream economists attributed the industrial deceleration in India to the inefficiencies caused by the inward-oriented policies with excessive controls on output and investment, constraining supply. The heterodoxy, however, argued that the lack of demand due to cutbacks in public investment and poor agriculture, for lack of radical agrarian reforms, were the long-term constraints on industrial growth.

Though the food crisis of the mid-1960s was overcome quickly, agrarian distress was growing, as evident from the rapid spread of the Naxalbari movement across the country. These, along with growing political dissonance, brought up for the first time poverty alleviation as a policy goal. This also meant a tacit admission that economic growth during the first two decades of Independence had made little dent in poverty or inequality.

The 'anti-poverty' programs are essentially of two types (regardless of popular nomenclature): self-employment programs to enhance productivity of farms and small businesses by offering subsidized loans from the just nationalized banking system; and wage employment programs for the asset-less rural labor. These are supplemented by provision of food grains at controlled prices from the public distribution system. Despite much criticism of wastage, the programs probably began to put a dent in absolute poverty from the second half of the 1970s.

Creeping liberalization, 1980 onwards

With greater economic and political stability, and accumulating evidence on the adverse effects of the industrial controls on efficiency, a gradual de-licensing began in the 1980s, while public expenditure became more concentrated on infrastructure and poverty alleviation. These efforts, combined with improved agriculture performance, turned around industrial growth in the 1980s, regaining the momentum of the early phase of rapid industrialization. As anti-poverty measures became institutionalized and green revolution technology was diffused, poverty reduction

gathered pace. The economy moved onto a higher growth path of about 5.5% per year, at a time when much of the developing world experienced a ‘lost decade of growth,’ and Latin America was mired in debt and an inflation crisis.

Speeding up of liberal reforms: 1991 onwards

Faced with a liquidity crisis in 1991 in response to the epoch-changing political upheavals in the erstwhile Soviet Union, and US invasion of Iraq to ‘liberate’ Kuwait (which impacted inward remittances from Indians in the Middle East, adding to the foreign exchange crunch), India embraced an orthodox stabilization and structural adjustment program that meant speeding up market-oriented reforms and rolling back state intervention in the economy. The World Bank and the International Monetary Fund (IMF) underwrote the initial reforms with large structural adjustment loans to tide over the balance of payment in the medium term, along with an International Development Assistance (IDA) component of the loan to finance retrenchment of public-sector workers—euphemistically called the *National Renewal Fund*. While the pace of reform was considered rapid by comparison with India’s past, it was perhaps modest when compared to Eastern Europe and Russia, and Latin America in the 1980s.

With services growing annually at 9% from 1991, domestic output growth has accelerated, though industry has stagnated and agriculture has decelerated (Nagaraj 2011). However, considering probable overestimation of services output due to infirmities in the methodology and slowdown after the global financial crisis in 2008, it would perhaps be reasonable to suggest a trend growth rate of about 6.0%–6.5% per year over the period since 1991 (Nagaraj 2009).

Financing of growth

India’s growth is predominantly internally financed, with the gross domestic saving rate, as a proportion of GDP, rising from about 10% in the early 1950s, to 38% in 2007/08. Household sector (consisting of not just wage-earning households but also all unincorporated businesses that come under the unorganized sector, including agriculture) savings constitutes about four-fifths of domestic saving, financing the bulk of capital formation in the public sector and private corporate sector, with the intermediation of public-sector commercial banks. Despite the reforms of the last two decades, India’s financial sector has as yet remained bank-centric, with the stock market playing a modest role in raising risk capital, and the debt market failing to take off. In the last five years or so, public-sector saving has turned positive, and the share of private corporate saving has also risen, taking India’s saving rate close to the East Asian level.

To finance its balance of payment deficit, until the mid-1980s India depended largely on bilateral and multilateral sources, with the private sector’s need for foreign exchange being met by domestic financial institutions. After two decades of gradual reforms, the share of the official sources of external finance has reduced to about one-third, with the rest coming in from the remittances of Indians working abroad, and increasingly from market-based sources, such as foreign direct investment, foreign portfolio investment, and external commercial borrowings.

The Indian labor market

In 2004/05 the Indian labor force consisted of about 450 million persons, growing annually at about 1%. Workforce participation rates have expectedly declined with the growing proportion of youth undergoing education. About half of the workforce is self-employed, and about 11 million are unemployed (Government of India 2007). Slightly less than three-fifths of the

workforce are engaged in agriculture, residing in rural areas, producing a little less than one-fifth of GDP. Cultivators constitute about two-thirds of the rural workforce; the remaining third is agricultural labor. Industrial employment forms around 18% of the workforce, producing about 27% of domestic output.³

The worker-population ratio in the economy has remained constant at around 40%, while it is about 28% for women (probably an underestimate). Child labor as a proportion of workers has steadily declined, with rising school enrollment, though it is still pretty large in absolute numbers (8.6 million in 2004/05 representing 6.2% of children in the age group 5–14), with high visibility, as it is concentrated in selected industries and locations, often producing exportable goods.

Despite considerable disparity in wages and earnings across the states, and between rural and urban areas, long-term economic migration rates are low in India (compared to developing countries); much migration is to the metropolitan areas—contributing to labor supply in the urban, informal sector, moderating wage growth and inducing flexibility in the labor market. Long-term migration across the states is reportedly declining, but short-term or ‘circulatory’ migration from rural hinterland to towns and cities in search of livelihood has apparently gone up.

In 2004/05 the unemployment rate—measured by the ‘usual status’ defined as whether a person was employed at all during the last year—was 3.1% (Government of India 2007). The low unemployment level—a spurious measure of ‘full employment’—simply reflects the reality that few can afford to remain unemployed in a poor country with no social security, and there exists severe underemployment or disguised employment.

Poverty, inequality and deprivation

In the 1950s and the 1960s there was optimism about the prospects of carrying out land reforms—that is, elimination of *zamindari* (landlordism), land redistribution, security of tenancy and land consolidation—with the expectations of yielding rapid agriculture growth and equity in the rural economy. However, the progress was largely restricted to abolishing absentee landlordism (Joshi 1975).⁴ Given the gaping loopholes in the laws, land reforms, in fact, accentuated the inequalities, as the landowners evicted tenant farmers to resume self-cultivating of land, resulting in a sharp rise in the share of agricultural labor in the rural labor force in the 1960s (see Figure 16.3). The capital-intensive nature of industrialization, and the failure of the agrarian reforms, increased the inequalities even in the first decade after Independence.⁵

With diminished expectations of radical reform, the focus shifted to reducing absolute poverty, defined normatively as meeting a minimum calorie requirement for the population. However, the policy could not be taken up in the 1960s as the economy was faced with food and foreign exchange crises (as discussed earlier). Politics breathed life into the initiative, though, when, faced with growing agrarian violence (and politically, to wrest the Congress Party’s control from her rivals), Indira Gandhi launched a political campaign to abolish poverty (*garibi hatao*) in the 1971 general election.

However, in the absence of public resources and political commitment for radical redistribution to finance the agenda, ‘target-oriented development programs’ were initiated to address poverty alleviation. These were intended to assist small and marginal farmers, asset-less urban poor with subsidized bank credit to help them acquire productive assets, yielding a regular stream of income (Chakravarty 1990). For the poor without assets or skills, employment-generation programs were considered, which remained a minor component of the anti-poverty program (in the absence of adequate food stocks for wage payment, and the lack of local-level organization to deliver the program). After much iteration, in the 1980s these efforts were consolidated into

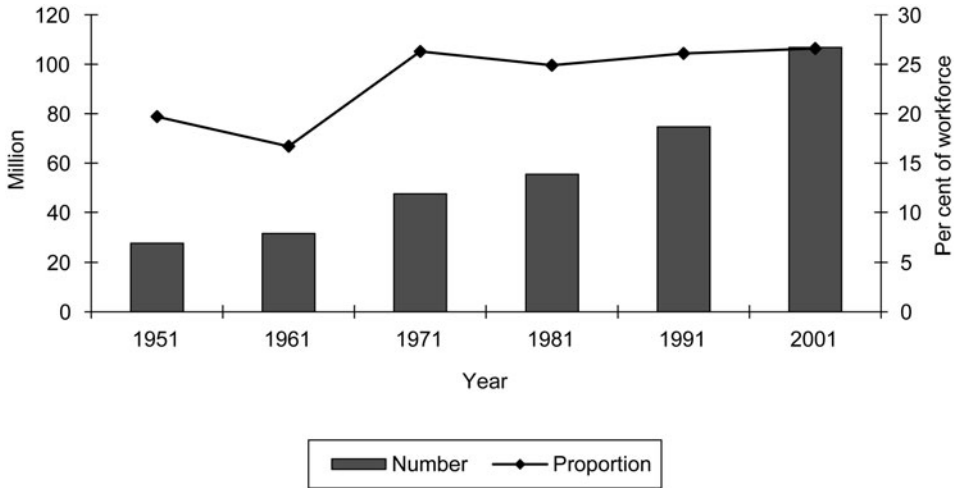


Figure 16.3 Agricultural labor, number and as a proportion of total workers, 1951–2001

the ‘integrated rural development program’ (IRDP) as the main instrument for poverty alleviation, with growing budgetary allocations.

Though its proponents claimed success in initiating poverty reduction, the IRDP was discredited for large-scale corruption, wastage of funds and its adverse effect on the public sector commercial banks’ balance sheets. In response, wage employment programs gained prominence in the 1990s (though on a much-reduced scale), evolving into the National Employment Guarantee Scheme in 2004—perhaps the largest such program in the world today, promising 100 days of productive employment at the official minimum wage rate within reasonable distance from the place of residence, or provision of a modest unemployment allowance.

The outcome of anti-poverty efforts

Official statistics show, based on a uniform methodology, in terms of income (or income poverty), the proportion of the population living in poverty began to decline from about 50% in 1977/78 to about 27% in 2004/05 (in absolute numbers from about 330 million to 302 million) (Government of India 2007). The rate of decline was faster in the 1980s, compared to the 1990s and beyond, suggesting a possible slackening of the pace after the liberal reforms were initiated (Dev and Ravi 2007). Deaton and Drèze (2009) estimate ‘that the rural (urban) headcount ratios of poverty declined from 46 per cent (41 per cent) [in] 1983, to 28 per cent (26 per cent) in 2004–5.’⁶ There is no evidence of widespread impoverishment in India, although the decline in poverty is a good deal less than might be expected given the rapid growth in per capita GDP (Deaton and Drèze 2009: 45).

However, a commensurate reduction in nutritional deficiency is not discernible, nor is there a measurable improvement in the typical indicators of physical wellbeing, which continue to be among the worst in the world. For instance, nearly half of all children in the age group 1–3 years remained underweight in 2005/06, with no reduction in this indicator during the next five years of that decade, despite a nearly 4% annual rise in per capita income. Therefore, the effect of poverty reduction on human welfare seems modest. Why? The answer perhaps lies in poor social development, as discussed later.

While the trends in poverty are well documented, we know much less about income inequality, as the data on personal incomes are unavailable since over 90% of the workforce is employed in the unorganized sector, and half of them are self-employed. However, using income tax data representing a small fraction of higher income earners, Banerjee and Picketty (2005) have demonstrated a steady rise in income inequality. This, together with evidence on increasing consumption inequality that Mahalanobis demonstrated even in the 1950s, seems to tell a consistent story of widening income inequality in post-independence India.

Further, the following simple, yet robust, measures suggest a discernible increase in economic inequality in many other dimensions since the 1980s:

- Between rural and urban per capita income (see Figure 16.4);
- Per capita net state domestic product (NSDP) across major Indian states (see Figure 16.5);
- Between organized and unorganized sectors (see Figure 16.6); and
- Between wage income and property income (see Figure 16.7).

There is, thus, an unambiguous rise in economic inequality, however measured. India's development story, therefore, is one of *growth acceleration with polarization: modest poverty reduction with marginal gains in tangible human welfare*. Growth does seem to trickle down, albeit marginally—as most economists believe—but perhaps too slowly to be tolerable—socially and politically.

In principle, and in comparative experience, equitable growth occurs with the expansion of gainful employment, supplemented by redistributive policies at the margin. In India, though, falling employment elasticity of output over the last three decades, in spite of accelerating growth, is ample testimony to the nature of the growth process that is polarizing, not equalizing. Promotion of virtuous growth would call for labor using agriculture, labor-intensive manufactures, and expansion of public expenditure to provide basic social services. What India has witnessed is the opposite: public expenditure has been sacrificed to bring about greater fiscal balance, which has fallen mostly on economic infrastructure, affecting the poor most (see Figure 16.8).

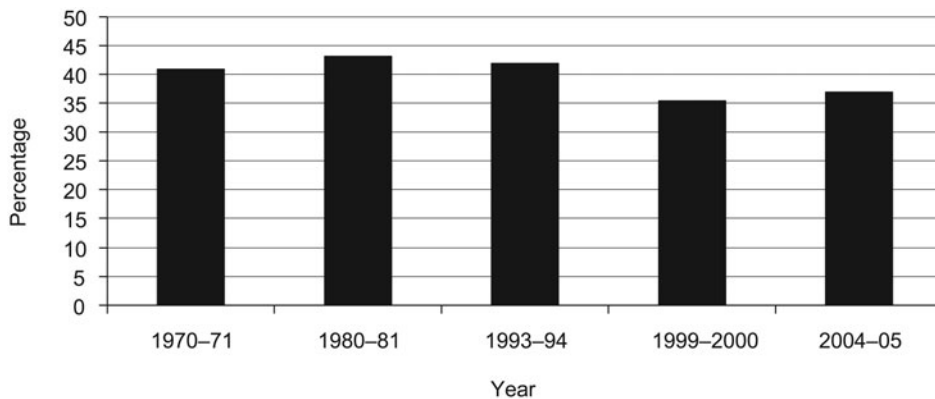


Figure 16.4 Rural to urban per capita NDP, 1970/71–2004/05

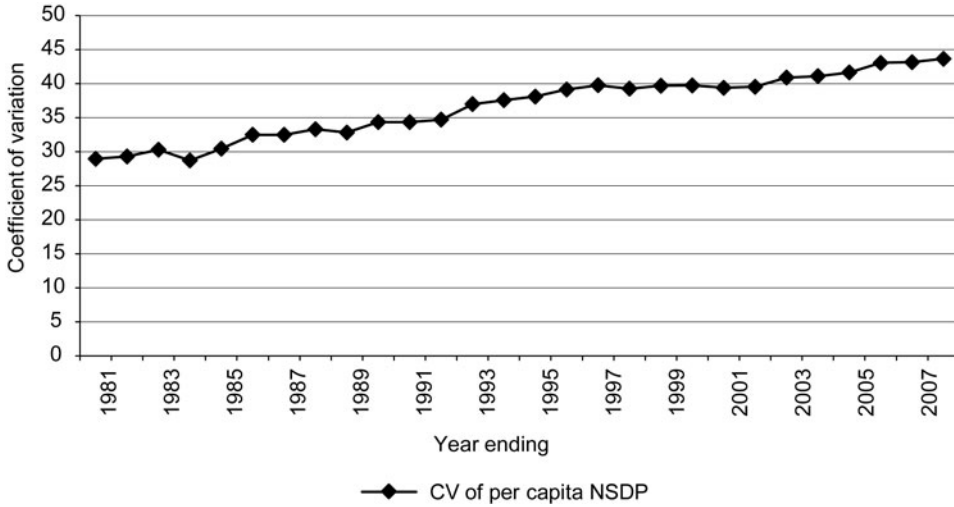


Figure 16.5 Coefficient of variation of per capita NSDP, 1980/81–2007/08

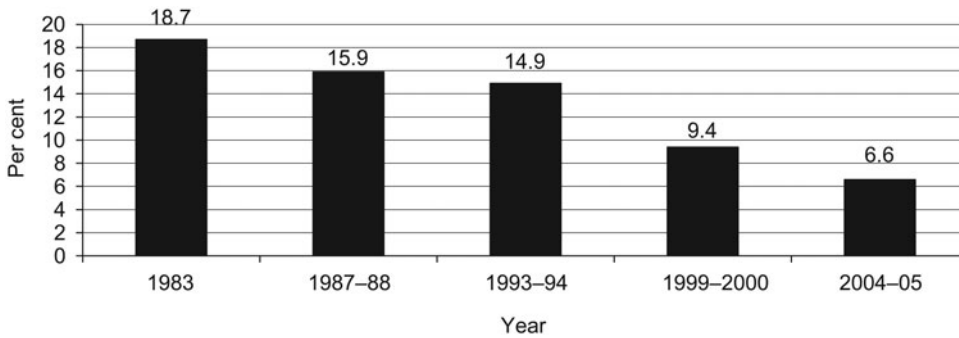


Figure 16.6 Ratio of unorganized to organized sector NDP per capita
Source: National Accounts Statistics, various issues.

Social development

Considering the inherent difficulties in measuring absolute poverty, it is perhaps simpler and more meaningful to examine social welfare by various physical indicators of wellbeing. As mentioned earlier, in 1950 India was nearly at the bottom of a list of all countries when measured by the physical quality of life index (PQLI).⁷ By 1970 the index had risen to 40, higher than West Africa and the Persian Gulf countries (Morris and McAlpin 1982). By 2001 the figure had risen to 61, a level where Kerala was three decades ago, and by 2011 the index had increased to 76.1 (see Figure 16.9). In 2006 India ranked 49th in under-five child mortality; the rate has declined from 115 in 1990 to 78 in 2006, while infant mortality has declined from 82 to 57 in the same period (UNICEF 2008).

Similarly, official figures show that access to clean drinking water has improved over the decades; only about 20% of population does not have access (see Figure 16.10).⁸ In the late

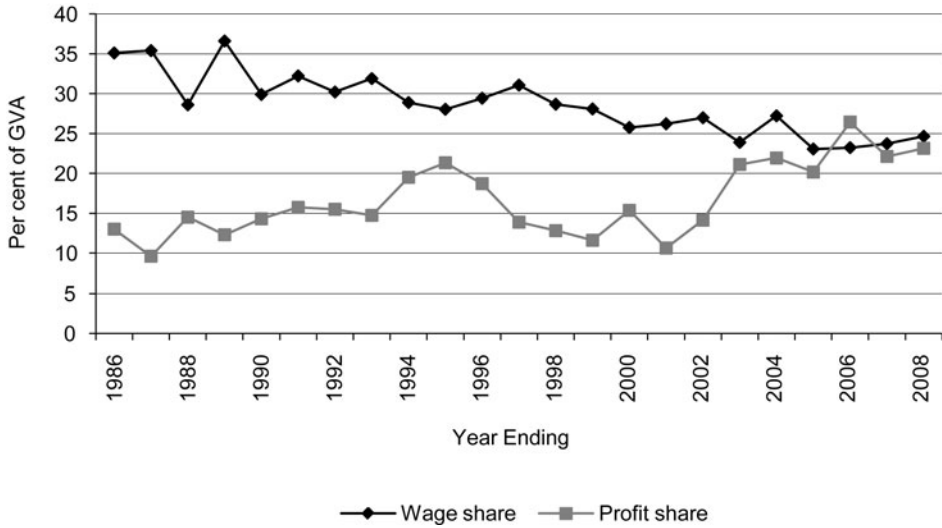


Figure 16.7 Wage and profit shares in private corporate sector, 1985/86–2007/08
Source: Reserve Bank of India Bulletin, various issues.

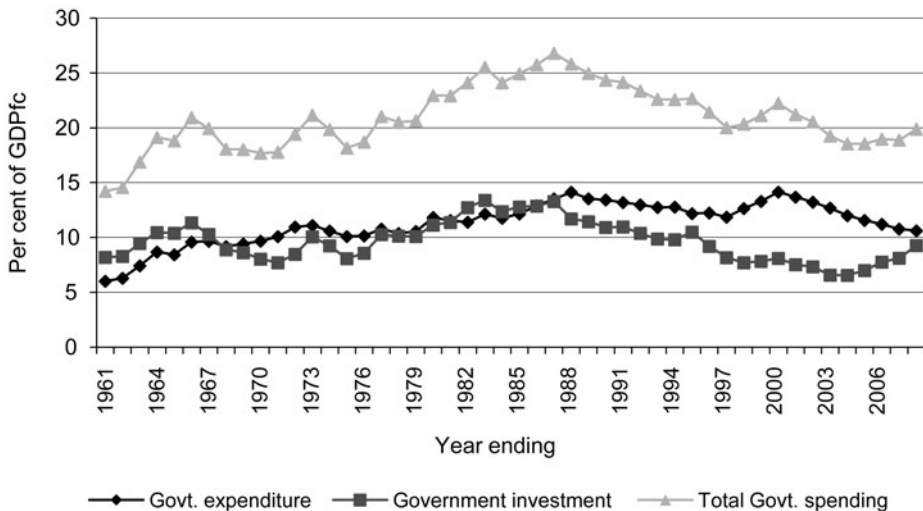


Figure 16.8 Public spending as percentage of GDP, 1961–2008
Source: National Accounts Statistics, various issues.

1990s only 18%–19% of rural households and 75%–81% of urban households had access to toilets.

The official coverage for rural sanitation is 26% and for urban sanitation it is 83.2%, according to the National Family Health Survey in 2005/06. The overall sanitation coverage as recently announced by the government is 48%. These are figures of infrastructure; they probably do not inform us about the access to and the use of latrines by individuals/families. Independent assessments show a much lower coverage (Vijay Shankar and Shah 2012).

As can be inferred from Figure 16.11, in 2011 about a quarter of India's population was still illiterate; the proportion is higher for women (not shown here). These figures, however, tell

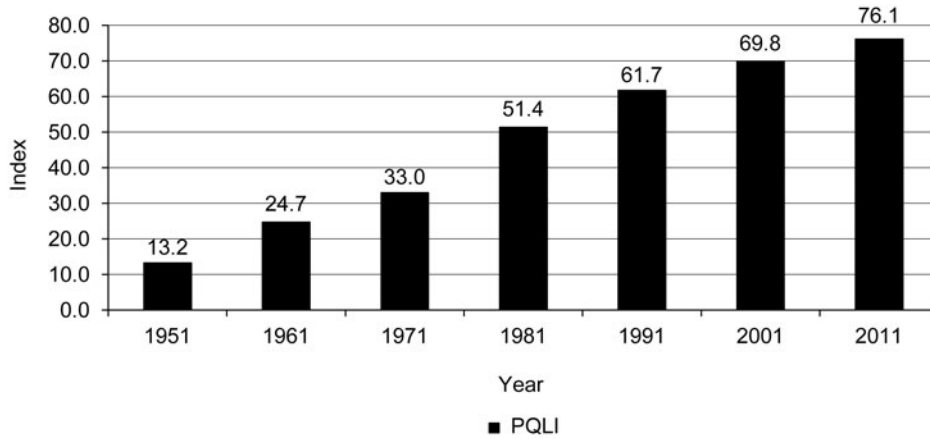


Figure 16.9 Physical quality of life index, 1951–2011

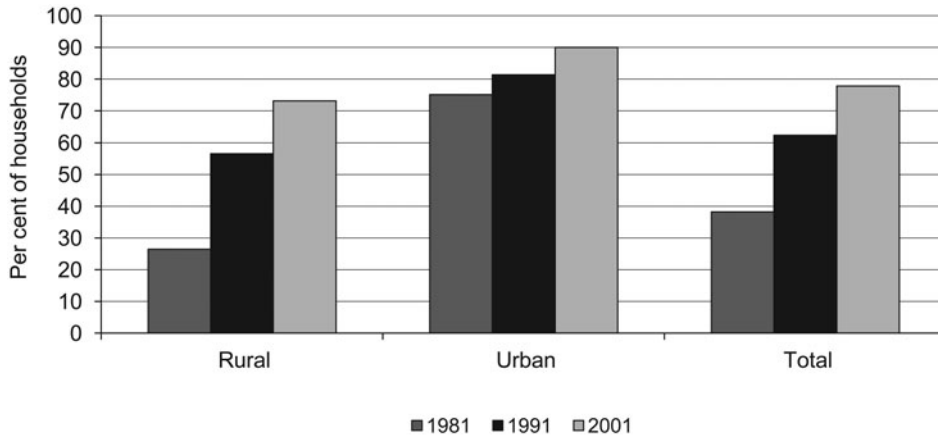


Figure 16.10 Access to safe drinking water

very little about educational outcomes, which are abysmal (Filmer *et al.* 2006). Infant mortality and life expectancy at birth are some of the highest in the world, comparable to (or worse than) those of sub-Saharan Africa (Drèze and Sen 1995).⁹ Notwithstanding these dismal numbers, there is a gradual pace of improvement in social development that remains invariant to the pace of economic growth.

Public expenditure on health and education has remained roughly at about 1% and 3.5% of domestic output, respectively. About half of the educational budget is reportedly spent on higher education, yielding excess supply of college graduates and a highly skilled workforce, leading to emigration and the export of highly skilled services. The flipside of this is the persistence of illiteracy, poor quality of primary education and appalling levels of vocational training. Unlike in East Asia, where education was a force of equalizing social and economic opportunities, it has perhaps had the opposite effect in India due to its elite orientation. Bardhan (2007), citing evidence from the *World Development Report 2006*, has contended that educational inequality in India is worse than economic inequality in Latin America.

What explains India's modest improvements in social development outcomes, even as the economic growth has accelerated? Why do the modest public resources get spent on socially

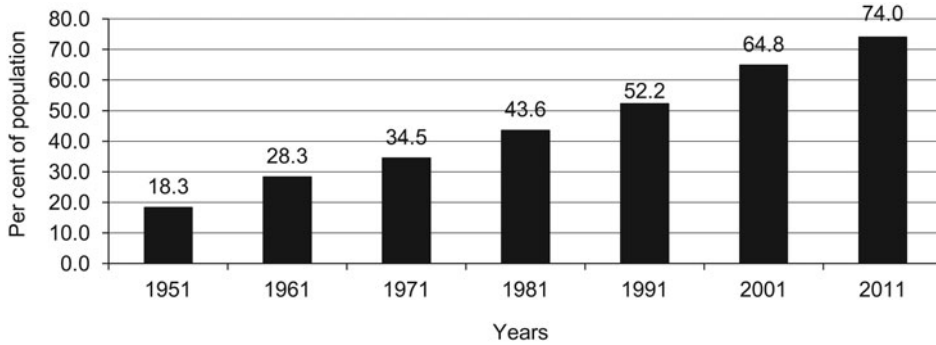


Figure 16.11 Literacy rate in India, 1951–2011

misplaced priorities? Perhaps one could take a sanguine view that in its desire to catch up with the developed world (following an autonomous development path), public policy has overlooked its citizens' welfare (in spite of the growing roots of democracy). However, deeper analyses would perhaps point to the politics of development policy.

Conclusions

India's development experience is a tale of growth acceleration in the twentieth century with a stable macro-economy and a gradual decline in absolute poverty. Economic growth is mostly domestically financed, with foreign capital, enterprises and markets making a modest (albeit rising) contribution. Perhaps India's accomplishments can be described best as efforts at building a nation state and creation of a national market, out of a civilizational entity—in a society and economy deeply divided in terms of class, caste, regional identity and economic condition. Yet, during the last six decades, the 'idea of India' seems to have acquired deep roots—perhaps not an inconsiderable achievement, from a comparative perspective.

Distribution of the fruits of growth has become increasingly unequal. Economic inequality, however measured, has widened despite growing political participation and constitutionally mandated social inclusion. Growth and distributive policies have succeeded in abolishing famines that were frequent during colonial times; yet, widespread malnutrition and destitution still persists. A decline in income poverty (though at a decelerating pace) has not made a perceptible dent in malnutrition, or in improved physical wellbeing, especially of children. Why? Perhaps the missing link between accelerating growth and minimal improvements in quality of life seems to be the dismal status of social services such as access to clean drinking water, sanitation, public health and primary education, most of which are essentially public goods. Efforts to improve these social provisions are severely constrained by the decline in public expenditure, as a proportion of domestic output, on account of fiscal conservatism in the last two decades.

From a comparative perspective, India's rising domestic saving, investment and growth are surely tending towards the East Asian levels, yet its economic inequalities are perhaps approaching the Latin American pattern, and the record in social development remains closer to sub-Saharan Africa. Compared to China—the only meaningful comparator, starting with similar initial conditions—India's economic progress is decidedly modest; yet, deepening democracy and open society perhaps make the Indian achievement appear less intolerable, and probably socially and environmentally less disruptive.

India's modest accomplishments are a matter of serious debate, suggesting divergent policy prescriptions. The currently dominant view holds that a move towards freer markets, and quicker and fuller integration into the world economy to reap the advantages of the international division of labor, is the only credible option for India.

The polar opposite of such a standpoint would be a neo-Marxist view, seeking to chart an independent path of development with rigorous planning, with a growing state role in the economy and with restrictions on foreign capital and markets. Such a view would perhaps hold that India's modest record of industrialization, growing inequality and poor social development is on account of giving up active planning after the mid-1960s, and failure to pursue agrarian reforms in the face of food and foreign exchange crises.

A third perspective—a structuralist view—would hold that for a large, agrarian economy like India, a strategy for growth with equity would have to focus on improving agricultural productivity, which would call for considerable public infrastructure investment, and institutional reforms; rapid industrialization would depend on growing market surplus from agriculture and public investment in industrial infrastructure that would 'crowd-in' private investment; and, to strategically integrate with the world economy, where export growth would serve as a lubricant for the engine of agriculture-led growth.

Acknowledgement

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Notes

- 1 Unless otherwise mentioned all growth rates in this paper are at constant prices, obtained by applying a log-linear trend equation.
- 2 Considering the infirmities in measurement, output in some of these newer services could be over-estimated, questioning the extent of the expansion of domestic output; for evidence, see Nagaraj (2009).
- 3 For brevity, sources of many statistics and evidence cited on this issue are not reported. For details, see Anant *et al.* (2006).
- 4 The effect of the abolition of *zamindari* or absentee landlordism was probably more to do with politics, as it swept aside the power of the socially conservative class. Its progressive character can perhaps be appreciated by looking at Pakistan, where a similar change did not happen.
- 5 Comparing distribution of consumption (as proxy for income), Mahalanobis concluded the following: 'From the information and analysis given ... it seems likely that there was some improvement in the levels of living and an increase in opportunity in many directions for most people of India during the first decade of planning (1951–61). The rate of growth of consumption was still low. Benefits arising from growth also seemed to have accrued, in a large proportion, to the richer sections of the people. In consequence, disparities between the rich and the poor did not generally decrease, but increased in many respects' (Mahalanobis 1975: 1168–69).
- 6 However, there have been many voices against celebrating the success in poverty reduction on the grounds that the official poverty line is too low as it ignores non-food requirements. The N.C. Saxena Committee Report set up by the rural development ministry to identify the poor for targeting anti-poverty measures has come up with an estimate of 50% poverty in the country. It is not clear how this figure is arrived at. However, the Planning Commission's Tendulkar Committee in 2009 revised the poverty line to the consumption level of 578.80 rupees per person, per month, in urban areas, and 446.68 rupees per month for rural areas. Poverty lines vary across the states and between rural and urban areas, as prices differ to meet the same consumption basket. By this measure, the head count ratio of poverty in India in 2004/05 was 37.2%: 41.8% in rural areas and 25.7% in urban areas.
- 7 Charles Battalheim (1969) said: 'When British rule came to an end, India's public health situation was poor. The mortality rate was one of the highest in the world—27.4 per cent in 1941–51—and major epidemics were frequent. The population's working capacity was considerably reduced. In such

conditions, the new Indian government should have made an effort to improve conditions of sanitation and hygiene. But just before the First Plan, annual expenditure on medicine, health services and sanitation was no more than 300 million Rs., which is less than one rupee per inhabitant' (Battalheim 1969: 318–19).

8 This figure could be seriously overestimated as it refers only to 'access,' without any indication of whether the water is piped or not, or whether water is potable.

9 While this is factually correct, it is perhaps necessary to appreciate that 50 years ago India was worse than sub-Saharan Africa, and it had one of the worst records in PQLI.

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THE STATE AND THE CAPITALIST CLASS IN INDIA

Vivek Chibber and Adaner Usmani

The relationship between Indian capitalists and the state has undergone considerable shifts over time. There also have been some changes in the scholarly perception of how the relationship has evolved. In early nationalist historiography, and in some of the mainstream social science literature, Indian business was seen as having been dominated by the state—first by the colonial administrators, who favored European expatriate enterprises, and then by the Nehruvian regime, which prioritized social objectives over entrepreneurial initiative. It was only with the onset of liberalization in 1991, the story goes, that business was able to acquire real power. Recent scholarship has forced a modification of this understanding. Although it is no doubt true that the last two decades have witnessed an increase in capitalist influence over the state, this was an increase over a baseline that was already very high. The capitalist class was a key agent in Indian politics even in the waning years of colonial rule.

The colonial period

When the East India Company took power in Bengal in the mid-eighteenth century, India was an overwhelmingly agrarian country. There was considerable manufacturing activity spread throughout the subcontinent, but it was artisanal and small-scale in nature, a far cry from the manufacturing enterprises that were already on the rise in Britain. It was not until the middle of the nineteenth century that modern industrial production came to India. For the next few decades, the growth of industry was steady, but slow—and it was overwhelmingly in British ownership. Due to the colonial state's discriminatory practices, aspiring Indian entrepreneurs were given very little assistance in setting up new undertakings, while British entrants into the market were given considerable support. Hence, unlike in other late-developing countries, where the state protected and nurtured local capitalist initiative, India's colonial status proved to be a serious liability to local industrial development (Bagchi 1972). This did not prevent the growth of local business houses; in fact, by the end of the century, there were already some prominent Indian industrialists making their way onto the scene. However, it did mean that Indian capitalists developed, in the early stages of growth, more out of their own initiative, and through relying on caste and regional networks, than through the helping hand of the state.

While Indians did make some inroads into the capitalist class in the late nineteenth century, it was really after World War I that Indian capitalists became a force in the economy. During the interwar period, Indians expanded their position in the lower end of the industrial structure,

mainly in jute and textiles. Atypically for colonial economies, though, Indian capitalists also expanded into some higher-end sectors like steel (the Tatas) and, by World War II, automobiles (Tatas, Walchand Hirachand). By the time India wrested free of colonial rule, its capitalist class was one of the more ramified and sophisticated in the developing world.

The fact that Indian business houses expanded their operations in the later years of colonial rule meant that their maturation was more or less coeval with the rise of the nationalist movement. Interestingly, the colonial state's bias against Indian business did not drive the latter into the arms of the nationalists. In fact, for much of the early twentieth century, as the Indian National Congress (INC) grew in strength, the domestic capitalist class evinced a decidedly ambivalent attitude toward it—sometimes receptive, but more typically wary and even hostile. In so far as the INC agitated for greater economic autonomy from Britain, economic boycotts of British goods, etc., they found a friendly reception from Indian capitalists, but as the INC graduated from being an elite lobbying group in the 1890s to a genuine mass party committed to a mobilizational strategy, the scions of the business world reacted with some alarm. During the late 1920s several of the most prominent industrialists floated the idea of a rival, more conservative organization in a desire to displace the Congress. In the event, some of the more politically savvy industrialists, led by G.D. Birla, prevailed upon their colleagues to abandon the idea, and to work instead toward expanding their influence within the nationalist organization. The initiative revealed the deep anxieties of much of the more powerful business houses toward the INC and its mass base (Sarkar 1983).

The reason for capitalist ambivalence toward the Congress is fairly straightforward. On the one hand, Indian businesses were every bit as dependent on the colonial state for law and order, particularly the suppression of left-wing organizers. Moreover, even though they continued to face discrimination by the state into the 1930s, they nevertheless found various means of working with, and even depending upon, regional colonial administrations. As the INC took up cudgels against this very state, it also disrupted the industrialists' nexus with it, built up so slowly over the decades. More important, though, was the fact that as the Congress grew into a mass organization, the influence of the left within its leadership also expanded. The decade spanning 1925–35 saw a rapid expansion of left-wing influence, to the point that Nehru openly flirted with socialist ideas in his speeches as president of the Congress in 1936. All this drove many prominent industrialists to the view that the INC would sooner or later turn against them.

By the end of the 1930s, however, whatever worries Indian business might have had about the INC were dissipating. Indeed, even the colonial state became increasingly solicitous toward the larger industrialists. The turning point seems to have been the election of regional governments in 1936, which allowed the INC to field candidates across much of the country for the first time. The Congress did very well, capturing majorities in five of the 11 provinces, and was thus empowered to lead the government in those regions. In all of these provinces, the Indian capitalist class found a dramatic turn to the Right, and hence a dramatic reorientation of Congress politics. During the few years that they were in power, Congress ministries did much to shed their image as socialists in the making (Markovits 1985). The brief experience of Congress administration in the waning years of colonial rule provided something of a foreshadowing of what was to come when the British finally pulled anchor from the subcontinent. By 1947, when Nehru declared Indian Independence, the INC and Indian business were natural partners at the apex of the postcolonial state.

The Nehru–Indira years

In the folklore of Indian postcolonial history, the Nehru years are viewed as a period in which the state was the dominant player in the domestic political economy, with capitalists having to dance

to its tune. This perception has been stoked by the official ideology of Indian political culture, which portrays the INC as a socialist organization, and the developmental path as a kind of socialism. However, the reality is far more subtle. As it happens, there was in fact an agenda to install a powerful planning apparatus in the early years after Independence. Two points need emphasis: first, the planning apparatus was always meant to be in aid of *capitalist* development, not any kind of socialism; second, this ambition to institute capitalist planning was substantially derailed by the capitalist class itself. Taken together, these points lead to the conclusion that, far from being sidelined by the state, Indian capitalists were a central actor in the country's ruling social coalition. The planning regime was designed to advance their interests, not to displace them. Its final form was substantially shaped by their power and their preferences, even though they weren't able to get everything they wanted from it.

The conventional periodization of postcolonial Indian history divides it into two distinct eras—the years of Nehruvian socialism (from 1947 to the early 1980s) and then the era of liberalization (from 1991, though in some analyses, from 1985). Like most popular histories, this has some elements of truth to it. There really are some important differences between the earlier and later periods, and there has been much greater autonomy for private investment in the later era. In its essence, though, the characterization is deeply misleading, because it misconstrues the relation between the business class and the state in postcolonial India. The INC under Nehru certainly adopted socialism as an official ideology, but it was never the design of the state to displace private capital. The reason Nehru's India is often called socialist is that there was a large public sector in the industrial arena, and development was guided by the promulgation of five-year plans; however, while both phenomena were important to the political economy, they were never intended to displace private investment. Indeed, they were designed to function at the service of the private sector (see Chakravarty 1987). When analysts cast the early post-independence decades as socialist, they are simply repeating official state ideology.

The basic problem with the conventional analysis is that it blandly associates planning and a state sector with socialism, but as a matter of fact, some kind of industrial planning was a very widespread phenomenon across the capitalist world after 1945, both in the West and in the developing countries. Industrial planning and policy played an important role in France, Japan, some Scandinavian countries, and much of the postcolonial world. It was especially important in the emerging Third World, because there was a powerful sense that if left to its own devices, private capital would not flow into sectors that were most conducive to rapid growth (see Ray 1998; Scitovsky 1958). In order to accelerate the industrialization process, it would have to be aided by state intervention in various forms, but if such intervention were to occur, it would also have to be coordinated in some fashion, to maximize its impact. Planning was the means by which state assistance to private capital would be effectively coordinated. Similarly, public enterprises were not intended to crowd out the private sector. They were largely confined to lines in which capitalists were disinclined to enter.

India was a paradigmatic example of this strategy. In the Industrial Policy Statement of 1948, which was issued by the government of India and which guided economic policy over the following decades, it was announced that there would be a substantial presence of public enterprises, but crucially the lines in which state undertakings were to be established were those in which private entrepreneurs had evinced little interest (Chattopadhyay 1985). The fact that they felt no real threat from the state sector was evidenced in the fact that the biggest industry associations welcomed the announcement. Second, it was also declared that economic development would be overseen by a planning body, which was entrusted with the task of designing a strategy for rapid growth. Now the capitalist class was of decidedly mixed sentiment about this issue. They most certainly did not object to state intervention in the economy, or even

planning. Industry showed no enthusiasm at all for *laissez faire*. They very loudly proclaimed the need for state involvement in the economy, in the form of assistance to industry—in the form of subsidies, cheap credit, logistical support, protection from international competition, etc. Hence, Indian business was very much in favor of a heavily interventionist state (Chibber 2003), and they were aware that such a strategy would have to have some kind of internal coordination, and hence planning. However, they were less enthusiastic about its other components.

While capitalists were very happy with the various kinds of subsidies and state supports that came with planning, they were adamantly opposed to being told how to *use* these subsidies. This is where they clashed with the state authorities. Whereas capitalists saw planning as a euphemism for public subsidization of their investment, planners argued that if capitalists were going to be given public monies, they would have to agree to some terms—namely, that they would invest them in accordance with plan priorities. The difference amounted to this: whereas capitalists wished to treat subsidies as outright gifts, planners saw them as an exchange, in which ongoing support would be conditional on their compliance with performance standards. It is important to bear in mind that this was not a debate on whether or not to *have* state intervention in industrialization, but only on its *content*.

In the event, the business community got much of what it wanted. The commitment to far-reaching subsidization of industry was kept in place, but the capacity of the state to direct the flow and the dispensation of those subsidies was substantially diluted. A sustained campaign by the capitalist class forced Nehru and the Congress to retreat on many of their objectives with regard to planning. While they continued to give lip service to socialism, they scaled back most of the measures that would have given the planning apparatus real teeth. The new Planning Commission was given very weak powers, both within the state and over private investors. They could draw up very sophisticated models of future investment, but had little power to implement them. It was an index of the tremendous power wielded by industry that it was able to substantially scale back the power that was originally intended for planners, while deepening the state's commitment to far-reaching subsidization of private capital. Hence, economic planning was pressed into the service of private capital. It was never in tension with the latter, much less an instrument to supplant it.

Once the policy apparatus for economic planning was in place, the basic priorities of the Indian development model could be discerned. India was still an overwhelmingly agrarian country in the 1950s, and the adoption of a democratic framework ensured that agrarian classes would get ample representation within the state. Even while the exigencies of electoral politics allowed rural elites to acquire real power in Parliament, however, the development model was firmly biased toward industry in the long term. Since the 1950s, the thrust of economic policy has been to promote industrial interests while placating agrarian interests. In other words, even while they are numerically stronger, rich farmers and landlords have been relegated to junior partner status in the ruling coalition. This was true throughout the Nehru-Indira years, and has only become more pronounced since.

The emergence of new forces

While the Indian state was always supportive of its capitalist class, the modalities of its relationship changed over time. In the Nehru years, the general approach was to funnel resources toward the private sector, while keeping individual businessmen at arms' length. In other words, the state recognized the structural power of capital, while maintaining its instrumental autonomy from the class of capitalists. Planners were of the general view that while *capitalism* was necessary to development, *capitalists* were not to be trusted in the halls of power. The prominent business

houses did still have political influence, but it was usually informal, often clandestine, and more pronounced at the middle and lower levels of the state's hierarchy.

This began to change in the late 1970s, and especially in the middle of the next decade as Rajiv Gandhi came to power. By 1985, there was a fairly open shift in political culture, as the state began to make quite dramatic overtures to the business class, not only to support its growth, but to bring it into closer proximity with policy circles. Driving this change in orientation were two deeper phenomena. The first was the gradual erosion of support for the planning regime, both within the state and without. Starting in the late 1960s, the rate of growth had slowed down, so that the 1970s were generally seen as a decade lost to economic stagnation. The slowdown gradually increased the leverage of groups critical of planning, who called for giving a greater role to the private sector (Chibber 2003: chapter 8; Kohli 2006). These not only included groups within the capitalist class itself, but also layers of the bureaucracy and political leadership. These groups had been on the defensive during the early years of economic planning, but as the 1970s rolled on, they found greater scope for their criticisms.

The second source of the shift was the emergence of new forces, both economic and political, that gave business groups greater access to the halls of power. The economic growth of the Nehru years created layers of new industries, dispersed across the country, which grew together with the traditional business houses (Damodaran 2008). In textiles, engineering, metals, chemicals and other lines, entirely new groups of businessmen came into existence, often starting out in the orbit of the more established firms as service or input providers. While these new groups grew in economic strength, they found their further growth stymied by the fact that access to key resources was controlled by economic planners, who had little or no connection to these new entrants. Planners naturally tended to favor established firms, which had a proven track record and some history with the state agencies. Newer firms thus found their entry into new lines blocked by the planning regime. There were only two ways to change this situation: either by inducing planners to shift resources away from established firms, toward the newer ones; or by calling for a dismantling of the 'license-quota raj.' Neither of these was possible without political influence.

The new firms began to push for more liberalization of the planning regime, and by the 1980s found a more receptive audience in policy circles because of the planning regime's loss of legitimacy. However, they also leveraged greater power for themselves by backing new, regionally based parties that grew in power during the same years. In 1977, the INC lost power for the first time since Independence, and even though it regained a majority in Parliament three years later, the experience was a massive jolt to its leadership. It now had to face the reality that other parties were real threats—and these parties were often fuelled by funds and logistical support from newer business houses, calling for greater liberalization and easier entrée into policy circles (Frankel 2005). The emergence of this challenge only gave a further impetus to the pro-business tilt that was developing within the INC. As challenging parties pushed for a loosening of the industrial regulatory regime, elements within the Congress that were of like mind found their own influence growing, as they appeared to be more in tune with the political culture than were the defenders of the traditional planning regime.

The turn in 1985–91

While pressure for a shift to a closer relationship with business continued to grow, this did not automatically mean a shift to economic liberalism. After all, the planning regime of the Nehru–Indira years created vast oceans of profits for the largest business houses, many of whom were quite content to continue with the established order. If there was going to be a turn in economic

strategy, and an opening up of the economy, it would meet with some resistance from capitalists themselves. This was in fact what Rajiv Gandhi found when he moved to liberalize the policy regime during his tenure. In 1985 Finance Minister V.P. Singh unveiled one of the most ambitious liberalizing packages ever seen in the subcontinent; however, it stalled, owing largely to a sustained campaign of opposition from traditional business groups who were dependent upon, and wedded to, the traditional protectionist regime (Roychowdhury 1992). Duly chastened, and having learned that ideas matter, but when carried on the wings of interests, policy planners in India set about remedying the situation. From this point on, the Indian state actively organized and built up a segment of the business community dedicated to promoting the idea of liberalization. Based mostly in engineering, mechanical, and allied industries, staffed mainly by newcomers to the economic scene eager to expand beyond the space allowed by the regulatory regime, these firms eagerly accepted the state's political patronage. The organizational vehicle for the new partnership with the state was built on an obscure federation of engineering firms, founded in Calcutta in 1974. Within the span of a few years, with state backing, the federation blossomed into the Confederation of Indian Industries (CII), which not only became the fastest growing business organization in India, but also the most powerful by 1990. For the half decade between the failed reforms of 1985 and the successful ones in 1991, the CII was an active lobbying group for a turn to liberalization. When the next reform impetus came in after the 1990 crisis, the scene was considerably different than it had been in 1985. This time, instead of a rebuff from the traditional business groups, the state was able to lean on a new and powerful partner in the business class.

The change in business attitudes was not automatic. The state could not just convince firms, through sheer force of ideas, that they ought to support liberalization; they had to be convinced that it was in their interest. As suggested above, in a competitive capitalist economy, there are effective mechanisms in place to alert firms as to their direct interest. Even in the case of strategy, which is rarely whittled down to a singular option, the range of possibilities open to firms will not be very large. Hence, while there is room for some play of ideas in the selection of strategy to serve firms' direct interests, that room will be somewhat limited. State managers and policy experts therefore have to work hard in mapping the particular *mix* of policies onto the real interests of market participants. In India, this process yielded a liberalizing regime that was not nearly so doctrinaire as in other parts of the world. This was largely because the business class did not line up neatly behind the liberalization drive. While some powerful elements did, like the newly created CII, other quite powerful segments remained skeptical, and insisted that the whole process ought to be a slow one. Soon after the turn to deregulation was announced in the early 1990s, scions of some of the most prominent business houses organized themselves into an informal lobbying group called the Bombay Club, which waged a public campaign to slow down the pace of liberalization, precisely in order to bring the particulars of the new regime closer to their interests (Roychowdhury 1992; Shastri 1995).

The Bombay Club did not last beyond a few years, but its campaign did have the intended effect. Indian liberalization, while real and quite significant, did not unfold at the speed, or go as far, as did the liberalization in Latin America in the same years. Indeed, the modalities of reform corresponded fairly closely to the business agenda. By the 1990s, the bigger business houses had come to support one kind of liberalizing reform—the dismantling of controls and regulations on domestic investment. What they were more skeptical of, and lobbied against, was a drastic and sudden lowering of protective tariffs, and the unrestricted entry of foreign direct investment. In the event, the state proceeded largely along the lines consistent with these preferences. Internal deregulation was, and had been, the centerpiece of Indian liberalization, while loosening the entry barriers on foreign capital had proceeded more slowly, and considerable regulations

remain in place. Perhaps the most important deviation from the boilerplate Washington Consensus menu is that India has shied away from full capital account convertibility. On this matter, there has been resistance not so much from business groups—though they have evinced some doubts about it—but from within segments of the bureaucracy as well, who have watched carefully as the Global South has been wracked by capital flight and contagious panic.

Thus, in the early decades of this new century, the Indian state has established quite a close relationship with its capitalist class. It is a class of entrepreneurs that has, by now, grown to one of the largest and most dynamic in the developing world, and certainly one of the most powerful. The new partnership has overseen a transition from a state-led development model to a more liberalized one, but the alliance between the state and business is not new to the era of liberalization. The Indian state has been committed to the growth of its capitalist class since the onset of Independence in 1947. As this essay has shown, the change has been in the modalities of the state-capital alliance, not in its very fact.

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18

POLITICS AND REDISTRIBUTION IN INDIA

John Harriss

The aspirations of independent India

As he moved the ‘Resolution on Aims and Objects’ in the opening debate of the Constituent Assembly in December 1946 Jawaharlal Nehru said ‘... I stand for Socialism and, I hope, India will stand for socialism and that India will go towards the construction of a Socialist State.’ Yet at the same time he explained that the word ‘socialist’ had not been included in the Resolution because, he said, it might not be ‘agreeable’ to all the members of the Assembly. In the discussion that followed the statement was criticized by the Dalit leader Dr. Ambedkar for its lack of firm commitment to socialist principles, and the differences of view between the two men reflect quite fundamental tensions within the Indian nationalist movement. Anti-colonial nationalism in India was led by middle-class people, mostly from the higher castes, with distinctly elitist attitudes. As the movement developed a mass base in the 1920s and 1930s the leadership came to accommodate objectives and policies—regarding land reform, for instance—that had previously been opposed or simply neglected (Sarkar 2008). The Congress leadership remained distrustful of popular movements amongst peasants and workers, while the local organization of the Congress had generally been captured, by the late 1940s, by ‘conservative coalitions built by the dominant landowning castes in alliance with urban businessmen’ (Frankel 1978: 74). Though the Congress had encouraged some social reforms, caste-based social hierarchy and the forms of oppression associated with it remained strong, so that as Mehta has argued, ‘the structure of what we might call India’s ancient social regime ... survived into democracy relatively intact’ (Mehta 2003: 52). There had been no social revolution. Thus it was that Nehru equivocated in the Constituent Assembly. Though he himself, and some others, were sympathetic to socialism, and recognized the need for some redistribution of assets, the majority were not, but were staunch defenders of the rights of property. There was justice, then, in Ambedkar’s words in his last speech before the Constituent Assembly when he argued that:

On the 26th January 1950 [when the Constitution was to come into effect] we are going to enter a life of contradictions. In politics we will have equality and in social and economic life we will have inequality. In politics we will be recognizing the principle of one man, one vote, one value. In our social and economic life we shall, by reason of our social and economic structure, continue to deny the principle of one man, one value. How long shall we continue to live this life of contradictions?

This chapter examines the record of independent India in tackling these contradictions, and the politics of redistribution both between social classes and over space, between states and regions of the country.

The nationalist movement in India was influenced by the ideas of the ‘economic nationalists’ who—anticipating the arguments of latter-day dependency theorists—emphasized the significance of the colonial connection and of the ‘drain’ of wealth from India in accounting for the massive and widespread poverty in the country. They neglected, however, the internal relationships that drained wealth from direct producers to the benefit of Indian owners of capital, who according to some historians, ‘had never had it so good’ as in the colonial period (Washbrook 1988). There is an echo of the economic nationalists’ arguments in Nehru’s words in opening the first debate of the Constituent Assembly, when he said, ‘The first task of this Assembly is to free India through a new constitution, to feed the starving people, and to clothe the naked masses, and to give every Indian the fullest opportunity to develop himself according to his capacity.’

These high aims were then sought to be achieved, following Independence, through planned economic development—though, as Nehru once put it, by following a distinctive ‘third way’ that combined central planning with accommodative democratic politics, ‘planning under a democratic pattern of socialism’ (Corbridge and Harriss 2000: 43). Initially the Planning Commission, chaired by the prime minister, exercised significant authority and can be seen as having been the sort of competent economic bureaucracy, insulated from politics, that is considered to have been an essential characteristic of the successful ‘developmental states’ of East Asia, capable even of disciplining capital and of effecting redistribution. However, as A.H. Hanson explained in his monumental study of the planning process, in India the Planning Commission gradually lost authority and the locus of decision making shifted in favor of the National Development Council (Hanson 1966; and see also Frankel 1978: 254–56). This then became the site of a great deal of politicking between chief ministers of the various states who competed with each other over projects and resources.

Failures of implementation

India achieved very respectable rates of economic growth in the 1950s and into the early 1960s, but planned development ran into trouble by the middle of the 1960s when the government was no longer able to sustain high levels of public investment. As the economist Sukhamoy Chakravarty (1987: 18) argued, ‘insufficient attention [was] paid to the problem of how to obtain resources for public investment purposes while encouraging the growth of income in private hands,’ and as Vivek Chibber (2003) has explained, the Indian state had very soon lost the capacity to discipline capital in the manner of the East Asian states. A consequence of this was the increasing dependence of the state for its revenues on socially regressive indirect taxation. A second crucial constraint was the failure to bring about higher rates of growth in agriculture, and this in turn can be explained at least in part as having followed from the failure of redistributive land reform, which might have been expected to have restructured the agricultural economy in favor of the more productive, smaller holdings. This might also have had the effect of supplying a more powerful demand-side stimulus to economic growth—a factor to which Chakravarty also drew attention in his analysis of the Indian planning experience. In short, the failures of planning in India had to do with the attempt at combining it with accommodative democratic politics that actually gave power to the big bourgeoisie and to the dominant land-holding peasants, who were able in effect, between them, to hold the state to ransom. Pranab Bardhan has argued persuasively that India’s economic growth was constrained by the frittering away of public resources in subsidies that have benefited mainly these two ‘dominant propertied

classes,' who were joined also by a third class of white-collar workers and public-sector professionals (Bardhan 1998). These three dominant classes long effectively constrained redistributive policies.

A crucial event in the history of India's development in this early period was the rejection of a detailed plan brought before the Nagpur meeting of the Congress in 1959, which was aimed at carrying through the sort of reorganization of agriculture, based on redistributive land reform and collectivized production, that had already taken place in communist China (see Frankel 1978). According to this view the blocking of the redistribution of agricultural assets by Congress leaders, led by Charan Singh, with widespread support amongst the richer peasants who controlled the party locally, helps significantly to account both for the failures of planned economic development, and for the persistence of deep and widespread rural poverty. There was a first, successful phase of land reform in India, involving the suppression of the rights of tax-farming intermediaries, the zamindars, in favor of peasants who actually operated the land. This, however, had the effect of consolidating the economic and political power of richer peasants, including those who very largely controlled the Congress locally, as political ethnographies showed (e.g. Bailey 1963). They were able to ensure that later generations of reforms aimed at redistributing land were effectively blocked, in spite of the passage of a great deal of legislation across the states that was supposed to bring it about (see Frankel 1978: chapter 5, on 'failures of implementation').

At the beginning of the 1970s new attempts at measuring the extent of poverty in India by Dandekar and Rath (1971) showed just how extensive it still was (about 40% of the rural population, they calculated, and 50% of the urban)—and so how far India was from achieving the high (and implicitly redistributive) objectives that Nehru had set before the Constituent Assembly. It was at this moment that Indira Gandhi, by now the prime minister, announced the objective of getting rid of poverty, *garibi hatao*. However, neither she, nor her (temporary) successors in the Janata government of 1977–80, nor her son Rajiv who succeeded her following her assassination in 1984, was successful in making much difference to the problem of poverty in the country. This was in spite of the introduction of a whole raft of programs that were intended to bring about the alleviation of poverty. One contemporary assessment of the reasons for this by Guhan (1980) shows the continuing significance of local power, grounded in the inequality of land ownership, in ensuring the trickle *upwards* from these programs of benefits intended for the poor. At the same time, and right up to the present, the Indian state has consistently invested less in education and in public health—both essential for successful poverty alleviation—either as a share of public expenditure or of gross domestic product (GDP), than have comparable countries¹ (Mooij and Dev 2004). As much as 80% of health expenditure in India is in the private sector, internationally an exceptionally high figure, while private education, too, has become more and more important (Jeffrey *et al.* 2008). The failure of the state—until more than 60 years after Independence, with the passage of the Right to Education Act in 2009—to realize the commitment made in the constitution to the achievement of universal primary education is particularly egregious, and probably reflects the persisting elitist biases of successive political leaders, as Myron Weiner (1991) argued.

The Indian economy came to be marked in the later 1960s and 1970s by what was called 'the Hindu rate of growth,' barely keeping pace with the rate of increase of population. However, this situation changed in the 1980s, as government policies and perhaps even more so the attitudes expressed by political leaders became more sympathetic to private big business (Kohli 2006). The trend continued, following the more 'market-friendly' reforms initiated in 1991, and in the new millennium the Indian economy began at last to grow at very high rates comparable with those already achieved in China. Whereas in the Nehruvian period there had

been a strong sense that economic growth was needed in order that every Indian should have ‘opportunity to develop himself according to his capacity,’ now growth came to be valued for its own sake and India came to celebrate consumerism and the accumulation of private wealth.² While the evidence is disputed, poverty probably has been reduced in this time—questions concern by how much it has been reduced and for what reasons (Deaton and Kozel 2005; Himanshu 2007), with different official bodies reporting the incidence of rural poverty across the extraordinary range of 28% (according to the Planning Commission) to 80% or more (according to the National Commission on Enterprises in the Unorganized Sector)³—but inequality has certainly increased. An early analysis of the post-reform period by Jha found that inequality was higher than it had been before, and attributed this to ‘a shift in the distribution of income from wages to profits [and] a drop in the rate of labour absorption’ (Jha 2000: 39). More recently Himanshu has shown that at the all-India level urban inequality was higher than ever before by 2004–05, and that although at the all-India level rural inequality was much the same by this time as it had been in 1983, inequality had worsened in the rural areas of a majority of states (Himanshu 2007: 499).⁴

Regional inequalities

In his analysis of trends in inequality in India Jha noted that ‘there is reason to be concerned about widening regional inequalities’ (Jha 2000: 39). There already were marked patterns of regional differentiation across the country in terms of levels of economic development at the time of Independence, reflecting differences in colonial policy as well as the geography of advantage and disadvantage, and these have not been much altered since then. At Independence the states of the northwest and ‘the southern region around Madras and Bombay, and especially what later became the state of Gujarat, [were] better placed and had a better start in terms of both agriculture and industry’ (Srivastava 1993: 150). A kind of virtuous spiral became established in these regions, reflected now in the persisting differences between major states. The states of the northwest, the south and the west have generally grown faster than those of the north and the east, though Rajasthan stands apart from the general trend, in all the periods referred to in the data shown in Table 18.1. Latterly the backward states of Bihar and Orissa, in particular, have grown fast, but from a very low base.

For all the ‘overwhelming economic power wielded by the Centre’ in India’s form of federalism (Chelliah 1998: 346), and the interventions both of the Planning Commission and the quinquennially appointed Finance Commissions, which advise on the allocation of public-sector resources between the central government and the states, there evidently are powerful constraints upon the ability of the central government to effect equalizing transfers to the more backward states. The factors involved—according to recent analyses reported by Rao and Singh (2005: chapter 11)—include the economic and demographic size of the states, which have a positive effect on transfers per capita, and the effects both of the match between state and center ruling parties, and of the percentage shares of ruling party/coalition MPs. The outcome has been that, contrary to some economic theory, there have come about widening disparities in levels of income, rather than narrowing, between states (Ahluwalia 2000: 1639, table 3; and Rao *et al.* 1999).

Limitations of the politics of redistribution

Whether at the level of individual citizens, therefore, or at that of the states, redistribution in India has been very much constrained. The plea entered by Jha in the conclusion of his study of inequality—about how important it is ‘to build up pressure groups of the poor to ensure that

Table 18.1 Annual rates of growth of gross state domestic product (% per annum), and elasticity of rural poverty with respect to growth

	(a) 1980/81– 1990/91	(b) 1991/92– 1997/98	(c) 1994–2001/02	(d) 2002/03– 2008/09	(e) Elasticity of rural poverty with respect to growth 1958–97
Bihar	4.66	2.69	4.94	9.80	–0.24
Rajasthan	6.60	6.54	7.36	7.60	–0.32
Uttar Pradesh	4.95	3.58	4.09	5.78	–0.59
Madhya Pradesh	4.56	6.17	4.73	4.51	–0.37
Orissa	4.29	3.25	3.90	9.34	–0.71
West Bengal	4.71	6.91	6.73	6.66	–1.29
Andhra Pradesh	5.65	5.03	5.70	8.20	–0.77
Tamil Nadu	5.38	6.22	5.54	7.33	–0.62
Kerala	3.57	5.81	5.33	8.73	–1.19
Karnataka	5.29	5.29	6.27	8.00	–0.41
Gujarat	5.08	9.57	6.45	11.19	–0.67
Maharashtra	6.02	8.01	4.97	8.70	–0.38
Punjab	5.32	4.71	4.23	5.56	–0.92
Haryana	6.43	5.02	6.47	9.28	–0.42
Combined SDP of all 14	5.24	5.94	All-India 6.16	All-India 7.83	Average of 16 major states: –0.60

Sources: (a) and (b) Ahluwalia 2000; (c) and (d) Government of India, *Economic Survey 2010–11*; and (e) Besley *et al.* 2005.

enough funds are made available for social programmes and that those in charge of these expenditures are accountable to the people’ (Jha 2000: 40)—seems never to have been answered, or if at all, only in the very recent past.

Left-wing political parties, supportive of redistributive measures, were stronger at the time of Independence and up to the early 1960s than they have been subsequently—at least until the period following the 2004 general election, when they were able to exercise significant influence upon the ruling Congress government. The Communist Party of India (CPI), formed in 1925, was successful, together with the Congress Socialist Party, formed in 1934, in shifting the Congress towards a socialist line in the 1930s, but the Congress conservatives counter-attacked very successfully, with the result, as we noted, that Nehru was unwilling to commit explicitly to socialism by the time that the Constituent Assembly first met. In the first Indian general election of 1951 the CPI and the socialists between them managed to secure almost 20% of the popular vote. Thereafter the share of the communists increased and that of increasingly fractured socialists declined—though Indian communists have never mustered as much as 10% of the national vote. The CPI won office in Kerala in 1957, and in 1962 became the largest single opposition party nationally (though with only 29 seats). In 1964 the party split, and the Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI(M)) was formed, and from the early 1970s became electorally the more successful of the two parties, though it has never succeeded in winning much support outside its bastions in West Bengal, Kerala and Tripura. The crushing defeat of the party in West Bengal in 2011, after 34 years in office, while it also failed to hold onto office in Kerala, seemed to some observers to suggest that the communist left is in serious, even terminal decline. The Indian trade union movement, too, though it may not have been so ineffectual as has often been claimed (Teitelbaum 2006), has not been at all successful in pushing for social transformation. The movement has been divided on party political lines, and it has never embraced the ‘Approximately 83 per cent of the population work[ing] wholly in the informal sector’ (Harriss-White 2003: 5).

Peasant movements and movements of agricultural laborers have exercised influence at times, but have never been at all successful in shifting the political agenda in favor of redistributive measures. The farmers' movements that acquired significant political clout in the 1980s were vehicles primarily of the interests of the wealthier and more highly commercialized cultivators beneath the veil of a struggle on behalf of the disfavored majority of rural 'bharat' against urban India (Brass 1995). In the new millennium they appear to be in decline, as well (Pattenden 2005). Meanwhile the historically subordinated and impoverished lowest castes (the Dalits as they have come to be known, or the 'Scheduled Castes' (SCs) according to official categorization) have not succeeded in overcoming the caste divisions amongst themselves in order to mobilize more effectively politically. Even the electorally successful Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), which commanded a governing majority in Uttar Pradesh after 2007, is primarily a party of one particular Dalit caste community, the chamars. In short, the social and political forces that might have been expected to have achieved redistribution in favor of the disadvantaged, have not been at all effective.

Differences amongst state political regimes

There is a great deal of variation between states, however, and some have done very much better than others in bringing about the reduction of poverty and the achievement of human development. One sensitive measure of these variations is that of the elasticity of rural poverty with respect to economic growth, calculated by Besley *et al.* (2005), and shown in Table 18.1. These range from -1.29 in the case of West Bengal, -1.19 in Kerala and -0.92 in Punjab, to -0.24 in Bihar. While there is a relationship across states between successful economic growth and success in poverty reduction, West Bengal, Kerala and Punjab have all been relatively much more effective at 'converting' growth into poverty reduction than have the economically very successful states of Gujarat and Maharashtra, or (in more recent periods) Rajasthan. We find, similarly, that while in the 1970s there was little variation between states in the incidence of child undernutrition, when the proportion of children who were underweight was as high as 70% in rural areas in most of them, there is now considerable variation. Kerala, Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka (in this order), and West Bengal, have all done much better in reducing rural child undernutrition than either the fastest growing states economically (Gujarat and Maharashtra) or laggards such as Madhya Pradesh (Harriss and Kohli 2009). These variations in terms of performance in poverty reduction, or in reducing undernutrition amongst children reflect differences in state political regimes. The most significant immediate factor that has influenced poverty reduction and child undernutrition has probably been the extent to which different states have achieved a degree of food security by building effective public distribution systems (PDS). Correlation (in this case between PDS performance and trends in the reduction of malnutrition) does not constitute causality but at least suggests the possibility of a causal link. Available published data relating to the 1980s and 1990s show that the states that have done well in reducing poverty and undernutrition amongst children are also states that have made the most extensive use of the PDS. Andhra Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, West Bengal and then Karnataka between them accounted for about half of the all-India offtake of foodgrains under the PDS in the 1990s (Swaminathan 2000: tables 4.1 and 4.2), and have generally had the highest per capita offtake amongst the major states from the early 1970s (*ibid.*: tables 4.3 and 4.4).

Atul Kohli argued on the basis of his comparative research on West Bengal, Karnataka and Uttar Pradesh in the 1980s (Kohli 1987; and see Harriss 2003: 205), that the party regimes most likely to accomplish pro-poor distribution have the following characteristics: coherent leadership; ideological and organizational commitment to exclude propertied interests from direct participation in the process of governance; a pragmatic attitude toward facilitating a non-threatening

as well as a predictable political atmosphere for the propertied entrepreneurial classes; and an organizational arrangement that is simultaneously centralized and decentralized, so that the regime is 'in touch' with local society but not subjected to local power holders. In varying degrees the CPI(M) in Kerala and West Bengal, the Dravidian parties in Tamil Nadu and possibly the Telugu Desam party in Andhra Pradesh display these characteristics. The CPI(M) in these two major states and, of the two Dravidian parties of Tamil Nadu, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), in particular, have local organization that is now singularly lacking in the Congress Party (though local party organization has been much reduced latterly, in the DMK); and the CPI(M) in Kerala especially, commands significant mass organizations of agricultural laborers, workers and women, in a state that is notable for a high level of 'public action' (Drèze and Sen 1989). More generally there is quite a strong correlation between variations in state political regimes and redistributive performance as this is reflected in a variety of indicators of human development.

We may differentiate between Indian states in terms of the political representation of different castes/classes (this formulation reflecting the view that while caste and class are certainly not equivalent there is considerable overlap between the categories), and second, the nature of political competition in them. Analysis on these lines suggests that there are important differences between states in terms of the extent to which their political systems allow for voice on the part of poorer, lower-caste/-class people such as may build political pressure for redistribution. There are also differences of degree between states when they are assessed along a scale between 'clientelist politics' on the one hand and 'programmatic politics' on the other. The typology of political regimes across major states that may be constructed on this basis is as follows:

- 1 States in which upper-caste/-class dominance has persisted and the Congress Party has remained strong in the context of a stable two-party system ('traditional dominance' rather than politics of accommodation vis-à-vis lower classes).
 - Madhya Pradesh
 - Orissa
 - Rajasthan
- 2 States in which upper-caste/-class dominance has been effectively challenged by middling castes/classes, and Congress support has been reduced in the context of fractured and unstable party competition (both traditional 'dominance' and the politics of accommodation have broken down).
 - Bihar
 - Uttar Pradesh
- 3 States with middle-caste/-class-dominated regimes, where Congress has been effectively challenged but has not collapsed and there is fairly stable and mainly two-party competition (the politics of accommodation vis-à-vis lower classes have continued to work more or less effectively).
 - Andhra Pradesh
 - Gujarat
 - Karnataka
 - Maharashtra
 - Haryana
 - Punjab⁵

- 4 States in which lower castes/classes are more strongly represented and where the Congress lost its dominance at an early stage (clientelism may persist but the leading political parties have well-defined programs).
 - Kerala
 - Tamil Nadu
 - West Bengal

The outstanding performance of Kerala where the redistributive agenda of the CPI(M) has survived through the many periods when the party has actually been out of office, is well known (Ramachandran 1996). The Tamil Nadu story is less well known, though the quality of provision of public services in the state (see, for example, Das Gupta *et al.* 2010), and the performance of its bureaucracy, have long been recognized, and latterly it has been marked by a strong commitment to social welfare (reflected in the maintenance of a universal public distribution system in the face of central government pressures for targeting). Tamil Nadu's political regime has long been known for effective mobilization from below, and electoral competition between relatively well-organized parties has led both the Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (ADMK) and the DMK, the two major regional political parties in the state, to adopt programmatic policies targeted at the public at large, such as the Nutritious Noon Meal Scheme first introduced under the ADMK (Rajivan 2006). On the other hand, in Maharashtra, for instance, there is an absence of any such programmatic policy on nutrition moved by a political party. West Bengal is a more problematic case amongst the states that may be distinguished as having the most accountable regimes. The state has done well with regard to poverty reduction (as the rural poverty elasticity measure shows), but that this success has not been more emphatically translated, for example, into the reduction of undernutrition amongst children may be explained by the (puzzlingly) poor quality of public provisioning in the state. Andhra Pradesh, on the other hand, stands out amongst the middle-caste-dominated regimes, having been second only to Kerala and on a par with Tamil Nadu in regard to improvement of nutrition, and following only Punjab amongst the major states, after Kerala and West Bengal, as regards the poverty elasticity of growth. According to recent data the incidence of rural poverty in the state is by now exceptionally low (8.5% according to calculations by Himanshu 2007: table 5). Amongst the middle-caste/-class-dominated regimes of group 3 it appears that this dominance has been challenged most strongly in Andhra, and that the state has a more institutionalized party system. In brief, there have been quite marked differences between states with regard to redistributive measures—differences that reflect variations in the extent to which their political systems make for accountability to the least privileged.⁶

Directive principles into rights: recent advances in social protection

Recently, however, the central government has become more responsive to popular welfare. While the initial notion that it was protest votes from rural people that brought about the fall of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) alliance in the general election of 2004 is certainly wrong, for Congress and its allies actually did better in urban areas than in rural India, the new Congress administration chose to behave as though this had been the case. It was politically useful for the Congress to appear more caring than its rivals (Manor 2009), and the Congress-led United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government, taking advantage after 2004 of the greatly enhanced revenues that have accrued to government in the context of sustained high rates of economic growth, has implemented a number of redistributive measures intended to improve social welfare. As Neera Chandhoke argues, the government of India has

subsequently ‘enacted laws that upgrade the status of social welfare coded [as “Directive Principles”] in Part IV of the Constitution, to that of fundamental right, in response to campaigns launched by civil society organizations [and] interventions of the Supreme Court’ (Chandhoke 2008). In all of this the role of the middle class has been decisive.

The most significant welfare measure of all, thus far, has been the National Employment Guarantee Act, enacted by Parliament in September 2005, and extended to all districts in the country in April 2008, giving the *right* to 100 days of wage employment in public works to all rural households. Early studies of what is now called the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (NREGA) in action show up the considerable difficulties of implementation, and that its effectiveness varies a lot between states (Drèze and Khera 2009). At best—in states such as Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh—evaluations show that there has been fair success in meeting the objectives of the legislation, particularly in opening up employment opportunities for women, and in spite of the mounting evidence of the diversion of vast sums intended for the scheme as a result of the corruption of local elected and other officials (Subrahmaniam 2009a, 2009b).

NREGA was the outcome of a campaign initially for the Right to Food that was launched in 2001, stimulated by the filing of public interest litigation by the People’s Union for Civil Liberties, before the Supreme Court, demanding that accumulating stocks of food in government warehouses be used to meet endemic conditions of scarcity and deprivation. The campaigns that have driven this legislation (Chopra 2011), and others invoking the language of rights, have been led by middle-class intellectuals, deploying a wide repertoire of political strategies, making use of transnational networks and deriving funding from international nongovernmental organizations (NGOs), and involving the support of the left parties on which the UPA government depended for support from the outside.⁷ With the exception of the campaign on the right to information, however, they have not been concerned much with raising popular consciousness, but have rather lobbied policy makers; and they have achieved notable results only when they have appealed successfully to the Supreme Court. Jean Drèze wrote tellingly of the Right to Food Campaign in 2004:

The ‘leaders’ almost invariably come from a privileged social background. However sensitive they may be to the viewpoint of the underprivileged, they cannot but carry a certain baggage associated with their own position. The bottom line is that, with few exceptions, social movements in India (or for that matter elsewhere) are far from democratic. This lack of internal democracy jars with the values we claim to stand for, and creates a deep inconsistency between means and ends.

(Drèze 2004: 128)

More recently the Right to Food Campaign has, however, kept up sustained pressure on the second UPA government to honor the electoral commitment that it made in 2009 to realize food security in the country. A Food Security Bill was in draft (in 2011), and was the object of a lot of controversy, between those who advocate the application of a universal principle as against targeting, and those who favor cash transfers rather than—as hitherto—the operation of a public distribution system (see Corbridge *et al.* 2012: chapter 5).

Concerns about the politics of the campaigning, and the controversy that has been aroused notwithstanding, such middle-class activism as over the Right to Food has built unprecedented pressures upon the central government of India to realize some modest redistributive measures. There is no doubt that basic social protection—a safety net—is being strengthened as a result. It must be remembered, however, that these are very basic *welfare* measures which, beneficial for

very many though they may be, only compensate for the failures of the contemporary Indian state to bring about the more inclusive economic growth to which a commitment was made in the 11th five-year plan (for 2007–12). These failures are reflected above all in the lack of the productive employment that is necessary for ‘inclusive growth,’ and in the ever-increasing inequality that is the outcome of this (Chandrasekhar 2011a, 2011b; and Corbridge *et al.* 2012: chapters 3 and 4). Redistribution remains limited in spite of the shifts in Indian politics, dubbed ‘the second democratic upsurge’ (Yadav 1996), which have seen lower-caste/-class politicians achieving greater political power than ever before. The power structure of the Indian state still constrains redistribution.

Notes

- 1 The combined expenditure of center and states, as a proportion of GDP, still remained below 3% for education and 2% for health over the years 2004–07.
- 2 The shift in ideas and attitudes has been particularly marked amongst the middle classes, as Pavan K. Varma argued in his book *The Great Indian Middle Class* (1998).
- 3 On these estimates see Drèze 2010, and Rath 2011.
- 4 The exceptions were Bihar, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan.
- 5 Punjab fits uneasily into this schema since the main lines of political competition in the state are so much influenced by religion.
- 6 An alternative explanation for the variations in the performance of the major states in realizing human development objectives, in terms of differences in the strength and quality of sub-nationalism, has been advanced by Prerna Singh 2011.
- 7 This was until the tensions between the left and the government over its nuclear deal with the USA led to the withdrawal of left support in July 2008.

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CORRUPTION IN INDIA

Stuart Corbridge

Corruption in India

Corruption is usually defined as the abuse of public office or entrusted power for private gain, and it happens all over the world. Scandals involving Enron, BAE Systems and Bofors remind us that *grand corruption* can be as pervasive in rich countries as it is in some poor countries, where *petty corruption* is often more common. It is also widely recognized that everyday corruption can be a spur to action in bureaucracies that otherwise are characterized by torpor or seeming incompetence. Samuel Huntington (1968: 69) suggested that, 'In terms of economic growth, the only thing worse than a society with a rigid, over-centralised, dishonest bureaucracy is one with a rigid, over-centralized, honest bureaucracy.' More recently, the development economist Ha Joon Chang (2002) has argued that no rich country became rich while abiding by the rules of what is now called good governance. Corruption is a natural bedfellow of what Schumpeter called 'creative destruction' and what Marx called 'accumulation by dispossession.' Corruption served this purpose in the nineteenth century in Europe and the USA, and it has done so again in the Tiger economies of East Asia. It is not so much corruption that should worry us, says Chang, or even crony capitalism, but what happens to the proceeds of corruption and crony capitalism (see also Khan and Jomo 2000; Fisman and Svensson 2007). So long as corrupt proceeds are used to finance accumulation and economic growth, rather than conspicuous consumption, it should not be an overriding concern.

Perhaps this is the case in East Asia, although public protests against both *bureaucratic corruption* and *political corruption* suggest that Chang's view is too sanguine. Corruption is no friend of the poor or transparency. In any case in India it is unlikely that corruption did foster much growth before the era of economic reforms. Dirigiste forms of development create scarcities and pervasive rent-seeking opportunities. Speed money then circulates as a response to these distortions. Whether corruption is now being curbed as gross domestic product (GDP) growth rates soar is hard to judge. Anecdotal evidence suggests that the location, type and onward distribution of corrupt transactions have changed more than its simple incidence. In Chang's terms, corruption in India might be in the process of becoming more productive. Instead of procuring licenses, some business people are now procuring land—legally and illegally—for special economic zones or construction projects.

Given the pervasiveness of corruption in India it is surprising that public protest has remained a low-key affair. The right to information movement has disturbed the landscape in some

respects, but mostly for the urban middle classes, and so too in 2011 did the promised 'fast unto death' by the social activist and anti-corruption campaigner, Anna Hazare. Poor people mainly challenge corruption when the sums exacted from them depart from the figures they expect to pay and which they build into transactions. They also fight back against corrupt land acquisitions and what are considered to be new bureaucratic scams. Public policies which fail to attend to the experiential dimensions of corruption are unlikely to be successful.

In the rest of this chapter we first examine the political economy of corruption in India. The analysis here is mainly macro. Next we consider a growing case study literature on how corruption works in practice and is experienced on the ground. The analysis here is micro and we introduce a gender dimension. Finally, we consider how corruption is being challenged in India by social movements and through public policy.

A political economy of corruption in India

India in 2009 stood 84th among 180 countries in Transparency International's annual survey of perceptions of corruption among public officials and politicians. Its 'cleanliness' score of 3.4 was closer to Somalia's bottom score of 1.1 than it was to top scores of over 9.0 (out of 10) in countries like Denmark, Sweden, Singapore and New Zealand. India remains a country where business people, not to mention less privileged citizens, expect to pay bribes to public officials on a routine basis. Many of these bribes are described in the literature as *voluntary* or *collusive* payments: for example, bribes to gain access to a decent power connection or to avoid a fine. The politicians or bureaucrats receiving these bribes are expected to provide favors in return for cash or kind payments. They do so mainly by exercising power over choke-points in the economy or polity. So long as the favor is performed properly the main loser is the public at large. In contrast, *coercive* bribes occur when the bribe giver is directly cheated. This happens, for example, when a police officer takes money to release an innocent person. *Corruption as theft* is also common in infrastructure projects across India. It is relatively easy to cheat laborers in the absence of well-kept accounts that are available to both parties. It is also not difficult for public officials and their supporters to steal some of the commodities necessary for the building of schools, roads and hospitals.

The pervasiveness of corruption in India is sometimes explained with reference to cultural norms. In a world of 'limited-group morality' cheating the system for individual or social group advancement is not frowned upon in the way that it is in societies characterized by 'generalized morality' (Platteau 1994; see also Corbridge 2004 and Ramanujan 1989). Due process and respect for distant strangers play second fiddle to the need to promote kith and kin. Many backward caste men and women also feel that it is now their turn to milk the state, after years of observing India's forward castes doing likewise. Yet another sort of morality is in play here.

Economists and political scientists prefer to explain corruption in India with reference to the development of a permit and license raj. The intuition is that competitive market transactions are less supportive of corruption than are transactions which arise in situations of regulated scarcity (informational and material). India's permit and license raj was built up in the 1950s as a way of protecting strategic and infant industries from unwanted competition. Foreign exchange controls and high tariff barriers allowed domestic industries to be developed in their lee. Meanwhile, different sectors of the economy were reserved for industrial units on the basis of size and location, amongst other factors. Regional policy sat alongside industrial policy in Nehru's India, as it did in the India of Indira and Rajiv Gandhi. It wasn't long, however, before these regulations were observed to have perverse effects. Lack of competition stymied innovation. Rajan (2010: 60) has observed that the Ambassador car came in 'only five different models [over

nearly four decades] ... and the sole differences between them seemed to be the headlights and the shape of the grill.' Over-regulation, meanwhile, forced business people to chase precious permits and licenses, the securing of which was often best effected through speed money.

Many of these relationships became routinized. Leading business houses came to enjoy the patronage of leading politicians and bureaucrats, and vice versa. All of this was evident by the time that the government of India set up its first major enquiry into corruption in the country—the Santhanam Committee on Prevention of Corruption, which reported in 1964. Changing a system which benefits a large number of powerful actors is not easy, however. Corruption generates a halo effect which can make oppositional collective action not only difficult but unproductive. Corruption that is squeezed from one enterprise or sector can re-appear elsewhere. Different politicians emerged in India in the 1970s and 1980s to take on the mantle of Mr (or Mrs) Clean, including Jayaprakash Narayan, but even prime ministers like Rajiv Gandhi and V.P. Singh found it hard to dismantle networks of collusive corruption. (Rajiv Gandhi's reputation suffered for a long time because of the Bofors scandal. He was accused of taking bribes from the Swedish arms company. Mr Gandhi was posthumously acquitted of this charge by the Delhi High Court in 2004.)

The commissions that are channeled to high-ranking officials in New Delhi are mirrored at state and local levels by widespread payments from ordinary citizens to their representatives and local bureaucrats. When corruption takes hold in the political sphere the benefits of competition can break down. The deepening of India's democracy may even contribute to a worsening of some forms of corruption as politicians seek to build up electoral war chests. Salman Rushdie once quipped: 'Indian democracy: one man, one bribe' (see Jeffrey 2010). The scale of funds that can be funneled upwards through a linked chain of corrupt transactions has also attracted criminals into politics, something that has been observed widely in north India. As yet, the costs of political competition do not seem to be outweighed by its advantages: notably, the promotion of citizen voice and accountability mechanisms.

Exactly how much money finds its way into corrupt transactions is impossible to say. The incidence of corruption varies by region, sector and type. Anne Krueger (1974) estimated that rents—not all of them illegal, of course—made up 7.3% of India's national income in 1964. Most of these rents derived from control over import licenses. More recently, Edward Luce (2006: 83) has claimed that 'more than 80 per cent' of subsidized food for the poor in Bihar is stolen, as against 20% in Kerala and Tamil Nadu (this might be changing as Nitish Kumar, the present Chief Minister of Bihar, improves government efficiency and opportunities for citizen voice). It is clear, too, that Indian citizens expect their politicians and police to be more corrupt than the military or High Court judges. School principals, forest guards and Indian Administrative Service officers fall somewhere in between. World Bank and Transparency International (TI) survey data suggest that bribes in India are more often coercive than they are collusive, while Bardhan (1997: 1321) notes that bribe givers often fail to get the services for which they pay: they fall foul of the fact that many government actions have to be sanctioned by more than one person.

It is also not easy to say whether things are getting better. The annual league tables produced by Transparency International suffer from selection bias and autocorrelation: they mainly sample the perceptions of business people, and perceptions in any one year may be influenced by previous TI scores. It is even possible that TI scores add to corruption's halo effect. Business people reading TI surveys might form an expectation of having to pay a bribe in a country like India and act accordingly. TI is probably right to suggest, even so, that the incidence of corruption in India has remained fairly stable even as its vectors have begun to change. In part, this is because the probability of facing sanctions for engaging in corrupt behavior remains low,

notwithstanding some innovations that are reported below. The rewards meanwhile remain high and may be growing in some areas. In part, too, it is because the liberalization of the Indian economy post-1991 has created new bottlenecks amid more rapid economic growth. Many permits and licenses have disappeared. In their place are new choke points—in the courts, in real estate markets, in admissions to top-notch schools and universities, and so on. The poor quality of public officials in India remains a problem in many line departments, not least at the lower levels of the public services where wages are often low. However, what also drives corruption is simple scarcity, for example of power and infrastructure, or of higher education places, construction sites and affordable, middle-class housing.

Everyday corruption and the poor

Trying to work out the total value of corrupt transactions is a thankless task. It also tells us rather little about the different uses to which corrupt proceeds are put. Numbers are more telling when they can be linked to the lives of ordinary Indians. This is even more the case when those numbers are expressed in units that are meaningful to both bribe givers and takers.

Case study work has established that retail corruption in India is extremely well organized, to the point of being predictable. Writing in the mid-1980s, Robert Wade developed both a theoretical and an empirical account of how a market for public office might work in India, and with what consequences. His key driver of corruption is the system of transference which allows public officials to remain in post (or not). Officials estimate how long they might remain in a given post and how much rent they can expect to gain from misusing a public office. Information on these tariffs circulates widely and determines how much an individual will pay for a post. Officials then extract enough funds from their subordinates to pay off their superiors and make a profit. Wade (1985: 475) reports that Assistant Engineers who were paid about 23,000 rupees a year in the late 1970s to work in the Irrigation Department of a south Indian state had to pay local politicians about the same amount for a posting in the Construction or Operation and Maintenance wings of the Department. Ultimately, of course, the money that is passed upwards in the irrigation bureaucracy and to local politicians is squeezed out of irrigation users. These users include *Gram Panchayats* as well as individual farmers. Citizen-clients come to know very well the charges that are due to different government servants: the forest guard, the Block Development Officer, the policeman or the Assistant Engineer. Cuts are regularized and they elicit protest most often when the standard tariff is not charged. Craig Jeffrey (2002) reports similar patterns of charging and behavior in his surveys of the police and higher education institutions in Meerut, Uttar Pradesh.

Everyday corruption of this type has non-private consequences, not all of which are easily anticipated. Downstream users of a surface irrigation system will be seriously disadvantaged by upstream users if the latter communities organize themselves collectively to pay or to cheat the local irrigation bureaucracy. Crop yields in potentially fertile downstream fields can be reduced as a result. Bribing tax inspectors not to prosecute a family or firm for tax evasion will have consequences for fiscal policy. Corbridge and Kumar (2002) report the perverse consequences of a highly regulated trade in timber in Jharkhand. Legislation that was intended to protect ‘innocent’ Adivasis (Scheduled Tribes, or STs) from ‘unscrupulous’ Hindu merchants made it difficult for households to chop down and sell trees from their homestead land (note, this is not Forest Department land). A local schoolteacher, Polus B., wanted to sell 10 jackfruit trees. In the early 1990s these trees were worth about 100,000 rupees, or 80,000 rupees net of stumpage and transportation costs. Before the trees could be cut, however, Polus needed to make a large number of trips to Ranchi, some 40 kilometers away, to gain permits from the

Revenue and Forest Departments. Payments had to be made to various government officials, as can be seen in Table 19.1. In the end, Polus sold his trees to a local *dalaal* (broker) for 20,000 rupees rather than incur high time and financial costs himself. Polus also worried about a possible risk of prosecution for an entirely legal activity. Corbridge and Kumar observe that this regime of ‘environmental/ethnic protection’ ensured that old trees were not being harvested and new trees were not being planted. When the tree trade was briefly liberalized, tree cutting peaked for a while but timber loss was soon offset by new plantings. People invested in afforestation when it became profitable.

Lastly, it is worth noting that corruption is gendered in key respects. The idea that women might be less corrupt than men has become a favorite topic of investigation (Swamy *et al.* 2000; Dollar *et al.* 2001). The driving intuition is that women behave more ethically than men, including in the provision of government services and public goods. The evidence for this viewpoint is patchy at best. It is more likely that women learn to be corrupt once they occupy public offices that offer opportunities for bribe taking. (Whether women target the distribution of public goods more effectively than men is a related but different question. It has been examined in the Indian context by two main teams of researchers: Beaman, Chattopadhyay, Duflo, Pande and Topolova, working in West Bengal and Rajasthan; and Ban, Besley, Pande, Rahman and Rao, working in south India. Chattopadhyay and Duflo (2004) report that female *pradhans* respond well to women’s perceived needs. Duflo and Topolova (2004) suggest that villagers offer fewer bribes in

Table 19.1 Rent seeking in the trade of privately grown trees; commissions paid where the *dalaal* chooses to log the tree himself and deliver the timber to the Forest Department depot

Local sarkar	Revenue Department (Circle office)	Forest Department territorial wing (Range office)	(Superior office)		Other expenses
1	2	3	4	5	6
Mukhiya ¹	Clerk (Rs.1,000)	Range forest officer Rs.4,000) ²	Clerks (Rs.4,500)	Officer in Charge (Rs.2,000)	Miscellaneous payments (Rs.1,500)
	Amin (Rs.1,000)	Clerk (Rs.500)	Officers (Rs.5,000)	Check posts (Rs.500)	Daily expense and transport for himself @ 150 x 40 trips (Rs.6,000)
	C.I. (Rs.1,000)	B.O. (Rs.1,000)	Others (Rs.500)		Transport for verification officers @ 350 x 3 trips (Rs.1,050)
	Circle officer (Rs.2,000)	Forest guard (Rs.1,000)			Contingency/ <i>chai-pami</i> (Rs.1,000)
		Check posts (Rs.500)			Logging and transport (Rs.20,000)

Notes: Summary: estimated net receipt from the State Trading Office: 100,000 rupees; expected total expenses: 54,050 rupees; payment to owner: 20,000 rupees; expected profits for *dalaal*: 25,950 rupees or 650 rupees per day of labor. This table is a generic model. The monetary sums here roughly equate to those spent in the story of Polus B., but are by no means exactly the same (for reasons of confidentiality). They equate to the reported ‘going rate.’

¹ This payment will often be in the form of a political donation or other favor.

² The range officer might use some of this money to procure genuine administrative facilities which are not provided by the bureaucracy because of a lack of funds.

Source: Reproduced from Corbridge and Kumar 2002.

Gram Panchayats with women leaders. Ban and Rao (2008: 526) report that women panchayat presidents 'never perform worse than men,' while noting, significantly, that women interact less well than men with higher-level officials.) What has been explored less systematically—indeed, hardly at all—is whether and by how much corruption transfers funds in net terms from women to men. The intuition here has to do with power and powerlessness. Women own much less immovable property than men in India, or indeed worldwide (Agarwal 1994). Literacy rates for Indian women have been improving, but they still lag those of men by 15%. This in turn affects female employment chances, as does simple discrimination. The chances for women to receive bribes are correspondingly less than for men, while the reverse is probably true for bribe giving. This is certainly true where women form a target population—receiving a widow's pension, for example, or benefits from the Ministry of Women and Child Development. Women continue to be hugely under-represented in government jobs in India.

Anecdotal evidence from eastern India also suggests that women define and experience corruption in ways that don't entirely map on to the experiences of men. Women report sexual humiliation in encounters with public officials, for example; men do not. Women have told the author that humiliation itself is a form of corruption, whether or not money changes hands. This picks up another definition of corruption: to be or to become rotten. Likewise, some women refer to corruption in terms of time spent waiting, or passing time. Women often have to wait longer than men of comparable social standing to see a public official. In some cases, too, they have to pay a male intermediary to make contact with that public official (Corbridge *et al.* 2005). Thinking about corruption only in terms of cash or kind payments is a mistake. Corruption is, finally, about power and powerlessness, and the ways these identities are constructed, lived, understood and contested. It is a key mechanism for the reproduction of inequalities.

Challenging corruption

Corruption is difficult to fight when it is widely entrenched and where it offers high rates of return to powerful actors. Ordinary people might hold back from challenging bribe payments that appear to be a charge like any other: reasonably limited and predictable, like a sales tax (*retail corruption*). It is likely they will object rather more when other conceptions of fairness are breached: for example, when monetary payments are coupled to forms of private or public humiliation, or when the possibility for bribery is dependent on membership of a named community. Corruption with theft is strongly resented. At the same time, corruption offers an opportunity for some poor people to become brokers themselves. It is also not uncommon for people to use caste, gender and other particularistic markers to decide how much another person should pay as a bribe (*parochial corruption* in Scott's terms; Scott 1972).

Both exit and voice strategies have been commended as ways of dealing with endemic corruption (Campos and Pradhan 2007). In the Indian context the exit option is often linked to liberalization. Again, the intuition is that people can escape corrupt transactions when they can make informed choices in competitive markets. Consider corruption in the field of real estate transactions. One way to reduce this form of corruption would be to strip back the zoning, rent and tenancy laws that distort India's urban land markets and which create artificially inflated land prices. Simplifying the legal architecture that surrounds land transfers would have the secondary benefit of reducing pressures on India's courts. This in turn might reduce opportunities for corruption among legal professionals. Bad lawyers can take advantage of the extraordinarily long time lags that exist between filing a case and having it adjudicated.

Exit strategies generally focus on the supply side of corruption. The idea is to close the opportunities that exist for actors to behave corruptly. Choke points in an economic or political

system have to be unblocked. This can be done by providing more or better-regulated service providers: better businesses for sure, but also better politicians. The hope is that the good drives out the bad, and not vice versa. Measures can also be taken to increase the moral cost of misconduct. Some business leaders are already stamping down on corruption in their ranks and refusing to pay bribes. Wipro, headed by Azim Premji, is often mentioned in this regard, along with the Tatas (Ramamurti and Singh 2008).

Voice strategies, in contrast, focus on the demand side of corruption. They seek to promote collective actions among bribe givers or those who are cheated of public funds. Some of these collective actions take the form of social movements. Others are coordinated by government and embrace a broader agenda for democratic accountability through decentralization.

The right to information movement has grown significantly in India over the past two decades. Important work was undertaken in the 1990s by the Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan (MKSS) in Rajasthan, among other bodies. Members of the MKSS sought access to official expenditure documents and used citizen activists to check reported spending against actual spending patterns (Jenkins and Goetz 1999). It also used village-based ‘court’ hearings—*jan sunwais*—to place the local state under public scrutiny. Partly in response to pressures from the MKSS, the Rajasthan legislature passed a Right to Information Law in May 2000. Goa and Tamil Nadu passed similar laws in the 1990s. The right to information movement gathered force after 2000 and led to the passing of a national Right to Information Act (RIA) in 2005. For a small filing fee (10 rupees in 2006), citizens can request access to non-classified public information from a Public Information Officer (PIO). The PIO has 30 days to make a first reply to the initial request.

Detailed accounts of Right to Information requests and subsequent actions are only just beginning to emerge. Initial filings suggest a strong urban bias, which is to be expected (see website of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India, www.cag.gov.in). In rural areas, the government has been hoping that politicians and contractors can be held to account by an active audit culture. Better inspection of muster rolls for work performed as part of the National Rural Employment Guarantee scheme has been demanded. More generally, the devolution of spending powers to Gram Panchayats is intended to increase opportunities for citizens to check where government monies finally end up. Whether such devolution leads instead to the decentralization of corruption is a moot point (see Véron *et al.* 2006). Much depends on local education levels and the severity of social cleavages. Information without power of redress remains a critical issue. In the longer run, of course, the government expects new information technologies to empower citizen clients. Computerized government records, text messaging by observant citizens, and unique identity cards all have been proposed as means by which government might be better held to account. Social scientists will be kept busy over the next few years monitoring the success of these interventions.

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PUBLIC GOODS PROVISION AND SOCIAL DEVELOPMENT IN INDIA

Prerna Singh

Introduction

Over the last few decades, there has been a growing awareness in development circles of the limits of purely economic indicators of wellbeing. Today the necessity of moving beyond income-based measures to take account of indicators of social development in assessing the overall level of development of a state and the standard of living of its citizens is well established. Following T.H. Marshall's (1964) influential formulation that citizenship involved not only civil and political rights, but crucially, social rights, the provision of basic social services, such as education, healthcare, housing, sanitation, and access to potable water have come to be widely regarded as one of the primary responsibilities of democratic governments. An enlightened and productive citizenry is in turn considered to be a prerequisite for the effective functioning of a democracy.

The establishment and maintenance of democratic institutions in India in the context of low levels of economic development and high levels of ethnic diversity has been widely studied and lauded (Kohli 2001; Varshney 2000). Yet while India has been relatively successful in guaranteeing civil and political rights, it has failed miserably in ensuring even a minimal range of social rights for its citizens. Today, over six decades of democratic rule and more than two decades of robust economic development later, levels of social development in India, measured virtually along any dimension, remain abysmal. Perhaps the starkest indicator of this is that almost *half* of Indian children under five are classified by the World Health Organization (WHO) as suffering from moderate to severe stunting. This is the highest proportion of children in *any* country in the world. The infant mortality rate (IMR) in India is more than three times that of Latin American countries such as Argentina, Mexico, El Salvador, Colombia, Venezuela and Brazil. The maternal mortality rate is almost double that of Iraq. In terms of life expectancy, India is ranked at 145 among a total of 197 countries. A woman in India today, on average, lives 20 years less than her counterpart in Hong Kong. India is also home to the largest number of illiterates in the world. According to the 2011 census, 74% of the population is literate, which is equivalent to that of countries such as Guatemala and Uganda. A particularly worrisome portent for the future of Indian education is that the youth female literacy rate is in the bottom 15% of all

countries in the world. In the composite rankings of the United Nations (UN) Human Development Index, India is ranked 134 out of a total of 187 countries,¹ just below Iraq and above Ghana.

India's failures are even more striking when juxtaposed with its South Asian neighbors, which have, in general, had lower rates of economic growth, a far more uneven record of democracy, a high degree of political volatility and widespread civil conflict. At 65 years, the subcontinental giant has the lowest life expectancy. In addition, India not only lags dramatically behind but has shown retrogression on child immunization, widely acknowledged as an essential governmental responsibility (Pritchett 2009: 14). Both India and Bangladesh had DPT3 immunization coverage of around 70% in 1995, but while this had risen to 88% in Bangladesh, it had fallen precipitously to 55% in India. Today DPT3 immunization in Bangladesh is 94% as compared to 66% in India. India is superior only to Pakistan in both the level of infant mortality and the pace of reduction since 1980. Literacy rates in Sri Lanka have consistently remained as much as 20% above those in India.

This failure to provide some of the most basic social services required for a decent quality of life to a large proportion of its citizens, especially the socially and economically marginalized, even 65 years after Independence, constitutes one of the most monumental failures of and outstanding challenges for the Indian state. This chapter seeks to understand the nature of and causes for these abysmal levels of public goods provision and low social development. It focuses in particular on education and health, the most prominent of the cluster of features associated with social development.² In so far as scholars have emphasized that education and health are good predictors of, or sensitive surrogates for other dimensions, such as the availability of clean water, nutrition levels, maternal wellbeing, overall status of women, the condition of the home environment, etc. (Morris 1979: 95), this chapter's focus on education and health is likely to enable claims about social development more generally. The chapter is divided into two sections. The first section analyzes potential explanations for the low levels of social development in India, as a whole, while the second section highlights and discusses the causes for the massive variation in public goods provision and social development across Indian provinces. In particular it makes a case for understanding the differences in levels of social development across provinces in terms of the strength of their subnational identification.

A national picture

It is useful to begin by noting that independent India inherited a sparse social infrastructure and very low levels of education and health. While the colonial period did witness important gains in education, health and sanitation associated with the activities of Christian missionaries as well as the initiatives of British administrators,³ the main aims of the colonial government were the extraction of resources and the maintenance of order, and this was, therefore, for the most part a period of stagnation and arguably even decline in levels of social wellbeing.⁴ As a result, at the end of the colonial period, India was characterized by very low levels of social development. The overall literacy rate was 18% and female literacy was a mere 9%. India's political leaders were aware of this dismal social situation and appeared, at least rhetorically, committed to improving it. In his famous 'tryst with destiny' speech on the eve of Independence from British rule, India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, had declared the eradication of 'ignorance and disease' as one of the most crucial tasks that the country faced. The Directive Principles of State Policy in the Constitution expressly stated that the state should provide free and compulsory education for all children until they were 14 years of age.⁵ This progressive rhetoric was, however, accompanied by a very different reality. For much of the early post-independence decades, there was

‘remarkable state apathy’ towards the social sector (Drèze and Sen 2002: 77). Social policy did not figure prominently on the national agenda. As a result, even as late as 1981 almost 60% of the total population of India was illiterate and for every 1,000 live births, as many as 75 infants died before their first birthday. While this was clearly an improvement from the situation at the end of the colonial period, these gains in social indicators were limited both in absolute terms and relative to other developing countries.

The massive ‘drain of wealth’ (Nauroji 1871) associated with British rule meant that India was in a precarious economic position at the end of colonial rule. It is important, therefore, to consider the possibility that absence of state prioritization of the social sector was because of lack of adequate economic resources. Economic growth has been widely believed to lie at the core of social development. Skocpol and Amenta (1986: 133) point out that Wilensky’s view that ‘economic growth is the ultimate cause of welfare state development’ has predominated among comparative social scientists. Modernization theorists emphasized economic development as the prime mover of improvements in the social sector. Parsons (1951), Lipset and Rokkan (1967), and Smelser and Lipset (1966) argued that with economic development all less developed countries would shed the characteristics associated with traditional societies, such as an illiterate, emaciated population and an authoritarian political culture, and acquire instead the characteristics of modernity, that is, an educated, healthy populace and a democratic political culture. Economic growth was believed to lead automatically and inevitably to concomitant improvements in the political and social realm. More recently, a number of studies in development economics have found income to be a robust and strong determinant of social outcomes. Filmer and Pritchett (1997: 6–7), for instance, write that ‘National income is strongly associated with child mortality and primary school completion.’

While low levels of economic development were certainly important, it is not in itself a sufficient explanation for the low degree of state prioritization of and consequently levels of social development in India. A number of states with equivalent or lower levels of economic development have made far more significant social gains than India. From the 1950s onwards, for example, Vietnam has been characterized by lower levels of economic development but better educational and health outcomes than India. From the 1950s until it embarked on a wide-ranging program of economic reforms at the end of the 1970s, gross national product (GNP) per capita in China was lower than or equivalent to that of India. Yet during this period it made far more significant social improvements, such that from roughly equal starting points at the end of the colonial period, it had a substantial lead on both education and health indicators. For example, in 1950 IMRs in China (195) were substantially above those of India (164), but by 1975, despite the disaster of the Great Leap Forward and tumult of the Cultural Revolution, IMRs in China (52) were half those of India (104). Today India’s GNP per capita (US\$1,170) is almost double that of Bangladesh (\$590), yet Bangladesh is ahead of India on a range of social indicators including life expectancy, child nutrition, mean years of schooling and female literacy (Sen 2011). Similarly, a number of African countries such as Nigeria, Zambia, Ghana, Malawi, Tanzania and Zimbabwe have lower levels of economic development but higher rates of literacy than India.

It is better to think of the absence of a progressive social policy less as an unavoidable product of limited economic resources and more as the result of a deliberate decision. Clearly, meagre economic resources meant that the Indian state was forced into choosing between different issue areas but as the experience of countries in a comparable position shows that it *could* have prioritized social development but it *chose* not to. A clear signal of this is found in the federal division of powers originally stipulated in the constitution. India is often termed a ‘federation with a unitary bias’ because of the disproportionate amount of power vested with the center

vis-à-vis the states as compared with other federal systems across the world. Education and public health were not considered to be of 'national importance' and therefore not included in the list of subjects under the purview of the central government; instead they were designated 'state subjects'—that is, jurisdiction over policies and implementation lay with provincial governments.⁶ This effectively meant that there was in fact no clear national policy on education until 1986!⁷

So the real question, then, is why did the Indian state choose not to focus on social policy? One possible explanation for the low degree of priority accorded to mass education has to do with the developmental path on which India embarked. During colonial rule, India had been reduced to a producer and exporter of primary goods. After Independence, towards gaining a place in the new world economic and political order, India's leaders focused on industrialization, especially the development of heavy and basic industries. This industrial strategy dominated by a focus on steel, power and machines triggered a concomitant demand for skilled technicians. This in turn led the state to focus on higher education over mass schooling.

A related explanation is that the state's lack of focus on social policy and its development policy more generally, reflected the elitist inclinations of India's post-independence leaders. In India, unlike, for example, countries such as China, the nationalist movement was not accompanied by a social revolution. Structures of power remained unchanged and social hierarchies persisted, especially in the countryside. In contrast to China where the communist revolution put people from humble, agrarian backgrounds and limited education at the helm, a large proportion of Indian leaders after Independence were upper-class/-caste individuals from cities, many of whom had been educated in elite institutions of higher education, often in the UK. It has been alleged that these leaders, ridiculed as 'brown sahibs,' were not alert to and ignored the needs of the masses. Nehru, despite his socialist commitments, was, for example, described by Barrington Moore (1966) as a 'gentle betrayer of the masses.' State policy during the early post-independence decades was characterized by a relative neglect of agriculture and social development.

Another closely related, more cynical explanation has been proposed by Myron Weiner (1991). In particular, Weiner emphasizes 'the belief systems of the state bureaucracy,' defined as 'a set of beliefs that are widely shared by educators, social activists, trade unionists, academic researchers and, more broadly, by members of the Indian middle class'. According to him, at the core of these beliefs is the Indian view of the social order, notions concerning the respective roles of upper and lower social strata, the role of education as a means of maintaining differentiations among social classes, and concerns that 'excessive' and 'inappropriate' education for the poor would disrupt existing social arrangements. Weiner argues that this view of education as an instrument for differentiation rather than as a fundamental obligation of the state towards its citizens means that those who control the education system are remarkably indifferent to low enrollment and high dropout rates among the lowest social classes and this is a key cause for India's low educational outcomes (Weiner 1991: 5–6).

In terms of supply-side variables, another potential factor for Indian states' lackadaisical attitude towards education might be the fact that unlike communist countries, such as China or Cuba, it did not feel the need to use schooling deliberately and systematically to inculcate a state ideology.

In addition to these factors, which inhibited the supply of social services by the state, there were also a number of reasons why through much of the early post-independence decades, the demand for education was quite low, especially in rural India. From the 1950s to the 1970s, over 90% of India's population was employed in the agricultural sector. Even today over 60% of Indians derive their livelihood from agricultural activities. However, as noted earlier, agriculture did not occupy an important place on the Indian policy agenda after Independence and until the introduction of high-yielding varieties of seeds and the use of fertilizers and irrigation with

the green revolution in the mid-1960s, the use of technology was consequently very limited and agricultural productivity was low. This greatly reduced the returns to and, therefore, the demand for education.⁸ The operation of a child labor market, endemic poverty, and high fertility rates, assuming there is a trade-off between the number of children and the education of each child within the family, also served to dampen the demand for schooling. In this context, the PROBE Team and Delhi School of Economics (1999) report's description of a broad-based surge in educational aspirations in the 1990s is especially heartening.

Subnational variation

So far we have looked at social development as an all-India phenomenon, examining national indicators and highlighting causal factors on both the demand and supply side that work at the national level. It is arguably more interesting, however, to analyze social development from a subnational perspective. To start with, subnational units in India are in demographic and geographic terms, larger than many countries in the world. If it were a separate country, India's most populous province, Uttar Pradesh (UP), would be the world's fifth most populous nation, next only to China, India, the USA and Indonesia. In addition, social indicators at the national level disguise a massive amount of subnational diversity. While certain states have attained levels of social development equivalent to those enjoyed by advanced industrialized countries, other states have fared worse than countries in sub-Saharan Africa. Women born in UP are expected to live 20 years less than women born in Kerala. A child born in Orissa (which has a larger population than Canada) is five times less likely to survive through infancy than a child born in the state of Manipur. A girl in Bihar (which has a larger population than France) is half as likely to be literate as a girl in Himachal Pradesh. The subnational variation in literacy and IMR is depicted visually in Figure 20.1 and Figure 20.2. A focus on the subnational level is also justified by the fact that national social development outcomes are, in the final analysis, simply an aggregation of social outcomes at the subnational level. Moreover, as discussed earlier, it is the provincial rather than the central government that has been the key unit of social policy in India. States play the key role in the formulation and execution of policies regarding both education and health, and account for nearly 90% of total government expenditure on these issues (Mehrotra 2006: 32). In an analysis of social policy in India, states are, therefore, clearly the appropriate administrative and political unit of analysis.

In addition to, and in order to better understand, the question of social backwardness in India, it is therefore important to ask why within the context of identical legal, financial and electoral institutions, some Indian states have performed far better than others in terms of educational and health outcomes? Prominent social science theories suggest a few different answers.

Economic development

The most obvious answer, which we have already considered at the national level, is levels of economic development. That is, the richer the state, the higher its level of social development. As Figure 20.3 shows, while there is a generally positive relationship between economic development, measured in terms of state domestic product and literacy rates and a negative relationship with IMRs. There are, however, a number of outlying states. Kerala, for example, is well known as an example of high levels of social development under conditions of low economic growth. Comparative historical research shows that in fact the welfare gains not only in Kerala, but also in Tamil Nadu occurred in a period when the states were in a precarious budgetary situation. Moreover, wealthier states like Punjab and Gujarat have been characterized by lower levels of social development.

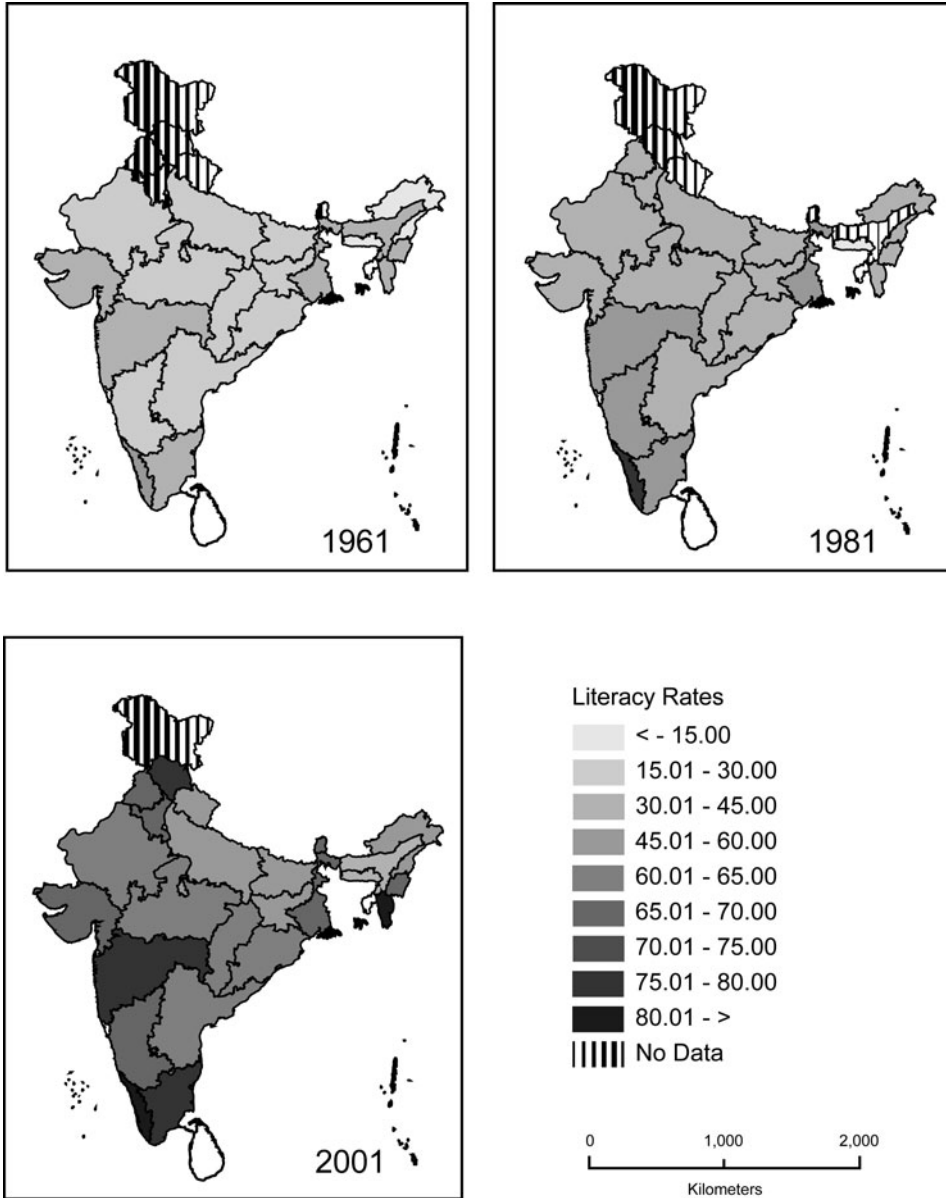


Figure 20.1 Literacy rates in India, 1961–2001

Rule by a social democratic party

Varying levels of social development have also been traced to differences in the nature of the ruling political party. A popular variant of the argument, which is equally correctly seen as a representative of the broad category of explanations termed ‘class politics,’ is related to the presence of social democratic parties. The argument, widely cited in the welfare state literature, is that states in which social democratic parties are in power are likely to incur higher levels of expenditure on social services and associatedly, to experience greater social development (Hibbs

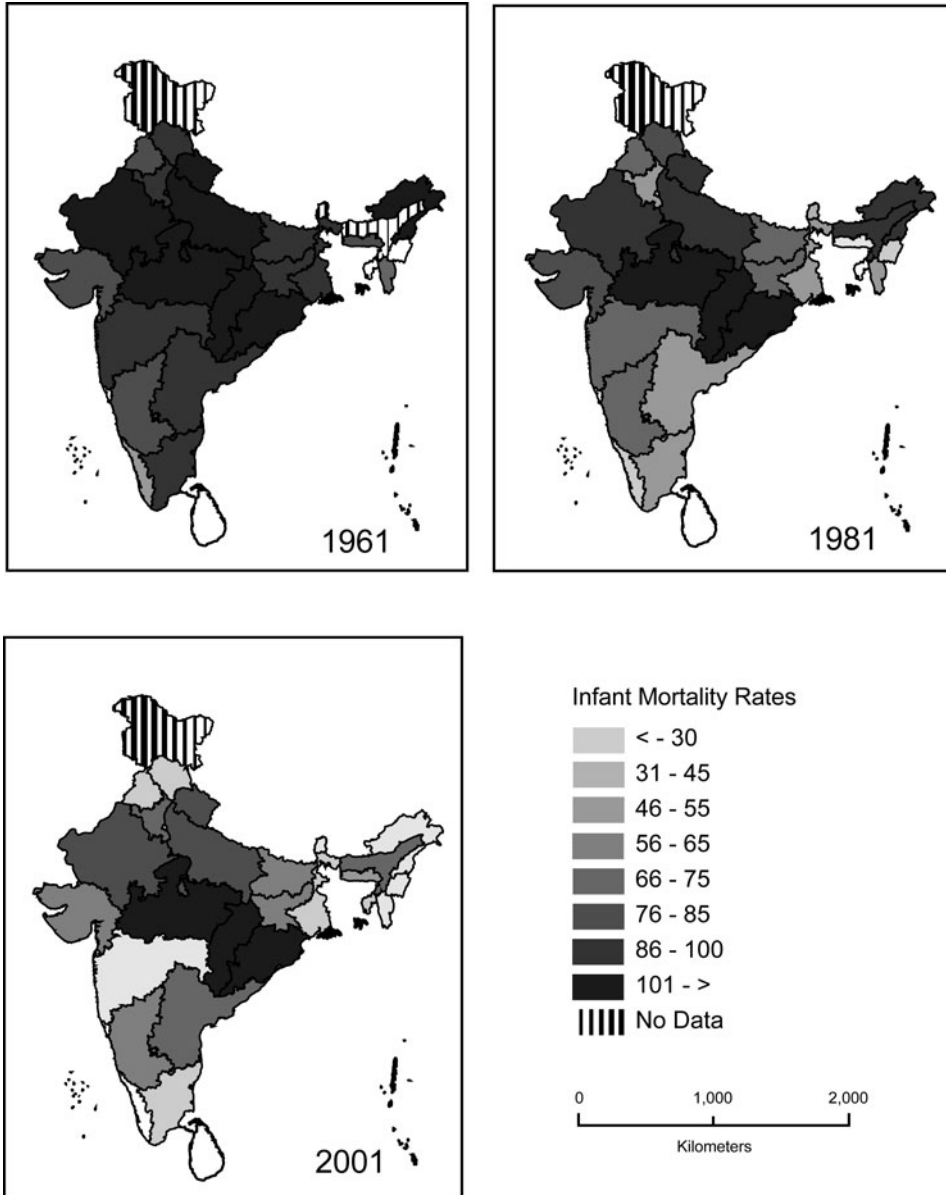


Figure 20.2 Infant mortality rates in India, 1961–2001

1977; Shalev 1983; Korpi 1983). One of the most influential statements of this argument in the Indian context is by Kohli, who explains the differential redistributive performances of state governments in terms of the ideology, organization and class alliances underlying the party-dominated regime (Kohli 1987: 10). Similarly, Herring (1983) and Heller (2000) trace the relative success of land reforms in Kerala to the strength of the labor movement and the communist party.

The presence of a social democratic party is undoubtedly an important contributory factor but it does not appear to be able to account fully for the empirical variation in social policy and

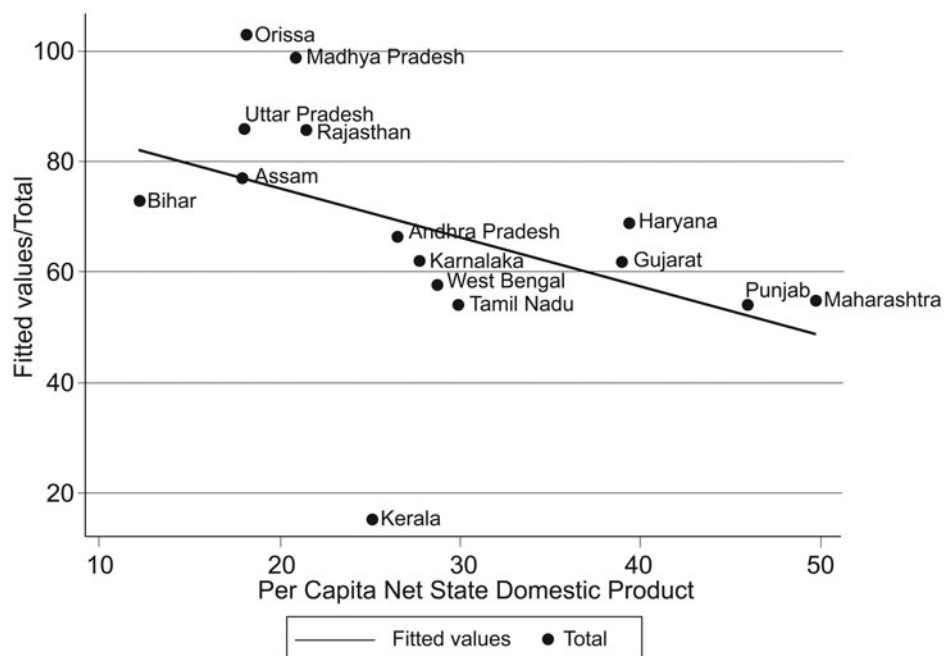
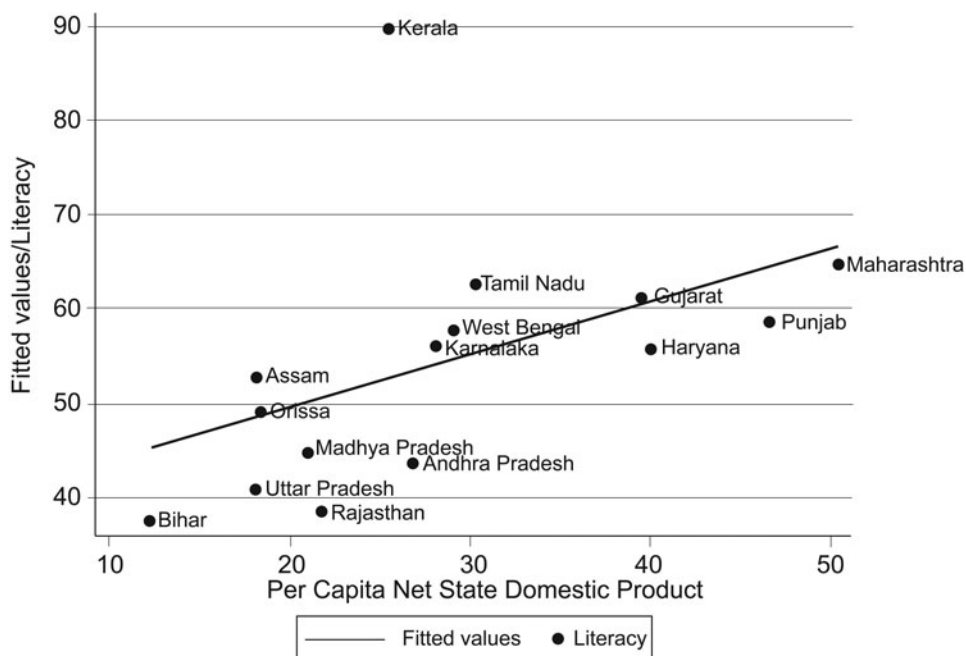


Figure 20.3 Relationship between social and economic development in Indian states

development both across states as well as within the same state over time. West Bengal, for example, has had the longest and most sustained experience of communist rule of all states in India. Yet its educational and health achievements are lower not only than Kerala, which has had a shorter and more intermittent history of left rule, but also states such as Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra and Gujarat, in which social democratic parties have remained very weak and have been unable to come to power. A number of scholars have explained Kerala's exemplary welfare achievements in terms of the policies of the communist party (Franke and Chasin 1989). While the communists have undoubtedly played a pioneering role in social development in Kerala, it is important to note that through the post-independence decades, communist commitment to the social sector has been virtually matched by that of Congress governments.⁹ Lal, for example, writes that, 'The defining feature of the [Kerala] paradigm is the centrality of political agency, *irrespective of the fronts that occupied office*, in the development process' (Lal 2006). Similarly, Kutty (2000: 103) points out that, 'Investment in education and health infrastructure has been a consistent policy of all elected governments in Kerala, *whatever their political leaning*.'

Nature of the party system

Another school of thought claims that it is theoretically limiting to examine the role of a particular party or its ideology in isolation from the competitive climate in which it operates. They argue that the party system has a substantial influence on the policies adopted by any party whatever its ideology—social democratic, right-leaning, Hindu nationalist or secular nationalist.

In the context of Indian states, Chhibber and Nooruddin (2004), for example, argue that whether the party system is characterized by two-party or multi-party competition has an effect on the provision of public goods. They claim that political parties engaged in two-party competition are more likely to provide public goods than those in a multiparty environment. This is because when there are only two effective parties competing in an election, each needs to win a majority to win the seat. Excessive reliance on any one group can isolate other groups from supporting the party and therefore in order to stand a chance of winning the election, the parties must build broad, cross-cleavage coalitions by providing public services accessible to all groups. In contrast, where there are multiple effective parties competing, the proportion of votes needed to win a seat is less and parties consequently need to appeal to 'vote banks' and particular support groups through the distribution of club rather than public goods.

Political competition

The intuitive hypothesis, rooted in democratic theory, is that a more competitive environment will encourage political parties to be more proactive in the provision of public goods as compared to a non-competitive environment in which they have little fear of being voted out of power. The classic formulation of this association between higher levels of political competition and progressive social welfare policies is by V.O. Keys (1949), who argues that political competition induces all parties to cater to the needs of the 'have nots' but in the absence of political competition, the status quo of an emphasis on the preferences of the 'haves' remains. Key's study triggered an active research agenda, which has generated an impressive body of cumulative research but a mixed bag of answers. While some scholars have found a strong relationship between a more competitive environment and public expenditures and services (Sharkansky 1969; Lockard 1968; Carmines 1974; Barrilleaux 1997; Manion 2006; Wang and Yao 2007; Hiskey 2003), scholars using different measures of political competition, methodologies or working on other parts of the world have not (Dawson and Robinson 1963; Dye 1966; Moreno

2005; Cleary 2007; Grindle 2007; Kauneckis and Andersson 2006). Statistical analysis that I have conducted elsewhere (Singh 2010) finds support for the political competition hypothesis in the context of Indian states. States characterized by closer electoral competition, operationalized in terms of the margin of victory between the winner and the runner-up party in the last state assembly elections, tend to be characterized by higher social spending and outcomes.

Civil society and social capital

In the last decade, the twin concepts of civil society and social capital have experienced an enormous theoretical rebirth and are an important focus of research in both academic and policy circles. Membership in associational networks and norms of reciprocity and social trust have been shown to contribute to the effective functioning of democratic institutions (Putnam 1995), maintenance of inter-ethnic peace (Varshney 2002), and economic performance at an individual (Narayan and Pritchett 1999) as well as at a cross-country level (Knack and Keefer 1997). There is also some evidence that civil society organizations promote public goods provision, such as state irrigation programs in Sri Lanka (Ostrom 1990) and waste management in Indian and Bangladeshi cities (Beall 1997; Pargal et al. 1999).

Evidence from the Indian case, however, raises doubts about the validity of civil society theories. Data from repeated rounds of surveys in India highlight the country's weak associational life. Chhibber (1999: 16) writes that, 'In 1991, only 13 percent of all Indians belonged to an organization, the lowest figure for all of the democracies on which comparable data [are] available.' The 1996 National Election Studies survey indicated that 96% of respondents said they did not belong to any social organization. Even in Kerala, a state described as having a vigorous associational life (Heller 2000: 497), only 12% of people surveyed reported being a member of an organization. Additionally, there is evidence that in contrast to the conventional explanations of civil society either as a product of autonomous private initiative or of antecedent civic practices (Putnam *et al.* 1993; Varshney 2002), the emergence of civil society organizations in the Indian context was endogenous to the development of political parties. Heller (2000) shows how the communist party in Kerala strengthened itself through entrenchment in civil society organizations. Subramanian (1999: 44) describes how the ascent of Dravidian parties was closely associated with the growth of formal and informal intermediate associations, such as debating forums, reading rooms and film fanclubs in Tamil Nadu. The distinctly political origins of civil society raise concerns about whether civil society in India has the autonomous impact posited by theorists, or whether its influence is instead contingent on, and channeled through powerful, and in the case of both Kerala and Tamil Nadu, subnationalist political parties.

Nature of colonial rule

The colonial conquest of India began through the activities of the English East India Company in the 1600s and the Company enjoyed the reign of the land until 1858, when in response to a major rebellion by native princes and sections of the colonial army, the Crown took charge and India officially became a colony of the British Empire. At this time Queen Victoria struck a bargain with the rulers of the hitherto unconquered regions of India—the Crown would respect their political rights in exchange for overall acceptance of British suzerainty. Thus, until Independence in 1947, some regions of India were controlled directly by the British, while a vast amount of territory was governed by over 500 large and small princely states that retained considerable autonomy over internal matters. Scholars have highlighted this varying nature of colonial rule as a potential determinant of the nature of political developments, and consequently

levels of social welfare in Indian states in the contemporary period. Specifically, there is some agreement on the relatively detrimental impact of direct British rule on the provision of social services.

Banerjee *et al.* (2005) find that districts that had been under British control in the colonial period had lower access to public goods in 1991 than districts that had been part of princely states. In a similar vein, Drèze and Sen (2002) suggest that Kerala's higher levels of social development were in large part a product of its legacy of princely rule. Banerjee *et al.* (2005) also find that districts in India where proprietary rights in land were given historically to landlords have significantly lower agricultural investments and productivity, and also investments in education and health, in the post-independence period than areas in which these rights were given to the cultivators.

Ethnic diversity

In the past decade and a half, ethnic diversity has emerged as a prominent causal factor in studies of public goods provision and developmental outcomes. A large body of research posits a negative relationship between ethnic heterogeneity and the provision of public goods (Easterly and Levine 1997; Alesina *et al.* 1999; Alesina *et al.* 2001; Baldwin and Huber 2010; Desmet *et al.* 2009; Easterly *et al.* 2006; Hopkins 2009; Miguel and Gugerty 2005; Khwaja 2009). In the Indian context, Bardhan and Udry (2000) show that ethnic homogeneity (in the form of 75% or more of the farmers belonging to the same caste group) is positively related to the successful maintenance of irrigation systems in south India. Banerjee and Somanathan (2007) and Banerjee *et al.* (2005) similarly show that Indian districts that have a higher degree of caste heterogeneity also have lower access to a number of public goods, including public transport, electricity and schools and health centers.

All these studies are, however, characterized by the same problematic tendency to read off *ethnic politics* from *ethnic demographics* (Singh 2011). *Ethnic diversity* does not necessarily imply *ethnic divisions*. Whether people from different ethnic groups hold opposed or shared preferences has less to do with objective diversity and more, I will argue below, to do with the extent to which they share a subjective sense of belonging, which has no necessary relation to objective diversity.

Subnationalism

A relatively novel, and arguably the most persuasive way to understand the variation in social development outcomes among Indian states is in terms of their strength of subnational identification, or subnationalism. States characterized by a shared identity and sense of community, based usually on a belief in a shared past and a common culture and language, are, likely to have higher levels of social development. This is because a powerful subnationalism can help overcome the obstacles to public goods provision posed by ethnic diversity.

One of the primary mechanisms through which ethnic diversity is hypothesized to dampen public goods provision in the studies cited in the previous section is through the polarization of preferences on the part of people from different ethnic groups about whether and how specific goods should be provided (Habyarimana *et al.* 2007). Ethnic diversity, however, need not lead to a polarization of preferences, if members of different ethnic groups have a shared, overarching identification, for example, with a subnational community. Studies in social identity theory, particularly in self-categorization theory and the Common Ingroup Identity Model, have consistently and robustly shown that 'if members of different groups are induced to conceive of themselves more as members of a single, superordinate group ... attitudes toward former

out-group members will become more positive through processes involving pro-in-group bias' (Dovidio and Gaertner 1999: 103). Recategorization into a single, common identity is shown to reduce social distance and generate a perception of common interests among members of different subordinate groups (Kramer and Brewer 1984: 105). In this way an attachment to an overarching subnational identity can serve to mitigate the obstacles posed by ethnic divisions by encouraging shared preferences in favor of collective welfare.

Support for social welfare, especially on the part of elites, serves as a powerful impetus for governments to prioritize the social sector. A strong affinity with the subnational political community also encourages citizens to be more politically conscious and active. In a cohesive political community, people are consequently more likely to be involved with the social services provided by the state. This combination of a progressive social policy 'from above' supplemented by popular involvement 'from below' can serve as a powerful determinant of social development.

Elsewhere I have shown how this subnationalist model can help explain the substantial social achievements of Kerala, incidentally one of the most diverse states in India¹⁰ (Singh 2011) as well as the wide gap in development indicators between the southern states of Tamil Nadu and Kerala as compared with north-central Indian states such as UP and Rajasthan, more generally (Singh 2010). Here I will summarize the argument.

While the southern states, and Kerala, in particular, are today hailed as models of social achievement, it is important to note that social policy and indicators in these provinces were virtually equivalent to those in states such as UP and Rajasthan until the closing decades of the nineteenth century. It was only the emergence of a powerful subnational identity among elites in Kerala in the late nineteenth century and in Tamil Nadu (TN) in the early twentieth century that triggered the emergence of a progressive social policy. The spread of Malayali and Tamil subnationalism to the masses through the Aikya Kerala movement in the early nineteenth century in Kerala and the Tamil nationalist movement in the mid-twentieth century in TN, spurred them to a greater degree of socio-political engagement. There was consequently greater popular involvement with the provision of social services in the two states. This combination of a progressive social policy and societal engagement with the social sector together generated key improvements in social development in Kerala and TN. The higher level of social development in Kerala as compared to TN can be traced to the earlier emergence and strength of Malayali subnationalism.

UP, in contrast, is a striking example of how the historic absence of a subnational identification can impede social gains.¹¹ Corresponding to the prominence of religious and caste identities, and the perception of the province as the 'heartland of India' (Kudaisiya 2011), elites have at different points of time pushed for the advancement of their specific religious and/or caste groups, or have focused on questions of national importance. Despite persistent and rampant illiteracy and ill health, governments in UP have consequently not introduced a comprehensive social policy for the state. Instead, at different points in time they have initiated policies targeted towards the development of specific religious or caste groups or have simply towed the federal agenda, which until the mid-1980s did not stress social development. In the absence of any allegiance with the political unit in which they reside or a sense of one-ness with each other, the residents of UP have been less involved with government schools and health centers and, as a result, even the inadequate expenditures that the UP government allocated towards basic social services have yielded only limited developmental gains.

The case of Rajasthan showcases how an increase in the cohesiveness of subnational identification in a political unit can generate important social achievements. During the colonial period there was little to no conception of a shared subnational community, and consequently an almost complete absence of state or societal action in the social sphere in the state. The early

years after Indian Independence marked the beginnings of Rajasthani subnationalism. Motivated by a concern for Rajasthani welfare, elites in the state pushed for the prioritization of the social sector. Rajasthani subnationalism remained confined during these years, however, to an elite stratum and did not resonate with the majority of the residents of the state who retained strong loyalties to their former native kingdoms and fiefdoms. This meant that the residents were less likely to be engaged with the socio-political life of a state and involved with the provision of public services. This lack of societal involvement greatly limited the potential gains of the relatively generous government allocations to the social sector. Beginning in the late 1980s, however, generational change and the rise of a subnationalist party facilitated the entrenchment of a Rajasthani identity in the popular psyche. The growing attachment to Rajasthan on the part of the masses increased their level of socio-political engagement and involvement with schools and health centers, thereby promoting more efficient social services. As a result, since the 1990s, Rajasthan has witnessed important improvements in social development, especially education.

Incidentally, the impressive social gains of Himachal Pradesh during the 1990s and improvements in the abysmal developmental situation of Bihar in the past few years, during the tenure of Nitish Kumar as chief minister, can also be understood in terms of the emergence of a powerful sense of subnationalism in both states.¹²

Conclusion

This chapter has sketched out the broad contours of and the factors behind the generally dismal scenario as regards public goods provision in India, while also highlighting and discussing the causes for the stark variation in the development indicators across different provinces. In recent years there has been a growing recognition of and concern about the country's dismal record of social development among India's political elites. The prime minister, for example, called the rates of malnutrition among Indian children, 'a national shame.'¹³ This has prompted the initiation of a number of landmark policies as regards the social sector. To give a boost to primary education, in 2004 the government proposed an education cess (levy) of 2% on income tax, corporation tax, excise and customs duties and service tax, the entire amount yielded from which was to be earmarked for education including provision of a nutritious, cooked midday meal. In 2009 the Parliament passed a bill for the 'right to education' and the provisions of the act came into force in early 2010, while 2009 saw the introduction of the National Health Bill, which recognized health as a fundamental human right and stated that every citizen has a right to the highest attainable standard of health and wellbeing.

This increased priority on the social sector on the part of the central government coexists, however, with grave problems in public goods provision on the ground. A number of studies have brought out the rampant absenteeism among key service providers such as doctors (Banerjee *et al.* 2004) and teachers (Kremer *et al.* 2005). Additionally, a particularly disturbing study by Banerjee *et al.* (2008) shows the ineffectiveness of a range of different measures, such as additional monitoring and incentives in improving the attendance of nurses in Udaipur district in Rajasthan. Other studies suggest that even when they do show up, service providers are either incompetent or indifferent (Das and Hammer 2005). This disjuncture between progressive social policies and the reality on the ground has prompted a provocative thesis by Lant Pritchett, who argues that:

India is today a *flailing* state—a nation-state in which the head, that is the elite institutions at the national (and in some states) level remain sound and functional but that this head is no longer reliably connected via nerves and sinews to its own limbs. In many parts of India in many sectors, the everyday actions of the field level agents of the

state—policemen, engineers, teachers, health workers—are increasingly beyond the control of the administration at the national or state level.

(Pritchett 2009: 4)

Such a line of thinking illuminates the enormity of the challenge of improving social development and public goods provision in India in so far as it suggests that a progressive social policy marked by generous financial allocations, constitutional directives and a range of social schemes is necessary but not sufficient; an equally important but perhaps more tricky task is to ensure the commitment of service providers on the ground. While this article has focused on the provision of social services by the state, it is important to note that, in large part to compensate for the failings of government schools and health centers, the past couple of decades have witnessed the explosion of nongovernmental, both non-profit and for-profit, private, provision of social services.

Notes

- 1 This is a composite of measures on three dimensions—health (life expectancy), education (mean years of schooling and expected years of schooling), and economic status (gross national income per capita) of a country.
- 2 Of the cluster of features associated with social development, education and health have been the most prominent. The annual *Human Development Report* brought out by the UN Development Programme (UNDP) defines the social dimension of its Human Development Index (HDI) in terms of attainments in education and health. Drèze and Sen (2002), seminal contributors to the field of development economics, have also conceptualized social development in terms of the education and health of the people.
- 3 The British resident in Travancore, Sir Thomas Munro, for example, played an important role in the establishment of a progressive social policy in the state.
- 4 In his pioneering book *The Beautiful Tree*, for example, Dharampal (1983) uses a range of British sources from the early 1800s to show that India had a thriving system of indigenous education that was steadily eroded under British rule.
- 5 The Directive Principles of State Policy are guidelines to the central and state governments of India, to be kept in mind while framing laws and policies. These provisions, contained in Part IV of the Constitution of India, are not enforceable by any court, but the principles laid down therein are considered fundamental in the governance of the country, making it the duty of the state to apply these principles in making laws to establish a just society in the country.
- 6 Education was transferred to the 'concurrent list' on which both the center as well as state governments can formulate policy only with the 42nd Constitutional Amendment in 1976.
- 7 In their comprehensive review called 'Education in India,' Ramachandran and Ramkumar (2005: 128) wrote that 'the country really came to grips with the monumental task of laying down goals for a national education scheme and devising a common policy, structure, design and strategy for implementation only with the National Policy on Education (NPE) in 1986.'
- 8 Foster and Rosenzweig (1994) show that for workers engaged exclusively in menial tasks, increased schooling attainment has little effect on productivity. They also show that rates of return to schooling among farmers in green-revolution India were highest in those regions experiencing substantial agricultural productivity growth (Foster and Rosenzweig 1996). The results from Foster and Rosenzweig (1996, 2004), also suggest that agricultural technical change is likely to increase schooling returns for landed households, who make decisions about the adoption and management of new seeds, but not for landless households, who undertake such tasks as weeding or harvesting crops, thereby increasing inequality in schooling in rural areas.
- 9 There is no statistically significant difference in social spending between the communist and Congress governments.
- 10 Kerala has the highest value on the ethno-linguistic fractionalization (ELF) index calculated for religion, which has been shown to be the most conflictual cleavage in India (Wilkinson 2008).
- 11 The lack of subnationalist identification in UP is brought out most starkly by the very name of the province, a geographic appellation—the northern provinces—which was arrived at as a compromise

because, unlike other Indian provinces, the leaders of UP could not settle on a name, and the fact that since its very creation there have been vociferous (and ultimately successful) demands for its division. The longstanding demand for a separate hill state was acceded to with the carving out of Uttarakhand in 2000. In late 2011 the government of UP, under Mayawati, passed a bill for the further division of UP into four different provinces: Poorvanchal (east UP), Paschhimanchal (west UP), Bundelkhand and Awadh (central UP).

- 12 The creation of the state of Himachal Pradesh in 1970 was the result of a subnationalist campaign led by Y.S. Parmar. Since its formation, the state has initiated a range of social policies, many of which have been explicitly presented as furthering the welfare of the Himachali people and the interests of the state as a whole. These policies have resulted in remarkable gains in education, and also in health. In the assembly elections of 2005 and 2010 Nitish Kumar campaigned and was elected on a platform that emphasized the unity of the Bihari people and their pride in their state. This 'Bihari subnationalism,' a term that incidentally Nitish Kumar himself uses, has been an important, impelling force in the developmental gains made in the state during his tenure.
- 13 *Times of India*, January 11, 2012.

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21

LABOR REGULATION, TRADE UNIONS, AND UNEMPLOYMENT

Emmanuel Teitelbaum

In the last five years, the study of labor regulation in developing countries has emerged as one of the fastest-growing topics in political economy. More than 30 papers have been published in peer-reviewed journals on the economic effects of labor regulation in low- and middle-income countries since 2004 (Djankov and Ramalho 2009). Many of these studies have focused on India, touching off a fierce debate regarding the economic impacts of India's thick web of protective labor legislation. The primary focus of the discussion has been on employment protection legislation (EPL), which imposes limits on the ability of managers of medium- and large-scale firms to hire and fire workers at will.

Guided by neoliberal economic theory, a number of econometric studies have purported to show that EPL, designed to help workers, has instead given rise to rigidities that hamper job creation in labor-intensive manufacturing. Further, it is argued that strict EPL pushes production into the informal sector as employers seek to evade regulations in the formal sector, which in turn results in higher inequality and poverty. Ultimately, these dynamics produce an unfair dualism in the labor market: a 'privileged' class of industrial workers is awarded high wages and job security at the expense of insecure, low-wage workers in the informal sector.

While such critiques of Indian labor regulations have featured prominently in the Western academy, the media, and in policy circles, the neoliberal view has not gone uncontested. Indian economists, in particular, have taken a more circumspect approach in their analysis of the economic effects of Indian labor regulation than their counterparts in the West. While acknowledging the need to rationalize and reform India's labor law, they have also been careful to point out the contributions of labor regulations to social stability and social justice. Further, studies emerging from the Indian academy have questioned the methodology used in neoliberal studies, and have pointed to economic trends that challenge the contention that India's EPL significantly hampers industrial performance.

This chapter is intended to familiarize the reader with ongoing debates in the literature pertaining to the effects of labor regulation on India's economic prospects, and to briefly suggest areas for future research. The chapter begins with a discussion of the phenomenon of 'jobless growth' in manufacturing that many observers cite as *prima facie* evidence of the adverse effects of India's strict regulations. This is followed by a discussion of the body of econometric studies that analyze the effects of state-level legislation on measures of economic performance. In separate

sections, I explore methodological critiques and empirical challenges to this literature. I then consider whether trade unions are responsible for slow employment growth, and conclude with some brief thoughts about areas for future research.

Labor regulation and the problem of jobless growth

During much of the 1980s, output in India's organized manufacturing sector was growing at the same time that employment was stagnating (see Figure 21.1). These trends in output and employment reflect what commonly has been referred to as the phenomenon of 'jobless growth.' The fact that jobless growth was accompanied by rising wages and an increase in the capital-labor ratio suggested to many analysts that employers were substituting capital for labor in response to strict EPL introduced in the 1970s and 1980s (e.g. Ahluwalia 1992; Ghose 2005; Goldar 2000; World Bank 1989). Because strict EPL makes it difficult, if not impossible, to retrench workers, the argument goes, hiring new workers becomes too risky, while the job security provided by strict EPL gives existing workers more leverage to negotiate higher wages. Ultimately, inflexible labor markets and artificially high wages induce employers to prefer capital-intensive over labor-intensive production strategies.

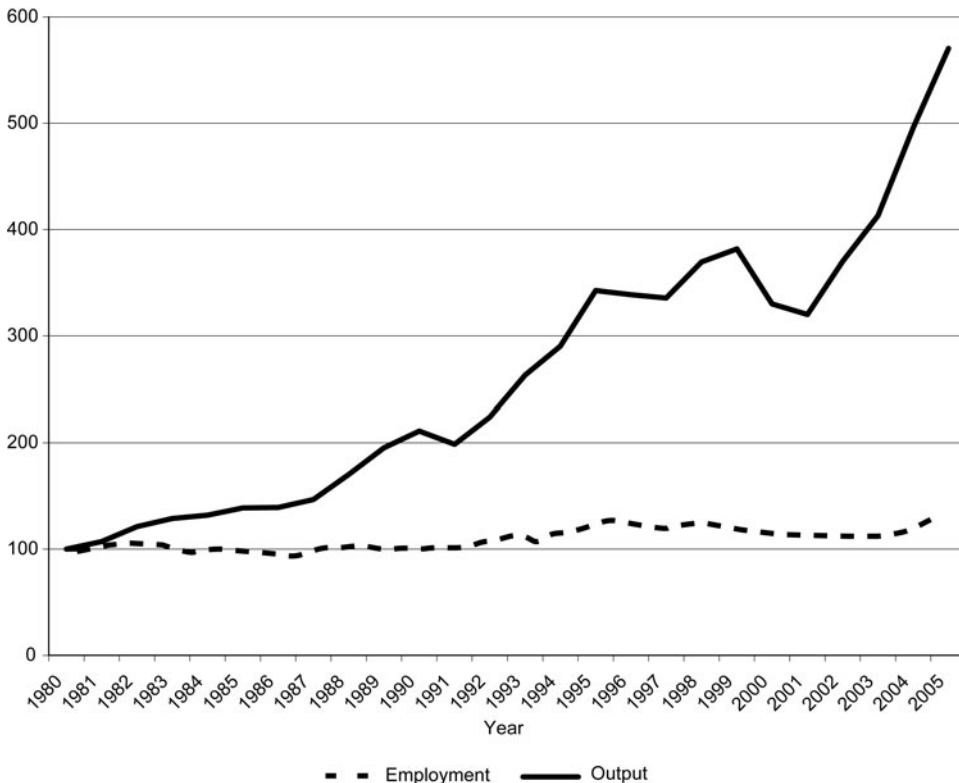


Figure 21.1 Indexes of growth in employment and output in manufacturing

Note: The employment index represents growth in the total number of persons engaged in manufacturing. The output index is based on real net value added in manufacturing, using the Wholesale Price Index as the deflator.

Source: The data for persons engaged and valued added were taken from the Annual Survey of Industries, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation, Government of India.

A number of laws in India prevent employers from hiring and firing workers at will. The Contract Labour (Prohibition and Regulation) Act of 1970 limits the ability of employers to contract out operations or hire temporary workers to perform core tasks typically handled by permanent employees. The Industrial Employment (Standing Orders) Act of 1946 makes it difficult for employers to remove workers for misconduct. Similarly, section 9-A of the Industrial Disputes Act of 1947 (IDA) hinders technological upgrades by allowing workers to contest ‘any rationalisation, standardization or improvement of plant or technique which is likely to lead to retrenchment of workmen.’¹

No set of regulations has drawn as much fire for its potential impact on labor markets, however, as Chapter V-B of the IDA. Chapter V-B was inserted in the IDA in 1976 during the height of the Emergency period. It initially required that any industrial establishment employing 300 or more workers seek the government’s permission in order to lay off or retrench workers, or in order to close down the undertaking. In 1982 an amendment was introduced to lower the threshold to 100 workers, substantially expanding the number of industrial establishments covered by its provisions.² The courts have also expanded the reach of Chapter V-B through their strict interpretation of the meaning of the word ‘retrenchment,’ which entails that discharging a worker for just about any reason is covered under the act (Debroy 2005: 56).³ Moreover, since industrial relations are jointly governed by the center and the states, many state governments have added their own amendments to enhance penalties and augment enforcement, the bulk of which were enacted in the early to mid-1980s.

The timing of the introduction of Chapter V-B, as well as its subsequent expansion and strengthening at the national and state levels, contributed to a widespread suspicion that India’s strong EPL was responsible for jobless growth in manufacturing in the 1980s and early 1990s. The first econometric studies by Fallon and Lucas (1991, 1993) analyzed the effects of the new restrictions at the national level.⁴ However, it was more than a decade after the Fallon and Lucas study that the econometric literature on labor regulation and economic performance found a broad international audience. I discuss this second generation of studies, which focused on the analysis of state-level amendments to the IDA, in the following section.

State-level analyses of labor regulation

Over the last five years, a number of studies have employed similar methodologies to examine the impact of labor regulation on economic performance in the Indian states. Specifically, these studies examine the effects of state-level amendments to the IDA, the primary piece of legislation governing the formal procedures to be followed by employers and unions in the event of an industrial dispute. Over time, state-level amendments to the central act have proliferated, and vary from those that make minor changes in the qualifications of industrial tribunal judges to those that place heavy restrictions on the ability of employers to hire and fire workers. Taken together, these amendments have resulted in a large amount of spatial and temporal variation in the character of labor regulation, which economists have harnessed to address questions about the impact of labor regulations on economic performance.

The seminal study is by Besley and Burgess (2004), who use panel regressions to analyze the economic impact of state-level amendments to the IDA during the period 1958–92. Besley and Burgess (hereinafter ‘BB’) purport to show that ‘pro-worker legislation’ results in lower levels of investment, lower productivity, lower levels of employment and reduced economies of scale, and conclude that ‘much of the reasoning behind labor regulation was wrong-headed and led to outcomes that were antithetical to their original objectives’ (ibid.: 124).

For their analysis, BB develop an original index of labor legislation. The index is constructed by coding individual amendments as ‘pro-worker’ or ‘pro-employer,’ and aggregating the codings of individual amendments to measure the direction of change in legislation for a given state/year. BB code ‘+1’ if the direction of change in a given state/year is ‘pro-worker,’ ‘0’ if it is ‘neutral,’ and ‘-1’ if it is pro-employer. These scores are then added to the previous years’ scores to measure the cumulative trend in labor regulation over the 35-year period.

The BB index has been employed in a number of subsequent studies to analyze impacts of labor regulation on various aspects of economic performance in India. One set of papers uses the BB index to explore the extent to which restrictive labor legislation dampens the effects of beneficial economic policies, such as trade liberalization (Hasan *et al.* 2007; Topolova 2004) and industrial de-licensing (Aghion *et al.* 2008). Similarly, Sanyal and Menon (2005) examine the effects of industrial disputes and labor regulation on investment location decisions in the post-reform era. Another group of studies explores the effects of specific types of legislation and/or the effects of legislation on economic performance in specific sectors. Ahsan and Pagés (2009) ask whether employment protection legislation has different effects on the performance of various subsectors within manufacturing than legislation pertaining to the resolution of industrial disputes. Amin (2009) combine the BB index with data from employer surveys to explore the effects of labor regulation on unemployment in India’s retail sector.

Critiques of the Besley and Burgess method

Since the publication of the original study, the BB method of analyzing the effects of labor regulation on industrial performance has come under tremendous scrutiny. Bhattacharjea (2006, 2009) has advanced the most comprehensive and trenchant set of critiques against the standard BB approach. He makes three primary arguments: (1) that the BB index does a poor job of capturing the substantive importance or volume of state-level amendments to the IDA; (2) that the poor specification of econometric models in the BB study likely results in omitted variable bias; and (3) that labor legislation may be a poor reflection of actual labor policy due to the uneven implementation and enforcement of legislation. These critiques continue to apply to studies that employ the BB method, and are important enough to warrant an extended reprise here.

One of the crucial flaws of the BB index is that it fails to consider the substantive importance of legislation or the volume of amendments passed in a given state/year. By coding all legislation as ‘pro-employer,’ ‘neutral,’ or ‘pro-worker,’ the BB index gives equal weight to legislation with a minor impact and legislation of great import. By coding for the ‘direction of change’ in a given state/year, the BB index gives equal weight to the passage of single amendments and the passage of a large volume of amendments. Bhattacharjea also questions whether the ‘pro-employer’/‘pro-worker’ distinction adequately captures the substance of many amendments, and highlights the odd implications of the BB method for coding individual states. One systematic problem is that amendments facilitating greater judicial intervention in a dispute are coded as ‘pro-employer,’ when it is not the case that the judicial system is systematically biased in favor of employers. The odd implications of the method for coding individual cases include the coding of Kerala, the state that was home to the first freely elected communist government in the world as ‘pro-employer,’ and Maharashtra and Gujarat, two of India’s most popular investment destinations, as ‘pro-worker.’

As for the specification of models, the primary issue is that the original BB study and subsequent studies using the BB method include only a small number of control variables, giving rise to the possibility of omitted variable bias. The original BB study includes two controls for infrastructure (development expenditure and installed electrical capacity), population, and

political ideology. Obviously, many other factors influence firms' decisions regarding the location and scale of their production units, such as geography, natural resource endowments, human capital and other aspects of the legal and regulatory environment.

Finally, there are the twin issues of implementation and enforcement. I take up the latter issue, which is related to the use of temporary workers to evade the law, in the following section. Regarding implementation, Bhattacharjee (2009) discusses how legal wrangling has resulted in the uneven implementation of Chapter V-B. For example, in 1978 the Supreme Court held that section 25-O, restricting the closure of industries, was an unconstitutional restriction on business. The High Courts of Madras, Madhya Pradesh, and Rajasthan struck down sections 25-M and 25-N (governing layoffs and retrenchments) on similar grounds. Subsequently, a number of states passed amendments and other legislation designed to deal with the courts' objections and revive key provisions of Chapter V-B, but even this remedial, state-level legislation was subject to protracted legal battles. As a consequence, Chapter V-B was in force at different times in different states, and in some states not at all, for key periods analyzed in the BB study, and the BB index fails to take this into account.

Empirical challenges to the neoliberal consensus

In addition to these methodological critiques, the neoliberal consensus regarding the adverse economic effects of labor regulation has been challenged on a number of empirical fronts. Recent data undermine both the contention that labor regulation causes slow employment growth in manufacturing, and the contention that labor regulation produces inflexibility in labor markets. These data suggest that the primary causes of slow employment growth in manufacturing were external to the labor market, that 'jobless growth' may not be a permanent feature of the Indian economy, and that employers have largely skirted the strictest provisions of the IDA by employing temporary workers. In this section I review, in turn, relevant data on employment growth, wages and productivity and labor market flexibility.

Employment growth

One challenge to the official consensus on the adverse effects of labor regulation is the fact that growth has not been uniformly jobless in the post-reform period. First, there was roughly a decade of, albeit slow, employment growth in manufacturing starting in the late 1980s. Annual Survey of Industries (ASI) data show that the number of workers in organized manufacturing grew at an annual average rate of 2.6% between 1987 and 1996.⁵ During the same period, the total number of employees (workers and supervisory staff) grew 2.8% per annum. Employment then dropped off in the late 1990s and picked up again to near 1996 levels by 2005. National Sample Survey (NSS) data suggest a more rapid growth in manufacturing employment during the 2000s.⁶ Sundaram's (2008) NSS-based estimates show that the number of workers grew from about 9.9 million to 12.3 million between 2000 and 2005. Moreover, the effects of jobless growth have not been uniform across sectors within manufacturing. Between 1981 and 2005, only a third of manufacturing industries experienced a net loss of jobs, and there was no clear division between labor- and capital-intensive industries in terms of the level of job creation or job loss (Kannan and Raveendran 2009).

Admittedly, the size of India's workforce (275 million workers in 2001) means that even following the rapid employment growth in the last five years, India's organized manufacturing sector continues to make only a meager contribution to overall employment. However, because there were no changes to EPL during this period, the surge and fall in manufacturing

employment suggests, at the very least, that labor legislation is not the primary cause of slow employment growth in manufacturing (Nagaraj 2004). Similarly, the inter-sectoral variation in job growth makes it difficult to point to EPL as the cause of jobless growth, because the legislation applies equally to all sectors, and because job gain (and loss) occurred in capital- and labor-intensive industries.

Wages and productivity

Available data also cast doubt on the argument that poor employment growth is a result of the downward inflexibility of wages produced by strict EPL. In early neoliberal studies, an assumption that wages were responsible for jobless growth stemmed in part from a misinterpretation of ASI data.⁷ As Nagaraj (1994) has demonstrated, wage growth during the 1980s was due to a more intensive use of labor and not an increase in the daily wage rate. Subsequent studies demonstrated that labor productivity was higher in 1980s than in two previous decades, and that productivity growth outstripped wage growth from the 1960s through the late 1990s (Kannan 1994; Papola 1994; Goldar and Banga 2005). In the early 2000s, productivity growth slowed, but real wages fell (Sundaram 2007). These trends are displayed in Figure 21.2, which presents indexes of labor productivity and real wage growth for the period 1980–2005.

Labor market flexibility

The argument that strict EPL produces rigidities in the labor market assumes an even and consistent application of the law; however, available evidence suggests that the enforcement of India's EPL in the post-reform period has been lax. The consensus emerging from the empirical literature is that the government has taken a 'do nothing' approach to the enforcement of India's labor law which, in essence, allows employers to hire and fire at will (Sharma 2006; Sundar 2005). The government does not grant the permission required for layoffs, retrenchment or closures, as per Chapter V-B of the IDA, because to do so would be politically costly. At the same time, violations of laws that require vigorous inspections or investigation to uncover go unpunished (Ahsan *et al.* 2008). The lack of enforcement is partly because state governments have pulled back on enforcement in the pro-employer political climate of the post-liberalization era, and partly because inspectors are easily bribed.

The Contract Labour Act, which places limits on the hiring of temporary (or 'casual') workers, is a key piece of legislation that has gone unenforced in recent years. This lack of enforcement has meant that employers are not, as is commonly stated in neoliberal studies, looking to the informal sector to evade strict EPL (Bagchi and Das 2005). Recent surveys demonstrate that instead employers are increasingly turning to temporary workers, to whom provisions of strict EPL do not apply (Desphande 1998; Desphande *et al.* 2004). Additionally, employers have increasingly been skirting the provisions of Chapter V-B through indefinite lockouts and the frequent use of voluntary retirement schemes (VRS) (Nagaraj 2004).

Alternative explanations for slow employment growth

Taken together, data on employment, wage and productivity growth, and the size of the casual workforce suggest that strict EPL is not hampering job growth or productivity. The most commonly cited counter-explanation for jobless growth in the 1980s and early 1990s relates to over-employment in manufacturing caused by an industrial slowdown in the 1970s (Nagaraj 1994; Papola 1994). When demand for manufactured products increased in the 1980s, firms used

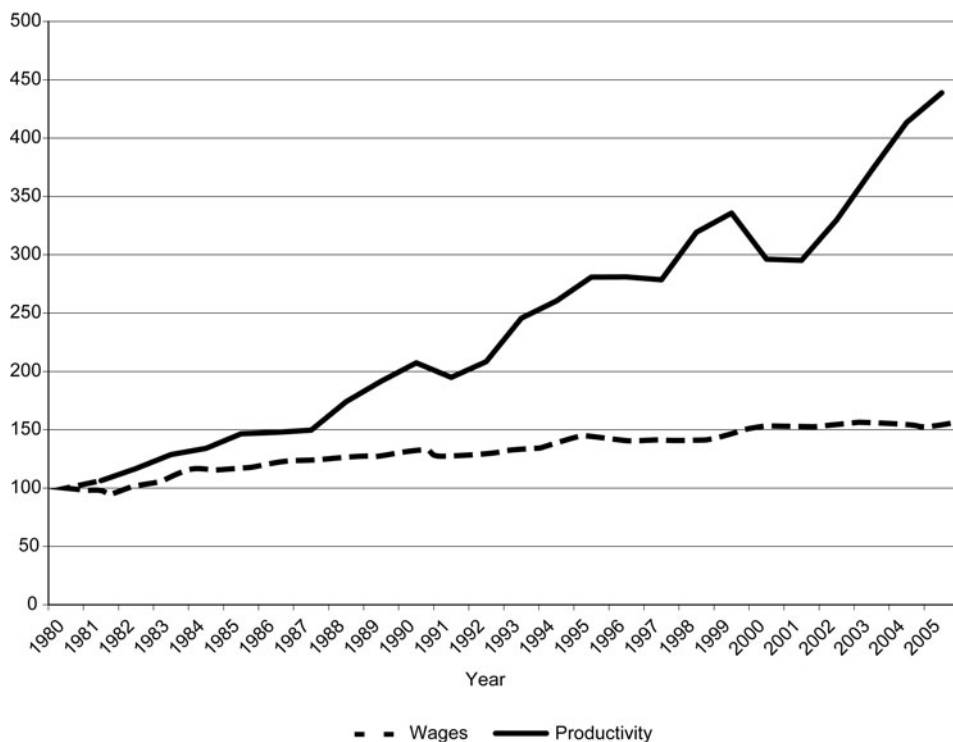


Figure 21.2 Indexes of growth in labor productivity and real wages

Note: The wage index represents growth in total emoluments per worker-day worked in manufacturing, using the Consumer Price Index for Industrial Workers as the deflator. Productivity is measured as real net value added per worker in manufacturing, using the Wholesale Price Index as the deflator.

Source: The data on emoluments, days worked, value added and workers in manufacturing were taken from the Annual Survey of Industries, Ministry of Statistics, Planning and Implementation, Government of India.

existing labor more intensively rather than hiring new workers, decisions which were, in turn, influenced by deregulatory policies and increased public investment (Bhalotra 1998). Other scholars have focused more closely on the nature of consumer demand. One such theory is the Fordist argument that the majority of India's workers, who toil in the low-wage, informal sector, cannot afford to purchase a high volume of manufactured products (Kannan 1994). A related point is that the demand among middle-class and international consumers is for high-end products that require a high degree of capital intensity to produce (Kannan and Raveendran 2009).

Are trade unions responsible for slow employment growth?

A number of scholars assume that protective labor legislation and the strength of trade unions are closely related—that strict legislation resulted from the vocal role of organized labor in Indian politics, and that protective legislation ensures the continuation of union dominance in the collective bargaining arena (e.g. Besley and Burgess 2004). Thus, one might reasonably anticipate that even absent the effective implementation protective labor legislation, trade unions could play an obstructionist role that would have adverse implications for investment, employment, and growth.

There are a number of reasons to question this reasoning. First, from an historical perspective, there has been very little connection between the strength of trade unions and the enactment, or the implementation, of protective labor legislation. Much of India's labor legislation was introduced when labor was weak and politically excluded, and was designed to subdue, not protect, organized labor. We have already noted, for example, that Chapter V-B of the IDA was enacted during the height of the Emergency, when trade unions were not permitted to function. Similarly, key provisions of the original Act were designed to facilitate state intervention in the industrial relations arena and, thereby, to impose industrial peace (Chibber 2003; Teitelbaum 2008).

Second, while trade unions in India continue to be a vibrant economic and political force, increasingly competitive labor and product markets have undermined the bargaining power of unions in the post-reform period. Labor's declining strength is illustrated by the fact that although output and profits have been increasing since the 1980s, labor's share of value added (wages) has declined (see Figure 21.3). During the early 1990s, this was largely due to capital deepening, but by the end of the 1990s it was due to employers taking greater profits (Teitelbaum 2007a). This set of dynamics is a direct consequence of the trends in productivity and wages we noted earlier—labor is becoming more productive while workers' wages remain stagnant.

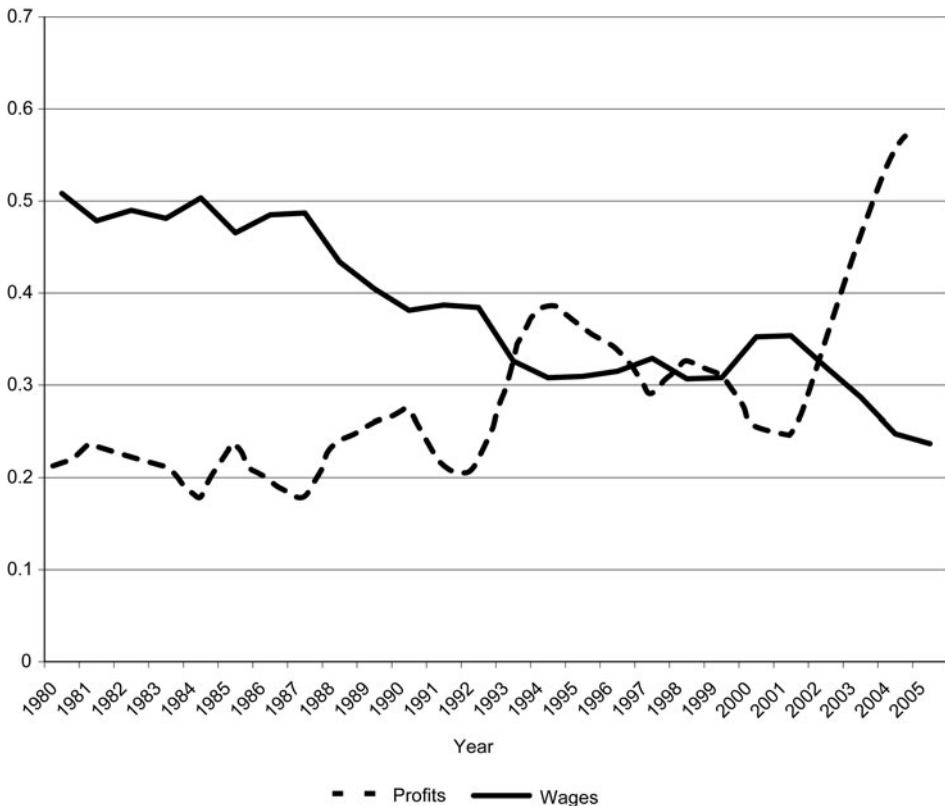


Figure 21.3 Wages and profits as a percentage of net value added

Source: Data on wages (total emoluments) and profits were taken from the Annual Survey of Industries, Ministry of Statistics, Planning and Implementation, Government of India.

We find more evidence of the declining bargaining power of unions in India's strike statistics. Since the mid-1980s, worker-days lost to industrial disputes have declined markedly while the number of worker-days lost to lockouts has remained constant (see Figure 21.4). A number of analysts have interpreted these dual trends in strike and lockout activity as indicative of the increasing dominance of employers in the collective bargaining arena (Dutt 2003; Sundar 2004; Teitelbaum 2007a). While workers are unable to mount a credible strike threat, employers continue to use lockouts to bring organized labor to heel, and as a means of closing factories without seeking the requisite permission from the government.

Finally, we know that unions' approach to collective bargaining has changed dramatically in the post-reform period. Increasingly competitive markets have made many unions aware of the need for compromise and change. In recent years, unions have not only been less likely to go on strike, but have also been more willing to sign productivity-linked wage agreements. These agreements have not only helped to spur labor productivity, but have included clauses that permit employers to rationalize the production process, make new investments in technology or even reduce the size of the workforce to maintain the profitability of the production unit (Venkata Ratnam 2003). Unions have also taken a less confrontational approach to collective bargaining. This is especially true for politically affiliated unions, which have refrained from violent protest and avoided provoking lockouts (Teitelbaum 2007b).

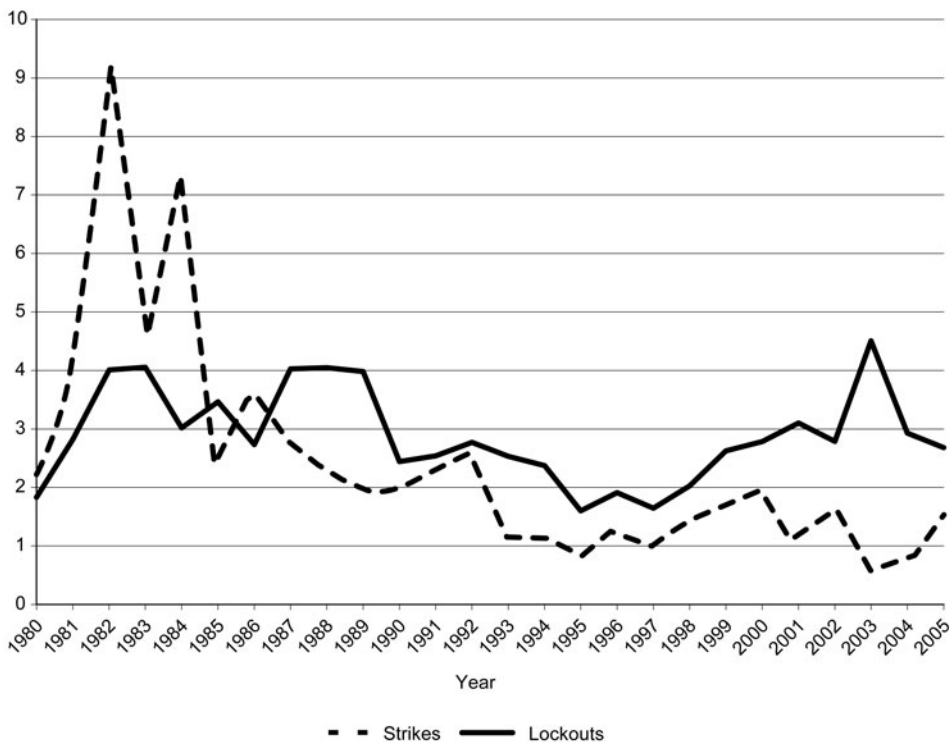


Figure 21.4 Man-days lost per worker owing to lockouts and strikes

Source: Figures on man-days lost due to strikes and lockouts are taken from the Indian Labour Yearbook. Figures on the number of workers are taken from the Annual Survey of Industries, Ministry of Statistics, Planning and Implementation, Government of India.

Conclusion

Existing studies have done a great deal to undermine the neoliberal contention that strict EPL, backed by powerful trade unions, is the best explanation for slow job growth in India's manufacturing sector. These studies have questioned the methodology of econometric studies purporting to show the adverse effects of labor regulation, and have pointed to trends in employment, wages, and productivity to demonstrate the growing flexibility of labor markets in the post-reform period. They have also undermined the widespread perception that unions impede the success of economic reforms.

What the literature continues to lack is a coherent and compelling alternative explanation for the phenomenon of jobless growth. The fact that organized manufacturing continues to make such a small contribution to overall employment remains a problem that needs to be addressed. Rather than speculating on the causes of slow job growth, the next generation of studies should rigorously test new explanations, preferably in an econometric framework. Further, while critiques of the BB index abound, we still lack a study that employs a defensible index of labor legislation. A more adequate coding of amendments to the IDA would take heed of Bhattacharjee's (2006, 2009) critiques, and perhaps give more detailed attention to the industrial relations provisions of the IDA.

It is also important to note that while a crucial piece of legislation, the IDA constitutes just one area of employment law. The myopic focus on the IDA has caused scholars to ignore the economic implications of a whole host of regulations that may have implications for economic performance. By one estimate, there are between 25,000 and 35,000 rules and regulations governing India's labor market (Debroy 2005). In a recent study, members of an Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) team developed an index to explore the effects of eight major areas of legislation in 21 states, and found that state-level labor market reforms had produced greater labor flexibility (Daugherty 2008). From a methodological perspective, this is a step in the right direction. Future studies should aim to account for the economic impacts of the full range of legislation governing the employment relationship in India.

Notes

- 1 Section 9A requires employers to provide notice of change to workers for any item listed in the Fourth Schedule of the IDA. Items 10 and 11 of the Schedule pertain to changes likely to affect the number of workers employed. The quote here is from item 10.
- 2 The 1982 amendment took effect in 1984.
- 3 For example, discharging a worker appointed on a temporary or probationary period, or a worker who is chronically absent have been interpreted as retrenchment by the courts.
- 4 Several studies followed the Fallon and Lucas approach of estimating the effects of labor legislation at the national level through the 1980s, and arrived at similar conclusions. See, for example, Aggarwala (2002) and Dutta Roy (2002).
- 5 According to ASI figures, the number of workers rose from 5.3 million to 6.5 million between 1986 and 1997, while the total number of employees grew from 6.7 million to 8.4 million.
- 6 NSS figures are arguably more accurate than ASI figures, but are gathered less frequently (every five years).
- 7 The early studies, and most notably the World Bank (1989) study, measured wage growth using the total wage bill in industry divided by the number of workers. As Nagaraj (1994) points out, this measure fails to account for the number of days worked. The appropriate measure is the total wage bill divided by the number of days worked, i.e. the average daily wage.

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PART III

Diversity of regional developments

22

UTTAR PRADESH

New patterns of mobilization in the 1990s and beyond

Sudha Pai

Over the last two decades the Indian states have emerged as important players on the political scene, shaping and transforming Indian democracy in many significant ways. They enjoy much greater autonomy from the centre, new social identities have asserted themselves, and regional parties are partners in national governance. Consequently, the states are feeding into and determining national patterns to a much greater extent than before. Uttar Pradesh (UP) has historically been a key state within the Indian Union. Most of the tall leaders of the national movement and prime ministers after Independence have been from this state and the Congress Party long occupied a dominant position.

Today, a seminal feature distinguishes UP from the other states in the country. Social change was slow in the state during the colonial period. Many significant socio-political changes that took place in states in western and southern India such as the anti-Brahmin and Dalit movements, have taken place here *only after Independence and after considerable democratization* of its highly traditional society and polity, a process not yet over. Consequently, UP today mirrors and contains within itself many of the significant changes being witnessed in the Indian polity since the late 1980s: collapse of single-party dominance, social movements in civil society questioning upper-caste/-class dominance, rise of narrower sectarian parties based on caste and communal identities leading to a fragmented multi-party system and unstable coalition governments. Thus, given its political importance analyzing some of the socio-political and economic features and recent changes in this state provides us with an important social laboratory or site for exploring and understanding some of the major challenges facing the Indian polity and democracy.

In recent years much literature on UP has been on new patterns of mobilization in the 1990s and its impact on politics. Undoubtedly, the decade constitutes a *distinct* phase in the politics of UP characterized by the rise of new social forces. Consequently, the emphasis has been on a break from the past and the sudden and at times destabilizing developments. However, beneath the constant and seemingly unchanging nature of politics in UP in the early post-independence period, a number of gradual but seminal changes took place, such as the backward caste (BC) movements, class-based changes in the countryside due to the green revolution, democratization among the lower castes and gradual decline of the Congress Party, which help explain the transition during the 1980s towards a markedly different political system. Accordingly, the

chapter provides a political narrative of the state since Independence over three major phases while focusing on movements in civil society representing forces from below, social base and mobilizational strategies of political parties, electoral politics—particularly caste and communal, identity-based politics—in recent years. Such a framework enables an understanding of the multi-faceted changes that have been taking place in this key state particularly over the last two decades and its enormous implications for national politics.

Early period of Congress dominance: stability with change

Up to the mid-1980s politics in UP had a stable and unpredictable character reflected in its single dominant party system. This was because at Independence the Congress shifted from an anti-colonial movement to a broad-based umbrella party which had the support of most sections of society: the smaller zamindars, bigger tenants and landless peasantry, industrial interests as well as the lower castes and minorities (Srivastava 1976). Though the leadership of the Congress was drawn from the upper castes, particularly the Brahmins, its base and support structure were broader. As the party that had led the national movement and because of its secular image it could gain the support of the lower castes and the Muslims. A party of the ‘extremes,’ it had the support of the top and bottom of the caste/class hierarchy (Brass 1968). As a ruling party it mobilized the upper castes and landlords by dispensing patronage and used these leaders to mobilize the lower castes/classes.

Inequality in the polity was supported by ‘pervasive inequality and resilient conservatism’ (Drèze and Gazdar 1997: 101) and a slow-growing economy. The upper castes in UP, constituting as much as 20%–22% of the population, traditionally enjoyed both socioeconomic and political dominance. The BCs, consisting of about 40%–42% and the Scheduled Castes (SCs), over 22%, have historically been poor, oppressed, and marginalized. At Independence UP was characterized by low income and productivity levels, predominance of the agricultural sector, a low degree of urbanization, inadequately developed infrastructure, widespread illiteracy and low levels of investment. Per capita expenditure on education, health and other social resources remains among the lowest in the Indian states pushing it into a vicious circle of poverty and low investment (Singh 2001: 7–9). Successive governments have repeatedly failed to utilize its large human and natural resources properly. It remains one of the most backward states of the Indian Union; today it ranks among the bottom two states of the 17 major states in the country in most indicators of socioeconomic development (*ibid.*: 5).

Competing socio-political movements emerged, leading to the formation of three opposition parties: the Jan Sangh (JS) the Bhartiya Kranti Dal (BKD) and the Republican Party of India (RPI). Despite this the Congress retained its dominant position till 1989, but the mid-1960s was a period of weakness due to opposition-led coalition governments and the party began slowly but imperceptibly to decline. The only party in north India that did not emerge out of the Congress, the JS was a legacy of the Rashtriya Swayam Sevak Sangh (RSS), formed during the colonial period (Baxter 1969). Representing the Hindu conservative upper castes and trading community in the urban areas and rich landlords in the rural areas, it grew steadily, obtaining the support of the middle-class agriculturists and urban professionals, doubling its strength in every election (Srivastava 1976). By 1967 it looked as if UP was poised for a two-party system, but after the elections it declined and was relegated to third place, as the results of the 1969 and 1974 elections show. However, it retained its base, which enabled it to emerge as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in the early 1980s. A major reason was its failure to evolve into a stable political force and institutionalize its leadership.

Equally important was the challenge posed by the BKD, formed in 1967 by Charan Singh representing a rising new social force—the BCs against the upper castes for the first time in

north India, and the rich farmers from among the middle and BCs. The latter, according to the 1971 census, constituted approximately one-third of the landowning classes and controlled approximately 70% of the land and had been able to take advantage of the green revolution (Brass 1983). In fact, the mobilization of the prosperous peasants as a class was reinforced by their simultaneous mobilization as a status order—the BCs (Rudolph and Rudolph 1984: 322); however, the BKD/Bharatiya Lok Dal (BLD) developed a base only in western UP and pockets elsewhere because the impact of the green revolution remained limited to bigger farmers and some regions. It could not challenge the dominance of the Congress but it made agrarian interests central in UP politics up to the late 1980s, when it was replaced by identity politics (Pai 1993: 126).

The RPI, representing the SCs, was a legacy of Ambedkarite mobilization in parts of UP in the late colonial period, but it proved to be a flash phenomenon, performing well in the 1962 and 1967 assembly elections and then disappeared. The first SC party, it attempted to mobilize the working class and the lower castes. Its brief success in pockets in western and eastern UP was due to Congress weakness in the 1960s and an electoral alliance with some Muslim organizations. Starting from a limited social/regional base at a time when SCs lacked a clear self-identity, its leadership was divided over both ideology and strategies, leading to self-destructive factionalism that enabled the Congress to absorb it (Pai 2002: 76). However, it left a longer-term legacy in the form of ‘Ambedkarization,’ a multi-faceted process of social change among the Chamars in parts of western UP in which education and conversion to Buddhism—two Ambedkarite tenets—played a central role (ibid.: 196). Carried forward by a small, educated class, this process contributed to the emergence of Dalit assertion at the grassroots enabling the formation of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) in 1984. The left parties also had a strong base in eastern UP, where they took up issues of land distribution, but they failed to build support and class politics was replaced by identity-based politics in the 1980s.

New patterns of mobilization in the 1980 and 1990s¹

During the 1980s two seminal changes took place: the ongoing process of democratization underway since Independence in the Hindi heartland accelerated creating greater consciousness of caste and communal identities. Simultaneously, in many states of the region including UP, there was the ‘decay and collapse of the Congress system’ (Stone 1982: 1020). The Congress had been declining since the mid-1960s, but centralization/personalization of power by Indira Gandhi in the 1970s destroyed its local leadership, social base and organization. In the 1980s Rajiv Gandhi’s ambivalent stand on the Ram Janma Bhoomi Babri Masjid (RJBMM) issue provided space for religion-based mobilization by the BJP. The party had no BC/SC leaders when these identities became politically salient in the 1990s, losing their support, which it has failed to recover.

In the ensuing vacuum, three sectarian movements/parties arose in the 1990s: the Samajwadi Party (SP), BJP and BSP arising out of backward caste mobilization following acceptance of the Mandal Report by the V.P. Singh government; the decision by the BJP/RSS to counter this using religion-based mobilization based on the RJBMM dispute to mobilize upper-caste Hindus; and a strong wave of Dalit assertion. Consequently, during the decade caste/communal identities drove mass and electoral politics. It is important to understand that there is little direct correlation between caste and voting patterns in UP: not all sections of the upper, backward and lower castes vote for the BJP, SP and BSP, respectively. The social and regional bases of parties has shifted constantly since the early 1990s with only a core section remaining constant due to construction/reconstruction of caste and communal identities and alliances before/after elections leading to extreme fluidity in the party system. There was fierce competition between

caste- and religion-based identities and parties representing them, to obtain the support of different castes/communities and capture state power.

The BJP used the Rath Yatra (chariot expedition) and the RJBBM dispute—with the support of the Visva Hindu Parishad (VHP) and Bajrang Dal—to establish successfully its politics of Hindutva. This strategy aimed in the wake of Congress decline, to obtain the support of the upper castes and counter the rise of the backward castes due to Mandal. This underlies its meteoric rise until the mid-1990s, moving from 57 seats and 7% of the vote in the 1989 assembly elections to 221 seats and 33% of the vote in 1991, as Table 22.1 shows. The decline of the Nehruvian secular consensus and centrist politics and the essentially democratic and secular method of mobilization by political parties provided it with space. However, its success was not due to successful mobilization of the Hindu community on religious lines. It was the result of a *well-planned political mobilization using Hindutva*, which took advantage of the collapse of the Congress, the split in BC votes between the SP and the JD, and hostility to implementation of Mandal to create a massive Hindu vote bank across the state.

The SP and the BSP, in contrast, represented the rising backward and SC groups in the state questioning the privileged social and political position that the upper castes/classes historically have occupied. In fact, the spread of Hindutva politics was ‘contained’ in the 1993 elections by the SP and BSP, which briefly joined hands to try and establish a Bahujan Samaj. However, the two remain fierce rivals due to the adversarial positions in production relations in the countryside occupied by the groups they represent. The SP—a product of backward-caste mobilization since the mid-1960s, under the leadership of Mulayam Singh Yadav—attempted to mobilize the numerous, politically conscious and upwardly mobile other backward castes (OBCs). By steadfastly opposing the BJP’s Hindutva politics, the party has gained the support of a substantial section of the Muslims. It has a support base in all regions of the state, except the Jat areas of western UP. However, as the SP emerged out of the JD/Samajvadi Janata Party (SJP) as a party mainly of the Yadavs, sections of the backwards have been attracted towards the BJP and the BSP. Despite these fissures, the party has an impressive electoral record in both the assembly and Lok Sabha elections, as Table 22.1 shows.

As the Dalit movement arose late in north India, the BSP was formed by a post-independence, educated and politically conscious generation of Dalit leaders such as Kanshi Ram and Mayawati. However, Dalit assertion in UP is not the result of mobilization by the BSP; it was an upsurge

Table 22.1 Seats and votes gained by political parties in assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, 1989–2007

Parties	1989		1991		1993		1996		2002		2007	
	Seats	Votes	Seats	Votes	Seats	Votes	Seats	Votes	Seats	Votes	Seats	Votes
INC	94	27.90%	46	17.40%	28	15.00%	33	8.40%	25	9.00%	22	8.47%
BJP	57	11.60%	221	31.50%	178	32.50%	174	32.50%	88	20.10%	50	17.00%
JD	208	29.70%	92	18.80%	27	12.30%	7	2.60%	—	—	—	—
SJP/ SP	—	—	34	12.50%	109	17.90%	109	19.70%	143	25.33%	97	26.14%
BSP	13	9.40%	12	9.40%	69	11.30%	67	11.20%	98	23.20%	206	20.45%
CPI	6	1.60%	4	1.00%	3	0.70%	1	0.60%	NA	NA	0	0.09%
CPM	2	0.40%	1	0.30%	1	0.50%	1	0.50%	2	0.31%	0	0.30%
INDs.	5	3.90%	2	1.80%	2	2.30%	3	0.30%	31	17.40%	9	6.97%
Others	40	15.50%	7	7.40%	8	6.90%	9	6.10%	15	4.84%	19	21.58%

Source: Election Commission of India, Statistical Report on General Election, 2007, Legislative Assembly of Uttar Pradesh.

from below in the 1980s, harnessed by the party's leaders for political purposes. While the rise of the BSP has encouraged assertion, it remains a wider force for social change at the grassroots level, driven by the process of Ambedkarization. Undeniably, though, the BSP's creation of 'Dalit' identity and ideology of 'Ambedkarism' have provided Dalits with empowerment, self-respect and dignity which underlie its electoral success. As Table 22.1 shows, the BSP steadily increased its seat and vote share in assembly and parliamentary elections, apart from a regressive phase in the mid-1990s. It carved out a base for itself in mainly three regions: Bundelkhand, Eastern UP and Central UP and has captured power four times in the state since 1993, gaining a majority in the recent state assembly elections held in March–April 2007.

By the second half of the 1990s the centrality of primordial identities repeatedly used by parties began to wane, but importantly with differential impact on political parties. The BJP by the mid-1990s, particularly after the destruction of the Babri Masjid, began to face the electoral limitations of religious mobilization. The party introduced three new strategies: 'social engineering,' by which it tried to make Hindutva more inclusive and acceptable to the backwards and Dalits to gain their support; it supported the Mandal Commission recommendations; and projected itself as a 'responsible' national party, focusing on developmental issues to broaden its appeal. While the first two did not yield much success in UP, the last was not consistently used by the state unit. The UP unit remains divided over whether to moderate/abandon Hindutva, as it would lose its distinct ideology and social base. By the end of the decade the party faced electoral decline from which it has not recovered, as the results of the 2002 and 2007 assembly in Table 22.1 show. The Hindutva project failed because caste played a dominant role in containing religious mobilization due to opposition from the SP and BSP; the RSS-VHP-Bajrang Dal grew disillusioned with the failure to rebuild the Ram Temple and the party leadership failed to 'read the Hindu mind,' which did not respond positively after the early 1990s to religious mobilization (Gupta 2007: 110). However *saffronization* of society has continued through a variety of channels: Shishu Mandirs, text-books and grassroots mobilization of Dalits (ibid.).

The SP maintained its electoral performance in the late 1990s/early 2000s, but was overtaken and defeated by the BSP in the 2007 elections. An important reason is that despite strenuous efforts, it has not been able to homogenize and unite all sections of the backwards. While other parties have been able to mobilize sections of the backwards, more importantly 'BC' is a loosely constructed identity since the mid-1960s, consisting of the forward, lower and most backward sections with little common interest, held together by ambitious leaders. Throughout the 1990s class-based changes due to education and urbanization exacerbated the already existing divisions among the backwards, such as rural/urban, poor/affluent. Moreover, the leadership deviated from its socialist ideology, with a base among the more elite Yadavs it failed to capitalize on the democratizing potential of Mandal, to connect the backwards in different states, or to build a strong electoral base within UP even among the upper backwards due to regional differences in social stratification, production relations and power structures (Verma 2007: 183). Thus, despite a strong party such as the SP since the late 1990s, there has been a break-up of the BC bloc and emergence of a post-Mandal phase.

In contrast, the BSP established itself by the end of the decade as a strong party with a base among both the urban educated and rural poor among the Dalits and sections of the backwards. This upward graph has continued in the 2000s. Most of the BSP's programs, however, were aimed at political empowerment and political symbolism such as Ambedkar memorials and statues and Periyar Melas with no economic vision/agenda for *the actual uplift of the poorer Dalits*. Its success lay in its ability to reinvent itself and adopt strategies of electoral mobilization in response to the changing political scene in UP: a radical social movement hostile to *manuvad*

and the upper castes in the 1980s, an opportunistic political party that joined hands with the BJP to capture power in the mid-1990s, and a broad-based party of the Sarvajan attempting to gain the support of the Brahmins in more recent years. Consequently, it emerged a winner by keeping its base intact, taking advantage of the ideological and organizational disarray of the BJP, failure of the Congress to rebuild its organization and unraveling of the BC base of the SP.

Contemporary period: new directions

Since the early 2000s with the decline of primordial identities by the end of the 1990s, a new phase is visible in UP politics. Prior to the 2007 assembly elections all parties attempted to form broad, aggregative 'social rainbow' identities and based on them, new alignments to widen social bases (Pai 2007: 221). In fact, law and order, improved governance and inclusive development were central issues in the 2007 assembly elections.² A second feature was further decline in the seat and vote share of the BJP and the Congress—which has failed to revive its organization despite the strenuous efforts of Rahul Gandhi—evident in the results of the 2007 elections in Table 22.1. A bipolar situation emerged with the BSP and SP as the major contestants and after almost two decades a single party—the BSP—was able to gain a majority. However, while the BSP increased its vote share to a formidable 30.45% in the 2007 elections, absorbing the anti-SP vote, the latter obtained 25.34% of the votes, which is almost the same as in 2002 (Pai 2008).

The capture of power by the BSP in the 2007 assembly elections has strengthened the centrality of Dalit politics in UP. Its victory was due to its successful mobilization of the upper castes, particularly Brahmins, and shift from a Dalit to a Savarna party, similar to the erstwhile Brahmin-Dalit-Muslim combination that had enabled the Congress Party to rule UP. In that election, the SP could neither unite the BCs nor widen its base by obtaining the support of the upper castes. It was able to change this in 2012. However, the BSP faces two seminal challenges with significance for state and national politics: maintaining the Dalit-Brahmin-Muslim alliance through a more inclusive agenda of development, and second, replicating the experiment of 'social engineering' in other states to construct a pan-Indian identity and emerge as a key player at the central level (*ibid.*). Based on these strategies Mayawati hoped to win more seats in UP and some other states in the April–May 2009 Lok Sabha elections and become prime minister, heading the 'Third Front'—an inchoate medley of nine regional/state parties lacking organizational cohesion or common program, formed in March 2009 (Pai 2009). Her principal opponent, the SP, had moved closer to the Congress as both needed each other to avoid division of the votes, while the BJP had made an alliance with the Rashtriya Lok Dal in west UP headed by Ajit Singh. Thus, the Lok Sabha elections would determine the fortunes of all parties, particularly the BSP and the future contours of UP and national politics.

Conclusion

Our narrative of the changing political scene in UP shows that it was a politically backward, socially conservative state with a stagnant economy dominated by the Congress Party in the immediate Post-independence period. By the mid-1960s a series of movements led by the BCs, SCs and shifts in the agrarian hierarchy took place. UP also experienced the emergence of a right-wing, conservative party, the JS, which appealed to the educated upper castes/classes and trading community in the rural and urban areas. Although these movements could not successfully challenge the dominant position of the Congress, beneath the surface significant changes in society and polity were taking place, the impact of which was felt only in the 1980s and 1990s. Thus, state politics in UP can be understood in a framework of *continuity and change*. It was only after a long

process of democratization, accompanied by decline of the Congress system and after a modicum of economic development that new patterns of mobilization emerged, led by the lower castes/classes.

Yet, despite the continuity from the past, the 1990s represent a distinctly new phase in UP and national politics. During this phase UP became the epicenter of Indian democracy where many important struggles led by lower-caste parties challenged the position of the upper castes/classes and contributed to the *social deepening of an elitist democracy*. The rise and decline of Hindutva represented by the BJP reopened questions of secularism and position of minorities in Indian society, but at the same time as to *how democratizing these forces have been for the vast majority of subaltern lower castes/classes in the state and the country*. Despite mobilization based on identity and dignity, the actual benefits so far have accrued to a small, better-off section of the backwards and Dalits. The SP remains an elite party of the better-off Yadavs and failed to tap the democratizing potential of Mandal; it has little to offer to the most backward sections. The BSP is now a Sarvajan party that wants to work for development of all castes/classes and the state. Despite the decline of the BJP, saffronization of society and its impact continues on politics in UP and the country.

Our discussion raises the question of the direction of future change in UP. One possibility based on the problems that the state has faced since the early 1990s could be that UP is moving towards greater caste-based mobilization and fragmentation together with the communalization of politics. However, a more positive view is that this is a transitory phase in which some of the major issues that are central to the future of Indian democracy are being resolved in UP: a struggle between the upper and the lower castes/classes over whether India should be an exclusive Hindu or an inclusive pluralistic nation with increasing secularization of caste and communal politics over time; and whether the country should be an elitist or broad-based democracy, with adequate representation of the underprivileged and with a pattern of development in which the benefits are shared by all sections. This viewpoint is based on the trend that identity-based politics, which reached a high point in the mid-1990s, has begun to decline, leading to gradual secularization of caste and communal politics over time. The process will not be easy, will take time and involve considerable contestation and conflict.

Postscript

Political change in UP has been very rapid and in recent years two significant developments have taken place: the 2009 Lok Sabha elections in which new political equations have appeared, and second, a move towards more development-oriented politics, which was visible in the run-up to the state assembly elections due in May 2012. This does not mean that identity politics has disappeared; rather it is now used in combination with an agenda of growth for all sections, and not for the benefit of a particular social group as in the past. In the 2009 elections the Congress Party, perceived as being in deep decline in UP, obtained 21 seats, while the BJP could gain only one seat over 2004, the BSP's failure to improve over its earlier position of 19 seats was not commensurate with the hype that surrounded the party prior to the elections, and the SP slipped from a high of 35 to 25 seats, though it remained the party with the highest number of seats. More important was the reversal of the bipolar system that had emerged following the steep decline of both the national parties since 1998, with greater space being given to the SP and BSP. The 2009 elections split the votes and accorded the Congress greater centrality in UP politics for the first time since the 1980s, just as in national politics. These shifts have been attributed to the attempt by Rahul Gandhi to revive the Congress organization and base through a three-pronged effort: bringing in a younger generation of workers and leaders; adopting an agenda of rapid development; and rebuilding the base of the party among Dalits. The election campaign in UP

also revealed a more demanding electorate no longer satisfied with the identity politics of the past, with Dalits complaining about lack of roads and schools and employment in their villages.

In the campaign for the 2012 state assembly elections, which had already begun at time of writing and promised to be highly contentious, development and governance issues such as law and order and land acquisition after a long period were occupying a central position in UP politics. While this could be attributed to the agenda of Sarvajan of the BSP, it signaled the impact of the market economy and need to attract private investment, which had been late in the states of the Hindi heartland. It was also due to rising aspirations among the electorate for a share in the rapid economic growth over the last decade, consequently both the central and state governments—owing to a perception that higher growth has not reached the poorer sections—now need to emphasize on both growth and equity. Owing to these changes a new relationship is emerging in the Hindi heartland states between faster and more inclusive growth and electoral politics. In the 1990s when economic progress was not good, anti-incumbency was a trend; in the 2000s, with faster growth, economic performance of the incumbent government has become an important determinant of the way voters behave. Both the BSP government headed by Mayawati since 2007 and the JD government headed by Nitish Kumar since 2010, which have come to power on a winning caste combination and use of inclusive development programs for all social categories, provide good examples. While much publicity has been given by the media to Mayawati's statue-building spree, less attention has been given to her attempts at urban revival by improving the major metropolises and other cities in the state, with special emphasis on numerous projects for sewerage, garbage disposal, housing, and drinking-water facilities.

In the electoral campaign the ruling BSP and the Congress were in sharp confrontation over these issues. The SP and BJP, following their poor performance in the 2007 assembly elections, had not been able to rebuild their organization and base. For the Congress, improving its position in UP by building on its success in the 2009 national elections was imperative not only for the 2011 assembly election, but also for the national elections due in 2014. It is too early to say whether the massive mobilization attempt by the Congress under Rahul Gandhi can provide a challenge to the BSP. Organizational hurdles such as building strong local leadership and machinery across the state, internal elections, removing factionalism, finding winnable candidates with clean records have yet to be resolved. Despite the discourse on development, Dalit/OBC issues retain importance and Mayawati's grip over her Dalit-Bahujan constituency remains strong. Thus, the 1990s were a decade when primordial identities drove state politics. During the decade of the 2000s faster but socially inclusive growth, economic reform, greater participation and improved governance occupied center stage. It is too early to say whether this shift will depoliticize identity politics, but new political patterns are discernible in UP which are markedly different from those of the 1990s and have created space for a new kind of democratic politics the contours of which have not been fully understood or investigated.

Notes

1 Unless otherwise stated, this section draws upon Pai 2002.

2 See *Seminar* 2007, special issue on UP.

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23

KERALA IN COMPARATIVE PERSPECTIVE

Movements, politics, and democracy

Patrick Heller

Beyond exceptionalism

To a degree that is probably unmatched in any other democracy, India's states all have distinctive political configurations. Each state is marked 'by an ongoing contestation between the logic of democracy and the logic of domination' (Yadav and Palshikar 2011: 62). In each state these configurations underpin highly varied degrees of effective and substantive democracy. By effective I mean the capacity of citizens to effectively exercise their civil and political rights. By substantive democracy I mean the extent to which citizens can leverage democratic processes to secure material outcomes (Rueschemeyer *et al.* 1992). Following a long line of work in comparative politics and sociology, I argue that there is a strong and robust relationship between the extent to which subordinate actors are collectively organized and the degree to which democracy secures the conditions for an inclusive socioeconomic order. The quintessential cases are the Scandinavian social democracies, but this argument has also been extended to explaining successful cases of social democracy in the global periphery (Sandbrook *et al.* 2007). In India, a number of scholars have similarly drawn a link between specific political configurations in Indian states and substantive outcomes (Harriss 2003; Kohli 1987; Singh 2011). The causal chain that links political process to substantive outcomes is necessarily complex, especially given the range of political identities, sub-national cultures and actors that populate Indian states. More than anything the case of Kerala stands out because it highlights the conditions under which political processes can work in favor of subordinate groups. The causal chain at work, moreover, bears a strong analytical resemblance to the Scandinavian trajectory. That trajectory rests on the linking of three necessary and sufficient conditions.

First, the most salient electoral interests must coalesce around basic lower-class interests or fundamental claims to social rights. To the extent that such claims are relatively encompassing—be they underpinned by the ideological commitments of programmatic leftist parties or a strong culturally based sense of solidarity (Singh 2011)—they favor the provisioning of universal services and public goods. Given the euphemization of class interests that is intrinsic to politics (Herring in this volume), both orthodox Marxism and rational choice models (the median voter hypothesis) over-predict the salience of class politics. The class-based political formations that

long dominated European democracies are not only in decline, but have also rarely been replicated in third-wave democracies. The specific conditions under which the ideational and resource constraints to collective action faced by subordinate groups can be overcome are rare, but not insurmountable. As Herring (this volume) points out, elite interests are structurally organized through the implicit or explicit threat of withholding capital and do not need to be politically activated to be effective. Subordinate groups in contrast have no structural power and are entirely dependent on politics for the realization of their material interests. Awareness of class interests ('class consciousness' in the traditional vocabulary) or solidarity is not given, and must be politically constructed. Second, emerging interests must be aggregated and organized to be collectively effective. The political system as such is critical, both in terms of the institutional rules of electoral competition and the role and nature of political parties. Third, even if subordinate class interests are effectively articulated and represented through politics, securing interests requires a state that enjoys significant redistributive capacities. For states to have redistributive capacity they must overcome the structural dilemmas of transforming private gains into social investments and the organizational challenge of providing public goods.

As I have argued elsewhere,¹ Kerala can more or less be described as a case of social democracy, albeit one with the characteristics of social democracies in the global periphery. The causal explanation developed here mirrors the three conditions identified as the ideal-typical social democratic trajectory: subordinate group mobilization that congeals into well-defined class-based demands; the organizational efficacy of a programmatic party that aggregates these demands and secures electoral victories; the formation of a high-capacity state that can command the necessary resources (even in an extremely underdeveloped economy) and organize redistributive interventions. Within India, the case of Kerala is often treated as an exception, a case so unique that its comparative significance is dismissed. Setting aside the obvious problem of treating a political entity of some 31 million as an idiosyncratic case (all of Scandinavia has a smaller population), there are in fact three useful comparative points to be made. First, Kerala is an *exception of a general type*. If the mobilization of subordinate actors and the effective political translation of their material interests into state policies distinguishes Kerala from the rest of India, its pattern of socially inclusive democratic development is paralleled by other cases that are also exceptions within their own regions, notably Costa Rica, Mauritius, to a lesser degree Chile, and most recently and significantly, Brazil. Second, to treat Kerala as idiosyncratic or accidental is to obfuscate the very dynamics of change. Kerala was hardly much different from other Indian states at the time of Independence. Its social structure was highly diverse and unequal, its economy was poorly developed and dependent on commodity exports, and it was politically fractured. The divergence of its post-independence trajectory requires explanation, not exceptionalization. Third, if the full causal sequence of social mobilization, political contestation and state capacity is most apparent in Kerala, elements of the chain have purchase in other Indian states, albeit with degrees of difference. Early social mobilization has been identified as a general historical feature of south India that explains its departure from the north Indian pattern of upper-caste dominance. Patterns of political contestation, and in particular the formation of disciplined political parties, have been associated with more effective pro-poor policies (Kohli 1987). Harriss (2003) draws a direct connection between the extent to which lower castes/classes are represented in political regimes and the success of poverty reduction through social programs.

Categorizing Kerala

At first glance, the claim that Kerala approximates a social democracy seems counterintuitive. It is, first, a sub-national state, and does not enjoy the macroeconomic powers that have been the key

policy instruments of social-democratic pacts. The state in Kerala cannot control the flow of capital, protect its markets, collect income taxes, or adjust interest rates. Second, whereas social democracy is generally associated with industrialized (or industrializing) societies, Kerala remains a largely rural society, three-quarters of its population living in rural areas. The industrial working class, a key actor in the historical formation of European social democracy, remains small, albeit quite powerful. At a per capita income that even after two decades of robust growth has only just passed US\$1,000,² the material base for social democracy is thin at best. Finally, the dominant political party on the left—the Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI(M))—would most emphatically reject the social-democratic label.³ For all of these reasons, the typical class-institutional configuration of social democracy—a centrally managed class compromise between capital and labor—appears to be largely missing. If we distinguish social from liberal democracy in substantive terms by the extent to which the state proactively enables social citizenship, that is makes life chances a function of rights rather than social position or market conditions, and specifically secures basic capabilities, provides protection against market forces, and reduces inequality, then Kerala in many respects becomes a prototypical case of social democracy in the periphery—especially when contrasted with the rest of India.

On all the key social indicators, Kerala has dramatically outperformed all other Indian states and even compares favorably with developed countries.⁴ Literacy is 93% and life expectancy has reached 72 years.⁵ Between 1957/58 and 1990/91, of India's 15 most populous states (including the Punjab, Gujarat, and Haryana—India's market-led growth success stories), Kerala experienced the most rapid decline in poverty (Datt and Ravallion 1996). In 1973, with 59.2% of its population below the poverty line, Kerala was on par with Bihar (61.2%) and well above the all-India average of 54.8%. By 1999/2000, Kerala's population below the poverty line stood at 12.7%, the lowest of any major Indian state, and less than half of the all-India average of 26.1% (Government of Kerala 2010). The impact of social development in promoting basic capabilities is most dramatically captured in two indicators: in 2001 Kerala had the lowest incidence of working children of any Indian state, at 26,000 (Government of Kerala 2010), a stark contrast in particular to its southern neighbors of Tamil Nadu (418,000) and Karnataka (822,000); Kerala is the only state in India where women outnumber men.

Kerala's achievements in social development have earned it the status of a 'model' which has produced a cottage industry of sorts. Following Drèze and Sen's lead, Kerala has been identified as an exemplar of a capabilities-enhancing model of development and as 'development as freedom' (Oommen 2008; Kannan and Pillai 2004). While the emphasis on capabilities is descriptively useful, arguing that 'public action' (Drèze and Sen 1989) or the 'correct set of policies' or even 'good governance' has made the difference obscures the underlying structural and institutional transformations that have taken place and the extent to which these have been driven by political processes. Examining Kerala as a case of social democracy provides more comparative leverage and specifically redirects attention to the political and social contestation and the periods of intense mobilization and conflict that have underwritten the transformation in the balance of social forces in the state. Simply put, what distinguishes Kerala from other states in India but aligns it with other cases of social democracy is the extent to which subordinate classes have been effectively empowered and mobilized and have seen their interests institutionalized in the state. Democratic practices have penetrated deeply into social life, directly challenging traditional forms of social authority. Most notably, the upper-caste landlords who once ruled with absolute social and economic authority over Kerala have disappeared as a social class, and the caste system, while still an important source of identity, no longer directly maps onto political and economic power.⁶ If democracy means blocking the translation of social power into political power, then Kerala clearly stands out as a case of democratic transformation.

There are probably few examples in the Global South where the causal link between organized lower-class movements and significant redistributive and social gains is as strong as in Kerala. Repeated spells in power by the CPI(M), combined with repeated episodes of mass mobilization, have exerted unrelenting pressure on the state to expand social programs, regulate labor markets, and implement land reforms. Despite a two-decade period (1970–90) of virtual economic stagnation, social indicators have continued to climb and poverty rates have continued to fall. No other state in India has been as consistently pro-poor or as successfully redistributive.⁷ Large sectors of the working population enjoy a range of social protections, and basic services such as health, education, and food security are provided on a near-universal basis. Redistributive measures, in particular land reforms, labor-market regulation and the extension of social protection schemes, can all be tied to specific episodes of sustained mobilization (Herring 1983). In the post-liberalization era, social spending has begun to fall and some social programs have been adversely impacted by fiscal adjustments—most notably the public food distribution system—but no major redistributive reforms have been reversed. Overall in no other major Indian state has the market been so successfully subordinated to social regulation. This has not, moreover, undermined economic growth. Though Kerala's economy stagnated in the 1970s and 1980s, over the past two decades the growth rate has taken off, averaging slightly better than the national average. Much of this is driven by higher consumption fueled by remittances, but this itself has been interpreted as a return on Kerala's human capital investment, leading some commentators to point to a 'virtuous growth cycle' (Kannan 2005).⁸ Beyond consumption-driven growth there is, moreover, some evidence of productive dynamism. Historically high unemployment rates have been falling quite dramatically since 2003 (Zachariah and Rajan 2007), and between 1998 and 2005 Kerala enjoyed a rate of enterprise growth of 8.89%—the highest of any major state, and almost double the national average of 4.8% (Government of India 2006).

Finally, to describe Kerala as a case of social democracy underscores profound changes in state-society relations and highlights the dynamics of democratic deepening. Iterated cycles of state-society engagement, driven primarily by lower-class movements, have extended the infrastructural powers of the state and produced a rich set of rational-legal intermediate institutions. The infrastructural reach of the state is reflected in basic indicators. Some 94% of births in Kerala are attended by trained healthcare personnel (compared to 34% in India), and 91% of rural females between the ages of 10 and 14 attend school (compared to 42% in India). Only one in four females from Scheduled Castes (SCs) are literate in India, whereas three out of four in Kerala are. Though Kerala lacks the comprehensive peak-level corporatist bargaining structures that characterize European social democracy, it has developed an array of sectoral bargaining structures—industrial relations committees—which play a key role in mediating capital-labor relations (Heller 1999). These mediating structures have, moreover, penetrated deeply into the countryside, where minimum wages are enforced, working conditions are highly regulated and even mechanization is regulated to reduce labor displacement (Heller 1999). State institutions in the form of the most extensive network of cooperative rural banks in the country have crowded out traditional moneylenders while making banking services available to the poor and marginal farmers. In contrast to the general Indian picture, in which district- and village-level institutions are often in the hands of landed elites or dominant castes, in Kerala a wide range of institutions—including district councils, *Panchayats* (local governments), student councils, and cooperative societies—are hotly contested by political parties. Most significantly, Kerala has gone further than any Indian state in devolving resources and authority to local governments. The 'People's Campaign for Decentralized Planning,' launched in 1996, has not only created substantial forms of local government where none existed before, but has also institutionalized participatory

processes. Finally, in every business survey and on all relevant indicators, Kerala consistently ranks first among all states in the rule of law (Debroy *et al.* 2003). In sum, the writ of the modern state is deep and broad, as is its legitimacy. This point bears emphasis because it flies in the face of one of the most pervasive generalizations of comparative political science, namely that conflict in a heterogeneous society inevitably undermines not only institutions (Huntington and various ‘demand overload’ arguments) but also the effective provision of public goods (Rothstein and Uslaner 2005).

Kerala’s regime characteristics are all the more notable when profiled against the national picture. If in many states the traditional dominance of upper castes has been superseded by the rise of other backward castes (OBCs), Kerala and Tamil Nadu stand out as the only states where the lower castes have secured a share of power. Moreover, as Yadav and Palshikar (2011: 620) note in their review of state politics in India, ‘there are few signs of transition from a politics of presence to one of substantive representation of the demands, interests and needs of the hitherto excluded groups.’ Social programs have been driven more by patronage politics than by programmatic goals, few states have secured significant institutional reforms (such as effective implementation of Panchayati Raj), and vast swaths of the rural and urban poor have access to only limited public services. A dominant theme in the political science literature on India over the past two decades has been the fragmentation and de-institutionalization of political life (Kohli 1990). The rise of the Sangh Parivar and its anti-liberal, communalist program is only the most obvious manifestation of India’s democratic and social crisis (Hansen 1999). Despite massive organizational efforts, the Sangh has failed to secure a significant presence in Kerala, a rare political failure that Herring (this volume) attributes directly to the state’s success in making social services public goods.

If electoral democracy in Kerala has changed the balance of power and delivered, it has been transformative also. Beyond the consolidation of electoral institutions, democratization can be conceived more broadly as a shift in the relationship between the state and its citizens. Democratic deepening occurs when state-society relations are governed increasingly by rule-bound universal rights and less by connections ‘based on membership in categories based on imputed durable traits such as race, ethnicity, gender, or religion’ (Tilly 2004: 128). The extension of both public legality and public services in Kerala has eroded traditional forms of social authority and clientelistic dependencies. Across a wide range of social activities, from accessing primary health services and attending schools to depositing money in banking institutions, citizens have in effect shifted their trust from asymmetrical interpersonal networks to formal public institutions. Such a shift has not occurred in most of India and Chatterjee (2001: 8) argues that most inhabitants of India ‘are not proper members of civil society and are not regarded as such by the institutions of the state.’ The poor engage the state, but only through a highly instrumentalized logic of exchanging votes for concessions, a logic that reproduces the dependencies of clientelism. In contrast, civil society in Kerala has been differentiated from traditional social structures of control and citizens can and do practice their rights. This is critical in two respects. First, it implies that society itself—that is, the relations *between* citizens—to a significant degree has been democratized. Second, it points to the fact that individuals engage the state not as members of discrete communities but as rights-bearing citizens. This in turn explains two distinctive features of Kerala’s politics: (1) the extent to which the politics of social citizenship have commanded center stage; and (2) the relative absence of caste and sectarian violence that has gripped the rest of the country in the past two decades.⁹

A robust civil society has had a politically transformative effect not because it has promoted ‘public action’ or supported generalized trust as in social capital arguments, but rather because it has been critical to sustaining subordinate class organization. Kerala has the highest levels of unionization in India, and unlike the national pattern, the presence of unions is not limited to

the formal sector of the economy. Large numbers of workers in the informal sector—including in the beedi, construction, coir, and cashew industries—are organized. The largest union in the state is the CPI(M)-affiliated Kerala State Agricultural Workers Union (KSKTU), the 1 million-member union of lower-caste agricultural workers. Unions in Kerala are almost all tied to political parties, as well as being highly professionalized and characterized by a broader, less militant, and more programmatic outlook than most other Indian unions, which tend towards economism and are often little more than vehicles for local powerbrokers.¹⁰ Both the left and right political fronts in Kerala support mass organizations of women, students, and youth, and even if these organizations are often little more than extensions of political parties, they nonetheless help sustain lower-class organization. The state's network of worker cooperatives and village-level cooperative banks is the most extensive in the country. In the political arena, the basic cleavage has been along class lines, opposing a coalition of right-wing parties organized around the Congress against a coalition of left-wing parties organized around the CPI(M).¹¹ These two coalitions have more or less alternated in power; consistently thin margins of victory point to a relatively stable bipolar distribution of political support.

The effectiveness of Kerala's democratic institutions is marked by high levels of participation both in and between elections, but also in the extent to which they have managed social and economic tensions successfully. During the 1960s and 1970s rural protest was endemic and rates of industrial unrest (as measured in strikes) were the highest in India. Coalition governments were short lived and often brought down by large-scale mobilization. Kerala's social structure is, moreover, marked by significant cleavages. Historically, its caste system was amongst the most rigidly stratified in India, and it has the largest minority concentrations of Christians and Muslims of any Indian state (roughly 20% of the population each). The major caste and communal groups have powerful and active associations, and Christian and Muslim political parties have played active roles in Kerala's coalition politics. Yet, the capacity of the political system to manage these sources of conflict has defied predictions of demand overload. Labor militancy has been on a downward trend for 20 years, the zero-sum logic of caste and sectarian politics has largely been displaced by the positive-sum politics of class coordination, and the bulk of social and economic conflicts are effectively channeled into formal state institutions (Teitelbaum 2011; Heller 1999). As with the case of Mauritius (Sandbrook *et al.* 2007) and more recently Brazil, Kerala defies the assumption in the literature that diverse and historically fragmented societies are less likely to develop stable political orders and workable social compacts (Singh 2011).

The historical origins of the Kerala trajectory

In explaining why Kerala has traveled such a different path than the rest of the country, three historical developments are key. First, social justice movements that emerged in the nineteenth century scaled up into distributive movements in the twentieth century. Second, an ideologically cohesive and disciplined communist party fused nationalism, caste reform, and anti-landlord demands into a broad-based, lower-class coalition that was able to win elections—including the state's first elections in 1957—and initiate redistributive reforms. Third, these favorable initial circumstances for lower-class mobilization in turn gave birth to a virtuous, though often tumultuous, cycle of mobilization and state intervention that has driven democratic deepening.

The source of Kerala's nineteenth-century social justice movements can be located in the early commercialization of its agrarian economy. In what was otherwise one of the most rigidly hierarchical caste structures in India, the commercialization of agriculture created prosperous segments within all the major religious and caste communities (Tharakan 1998). These elites formed associations dedicated to the social reform and uplift of their communities, and invested

in community-based schools and hospitals. This general effervescence of civil society percolated downwards as untouchable Pulayas (whose status as slaves had only been revoked in 1855) organized to demand access to the public sphere, quite literally the right to travel public roads. By the 1920s, these community-based demands had evolved into full-blown socio-religious reform movements (Tharakan 1998) that were directly challenging Brahminical authority in what was an increasingly pluralistic and politically competitive public arena. These movements in turn directly fed into incipient distributive conflicts. In the south (Cochin and Travancore), large-holding farmers modernized and intensified agricultural operations, creating an agrarian proletariat that was quickly politicized (Varghese 1970: 128). In the larger context of the socio-religious movements, political radicalization specifically took the form of a communist-led union movement demanding both higher wages and social reform. In the north, Malabar, a parasitical Brahminical landlord class, found itself increasingly challenged by lower-caste and Muslim tenants who used openings in the political field (limited-franchise elections under the British) to demand tenancy reform in the 1930s. By the time of Independence, the agrarian structures of Malabar and Travancore/Cochin were ripe for social transformation. If in Malabar, the issue was land, and the movement opposed tenants to landlords, in Travancore/Cochin the issue was labor, opposing lower-caste field laborers to upper-caste and Christian capitalist farmers. If the classic class alliance of Scandinavian social democracy was a green-red alliance of smallholding farmers and an embryonic industrial working class, the class alliance in Kerala that undergirded the social-democratic path might be coded as *green-orange*: orange underscoring the fact that agricultural laborers were a protoproletariat.

Classes are not structural givens. They are, in Przeworski's (1985: 69) succinct formulation, 'formed in the course of struggles.' Those struggles take shape on multiple fronts and affect the process of class formation only inasmuch as they come to define new identities. The CPI emerged at the confluence of three distinct movements—the anti-colonial struggle, a caste-reform movement, and an agrarian movement—which brought together issues of sovereignty and democracy, identity and dignity, and exploitation and redistribution. Driven more by events and concrete struggles than theoretical insight, and acting more as a movement than a Party, the CPI (which was formed by disillusioned socialists from the Congress) built on existing repertoires of contention (strikes, petitions, marches, theatre, temple festivals) and wove together the themes of social dignity and justice of the caste reform movement, the demands for economic redress of the agrarian movement, and the democratic aspirations of the nationalist movement to form a coherent and sustained ideological attack against colonialism and the feudal class/caste structure. Desai (2001) has shown just how determinant the actual political practices of the Kerala communists were by drawing the comparison with colonial Bengal and the Bombay Presidency, the two other regions in India that had been the most fully integrated into the world economy. In both Bengal and the Bombay Presidency (now Maharashtra), communist parties in the 1940s did successfully organize industrial workers, but in both cases they embraced more orthodox Marxist politics and shied away from working with rural and caste movements. Not only did these communist parties fail to develop a mass base before Independence, but their narrow political base led them to the ultraleftist positions of rejecting the parliamentary route and resorting to insurrectionary tactics. Though the West Bengal CPI(M) would come to power in 1977 (20 years after the Kerala CPI) Kohli wryly observes that this electoral success came only after the West Bengal CPI(M) 'discovered' the peasantry in the late 1960s (Kohli 1987: 104).

With Independence, the state-society balance was further tipped in favor of mobilization. Electoral competition gave further impetus to class politics which in turn drove state building. The electoral victory of the CPI in the state's first elections marked a rupture with the logic of dominance. In a few short decades, the poor and property-less had gone from complete social and

economic subordination to political power. The 1957 government set into motion a series of reforms that, over the next two decades, would transform the face of Kerala's agrarian social structure. Well into the 1970s, the politics of class occupied center stage. Throughout, the conflicts between tenants and landlords, labor and capital, upper caste and lower caste, were acrimonious. The communist agenda was one of radical transformation, its methods those of large-scale agitation and labor militancy. Taking its cue from communist organizational successes, the Congress built its own mass organizations. Politics became synonymous with popular mobilization and Kerala often appeared to be teetering on the brink of ungovernability, with hyper-mobilization threatening to overload political institutions. In the political science literature of the time Kerala became widely known as the 'problem state.' Yet class conflicts did not result in breakdown or disintegration because they evolved within a framework of democratic rules-of-the-game marked by balanced electoral competition between right and left fronts. This in effect allowed class politics to congeal into a form of organized class compromise in which, following Gramsci, the dominant groups made 'concrete concessions' to subordinate groups without subverting capitalism. Agrarian reforms gave land rights to actual cultivators and provided social protection and regulated conditions of work to landless workers. Welfare reforms socialized access to primary goods without threatening private profits. Informal-sector workers secured collective bargaining rights. All of these reforms called for careful coordination of interests and greatly enhanced the state's macro and local institutional capacity, most notably exemplified by Kerala's sophisticated wage negotiation system for agricultural laborers (Heller 1999). Democracy as a general form of state-society relations was institutionalized.

One might be tempted to interpret Kerala's post-1957 trajectory in path-dependent terms: at a critical juncture (1957) a certain balance of forces was locked in to a specific set of institutions. However, this ignores the fundamental imbalance of class power between dominant interests that are *always organized* and subordinate interests that must be *politically mobilized*. Given that class interests and alignments constantly shift and must compete with other bases of mobilization, the sustained effectiveness of subordinate class politics has to be explained, all the more so because it necessarily challenges dominant interests. Clearly, much as Kohli has argued for the CPI(M) in West Bengal, a programmatic and disciplined political party has played a critical role in aggregating and sustaining lower-class interests. Highlighting the organizational capacity of a party captures only one side of the equation. In contrast to its 34 consecutive years in power in West Bengal, the CPI(M) in Kerala has only ruled intermittently, and never for two consecutive terms. The Kerala CPI(M)'s critical role has been less in its governance capacity than in its mobilizational capacity. Having found itself periodically in the opposition, the CPI(M) has retained much of the social movement dynamic from which it was born. As is true of most disciplined, hierarchical organizational structures, the party does have oligarchical tendencies, but competitive elections serve as an effective countervailing force, empowering the party's mobilizational wing. The party has as such had to reinvent itself routinely, both realigning its constituencies and changing its substantive focus.

Nowhere is this more evident than in the party's decision to champion the 'People's Campaign for Decentralized Planning,' launched in 1996. The Campaign has been widely recognized to be the most ambitious and successful effort of any Indian state to implement the spirit and the substance of the 1993 Panchayati Raj constitutional reforms. The Campaign not only effectively devolved 30% of the planning budget to Panchayats, but also instituted participatory structures that compare favorably to some of the best known international cases of participatory democracy (American Political Science Association 2011).¹² Explaining the genesis and roll-out of the campaign requires attention to the interplay of political and civil society (Heller 2009). First, the agency of the CPI(M) was critical. Democratic decentralization requires massive institutional

changes—literally a devolution of power downwards—that must necessarily come from above and must be sustained against entrenched bureaucratic and political opposition. Second, the CPI (M)’s rationale for pushing through decentralization was to address both the developmental and electoral limits of class politics. On the one hand, democratic decentralization was seen by the campaign’s architects not only as a means for breaking the hold of an inefficient and often corrupt line-department bureaucracy, but also as a means for encouraging new forms of local initiative and innovation. A strong, centralized, and interventionist state had secured high levels of social development, extensive public infrastructure, and basic institutional reforms. However, the second-generation social development challenges Kerala faced (the quality, rather than the quantity of public services) called for a fundamentally different mode of governance. The fiscal logic of the campaign is revealing: by reducing rents and leakage through greater accountability, more can be done within existing constraints (Heller 2005). On the other hand, the CPI(M) had to confront the limits of traditional left party politics. Much as is the case for social democratic parties across the world, the decline of a unified working class and the rise of new, organized social actors, including the women’s movement and environmentalism, has opened the door to a critique of bureaucratization (and more specifically in the Kerala context, of Leninism) and calls for greater openness to civil society. Third, the actual impetus for the campaign came from civil society. The logic and architecture of the campaign, including most importantly its participatory design, drew on years of experiments by community-based organizations (CBOs) and in particular the Kerala Sastra Sahitya Parishad (KSSP) in local participatory planning, watershed management, integrated farming systems, and health and educational reform. Key members of the KSSP played a direct role in shaping the program and were directly involved in the lead agency, the State Planning Board. The KSSP and other civil society organizations were instrumental in providing the mobilizational resources for the campaign, including massive capacity-building exercises that drew on upwards of 100,000 volunteer facilitators.

Conclusion

Kerala may be an exception among Indian states, but its divergence can be explained in terms of the well-tested arguments about social mobilization, political contestation and the building of state capacity. Reconstituting the case of Kerala as an *exception of a general type*—that is, as a form of social democracy in the periphery—holds a number of important lessons for scholars of Indian politics. First, at a time when party politics seems to be less capable than ever of addressing social and economic challenges, it is important to be reminded that politics can have transformative effects. Against the backdrop of extreme inequality and social heterogeneity, political processes in Kerala have made a substantive difference. Second, at a time when many have argued that civil society in India is little more than the privileged realm of the middle classes (Chatterjee 2004), the case of Kerala reminds us that we should not reduce civil society and the general principles of citizenship to a theoretical fiat (bourgeois society), but should rather locate civil society in actually existing historical and political configurations. Subordinate groups in Kerala have claimed and secured citizenship, and in the process have fundamentally transformed the relationship of the state to civil society. Explaining this outcome requires close attention to the ways in which social movements, party politics and state building have historically shaped each other.

Notes

- 1 Parts of this argument were first developed in a chapter I authored on Kerala in Sandbrook *et al.* 2007.
- 2 In 2007–08 state domestic product per capita was 51,980 rupees, or just above \$1,000. India’s as a whole was 39,903 rupees (Government of Kerala 2010).

- 3 Although the CPI(M) calls itself a Marxist-Leninist party its pragmatism has earned it the social-democratic label from many observers (Kohli 1987; Törnquist 1997; Desai 2001).
- 4 Kerala is quite literally two decades ahead of the rest of India. Of 15 major states, only four in 2001 had surpassed Kerala's Human Development Index (HDI) score of 1981 (Planning Commission 2001).
- 5 For the most recent analysis, which includes careful documentation in inter-state differences in social expenditures, see Singh (2011).
- 6 Some would challenge this statement, notably Devika (2010). No doubt caste inequities still matter, and there are some resilient pockets of exclusion, most notably Adivasis. However, in a comparative perspective, there is little doubt that historically marginalized groups have fared better in Kerala than elsewhere in India.
- 7 For the most explicit comparative assessments internationally see Drèze and Sen (1989). For comparisons across Indian states see Drèze and Sen (1995).
- 8 The most recent figures confirm this trend. Kerala's annual state domestic product growth in 2005–10 was 8.74%, slightly higher than the national average (Government of Kerala 2010).
- 9 Varshney (2002) provides a compelling account of how Kerala's civic organizations, by producing dense ties across caste and religious groups, have helped diffuse communal violence.
- 10 Drawing on a sample of 100 factories, Teitelbaum (2011) found not only that unions in Kerala were far more likely to be tied to parties than those in Maharashtra but also that political unions (as opposed to what he terms 'parochial unions') are more likely to eschew conflict in favor of long-term cooperation.
- 11 Survey data from the Centre for the Study of Developing Society for the 2004 Lok Sabha elections show that the Left Democratic Front (LDF) was supported by the 'poorer classes, the less educated and the relatively disadvantaged sections of society' (*The Hindu*, May 20, 2004: AE-3). Though the LDF did get most of the Dalit vote (71%), the fact that it got less than half the OBC vote, and only 59% of the Ezhava vote (the traditional core constituency of the CPI(M)) suggests that caste has lost much of its political saliency.
- 12 A wide body of research confirms that the Campaign has put down deep roots, and has significantly increased the accountability of local government (Thomas Isaac and Franke 2002; Heller *et al.* 2007; Mannathukkaren 2010; Venugopal and Yilimaz 2009).

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TAMIL NADU

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Gopal Krishna Gokhale, an early member of Congress and opponent of British imperial rule, once said that what Bengal thinks today, India thinks tomorrow. In the realm of politics, Gokhale's well-known claim is perhaps better applied today to the state of Tamil Nadu, where many of the most important trends in contemporary Indian politics have long been evident. Although Tamil Nadu is at the forefront of a number of political trends, the state's politics has nevertheless retained a distinct flavor that differentiates it from other states in India. This chapter begins by focusing on two unique aspects of Tamil politics. The first is the Dravidian movement, a social movement the ideology of which, Dravidianism, has lastingly shaped Tamil Nadu's political culture and discourse. The second is populism, a political strategy pioneered by parties representing the legacy of the Dravidian movement. From there, the chapter moves on to address several phenomena that long have been central to Tamil politics but only more recently have come to characterize India as a whole: the success of regional political parties, the importance of alliance politics, and the extensive use of caste-based reservations.

The Dravidian movement

One of the most defining features of Tamil politics is the Dravidian movement, a complex social and political movement combining ideas related to caste, religion, and linguistic nationalism. The term Dravidian refers to the language family that comprises the major languages spoken in south India. The term has also been used, particularly within the Dravidian movement, to refer to a racial/ethnic group largely coterminous with speakers of Dravidian languages. In spite of a name that invokes the entirety of south India, the Dravidian movement historically has been confined mainly to Tamil Nadu.

The earliest traces of the modern Dravidian movement can be found in non-Brahminism, which was a movement to protest against the dominance of Brahmins in public life and modern colonial institutions. Associations promoting non-Brahminism began to emerge in the first decades of the twentieth century. One such organization was the Justice Party, officially known as the South Indian Liberal Federation, which was organized over the course of 1916 and 1917 by elite non-Brahmin upper castes whose main concern was breaking the Brahmin stranglehold on positions in the colonial civil service. The Justice Party held power in the Madras Presidency throughout much of the 1920s and 1930s.¹ Another organization advocating non-Brahminism

was the Self-Respect Association, founded in 1925 by E.V. Ramaswami Naicker, also known as Periyar. Periyar eventually merged the Self-Respect Association into the Justice Party and oversaw the transformation of the elite-dominated Justice Party into the more mass-based Dravidar Kazhagam (DK).

Periyar's version of non-Brahminism was a far cry from the limited demands of the Justice Party for non-Brahmin reservation in the civil service. Periyar identified Tamil Brahmins as cultural outsiders who brought with them from north India a Brahminical form of Hinduism that oppressed the non-Brahmin majority.² In so doing, Periyar and other early ideologues in the Dravidian movement fused non-Brahminism with the two other crucial components of Dravidian ideology: atheism and linguistic nationalism.

Atheism was the Dravidianist response to the humiliations that Brahminical Hinduism visited upon the lower castes. As part of their rejection of Hinduism, activists in the Dravidian movement publicly destroyed statues of Hindu deities and held 'self-respect marriages' that eschewed Hindu wedding rituals. Although atheism was a prominent strain in the early Dravidian movement and many contemporary leaders who cast themselves as heirs to this movement remain staunch atheists, this aspect of Dravidianism never gained wide acceptance in Tamil Nadu.

By contrast, the mingling of linguistic pride with the non-Brahmin critique has had a lasting impact on Tamil politics. The Dravidian movement conflated Tamil Brahmins and north Indians, treating them as common enemies of an ancient and glorious Tamil culture and language. The major political party propounding Dravidianist ideas throughout the 1950s and 1960s, the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), portrayed itself as the defender of Tamil interests and language. During this time, the DMK routinely portrayed Tamil Nadu as having been victimized by a central government dominated by north Indian interests. In spite of relatively scant evidence in support of this claim, in the late 1950s and early 1960s, the DMK went so far as to openly advocate for Dravida Nadu, an independent south India. Although the Dravida Nadu demand remained part of the DMK's platform until 1963, much of the party's leadership had many years earlier written off the demand as impractical (Barnett 1976: chapters 5 and 6).

The DMK characterized its main opponent at the time, Congress, as a party dominated by north Indian Brahmins bent on imposing Hindi on an unwilling population.³ At various junctures, the Congress-led government indeed attempted to establish Hindi as a national lingua franca to be used in government and taught in schools. Such attempts met with considerable opposition in Tamil Nadu from the late 1950s through the mid-1960s. When, in early 1965, Hindi officially replaced English as the national language, massive protests erupted in Tamil Nadu and eventually turned violent. After two weeks of agitation that escalated from protests and strikes into riots, the central government abandoned the attempt to impose Hindi and promised to retain English as a medium of communication in government. Aside from its role in spearheading agitations, the DMK also appears to have spurred increased electoral participation. Across the board, turnout in state elections increased substantially in the 1960s to above 70%, and constituencies where the DMK had contested several times appear to have experienced higher turnout than those where its electoral participation was more recent (Barnett 1976: 140–45).

On the one hand, Dravidianism has become a common idiom that has now permeated Tamil politics for several decades. With the rise of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK)⁴ as the DMK's main rival in the 1970s, both of Tamil Nadu's major political parties have been self-described heirs to the Dravidianist legacy. Parties with followings across India—namely Congress, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), and the two main communist parties—that never embraced the Dravidian movement have, since the early 1980s, won no more than a quarter of the vote, and often much less. Meanwhile, parties invoking the names, symbols, and ideas of the Dravidian movement have typically won between two-thirds and three-quarters of the

vote. Indeed, the adoption of a highly assertive pro-Tamil rhetoric characteristic of the Dravidian movement is now one way through which political elites seek to move their parties into the mainstream. For example, in the mid- and late 2000s, two small caste-based political parties, the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) and Viduthalai Ciruthaigal Katchi (VCK) began to drop their caste-based messages in favor of Tamil nationalist appeals that included support for the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), the Tamil insurgent group in Sri Lanka. The legacy of the Dravidian movement can also be seen in the relative marginality of Brahmins in the Tamil political class, the extensive use of caste-based reservations, and the broad support for Tamil nationalism. According to the 2004 Indian National Election Study, more than 90% of respondents in Tamil Nadu agreed with the statement that people should be loyal to their region before their country—more than in any other major state in India.

At the same time, the effect of the Dravidian movement should not be overstated. Dravidianist parties have governed Tamil Nadu since 1967, but no state government has made serious attempts to increase autonomy for the state. On the contrary, the DMK and AIADMK have happily engaged in electoral cooperation with Congress and the BJP, India's two major national parties. Although Dravidianism objects to the Hindu caste system, most of the Dravidian parties have—either openly or more quietly—exploited caste for political ends, and caste remains salient in both the social and political spheres. Moreover, the marginalization of Brahmins in politics and the extensive use of reservation are common throughout south India, even though other south Indian states did not experience anything comparable to the Dravidian movement.

Although regional parties now dominate Tamil politics, the precise link between Tamil nationalism and the rise of regional parties has never been well established. In the 1967 state election, following the widespread protests against the imposition of Hindi and the DMK's unprecedented move to politicize Tamil identity, Congress' vote share declined by only a modest 5%, and voting for the DMK and Congress was arguably driven more by caste concerns than by Tamil nationalism (Chandra 2004: 275–81). More recently, voters for national parties were, based on the 2004 data from the Indian National Election Study, just as likely to profess loyalty to their region ahead of their country as those who voted for Dravidian parties. Thus, the link between Tamil nationalism and mass political behavior has never been conclusively shown. Rather than Tamil nationalism leading to the rise of Dravidianist parties, it may be that the rise of the Dravidianist parties went a long way in inculcating a strong sense of Tamil nationalism among voters. In short, though the language of the Dravidian movement has become hegemonic in Tamil Nadu and has created a distinct political culture, the Dravidian movement's impact on real political outcomes appears to have been far less sweeping.

Populism

Aside from the Dravidian movement, another uncommon feature of Tamil politics is populism, the strategy of appealing to the 'people,' or the masses, against the elite. This political strategy is relatively underdeveloped elsewhere in India as compared to Tamil Nadu, where it originated with the Dravidian movement's early leaders who exhorted the Tamil masses to oppose the political power of the 'foreign' Brahmin elite. Over the course of the past 40 years, the two main Dravidian parties have pioneered distinct forms of populism (Subramanian 1999). On the one hand, the DMK's populism has been more assertive in nature. It has appealed to society's intermediate strata—backward castes, small farmers, and shopkeepers—to claim entitlements that would help them break the dominance of the traditional elite. On the other hand, the AIADMK's populism has been more paternalistic, involving a benevolent leader who protects the people and looks after their interests. Its appeals have resonated more strongly with the poor and

marginalized. These distinct brands of populism have implied different strategies for wooing voters. Whereas the DMK's main achievement for years was 'the provision of quotas for intermediate castes in education and governments jobs ... the ADMK's most significant welfare scheme was the provision of free lunches for all public school children' (Subramanian 1999: 76).

Together, the populist strategies of the state's two main parties have contributed to an array of progressive social policies that have made Tamil Nadu a leader in levels of human development within India. The DMK and AIADMK manifestos to this day continue to include promises of a litany of subsidies targeted at various populations (e.g. fisherman, farmers, school children). While these pledges are undoubtedly aimed at shoring up electoral support, many of them embody common elements of well-developed welfare states: maternity assistance, subsidized public transportation, and educational grants. However, in the 2000s, Tamil populism took something of a new turn, with the parties increasingly competing over the distribution of consumer goods. During its 2001–06 term in office, the AIADMK distributed free bicycles to students in Classes 11 and 12. In the 2006 election, the DMK upped the ante by promising to distribute free color TVs for those who did not already own one, allegedly for the sake of increasing general knowledge among women, many of whom are largely confined to the home. In 2011 the party announced a pledge to give free laptops to specified groups of college students and a mixie or grinder (both kitchen implements) to all women. The AIADMK's rejoinder in its manifesto was to promise free laptops to students in Class 11 and beyond as well as a mixie, grinder, and fan to all women.

Somewhat surprisingly, parties across India do not make a habit of using campaign manifestos to promise a laundry list of populist measures. Although populist pledges are not unknown in the rest of India—promises to offer free electricity or loan waivers to farmers are not uncommon—more often, parties campaign on vague pledges of development, improving infrastructure, law and order, and clean administration. Tamil Nadu's long history of populism marks another unique aspect of the state's politics.

Regional political parties

In the 1990s, regional political parties gained prominence in India's national politics, and they became increasingly important players in many Indian states. Though the importance of regional parties was a new phenomenon in many states, this was not the case in Tamil Nadu. No major state in India has been dominated by regional parties as thoroughly and for as long as Tamil Nadu. Regional parties have governed the state from 1967 until the present, a record unparalleled anywhere else in India. Since the late 1970s, Tamil Nadu's two main parties have both been regional parties.

The DMK was Tamil Nadu's first major regional party. C.N. Annadurai, Periyar's right-hand man, founded the party in 1949. Annadurai left the DK bent on creating a more modern organization aimed at electoral participation in addition to social change. The DMK first contested state elections in 1957. Over the next decade, it more than tripled its vote share from 13% in 1957 to 41% in 1967, eventually dominating the non-Congress political space. From the beginning, the DMK enjoyed two principal advantages over Congress and the other national parties with which it competed. First, the DMK was well organized. It established a cadre of party workers who engaged directly with the public rather than relying on the caché of local notables. The DMK was known especially for its cultural engagement, establishing literary journals, performing street plays, and using cinema as a medium for furthering political messages. Second, numerically small upper castes did not dominate the party's leadership. Instead, most of its political leaders were drawn from the middle castes at which the party aimed its appeals.

By 1967, when the DMK first came to power, it had effectively sidelined other opposition parties, creating a two-party system in which it and Congress were the main competitors. In 1972 a

new regional party emerged. The massively popular film star and politician M.G. Ramachandran (known as MGR) was expelled from the DMK after a power struggle between MGR and party leader M. Karunanidhi. MGR later established the AIADMK. Building on an extensive network of fan clubs devoted to MGR, the party quickly established itself as a major force in Tamil Nadu. In the first state elections that it contested, in 1977, the AIADMK won power in a quadrangular contest against the DMK, Congress, and the Janata Party. Since then, the DMK and AIADMK have been the state's two major poles around which politics has revolved. The AIADMK held state-level power from 1977 until 1989, which was the first election held after MGR's death. From 1989 onward, the DMK and AIADMK have alternated in power, neither capable of winning two successive elections.

Beginning in the late 1980s and early 1990s, a new wave of smaller regional parties began to emerge. Though none of them have challenged the AIADMK or DMK for a spot as one of the state's two leading parties, these new formations have significantly eroded the support bases of the major parties and entrenched themselves in the party system. Of these, three have been particularly important. First, the aforementioned PMK was founded in 1989 as the political wing of a caste association, the Vanniyar Sangham. The party agitated for the creation of a new reservation category of Most Backward Castes and inclusion of the Vanniyar caste in that category. Since its inception, the PMK has attempted to broaden its support base beyond Vanniyars, but with very limited success. Second, the Marumalarchi Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (MDMK) was founded by former DMK leader, Vaiko. Vaiko had protested against dynasticism within the DMK—namely, the growing role of M.K. Stalin, son of M. Karunanidhi. Having been expelled from the party, Vaiko founded the MDMK. Though the MDMK has always explicitly eschewed caste-based appeals, focusing instead on themes of Tamil nationalism, the party draws considerable support from Telugu Naickers, the caste to which Vaiko belongs. Third, the Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) is the newest regional party of note. Whereas the PMK and MDMK routinely win approximately 4%–5% of the vote, the DMDK has won closer to 10% since its founding in 2005, threatening to displace Congress as the state's third-largest party. The party's founder is Vijayakanth, a film star.

Aside from these three parties, Tamil Nadu has several other regional parties, many of them caste based. For example, the VCK and Puthiya Tamizhagam (PT) draw support from Scheduled Castes (SCs) in the northern and southern portions of the state, respectively. Most other caste-based parties have tended to be relatively short lived. In addition, Congress has occasionally suffered splits that have produced regional parties. One example in the 1980s was the Gandhi Kamaraj Congress. More recently and more notably, in 1996, most of the Tamil Nadu unit of Congress quit the party over its decision to ally with the AIADMK in elections. Those who left the party established the Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar) (TMC) under the leadership of G.K. Moopanar. After Moopanar's death in 2002 the TMC merged back into Congress. In the intervening years, Congress was reduced to a virtual non-entity in the state.

A feature common to Tamil regional parties and their counterparts elsewhere in India is a penchant for personalism, a trend evident in Tamil Nadu long before it became common elsewhere in India. Although the DMK was founded with strong ideological moorings, it was closely associated with its founder Annadurai and then his successor, M. Karunanidhi. Today, an increasingly common charge levied against the party is that it functions as a family business for Karunanidhi; members of his immediate and extended family now occupy many of the party's most important posts. The AIADMK's founding was a somewhat clearer expression of personalism. MGR effectively parlayed his film persona as a savior of the poor and downtrodden into a political appeal to the marginalized (Pandian 1992). MGR's successor, another former film star, J. Jayalalithaa, has ruthlessly centralized power in her own hands. The smaller regional

parties are also inextricably identified with their leaders—PMK's Dr. Ramadoss, MDMK's Vaiko, DMDK's Vijayakanth, VCK's Thirumavalavan, and PT's Krishnaswamy.

One way in which Tamil regional parties differ from many other regional parties in India is in their emphasis on Tamil identity. With the exception of the Congress splinters, at a minimum most regional parties in Tamil Nadu pay lip service to Tamil nationalism and the leading lights of the Dravidian movement, such as Periyar and C.N. Annadurai. Furthermore, in some cases, such as with the MDMK, issues of regional identity and demands for autonomy constitute core parts of the parties' rhetoric. As a consequence of their emphasis on Tamil identity, regional parties in Tamil Nadu confine their contestation to Tamil Nadu and the tiny Union territory of Puducherry, which has a Tamil majority.⁵ Many other regional parties in India, and particularly those that have emerged in the last 20 years, do not similarly limit their contestation to single state or make regional identities or issues central components of their electoral appeals.

Given the emphasis of most Tamil regional parties on Tamil identity, one potential interpretation of the evolution of the state's party system would suggest that the dominance of regional parties in Tamil Nadu is a product of the resonance of Tamil nationalist appeals. Such an account vastly oversimplifies the state's electoral history and understates the importance of national parties' strategic blunders. Congress, in particular, helped pave the way for regional party dominance by willingly adopting a subordinate position to the Dravidian parties. In 1969 Congress split at the national level into Congress (O) and Congress (R). The former was stronger in Tamil Nadu than almost anywhere else, and the latter faction, led by Indira Gandhi, was quite weak. In 1971, Congress (R) opted not to contest state elections as part of its alliance with the DMK, leaving only the Congress (O) faction to compete. In 1977 Congress (which was the renamed Congress (R) faction) and the Janata Party, which was essentially a renamed version of Congress (O), together won 34% of the vote—greater than either the DMK or AIADMK. Bearing in mind that many Janata Party leaders rejoined Congress in the late 1970s and 1980s, Congress could have reasonably hoped to compete on roughly equal terms with the DMK and AIADMK.

Throughout the 1980s and 1990s, however, Congress did not opt to compete with the Dravidian parties for a dominant position in the state, choosing instead to become a junior partner to either the AIADMK or DMK. As a consequence, Congress effectively has abandoned any serious attempt to come to power. In many assembly constituencies, the party has gone long periods of time without contesting elections. As a consequence, the party's base has gradually shrunk, leaving the AIADMK and DMK in increasingly advantageous positions. More recently, India's other main national party, the BJP, has failed to break into the Tamil party system. It has not, to date, diversified the caste base of its top leadership and shed its image as a Brahmin party. Nor has the BJP cultivated a class of mass leaders or a base among one of the state's major caste groups as it has in neighboring Karnataka, where it has rapidly expanded its support base from almost nothing to being one of the largest parties in the state.

Although the strength of Tamil nationalism has undoubtedly helped the cause of regional parties in Tamil Nadu, national parties elsewhere have accommodated regional nationalism with some success. The dominance of regional parties in Tamil Nadu should not be seen as the ineluctable outcome of Tamil nationalism or Dravidianist ideas. Rather, much of the credit for the success of regional parties in Tamil Nadu lies with national parties and the opportunities they have provided to regional parties.

Alliance politics

Since the late 1980s, negotiating pre-election alliances has been a common practice in national elections. Although India's national party system has fragmented considerably over the past

20 years, national elections typically feature two or three major electoral fronts. The same is true in Tamil Nadu. Even as the Tamil party system has become increasingly fragmented since the early 1990s, the state has retained a bi-frontal party system in which two major electoral fronts, each comprising multiple parties, compete against one another and monopolize the overwhelming majority of votes. Such a bi-frontal party system has been a common feature of Tamil politics since 1967.

In India, the main purpose of electoral fronts is to arrive at seat-sharing agreements. Seat-sharing agreements occur when parties coordinate so as to field a single candidate from the electoral front in each constituency, thereby avoiding a division of the vote among the various partners in the alliance. As early as the 1950s, parties across India brokered electoral alliances with each other in efforts to dislodge Congress from power. Parties in states outside of Tamil Nadu have brokered election alliances too, but the consistency with which they have occurred in Tamil Nadu is somewhat unusual. Even more unusual is that election alliances in Tamil Nadu combine frequency and comprehensiveness along with fluidity.

Since 1967, all but two elections have featured comprehensive electoral alliances that have included all major parties in one of two major fronts. Since 1980, those fronts have been led by the AIADMK and DMK, except in 1989 when the bi-frontal system broke down. Nevertheless, the composition of electoral fronts is extremely fluid. Almost all of the state's smaller parties have been, at various times, allies of both the AIADMK and DMK, sometimes switching between them numerous times. This fluidity stands in stark contrast to the leftist electoral fronts in Kerala and West Bengal which have had significantly more stable memberships.

Because the alliances that the main parties cobble together differ dramatically from one election to the next, election outcomes depend crucially on alliances. More often than not, election outcomes can be predicted based on alliance arithmetic, by simply adding up estimates of the alliance partners' support bases. Because of India's single-member district system, parties (or electoral alliances) that enjoy a consistent electoral advantage across seats can win huge legislative majorities. Election outcomes in Tamil Nadu are often described as waves because one of the fronts sweeps to power and decimates its opponent. These waves occur precisely when one side enjoys a distinct advantage in alliance arithmetic over its rival. As a result of these sweeping victories, even though the AIADMK and DMK have usually contested in alliance with a number of other parties, the largest party in the winning alliance almost always wins a legislative majority on its own. Consequently, in spite of Tamil Nadu's highly fragmented party system, the state has never had a coalition government.⁶ The winning party has always opted to govern alone, meaning that pre-election alliances have not translated into governing coalitions.

Reservation

Perhaps nowhere has Tamil Nadu better anticipated national trends than in the realm of reservation. Reservation was one of the first major issues animating political competition in Tamil Nadu, ever since the Justice Party first demanded reservation for non-Brahmins in the early twentieth century. By the early 1920s, the colonial government had granted non-Brahmin reservation in the colonial civil service in the Madras Presidency, the benefits of which went largely to the forward non-Brahmin castes. Shortly after Independence, reservations for SCs and Scheduled Tribes (STs) were implemented throughout the country. In Tamil Nadu, an additional 25% reservation was set aside for the backward castes, also known as the other backward classes (or castes, OBCs). That figure was raised in 1971 to 31%. By 1980, in addition to an

18% reservation for SCs and 1% for STs, 50% of government jobs and places in government-run institutions of higher education were reserved for OBCs, bringing the total reservation to 69%. Although the Supreme Court ruled in 1992 in *Indira Sawhney and Ors vs. Union of India* that reservation could not exceed 50%, the state of Tamil Nadu has made no move to lower its reservation quota.

In 1989 a new chapter in the reservation debate began with the Vanniyar Sangham's agitations for the creation of a special reservation category for Vanniyars. The Vanniyar Sangham claimed that Vanniyars were disadvantaged among the OBCs and therefore failed to benefit from reservation since the better-off OBC castes were cornering most of the reservation benefits. In response to their agitations, the DMK government split the OBC quota into two, reducing the OBC quota to 30% and introducing a new group called most backward castes (MBCs), with a quota of 20%. The Vanniyars were then classified as MBCs. Since then, many other castes have clamored to be reclassified as MBC instead of OBC in the hopes of increasing their community's access to reservation benefits. Similar wrangling has gone on elsewhere in India, with castes either clamoring to be moved into reservation categories intended for more economically deprived communities, or agitating against the reclassification of other castes which they fear might monopolize benefits in the quota.

The agitation for the creation of an MBC quota occurred at roughly the same time as the controversy surrounding the implementation of OBC quotas for central government jobs. Whereas north India was convulsed by protest in the early 1990s over the extension of OBC quotas in jobs and again in the mid-2000s with the extension of quotas to central educational institutions, these events were met with little opposition in Tamil Nadu, where extensive OBC reservation was already the norm. Given Tamil Nadu's long history of reservation and its relative economic prosperity within India, Tamil Nadu has been invoked as a counter-example to anti-reservationists' arguments about the negative consequences of reservation's alleged failure to reward 'merit' in the allocation of jobs and access to education.

This chapter has focused on several of the ways in which politics in Tamil Nadu has anticipated wider trends in Indian politics. The state has led the way in producing highly successful regional parties, perfecting the use of electoral alliances, and implementing extensive reservation. In other ways, politics in Tamil Nadu has remained distinct. The ways in which Dravidian ideology has permeated political discourse in the state and the frequent use of populist election promises continue to lend a distinctive flair to politics in Tamil Nadu.

Notes

- 1 During the colonial period, contemporary Tamil Nadu was part of the Madras Presidency, which also included parts of today's Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, and Kerala. At Independence, the Madras Presidency became the state of Madras. In the 1956 states reorganization, the state of Madras was reduced to Tamil Nadu's current borders, but the name Tamil Nadu was not adopted until 1969.
- 2 The usual estimate of the Brahmin population in Tamil Nadu is approximately 2%–3%.
- 3 Responding to the rise of the Justice Party in the 1920s and 1930s, Congress in Tamil Nadu went to great lengths to diversify its ranks and promote non-Brahmin leaders. By the late 1950s, the leading figure in the Tamil Nadu Congress was K. Kamaraj, a Nadar (a backward caste). In many states outside of Tamil Nadu, Brahmins retained a pre-eminent position within Congress.
- 4 The party was originally founded as the ADMK. 'All India' was added later. The party's name is often still abbreviated as ADMK.
- 5 Puducherry comprises four non-contiguous enclaves. The two largest, which account for more than 90% of the population, are entirely surrounded by Tamil Nadu.
- 6 In the 2006 state election, the DMK failed to win a majority on its own, but it governed as a minority government until 2011 when its term expired.

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WEST BENGAL

Manali Desai

West Bengal has drawn special scholarly recognition in the study of Indian politics because it has been ruled by one of the longest-running democratically elected communist governments in the world since the 1970s. Arguably Bengal defies the general decline in the electoral viability of left parties, the breakdown of socialism and socialist experiments, and the purported decline of class politics across the globe. In India while Congress hegemony has faced strong challenges from the Hindu right and caste parties since the 1980s, Bengal with its unchallenged left party dominance, absence of high party turnover and the absence of a challenge from caste or regional identitarian parties appears highly distinctive and anomalous. Not least, despite its violent communal history before and after the partition of the state in 1946–47 which resulted in a massive refugee crisis, communalism and the political ascendancy of the Hindu right have found little fertile ground in the state. The stability of rule by the Communist Party of India (Marxist) or CPI(M) over a population of 80 million thus places Bengal among the paradigmatic, if controversial, cases of reformist left experiments.

The state of West Bengal was formed in 1947 after the Partition of India brutally split Bengal into two parts: East (later known as Bangladesh) and West. After a series of communal riots, West Bengal became the site of an unprecedented flow of Hindu migrants from the eastern part, many leaving landed property behind. This deracinated and ‘declassed’ former landed elite formed the crux of the communist movement which has since dominated politics in West Bengal. Mostly confined to government employment, this class of *bhadralok* (gentlemen) found in communism a representational ideology for their newly found and downwardly mobile social location beneath the established landed gentry. In addition, many refugees worked in higher-skilled jobs in the newer industries and formed part of the industrial workforce that supported communism (Zagoria 1973). They also carried over their ideologies and party affiliations from the eastern regions where communism was stronger than in the western part of Bengal.

The lineage of the post-independence communist party can be traced back to the 1930s regional anti-colonial movement, with many of the party stalwarts emerging from radical underground organizations such as Anushilan Samiti and Jugantar. In many ways this period established the most radical strand of communist policies in the early decades of their winning power. In particular, the land reforms of the 1970s also known as Operation Barga eliminated the practice of sharecropping and destroyed the political and economic power of landlords. These reforms for which Bengal is justly renowned, date back to the 1930s and 1940s when the

party (then known as the Communist Party of India—CPI) was heavily involved in rural, anti-landlord struggles among sharecroppers (*bhagchasis*); the movement came to be known as *tebhaga* for the claim of one-third of the agrarian produce made by sharecroppers. The CPI dominated radical rural struggles in Bengal during the late anti-colonial period, yielding them a powerful base among poor peasants and sharecroppers by the time of Independence in 1947. The communists did not win elections until 1964, however; instead, the 1950s and 1960s were a period of increased rural radicalization in which the power of landlords was severely curtailed.

The most crucial period for the increased dominance of the CPI (and after that the CPI(M), after the split in 1964) was the 1960s when intense struggles between the Congress and CPI exploded into ongoing violence between the two parties. The 1960s was a period of growing crisis for the Congress Party, leading to a split in 1969 after which Indira Gandhi emerged as the dominant leader. In Bengal, this crisis played out in a particularly violent fashion. In 1977 the CPI(M) and its Left Front partners won by distinct majority, riding on its earlier successes in the 1967 and 1969 elections. The story of later communist electoral ascendancy is in part the story of communist victory and stabilization during the 1960s (Kohli 1987). The emergence and stabilization of a new socio-political order under communist dominance was premised on a shift from the radical insurgency of the 1930s–1960s towards tactics of parliamentary ascendancy. This transformation of the communists' agenda has provoked fierce debate over whether it has led to an abdication of the anti-poverty agenda upon which the communists' claims to legitimacy rest. In recent years, the adoption of increasingly neoliberal strategies of economic growth by the CPI(M) in Bengal have led not only to increased conflict between the state and the poor, but have raised further questions regarding how far the communists have slipped away from their foundational claims and where they might be headed.

Debates over Bengali politics inevitably succumb to the ideological predilections of various sides and the analytical issues need to be carefully disentangled. The first concerns the strategy of parliamentary democracy, and the possibilities and limits entailed by this strategy. Second, the question of tactics—what tactics did the communists choose over the years and why? How were the political possibilities enabled and constrained by structural factors? Finally, having achieved what they did, what further possibilities opened up, and which were foreclosed? Answering these questions can provide a more analytically informed assessment of communist-led politics, and the possibilities of challenges and struggles to their agenda.

To start with, the strategy of parliamentary democracy should strike the observer as a rather surprising one. As noted earlier, many of the top brass of the early party leadership, such as Harekrishna Konar, were affiliated with left terrorist cells in their youth, choosing a brand of revolutionary terrorism that adamantly eschewed electoral politics. In this regard Bengali communism compares rather starkly with its counterpart in Kerala, which was founded simultaneously through the caste, class and anti-colonial movements of the 1930s and 1940s, but also gained experience in government through its electoral victory in the 1937 elections under British rule. In contrast, parliamentary socialism in Bengal came to the communists 'from above' as a result of national-level strategic decisions rather than through its organic development in regional politics. The 1960s and 1970s, therefore, were a learning experience, with the communists increasingly alienating their middle-class base through slogans such as 'seizure of benami land' which opened the door to Naxal-led mobilization and a challenge to the CPI(M) which it suppressed through the use of state repressive forces (Kohli 1987: 101). A protracted struggle between the CPI(M) and Naxalites, many of whom came from the radical left factions of the CPI(M), ensued with accusations of state brutality and violence leveled against the CPI(M)-led government. Referring to the challenges for parliamentary socialism, Przeworski (1985) argues that in a Western, capitalist context the strategy and tactics of class alliances are crucial, given

that the working classes strictly defined do not form a numerical majority. In a predominantly agrarian context such as India, rural-urban divisions and complex agrarian structures can prove even more challenging to an appeal to proletarianized workers and peasants. Instead, alliances with other agrarian groups whose interests are opposed to the large landowners, as well as with workers in different sectors can prove to be fragile and internally contradictory. Unsurprisingly in West Bengal a class-confrontational stance has been modified towards a social democratic one emphasizing gradual reform and class compromise. Tactically, the party has acknowledged the futility of alienating the majority of small owners and assorted urban and rural middle classes, emphasizing 'agrarian unity' rather than class struggle. This has had an important legacy the value of which has been much debated—for some, the land reforms have substantially altered not just rural economic relations, but the nature of politics itself, with bureaucracies and local *Panchayats* occupied by people sympathetic to the party's reformist agenda. Such a ground-level transformation in personnel has enabled reforms to penetrate most villages in a manner that has consistently eluded the Congress and other regional governments across India. In this sense Bengal's achievements are exemplary and draw attention to the political determinants of redistribution and reform, as well as the fundamental importance of land reforms and the electoral relevance of left parties in altering the balance of power in a state.

However, others have argued that such opportunities for radical left parties that come with occupying the state are equally matched by the compromises entailed in managing the state and ensuring the conditions for capitalist accumulation. Neither leading the process of socialist transformation, nor able to significantly push forward a social democratic agenda, such parties, it is argued, are doomed to increasingly resemble bourgeois parties. In Bengal, as Mallick (1993) argues, the contradictions of proclaiming the radical mobilization of the most subordinate classes with maintaining power have led to a near complete abdication of intended reforms. Despite the widespread publicity accorded to Operation Barga, Mallick points out that the reforms offered security of tenure to sharecroppers but balked at the redistribution of land. Sharecroppers in fact hardly constitute a homogeneous group, with a larger number of them approximating the middle peasant category by owning land and sharecropping on neighboring plots (Mallick 1993: 51). Furthermore, agricultural laborers form a higher proportion of the agricultural population compared with sharecroppers, and with sharecropping on the decline arguably it is the former who need targeted reforms. Yet Mallick argues that policies such as minimum wage legislation have been weakly implemented where middle peasant interests might be hurt. A similarly lackadaisical implementation of education, healthcare and policies targeting Scheduled Caste (SC) and Scheduled Tribe (ST) sections has been noted (Desai 2007; Mallick 1993). A survey of Bengal's position with respect to literacy rates, health-related indicators including child mortality and a range of indicators of social development—both in aggregate figures and distribution across caste and class—reveal a middling position for the state compared with the all-India average. In 2001 Bengal ranked somewhere between seventh and 13th position with regards to literacy and medical care provisions (National Council of Applied Economic Research 2004: 259). Literacy for rural and urban SC and ST communities is slightly below the all-India average (*ibid.*: 264). This gap is particularly wide in Kolkata, as well as in the more prosperous district of Bardhaman, and in Bankura, Purulia and Birbhum, which have overall low literacy rates. The worst is Jalpaiguri where only 11% of SCs are literate (*ibid.*). These caste and regional disparities are increasingly viewed as the product of a strategy that has disavowed a political commitment towards the poorest in favor of a broad alliance anchored in the middle rural classes.

The political ascendancy of Bengali communism has been premised on a difficult strategy of maintaining electoral dominance without hegemony among the intended beneficiaries of a communist strategy, i.e. the proletarianized rural and urban classes. While on the one hand the

formation of a disciplined and centralized organization has brought about reforms that other states have been unable to push through, arguably the capacity of the party in government has reached some limits. The CPI(M) has been accused of gradually becoming a 'party of the middle,' representing the interests of a new agrarian elite at the expense of poor peasants and agricultural labor (Bhattacharaya 1999). In urban areas the CPI(M) is beholden to a form of trade unionism that the party itself admits has eschewed workplace discipline and productivity, instead fighting hard to maintain job security and rising wages in the context of industrial decline and depleting government coffers. Government employees in Bengal form a recalcitrant block on reform of services and are seen as obstructing efforts to remove procrastination and absenteeism (Mallick 1993: 175). This is far from unusual in India, but significant insofar as it has been perceived as a problem by successive communist governments. If the CPI(M) has been insufficiently embedded (to invoke Peter Evans's term) among the agricultural laborers and marginal classes in rural areas, it appears to be overly embedded among its urban, working constituencies.

The problems for state autonomy raised by these uneven forms of embeddedness has led scholars such as Mallick to argue that parties such as the CPI(M) should abstain from parliamentary ascendancy if it means that the party's interests become coeval with the state's in a capitalist developmental context. Under these conditions the party cannot but renounce its representational role among the poorest. Yet, the counterfactual question of whether communism would have been a far weaker force had it not utilized parliamentary institutions is a real one and has not been adequately answered by the CPI(M)'s critics. A crucial question is whether any reforms, however limited, would have been adequately institutionalized (even if they were introduced under Congress governments), leading to an irreversible decline in the power of the landed classes. This question is all the more pertinent given that unlike in Kerala, non-party social movements particularly among lower castes have been relatively weak, and arguably would have been unable to push the state in the direction of deepening reforms.

It has been argued that anti-poverty capacities are enhanced when a more rigorous relationship between parties and social movements is developed (both led by the party as well as outside it) (Desai 2001, 2007). In West Bengal, the stability of communist rule was arguably premised on the relative absence of a more agonistic democratic process whereby the inertia and interests of the bureaucracy and party elite are institutionally challenged on a regular basis. A comparison with Kerala, where the same party (CPI(M)) has found itself regularly disciplined by social movements organized from within and outside the party, shows that reforms are pushed further and institutionalized when such a synergy exists. In Bengal such a synergy was less evident. Formal organized opposition to the CPI(M) within the parliamentary arena was largely fragmented, with the Trinamool Congress initially unable to launch an effective electoral challenge or forge meaningful alliances with other parties. Such challenges have arisen more recently in the wake of liberalization during the 1990s (to be discussed), but it is too early to say whether they will have more positive and longer-term effects on democratization. The CPI(M) instead pursued a decentralization agenda in an effort to increase popular participation in decision-making. The results of this decentralization agenda appear to be rather mixed, however; some scholars argue that a number of villagers in different districts reported never having attended a *Gram Sabha* meeting where they could have voiced their concerns (Williams 1999: 235). Effectively, popular participation is highly uneven across districts, with the marginalized least likely to participate in a meaningful way. Many of the poor perceive the *Panchayats* to be corrupt (Chatterjee 2001). Clientelism rather than active citizenship appears to define relationships between elected officials and the poor, although studies have shown mixed results across districts and villages and reveal a complex picture whereby many of the poorest continue to support the

communists on the basis of a perceived change in their life chances (Bardhan *et al.* 2009). These factors appear to be crucial to explaining the weakening electoral performance of the CPI(M) in state assembly and Lok Sabha elections, culminating in their defeat in the May 2010 state assembly elections. This important outcome will be discussed at length subsequently.

The strategy of broad alliances also has had organizational consequences that in turn limit the movement-party dynamic. For instance unlike in Kerala, agricultural workers are not represented through a separate union in West Bengal; rather, by working within the Kisan Sabha their interests have arguably been subsumed under those of the small and middle peasantry. It is estimated that the proportion of agricultural laborers among the working population in agriculture has risen from 46.1% to 56.6% between 1991 and 2001, while the percentage of owner-cultivators has declined from 53.9% to 43.4% (Banerjee and Roy 2007: 2048). Many of them belong to the SC, ST or lower-caste communities, and continue to experience a high degree of marginalization in comparison to the new agrarian elites who have succeeded in gaining administrative and party positions (*Economic and Political Weekly* 2009). It is increasingly suggested that in the face of the communists' new strategy of industrialization, such groups are open to political mobilization by anti-left parties and/or radical movements outside the Left Front, as witnessed in Singur, Nandigram and Lalgarh, as well as the protests surrounding starvation deaths in the tea plantation areas of Darjeeling. In the three former villages efforts to seize land, for example to manufacture the widely publicized Tata Nano in Singur, led to mass protests that often turned violent, and ended in the abdication of the project itself. Historically, the CPI(M)'s policies of class compromise and agrarian unity have brought them into direct struggle with the Naxalites, which has often taken a violent turn. This political antagonism has thus far failed to damage the parliamentary stability of the CPI(M), but may do so in the future as not only Naxal groups but previously sympathetic left intellectuals turn against the CPI(M)'s perceived hospitality towards capital in the growing struggle over land.

Arguably Bengali communism has largely been a rural affair, and its ability to win elections in urban areas in a consistent fashion has been impaired by the industrial crisis facing the state. Theoretically, and historically, at least during the years of communist ascendancy, the urban working classes constituted an integral element in its strategy of mobilization. In the 1987 assembly elections, however, while the Left Front won 51% of the vote, they lost in a number of urban constituencies including Calcutta, Howrah and Darjeeling. By then Bengal had found itself behind Gujarat, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu, in part as a result of serious biases against the state by the centre since the 1960s. Industrial militancy during the late 1960s played some part but its role in declining investment should not be overstated. Central government industrial policy favored other states consistently, yet the communist governments had already begun attempts to reverse industrial decline by curbing militancy and encouraging small-scale industries (Pedersen 2001: 649). A strong anti-foreign investment sentiment underpinned the industrial policy of the communist government as set out in 1978. Yet these policies did not succeed—industrial stagnation, job losses and low wages have formed a chronic set of symptoms of overall industrial decline in the state. West Bengal's share of registered factory production at Independence was 30% of India's total, but just 6% by the 1990s (*ibid.*: 651). Attempts at fostering a class compromise and attracting foreign and domestic investment has become the mainstay of the Bengal communists' New Economic Policy, which also marked a distinct shift in policy since 1978. While criticizing the neoliberal agenda of the center, the CPI(M) took advantage of opportunities to attract foreign investment in the state, drawing allegations of hypocrisy from its critics to the left and right. By soliciting the views of management consultants such as Price Waterhouse and McKinsey, which drafted a series of recommendations urging a strong industrial strategy premised on labor quiescence, the communists sought to reshape industrial

policy and woo the very entities they had earlier rejected—namely, big business houses and multinationals.

The Bengal communist experience has drawn praise and criticism in equal measure for its unprecedented role in using parliamentary democracy and mobilization of the poorest to repeatedly win elections and foster a radical reform agenda. These reforms have eluded most Third World governments—even those that have professed an interest in redistributive programs—and compare very favorably with most Indian states. As the veteran leader Jyoti Basu has admitted, the CPI(M) has limited powers operating as it does at the state level within a ‘capitalist feudal economy.’ Yet within these limits, by providing relief for the poor, strengthening the *Panchayats*, and thus transforming social relations, the CPI(M) has achieved more than many parties confronting the objective situation of a refugee crisis and post-colonial scarcity. These reforms, moreover, succeeded in redefining the rules of the game by severely curtailing the power of landed interests in the government, in policy-making and in shaping the political culture. Bengal’s ability to remain free of communal violence and a culture of communal hatred is no mean feat when compared to the inability and lack of will displayed in most states against extreme communalism. Yet, contemporary political developments in the context of liberalization are beginning to signal new political difficulties for a self-avowed social democratic regime. The most recent state assembly elections in May 2011 were the first time in over 30 years of rule that the CPI(M) was so severely defeated and routed from office.

The historic electoral defeat of the CPI(M) had been preceded by reversals in Panchayat, Lok Sabha and municipal elections since 2008. The Lok Sabha election of 2009 was the first time since it came to power that the CPI(M) failed to win a majority of seats. Its prime antagonist, the Trinamool National Congress (TNC) led by Mamata Banerjee, had gradually built support among disillusioned voters, enabling it to become the main opposition to the CPI(M). Significantly, the TNC managed something that opposition parties in Bengal had failed to do: unite several parties into an anti-CPI(M) alliance including the Indian National Congress (INC), National Congress Party (NCP) and Socialist Unity Centre of India (SUCI). Arguably this was the single most crucial factor that explains the 2011 outcome. The TNC alliance won 227 out of 294 seats, while the CPI(M) won 62 seats. One should not exaggerate this picture, however; it is important to remember that the CPI(M) won 41% of the total votes polled (n.a. 2011). Most of the votes the CPI(M) lost were in urban and semi-urban areas where the TNC-led alliance scored significant victories. The salaried/professional and business classes, as well as skilled and semi-skilled urban workers voted in favor of the TNC. With ‘law and order’ cited as one of the key issues affecting voters, it would seem that Mamata Banerjee had succeeded in her strategy of raising poor governance and instability as key failings of the communists, in particular using Singur and Nandigram as key examples of communist ineptitude and worse, criminality.

Aside from governance, however, the political economy of social democracy under liberalization inevitably creates the need for new political strategies. Receding support for the CPI(M) is worryingly centered among those strata that theoretically should be supporting the communists. Instead, the CPI(M) appears to be in an intractable position whereby economic growth is premised on alienating part of its rural base, while slowing growth equally threatens the viability of social democracy in Bengal. The rural middle classes and assorted lower-middle classes who constitute the backbone of the party apparatus such as teachers and clerks, for example, depend on the state for its salary and social position. It is argued that this has led to a fiscal crisis whereby state revenues are exhausted through payments in the form of pensions, privileges, subsidies, etc. (Mukherjee 2007: 103). As the CPI(M) attempts to maintain its electoral dominance, its political survival will depend on how it pushes forward a growth agenda that is

inclusive and democratic. The development and maturation of a neoliberal developmentalism may pose unforeseen problems for communist dominance and hegemony in Bengal.

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26

BIHAR

Jeffrey Witsoe

Bihar, a north Indian state of over 90 million people, is India's poorest state, known for endemic caste conflict, political violence, and a strengthening Maoist insurgency. At the same time, since the early 1990s a democratic empowerment of lower castes has transformed the political geography of the state. This chapter will examine the politics of caste in Bihar. As I shall seek to show, a breakdown of public institutions, the political marginalization of development and a dramatic rise in criminality followed in the wake of a politics of caste empowerment, but while caste-based political mobilizations destabilized the institutions of governance and state-directed development, this also catalyzed a meaningful, although partial, empowerment of lower castes. In particular, the case of Bihar reveals the dynamic relationships between caste dominance, state institutions and electoral politics that lie at the heart of the politics of caste in India. I will focus on the long period of rule by the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), when Lalu Yadav and then his wife Rabri Devi served as chief minister from 1990 until 2005.¹ I will then briefly consider changes that have occurred since the coming to power of a National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government with Nitish Kumar as chief minister in 2005. First, I briefly turn to the historical context that has shaped Bihar's political world.

The historical context

In colonial Bengal, which included present-day Bihar, the primary divisions in the agrarian economy were between three broad groups: 'twice born' (*dwijas*) wearers of the sacred thread; peasant castes that did not don the sacred thread and had to settle for inferior tenancy arrangements and provide free or discounted labor and services; and 'untouchable' castes the ritual impurity of which perpetuated a class of landless and often bonded laborers. The entire *zamindari* system of colonial land tenure in large areas of north India was underpinned by these caste divisions.² As British rule under the permanent settlement strengthened the role and authority of zamindars, caste inequalities inevitably worsened, reinforcing the local dominance of landowning 'twice-born' castes.

From the late colonial period, land scarcity resulting from India's burgeoning population, and a fragmentation of landholdings (caused by the division of inherited land among brothers), forced landed elites to turn to the state in order to reinforce their dominance. Caste-facilitated relationships between landlords in the countryside and an expanding and predominantly upper-caste, urban

elite. Caste organizations founded universities and patronized caste-based educational scholarships. In this way agricultural surplus and rural power were channeled into urban pursuits, human capital, and access to government, on the basis of emerging caste networks.³ Colonial caste identities became instrumental for accessing state resources and public employment. Privileged access to administrative jobs, in turn, allowed patronage relationships that disproportionately transferred public resources to already dominant castes. The pervasive relationships between caste networks, state institutions and local dominance that became established during the late colonial period has had a lasting impact on politics in Bihar.

After Independence, the Congress Party relied heavily on landed elites as a base of political support in the countryside, which served to buttress their elite position. While upper-caste control of state institutions reinforced the dominance of upper-caste landlords, the votes that these landlords delivered elected members of their own castes to office, reinforcing upper-caste control of the state and the village in a mutually reinforcing pattern. This resulted in a nexus between local landowning elites, politicians, bureaucrats and contractors. Caste facilitated these networks because the majority of landed elites, Congress politicians (especially in the early years after Independence) and bureaucrats all came from upper-caste backgrounds.

Gradual changes within the agrarian economy set the stage for later political transformation in Bihar and other areas of north India. The abolition of the zamindari system of land tenure after Independence, which was not implemented until a decade or so later, weakened the position of large landlords, although loopholes were exploited that still enabled very large landholdings to be maintained in many areas. Much of the land that former zamindars were forced to relinquish came into the hands of their former tenants, many of whom came from peasant-caste backgrounds (in Bihar, for example, this included Yadav, Kurmi and Koeri castes). The expanding economic status of many other backward class (or caste, OBC) cultivators in the wake of the green revolution conflicted with their political marginalization, especially since the patron-client ties that had allowed their votes to be controlled by upper-caste landlords were progressively weakening. In 1967 Bihar was among the first state assemblies in north India where the Congress lost power. The next five years saw chronic political instability, with nine different ministries and three periods of president's rule. In 1977 the first, albeit short-lived, non-Congress national government was formed in 1977. In the same year the anti-Congress Janata Party came to power in Bihar, with the lower-caste leader Karpooori Thakur as chief minister.⁴ In 1978, Thakur implemented the 1971 Bihar Backward Classes Commission Report (known as the Mungeri Lal Commission), which recommended affirmative action quotas in the state civil services and universities for the OBCs. This decision precipitated widespread rioting by upper-caste youth, the fall of Karpooori's government, and a return to Congress rule for the subsequent 12 years.⁵ In the longer view, the significant political challenges to the Congress and to upper-caste dominance from the late 1960s forward were nonetheless unable to dislodge the supremacy of the Congress or the upper castes.⁶ Congress supremacy, and the conservative political alliances underlying it, continued until the politics of caste empowerment swept north India in the 1990s.

The politics of caste empowerment: Lalu Yadav's incomplete revolution

Although politicians from upper-caste backgrounds dominated political life in Bihar for most of the post-independence period, it is difficult now to imagine a future chief minister in Bihar from an upper-caste background. Jaffrelot (2003) has gone so far as to refer to these changes—following V.P. Singh's apt expression—as a 'silent revolution' in north India.⁷ In Bihar, for example, in the space of just a decade from 1985 to 1995 the number of backward-caste

Table 26.1 Caste background of members of the Bihar assembly¹

Year	Forward caste MLAs	%	Backward caste MLAs	%
1967	133	41.82	82	25.78
1969	122	38.36	94	29.55
1972	136	42.78	76	23.89
1977	124	38.27	92	28.39
1980	120	37.03	96	29.62
1985	118	36.41	90	27.77
1990	105	32.40	117	36.11
1995	56	17.28	161	49.69

Notes: ¹ Taken from Chaudhary 2001: 316; translation mine.

Source: Witsoe 2005.

candidates elected to the assembly more than doubled to 50%, while the number of upper-caste candidates more than halved to 17%, indicating a profound transformation of political representation in the state (see Table 26.1).

The politics of caste empowerment, as well as the many failures of the Bihar government became embodied for most people in the political figure of Lalu Prasad Yadav, a charismatic lower-caste leader who challenged the hegemony of Bihar's upper-caste elite and who consistently dominated politics in Bihar from the time when he became chief minister in 1990 until the electoral victory of the rival NDA in 2005. Lalu was a strong supporter of the Mandal Commission's recommendations for employment quotas in the central civil services for members of the OBCs, despite the widespread violence following Prime Minister V.P. Singh's decision to implement these recommendations in 1990. Within this charged context, Lalu's militant campaigning for caste empowerment earned him a reputation as the foremost leader of a 'backward-caste' state government fighting against a perceived upper-caste hegemony. Lalu built a mass base of support for himself in villages across Bihar, using a helicopter (which he called his 'flying machine') to access remote villages, many of which had never been visited by a prominent politician. Instead of visiting the upper-caste sections of villages, where many politicians in the past had been received, Lalu made a point of visiting lower-caste areas.

Lalu's politics of caste empowerment consciously marginalized development-related issues. A popular RJD slogan was '*vikaas nahiñ, samaan chahiye*' (we need dignity, not development).⁸ In fact, he explicitly put issues related to honor and voice above development. As Lalu famously commented, 'I may not have given them heaven, but I have given them voice' (*swarg nehi, swar diya*). Lalu Yadav's core political project was as all-out effort to displace the upper castes from the center of Bihar's political, social and economic life. As he described the fruits of this project towards the end of his rule, 'the forward castes used to rule Bihar. I have finished them off.'⁹

Why, though, did Lalu and other lower-caste politicians not aggressively embrace constructive reforms in areas such as primary education and rural health services which would have benefited the majority of the lower-caste poor? We might have expected the RJD government to pursue an agenda of redistributive policies that would have expanded the role of the state, but instead public institutions were allowed to deteriorate, and little in the way of pro-poor policy initiatives was even attempted.¹⁰ It was not that Lalu chose retribution over growth but that he did not systematically pursue any state-directed policies, redistributive or otherwise.

It is therefore not surprising that during the period of RJD rule, Bihar was widely considered to be the worst-governed state in India. There was a sharp decrease in public investment in Bihar during the 1990s.¹¹ While there are many reasons for declining investment expenditures

(especially the increasing fiscal burden of debt servicing and pension payments), the Bihar government consistently failed to use funds allocated by the central government. One high-level government report claimed that the state government was annually forfeiting an estimated 10 billion rupees (US\$250 million) of potential funds from the center due to easily correctable procedural inefficiencies (Saxena 2003).¹² The primary factor explaining the lack of policy-oriented governance during RJD rule relates to the long history of caste dominance, and the role of upper-caste influence within public institutions in reinforcing this dominance, as described above. Contrary to popular opinion outside Bihar, the chaos and partial collapse of governance that occurred during the period of RJD rule did not result primarily from the leadership's ineptitude or corruption. In fact, although there are obviously no comprehensive data on this point, my sense from interviewing scores of bureaucrats, politicians and various well-placed 'middlemen' is that much of the looting of public funds that occurred during this period was carried out by upper-caste bureaucrats.¹³ Rather, the RJD intentionally weakened state institutions controlled by upper castes as part of its political project to empower lower castes; the governmental breakdown that occurred in Lalu's Bihar was by design.¹⁴

As Table 26.2 demonstrates, in the 1990s a clear disjuncture emerged between the caste backgrounds of elected representatives and that of the bureaucracy. While OBCs had displaced upper castes within the realm of political representation, this was clearly not the case within the

Table 26.2 Indian administrative service and Bihar legislative assembly in 2002¹

Social background	Indian administrative service (Bihar cadre)		Members of the state legislative assembly	
	No.	%	No.	%
<i>Forward Castes</i>				
Kayasth	34	14.0	3	1.3
Brahmin	60	25.0	8	3.4
Rajput	22	9.0	22	9.4
Bhumihar	27	11.1	17	7.3
<i>OBC Castes</i>				
Bania	15	6.1	12	5.1
Yadav	4	1.6	64	27.4
Kurmi	3	1.2	13	5.6
Koeri	0	0.0	23	9.8
'Backward'	9	3.7	NA	NA
Annexure One	0	0.8	11	4.7
Muslim	10	4.1	25	11.0
Scheduled Castes*	25	10.2	36	15.4
Scheduled Tribes*	7	2.9	0	0.0
Christian	3	1.2	0	0.0
Sikh	2	0.8	0	0.0
Jain	2	0.8	0	0.0
Unidentified	21	8.6	0	0.0
Total	244	100	234	100

Notes: ¹ These numbers are from interviews with senior IAS officers in Patna in 2002. ² Almost exclusively composed of reserved seats. Source: Witsoe 2005.

bureaucracy. Within this context, a political leadership whose stated goal was the realization of lower-caste empowerment (under the pretext of ‘social justice’) could go a long way toward accomplishing this by transferring power from recruited officials in the state bureaucracy and police force to elected politicians. Lalu Yadav accomplished this by centralizing decision-making power in his own hands (especially through a regulation that required every development expenditure over 2.5 million rupees to go through a complex procedure that required the chief minister’s approval), by posting OBC, Scheduled Caste (SC) and Muslim officers in key posts in the districts (in 1995, 30 out of 50 district magistrates were from these groups),¹⁵ through very frequent transfers of officials whose loyalty was in doubt (which included many, if not most, Indian Administration Service (IAS) officers), and by tolerating and even encouraging political interference in administration and policing at all levels. This caste divide between elected leaders and recruited bureaucrats was the socio-political basis of the breakdown of governance during RJD rule.

Caste conflict further weakened public institutions that were already under severe stress. Faced with severe fiscal constraints caused by the legacy of habitual overstaffing of public institutions by Congress politicians eager to provide patronage to their caste constituencies, burgeoning pension and debt servicing costs, and more adverse lending terms from the central government to the states (a result of structural adjustment in the early 1990s), the newly elected lower-caste leadership in Bihar had little incentive to undertake the difficult institutional reforms required to dislodge upper-caste control of public institutions, or to promote a private sector also owned and staffed almost entirely by upper castes. Instead, institutions thought to be controlled by upper castes were simply allowed to collapse.

The weakening of state institutions did succeed in at least partially displacing upper-caste dominance. Under RJD rule, upper-caste, landed elites found themselves without access to subsidized credit from cooperative banks (most of which became effectively insolvent), cut off from sources of patronage and ‘commissions’ that they had long enjoyed through the control of development funds and, above all, deprived of the connections with politicians and the police (the later seriously weakened) that had enabled them to effectively control labor, protect standing crops from theft and enforce exploitative sharecropping arrangements. Within this changed political context, lower-caste peasants, and especially Yadavs, progressively took over much of the active cultivation that upper-caste landlords were increasingly abandoning. It is therefore important to emphasize that in addition to the less tangible issues of honor and respect often associated with the politics of caste empowerment, many lower-caste people also materially benefited from these changes within the rural economy.¹⁶

However, as upper-caste dominance within village contexts and within public life in Bihar was weakened, this was increasingly replaced by OBC dominance. Within the heterogeneous OBC category, Yadavs, the most populous caste in Bihar (which also happened to be the caste of the chief minister), were widely believed to have reaped a disproportionate portion of the benefits of RJD rule—so much so that RJD rule was frequently described as ‘Yadav Raj.’ This new Yadav dominance was accompanied by a dramatic increase in Yadav political representation; Yadav members made up 27% of the state legislative assembly in 2002 (see Witsoe 2005), more than all other OBC castes combined, and Yadav legislators made up no less than 40% of the ruling party’s legislators compared to only 17% from other OBC castes. In fact, the bulk of the dramatic increase in OBC political representation in the 1990s was actually an increase in Yadav representation. In other contexts Yadav dominance was even more pronounced; in the Patna Municipal Corporation, Yadavs made up roughly half of all elected ward members in 2004, including the post of mayor (although almost all higher-level administrative positions in the Corporation, where most decision-making power resided, continued to be held by upper castes).

So while upper castes lost much of the status they had previously enjoyed, especially within the realm of politics, the negative influences of caste dominance did not dissipate—they just changed hands. In addition, there were many groups that were left behind. This was especially the case for castes officially classified as ‘Annexure One’ within Bihar’s unique system of reservations (which divides the OBC category into two annexes), popularly referred to as extremely backward castes (EBCs). Although these castes make up an estimated 32% of the population, Annexure One legislators made up less than 5% of the Bihar assembly. This unequal representation between different OBC groups made it increasingly difficult for the RJD to claim to represent all lower castes.

Perhaps the most visibly detrimental impact was the deteriorating law and order situation in the state as an ineffective, funds-starved and corrupt police force was unable to contain the spread of criminal networks patronized by politicians (and sometimes by the police themselves). For example, Bihar accounted for 26% of India’s total murders with the use of firearms in 2000, and the relatively small city of Patna accounted for 40% of all murders with the use of firearms in Indian cities.¹⁷ Between 1992 and 2005, criminal groups, often patronized or even led by politicians, carried out a reported 30,000 kidnappings in Bihar, as kidnapping for ransom became a booming growth industry.¹⁸ While a disproportionate amount of this surge in criminality was targeted at wealthier and upper-caste groups, poorer and lower-caste people also felt the impact.

In the November 2005 assembly elections, Annexure One castes consolidated around Nitish Kumar’s Janata Dal (United), in alliance with the BJP’s upper-caste supporters, particularly Bhumihars, who were seeking to regain their lost position or at least stem the decline. The NDA won a decisive victory, capturing 143 seats in the 243-seat assembly. This ended the long period of RJD rule and profoundly altered Bihar’s political geography.

Nitish Kumar’s development agenda

Nitish Kumar came to power, following a decade of spearheading the opposition in the state after he broke with Lalu Yadav in 1995, promising to restore law and order and to implement a highly ambitious development agenda. Over the next five years, Bihar’s economy only trailed behind the industrial powerhouse of Gujarat as the fastest growing state in India, and fast-track courts and a fortified police force resulted in a reported 52,343 criminal convictions—many times that of any comparable earlier period.¹⁹ The Nitish government introduced 20% reservations for the EBCs, which were so crucial to his party’s election victory, and an unprecedented 50% reservations for women in local Panchayats. Not surprisingly, these successes enabled Nitish Kumar and his NDA government to sweep the state elections held at the end of 2010, virtually obliterating the main opposition RJD led by Lalu Prasad Yadav, which had been thought to be unassailable during its 15-year rule from 1990 to 2005.

In order to understand the dramatic shift from a government that was in many ways opposed to development to a government that has put development at the center of its agenda, the electoral alliance underlying the new administration needs to be examined. The Nitish government, combining the BJP’s upper-caste support with Nitish’s core base of Annexure One voters (including Hindus as well as lower-caste Muslims) and his own Kurmi caste, can be seen as simultaneously progressive and regressive. While Kurmis are arguably the most socio-economically well positioned amongst the OBCs, the Kurmi caste is not populous enough, and is too regionally concentrated to exercise a state-wide dominance, in contrast to Yadavs during RJD rule. This is why Nitish has relied on the individually small, but collectively populous Annexure One castes, the support of which was the crucial factor in the NDA’s sweeping

electoral victory in 2005. The political consolidation of Annexure One castes represents a deepening of the politics of caste empowerment to groups that had not received the full benefits of the RJD's 'backward-caste' government. In addition, Nitish broadened this already formidable base to include a category that he has termed 'Maha Dalits'—SCs excluding the populous Paswan caste (which was already aligned with the opposition Lok Janshakti Party). A Maha Dalit Commission was formed, and Nitish stated his intention to 'saturate them [Maha Dalits] with development funds.'²⁰

It is crucial to recognize that both the Annexure One castes and the Maha Dalits that form the basis of Nitish's support will never be in a position to exercise the kind of caste dominance that upper castes, and then Yadavs, have exercised. While the political emergence of these groups is an important historical development, they remain geographically dispersed and poorly organized, making it difficult for Nitish to build a grassroots organization through which to carry out policy initiatives.

In fact, the elements of the NDA that do enjoy local dominance include a large number of criminal politicians, especially in the BJP, including many who became ministers in the state government.²¹ If Nitish delegated power to such ministers, legislators and party leaders, it would have made it impossible to restore law and order. In addition, the desire of Nitish to gain the support of lower-caste Muslims necessitated keeping his alliance partner—the Hindu nationalist BJP—as weak as possible in the state.²² While the upper castes have regained a foothold in the NDA state government, the fact that the Nitish administration has been headed by a powerful lower-caste chief minister underscores the political change that has occurred in Bihar.²³

Faced with the lack of politically viable grassroots organizations, and corrupt, even criminal, legislators, Nitish Kumar responded by shifting power from elected politicians to recruited officials. Nitish, like Lalu before him, centralized power in the post of chief minister. In stark contrast to Lalu, however, who weakened the bureaucracy and ruled through informal political networks, Nitish sought to revive the bureaucracy by operating through a 'core team' of senior IAS officers. In key departments, while Nitish distributed ministerial posts out of political compulsion, corrupt ministers were teamed with secretaries with honest reputations, undermining the influence of the former. Circulars instructed officials at all levels, including police *thanas* and block offices, to resist interference from politicians, including those from the ruling party. The government threatened politicians caught unduly influencing administration, including those from the ruling party, with being charge-sheeted and arrested. As we would expect, a broad governing alliance enjoying both upper-caste as well as lower-caste support resulted in greater cooperation and cohesion between different state institutions. This was demonstrated by the Bihar Administrative Service's enthusiastic support for the new government, as well as the government establishing an Administrative Reforms Commission. Such reform was impossible during RJD rule because of the endemic intra-state conflict examined above.

In stark contrast to during the Lalu period, the story of Nitish's Bihar is of a consolidation and strengthening of state institutions. Both the Annexure One castes and upper castes that form the basis of Nitish Kumar's support benefit from a shift of power from elected politicians to the bureaucracy. Upper castes do so directly because, while upper-caste political representation has declined considerably, upper-caste influence within the bureaucracy remains strong. Annexure One castes, on the other hand, received very little during RJD rule because they lacked political representation, so they stand to lose very little from disempowering politicians, and whatever benefits they receive from the current government (such as reservations in the Panchayats and increased development expenditures) is perceived as a significant improvement. The shift of power from elected leaders to the bureaucracy, therefore, reflects the political configuration underlying the NDA government's electoral victory. As political power

descended downwards to non-dominant castes, this has opened space for a reconstitution of state institutions in Bihar.

The politics of caste and the future of Bihar

It is easy to see Lalu Yadav and Nitish Kumar as embodying diametrically opposed political projects—a divisive, populist politics of caste empowerment versus development-oriented bureaucratic governance. I would like to suggest, however, that there are important continuities between their respective governments lurking beneath the surface, which reveal the larger implications of what has occurred in Bihar since the 1990s.

The Nitish Kumar government has not only reconsolidated state institutions, but in many cases these institutions are emerging as stronger than before the politics of caste empowerment erupted in the 1990s. This is because the networks of patronage that had long placed state institutions under the control of upper-caste, landed elites have been weakened progressively by three decades of lower-caste politics. The successes of Nitish Kumar's government in strengthening state institutions, therefore, in important ways built upon the political changes that occurred during RJD rule. The displacement of upper-caste dominance, catalyzed by a weakening of upper-caste-controlled state institutions, was a necessary condition for reconsolidated state institutions to operate more independently from the dictates of local elites (although this process is very far from complete). As examined above, the strengthening of state institutions also benefits the EBCs and Maha Dalits. Nitish Kumar's development-oriented agenda, therefore, does not represent the end of the politics of caste in Bihar, as some have suggested, but rather reflects a deepening of caste empowerment to include increasingly marginalized groups.

The politics of caste in Bihar has resulted in progressively changing relationships between state institutions, electoral politics and caste dominance. While during the Lalu period caste empowerment was achieved by weakening state institutions, Nitish has pursued similar ends by reasserting these same institutions. In the longer term it may turn out that Lalu Yadav's and Nitish Kumar's governments represent two phases of a single process of lower-caste empowerment, a process that will likely continue to shape the political future of Bihar.

Notes

- 1 The RJD was formed in 1997 after Lalu Yadav was expelled from the Janata Dal in the wake of the 'fodder scam.' As this shift did not significantly alter power in the state, which remained centered around Lalu, I refer to the period of both Janata Dal (1990–97) and RJD rule (1997–2005) as 'RJD rule.' There was also a National Democratic Alliance (NDA) government for a very brief seven days in 2000.
- 2 See Yang (1989, 1998), Das (1983), Mishra and Pandey (1996).
- 3 See, for example, Bayly 1999: 160–62, 264.
- 4 Karpoori Thakur, who was from the small, geographically dispersed *nai* (barber) caste, was the most important backward-caste leader in Bihar until his death in 1989.
- 5 See Frankel 1989: 107–19.
- 6 From the late 1960s, and especially from the late 1970s, the Naxalite movement engaged in armed conflict with oppressive landlords, who formed caste-based *senas* (militias) to counter this challenge. See Das (1983) and Bhatia (2005).
- 7 As Hasan (2000: 26) puts it, '... the unmistakable aftermath of Congress decline has been the displacement of upper-castes from positions of power and the rise to power of backward and lower castes. This is nothing short of a quiet social revolution.'
- 8 Raj Kamal Jha and Farzand Ahmed, 'Laloo's Magic,' *India Today*, April 30, 1995: 54.
- 9 Interview with Lalu Yadav, October 2002, Patna.
- 10 The few initiatives that were attempted, such as Lalu's idea of setting up *charvaha* schools in remote areas so that children could attend while grazing cattle (primarily benefiting poorer Yadavs), were not sustained.

- 11 Plan expenditure as a percentage of Bihar's state domestic product dropped from 6.2% in the 1980s to a mere 2.87% in the 1990s. Expenditure on agriculture—the sector on which most people's livelihoods depend—dropped from 6.8% in the 1980s to a mere 2.2% in the 1990s, and irrigation from 13.3% to 4.7% (see Witsoe 2006).
- 12 There were many reasons for such poor expenditure performance, including lack of administrative and technical capacity, late release of funds from the center, lack of 'matching funds' that are required for many central schemes, and overestimation in plan budgets. Saxena (2003), however, suggests that a substantial improvement could have occurred through simple procedural reform.
- 13 Although many politicians, unable to loot public funds as efficiently as bureaucrats versed in the art of 'managing the file,' received substantial 'revenue' from criminal activities such as kidnapping and drugs smuggling (see Witsoe 2011).
- 14 Mathew and Moore (2011) make a similar argument, partly drawing from one of the authors' experience serving as an Indian Administration Service (IAS) officer (Bihar cadre) during the Lalu period. They note, for instance, that in many cases government positions were intentionally left vacant in order to avoid recruiting an upper-caste officer.
- 15 'Going with the Wind,' *India Today*, February 28, 1995: 100.
- 16 For an example of this process within four villages, see Kapur and Witsoe (2008).
- 17 National Crime Records Bureau 2000.
- 18 Amarnath Tewary, 'Federal Rule "Improves" Bihar Life,' *BBC News*, Patna, April 23, 2005.
- 19 Although it should be pointed out that Bihar benefited from vastly increased fiscal transfers from the center during this period as India's economic growth rate and tax collection increased. With three-quarters of its revenue coming from central transfers, the state government's budget more than doubled and its budget for 'plan expenditure'—funds used for productive investments—more than quadrupled within five years.
- 20 Interview with Nitish Kumar, December 4, 2007, Patna.
- 21 In 2005, for the first time the BJP topped the list of major parties fielding candidates with criminal backgrounds (nearly 50%). The BJP was followed by the RJD and then the Janata Dal (United) (JD-U). See 'Criminals as Leaders—Yet Again?' November 19, 2005, www.indiatogether.org.
- 22 Anwar Ali, a prominent lower-caste Muslim leader in Bihar who became a member of Parliament (Rajya Sabha) after Nitish came to power, stated that he frequently asked Nitish to part ways with the BJP and assumed that he would do so at the earliest opportunity (interview with Anwar Ali, December 3, 2007, Patna).
- 23 It should be pointed out, however, that if upper castes were to regain dominance in a significant way, or if the Hindu nationalist project of the BJP were to gain real traction in the state (which so far it has not), then Nitish Kumar's political support would almost certainly fracture.

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PART IV

India and the world

INDIA AND THE WORLD

The vicissitudes of mutual adjustment

Baldev Raj Nayar

After a long, sustained struggle against colonial rule, India entered the modern world as an independent entity in 1947. The interaction between India and the world started with neither having much knowledge or understanding of the other. The world's established powers found India to be a difficult state actor to deal with, while India would find its experience with them to be painful, often threatening. It is the argument of this chapter that both have over the long period since made a mutual adjustment that may not be entirely satisfactory to either but does represent a considerable advance over the past for them.

The security dilemma and major powers

Whether as a consequence of the drive for domination in human nature (classical realism) or the anarchic structure of the world (structural realism), the key characteristic of the world has been and is a struggle for power among its member states. That feature confronts states with a constant threat to their national security as well as their economic wellbeing. The long history of partitions and conquests of weaker states by the stronger ones reinforces the perception of such a threat. States cope with the resultant 'security dilemma' through *balancing* against threatening states by acquiring capabilities, either building them domestically or borrowing them from others through alliances.

An essential requirement for states in realist theory is that they maintain a balance between their aims and capabilities. The violation of this requirement usually invites punishment from other states. However, since it is human agents who develop strategies for national security, their actual policies are influenced by many factors, often in tension with the requirements of realism. This tension is often expressed in simplified form as one between ideals or idealism and realism. Because of this tension, there is constant readjustment in strategy by states in the light of their experience in interacting with the world. Essentially, new states—emergent from long struggles of national liberation—enter the international system with little or no experience or tradition of managing international relations, often imbued with revolutionary fervor and messianic ideologies to change the existing world order. Consequently, there is often a painful learning process involved during their socialization into the system. India has been no exception to this process.

The realist understanding of the international system entails coming to terms with another aspect of that system. Notwithstanding the legal doctrine of sovereign equality among states, the

international system is in actuality an oligarchical structure, where only a handful of great powers determine, whether in conflict or cooperation, the system's present state and its future destiny. In short, the world is what the great powers make of it. While the great or 'major powers' are the system's subjects, making the life-and-death decisions about the world's fate, the 'minor powers' are in dramatic contrast mere objects of their decisions. Great or major powers are defined by their capabilities, which are a function of the size and productivity of their population and the coherence of their society and polity.¹

Ambiguity marked India's status at Independence. On the one hand, it had the second largest population in the world, led by a remarkable band of able and dedicated leaders, who—driven by the country's size, its having been the site of a distinctive and ancient civilization, its past intermittent periods of greatness, and its future economic potential—aspired to make it a major power.² On the other hand, India was at the same time a poor and underdeveloped country with weak economic capabilities. It was at the time thus neither a major nor a minor power. Peter Lyon well expressed India's ambiguous status by asking: 'Is she the last and least of the great Powers, or is she the first of the lesser Powers?'³ However, if the binary distinction between major power and minor power is modified slightly, India of the time can fairly accurately be characterized as a 'middle power,' standing in between the categories of major and minor powers as an independent center of power with enough capabilities to withstand or resist imposition of unacceptable policies by the major powers, but not enough to enter their club.

Interestingly, an inherent tension exists between major powers and middle powers, with the former seeing the rise of the latter, unless beneficial to them, as not only derogating from their status but also, more crucially, diminishing the reach of their power. On the other hand, middle powers see their own security and welfare constrained by the major powers and are therefore eager to break into the latter's club. Indeed, India's relations with the world in the post-independence period can be read as a saga of conflict with one or more major powers that have sought to keep it down or constrained, even encircled.

India's perception of its own future role was best expressed by Jawaharlal Nehru, the maker of modern India and of its foreign policy during the first 17 years after Independence: '... we are potentially a great nation and a big Power, and possibly it is not liked by some people that anything should happen to strengthen us ... Leaving these three big countries, the United States of America, the Soviet Union and China, aside for the moment, look at the world. There are much advanced, highly cultured countries. But if you peep into the future, and if nothing goes wrong—wars and the like—the obvious fourth country in the world is India.'⁴ If India at the time lacked the material capabilities required of a major power, Nehru aimed to rectify the situation by building them. He soon launched the 'big push' industrialization strategy, with that strategy, focused on heavy industry, designed precisely to build not just economic capabilities but also the sinews of national power. While the economic strategy underwent changes in the subsequent decades, Nehru's successors sought ardently and steadfastly to protect and advance his national project of elevating India from a middle power to a major power.

Nonalignment, Nehruvianism and the national interest

Nonalignment has become the summary shorthand term to describe India's posture toward the world, at least until the end of the Cold War. Nehru as the founder of that policy had articulated its essence even before India emerged as an independent entity. He declared in 1946: 'We propose, as far as possible, to keep away from the power politics of groups, aligned against one another, which have led in the past to world wars.'⁵

Nonalignment issued out of the fact that India's emergence as an independent entity was the consummation of a genuine national liberation movement, albeit largely nonviolent. The new nation-state was therefore unwilling to compromise its hard-won Independence by subordinating itself to one or the other power bloc. However, India was not content with simply staying out of power blocs. Rather, it took to an activist global role, through which, consistent with the values it had acquired during the freedom struggle, it sought to organize the other newly independent states of Asia and Africa under its leadership to oppose imperialism, colonialism and racism.

Beyond these salient issues, India also opposed the politics of confrontation between the two power blocs, indeed power politics itself, because of the potential danger it held for war. To the annoyance of the USA, the interests of which as the hegemonic power were adversely affected by Nehru's policy, India propagated pacifist themes on the world scene, and offered, indeed interposed, itself as a mediator between the two blocs. Nehru's nonalignment incorporated also an element of romanticism insofar as it assumed a commonality of interests among the states of Asia and Africa, particularly as between India and China. To this complex of attitudes, the term Nehruvianism has often been applied, which, with its idealist underpinnings, stands distinguished from and counterpoised to realism.⁶

However, it seems rather simplistic and inaccurate to take nonalignment as encompassing India's posture in its totality to the world. Indeed, it would be a serious distortion to take even Nehru's own policies in their entirety to be either Nehruvian or nonaligned. Nor were the Nehru years by any stretch of imagination an idyllic period of nonalignment's success. There are two aspects to this reservation on Nehruvianism and its outcomes. One pertains to the level of analysis—whether it is the regional or the global system that is being considered. The other aspect concerns the temporal dimension—that is, the time period being studied—for India's foreign posture was not static but rather partially responsive to developments in the region and the world.

Notwithstanding the moralist and pacifist overtones in India's foreign policy at the global level, at the regional level—where concrete threats to its own security existed—that policy was largely consistent with the requirements of realism. Two features of India's posture are noteworthy here. One, given the fact that India has a hegemonic presence in its region, holding about three-quarters of its population, territory and economic product, India is basically a satisfied power at the regional level. Accordingly, while it wishes its intra-regional neighbors well and seeks a cooperative relationship with them, India has endeavored, though largely unsuccessfully, to prevent them from inviting intervention by the major powers into the subcontinent. The explanation for this stance of India's is that, given its power position in the region, a security threat to India can basically arise from a major power rather than from local powers acting by themselves.

The other feature of India's posture under Nehru was that while its repeated emphasis on idealism, pacifism and moralism had—in line with the theory of cognitive dissonance—an inhibiting effect on pursuing national interests (witness the long hesitancy in incorporating the colonial outpost of Goa), India was not altogether neglectful of its security interests. For example, as China occupied Tibet and thus removed this buffer between India and China, India extended a security umbrella to Nepal and Bhutan through special treaties. If there was thus a contradiction manifest between how India operated at the regional level and at the global level, India was not unusual among the major powers or potential major powers.

The realist element in India's posture extended also to the intersection of the regional and global levels during what is often regarded as the heyday of the nonaligned movement. In part, this was a consequence of social learning through harsh lessons in realism administered by the

major powers. When the USA entered into a pact with Pakistan to build its military capabilities in 1954, as part of an effort at the limited or regional containment of India—in Vice-President Nixon's words, to strengthen Pakistan 'as a counterforce to the confirmed neutralism of Jawaharlal Nehru's India'⁷—India resorted to a balancing strategy, though for the present confined only to the political and diplomatic arena. It reactively moved closer to the Soviet Union and communist China. Interestingly, while India offered a full-throated condemnation of the Anglo-French military attack on Egypt in 1956, it was largely evasive and low key in its criticism of the Soviet Union for its invasion of Hungary the same year, perhaps because it depended on the Soviets for vetoing US and British resolutions aimed against India on Kashmir on the United Nations (UN) Security Council.

Subsequently, the international system delivered India an even sterner and costlier lesson. By the late 1950s India's relations had worsened with China, culminating in 1962 in a clash of arms in which India suffered a humiliating defeat. India was shown up to have been living in a world of delusion, with Nehru lamenting, 'we were getting out of touch with reality in the modern world and were living in an artificial atmosphere of our own creation. We have been shocked out of it, all of us.'⁸ Nehru now admitted:

... this world is cruel. We had thought in terms of carrying the banner of peace everywhere, and we were betrayed. China has betrayed us; the world has betrayed us. Our efforts to follow the path of peace have been knocked on the head. We are forced to prepare for a defensive war, much against our will.⁹

To his great consternation and personal humiliation, Nehru was compelled to appeal frantically to many states, especially the USA, for military aid and air cover. Interestingly, the nonaligned countries proved to be of little avail to India at that time or ever since. To ignore these critical developments in the evolution of India's strategic policy would be to give a distorted view both of India's post-independence posture toward the world and of the presumed solidarity of the nonaligned world. After the 1962 war, finding the USA unwilling to provide long-term military aid, India entered into an arms relationship with the Soviet Union, which supplied MiG-21s and built factories for their coproduction in India.

The trauma of military defeat in 1962 at the hands of China shattered both India's and Nehru's prestige in the world; it perhaps also delivered a blow to his personal health, from which he never recovered, leaving the world in May 1964.

Nehru's successors and the Cold War

As a political hero of the nationalist movement, a political visionary, the founder and nurturer of institutions in post-independence India, Nehru long bestrode the Indian political scene like a colossus. His eminence and noble status necessarily heavily colors assessments of his role. However, it seems that the legacy bequeathed by Nehru in world affairs, regardless of whether or not it was a direct result of his specific policies, was extremely challenging for his successors. The severe reverses to nonalignment and India's relations with its neighbors had left the nation's foreign policy in confusion.

Apart from the parlous state of its foreign affairs, India also suffered heavy blows to its economic capabilities, with droughts and declining agricultural production making India heavily dependent on the USA, while the decade-long economic stagnation from the mid-1960s to the mid-1970s placed great strains on political stability. Taking opportunistic advantage of this situation, a much-strengthened Pakistan, benefiting from the superior weaponry supplied by the

USA, initiated attacks against India, which led to the 1965 India–Pakistan War. The war ended in a stalemate, but it administered India yet another lesson in realpolitik. Let alone any aspirations for major power status, India now found that even its middle-power position was under serious threat. India's immediate focus, therefore, became its own security vis-à-vis China and Pakistan, which had by now become de facto military allies and 'all-weather friends.' Meanwhile, China detonated a nuclear explosion in 1964, which raised new concerns in India about security.

Apparently, India was not technologically ready to respond with a nuclear test of its own. Instead, it asked the major powers to extend a nuclear umbrella over states without nuclear weapons of their own, but met with a firm refusal. To its horror, it found the major powers, while admitting China to the nuclear club, eagerly constructing an international nuclear regime with the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) of 1968 to preclude any new states joining that club. Holding the treaty to be unfair and discriminatory, India refused to subscribe to it; even in its weakened situation, India chose to defy the major-power system.

The opening of the 1970s presented a new and imminent danger to India's security, when 10 million refugees flooded into India from East Pakistan following the military crackdown there by the Pakistani military in 1971. Simultaneously, attempting to radically restructure the existing world order, the USA entered into a de facto alliance with China. Confronted by an axis of the USA, China and Pakistan ranged against it on the subcontinent, India in its desperate situation reactively entered into a semi-military treaty with the Soviet Union, demonstrating in the process that when security was at stake, nonalignment held little ideological charm. When the 1971 India–Pakistan War broke out, China and the USA made common cause in supporting Pakistan, with the USA even engaging in gunboat diplomacy against India with a naval taskforce headed by the *USS Enterprise*. However, with Soviet diplomatic support at the UN, India under Indira Gandhi's formidable leadership administered a defeat to Pakistan militarily and to the USA and China diplomatically.

Attempting to challenge the international nuclear regime, India finally undertook a nuclear test in 1974, officially under the pretense of a peaceful nuclear explosion. It, however, soon confronted a tightening noose at the hands of the Western powers, which sought to cripple India's nuclear capabilities by cutting off nuclear cooperation and advanced technology. For its part, after having defied the major powers, India for the next quarter century strangely went into nuclear hibernation, perhaps because of fear of further economic and technological sanctions, or preoccupation with domestic economic and political constraints, or the inability of India's soft state to impose sacrifices on the population, or the known cultural lack of a killer instinct in pursuing national interests.

India was, however, soon to wake up from its nuclear slumber. The 1970s and 1980s saw increasing military collaboration between China and Pakistan, with China transferring nuclear equipment and technology to Pakistan and supplying missiles and missile technology, while the USA turned a blind eye to this activity after the Soviets invaded Afghanistan. By the mid-1980s, Pakistani leaders were uninhibitedly proclaiming to the world that they possessed the ultimate weapon and were now strategically invulnerable. In view of this development, and the uncertainty about the future of its relations with the Soviet Union as leadership there passed to a new generation, India finally covertly permitted its scientists in 1988 to fabricate nuclear weapons. India's nuclear posture, however, remained embedded in ambiguity.

Meanwhile, emboldened by its acquisition of nuclear capability and also by its success in the ouster, sponsored and bankrolled by the USA, of the Soviets from Afghanistan, Pakistan mounted a major effort at asymmetric warfare against India in 1989, by massively redirecting the zealotry-driven guerrilla fighters from Afghanistan to the Indian state of Jammu and Kashmir. India withstood the attack but at the cost of enormous casualties, military and civilian, and of

internal turmoil. In its asymmetric 'war of a thousand cuts' against India, Pakistan has, however, sponsored and allowed the export of guerrilla fighters and terrorists to it.

The end of the Cold War, globalization, and the drive for major power status

The end of the Cold War following the unraveling of the Soviet bloc in 1990 held the potential for the liberation of India's foreign policy from the constraints of that conflict and from the apron strings of strategic dependence on the Soviets. By forcing India to rethink its relationship with the world, it offered the opportunity to rework its foreign policy and develop its own strategic destiny rather than depend on the Soviet Union as a protector. Unfortunately, the initial aftermath was hardly propitious.

The end of the Cold War coincided with an enormous economic crisis in India, which forced India to turn to economic liberalization. Of course, hesitant and tentative moves toward the opening up of the Indian economy had started as early as 1975 in order to overcome the economic stagnation of the preceding decade. Partly as a result of this partial change and partly as a result of an expansionary, if profligate, economic policy, the 1980s had seen an acceleration of the growth rate. However, there was rising concern that India's economy was falling seriously behind the East Asian economies, with potentially perilous geopolitical implications. India therefore took the opportunity of the economic crisis, partly under the prodding of the International Monetary Fund (IMF), to launch a major, though not thorough, restructuring of the economy in 1991. The consequent growth acceleration to 7% or higher was of enormous significance in India's subsequent self-assertion internationally.

If economic crisis was one challenge, the other major challenge was the ominous effort mounted by the USA and the major powers, with the connivance of the nonaligned and Islamic countries, to close the door on India's possible ascension to a major power role through tightening the screws of the international nuclear regime. The US administrations of George Bush, Sr, and Bill Clinton insistently pressured India 'to cap, roll back and eliminate' its nuclear capabilities. The attempt of the major powers to defang India in perpetuity in the nuclear arena—through permanently extending the NPT in 1995 and launching the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty (CTBT) in 1996, the specific target of the latter being precisely India—made India's position desperate. However, the USA and the major powers could not bend India, which under a more nationalist government, with in-your-face defiance, conducted nuclear tests and held itself forth as a nuclear weapons state (NWS) in 1998.

The reaction was swift and angry. The USA instantly imposed economic and technological sanctions, and a special session of the UN Security Council, chaired by China, condemned India forcefully through a resolution drafted by the Chinese. India thus endured considerable economic and strategic pain. Interestingly, US President Clinton and Chinese President Jian Zemin agreed in Beijing in June 'to continue to work closely together' to handle the situation arising from the nuclear tests. When India objected to this joint interference, the Chinese rebuffed it by reminding India of the major power status of both China and the USA, which entailed responsibility for maintaining the international nuclear order.¹⁰

Ironically, the same tests that brought down economic and technological sanctions on India also triggered the process whereby the major powers began to take India's claim to be a potential major power seriously, if not always positively. France and Russia were first to show understanding of India's aspirations, supporting recognition of it as an NWS and also permanent membership in the UN Security Council. The USA, too, entered into a long strategic dialogue with India: while the Clinton administration refused to modify its nonproliferation demands, it

began a comprehensive rapprochement process. On the other hand, China repeatedly insisted on India signing not only the CTBT but also the NPT, and thus renouncing its nuclear weapons capability. Indeed, China displayed annoyance with the USA for engaging in a strategic dialogue with India.¹¹

President George W. Bush carried forward the rapprochement with India, begun by Clinton, through the gradual but progressive relaxation of the sanctions. Indeed, during his second term Bush did something extraordinary, indeed revolutionary, which had so far been unthinkable. Stunningly, his administration offered to support the rise of India as a major power. The State Department unveiled a new strategy toward India: 'Its goal is to help India become a major world power in the 21st century. We understand fully the implications, including military implications, of that statement.'¹² As part of this effort, the Bush administration offered India an exceptional nuclear deal, which would in effect accord India *de facto*, though not *de jure*, status as an NWS through allowing it to avail itself of civilian nuclear cooperation from the world without having to sign the NPT. This was a remarkable and unprecedented concession to India, and only to India, since the existing international nuclear regime barred non-NPT states from international nuclear cooperation. The Bush administration then mounted a truly stupendous effort to obtain approval for the deal from the US Congress and the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG), where China attempted to scuttle the deal but finally let it go through when it found itself alone in opposition. Apparently, the NSG later began to have second thoughts on the deal, for in 2011 it sought to qualify the clean waiver it had earlier given to India.

One explanation often offered for the powerful effort of the Bush administration to get approval for the deal is a systemic one, which regards it as part of a balancing process aimed as a hedge against the future rise of China as a challenger to US hegemony. While India may covertly favor a balancing process against China, it is unlikely ever to acknowledge it openly for fear of annoying China. Although there may be considerable merit in this systemic explanation, it cannot be the entire explanation, however. It is remarkable that the same systemic structure did not compel the Clinton administration to its very end to removing the nuclear constraints on India, while the electoral triumph of President Barack Obama in 2008—and therefore the prospect of the return of some officials from that administration with their pro-China and nonproliferation orientation—caused considerable consternation in India. Another, perhaps complementary, explanation is an idiosyncratic one, arising out of the earlier favorable personal impression of President George Bush as Governor of the Indian community in Texas, obviously supplemented by a reassessment of India's augmented capabilities after globalization.¹³

Fortunately for India, President Obama's administration has continued to work for a closer partnership with India, visiting it in 2010. At that time, he provided considerable satisfaction to India by a positive but restrained statement before India's Parliament in support of a key aspiration of India's in recent years: 'I look forward to a reformed United Nations Security Council that includes India as a permanent member.'

The rapid rise of China, which is making for a massive shift in the global balance of power, arouses anxiety in both India and the USA. There is a considerable basis in this anxiety for the strategic partnership both have been working at for over a decade now. However, both are independent-minded states and, in the ultimate analysis, will do what they perceive to be in their national, it is hoped enlightened, interest.

For India the international approval of the civilian nuclear deal—that is, the changing of the extant international nuclear regime exceptionally to accommodate India—represented an adjustment on the part of the international system to India's status as a rising major power. To that extent, it reduced in considerable measure India's 'status inconsistency' as between its existing capabilities and its international status. India, too, has meanwhile adjusted to the international

system, having learnt to act in accord with realpolitik, at times even speaking its language.¹⁴ Not unexpectedly, some of the ideological residue of the non-alignment era still lingers on, while there is a visceral distrust of the major powers based on the experience of that era.

India still remains a candidate major power, however. That is so not merely because it lacks the insignia of permanent membership of the UN Security Council. More seriously, the real constraints to its ascension to a major power role are internal as manifest in the prevalence of enormous poverty, increasing economic inequality, widespread corruption, the deterioration of many of its institutions, the perversion and breakdown of the rule of law, and large-scale organized violence by various separatist, communal and insurgency elements. Besides, India suffers from the handicap of the turbulent condition of the region in which it is located. Ultimately, major power status is not a gift bestowed by others but something to be achieved by one's own efforts at comprehensively building capabilities. That requires, first and foremost, setting one's house in order with some determination.

Summary and conclusions

Over the 60 plus years' history of India's interaction with the world, a two-way movement is evident. On the one hand, the international system has socialized India into behaving like a normal state that gives priority to its national interests, the chief one of which is national security, rather than ideology, and to maintaining a balance between goals and capabilities. On the other hand, by building its capabilities, particularly economic but also military, especially naval, India was able to persuade some of the major powers, especially the USA as the contemporary, though declining hegemonic power, to facilitate in some measure its rise as a major power. However, there is still considerable distance for India to traverse in achieving its ambition to be one of the poles in the unfolding multipolar world.

Notes

- 1 Ronald L. Tammen *et al.*, *Power Transitions: Strategies for the 21st Century*, New York: Chatham House, 2000.
- 2 See Baldev Raj Nayar and T.V. Paul, *India in the World Order: Searching for Major Power Status*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003.
- 3 Peter Lyon, 'The Foreign Policy of India,' in F.S. Northedge, ed., *The Foreign Policies of the Powers*, New York: Praeger Publications, 1968, 287.
- 4 Jawaharlal Nehru, *Independence and After*, New York: The John Day Company, 1950, 219, and *Jawaharlal Nehru's Speeches: Volume III, March 1953–August 1957*, New Delhi: Publications Division, 1958, 264.
- 5 Jawaharlal Nehru, 'Free India's Role in World Affairs,' in *Selected Works of Jawaharlal Nehru: Second Series*, Vol.1, 404–8.
- 6 On Nehruvianism, see Kanti Bajpai, 'Indian Strategic Culture,' in Michael R. Chambers, ed., *South Asia in 2020: Future Strategic Balances and Alliances*, Carlisle, PA: Strategic Studies Institute, 2002, chapter 11.
- 7 Ralph de Toledano, *Nixon*, New York: Henry Holt, 1956, 164.
- 8 Sarvepalli Gopal, *Jawaharlal Nehru: A Biography*, Vol.III, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1976, 223.
- 9 Jawaharlal Nehru, *Jawaharlal Nehru's Speeches: Volume V, March 1963–May 1964*, New Delhi: Publications Division, 1964, 198–99.
- 10 B. Raman, 'Sino-Indian Relations: A Chronology,' South Asia Analysis Group, www.saag.org/papers/paper49.html.
- 11 Ibid.
- 12 US Department of State, 'Background Briefing by Administration Officials on US-South Asia Relations,' March 25, 2005, www.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2005/45853.htm.
- 13 See the interview with Ashley Tellis, in Jyoti Malhotra, 'De Facto, Not de Jure—India is the World's Sixth Nuclear Power,' *Mint* online, Mumbai, September 29, 2008.

- 14 In a remarkable address in 2005, the then foreign secretary privileged the national interest rather than ideology and nebulous Third World solidarity, and underlined strengthening the nuclear non-proliferation regime (notwithstanding India's own earlier defiance) and engaging with the world as an NWS. Shyam Saran, 'Nuclear Non-Proliferation and International Security,' India Habitat Center, New Delhi, October 24, 2005.

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INDIA IN ASIA

Geostrategic and economic considerations

Lawrence Sáez

India's position within Asia is loosely defined by its evolving global political outlook and conditioned by a number of overlapping geostrategic and economic considerations. At a primary level of analysis, India's relationship with its neighbors has shaped its role in Asia and in the global scene. For historical reasons that will be discussed below, India's regional standing within Asia is likely to continue to be motivated by these regionally driven, geostrategic parameters. From India's perspective, Pakistan and China are its chief geostrategic competitors. For this reason, much of India's foreign policy is motivated by an effort to both contain and counterbalance these two countries. At the same time, India attempts—rather sporadically—to assert leadership over its smaller regional neighbors (e.g. Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Nepal).

India's relationship with Asia is undergoing a period of transformation on the economic front, particularly as India has been able to assert itself globally in recent years. In light of the country's growing international economic presence, India has gradually tended to view bilateral trade relations with other Asian countries as a critical component of its regional position. As such, this chapter will evaluate the trends in India's bilateral relations with China, Japan, South Korea, and the member states of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) and the Association of South East Asian Nations (ASEAN).¹

India's geostrategic considerations: Pakistan and China

Since India's Independence from Britain, the country has fought four external wars. Three of these wars have been with Pakistan (1947–48, 1965, and 1971), and one with China (1962). India's initial concern following its Independence from Britain was how to define its relationship vis-à-vis Pakistan. By virtue of the unique circumstances that surrounded the partition of India and the creation of Pakistan, India's position within Asia is intertwined with Pakistan. In August 1947, India and Pakistan attained Independence, but the country of Pakistan was itself divided into two regions separated by Indian territory. At the core of the inherently complex relationship between India and Pakistan are unresolved disputes relating to the precise allocation of territory to each country after Partition. Since 1947, the most prominent territorial dispute between India and Pakistan concerns the status of Kashmir, an area over which there has been an ongoing bilateral dispute between India and Pakistan.

Pakistan

India and Pakistan have fought three wars against each other. The first war, in 1947–48, was directly linked to a dispute over the status of the territory of Kashmir. Subsequently, India and Pakistan have waged war on a broader set of issues. For instance, the 1965 India–Pakistan war was a brief border war relating to claims over conflicting claims along India’s western frontier with Pakistan as well as the unresolved dispute over Kashmir. The third India–Pakistan war was fought in 1971 as a consequence of India’s support for a Bengali insurgency in East Pakistan.

During the first two decades of India’s Independence, the bilateral relations between India and Pakistan were defined by mutual distrust. From Pakistan’s point of view, by virtue of its ongoing campaign to hold on to the southern sections of Kashmir, India has been viewed as an aggressive regional power that aimed to destabilize Pakistan. Pakistan’s concerns about potential Indian efforts to foster domestic political instability were later solidified as a result of India’s assistance to the pro-independence *Mukti Bahini* (liberation army) rebels in East Pakistan during the early 1970s. India’s support for Bengali rebels in East Pakistan was instrumental in the creation of the state of Bangladesh. More damagingly, the 1971 war also proved to be an embarrassing military defeat for Pakistan.

The creation of Bangladesh gave India the opportunity to demonstrate that it was capable of establishing itself militarily in the region. Although India and Bangladesh enjoyed a brief interlude of bilateral friendship during the rule of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman—having a rather demoralizing effect on Pakistan—there has been no long-term realignment in India’s relations with other South Asian neighbors. A succession of military coups d’état in Bangladesh eventually undermined India’s strategic partnership with that country.

Despite India’s numerical advantage in troop levels and weaponry, it has become increasingly apparent that India and Pakistan are not likely to settle their disputes in conventional military terms. As such, over the last two decades, Indo-Pakistani relations have acquired a new geostrategic dimension. Since the mid-1980s, there has been a notable deterioration in the political stability of the Indian-held section of the Kashmir valley, a region that has a predominantly Muslim population. The level of discontent in the Kashmir valley has found its most violent expression in the growth of a disparate number of Kashmiri nationalist and separatist insurgent groups. As the dominant military power in South Asia, India has had difficulty fighting asymmetric warfare with Kashmiri insurgents.

India’s aggressive response to counter such an incipient Kashmiri nationalist movement has complicated its continually turbulent relations with Pakistan. India generally blames the ongoing political instability and emerging insurgency in the Indian-held territory of Kashmir on tacit support from Pakistan. In turn, Pakistan has repeatedly denounced what it considers to be human rights violations by Indian armed forces and paramilitaries in the region as the key causal reason behind Kashmiri militancy.

The animosity between India and Pakistan reached a new level with the growing realization that India and Pakistan are nuclear armed states. In May 1998, both India and Pakistan conducted successful underground nuclear tests. Since the detonation in 1998 of the nuclear devices, India and Pakistan have become the world’s first contiguous nuclear armed adversaries. The gravity of the new status emerged between May and July of 1999, just a year after India and Pakistan demonstrated their nuclear capacity, when India and Pakistan engaged in a bilateral conflict along the Kargil district in Kashmir. Given the inhospitable weather and mountain terrain, continued warfare was difficult to sustain. However, the rapid escalation of the Kargil conflict demonstrated that relations between India and Pakistan continued to be founded on a tenuous

footing. Nevertheless, India-Pakistan relations have shown a cyclical pattern with periods of intense hostility followed by peaceful entreaties.

China

Although India's regional position is shaped by its complex historical legacy with Pakistan, India's outlook in Asia has been more dramatically defined by China. India's first Prime Minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, focused India's foreign policy along the pursuance of five principles (*panchsheel*): mutual respect for other nations, territorial integrity and sovereignty, non-aggression and non-interference in internal affairs, equality and mutual benefit, and peaceful coexistence. These five principles have been the cornerstone of India's foreign policy. Nehru's *panchsheel* were foreign policy principles that were a replica of a set of five principles of peaceful coexistence that Zhou Enlai announced on the occasion of meeting an Indian delegation to China in December 1953. These foreign policy principles formed the backbone of the 1954 Agreement Between the People's Republic of China and the Republic of India on Trade and Intercourse Between the Tibet Region of China and India, one of the diplomatic landmarks of India's foreign policy.

India and China's embrace of the *panchsheel* principles had wider ramifications. India was one of the founding members of the non-aligned movement (NAM) and viewed China as a natural ally in its commitment to non-alignment. The non-alignment movement's adoption of the broad principles of peaceful coexistence placed India's foreign policy on a dual track with other prominent Third World leading nations, including China. Based on the NAM's expressions of multilateral cooperation, India perceived that it could advance its national security and developmental goals with deeper cultural and political engagement with China.

China and India's engagement began weakening on the basis of India's willingness to grant asylum to the exiled Tibetan religious leader, the Dalai Lama. India argued that its decision to grant asylum to Tibetan refugees was based on humanitarian and cultural heritage grounds. From China's perspective, though, the dominant view was that India had wished to undermine the assertion of Chinese sovereignty in Tibet and that it covertly assisted Tibetan rebels. Thus, although China and India shared some elements of cultural heritage, it also became evident that India and China shared the inherent problems associated with poorly demarcated geographic borders. Although India and China were drawing closer together politically, by the mid-1950s it emerged that these two countries shared over 2,500 miles of potentially disputed border territory.

Given the turmoil that followed India's partition, the precise delimitation of all India's border lines with China did not receive adequate attention. Once China defeated the Tibetan uprising and asserted its authority in the region, there were growing concerns that areas surrounding the Tibet and India border were not mutually agreed upon by India and China. In the presence of an ambiguous demarcation of territory, India began to adopt the McMahon line—a boundary line established in 1914 during colonial times—as the default boundary between India and China. However, the Chinese government objected to the acceptance of the McMahon line as being the proper boundary and complained that along specific portions, Indian troops were stationed north of the McMahon line.

The growing boundary dispute between India and China developed into a series of border skirmishes which culminated in a full-scale border war along two fronts, one near the Aksai Chin glacier and the other near the Nathula Pass. From October 1962 until the end of November, Chinese troops easily overwhelmed their Indian adversaries and eventually declared a unilateral ceasefire. Although short in duration and limited in terms of actual territorial losses for India, the 1962 India-China war was a monumental catastrophe for the credibility of India's military. The conflict also caused substantial harm to India's diplomatic relations with China.

During the period of China's self-imposed international isolation during the Cultural Revolution (1966–76) and on the basis of China's existential threat to Indian security, India began to reassess its relationship with Nepal, up to then one of India's strongest allies. India-Nepal relations hit a low point in the 1970s, initially on the presumption by the Nepalese government that Indo-Nepalese trade relations were skewed in favor of India. Nepal, a landlocked country lodged between India and China, could only count on India as an outlet for its exports. Nevertheless, both countries struggled to reach an agreement on separate trade and transit treaties that would restore some balance in their trade relationship.

Indo-Nepalese disagreements over trade and transit agreements led to a stalemate and Nepal began to consider realigning its economic interests more closely with China. Nepal began to acquire Chinese weaponry, further aggravating its relationship with India. In reaction, India sought to link concessions on agreements on trade with veto power over Nepal's arms purchases from China. By the end of the 1980s, India was imposing a virtual economic blockade of Nepal. India and Nepal eventually signed separate trade and transit agreements in 1991, an event which appears to have eased trade-related tensions between both countries.

A period of Indo-Nepalese diplomatic stability lasted until the outbreak of a Maoist insurgency in Nepal. Although ideologically drawn to a unique vision of a Maoist revolutionary warfare, China did not support the Maoist insurgency in Nepal. Instead, China viewed the civil war in Nepal as a threat to its peripheral stability along Nepal's border with the Tibet region. The end of the civil war in Nepal and the subsequent period of constitutional uncertainty in Nepal have weakened India's influence in the internal affairs of that country. Paradoxically, given its geographic location, Nepal could serve as an important economic bridge between China and India, a role that it will be unable to serve with any effectiveness until Nepal's domestic political setting attains some stability.

China's interests and influence in South Asia have begun to draw some scholarly attention.² China has been engaged deeply in providing military weaponry and physical infrastructure assistance to Myanmar (Burma). On a similar pattern, China's military assistance to the Sri Lankan government contributed to a sudden conclusion of the civil war in Sri Lanka. Mirroring its involvement in Myanmar, China is a core provider of physical infrastructure development to Sri Lanka. As argued by Sáez, it appears that China's involvement in the Arabian sea and the Indian ocean is motivated by an effort by China to secure the stability of oil supply from the Persian Gulf. These developments should provide Indian policy makers with a renewed concern for how to respond to an apparent encirclement by China in the Arabian Sea and the Indian Ocean. Although India and China have a great deal to gain from economic cooperation, it is certain that Chinese involvement in the Indian Ocean will increasingly pose a strategic threat to India.

India's economic relations with Asian regional blocs

During the first decades following its Independence from Britain, India had shied away from conducting extensive commercial relations with other countries. In 1950, shortly after India's Independence, India's total exports represented 2.2% of world exports. However, by virtue of India's policy of self-reliance in industrial production and high tariff levels, India's participation in the world economy declined substantially. By 1960, India's total exports represented 1.2% of world exports; by 1970 this figure had plummeted to 0.7%, reaching a low of 0.4% in 1980.³

On the basis of India's inward-oriented development strategy and limited involvement in world trade, some authors (Desai 1999; Srinivasan 2004) have described India's trade relations over 1950–90 as being autarkic. As a result of a gradual lowering of tariffs, India began to participate more fully in the global economy in the 1990s and thereafter. As a result of India's

growing global engagement, the share of India's exports as a proportion of world exports grew from 0.5% in 1990 to 1.3% in 2009.

It would be expected that a nation that trades little relative to other nations is likely to concentrate its limited trade links regionally. India is unusual insofar as its pattern of trade with its neighbors is rather limited.⁴ Some of the explanation for India's low level of trade is that some of India's neighbors have pursued a policy of autarky (e.g. Bhutan, Myanmar). Likewise, the low and uneven level of bilateral trade between India and Pakistan can be understood in context of the poor political relations between these two countries. Among South Asian nations, Sri Lanka traditionally has been India's largest trade partner. Other explanations for the low level of India's interregional trade with its South Asian neighbors have also emphasized the low level of trade congruence between these countries.

SAARC

In order to boost collaboration between South Asian nations, seven South Asian countries established SAARC in December 1985. One of the immediate concerns that emerged at the creation of SAARC was that India, one of SAARC's founding members, would be disproportionately advantaged. Several provisions were established to prevent SAARC from becoming an Indian-dominated institution, so member states have an equal vote. Likewise, annual summits are held on a different South Asian nation on a rotating basis. Trying to find common ground within the distinctive range of diverse Asian economies is a challenge for SAARC (Sáez 2011). To that effect, members of SAARC coordinate their activities around eight core areas of cooperation: agriculture and rural development; health and population activities; environment and forestry; health and population activities; human resources development; science and technology and meteorology; transport; and women, youth and children. SAARC members have also established high-level Working Groups to enhance cooperation on areas relating to biotechnology, energy, information and communications technology (ICT), intellectual property rights (IPR), and tourism.

Since its inception, SAARC has not proven to remedy ongoing problems of intraregional cooperation. Rather than serving as an asymmetrical forum where only India would exercise hegemonic influence, some authors (Muni 2000) have suggested that India has been a reluctant participant in SAARC activities precisely because India does not have sufficient influence in the institution. Alternatively, critics of SAARC suggest that the institution is of little consequence and requires substantial institutional changes to be an effective body (Cheema 1999; Ahsan 2004). Nevertheless, one of the substantive areas in which there has been greater collaboration is on the issue of the creation of a free trade area in South Asia. In January 2004, the member states of SAARC signed an agreement on the South Asia Free Trade Area at the 12th SAARC summit being held in Islamabad. The agreement calls for greater intra-SAARC trade and economic cooperation and sets a timeline for the reduction of bilateral tariffs.

ASEAN

As India has become more assertive in its international trade transactions, it has become more focused on shaping its trade and commercial strategy to suit its strategic interests. Within the context of new developments in international relations theory, some authors have referred to this particular form of engagement as economic diplomacy (Bayne and Woolcock 2003) or commercial diplomacy (Frost 2007). In 1992 the Indian government began to enunciate a policy that has been dubbed the 'Look East Policy,' notably in reference to increased commercial cooperation between India and its eastern neighbors. According to Manmohan Singh, India's

Finance Minister in 1992 (and later its prime minister), the Look East Policy 'was not merely an external economic policy, it was also a strategic shift in India's vision of the world and India's place in the evolving global economy' (Prime Minister's Office 2005).

In aggregate terms, prior to India's economic liberalization measures in the 1990s, India's aggregate trade relations with ASEAN countries as a proportion of total trade worldwide did not exceed 5.4%. Since the formulation of India's Look East Policy, there has been a noticeable increase in aggregate Indian trade with ASEAN countries. In 1992 Indian trade with ASEAN countries represented 6.2% of India's trade worldwide. This figure increased to 7.4% in the year 2000. By the end of 2009, ASEAN represented 8.7% of India's trade worldwide (International Monetary Fund n.d.a).⁵

Although there has been an evident rise of aggregate trade between India and ASEAN countries, it would be misleading to suggest that such trade has been evenly dispersed. Rather India's trade relations with ASEAN countries show a pattern of persistent trade concentration into a few countries. Among ASEAN countries, the bulk of India's trade relations are particularly focused on three countries: Singapore, Malaysia, and Indonesia. By 2009, over 86% of India's trade with ASEAN countries went to one of these three countries.

Another peculiarity of India's trade with ASEAN countries is that there has been a gradual shift in the composition of the types of commodities being exchanged. An analysis of the trends in the commodities exchanged between India and ASEAN countries reveals that in the early 1980s, India's primary exports to its top trade destinations in ASEAN were in the form of manufactured products, food and live animals, and machinery and transport equipment. Over time, though, nearly half of India's exports to its top ASEAN trade destinations have been in the form of mineral fuels and mineral oils.⁶ Likewise, we find a similar pattern of transformation in the types of commodities being imported from ASEAN to India. India's imports from ASEAN countries have also experienced a gradual transformation. In the early 1980s India's top exports from its leading ASEAN trade partners were animal and vegetable oils. Recent trade trends point to a shift toward machinery and transport equipment and electrical machinery.

An analysis of India's trade patterns in recent decades shows that the volume of aggregate trade with the rest of the world has increased sharply since 2002, the sole exception being the significant dip in global trade during the global financial crisis (see Figure 28.1).

The data in Figure 28.1 show that using a comparison of India's trade relations with SAARC and ASEAN countries shows that India's trade with these countries has risen incrementally, but has not experienced a surge similar to that seen globally.

India's evolving economic relations with Japan, South Korea, and China

Given the tenor of India's inward looking commercial and external trade policy during the 1950s until the 1990s, there was little economic contact between India, Japan and South Korea. As discussed earlier in this chapter, the difficulties associated with India's historical relationship with China also precluded extensive commercial and trade contacts with that country.

An analysis of aggregate trade trends between India and Japan, South Korea, and China reveals that there has been a sudden spike in bilateral trade activity. As Figure 28.2 shows, the sudden increase (in nominal terms) of bilateral trade activity has been of recent provenance, largely since the year 2000. This period of rapid growth, though, appeared to taper off during the global financial crisis.

The data on bilateral trade, as illustrated in Figure 28.2, show that the most rapid growth in bilateral trade has been with China. An intriguing facet of India's complex relation with China is the expectation that these two emerging markets will be able to transform the dimension of

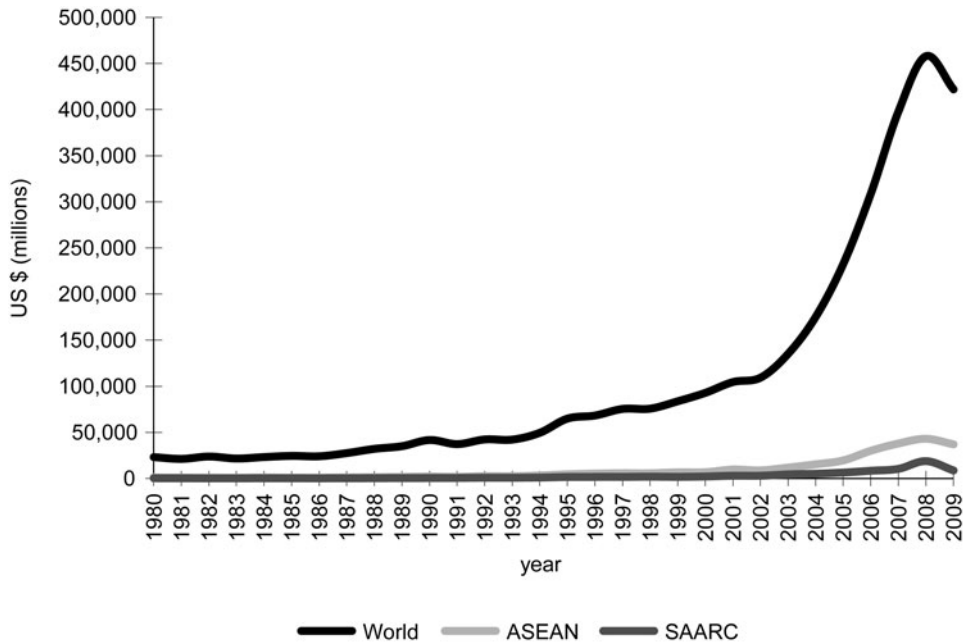


Figure 28.1 India's aggregate trade worldwide, with ASEAN and SAARC countries, 1980–2009
Source: IMF, Direction of Trade Statistics 2010.

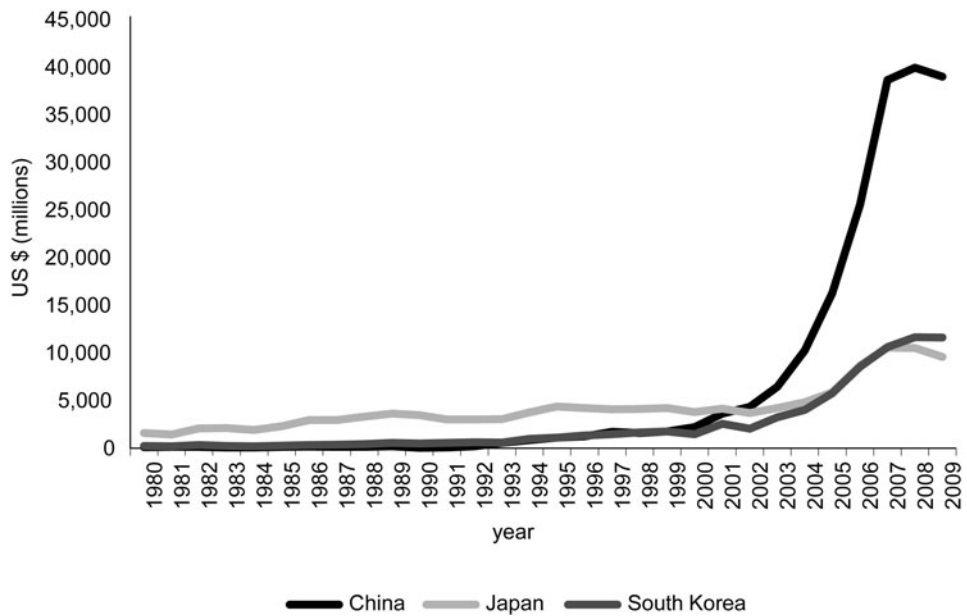


Figure 28.2 India's aggregate trade with China, Japan, and South Korea, 1980–2009
Source: IMF, Direction of Trade Statistics 2010.

their relationship to one that stresses potential commercial collaboration. It is also worth noting that South Korea surpassed Japan.

China

India's economic relations with China have shown tremendous growth potential since 2000, mostly on the basis of bilateral agreements to increase trade. The bilateral growth in trade between India and China has revolved around two clear phenomena—namely, a surge in Chinese manufactured goods exports to India, and India's iron ore and steel exports to China. As shown by this author elsewhere (Sáez and Chang 2010), nearly three-quarters of India's trade with China involves an exchange between Chinese manufactured products and intermediate goods and Indian primary commodities and raw materials.

Although the perception that bilateral trade between India and China could help foster the incentives for mutual understanding, some offered a pessimistic assessment of the likely imbalance in trade between India and China. As Figure 28.3 shows, there is evidence that India is developing growing trade deficits with China.

As Figure 28.3 shows, there has been a notable increase in bilateral trade from India and China. Figure 28.3 shows that India attained a small trade surplus with China from 2003 until 2005. However, since 2005 there has been a substantial reversal in the bilateral trade balance between India and China. India's exports to China began to show a gradual decline after 2007. By 2009, India's trade deficit with China approached US\$20 billion; a sizeable amount given that India's exports to China only surpassed \$10 billion. Given the pattern of China's trade relations in other parts of the world, it is expected that the asymmetry in China's trade relations with India will continue to expand in the future.

As some analysts have pointed out, India and China are likely to be important players in the global economy of the twenty-first century. However, these two economies are hampered by

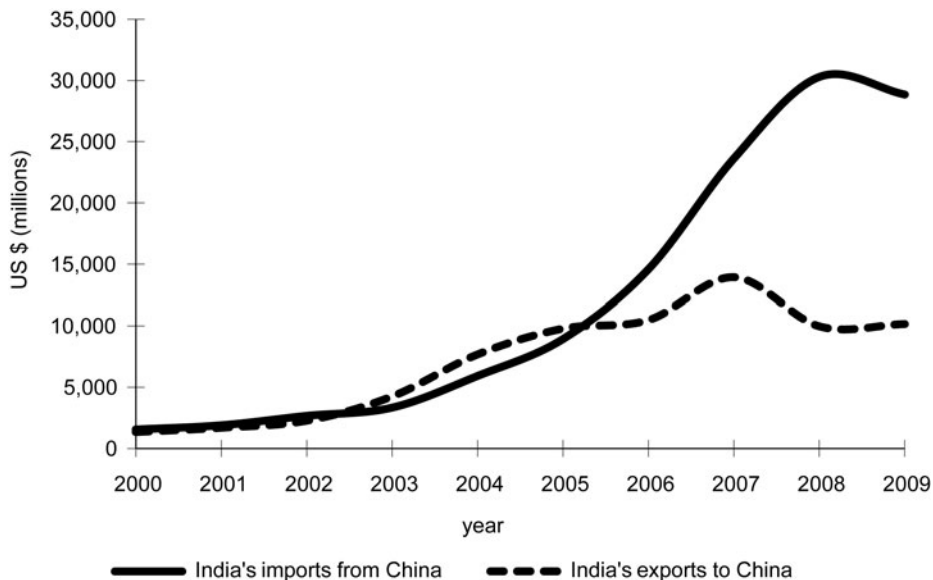


Figure 28.3 India's trade relations with China, 2000–09

Source: IMF, Direction of Trade Statistics 2010.

severe energy security concerns (Sáez 2007). China's and India's energy shortages have heightened the strategic importance of energy supplies. As noted by a strategic analysis by the NATO Parliamentary Assembly (2008), a significant share of China's oil imports passes through the Indian Ocean. Given that nearly three-quarters of India's trade is conducted over blue waters, it is anticipated that there may be a clash between India's and China's strategic and economic imperatives.

Japan

Another interesting development of India's trade relations with other leading Asian economies (e.g. Japan and South Korea) is the rapid transformation in the nature of the bilateral relationship. For instance, as Figure 28.2 shows, Japan and South Korea have not traditionally been strong trade partners with India. With India's gradual economic openness in the 1980s, however, a Japanese firm (Suzuki Motors) was the first foreign market entrant to be allowed to manufacture a car, the Maruti Udyog, in collaboration with the government of India.

Although trade would emerge as an important tool in Japan and South Korea's diplomacy with India, these two economies have been leading donors to India of overseas development assistance (ODA). Given Japan's postwar constitutional restriction on the building of its military capabilities, the country has opted to use ODA as its principal foreign policy tool in dealing with leading Asian countries. The preferred method of delivery of such assistance was through the usage of loans granted through the Japan Bank for International Collaboration. Traditionally China and Southeast Asia (notably Indonesia) have been the largest recipients of Japan's ODA. As China gradually began to decline loans from overseas, India became the largest recipient of Japanese ODA from 2003 onwards.

Following a visit by Japanese Prime Minister Yoshiro Mori in August 2000 and a reciprocal visit by India's Prime Minister Atal Behari Vajpayee, India and Japan have strengthened their relations in other issue areas, including high-level dialogue and science and technology collaboration. The reciprocal visits culminated with the signing of the Japan–India Joint Declaration in 2001 and the Japan–India Economic Partnership Agreement in 2007.

Aside from the important contribution in terms of ODA, Japan's impact on the Indian economy is notable in terms of investment. Japan ranked sixth among the top suppliers of foreign direct investment to India from April 2000 to April 2011.⁷ More significantly, Japan ranks third, behind the USA and Germany, in terms of the number of foreign technology transfer project approvals from August 1991 until August 2008.

South Korea

Similar to the experience with China and Japan, India's economic relations with South Korea have only seen a surge in recent years, particularly in the form of trade and foreign direct investment. If measured in terms of aggregate bilateral trade, by 2009 South Korea ranked third—behind China and Singapore—among all Asian nations trading with India. Given its comparative advantage in this industrial sector, the primary source of South Korea's exports to India is related to the automotive industry. Although India and South Korea did not establish formal diplomatic relations until 1973, South Korea was one of the first countries to manufacture cars in India, notably the Hyundai Santro and Accent.

Like Japan, South Korea has been an important Asian provider of initial foreign direct investment to India. From August 1991 until September 2005, South Korea ranked ninth among all countries providing foreign direct investment in India. By 2008, though, South Korea's ranking

as a provider of foreign direct investment had dropped, relative to other nations.⁸ Following a 2004 visit to India by South Korean President Roo My-hoon, India and South Korea engaged in ministerial discussions to reverse this trend.

The subsequent ministerial discussions have engaged in modalities to negotiate a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement between India and South Korea. Undoubtedly the centerpiece of the bilateral collaboration is a large-scale, flagship investment project—the construction of a \$12 billion fully integrated steel plant in Paradip, Orissa. Once finished, the steel plant, operated by South Korea's industrial giant Posco, would become the single largest foreign direct investment project ever in India.⁹ Phase I of the Posco plant in Paradip was expected to be completed by 2011–12. However, complications emerging from political protests from local farmers who oppose being displaced by the construction of the project have delayed the implementation of this ambitious project.

India's economic relations with South Korea have been transformed also by the recent emergence of India as a global economic power. In one of its first foreign acquisitions, Tata Motors acquired Daewoo Motors' truck manufacturing unit in 2004 (hence renamed Tata Daewoo Commercial Vehicle). Although Tata's acquisition is the first of its kind by an Indian global business firm in South Korea, the transaction represents an important change in India's position within Asia.

Conclusion

In this chapter we have examined India's relations with Asian countries. We have argued that India's relationship with China and Pakistan have traditionally been the core focus of India's foreign policy. However, as a consequence of India's growing emergence as a global superpower, there is a growing realization that it cannot be hampered by traditional regional rivalries. In this sense, India's relations with other Asian countries ought to be based on trade and investment interactions, rather than on military competition.

Notes

- 1 The current member states of SAARC are: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka. The current member states of ASEAN are: Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar (Burma), the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, and Vietnam.
- 2 See for instance, Rollie Lal, 'China's Relations with South Asia,' in Joshua Eisenman, Eric Heginbotham, and Derek Mitchell, eds, *China and the Developing World: Beijing's Strategy for the Twenty-First Century*, Armonk, NY: M.E. Sharpe, 2007, 133–49; also see Lawrence Saez and Crystal Chang, 'China and South Asia: Strategic Implications and Economic Imperatives,' in Lowell Dittmer and George Yu, eds, *China's Policy Towards the New Third World*, Boulder, CO: Lynne Rienner, 2010, 83–108.
- 3 Data on India's share of world exports have been calculated by the author using data from the International Monetary Fund's (IMF) *International Financial Statistics*. Single country and world export data refer to merchandise exports f.o.b.
- 4 For a theoretical treatment of the issue of trade congruence, see Lawrence Saez, 'Trade and Conflict Reduction: Implications for Regional Strategic Stability,' *British Journal of Politics & International Relations* 10, 4 (November 2008): 698–716.
- 5 Data on the relative share of India's aggregate trade with ASEAN countries has been calculated by the author using data from the IMF's *Direction of Trade Statistics*.
- 6 Commodities trade data between India and ASEAN countries have been calculated by the author using data from the United Nations Commodity Trade Statistics Database (UN Comtrade).
- 7 Unless otherwise indicated, data for foreign direct investment inflows to India have been derived from the Department of Industrial Policy and Promotion, Ministry of Commerce and Industry, government of India.

8 Between April 2000 and September 2008, South Korea ranked 16th among all countries providing foreign direct investment to India.

9 In order to assess the magnitude of the project, it is worth noting that cumulative foreign direct investment inflows to India from August 1991 until September 2008 amount to \$96.4 billion.

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THE INDO-PAKISTANI CONFLICT

Sumit Ganguly

What explains the enduring rivalry between India and Pakistan?¹ The two states have gone to war four times since their emergence from the collapse of the British Indian Empire in 1947 (1947–48, 1965, 1971 and 1999). Three of these conflicts involved the disputed state of Jammu and Kashmir.² Despite the significance of this conflict, especially in the aftermath of the overt acquisition of nuclear weapons by both India and Pakistan, the scholarly literature on its origins and evolution remains quite limited.³ This chapter will proffer an explanation for its origins, discuss its key characteristics, examine past efforts at conflict resolution, discuss some recent crises, and suggest possible pathways for its eventual settlement.

Origins and evolution

The roots of this rivalry can be traced to the competing visions of state construction in South Asia.⁴ The primary ethos of the Indian nationalist movement was both civic and secular.⁵ In contrast, the Pakistani nationalist movement was based upon a primordial political vision.⁶ These two competing nationalist projects collided over the status of a Muslim-majority state that abutted their nascent borders. Pakistan, which had been created as the putative homeland of the Muslims of South Asia, insisted that this Muslim-majority state should necessarily be incorporated into its realm. India, with equal fervor, maintained that the state should become part of its political dispensation as an exemplar of the country's secular status.⁷ The dispute has proven to be especially intractable because at least one party to the conflict, Pakistan, does not see the contested issue as being subject to divisibility.⁸ According to its politico-military leadership, the contestation over Kashmir constitutes the 'unfinished business of partition.' Such a position is at least ironic, if not downright intellectually untenable, given that religious affiliation alone could not sustain the unity of Pakistan and culminated in the creation of the state of Bangladesh in 1971.

Indeed, between 1972 and 1989 the Kashmir question in Indo-Pakistani relations, for all practical purposes, had dramatically receded. An indigenous uprising in the Indian-controlled portion of the state in December 1989 enabled Pakistan to resurrect the dormant issue and imbue it with renewed political significance.⁹ From the early 1990s, owing to Pakistan's involvement, it was steadily transformed from a largely domestic political upheaval into a carefully orchestrated, externally supported and ideologically charged extortion racket.¹⁰

Characteristics of the conflicts

Given the extraordinary stakes that both parties have in this conflict and its seeming diplomatic intractability, it is puzzling that all the Indo–Pakistani wars have been marked with much mutual restraint.¹¹ The total battle deaths in all four Indo–Pakistani conflicts have amounted to about 20,000.¹² This number is substantially lower than the toll that the Kashmir insurgency has exacted.¹³ Institutional legacies and personal contacts largely explain such restraint. It is certainly arguable that continued and indeed greater restraint might still characterize future Indo–Pakistani crises because of the mutual possession of nuclear weapons.¹⁴

Mutually accepted restraints on the use of firepower in the first three Indo–Pakistani conflicts explains, in considerable measure, the limited battle deaths that ensued. Such tacit, and even explicit, but informal agreements were possible because of the common colonial legacy of the respective military establishments.¹⁵ In the fourth Indo–Pakistani war, in 1999, such restraint, however, was mostly one-sided. India, the status quo state, exercised considerable restraint in an effort to limit the scope and dimensions of the conflict. To that end, Indian fighter pilots were specifically instructed not to cross the Line of Control, the *de facto* international border in Jammu and Kashmir. Indian restraint, in considerable part, stemmed from concerns about the dangers of escalation. In the future, limitations on the deployment and use of firepower, to the extent that it does occur, will stem less from personal contacts and more from mutual fears and concerns about a possible escalatory spiral especially in the absence of institutional mechanisms designed to limit conflict.¹⁶

Limited tactical and strategic innovations have also characterized all four wars. During the first two wars, in 1947–48 and 1965, both sides relied on World War II battle tactics and strategies. In considerable part, reliance on these strategies stemmed from the common training of Indian and Pakistani military officers during the colonial period. Prior to partition, the vast majority of the officers in both military establishments had served in British Indian colonial forces and had been trained in the identical military academies of the UK. In the third Indo–Pakistani war, General S.H.F.J. Manekshaw, the Chief of Staff of the Indian Army, relied on a blitzkrieg strategy, bypassing Pakistani military strongholds in East Pakistan to quickly seize the capital city of Dacca (later Dhaka) and its environs.¹⁷

In the 1999 Kargil War, the Indian Army resorted to a painstaking effort to dislodge Pakistani forces in well-ensconced mountain redoubts and at considerable human cost.¹⁸

It is also important to underscore that barring some allegations of the torture of Indian prisoners of war in the Kargil conflict, the two sides have adhered to the expectations of international law in all four conflicts.¹⁹ For example, in the aftermath of the 1971 war, which had culminated in the creation of Bangladesh, India repatriated 90,000 Pakistani prisoners of war. Despite the extraordinary brutality that the Pakistani Army had visited on their Bengali compatriots in East Pakistan, Indian forces treated the Pakistani prisoners of war according to the canons of the Geneva Convention.

Efforts at conflict resolution

Neither multilateral nor bilateral efforts to address the origins of and unilateral efforts to end this conflict have met with any significant success. The multilateral efforts to resolve this conflict began with India's initial referral of the Kashmir question to the United Nations (UN) on January 1, 1948. Unfortunately, as recent scholarship has demonstrated, the issue quickly became embroiled in the politics of the Cold War and the UK's keen interest in preserving what it believed were its strategic prerogatives in Pakistan and adjoining regions.²⁰ Worse still, the UK played a critical role in influencing and shaping US policy toward the dispute.

The convoluted discussions that ensued in the UN have been discussed elsewhere. Suffice it to say that none of the proposals that the UN devised proved acceptable to both sides. Most importantly, two critical resolutions of 1948 and 1949, which called upon Pakistan to 'vacate its aggression' and for India to reduce troops in the state to a level compatible with the maintenance of law and order after which a plebiscite would be conducted, were interpreted selectively. Pakistan insisted that India withdraw its troops and a plebiscite be conducted.²¹ Depending on its results, Pakistan would remove its military presence in the state or not. India simultaneously argued that it would not allow a plebiscite to be held until Pakistan returned to the status quo ante. By the early 1960s the UN had lost interest in the conflict.²²

The failure of multilateral negotiations did not end Pakistan's quest for Kashmir. More to the point, because of Cold War considerations, both the UK and the USA remained sympathetic to Pakistan's position on the dispute. Not surprisingly, in the aftermath of the disastrous 1962 Sino-Indian border war, the USA and the UK induced India to enter into a series of bilateral talks to settle the Kashmir dispute with Pakistan.²³ These talks, in turn, ended in a stalemate despite significant Anglo-American pressures on India.

The failure of the multilateral and subsequently bilateral negotiations coupled with India's efforts to integrate its portion of Kashmir into its political order prompted Pakistan to launch a second war with India. For complex reasons the war ended without a clear-cut victory for either side.²⁴

Thanks to Soviet intercession, another set of bilateral talks ensued after the 1965 Indo-Pakistani conflict. These negotiations took place in the then Soviet Central Asian city of Tashkent. Under the terms of the Tashkent Agreement of 1966 the two parties agreed to return to the status quo ante and to eschew the use of force to settle the Kashmir dispute. Also, despite the objections of the Indian military, Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri chose to return the strategic Haji Pir Pass that the Indian forces had captured during the war.²⁵

The peace proved to be short lived. In the aftermath of Pakistan's first free and fair election in 1970 a civil war broke out in East Pakistan owing to the failure of the military and the two principal political parties, the Pakistan People's Party (PPP) and the Awami League (AL), to reach a post-election understanding on power sharing. The Pakistani military sought to suppress brutally the incipient sub-nationalist movement in East Pakistan, resulting in widespread civilian casualties. As a consequence, close to 10 million East Pakistanis sought refuge in India.²⁶

The Indian political leadership under Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, after some deliberation, came to the inexorable conclusion that it was cheaper to resort to war than absorb several million refugees into its already turgid population. Accordingly, she and her advisors in consultation with the military devised a complex politico-military strategy initially to exhaust all reasonable diplomatic initiatives and then embark on a war designed to break up Pakistan. To that end she initially appealed to the great powers to address the ongoing and vicious civil war within East Pakistan and the plight of the refugees in India. Global reactions, however, proved to be quite inadequate and the USA, in particular, showed little interest in exerting pressure on the military regime of General Yahya Khan in Pakistan largely because of its vital role in serving as a conduit for the US diplomatic overture to the People's Republic of China in 1970.²⁷ Faced with this diplomatic impasse, India embarked on a military strategy designed to create a separate state in East Pakistan. The war, which ensued with a Pakistani attack on India's northwestern air force bases in early December, resulted in a complete rout of Pakistani forces and culminated in the creation of the sovereign state of Bangladesh.

Following the war, Indian and Pakistani leaders met at the Indian hill resort of Simla (Shimla) in 1972 to formulate a post-war accord. This agreement, known as the Simla (Shimla) Accord, led to the repatriation of 90,000 Pakistani prisoners of war, the changing of the nomenclature of

the Cease Fire Line (CFL) to the Line of Actual Control (LoC) and to a reiteration of the prior commitment to abjure from the use of force to resolve the Kashmir dispute.²⁸

Between 1972 and 1989, the Kashmir issue became dormant. Pakistan's defeat in the 1971 war clearly established India's military supremacy in the subcontinent.²⁹ More to the point, the creation of Bangladesh undercut the ideological basis of the Pakistani irredentist claim to Kashmir. Religion alone clearly had not served as a sufficient basis for the cohesion of the Pakistani state.

Indeed, were it not for the abrupt eruption of an ethno-religious insurgency in the Indian-administered portion of the state of Jammu and Kashmir, the Kashmir question may have remained undisturbed. Unfortunately, a complex set of social processes and political choices within Kashmir and on the part of the Indian state contributed to a violent domestic uprising in December 1989.³⁰ Sensing an opportunity to exploit the prevailing conditions in the Indian-administered part of the state, Pakistani authorities promptly entered the fray and managed swiftly to transform the indigenous rebellion into a well-financed and carefully supported, religiously inclined extortion racket.³¹

Indian authorities, after some faltering steps, fell back on their time-honored counterinsurgency strategy. This strategy involved the use of substantial coercion followed by the promise of free and fair elections. As a consequence of this strategy India managed to restore a modicum of order if not law in the Kashmir Valley by the mid-1990s.³² Not surprisingly, India's ability to contain the Kashmir insurgency contributed to the next crisis in Indo-Pakistani relations in 1999. Two years after this crisis, the two sides met briefly in Agra outside New Delhi to fashion a strategy to resolve the Kashmir dispute. However, this summit floundered because of differing expectations of how best to tackle the nettlesome Kashmir question.³³

From crisis to crisis

Steadily declining international attention on the Kashmir dispute coupled with the growing success of India's counterinsurgency strategy were, in all likelihood, the two critical factors that led the Pakistani military to embark on a military incursion in the Kargil region of Kashmir in April 1999.³⁴ Indian military and intelligence authorities were slow to ascertain the full extent and scope of the Pakistani military incursions across the LoC.³⁵

Once they became aware of the dimension of the incursions India acted with considerable alacrity and determination to dislodge the invaders. Nevertheless, they chose not to resort to horizontal escalation and limited the use of airpower to the Indian side of the LoC. These decisions, in considerable part, reflected the Indian awareness of and sensitivity to the dangers of conflict escalation. After nearly two months of bitter fighting, Pakistani forces started to lose ground. At this point, Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif of Pakistan abruptly flew to Washington, DC, and met with President Clinton on July 4, 1999, seeking US intervention to terminate the conflict. In the meanwhile, a critical location, Tiger Hill, fell to the onslaught of the Indian forces.

Clinton offered his good offices to end the dispute but held Pakistan squarely responsible for initiating the conflict in the first place, making it clear that the sanctity of the LoC could not be militarily altered.³⁶ Soon thereafter the war drew to a close. However, relations between Sharif and the Chief of Staff of the Pakistan Army, General Pervez Musharraf, became severely strained, culminating in a military coup in October 1999.³⁷

The 2001–02 crisis

Despite Pakistan's failure to internationalize the Kashmir issue to its advantage, it refused to abandon the support for the *jihadis* operating from its soil. This strategy contributed to a brazen

attack by members of two such organizations, the Lashkar-e-Taiba and the Jaish-e-Mohammed, on the Indian Parliament on December 13, 2001. In the immediate aftermath of this attack, India spelled out a series of demands to Pakistan including an immediate dismantling of the jihadi infrastructure. It also recalled its High Commissioner (ambassador) from Islamabad and cut off all travel links to the country. Under sustained pressure both from the USA and India, Pakistani authorities did round up several hundred individuals connected to jihadi organizations and placed some of the leadership thereof under house arrest. Nevertheless, it refused to comply with India's demands to hand over a number of individuals accused of carrying out terrorist attacks on Indian soil. Faced with what it perceived to be Pakistani intransigence, India embarked on a substantial strategy of coercive diplomacy through a massive deployment of firepower on the Indo-Pakistani border.³⁸

Over the next several months, the George W. Bush administration sought to reduce Indo-Pakistani tensions for two compelling reasons. First, it wanted to elicit Pakistan's cooperation to dislodge the Taliban regime in Afghanistan and thereby deny al-Qaeda a safe haven within the country. Second, it was concerned that an Indo-Pakistani conflict could escalate into a full-scale war and culminate in the use of nuclear weapons. Despite its efforts and General Pervez Musharraf's stated commitment to end support for jihadi terrorism emanating from Pakistan, at least two dramatic attacks took place against Indian military installations. As a consequence of these attacks tensions again escalated and the possibility of war loomed large. By the end of the summer, sustained US diplomacy coupled with an Indian recognition that continued military deployments would accomplish little, led to a de-escalation of the crisis.³⁹

In the aftermath of the 2001–02 crisis, the USA continued to urge the two sides to undertake a peace process. Persistent US efforts contributed to the onset of a peace process in 2004. Some reports suggest that the two sides nearly accomplished an important set of breakthroughs on the vexed Kashmir question through this bilateral dialogue.⁴⁰ However, two developments brought these discussions to an abrupt close. First, domestic political developments with Pakistan undermined General Musharraf's authority and led to his eventual ouster. Second, a shocking terrorist attack in late November 2008 in Bombay by Pakistan-based terrorists effectively ended any residual support in India for the peace process.⁴¹

A pathway to peace?

Neither negotiations, whether bilateral or multilateral, nor the use of force, have repeatedly brought the two warring sides to a settlement of the Kashmir question. However, in every case the dispute has evaded a final resolution for a variety of reasons. Sometimes domestic politics have hamstrung leaders and at other times leaders have been unwilling to adhere to their professed commitments. In the meanwhile, a host of seemingly imaginative proposals have surfaced, all of which profess to offer possible solutions to the conflict.⁴²

Given the tortured history of this dispute it is extremely unlikely that it will be resolved through negotiations or another conflict. Owing to its varying levels of success in sustaining the Kashmir insurgency, the Pakistani military establishment has convinced itself that it can ill afford to make concessions on that question.⁴³ On the other hand, successive Indian leaders have also made clear that they will not make territorial concessions to Pakistan. In the end, given the differential economic growth rates of the two states, their divergent institutional capacities and their relative military capabilities, the Kashmir issue will simply recede in significance. Despite Pakistan's proclivity to needle India, the latter's relative material and institutional capabilities will simply enable it to cope with such provocations. Simultaneously, India's ability and willingness to address the underlying grievances of its Kashmiri citizenry, regardless of religious affiliation,

through institutional channels and mechanisms will also significantly reduce Pakistan's capacity for mischief making in the state.⁴⁴

Notes

- 1 For varying theoretical accounts see T.V. Paul, ed., *The Indo-Pakistani Conflict: An Enduring Rivalry*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007.
- 2 For a discussion, see Sumit Ganguly, *Conflict Unending: India-Pakistan Tensions Since 1947*, New York: Columbia University Press, 2001.
- 3 See, for example, Russell Brines, *The Indo-Pakistani Conflict*, New York: Pall Mall, 1968; Leo E. Rose and Richard Sisson, *War and Secession: Pakistan, India and the Creation of Bangladesh*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 1990; Robert Victor Jackson, *South Asian Crisis: India, Pakistan and Bangla Desh: A Political and Historical Analysis of the 1971 War*, New York: Praeger, 1975; and Sisir Gupta, *Kashmir: A Study in India-Pakistan Relations*, London: Asia Publishing House, 1966.
- 4 For an early and useful discussion see Paul R. Brass, *Language, Religion and Politics in North India*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1974.
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INDIA AND NUCLEAR WEAPONS

Kanti Bajpai

India's attitude to nuclear weapons, like the attitude of other nuclear powers, has been marked by ambivalence: that it waited 24 years between its first test of nuclear weapons in 1974 and its second set of tests in 1998 is testimony to this viewpoint. Two questions are central to this essay: first, what factors encouraged India to develop nuclear weapons and what other factors discouraged it?; second, after the nuclear tests of 1998, what is the nature of India's nuclear arsenal and doctrine, and how has India come to view the usefulness of nuclear weapons for its security?

India's nuclear history can be divided into the following phases: from 1947 to 1964, 1965 to 1974, 1975 to 1983, 1984 to 1998, 1999 to 2002, and from 2002 onwards. This division finds its justification in a number of defining moments in India's external relations, domestic politics, and nuclear capabilities.

Nehruvian beginnings: 1947 to 1964

The first phase of India's nuclear history is defined by Prime Minister Jawarharlal Nehru and Homi Bhabha, the physicist entrusted with running the country's nascent atomic energy program. From 1947 to 1964, Nehru and Bhabha charted the course, keeping in mind both the civilian and military applications of atomic energy. Nehru's deepest instincts were repulsed by nuclear weapons. The horror of Hiroshima and Nagasaki was the most important influence on him. That the rivalry between the USA and the Soviet Union, in the wake of World War II, extended to a competition over nuclear weapons deepened his anxieties about a technology that held great promise for mankind as a seemingly limitless source of energy, but which also could end life on the planet if used as a weapon. While the two superpowers stated that nuclear weapons were deterrents and had no real military value, Nehru's reading of history suggested that, like the balance of power, which had failed to hold back war in 1914 and 1939, deterrence was flawed.

At the same time, Nehru ruefully acknowledged that nuclear weapons were sources of prestige in world politics and a bolster to security in facing a nuclear opponent or an overwhelmingly superior conventional army. Thus, while he insisted that India would not develop nuclear weapons, he noted that circumstances might force the country to change its mind (Raja Mohan 2003: 7–9; Nayar and Paul 2004: 155–57). He therefore allowed Bhabha to build up a nuclear program that had both civilian and military uses. He also shielded the program from

public scrutiny. Nehru ensured that Bhabha and the scientists reported directly to him, and he passed the Atomic Energy Act under which it was incumbent on nuclear scientists and officials not to divulge information on the program.

Internationally, Nehru was dedicated to the cause of nuclear and general disarmament. Throughout his tenure as prime minister he worked creatively and assiduously to convince the nuclear powers and the international community to get rid of nuclear weapons, to limit arsenals, and to constrain, if not stop, testing. He was both practical and visionary in his pronouncements, arguing that small steps towards disarmament were essential given that the insecurities of the great powers would not allow them to divest themselves of their bombs in one single, dramatic moment (Bajpai 2003: 353–93).

Nuclear activism: 1965 to 1974

When Nehru died in 1964, two years after India had been defeated by China in the border war, India was not a nuclear weapons power. However, it had clearly come quite a long way. Before his death in January 1966, Bhabha, in a radio interview, revealed that India was in a position to build a weapon in about 18 months (Nayar and Paul 2004: 172). Nehru, the champion of nuclear abstinence, must have been aware of the amount of progress made under Bhabha.

Lal Bahadur Shastri succeeded Nehru in 1964 and initiated a change in the country's nuclear policy. Before and after the war with China, there were those who had argued that nuclear weapons were vital in the competition and conflict with Beijing. There was consternation in India when China tested its first nuclear device at Lop Nor in 1964. Nehru had not, even after the war and in the wake of China's test, succumbed to the pressure to go nuclear. Shastri took a different view, and upon taking office, ordered India's nuclear scientists to work on a subterranean nuclear explosion or SNEP (Raja Mohan 2003: 10). If Bhabha's 18-month estimate was correct, then India might have been in a position to test in 1966. However, in September 1965 India went to war with Pakistan, once again over Kashmir. The great powers, and particularly the Soviet Union, helped arrange a ceasefire with Pakistan. At the summit with Pakistani President Ayub Khan in Tashkent in January 1966, which had been organized by the Soviets, Shastri signed the so-called Tashkent Declaration—and within hours died in his sleep.

Shastri was succeeded by Indira Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru's daughter. Mrs Gandhi stopped the SNEP from going forward, although it is not clear why she did so. The death of Shastri and Bhabha in January 1966 may have induced a sense of strategic caution. Also, India had just signed the Tashkent agreement under the watchful eyes of its ally, the Soviet Union. For India to test so soon after this event would have been embarrassing to Moscow which, with the USA, was in any case preparing to launch the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT), a treaty that India had originally sponsored. The USA was a serious concern. India's economic situation was precarious, and in particular it was beset by chronic shortages of foodgrain. Only the USA could help out. Testing a nuclear weapon risked their wrath, and relations with the USA were already strained after the 1965 war with Pakistan and as a result of Mrs Gandhi's sharp criticisms of US policies in Vietnam (Nayar and Paul 2004: 168–75). Anxious to appear constructive and to hew to a Nehruvian policy, Mrs Gandhi explored the possibility of India signing the NPT in exchange for security guarantees from the nuclear powers. In the event, India did not get any guarantees and did not sign the treaty in 1968 when it was opened for signature (Raja Mohan 2003: 9).

Nor, however, did New Delhi test. To test at this stage would have dealt the NPT a death blow and would have put India at odds with the great powers and many other international friends. Economic worries predominated—the food situation was not good, the rupee devaluation urged by the USA had been disastrous, and there were shortages and stagnation in the economy.

Additionally, Mrs Gandhi's political position was weak. In the 1967 elections her party had been unable to secure a majority for the first time, and in 1969 the party split over her leadership (Nayar and Paul 2004: 168–75). There was also the state of the nuclear program itself. Vikram Sarabhai, Bhabha's successor, was not enthusiastic about testing. Further, the amount of fissile material available to India was small (Nuclear Weapon Archive n.d.). To use it in testing might have been risky.

Two years later, things had changed, at least politically. Mrs Gandhi was in full control of the Congress Party, and in February 1971 she won a massive electoral victory. However, events outside India now played a role. War clouds with Pakistan were once again on the horizon after Islamabad cracked down brutally on East Pakistani separatists. By late March 1971 Mrs Gandhi had set in motion plans to support the armed resistance in 'Bangladesh,' and to prepare for a liberation war. In December 1971 the Indian Army and East Pakistani resistance fighters defeated the Pakistani Army in the east and brought Bangladesh into existence.

With war behind her, Mrs Gandhi ordered India's nuclear scientists to go ahead with a nuclear test in September 1972 (Nuclear Weapon Archive n.d.). Sarabhai had died in December 1971, and the scientists were eager to proceed. The test was carried out on May 6, 1974, roughly 18 months after it had been ordered. Why Mrs Gandhi tested when she did is unknown, given the veil of silence over these matters, but the most likely explanations are that: after the Chinese test of 1964, this was the first time India felt it was opportune to do so given the international and domestic situation; and the US Navy's presence in the Bay of Bengal during the Bangladesh War convinced Mrs Gandhi that she must demonstrate India's resilience. The test was a signal not just to the USA. India had signed a 25-year treaty of friendship and cooperation with the Soviet Union in 1971 as a hedge against Chinese and US intervention in the war, and the tests may have been a way of showing Moscow as well as the world at large that India was not a Soviet camp follower (Nayar and Paul 2004: 181).

Nuclear quietism: 1975 to 1983

Despite the tests, India chose not to become an overt and full-fledged nuclear weapon power. It had tested one nuclear device, declared the test a success, and rejected any thought of joining the NPT, but it did not proceed with a declared weapons program. Once again, the issue of the amount of fissile material may have held India back, at least in the 1970s. Mrs Gandhi may also have harbored Nehru-like notions of global restraint and disarmament and have chosen therefore to abstain from weaponizing. In any case, domestic politics quickly assailed her, and in 1975 she declared a national Emergency as a way of dealing with intensifying protests in northern India. In 1977, however, she changed her mind on dictatorial rule and opted for general elections, in which she was voted out of power.

The hastily formed Janata Party was preoccupied with running the disparate coalition that had won the elections. Morarji Desai, Mrs Gandhi's old foe and a former congressman, was prime minister for most of the next three years. Desai was anti-nuclear and firmly opposed further testing. Like Nehru and other prime ministers before him, though, he did protect the nuclear program: he ordered scientists to refine weapons designs (Nuclear Weapon Archive n.d.), and when US President Jimmy Carter tried to get India to sign the NPT in 1978, he was blunt in saying no.

By 1980, the Janata government had collapsed, and the electorate, tired of the squabbling coalition, had voted Mrs Gandhi back into power. India's policy of nuclear ambivalence continued. In 1982–83 Mrs Gandhi ordered the scientists to prepare for another test. Within hours she had changed her mind and stopped the preparations. To the scientists' dismay, she ignored their requests for a test (Chengappa 2000: 246–61; Perkovich 2000: 242–44).

Geopolitics and economics may have caused her to change her mind. The Soviets had invaded Afghanistan in December 1979, and Mrs Gandhi was uncomfortable with their presence in South Asia. While she refused to criticize Moscow publicly, she made her feelings clear to the Soviets. In addition, Ronald Reagan had become US president in 1981, and Mrs Gandhi was hoping to open a new chapter with the USA. In part this was to indicate her displeasure with the Soviets; in part, she had economics on her mind. The Indian economy was moribund and desperately needed trade, technology, and investment. The West, led by the USA, was virtually the only source of all three (Nayar and Paul 2004: 191–94).

Nuclear activism resumed: 1984 to 1998

In October 1984 Mrs Gandhi was assassinated by her Sikh bodyguards in retaliation for the Indian Army's storming of the Golden Temple to flush out armed militants. The country went back to the polls, and Mrs Gandhi's older son, Rajiv, was elected by a massive margin.

Rajiv Gandhi was determined to set a new course for India in economics, politics, foreign policy, and national security. Even as he tried to liberalize the economy and solve the militancy in Punjab and Assam, he turned his attention to national security and foreign policy. Among his initiatives were the speeding up of India's missile program, authorizing scientists to complete nuclear weaponization, and improving relations with both the USA and Pakistan (Raja Mohan 2003: 11; Nayar and Paul 2004: 198–200). However, India once again stopped short of testing and declaring itself a nuclear weapon power. The new prime minister wanted a much stronger relationship with the USA for both geopolitical and economic reasons. He also wanted to repair relations with Pakistan. For India to test and to go nuclear overtly would have alienated both countries and brought these initiatives to naught.

In the meantime, in 1988 Rajiv presented a plan to the United Nations (UN) for complete nuclear disarmament to be carried out in phases. The plan may have been intended to enhance the youthful prime minister's place on the world stage and to distract attention from India's nuclear and missile program, but it was more likely an attempt to bring India back into a more constructive dialogue on nuclear weapons and out of the gun sights of the non-proliferation lobbies in the West.

Rajiv Gandhi lost power to his former minister of defense, V.P. Singh, in the 1989 elections. During the 1990 crisis between India and Pakistan, the USA warned New Delhi that Islamabad may have loaded nuclear weapons onto its F-16 aircraft. Though this was never confirmed—it seems that the USA may have been too alarmist—V.P. Singh seemed to suggest that India would retaliate with nuclear weapons if Pakistan chose to use nuclear weapons in a shooting war. Singh also authorized a review of India's nuclear status (Chari *et al.* 2008: 99–103).

No Indian leader after Desai seriously opposed nuclear weapons. On the other hand, no one chose to test or to order full weaponization. As in the past, a series of domestic and international events and considerations made it awkward for India's leaders to go nuclear outright. Among the domestic problems constraining the program were the rise and fall of governments from 1989 onwards. Rajiv's government had given way to that of V.P. Singh, and Singh's government soon gave way to Chandrashekhar's. By 1991 India was ready to vote once more. In the ensuing election campaign, Rajiv was assassinated, but the Congress Party returned to power under P.V. Narasimha Rao.

Rao faced a number of domestic challenges. He had come to power at the head of an extremely shaky minority government. While the Punjab militancy was winding down, the Kashmir problem, which had flared in 1989, was now at its height. Worse, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), with substantial public support, was demanding that the Babri Masjid, a shrine

claimed by Muslims and Hindus, be made the site of a Hindu temple in honor of the Hindu deity Ram. The campaign had led to riots, and on December 6, 1992, the Babri Masjid was torn down by Hindu militants. Finally, India's economy was in a parlous state: hard currency reserves had dwindled alarmingly, and the country was nearly bankrupt.

Rao became prime minister at a difficult time geopolitically as well. With the end of the Cold War, India was left adrift. The USA and China, neither of which had been terribly friendly to India, had come out triumphant, as had Pakistan, which had played a role in the Soviet withdrawal from Afghanistan. The Western alliance was rampant, and among its concerns were human rights and nuclear proliferation. India figured as a problem in both areas. India's actions in Punjab and Kashmir were criticized from a human rights perspective, and the momentum to extend the life of the NPT in perpetuity and to write a Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty (CTBT) gathered steam. India was an obstruction in both endeavors (even though it was not a signatory to the NPT and had supported the idea of a CTBT). In the end, New Delhi was rather modest in its criticism of the first, and as for the second, it refused to sign the treaty, arguing that the CTBT in its current form was not in its security interests (Ghose 1997).

Many in the Indian strategic community urged Rao to test and to weaponize to strengthen India's security, status, and susceptibility to pressures. In 1995 Rao finally ordered the nuclear scientists to prepare for a test. The USA spotted the preparations and confronted Rao with evidence, leading him to stop the tests (Chengappa 2000: 31; Perkovich 2000: 365–71). However, perhaps he had intended to be discovered, to make a point: if India were pushed too hard on a range of issues, it might be forced to go overtly nuclear. Perhaps the aim was to get a fix on US satellites so that when India finally chose to test it might evade detection (as occurred in 1998). Perhaps, finally, his aim was to rally public opinion to his side rather than, as happened, to alienate the public which saw him as weak and vacillating.

Whatever Rao's motives in calling off the test, India was clearly in a vulnerable position in the 1990s. To test at this juncture would have increased the pressures on India to acquiesce in the permanent extension of the NPT and perhaps even in signing the CTBT. India's economy was its Achilles heel. The reforms that Rao and Finance Minister Manmohan Singh had started in 1991 in the wake of the crisis were just beginning to restore economic health. Sanctions and other pressures at this juncture might have derailed the process they had set in motion.

In 1996 Rao ended his term, and the BJP briefly came to power—for 13 days. The BJP government was led by Atal Behari Vajpayee, whose party had consistently supported the idea of going nuclear. Vajpayee ordered a test as soon as he came to office, only to be told by the scientists that given the precariousness of his government it would be unwise to proceed. He concurred and rescinded the order (Chengappa 2000: 31–32). Vajpayee was replaced by H.D. Deve Gowda and I.K. Gujral. Both prime ministers considered testing but eventually drew back (Chengappa 2000: 390–407). In 1998, as the Gowda-Gujral governments faltered and fell, the BJP returned to power at the head of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA). Within days of taking office, Vajpayee ordered the five tests that were carried out on May 11 and 13, 1998.

Vajpayee had long believed in an Indian deterrent, and so it was logical enough that he would take the decision to test, but why so early in his second tenure at the head of a fairly tenuous government? Domestic politics may have been one reason: his hold on power, within his party and the coalition, was again rather fragile, but this time he may have calculated that testing would strengthen his hand. Officially, though, India pointed at Pakistan's test of a longer-range missile, the *Ghauri*, in early April as the reason for the decision. New Delhi also argued that proliferation in its neighborhood and the deteriorating security situation in South

Asia had forced it to test. In a letter to US President Clinton, Vajpayee suggested that China was a major security concern.

At any rate, Vajpayee and Brajesh Mishra, the national security advisor, were not deterred by arguments about domestic instabilities, geopolitical constraints, and economic crisis that had seemingly bound the hands of their predecessors. Indeed, they turned these contentions on their heads. The vagaries of domestic politics might again lead Vajpayee's government to collapse before its full term; better, then, to test at the start of his term. Geopolitical pressures on India should not stop the tests; instead, India must assert itself against hostile or indifferent powers. As for the economy, by 1998 it had improved considerably. In any case New Delhi's calculations were that sanctions and other embargos would be temporary and not terribly costly. The lure of doing business with India would soon trump proliferation concerns in Western capitals and boardrooms.

Post-test crises and responses: 1999 to 2002

Vajpayee and Mishra's assessments were largely correct. The tests helped stabilize Vajpayee's hold on power, at least initially. To unseat him or his government at this time would have been regarded as unpatriotic. The tests and the Kargil War with Pakistan that followed helped the NDA to a second electoral victory, in a snap midterm poll in 1999. Geopolitically, India lost little. Indeed, the dialogue between US Assistant Secretary of State Strobe Talbott and Indian Foreign Minister Jaswant Singh deepened India-USA understanding (Talbott 2004). The sanctions and embargos did not affect India greatly. Foreign investment and business continued to come to India, and the economy grew faster than ever.

The immediate regional consequences of India's tests were instability and violence. Indian and Pakistani leaders used intemperate and threatening language. Islamabad feared that New Delhi, with Israel's help, would attack its nuclear facilities. Both governments moved ballistic missiles around, fearing preventive attacks (Ganguly and Hagerty 2005: 127–32). On May 28, 1999, Pakistan responded with six tests of its own, but continued to worry about a disarming attack. In the same month Pakistani militants and troops were discovered across the Line of Control in the Kargil region of Kashmir. The ensuing conflict ended in an Indian victory but was clearly a shock. To compound matters, a series of terrorist attacks by Pakistani or Pakistani-backed militants occurred in different parts of India. In sum, whereas nuclear weapons promised greater security, India had been plunged into war and internal violence.

Then, on December 13, 2001, terrorists tried to storm India's Parliament while it was in session. The attack failed, but India responded by mobilizing half a million troops on its western border with Pakistan. War seemed imminent, and both sides gestured at their nuclear weapons as they threatened each other. Fortunately, neither nuclear nor conventional war occurred. On the other hand, terrorist provocations continued. President Pervez Musharraf promised to stop terrorists operating in and from Pakistan, but in May 2002 terrorists struck again, killing off-duty personnel and their families in their barracks. Vajpayee once more threatened war, and once more Pakistan promised to rein in the militants. It took some rather strenuous efforts by the USA to strengthen the forces of stability on both sides of the border (Chari *et al.* 2008: 164–71).

The Kargil War and the crises of 2001–02 raised the question of the effect of nuclear weapons on India's security. Nuclear optimists argued that nuclear weapons had kept war limited in 1999 and had stopped the two nations, and in particular India, from starting war in 2001–02. Nuclear pessimists argued that nuclear weapons encouraged Kargil-like confrontations by ruling out war: if Pakistan did not have nuclear weapons in 1999, India would have been free to declare war across a wide front and to end the insurgency in Kashmir. Similarly, faced

with the possibility of full-scale war, perhaps Pakistan would not have allowed terrorist groups to attack with such impunity (on the war and crisis, see Ganguly and Hagerty 2005; Chari *et al.* 2008; and Ganguly and Kapur 2009).

In the wake of 2001–02, the Indian Army concluded that the ponderous nature of its striking ability had given Pakistan and the international community time to head off a punitive attack. The Army therefore began to prepare itself for a ‘cold start’ to allow it to hit deep into Pakistan at very short notice (Ladwig 2007/08). This thinking was based on the view that nuclear weapons would constrain Pakistan militarily and that attacks which respected Islamabad’s ‘red lines’ or thresholds would discourage escalation. Since India had more nuclear weapons, greater strategic depth, and larger conventional forces, military strategists argued, it would have ‘escalation dominance.’ Pakistan, whatever its rhetoric, would therefore choose to control the scope of fighting. Critics suggested that the armed forces were not ready for cold start and that the doctrine was dangerously provocative. In any case, cold start has never been publicly approved by the Indian government, and by 2011 there were signs that the Indian Army was rethinking the doctrine. With China’s growing economic and military power, India is increasingly concerned about the possibility of a two-front challenge in which both adversaries have nuclear weapons. In this situation, cold start, already controversial, is increasingly problematic.

India as a nuclear weapon power

Finally, it is necessary to ask how India is placed as a nuclear weapon power and how India’s strategic community views nuclear weapons.

India does not officially give figures on fissile material production or the number of nuclear weapons in its arsenal. International estimates put the number of weapons at 40–120 (Arms Control Association 2007; Nuclear Threat Initiative n.d.). It is unclear, after the 1998 tests, whether or not India has successfully designed and produced a thermonuclear (or hydrogen) bomb. The fusion device in the 1998 tests most likely ‘fizzled,’ with the primary explosion having failed to ignite the secondary, fusion explosion (Ganguly and Hagerty 2005: 124–25; Nuclear Threat Initiative n.d.). If this is correct, then India’s nuclear force may currently be made up of fission devices of various sizes. On miniaturization, it is not known if India has proceeded with making smaller, tactical weapons that might be loaded as artillery or on cruise missiles. Nor is it known how India keeps its nuclear weapons. For many years it was assumed that the fissile cores are kept separate from the triggers and that these in turn are separate from the delivery vehicles. There is pressure from sections of India’s nuclear scientists and armed forces for more tests, in the interest of reliability and further miniaturization, and the government has not ruled this out (Karnad 2008: 63–71). Scientific advances in computer-based virtual testing, the punitive clauses in the India–US nuclear agreement, general international opprobrium on testing, and larger geopolitical factors will influence Indian decision making on more testing.

Nuclear weapons require delivery vehicles. India has Russian and European aircraft which can deliver nuclear weapons, though as things stand none of these aircraft has the range to make it into the Chinese heartlands (India is acquiring mid-air refueling capability, but to refuel nuclear-loaded aircraft risks accidents and makes them vulnerable to interdiction). India also has a number of ground-launched missiles that could carry nuclear weapons, the latest of which, the long-range *Agni* missiles, could reach parts of China. It does not yet have a truly intercontinental ballistic missile or submarine-launched ballistic missiles (SLBMs). India’s short-range *Prithvi* missile is liquid fuelled which means that it is slow to ready and fire. However, its newer and longer-range *Agni* missiles are solid fuelled. India now has the *Agni I* through *Agni V*, which have a range of 700km–5,000km. An *Agni VI*, with a range of up to 10,000km, may be under development. At

least some of these will be mobile, either on trucks or on rail. A nuclear-powered submarine is on the anvil, but so far India has relied on nuclear submarines on lease from the Soviets (which it deployed in the 1980s, but which did not have SLBMs on board). The 700-km submarine-launched ballistic missile, which has undergone some testing, will have a range of 5,000km–6,000km in its final version. India also has the Brahmos supersonic cruise missile with a range of 300km (Karnad 2008: 63–106).

The Indian strategic community sees nuclear weapons as do other strategic communities: primarily as deterrents. On August 17, 1999, India published a draft nuclear doctrine which was written by the National Security Advisory Board (NSAB) under the chairmanship of the doyen of its strategic community, K. Subrahmanyam. While the precise status of this document is unclear—the government characterized it as a recommendation and did not declare it to be India's official doctrine—it nonetheless provides a window into Indian thinking. The doctrine insists that India will have a credible minimum nuclear deterrent and that nuclear weapons will only be used in retaliation for nuclear strikes against India or, in a later modification, if India is hit by biological or chemical weapons. The doctrine commits India to a policy of No First Use and of non-use against those who do not have nuclear weapons. Ultimately, the use of nuclear weapons will depend on the authority of the prime minister or his designated successor. To increase the credibility of its deterrent, India will develop a triad of land-, air-, and sea-based retaliatory forces. Finally, to ensure that nuclear weapons do not fall into the wrong hands, that they are not damaged or fired accidentally, and that they are not used in an unauthorized manner, the doctrine notes that all appropriate command and control measures will be designed and made operational.

The Indian government has slowly put in place the organizational infrastructure for a nuclear weapons program. It has created a Strategic Forces Command (SFC), which is responsible for the deployment, targeting, and use of nuclear weapons and the structuring of nuclear forces. It has also constituted a Strategic Policy Group (SPG) in the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC) to coordinate amongst nuclear scientists, the government, and the military on overall nuclear planning. A retired three-star general in the Prime Minister's Office is in charge of the Special Projects Group which deals with nuclear policies and postures and coordinates with other agencies and the military. While nuclear weapons will ultimately be launched by the armed forces, the command to launch will come from the SFC. The prime minister through the National Security Council will authorize the chairman of the Chiefs of Staff Committee, who in turn will authorize the Commander in Chief of the SFC. In case the top leadership has been eliminated by a 'bolt from the blue' nuclear attack, commanders in the field will have the discretion to retaliate. Various other command and control features have seemingly been implemented, including a Red Book for nuclear war and crises, a four-stage alert ladder, a 'two-man' rule for arming and launching nuclear weapons, communication systems immune to electromagnetic pulses (which are let loose by nuclear explosions), two fall-back National Command Authority (NCA) centers, and the psychological vetting of military officers connected to nuclear weapons use (Karnad 2008: 92–105).

There are differences in the strategic community on the appropriate numbers and types of weapons and the state of readiness of nuclear weapons. Thus, a minimalist school of thought argues that minimum deterrence implies preventing a nuclear attack by Pakistan and China and that a force of 60–140 weapons in the 20-kiloton range will suffice. These weapons will be air, land, and sea launched and should have the range to hit China. Minimalists discount the necessity of investing in thermonuclear bombs and in tactical, war-fighting weapons. Some minimalists argue the case for a de-alerted posture in which the fissile core, the warhead trigger, and the delivery vehicle are 'de-mated' and only assembled in the event of crisis (Bajpai 2000).

Maximalists, by contrast, regard a force of fewer than 400–450 weapons as being incommensurate with India's strategic position. Further, these weapons should span the spectrum from battlefield and other tactical weapons to thermonuclear bombs. Maximalists firmly reject any kind of de-alerted posture, which they regard as vulnerable to a first strike, particularly by the three great nuclear powers—the USA, Russia, and China. This reveals a crucial difference. Some maximalists regard all the nuclear powers as potential threats to India's security and would therefore have New Delhi plan for a much bigger arsenal, with intercontinental ballistic missile capability (ICBM) and a 'classical' posture of alertness and readiness (Bajpai 2000).

What of public opinion on nuclear weapons? At least in Nehru's time and the early years of Indira Gandhi, Indian opinion tended to be against the development of nuclear weapons although a substantial minority always supported weaponization. Amongst India's political parties, there were no serious objectors except for the communist parties, particularly the Communist Party of India (Marxist). Within the armed forces, opinion gradually shifted. Up to the 1960s, Indian officers were skeptical about the utility of nuclear weapons. Inter-service rivalries may have played a part in this skepticism—each service may have worried that its relative standing would decline if the other got control of the bomb. Many officers thought that India's conventional weapons program needed far greater attention and that the bomb would be a distraction. Then, too, there was a certain degree of distaste for nuclear weapons, which were not regarded as true weapons of war (Bhatia 1979). Thus, it was only in 1983 that the service chiefs submitted in writing their view that India must have nuclear weapons (Nuclear Weapon Archive n.d.).

Nevertheless, by 1974 and in the two decades thereafter, virtually all sectors of Indian opinion swung behind the idea of weaponization. Opposition to the NPT remained uniformly high, even amongst those who opposed nuclear weapons, but support for a nuclear program slowly expanded and solidified. That said, the Indian public has a rather nuanced position. When asked how important nuclear weapons are in relation to several other issues before the country—economic growth, employment, inflation, communal peace, and social justice—respondents generally rank nuclear weapons very low. This suggests that Indians support a nuclear weapons program but not a terribly ambitious one (Cortright and Mattoo 1996: 118).

Conclusion

The future of India's nuclear weapons program remains somewhat obscure, though the broad shape of India's force structure and doctrine are visible enough. With the exception of Pakistan amongst the declared weapons powers, there is probably no nuclear weapon program in the world more shrouded in secrecy (Israel is not a declared weapons power). Whether or not such secrecy enhances deterrence and military stability is debatable.

India signed a nuclear deal with the USA in 2008, which opened its civilian nuclear reactors to international inspection and which allowed it to trade globally in nuclear technology and materials, including reprocessing technologies. However, as of 2012, India seems to have gained very little materially from the agreement, though its *de facto* status as a nuclear weapon power has been enhanced. The international community remains suspicious of India's reprocessing plans and is largely opposed to the nuclear liability bill passed by the Indian Parliament in August 2010. In addition, while India has lobbied to be a member of the various non-proliferation 'clubs'—the Nuclear Suppliers Group, the Missile Technology Control Regime, the Wassenaar Arrangement, and the Australia Group—it has yet to be admitted to these regimes.

What have nuclear weapons achieved strategically for India? War, both nuclear and full-scale conventional, has been avoided, but terrorists continue to hit India with impunity, most recently and tragically in Mumbai on November 26, 2008. Pakistan has gone back on virtually

all the promises it made in 2001–02 about discouraging terrorism. Nuclear weapons have given Pakistan a sense that it can support terrorists from its territory without fear of costly retribution since India cannot risk a conflict getting out of hand.

Indian strategists argue that the fear of nuclear conflagration cuts both ways and that New Delhi can make war, at least up to a certain threshold, if it is pushed to do so (Chari *et al.* 2008: 198). A punitive strike, built around a cold start attack, is India's threatened response. The 2008 terrorist strike in Mumbai might have been the occasion to mount a punitive retaliatory attack. New Delhi may have felt, however, that an attack would have worsened the situation for the embattled civilian government of Pakistan, that the diplomatic gains of restraint were advantage enough, that the cold start posture was simply not ready to be used, or that punitive strikes were too dangerous because of the escalatory potential.

Not surprisingly, India's attitude to nuclear weapons remains ambivalent. Nuclear weapons are seen as a security necessity against Pakistan and China. Nuclear weapons are also regarded as status symbols in a world where permanent membership of the UN Security Council, the most visible indicator of global status, rests with the declared nuclear powers. On the other hand, the record of nuclear weapons giving India security and status is mixed at best. Nuclear war and large-scale conventional war have been avoided, but crisis, war and near-war, and terrorism have not. The nuclear tests gave India considerable publicity for a few years and made India a rather intimate interlocutor of the USA on strategic matters, but sustained interest in India has come not from nuclear weapons but rather from India's economic performance and potential in the wake of its reforms.

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INDIA'S EVOLVING SECURITY STRATEGY

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The texture of international security has been defined historically by the rise and fall of great powers. In the coming decades, the economic growth of Asia's engines, China and India, may define the patterns of conflict and cooperation in the international system. Indeed, India's impressive economic growth since the 1990s has poised it potentially to emerge as one of the twenty-first century's most powerful nations. Military power has traditionally flowed from economic growth: except for economic powers that were protected by a superpower such as Japan and Germany during the Cold War, all major economic powers have ultimately channeled their wealth toward hard military capabilities. If it chooses to follow the path of other rising powers, India may thus have a significant impact on regional and international security.

This chapter explores both the drivers and the content of India's evolving security strategy with respect to both its major immediate neighbors—Pakistan and China—as well as toward the present hegemon, the USA. Two features define India's approach to its security strategy, one ideational and one structural. Ideationally, the enduring feature of India's worldview has been the concept of 'strategic autonomy'—the post-Cold War incarnation of non-alignment. While most of the developing world subjugated their Independence to one of the two superpowers during and after the Cold War, India markedly has refused to do so. This conception of strategic Independence shapes India's aspirations toward global affairs. However, the goal of achieving strategic autonomy is mitigated by the second feature of India's security strategy: sclerotic domestic institutions and bureaucracies that serve as a structural impediment to realizing its full indigenous and military potential. These twin features of India's evolving security posture imply that while Delhi might continue to assert its autonomy in strategic affairs, domestic political impediments will significantly slow the pace at which it can do so and complicate Delhi's ability to formulate coherent strategies that align with India's ambitions. After describing these drivers of India's evolving security strategy, I will illustrate how they are shaping India's security approach toward Pakistan, China, and the USA.

Drivers of India's security strategy

Since Independence and under both major political parties—Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)—India has had a strong tradition of what was once termed non-alignment but which is now described as 'strategic autonomy' (Staniland and Narang 2012). Many developing world

countries and, indeed, even major powers such as Japan and Germany during the Cold War, sacrificed their Independence for the sake of superpower protection. India chose not to do so, largely because its subjugation as a colonial power imbued within Nehru an unwavering preference for strategic autonomy and self-reliance. Amitabh Mattoo writes that 'the two pillars of Nehru's grand strategy were Non-Alignment and Self-Reliance, both sharing a close symbiotic relationship.'¹ Indeed, according to Stephen Cohen, Nehru was even 'reluctan[t] to join with another major power (such as the United States) to develop India's military potential.'² That is, Nehru had a clear prioritization of strategic ends: autonomy trumped even the need for hard military power.

This preference for strategic autonomy has been a recurrent feature under an array of Indian prime ministers with substantially different domestic platforms, including Indira Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi, Atal Bihari Vajpayee of the BJP, and Manmohan Singh. Indira Gandhi explicitly said, 'there are people in our country who think that we could ally ourselves with some people and perhaps that way we would be safer. I do not think that such borrowed strength can be real strength ... the only security is to strengthen our own people and to be confident of ourselves.'³ Although more militant and more willing to take arms from the Soviet Union than her father, Indira Gandhi expressed an unwavering belief in strategic autonomy. Indeed, Shashi Tharoor concludes that 'every pronouncement by her [Indira] on the animating principles of her foreign policy stressed the concept of Independence.'⁴ Although there are very real differences in the worldviews of the Congress and BJP, it is noteworthy that Vajpayee as foreign minister during the Janata government and later as prime minister, evinced little deviation from this bedrock principle. He noted that 'after freeing itself of the clutches of imperialism, a great country like India could not possibly become a camp follower of some great power.'⁵ Similar pronouncements punctuated Rajiv Gandhi's approach to international affairs. Even today, well after the end of the Cold War, the neoliberal Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, whose economic inclinations are closely aligned with the West, has repeatedly emphasized India's right to pursue an independent foreign policy—friends of many, ally of none. He recently noted that, 'We have always prided ourselves on preserving our strategic autonomy, and this is an article of faith for us. India is too large a country to be boxed into any alliance or regional or sub-regional arrangements, whether trade, economic or political.'⁶ This strand of India's approach to international affairs has endured for over half a century and has been privileged over almost every other preference, including sometimes over hard military capabilities that might have enhanced India's security.

In terms of security strategies, the implication of India's enduring preference for strategic autonomy is that it will not be reliant on another power for its security—either as an ally or an arms supplier. In order to meet its security requirements, then, India imports arms from a diverse array of suppliers including the Russians, French, and increasingly the USA (Cohen and Dasgupta 2010). However, it tries not to be dependent on any one of them. In addition, for 50 years it has attempted to become militarily self-reliant through its government-run Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) and affiliated organizations. Nehru's belief in the power of science as a way forward for India was a necessary corollary to strategic autonomy—in order to be free from the superpowers and external interference, India had to develop the capability to arm herself, both with conventional and ultimately with nuclear weapons (Bajpai and Mattoo 1996). Strategic autonomy can only be realized with such an indigenous capability.

Unfortunately, the second feature of India's security apparatus—a sclerotic defense bureaucracy—undermines India's pursuit of strategic autonomy by hamstringing its ability to be self-reliant with respect to military capabilities (Cohen and Dasgupta 2010; Mukherjee 2011; Staniland and

Narang 2012). Cohen and Dasgupta argue, perhaps a bit extremely,⁷ that ‘DRDO is the best-funded research institution in India, but it has not produced a single weapons system that could alter the country’s strategic condition.’ Indeed, ‘DRDO has not delivered a single major weapon system in five decades of existence ...’⁸ Part of this lag is due to the natural difficulty of indigenously developing sophisticated military platforms, particularly in the face of US-led, proliferation-related sanctions at various points in the development cycle of major programs. However, other major reasons include the lack of competition DRDO faces for Indian military contracts, which slows the pace of development and has depressed the quality of platforms such as the Light Combat Aircraft project and the Arjun tank program, both of which are horrendously delayed and over budget. Another major impediment is institutional: the Ministry of Defense often does not care about this consistent underperformance. Especially since the Bofors howitzer scandal under Rajiv Gandhi, the operating maxim at the Ministry has often been ‘avoid another Bofors,’ which frequently means that the Ministry is populated by bureaucrats with little expertise in defense affairs and whose sole purpose is to avoid major corruption scandals, even if acquisition and development processes are dramatically slowed as a result. This is more than a fair concern given the sheer scale of military acquisitions, but it does come at a price to India’s military capabilities. Anit Mukherjee’s excellent contribution on the failure of attempted defense reforms in the past decade damningly concludes that they have simply ‘failed to deliver’ effective organs to manage India’s security environment (Mukherjee 2011).

The combination of India’s preference for strategic autonomy and the institutional impediments to achieving it mean that India’s capabilities consistently lag behind its ambitions and potential. Thus, India’s evolving security strategy often appears schizophrenic: it frequently pursues strategies at odds with its actual capabilities. In other issue areas, this may not be a significant problem—ambition in infrastructure or education has little downside. In security affairs, however, ambition can trigger adversaries to respond in ways that are ultimately counterproductive. Ambition that is not backed by the requisite capabilities is a doubly dangerous game, because at some point the bill may come due and a country may be unprepared to pay it (Glaser 1997). I illustrate this particular dilemma for India with respect to its security strategies toward its primary adversaries—Pakistan and China—in the last decade or so, and close with a brief analysis of India’s security relationship with the USA.

India and Pakistan under the shadow of nuclear weapons

India and Pakistan’s mutual nuclearization in May 1998 marked a turning point in their security relationship. Prior to 1998, India’s conventional superiority over Pakistan, which was demonstrated in all three wars the two nations had fought—in 1948, 1965 (though largely a stalemate with India sustaining non-trivial losses), and 1971—gave it a major coercive advantage over its neighbor. Without a credible nuclear capability to deter Indian conventional superiority, Pakistan was essentially at the mercy of its bigger neighbor’s quantitatively larger conventional military and the armored punch of India’s Strike Corps. Prior to nuclearization, India had not hesitated to operate deep into Pakistani territory when necessary, not only supervising the birth of Bangladesh out of East Pakistan in 1971, but operating several tens of kilometers across the international border in 1965 as well.

The nuclearization of the subcontinent through the 1990s and overtly in 1998 radically altered that equation. While India pursued nuclear weapons for largely prestige reasons, and tested them to assert its strategic autonomy—to break the so-called shackles of ‘nuclear apartheid’ induced by the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT)—and for domestic political reasons, Pakistan did both entirely for security reasons (Singh 1998; Perkovich 1999; Hymans 2006; Narang 2010). Very little consideration seems to have been given by the BJP government about

the security implications of testing nuclear weapons—that Pakistan would certainly follow suit—and what an overt nuclear Pakistan might mean for India's security. India tested first and asked questions later. Indeed, only after India's nuclear tests in May 1998 was any consideration given to questions about who was to manage them, how they were to be operationalized, what kind of nuclear doctrine India would have. Once Delhi crossed the nuclear Rubicon, however, there was no going back. Pakistan's nuclear tests gave it the only military equalizer it could have against India: the threat of nuclear first use against India's conventional forces in a conflict (Narang 2010). India's erstwhile strategic concept in a conventional war, popularly known as the Sundarji Doctrine, which relied on a massive three Strike Corps punch through the heart of Pakistan had, literally in a flash, become irrelevant.

Since testing in 1998, India's nuclear posture has evolved toward one of 'assured retaliation' designed to deter the use of weapons of mass destruction (WMD) against India or its forces by threatening certain retaliation against an adversary's population centers. India's first line of defense is still its conventional forces and, as such, it pledges not to be the first to use nuclear weapons in a conflict (Ministry of External Affairs 2003). It has not developed any tactical nuclear forces and, for a variety of institutional reasons, India's nuclear forces are managed by a dedicated Strategic Force Command (SFC) that operates in parallel to the conventional military chain of command and which takes orders directly from the Prime Minister's Office. Because its nuclear forces are oriented entirely for nuclear retaliation, India's nuclear weapons serve little deterrent function against limited conventional attacks or against terrorism. Pakistan's nuclear posture, however, has evolved much more aggressively, threatening the first use of nuclear weapons on advancing Indian forces to deter Indian conventional attacks or retaliation (Narang 2009/10). Such a threat is paralytic for India's security managers: if Pakistan were to use theater nuclear weapons on Indian conventional forces that were operating offensively on Pakistani soil, could Delhi credibly threaten to retaliate with a 'massive' and disproportionate strategic nuclear strike on Karachi, Islamabad, and/or Lahore? Pakistan is presently betting that it would not, and that India would be self-deterred in such a scenario.

The balance of these nuclear postures is not *ipso facto* detrimental to India's security. However, it is paralyzing for Delhi in combination with another critical feature of the India-Pakistan dynamic: Pakistan's long-standing revisionist objectives toward India, which spark periodic militarized crises between the two nations (Ganguly 2008; Kapur 2007). Emboldened by its nuclear capabilities which can now deter Indian conventional and nuclear retaliation, Pakistan since 1998 has been free to pursue more aggressively these objectives against India with virtual impunity (Ganguly 2008; Kapur 2007). Attacks from elements based in Pakistan have occurred with greater frequency and audacity since 1998, in a dynamic that is most aptly described as 'nuclear weapons-enabled terrorism.'

The 1999 Kargil War involved the infiltration of Pakistan's Northern Light Infantry into Indian-held Kashmir, which sparked a serious conflict that involved the risk of escalation (Riedel 2002; Ganguly 2008; Narang 2009/10). Pakistan's nuclear capabilities and some explicit nuclear saber rattling constrained the BJP's military response, including Vajpayee prohibiting the Indian Air Force or Army from crossing or striking across the Line of Control or threatening to open a second front across the international border—two tactical and strategic options that were staples of the Indian response to previous Pakistani infiltrations.

In December 2001 a group of militants from the Jaish-e-Mohammed, with perhaps some cooperation from the Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT), attacked India's Parliament building in Delhi. Unlike previous attacks from militant groups based in Pakistan, attacks were now starting to occur in India's metropolises. This attack triggered a 10-month twin peak crisis that involved a three-week mobilization of almost 800,000 Indian forces and all three strike corps to the

international border, poised for a massive conventional assault into Pakistan's Sindh and Punjab provinces. For a variety of reasons, including US intervention and Pakistan's explicit nuclear threats, the Vajpayee government walked back from the threat of war and demobilized India's forces after a 10-month deployment.

The most spectacular recent attack against India was the three-day LeT siege of Mumbai that commenced on the night of November 26, 2008, killing almost 173 people including Indian, British, US, and Israeli citizens. The level of direct Pakistan state involvement is unclear, but the LeT is a group that historically has been protected and funded by the state. Once again, India's government—at the time led by the Congress Party's Dr. Manmohan Singh—contemplated its military retaliatory options. An investigative journalistic account two years after the attack discovered that at the height of the deliberations in the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS), 'the Prime Minister then wanted to know if there was a chance Pakistan could misjudge a conventional strike by India and trigger a nuclear response. There was near silence ... The larger consensus was that you could not be sure about Pakistan's response. It is reliably learnt that it was this uncertainty which halted Indian strategists from fully backing any military response.'⁹

Thrice since 1998, then, India's leaders have been paralyzed after overt conventional and terrorist attacks from elements within Pakistan. India's nuclear weapons, and its posture of assured retaliation, are not oriented to deter limited or terrorist attacks—nuclear weapons are largely useless in such a role. However, Pakistan's nuclear weapons, and its posture of first use or 'asymmetric escalation,' *do* deter India's ability to retaliate with significant conventional military power, which generates a pattern of India being forced to absorb increasingly frequent and spectacular attacks from Pakistan with little ability to respond. India's decision to test nuclear weapons in 1998 without first thinking through the strategic ramifications of that test partly created this situation and is the most significant example of India's ambitions outstripping its strategic thought and its capabilities.

So how does India plan to rectify this situation with respect to Pakistan, where nuclearization has cast a dark shadow on India's security and national interests? India has firmly committed to keeping its assured retaliation nuclear posture, and its no-first-use pledge, intact. Therefore, its primary approach has been to attempt to generate a credible conventional retaliatory option against Pakistan that would require three features: (1) it would have to be quickly mobilized in order to retain the element of surprise and avoid international pressure (the lessons from the 2001–02 month-long mobilization); (2) it would have to be significantly punitive to Pakistan in order to deter it from—or punish it for—launching attacks against India from its soil; and (3) it cannot be so punitive that it risks Pakistan using nuclear weapons. Strategically, it would seem that the second and third requirements are fundamentally incompatible—any punitive strike that caused Pakistan significant military or territorial pain would, by definition, risk nuclear use on Indian forces. Nevertheless, India's security managers have pressed ahead with developing what is popularly known as 'cold start,' internally referred to as 'proactive strategy options' (PSOs).

The primary aim of PSOs is to give India's political leadership conventional military retaliatory options in between the massive three-week three strike corps assault envisioned in 2001–02, which would certainly risk nuclear escalation, and 'do nothing.' There are many possible versions of PSOs in the popular press and scholarship that involve breaking up the strike corps (which are presently deployed in India's interior) and pre-deploying elements closer to the border so that offensive operations could be initiated within two to three days from an order to do so from a 'cold start' (see Ladwig 2007/08). Based on more recent open-source literature and research, however, these options for a new 'doctrine' seem to have been rejected in favor of retaining the old concept but focusing on a more rapid mobilization procedure to enable the Indian Army to commence offensive operations within five-to-seven days of an order to do so (rather than 21).

The erstwhile 'holding' corps (IX–XII Corps), which were largely defensive units designed to block a Pakistani attack, reportedly have been converted to 'Pivot' corps by attaching an armored brigade to them—so that they can 'pivot' between defensive and offensive operations while the traditional strike corps mobilize to the border and provide offensive surge capability. The development since 2001, when India's long mobilization timetable was seen as an embarrassment to the Army, seems to have been focused largely on reducing mobilization times rather than developing a new 'doctrine,' per se, as is often believed.

However, while the Army in particular seems to have made some significant headway in developing these more reasonable mobilization options, the larger strategic questions have gone unanswered, again generating a schizophrenic Indian security strategy toward Pakistan. Brig. Gen. (ret'd) Gurmeet Kanwal, a proponent of some of the more aggressive PSOs, writes, '[The army and air force] should be launching their break-in operations and crossing the "start line" even as the holding (defensive) divisions are completing their deployment on the forward obstacles. Only such simultaneity of operations will unhinge the enemy, break his cohesion and paralyze him into making mistakes from which he will not be able to recover.'¹⁰ In particular, India envisions making shallow, 'salami slice' penetrations across the international border and LoC from a variety of azimuths to confuse Pakistani commanders, and to achieve limited objectives without triggering Pakistan's nuclear redlines.

However, there are two hefty assumptions therein: 1 that India actually has the capability to do this; and 2 that Pakistan Army commanders will be forgiving of Indian surprise offensives that penetrate 30km–50km into Pakistani territory and that they would not contemplate using nuclear weapons to slow the Indian offensive. Both are probably false, again revealing the dangerous gamble India might be playing in pursuing ambitions that it does not have the capability yet to achieve. The Indian Air Force and Army have not instituted the connectedness required of such an offensive, and it is certainly not a given that India would be able to achieve rapid and decisive military successes against a formidable Pakistan Army, air defense, and Air Force that can still mobilize quicker than India (Clary 2011; Ladwig 2007/08; Narang 2009/10). The unanswerable question at this point is that while the Indian military might present PSOs as one of several choices on the menu during a crisis, under what conditions would a political leadership authorize offensive retaliatory options against Pakistan, which always carries with it the risk of uncontrollable escalation? It seems highly unlikely that PSOs would ever be authorized under anything but the most extreme existential scenarios; they seem mostly designed by the Army to avoid the embarrassingly long mobilization time from 2001–02.

Even if they are never actually executed, the very existence and advertisement of PSOs carries significant negative security externalities for India. Indeed, by even sometimes advertising a capability which it still does not possess fully, India is potentially exacerbating its security challenges. Citing PSOs, Pakistan has developed its own rapid mobilization procedure and schemes to defend against surprise Indian attacks, tested in the large-scale Azm-e-Nau III exercises in 2010. More disturbingly, Pakistan has tested a tactical nuclear capability (Hatf-IX/Nasr) developed explicitly as a rapid reaction 'shoot and scoot' nuclear system to counter surprise Indian offensives, expanded its fissile material production, and has likely loosened command and control of relevant nuclear systems to make their use possible and credible in the event of a surprise Indian attack. Given the internal threats in Pakistan that may seek nuclear weapons for their own terrorist agenda, any loosening of nuclear command and control in Pakistan not only endangers Indian security, but global security as well.

As other chapters in this volume note, the only viable long-term solution between India and Pakistan is crisis prevention, such as political normalization. Unfortunately, absent such a normalization, India's security strategy toward Pakistan is not an effective crisis management

blueprint. Advertising an offensive retaliatory option that is not entirely developed has triggered Pakistan to pursue risky countermeasures, without successfully deterring terrorist attacks like that in Mumbai in 2008. Certainly once the PSOs are fully developed, the prospect of rapid surprise conventional offensives against a Pakistan that credibly threatens theater nuclear use is not something any Indian political leadership could legitimately authorize. So India's security managers seem to be making their dilemmas against Pakistan worse by developing aggressive retaliatory options that have little to no chance of ever being executed.

Managing a rising China

While Pakistan is India's most likely adversary, India's most worrying adversary might be a rising China, the power metrics of which in absolute terms are already large, and growing with respect to both symmetric military capabilities (army, navy, air force, nuclear) and asymmetric military capabilities (particularly cyber). India's present relationship with China is that the two are caught in a complex security dilemma: neither side, it seems, has any interest in conflict with the other but China's growth in military capabilities to counter US presence in the Western Pacific could pose an offensive threat to India, while India's fortification of the northeast and growth in naval capabilities in the Indian Ocean region, which could pose a threat to China's energy supplies through the Straits of Malacca, could also appear threatening to China (Jervis 1976; Fravel 2011). Thus, what is largely defensive developments by both sides can be interpreted as offensive capabilities for a future conflict and generate flashpoints for a conflict in which neither side has any interest. To be fair, neither India nor China is making it easy to escape the security dilemma.

According to M. Taylor Fravel, China's primary focus in the development of its military capabilities is the USA—India is not viewed as a viable threat to China, and outstanding territorial disputes in their present form do not provide flashpoints for conflict as far as Beijing is concerned (Fravel 2011). Similarly, presently, the Congress government led by the neoliberal Dr. Singh appears to have internalized the old neoliberal maxim that 'states that trade with each other don't invade each other,' contrary empirical examples such as Germany and Britain in 1914 notwithstanding. As such, China and India have reach bilateral trade levels close to US\$60 billion per annum, with a goal of reaching \$100 billion in the years to come. Neither government has let outstanding territorial disputes around the Line of Actual Control (LAC) hold trade or a broader bilateral relationship hostage.

Furthermore, to signal its benign intentions to Beijing, Delhi has not engaged in any formal alliance system to counter China despite overtures from the USA in particular. Although the Bush, Jr, and Obama administrations carved out an unprecedented exemption for India in the non-proliferation regime in the hopes of solidifying a strategic partnership between India and the USA, India has proven an unwilling dance partner—in the words of Stephen Cohen, India and the USA are 'friends but not allies.' Much of the reason lies in India's enduring emphasis on strategic autonomy. In particular, it is leaving open the option of a rapprochement with China, and a formal alliance with the USA would provoke China unnecessarily, even though the latter's security relationship with Pakistan has created a soft encirclement of India already. The political strategy in Delhi therefore seems to be soft engagement with China and avoiding entangling alliances that might be viewed as threatening to Beijing. Underlying this hedging approach is the belief that if China's capabilities and intentions were ever to turn hostile toward India, it would be able to defend itself on land, at sea, and in the air.

However, India's military developments with respect to China are undermining the political strategy in much the same way as PSOs are with Pakistan: the developments themselves are creating friction between India and China, but are insufficient to equip India with the capability

to defend itself without a more powerful US ally. That is, the advertised military strategy is creating precisely the conditions that might trigger Chinese hostility without providing the requisite capability to defend against it.¹¹ First, with respect to nuclear developments, DRDO has consistently overpromised and under-delivered with respect to strategic delivery capabilities that might provide an assured retaliation capability against China's major cities. The *Agnis* II–IV are supposed to give India some land-based strategic reach against China's eastern population centers and although some variants have technically been 'operationalized' and handed over to the Strategic Force Command for user trials, they have only been successfully tested a handful of times, punctuated by some spectacular failures. Adversaries may thus have significant reasons to doubt the full systems reliability of India's nuclear forces (i.e. the probability that the delivery vehicle is able to deliver the appropriate payload to the envisioned target and that the payload properly detonates). India (like China, in fact), is a long way from developing a reliable submarine-based nuclear delivery system, so while the SFC and DRDO promise they have the ability to retaliate against Chinese strategic targets with nuclear weapons, this is an objectively controversial claim. In the event of a significant militarized crisis with India, China may thus believe it has nuclear superiority due to the opaque nature with which DRDO has operationalized the backbone of India's strategic deterrent. Nuclear deterrence requires a significant amount of transparency and while India has no doubt that China could successfully deliver nuclear warheads on any target of its choosing, Beijing might have significant doubts that India could do the same.

India's conventional military developments with respect to China are also risky. In the northeast theater, the Army and the Air Force seem to be developing a modern incarnation of the forward policy which had disastrous consequences in 1962. The Air Force is deploying its heavy fighters, the Su-30MKI, which is an extremely capable aircraft, in the northeast—presently one squadron each at Chabua and Tezpur air bases in Assam. These are clearly China-specific. In addition, a Chief of Army Staff, General V.K. Singh, has publicly talked about raising not only two additional mountain divisions to address a potential Chinese threat, but also advertised the possibility of raising a mountain strike corps explicitly for offensive operations across the border to hold Chinese territory at risk in a potential conflict.¹² In early 2011, General Singh spoke of upgrading infrastructure on the Indian side as well as raising these additional offensive assets, 'restructuring to ensure offensive capabilities in the mountains as well.'¹³ That is, the concept of PSOs has also been applied to China, but again without the actual capability being present and against a much more potent adversary which already has a natural geographical advantage in the northeast theater.

Similarly, the Indian Navy, without mentioning China specifically, is investing in capabilities to expand its blockade options in the Straits of Malacca, through which the majority of China's sea-based energy transportation occurs. In 2001 the Indian Navy raised the Andaman and Nicobar command and explicitly noted in its Maritime Strategy 2007 that the Straits of Malacca is the most vulnerable chokepoint between the Indian Ocean region (which includes the Persian Gulf and East African coast) and China (Ministry of Defense 2007). The development of a blockade capability at the Straits could potentially cripple China's energy supplies. Although the Navy is better equipped to achieve its maritime strategy than the other services, China's rapid growth in naval capabilities, submarine warfare, and anti-ship weapons suggest that the Indian Navy may not be able to do so easily or for very long. The Army and Air Force are still a long way from having the doctrinal capabilities that they advertise, particularly as Chinese capabilities grow at an even faster rate. India again finds that its China strategy ambitions outstrip its capabilities. Worse, the very mention of the ambitions—without the requisite capability—is pushing China to counter India's developments at a rapid rate, making it both more likely that China may turn hostile if India pushes the wrong buttons (Tibet? Vietnam?), and that India will be increasingly vulnerable should China do so.

India and the USA: at arms' length

For a variety of reasons—shared democratic values, diaspora ties, China—it is often argued that India and the USA are 'natural allies.' Indeed, the Bush, Jr, administration in particular attempted to cement a strategic partnership between the two nations through the so-called Indo-US nuclear deal, which carved out an unprecedented exemption for India in the nonproliferation regime, and through a strengthened defense relationship, including arms offers of transport aircraft and the vaunted medium multirole combat aircraft (MMRCA) tender. These initiatives were continued by the Obama administration. In both cases, though, the USA was spurned, suggesting that India is still concerned with exercising its strategic autonomy.

With the nuclear deal, India's Parliament passed a strict liability bill which makes it virtually impossible for US nuclear vendors to operate in India without risking unlimited operator liability (a problem which French and Russian firms do not face since, unlike US firms, they are underwritten by their governments). Thus, the USA believed that it shouldered the heavy lifting for India's exemption and legitimatization as a nuclear weapons state without any attendant commercial benefits. Delhi was similarly disappointed by subsequent language about enrichment and reprocessing rights that seemed to undermine India's supposedly 'clean' exemption. Furthermore, the Obama administration placed significant emphasis on the MMRCA deal, in which two US aircraft (the F-16 and F-18) were offered alongside four other competitors (Tellis 2011). India decided not to shortlist either of the US platforms, largely for technical compliance reasons (and the F-16 is also flown by Pakistan), but also because there was lingering concern that the USA would use spare parts in an India-Pakistan conflict as leverage against Delhi. Democracy and diaspora do not seem yet to have overcome a fundamental trust deficit between the two nations.

On the military side, there have been a significant number of exercises between the Indian Navy and US Navy, in particular over the last decade. The annual Malabar series of exercises, as well as others with Japan (Trilatex), have laid the foundation for general interoperability between naval forces, which is already paying modest dividends in coordinated anti-piracy operations. However, the present Defense Minister A.K. Antony captures the sentiment that the Indian political class has toward the USA: exercises and even some weapons purchases are good, publicity and visibility are bad. That is, the government still prefers to deal with the USA at arms' length, reflecting the long-standing mistrust between the two nations and India's unwillingness to be a junior partner to a USA that is used to *only* having junior partners. India is happy to cooperate with the USA on a piecemeal basis where the two nations' interests overlap, but it seems unwilling to enter into a strategic alliance that might constrain its options vis-à-vis Russia, China, Myanmar (Burma), or Iran. This no doubt comes at a cost to Indian security, as its willingness to purchase some US military hardware but insistence on maintaining a diverse set of suppliers means that the services have to support a wide array of sometimes non-interoperable platforms, and that India may sometimes be foregoing superior technology for the sake of strategic autonomy. As a result, as the USA tempers its expectations of India as an ally, India should not expect the USA to date her exclusively in the region either.

Conclusion

India's evolving security strategy rests on two sometimes competing foundations. On the one hand India persistently has pursued strategic autonomy and self-reliance. On the other hand a mix of institutional and bureaucratic features prevent India from fully realizing its potential and ambitions, thereby creating vulnerabilities in its security strategy toward key countries such as

Pakistan, China, and even the USA. In international relations this can be a dangerous game as India's ambitions may write security checks that its sclerotic acquisition and production capability cannot cash. The dynamic introduced by nuclearization in South Asia—at India's behest as an expression of its strategic autonomy—has created a paralytic dilemma for India's security managers from which it not only has not recovered, but which it may be making even worse by advertising schemes such as 'proactive strategy options.' With respect to China, India's emphasis on strategic autonomy has made it unwilling to ally with the USA to contain China (even though China has no qualms about arming a Pakistani client state). In relying on itself, however, India is again advertising capabilities that it does not yet fully possess, thereby possibly triggering Chinese hostility while the state is still incredibly vulnerable to China's own growing military capabilities.

If India is unwilling to sacrifice its strategic Independence, a critical path forward out of these dilemmas is perhaps to address the second input into its security strategy: domestic institutions and bureaucracies. In particular, in order to better align these organs with India's broader political strategy toward its external environment, Delhi ought seriously to consider reforming the domestic institutions and processes charged with providing India with its security—the civil-military relationship, the defense acquisition procedures, the defense production capability—such that they are more flexible, competitive, integrated, and productive. India's national security advisor during the second United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government, the highly capable Shivshankar Menon, recognized India's challenge: 'Talk of strategic autonomy or of increasing degrees of Independence has little meaning unless our defence production and innovation capabilities undergo a quantum improvement. A country that does not develop and produce its own major weapons platforms has a major strategic weakness and cannot claim true strategic autonomy. This is a real challenge for us all.'¹⁴ In the coming decades, to achieve truly strategic autonomy, India's security managers must focus not only on indigenous military production and self-reliance, but also integration of its myriad security institutions and bureaucracies so that India's capabilities align better with its strategic vision.

Notes

- 1 Amitabh Mattoo, 'Raison d'Etat or Adhocracy,' in Kanti Bajpai and Amitabh Mattoo, eds, *Securing India: Thoughts and Practices*, Delhi: Manohar Publications, 1996, 204.
- 2 Stephen P. Cohen, *India: Emerging Power*, Washington, DC: Brookings Press, 2001, 154.
- 3 Indira Gandhi, *India: The Speeches and Reminiscences of Indira Gandhi*, Calcutta: Rupa, 1975, 136.
- 4 Shashi Tharoor, *Reasons of State: Political Developments and India's Foreign Policy Under Indira Gandhi 1966–1977*, Delhi: Vikas Publishers, 1982, 66.
- 5 Atal Bihari Vajpayee, *India's Foreign Policy: New Dimensions*, New Delhi: Ministry of External Affairs, External Publicity Division, 1977, 38.
- 6 Manmohan Singh, 'Excerpts of Speech to Combined Commanders' Conference,' Targeted News Service, September 13, 2010.
- 7 DRDO and the Integrated Guided Missile Development Programme (IGMDP) did develop the *Agni* family of missiles, though slowly and ploddingly at times, which has certainly altered India's strategic condition.
- 8 Stephen P. Cohen and Sunil Dasgupta, *Arming Without Aiming: India's Military Modernization*, Washington, DC: Brookings Press, 2010, 26, 32.
- 9 Pranab Dhal Samanta, '26/11: How India Debated a War with Pakistan that November,' *Indian Express*, November 26, 2010.
- 10 Gurmeet Kanwal, 'Cold Start and Battle Groups for Offensive Operations,' *Strategic Trend (Observer Research Foundation)* Vol.4, issue 18 (June 2006).
- 11 This is not to deny that Chinese military developments, particularly infrastructural developments in Tibet and around the LAC that could make transporting military forces to the region easier in the event of conflict, are also potentially threatening for India. However, some of the moves that have attracted much media attention—such as supposed redeployments of DF-21 nuclear-capable missiles to

the region as well as the so-called ‘string of pearls strategy’—are largely false. China has replaced its entire land-based nuclear force with more mobile and solid-fuel capabilities, but has not ‘redeployed’ them to India’s frontier, and the so-called ‘string of pearls’ strategy is a term coined by a consultant at Booz Allen to describe private Chinese (now also Singaporean) companies building ports across the Indian Ocean region. As of now they have no role for the People’s Liberation Army (PLA) Navy.

- 12 ‘Army Planning to Set up Mountain Strike Corps,’ *Press Trust of India* (August 22, 2011).
- 13 General V.K. Singh quoted in Rajat Pandit, ‘Eye on China, Army Focuses on Mountain Warfare,’ *Times of India* (January 15, 2011).
- 14 Shivshankar Menon, Prem Bhatia Memorial Lecture, New Delhi, August 11, 2011, www.tribuneindia.com/2011/20110814/edit.htm#1.

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INTERNATIONAL MIGRATION AND ITS CONSEQUENCES FOR INDIA

Devesh Kapur

Introduction

Along with capital and trade flows, international migration has been the third leg of globalization. While there is considerable commentary and research on the first two mechanisms, the characteristics and consequences of international migration on India (the focus of this chapter) are less well understood. The chapter is organized as follows: it first presents an analytical framework outlining four channels through which international migration affects the country of origin and the variables that attenuate or amplify these effects. The next section provides evidence on the magnitude and characteristics of international migration from India. The subsequent two sections examine the political and economic consequences of international migration from India on India. Finally, the conclusion analyzes how international migration has been reshaping conceptions of Indian citizenship.

Effects of international migration: what are the mechanisms?

Kapur and McHale (2005) laid out an analytical framework outlining four key channels through which migration may have political consequences:

- The *prospect channel* captures the way in which a prospect or an option of migrating affects the decision making of individuals and households. The prospect channel can affect decisions ranging from skills acquisition to incentives for exercising voice, to investment in social capital and networks.
- The *absence channel* focuses on the effects that migration has on those left behind in the community of origin; this channel clearly depends on the characteristics of those who leave. This is particularly important in a multiethnic society like India, where different rates of migration across social, religious and ethnic groups can alter the demographics germane to critical political cleavages. The social and political implications in turn will depend on the structure of institutions and cleavages already present in society and the reasons the migrants left their place of origin.
- The *diaspora channel* speaks to the impact of migrants on the place of origin from their new spatial location. Migrants are a source of additional financial flows, but also of new ideas,

expectations and practices. Their greater social capital may result in strengthening civil society and a greater cosmopolitanism—or it might result in long-distance ethnic nationalism. The political effects of the former are likely to be more diffuse and long term. The latter, however, has the potential for more immediate—and negative—political impact.

- The *return channel* looks at how returning migrants can affect the political economy in the place of origin differently than if they had never left. In a narrow sense, migrants typically return home with greater financial wealth, augmented human capital, and access to international networks. External experiences change expectations as well as preferences, and the resulting cognitive impacts can have substantial long-term effects.

The scope, magnitude and duration of these effects are strongly mediated by the selection characteristics of the migrants: not by just *who leaves* (including age, gender, education, occupation, religion, ethnicity, political beliefs), but also by *how many leave*, *the areas from which they leave* (sectors, regions, communities), the *destinations* to which they go (industrialized or developing countries; democratic or authoritarian regimes), and crucially, the *reasons for leaving*. It does not take much to realize that the effects are likely to be different if the migrant was forced to leave as a result of conflict (as has been the case of many migrants from Kashmir, India's northeast and Punjab in the 1980s), or instead left to look for better economic opportunities.

In recent years much of the attention on the effects of international migration on developing countries has focused on financial remittances, both at the macro-level on balance of payments and at the micro-household-level, on consumption and investment. There is, however, relatively less analysis on the political economy consequences of remittances. The most familiar framework for analyzing the political effects of migration is Albert Hirschman's well-known treatment of 'exit, voice and loyalty.' Hirschman argued that 'exit has shown to drive out voice,' and 'voice is likely to play an important role in organizations only on condition that exit is ruled out.'¹ In this framework, societal groups that exit through migration would lose their voice and their political influence would wane. However, this is hardly inevitable. When a migrant 'exits' it is usually *not* the case that s/he no longer contributes to the household or country from which s/he migrated. Migration provides greater access to resources, ranging from remittances, skills transfer through returns, and networks, which can 'buy' voice. Migration can consequently amplify rather than attenuate voice, depending on the selectivity characteristics of the migration.

Dimensions of international migration from India²

Although Indians have been migrating to other lands for thousands of years, large-scale migration began only after the end of slavery in the 1830s. Most migrants went to South or Southeast Asia—about 42% settled in Burma, another 25% in Ceylon, 19% in British Malaya, and the rest in Africa, the Caribbean, and the Pacific, with the vast majority going as indentured labor.

International migration from independent India was initially driven by the large demand for unskilled and semi-skilled workers in the UK following the end of World War II. These labor shortages drew large numbers of Indians, mainly from Punjab and Gujarat. A modest number of professionals and traders also migrated during this period. These numbers were considerably supplemented by 'twice migrant' East African Asians (especially of Gujarati origin) into the UK in the late 1960s to early 1970s, following political upheavals in that part of the world.

Two unrelated events sparked the next major flow of emigration from the late 1960s onwards. First, the sharp increase in oil prices and the resulting economic boom created a large demand for overseas labor in the Middle East. The majority of the emigrants were unskilled or semi-skilled, although in comparison to earlier migration waves there were considerable numbers of

skilled migrants as well. Because the policies of the Middle Eastern countries have made permanent settlement extremely difficult, Indian migration to this region has been high in terms of annual flows, while inherently temporary at the individual level, with most eventually returning home (although some skilled migrants moved on to countries like Australia and Canada). Although labor flows from Kerala were dominant in the 1970s and 1980s, by 2010 it accounted for less than one-sixth of low-skilled labor flows from India (about 640,000) and Uttar Pradesh had emerged as the largest state for low-skilled international labor outflows (Ministry of Overseas Indian Affairs 2011). Six states accounted for nearly four-fifths of all low-skilled labor flows from India, with about half from the three southern states (Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh) and half from three states in the Hindi-speaking belt (Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan). Nearly 80% of these labor flows were to three Middle Eastern countries (Saudi Arabia, United Arab Emirates, and Oman), with Malaysia being the only other important country of low-skilled labor flows outside the Middle East.

Second, the liberalization of US immigration law in 1965 led to a large emigration of highly skilled professionals and students seeking to study in, and eventually immigrate to, the USA. The large demand for information technology workers in the USA in the late 1990s led to another wave of young professional immigrants. However, since most came with temporary work visas, a relatively larger, though still modest fraction returned home. The Indian-born population in the USA grew from just around 12,000 in 1960 to 51,000 in 1970. It then climbed to 206,000 in 1980, 450,000 in 1990 and 1 million in 2000. By 2010 the size of the Indian-origin population in the USA was estimated at 3.18 million, of which 70% were foreign born. Two-fifths of this foreign-born population entered the USA between 2000 and 2010, helped considerably by employment-based preferences under the H-1B visa program. This migrant stream has been highly educated, both compared to other immigrants into the USA (almost two-thirds work in a management or professional occupation), as well as any other Indian migrant streams.

At the end of the millennium an official Indian government report estimated that the Indian diaspora spanned over 110 countries (Government of India 2001). There were 10,000 or more overseas Indians in 48 countries, and 11 countries had more than half a million persons of Indian origin. As of 2011 the Indian diaspora is estimated to be around 22 million people. More than four-fifths of the diaspora lived in middle- and high-income countries, and more than 90% of those who lived in low-income countries were concentrated in just one: Myanmar (Burma). The diaspora from the first two waves of migration (in the second half of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries) has enjoyed mixed fortunes. On the one hand this immigrant group on average is better off in terms of income per capita when compared to both the society from which it emigrated, as well as in many cases that into which it settled. The latter holds true for many countries where there is a significant Indian-origin population (Malaysia and Trinidad are notable exceptions). On the other hand the diaspora suffers from ethnic tensions in many countries and, periodically, has been politically disenfranchised in the Caribbean, East Africa, Fiji, Myanmar and in South Africa under the Apartheid regime. The large 'generational distance' of this diaspora means that its economic and family ties to India are quite weak, though it continues to draw religio-cultural sustenance from its roots in India.

Political impact of international migration on India

Based on extensive original data, Kapur (2010) has argued that international migration has had a significant positive impact on Indian politics: first, by influencing the commitment to liberal democratic politics among Indian elites; and second, by promoting India's democratic durability

and stability through elite 'exit.' The analysis points to the less salubrious effects on India, arising from support for extremist nationalist and separatist groups by members of the Indian diaspora. However, the evidence suggests that the systemic effects of this support are relatively modest compared to domestic variables and much less important than critics suggest.

First, the *international exposure and return migration* of Indian elites contributed to several key ideas that have shaped India: its commitment to a democratic form of government at the time of Independence and, more recently, to economic liberalization. This is not to say that these two critical characteristics of contemporary India have been primarily shaped by international migration, but international migration has certainly played an important role in shaping the sensibility of Indian political and policy elites. Drawing on a database developed on India's business, intellectual, political, and scientific elite over the past half century that examines the extent and nature of these elites' overseas experience, Kapur (2010) points to the subtle and dynamic effects of migration's 'social remittances' on reshaping political understandings, expectations, and norms, particularly of national elites. The distinctively 'elite' character of modern Indian emigration has amplified these 'social remittance' effects, both because of the diaspora's overseas success and its access to influential institutional channels to transmit these ideas.

Second, international migration has had a notable political impact on the endurance of India's democracy. Elite 'exit' through emigration eased the political ascendancy of India's numerically dominant lower castes. From the mid-nineteenth century to the end of the millennium, Indian emigration became increasingly positively selected (whether measured by caste, class, or education and skills). This elite emigration has lubricated the political ascendancy of India's numerically dominant lower castes. The introduction of universal franchise in India following Independence signaled the death knell of the political hegemony of India's high castes. In recent decades, as the inexorable logic of numbers reshaped the political landscape of India, it resulted in hitherto socially marginalized groups coming into political power and challenging the entrenched political power of upper castes. The question was not *if* this would happen, but *when* and *at what cost*. No group gives up its privileges without a fight, and the 'silent social revolution'³ in India could have been much more contentious but for the possibility of exit open to India's elites.

The inexorable logic of democratic politics forced the Indian elite to loosen their grip on political power, but palatable exit options made it easier to relinquish their centuries-old privileges. In 1990 India was reeling in the aftermath of a policy decision by a minority government to increase sharply affirmative action in government jobs and education. A decade later the issue had faded away so quietly that few could recall what the riots had been about. One reason for this change was greater exit options for India's upper-caste elites. The exit possibilities inherent in international migration, whether for jobs or education, mitigated the economic insecurities of India's elites—thereby making them less implacably opposed to the political ascendancy of hitherto marginalized social groups. In turn, this has made Indian politics less contentious than it might otherwise have been in the absence of possibilities of exit for elites (and their progeny). It is in this contribution to the strengthening of India's democracy, even if inadvertent, that international migration may have had its strongest impact on India.

That being said—and contrary to Albert Hirschman's famous formulation⁴—actual exit (and not simply the threat of exit) has not weakened the political voice of India's upper castes in any significant way. At the same time, the elite basis of Indian emigration has also had implications for the quality of Indian democracy. Exit has implied a reduced incentive to exercise voice, particularly for public goods such as health and education that have been the very basis for mobility of Indian elites (i.e. human capital). It has also had pernicious effects on the competence of India's public institutions, by undermining the availability of human capital. This is particularly the case with higher education, where the absence of qualified faculty at a time of

rapid expansion has entrenched mediocrity with debilitating long-term consequences. Thus, while international migration has allowed an exit mechanism that has mitigated conflict, it simultaneously undermined the quality of India's democracy by weakening the competencies and capabilities of India's public institutions.

If the political impact through the 'absence' channel is subtle but complex, that arising from the 'diaspora' channel is quite contentious as it has served to provide both a form of international social capital (with its implied positive virtues), as well as a more contentious ethnic long-distance nationalism, supporting more extreme groups and political parties. The former has been manifest in Indian diasporic philanthropy. While this was long directed at religious institutions, in recent years it has shifted to more civic causes, especially in supplementing the manifest weaknesses of the Indian state in providing public services, be it education, health or drinking water, and has been bolstered by an upsurge in social entrepreneurship.

For many years, particularly from the early 1980s to the mid-2000s, there were serious apprehensions about 'the role of India's diaspora in the Hindu nationalist imagination,' resulting in 'how religion has come to be deployed as a group identity in Indian politics'.⁵ A careful analysis of the empirical evidence based on a random survey of the Indian-American population suggests that while elements of the diaspora have been strong supporters of Hindu nationalism and the evidence that Indian Americans harbor prejudices against Muslims is compelling, the evidence that the diaspora has been an important, let alone primary, cause of anti-Muslim violence in India is weak, notwithstanding the numerous charges on this issue (Kapur 2010). Indeed, support for long-distance nationalism-fuelled violence in India has been more important among some sub-national groups in India through their support for separatist groups (Punjab, Kashmir, the northeast). In each case, including Hindu nationalism, diasporic long-distance nationalism and its support for extremist causes has followed rather than been causal in internal conflict in India and has not had *systemic* effects on the country.

Finally international migration and the Indian diaspora has both created new opportunities but also serious challenges for India's foreign policy. In established industrialized democracies, like the USA, where the Indian diaspora enjoys full citizenship rights and is also in a privileged economic position, the diaspora has broadly facilitated Indian foreign policy goals. In contrast, the diaspora's impact on India's foreign policy has been more circumscribed in countries where it enjoys virtually no citizenship rights and forms a mix of an economic underclass as well as middle-class professionals (as is the case in the Middle East and Gulf states). In these cases, while the diaspora has helped weave a limited web of ties between India and the Middle East, periodic bouts of political instability in that region put them at physical risk, placing a substantial repatriation burden on the Indian state (as evidenced during the Gulf wars and the Libyan crisis). The third group of countries, where the Indian diaspora is of older vintage and where citizenship rights are contested with other ethnic groups, have posed serious challenges. These include countries in India's neighborhood and in others such as East Africa in the late 1960s-early 1970s, Fiji and Malaysia. Domestic political instability and ethnic conflicts invariably target immigrants and as Indian emigration grows, addressing the fallout when this occurs putting Indian migrants at risk, will pose serious challenges to Indian foreign policy.

Economic consequences of international migration on India

International migration from India has also had multiple economic effects. Kapur (2010) highlights three mechanisms through which the economic effects of emigration and the Indian diaspora manifest themselves: financial flows, global networks, and the diaspora's role as reputational intermediaries.

Unlike the Chinese diaspora which has been a critical source of foreign direct investment (FDI) into China, the Indian diaspora's role as a source of FDI into India has been modest. Instead, however, it has been an important source of financial flows into India in the form of remittances, which emerged as an important part of India's balance of payments (BOP) in the mid-1970s and grew dramatically after the onset of economic liberalization in 1991. According to official Reserve Bank of India (RBI) data, remittances have grown enormously from US\$2.1 billion in 1990/91 to \$53.9 billion in 2009/10. The share of private transfer receipts in India's gross domestic product (GDP) rose from 0.7% in 1990/91 to 3.6% in 2009/10. These figures reflect both the degree to which the stock of Indian citizens residing abroad (especially in North America) has jumped, as well as the degree to which their earning power has increased. Policy changes over the last two decades including the devaluation of the rupee and liberalization of gold imports, and exchange rate convertibility in the current account have also made a difference, especially in bringing remittances from the Middle East through official channels, rather than underground (*hawala*) markets. A major source of worry, however, is the wide discrepancies between the BOP estimates from the RBI (which would indicate that remittances are approximately 4% of GDP), and aggregates from micro-household surveys (specifically the 64th Round of the National Sample Survey), which add up to just 0.4% of GDP. The large margin of error is a big area of concern since estimates of income mobility, inequality and growth will all be affected by this mis-measurement.

The large inflows of financial remittances into India that have resulted from international migration have mitigated the effects of external shocks through a range of mechanisms, from increased consumption levels to provisions for social insurance, at both the household and national levels. For instance, remittances enhanced the Indian state's ability to withstand sanctions imposed in the aftermath of its nuclear tests. Financial remittances also have had considerable distributional consequences, affecting income inequalities across states, social groups, and households. In the state of Kerala, remittances account for nearly a quarter of state net domestic product and appear to have had considerable policy incentive effects as well, by reducing pressures for policy change.

The Indian diaspora has created a web of cross-national networks, thereby facilitating the flow of tacit information, commercial and business ideas, and technologies into India. It has also facilitated 'home sourcing,' as exemplified by the rapid growth of India's diamond cutting and polishing industry on the one hand and the rapid growth of India's IT sector on the other.

The third mechanism is cognitive. The extreme selectivity of recent Indian emigration and the success of migrants abroad transformed the 'brain drain' into a 'brain bank.' This has resulted in broader spillover effects for India with diasporic networks acting as reputational intermediaries and as credibility-enhancing mechanisms. The Indian diaspora's success in Silicon Valley has had a considerable cognitive impact on global perceptions of India. By the 1990s, India's human capital-rich diaspora, especially in the USA, had emerged to become an international business asset for the country. As reputational intermediaries and as credibility-enhancing mechanisms, this diaspora favorably influenced global perceptions of India, reflecting the reputational spillover effects of succeeding in the most powerful country's leading technology sector.

Conclusion

While the transformative effects of international migration are most apparent on the individual migrant, they can also be substantial on the communities of origin and destination. The political and economic effects of international migration from India on India have been considerable, both materially as well as cognitively. However, for the most part the political and economic impact

has depended largely on the economic policies, social cleavages and political conflicts within India. People leave for a reason—and understanding those reasons is critical to assessing its implications.

During the more than a century and a half of Indian emigration, the Indian government has required emigration clearance for low-skilled workers and young women going to certain countries, to try and ensure that these vulnerable groups were not exploited by unscrupulous labor contractors. Aside from that, however, the government did little else until the 1970s, when it took steps to attract financial remittances from the burgeoning labor migration to the Middle East.

The Indian government's attitude towards its migrants changed from a mix of apathy and mild hostility to a much more welcoming attitude in the new millennium. In 2001 the Indian government set up a 'Commission on the Indian Diaspora.' Two years later (January 2003) it organized the first *Pravasi Bharatiya Divas* (an annual celebration and gathering of overseas Indians) in New Delhi and created a dedicated ministry (the Ministry of Overseas Indian Affairs). At one level the event signaled that India was becoming more proactive in trying to leverage its diaspora. Since then, governments in India—both at the national and state levels—have been making greater efforts to cultivate relationships with overseas Indians. In 2002 the Indian government created the Person of Indian Origin (PIO) card, which granted modest privileges to foreign citizens of Indian origin. Subsequently, the Citizenship Act was amended to allow for the registration of persons of Indian origin holding foreign citizenship as 'Overseas Citizens of India' (OCI).

Concurrently, the Indian government also mounted initiatives to ensure that Indian workers overseas (for instance in the Gulf) have minimal statutory protections such as minimum monthly salary, stipulated hours of work, medical care, overtime payment, access to consular services during a crisis, insurance schemes for workers going overseas, and efforts to address the predicament of deserted Indian women. In 2009 the government constituted a prime minister's Global Advisory Council to facilitate a dynamic two-way engagement between stakeholders in India and the overseas Indian community.

While these schemes certainly have benefited Indian workers overseas, the overall impact of these initiatives for India have been modest, principally because they are stand-alone enclave-type initiatives and are rarely embedded in the wider national and international policies of the Indian government. As long as broader institutional and policy concerns within India remain unaddressed, India's efforts to leverage its diaspora will continue to under-deliver.

Migration results in subtle but important changes to ideas that are at the heart of nationhood—citizenship and the basis of a political community. Around the world, international migration has deepened anxieties, as countries are forced to grapple with settled, comfortable assumptions about 'national identity.' In the closing years of the twentieth century, dual citizenship, once anathema to nation-states, has become increasingly accepted as countries react to international migration and seek to maintain ties with their migrants, presumably to reap economic and political benefits.

This has been the case with India as well, where international migration has created incentives to shift (albeit to a limited extent) the definition of Indian citizenship from birth in India or naturalization, to encompass ethnicity as well. Initially, when the Indian government was contemplating the creation of an OCI category, it announced that the privilege would be granted only to the diaspora from selective (mainly industrialized) countries, appearing to privilege 'money politik.' Responding to strong criticism, it settled on a more uniform principle wherein anyone who left India after the Indian Republic came into being (January 26, 1950) could become an OCI, excluding those who went to Bangladesh and Pakistan.⁶ Although OCIs were extended most privileges available to nonresident Indians (NRIs)—i.e. Indian citizens living abroad with an

Indian passport—they have not yet been granted any political rights or the right to own agricultural land. Thus with regard to the country's international migrants, there has been a subtle shift in the basis of Indian nationalism from a purely civic and territorial one, to ethnic nationalism. Whether there will be an impact of this—and what that impact will be—on India in the long term remains to be seen.

Notes

- 1 Albert O. Hirschman, *Exit, Voice and Loyalty: Responses to Decline in Firms, Organizations, and States*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1970, 76.
- 2 For a comprehensive overview see Lal *et al.* (2006).
- 3 Christopher Jaffrelot, *India's Silent Revolution: The Rise of the Lower Castes in North India*, New York: Columbia University Press, 2003.
- 4 Hirschman, *Exit, Voice and Loyalty: Responses to Decline in Firms, Organizations, and States*, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1970, 76.
- 5 Vibha Pingle and Ashutosh Varshney, 'India's Identity Politics: Then and Now,' in David Kelley and Ramkishan Rajan, eds, *Managing Globalization: Lessons from India and China*, Singapore: World Scientific Book Corporation on behalf of the Lee Kuan Yew Center for Public Policy, 2007.
- 6 A foreign national who was eligible to become a citizen of India on January 26, 1950 (when India became a Republic), or was a citizen of India on or at any time after January 26, 1950, or belonged to a territory that became part of India after August 15, 1947, and his/her children and grandchildren, provided his/her country of citizenship allows dual citizenship in some form or other under the local laws, is eligible for registration as an OCI. Applicants who have ever held citizenship of Pakistan or Bangladesh are not eligible for OCI.

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